

In the name of God most Gracious, ever Merciful!

The Beloved and I

Volume 4: Ezra to Job

Thomas McElwain

New Jubilees Version of Sacred Scripture in
Verse

With Verse Commentaries

Revised Edition

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Preface

The New Jubilees Version of Sacred Scripture in Verse with Verse Commentary includes the entire Bible, Deuterocanonical books, Ethiopic Enoch and Jubilees, several apocryphal gospels and the Qur'an set to verse. The nearly nine thousand commentaries are set in sonnet-like form to distinguish them from the Scriptural text.

The first volume consists in the presentation of the books of Moses. The second volume includes Enoch and Jubilees, also books in the Mosaic tradition, and Joshua and Judges. The third volume introduces Scriptures that acknowledge the figure of David, beginning with the book of Ruth. This volume continues that tradition, the presentation of Scriptures that acknowledge both Moses and David, beginning with the book of Ezra.

The reader is referred to the preface of the first volume for a comprehensive introduction to the source texts and the ways by which they have been treated.

Ezra

While Ezra is traditionally considered one with Nehemiah, the fact that Ezra 2 is repeated in Nehemiah 7 suggests to many that they were originally distinct writings. Traditionally, Ezra is thought to be the author and editor of the sources he makes use of. The book is thought by traditionalists to have been written between 456 and 444 B.C.E.

The first six chapters refer to the reigns of Cyrus (539-530) and Darius I (522-486). The last chapters (as well as 4:7-23) refer to the reign of Artaxerxes I (465-423). Nothing in the book refers to the interim period of 515-457, during which time the book of Esther is set. The jostling for power on the part of the Jews within the wide stretch of the Persian empire is the background of Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther, as well as Tobit and Judith, less historically-based and more imaginative writings. Scholars prefer, however, to see Ezra and Nehemiah as priestly writings

within the same tradition as the two books of Chronicles. Thus the priestly tradition bridges the subjects of the preceding volume in this series, with other models of approach to post-exilic problems.

Ezra is the first book in the canon to present itself as post-exilic, although most scholars consider Enoch and Jubilees to be late writings. The Hebrew Scriptures can be roughly divided into writings that assume the theocratical system of patriarchs, judges, and kings, and writings that provide models for living the law of God under hostile regimes, governments that do not in principle recognize the binding validity of divine law.

The model that Ezra proposes is an assumed accommodation to imperial government in view of taking advantage of its resources and facilities to re-establish the seat of the theocracy and its temple worship. The idea of theocracy under the imperial umbrella is ingenious and fascinating. It is not simple, however, and the background of the Persian court and its interests is projected on the land and people surrounding Jerusalem. In the end, one must surmise that Persia is playing different groups off against each other for its own interests, specifically the Jews and Samaritans.

As such, all of the post-exilic prophets are extremely relevant to contemporary faith, giving as they do various models of survival and influence within regimes that are potentially at cross-purposes with the life of faith.

Ezra 1

1 In the first year of Cyrus king
Of Persia, then the word of YHWH
By Jeremiah's mouth rung true,
YHWH stirred up the spirit *to wing*
Of Cyrus king of Persia, so
He made a proclamation go
Throughout all his kingdom, also
In writing, saying, 2 "Thus says Cyrus
King of Persia (*and not to tire us*):
'All the kingdoms of the earth YHWH
The God of heaven has *been true*
To give me, and commanded me
To build Him a house *faithfully*

At Jerusalem in Judah.

3 'Who's among you of His folk's *draw*?
May his Alohim be with him,
And get him to Jerusalem
Which *is* in Judah, and to build
The house of YHWH Israel's God filled
(He *is* Alohim), who *indeed*
Is in Jerusalem *decreed*.

4 'And who is left in any place
Where he dwells, let men of his place
Help him with silver and with gold,
With goods and livestock *from the fold*,
Besides the freewill offerings for
The house of Alohim, its store,
Which in Jerusalem *is told*. '''

Your servant Cyrus, My Beloved, who
reigned
Over the Persian conquered lands,
sustained
Your law and love in many ways, but best
Because he ordained that Your land in rest
Should see the rising of the temple halls
That fell at Nebuchadnezzar's high calls.
Although the king gives the command, just
wait

To see how many come to storm the gate,
Pretending to be servants of the king,
And yet just out to punish righteous wing.
Beloved, today as I stand on the shore
Of frozen lake and look upon the door
Of heaven and sky to see the rosy tint
On morning, I retreat into Your glint.

5 Then up rose the head fathers of
Judah and Benjamin *for love*,
And the priests and the Levites, too,
With all whose spirit Alohim
Had raised up to go build in crew
The house of YHWH, which is in *dream*
Land of Jerusalem *in view*.

6 And all the ones about them came
To strengthen their hands with *the claim*
Of silver vessels, and with gold,
With provisions and with beasts *told*,
And precious things as well as all
That was willingly offered *tall*.

7 Also Cyrus the king brought out
The vessels of YHWH's house which *stout*
Nebuchadnezzar had brought down
From Jerusalem and *with frown*
Placed in house of his gods' *renown*.

8 Even those did Cyrus the king
Of Persia and by the hand bring
Of Mithredath the treasure chief,
And counted them to Sheshbazzar
Who was the prince of Judah's *star*.
9 And this is how many in brief
There were: thirty chargers of gold
A thousand of silver unsold,
And twenty-nine knives *sharp and cold*.
10 Thirty basins of gold and yet
Silver basins in second store
Amounting in all up to four
Hundred and ten, and pots to get
Up to a thousand once they're set.
11 All the vessels of gold and more
Of silver, five thousand and four
Hundred. All these things Sheshbazzar
Brought up along out of the far
Captivity, that were brought out
Of Babylon to come about
Jerusalem *to stand and shout*.

The faith of Judaism that came out
Of Persia was an essay without doubt
To cause dissention on the farther shore
So Persian kings could be sure of the chore.
Samaritans might well be planning such
Rebellion in that far-off land of much,
And setting there another brood to make
A competition for religion's sake
In just what might by factions strengthen
king.

The Jewish sort is just a Persian fling,
But those sweet, secret politics remain
And set the world in factions, some insane,
Even today around the city grim
That is Jerusalem, the bright and trim.

Ezra 2

1 These are the people of the state
That went up out of prison's fate,
Of those who'd been taken away
When Nebuchadnezzar *in sway*
As king of Babylon had done
Taking them all to Babylon,
They came back to Jerusalem
And Judah every one to *hem*
Of his own city *under sun*,
2 Who came with Zerubbabel *were*
Jeshua, Nehemiah *fer*,
Seraiah, Reelaiah *and yet*
Mordecai, Bilshan, *and the set*

Mispar, Bigvai, Rehun Baanah.
 The number of the men *in awe*
 Of the folk of Israel *to draw*.
 3 The children of Parosh were two
 Thousand one hundred seventy-two.
 4 The children of Shephatiah,
 Three hundred seventy-two *in paw*.
 5 The children of Arah *alive*,
 Seven hundred seventy-five.
 6 The children of Pahathmoab,
 Of sons of Jeshua, Joab,
 Two thousand eight hundred and twelve.
 7 The children of Elam *to delve*,
 One thousand two hundred fifty
 And four *to top menagerie*.

The sons of Jeshua: that lovely name
 Has been born since the time of Moses'
 fame
 To give the world the hope that You
 became
 Salvation for all time above the flame
 Of this world's fast oppression of the poor.
 The name's attached to every portraiture
 Of cross, of temple cleansing and the
 mount
 Of his transfiguration in account.
 The name's attached to hundreds more, and
 yet
 The most famous of all was one to get
 A place under the sun long after this
 Man Jeshua sent sons abroad to kiss
 The threshold of Jerusalem and build
 A temple there and with Your glory filled.

8 The children of Zattu *alive*,
 Add to nine hundred forty-five.
 9 The children of Zaccai *unmixty*
 Add up to seven hundred sixty.
 10 The children of Bani *in view*
 Are six hundred and forty-two.
 11 The children of Bebai *set free*
 Make six hundred and twenty-three.
 12 The children of Azgad *in pew*,
 Thousand two hundred twenty-two.
 13 The children of Adonikam,
 Six hundred sixty-six, *no scam*.
 14 The children of Bigvai, no tricks,
 Add to two thousand fifty-six.

Adonikam, my lord arises on
 The gloried lights of the awaited dawn

To travel westward in the hope and sound
 That Abraham himself once heard and
 found.

From Babylon and the fair Persian state,
 Most beautiful of countries risen late,
 The soul still turns towards the desert land
 And tramples bruising rocks upon the sand
 To find the barren heights of Sinai and
 The wells of my Medina and the grand
 Halls of the poor, proud Makkah, and with
 eye

Upon its fading justice under sky,
 Jerusalem, unfaithful year by year,
 And still the jewelled city to appear.

15 The children of Adin *in store*
 Add to four hundred fifty-four.
 16 Hezekiah's children of Ater
 Were ninety-eight *and none came later*.
 17 The children of Bezai to be
 At least three hundred twenty-three.
 18 The children of Jorah *to delve*
 Add up to one hundred and twelve.
 19 The children of Hashum *to see*
 Were just two hundred twenty-three.
 20 The children of Gibbar *to strive*
 Make up the number ninety-five.
 21 The children of Bethlehem be
 Just one hundred and twenty-three.

The children of Hashum in retinue,
 The name of entourage come into view,
 Reminds me that the tongue, ancient
 Hebrew,

Contains much of the Arabic names too.
 Hashum as seen two thousand years ago
 Extends a hand to greet his brothers' row
 Who all go by the name Hashim and know
 No other god but You beneath the stew.
 Beloved, the joys of Hashum in the wake
 Of kings in their parade and for Your sake
 Still light the sky beside the Gulf and make
 The ancient faith glow brighter on that
 shore.

I join hands with Hashum and to the core
 We turn returning to Your faith in store.

22 Fifty-six men of Netophah,
 23 One hundred twenty-eight *in paw*
 The men of Anathoth *to draw*.
 24 The people of Azmaveth true
 Add up in all to forty-two.

25 The fold of Kirjath-arim be
 Along with Chephira, Beeroth,
 Seven hundred and forty-three.
 26 Folk of Ramah and Geba both
 Come to six hundred twenty-one.
 27 The men of Michmas, *when they've*
done,
 Make one hundred twenty-two *won*.
 28 The men of Bethel and Ai,
 Two hundred twenty-three to cry.

The men of Ai once came out to fight
 Your cohorts under Joshua in sight
 Of Jericho still burning in the night.
 Despite their single victory and loss
 To Israel because of golden cross,
 They fell to be renewed by those You
 chose
 To fill that place with holy heart and nose.
 After the centuries' vicissitudes,
 The times of peace, the years of family
 feuds,
 The wanderings, the hard captivity
 In Babylon and Persia, to be free
 They came back to Ai and Bethel too,
 To Bethlehem, Jerusalem to see
 The house of God still shining in the dew.

29 The folk of Nebo, fifty-two;
 30 The folk of Magbish, *in one crew*
 One hundred fifty-six *in view*.
 31 The folk of the second Elam,
 One thousand two hundred *to cram*
 And fifty-four. 32 And Harim's folk,
 Three hundred twenty more *to stoke*.
 33 The people of Lod, Hadid, and
 Ono, seven hundred twenty-five.
 34 The people of Jericho's land
 Come to three hundred forty-five.
 35 The people of Senaah, at three
 Thousand six hundred and thirty.

I guess that Maghish is a place, not man,
 A place where crystal waters or the span
 Of crystal rock shows to the eye that waits
 Upon that sacred home, within its gates
 Enfolding all the hope the captive mates
 After their journey find in Palestine.
 The bright and shining word, no doubt in
 meaning
 Quite different from the sound I hear in
 screening,

No matter what it means, no matter which
 It refers to, a man, a town, a ditch,
 To hearts returning becomes bright and
 fair.

I too, Beloved, look round me everywhere
 And see Your presence turn the fetid air
 To sweet perfumes, create gems out of
 pitch.

36 The priests: the sons of Jedaiah,
 And of the house of Jeshua,
 Nine hundred seventy-three *paw*.
 37 The sons of Immer, one thousand
 And fifty-two *on every hand*.
 38 The sons of Pashhur, one thousand
 Two hundred forty-seven spanned
 39 The sons of Harim, one thousand
 And seventeen. 40 The Levites: sons
 Of Jeshua and Kadmiel's buns,
 Of sons of Hodaviah more,
 They all come up to seventy-four.
 41 The singers: the sons of Asaph,
 One hundred and twenty-eight *laugh*.
 42 The sons of the doorkeepers *later*,
 The sons of Shallum, sons of Ater,
 The sons of Talmon, sons of Akkub,
 The sons of Hatita *for back-up*,
 The sons of Shobai *in their stall*,
 One hundred thirty-nine *in all*.

Of singers and doorkeepers there's no lack
 In those captives who got up to come back.
 The sons of Asaph in the generations
 Of exile in the wakened eastern nations
 Remembered daily, week by week, to sing
 The temple songs that flew from David's
 wing.

Their faithfulness was great, despite the
 fact

The temple lay in ruins by the act
 Of earthly kings. Today, Beloved, I too
 Sing those same songs of David to be true
 To tabernacle spent, threadbare in view,
 Abandoned by the false descendant crew.
 Beloved, though no one now loves David
 here,

I join his voice to come before Your ear.

43 The Nethinim: sons of Ziha,
 As well as sons of Hasupha,
 The sons of Tabbaoth, 44 and the sons
 Of Keros, sons of Siaha, sons

Of Padon, 45 as well as the sons
 Of Lebanah, Hagabab's sons,
 At last the many sons of Akkub,
 46 To catch up with the sons of Hagab,
 The sons of Shalmal, sons of Hanan,
 47 The sons of Giddel, *for the canon*
 The sons of Gahar, of Reaiah,
 48 The sons of Rezin, to go higher
 The sons of Nekoda, the sons
 Of Gazzam, 49 and then Uzza's sons,
 The sons of Paseah, the sons
 Of Besai, 50 and Asnah's sons too,
 The sons of Meunim, the crew
 Of Nephusim, 51 sons of Bakkub,
 The sons of Hakupha, no crook,
 The sons of Harhur, 52 the sons too
 Of Bazluth, Mehida's fair crew,
 The sons of Harsha, 53 Barkos' sons,
 The sons of Sisera, the sons
 Of Tamah, 54 the sons of Nezhiah,
 And sons of Hatipha *for fire*.

I wonder if the name Hatipha came
 From one kidnapped in captivity's blame
 And taken off to Babylon to live
 And propagate a house and then to give
 That name to all descendants, so they'd
 know
 That he was seized and had to make a show
 Of living satisfied beneath the glow
 Of tyranny. Beloved, it may be so.
 The sons of Hatipha, one quickly taken
 From truth into the land of egg and bacon,
 Return to kosher life and land to tell
 Your praises among faithful Israel.
 I have been seized, Beloved, and taken up
 To quaff the silver liquid from Your cup.

55 The sons of Solomon's servants:
 The sons of Sotai come to dance,
 The sons of Sophereth, the sons
 Of Peruda, 56 the sons *by tons*
 Of Jaala, the sons of Darkon,
 The sons of Giddel, 57 the sons drawn
 From Shephatiah, the sons of
 Hattil, as well as the sons of
 Pochereth of Zebaim, and sons
 Of Ami. 58 All the Nethinim
 And children of Solomon's *dream*
 Servants: three hundred ninety-two,
All clean and straight sitting in pew.

Sons of Darkon, who knows what story lies
 Behind that strange name that in word
 implies
 A leather shield, if Arabic relay
 The meaning of the word in which I stray.
 Does leather shield protect the son from
 being
 Taken into captivity and seeing
 Great Babylon fall before all the hordes
 Of Persians following their dark warlords?
 It seems not, my Beloved, and yet a shield
 I need here in this life of silver field.
 Shield me from hate and from hateful
 desires,
 Shield me from my own self and from the
 fires
 Of sacrifice to other gods, but let
 My soul above Your shield at last be met.

59 And these *were* the ones who came from
 Tel Melah, Tel Harsha, and rum
 Cherub, Addan, and Immer, but
 They could not find ancestral what
 Or place upon the family tree,
 Lacking their genealogy,
 Whether they *were* of Israel's free.
 60 The sons of Delaiah, the sons
 Of Tobiah, as well as sons
 Of Nekoda, six hundred and
 Fifty-two *in that sorry band*.
 61 And of the sons of priests: the sons
 Of Habaiah, of Koz the sons,
 And sons of Barzillai, who took
 A wife of daughters of *no crook*
 Barzillai the Gileadite, and
 Was called by their name and their band.
 62 These sought their listing *among* those
 Who were registered in their rows,
 But they were not found; therefore they
 Were unclean from the priestly way.
 63 The chief told them they should not eat
 Most holy things upon the beat
 Before a priest enquired of such
 From Urim and Thummin in touch.
 64 The whole assembly there together
Was forty-two thousand *off feather*,
 And three hundred *and sixty much*,
 65 Besides their man and maid employed,
 Of whom *were* seven thousand *joyed*
 And three hundred and thirty-seven;
 And they had two hundred from heaven,
 Men and women singers *uncloyed*.

The sons of Nekoda were never found
Among the lists of priests and once
renowned.

Nekoda I suppose means spotted one,
Covered with vowel signs and the dots
undone

That represent the melodies to sing
When opening Your Word, cantillating.
What spots made Nekoda to share
A name that later rose into the air
In technical term for the holy Writ?
Spotted like leopard or peppered a bit,
The father of these lost ones waits to see
What Urim and Thummin reveal to be.
Beloved, write my name on Your divine
heart
And never, never let it come to part.

66 Their horses *were* seven hundred
And thirty-six, their mules that sped
Were two hundred and forty-five,
67 Their camels four hundred alive
And thirty-five, and *their* donkeys
Six thousand seven hundred *please*
And twenty. 68 *Some* ancestral chiefs,
When they came to YHWH's house of
griefs
There in Jerusalem, donated
For Alohims' house built instated,
69 As much as each one could, they gave
To the storehouse for the work *brave*
Sixty-one thousand drams of gold,
Five thousand silver minas told,
And one hundred priestly robes' *fold*.
70 So the priests and the Levites and
The folk, the singers, and the band
Of the gatekeepers, and kiddies
Called Nethinim, lived in cities,
And all Israel in their cities.

Why are the Nethinim mentioned again
Along with Levite singers and the men
Who keep the gates? I wonder with what
grace

This lengthy chapter comes before my face.
I touch the names and find them all aglow
And yet there are so many things to know
And not revealed. The Nethinim, the sons
Of gift, it seems, are mentioned in their
tons.

Beloved, I walk the sacred aisles of stone

Reverberating with the trees alone
That form the pillars of my temple here,
And long to know the many that appear
In holiness before Your righteous throne.
And still I wait sitting upon my gear.

Ezra 3

1 And when the seventh month had come,
The children of Israel *in sum*
Were in the towns, the people came
Together as one man in name
Into Jerusalem *of fame*.

2 And Jeshua Jozadak's son
And his brothers the priests *for fun*,
Zerubbabel Shealtiel's son
And his brothers, got up and built
The altar of Alohims' *lilt*

In Israel, to offer burnt
Offerings on it, as *it is learnt*
In the Law of Moses the man
Of Alohims *as bright as can*.

3 Though fear *had come* upon them for
The folk of those countries before,
They set the altar on its feet,
And offered burnt offerings in treat
To YHWH, the morning and the eve
In sacrifices for reprieve.

4 They kept the Feast of Tabernacles
Too, as *it's* written, with its snackles
Of daily burnt offerings in count
Required by ordinance amount

For each day. 5 After *that they gave*
The regular burnt offering wave,
And *those* for the months' first day and
All the appointed feasts at hand
Of YHWH that were set apart and
Of everyone who willingly
Offered to YHWH an offering free.

6 From the seventh month's first day they
Began to sacrifice that way

To YHWH, although the temple base
Of YHWH was not yet put in place.

7 They also gave payment to those
Masons and carpenters they chose,
And food, and drink, and oil to folk
Of Sidon and Tyre to bring yoke
Of cedar logs from Lebanon
To the sea, to Joppa, anon
By the leave they had from the king
Of Persia, Cyrus by naming.

Nobody thought to ask why workers long

Past did not come in droves to a bee's song
 And volunteer their labour to Your tent
 To patch the base and raise a rafter bent.
 Today they always advertise for all
 To work free building up the kingdom hall,
 But in those ancient times the work was
 paid
 To every mason, carpenter waylaid.
 Beloved, the days when masons worked
 abroad
 From hand to mouth for the day's wages
 laud
 Are passed. Those men without their
 wages' sum
 Would have died of their hunger on the
 bum.
 It's only now that people are so rich
 That they can take a day out of the pitch.

8 In the second month of the year
 Second of coming to appear
 At the house of Alohim at
 Jerusalem, Zerubbabel
 The son of Shealtiel, and that
 Jeshua son of Jozadak,
 And the rest of their brothers fell
 The priests and the Levites *on track*,
 And all those who had come out from
 The captives of Jerusalem,
 Began *work* and appointed such
 Levites from twenty years old much
 And above to oversee all
 The work of the house of YHWH's call.

9 Then Jeshua *with* his sons and
 Brothers, Kadmiel *with* his band
 Of sons, and the sons of Judah,
 Arose as one to hold a paw
 Over those working on the house
 Of Alohim: the sons to grouse
 Of Henadad *with* their sons and
 Their brothers the Levites *in band*.

10 When the builders laid the foundation
 Of the temple of YHWH's elation,
 The priests stood in their priestly robes
 With trumpets, *though no astrolobes*,
 And the Levites, sons of Asaph,
 With cymbals, to praise *without gaff*
 YHWH, according to ordinance
 Of David Israel's king *to dance*.

11 And they sang antiphonally,
 Praising and giving thanks *in fee*
 To YHWH: "For *He is* good, mercy

From Him *lasts* forever to see
 Toward Israel." Then all the folk
 Shouted with a great shout for broke,
 When they praised YHWH, for was the
 base

Foundation of YHWH's house in place.
 12 But many priests and Levites and
 Chiefs ancestral of house and band,
 Old men who had seen the first temple,
 Wept with a loud voice when the stemple
 Of this house rose before their eyes.
 Yet many shouted joyous cries,
 13 So that the folk could not tell which
 Noise was the shout of joy in pitch
 And which the weeping of the folk,
 For the folk shouted loud for broke,
 The sound was heard far off in stroke.

In every vision of the hopeful glade
 Where I have moved and sung, and worked
 and laid

My head to sleep, I find there's always
 choice

Either to weep aloud or then rejoice.
 Some are resigned to will of God when
 things

Go bad and they are faced with
 questionings.

Some rage against the portals of the sky,
 Some break their faith and some come to
 deny.

I do not bring an accusation strung
 Against You, my Beloved, like Christian
 sung.

Instead I take up hand and heart and choose
 Before the glories of the things I lose
 And gain to find that You have made me so
 That I can choose the way I wish to go.

Ezra 4

1 And when the foes of Judah and
 Benjamin heard the captive band
 Were building the temple of YHWH
 Alohim of Israel, 2 in crew
 They came to Zerubbabel and
 Ancestral chiefs, and said to them,
 "Let us build with you, for in gem
 We turn to your Alohim just
 As you; and we upon the dust
 Have sacrificed to Him as long
 As we've been here and since the days
 Of Esarhaddon king to praise

Of Assyria, who brought us strong."

3 Zerubbabel and Jeshua

And the rest of the heads in awe

Of Israel's ancestors told them,

"You cannot do a thing in hem

To help us build our Alohim

A house, but we alone we deem

To build to YHWH the Alohim

Of Israel, as King Cyrus

The king of Persia ordered us."

4 The people of the land essayed

To trouble Judah's folk waylaid.

They hindered their building 5 and paid

People to keep them from their task

All Cyrus king of Persia's bask,

Even until Darius' reign,

The king of Persia *to maintain*.

6 In the reign of Ahasuerus,

In start of his reign *not to clear us*,

They wrote an accusation sent

Against Judah's folk and the tent

Jerusalem *as city bent*.

7 In Artaxerxes' times also,

Bishlam, Mithredath, Tabel go,

And the rest of their friends wrote to

Artaxerxes the king of crew

Of Persians. And the letter then

Was written in the script of men,

Script Aramaic, and was wrought

In Aramaic tongue and plot.

The foes of Judah spend a weary dime

Having the legal face upon their crime.

Especially the governor is set

For juggling papers to see what he'll get.

Outside the swallows in their swiftly curl

Enunciate the freedom of the churl

So evident in his conformity

Of legalize to sit under a tree.

From his name I'd think I would find

mercy,

Justice and help, but that is par to be

Under the civil servants' polished vests.

Did I not see the swallows make their nests

Around the Rum Kale, while Byzantine

Heroes were no longer there to be seen.

8 Rehum commander and the scribe

Shimshai wrote letter and for bribe

Against Jerusalem and sent

To King Artaxerxes and lent:

9 From Rehum the commander and

From Shimshai the scribe, and the band

Of their friends, of the Dinaites,

The Apharsathchites, Tarpelites,

The folk of Persia and Erech

And Babylon and Shushan's *beck*,

The Dehavites, the Elamites,

10 And the rest of the nations's wights

Whom high and noble Osnapper

Took captive and removed to where

The cities of Samaria

And the rest on the other crow

Of the river, et cetera.

11 This *is* a copy of the brief

That they sent to him *for relief*:

"To King Artaxerxes from your

Servants, the men beyond the shore,

Et cetera. 12 "Let it be known

To the king that the Jews here shown

Came up from you, arrived to us

Into Jerusalem *for fuss*

Are building the wicked, rebellious

City, and make its walls *to jelly us*,

Repairing its foundations' truss.

13 "So let it be known to the king

That if this city's built to sing

And its walls finished, they will not

Pay tax, tribute, or custom aught,

And the king's store will lose a lot.

14 "Since we get our rate from the house

Royal, it was not right to douse

The king's regard, so we have sent

To tell the king the thing we meant.

15 "Just take a look in record book

Of your ancestors who mistook

And you will find in record book

And know this city has a look

Rebellious, hostile to the kings

And countries with their rebellings

From the city in former times,

Which is why this town in its primes

Was destroyed. 16 "We inform the king

That if this city's built and wing

Of its walls are finished, the end

Will be that you will have no friend

Beyond the river to attend."

The record books are easy ways and

guides.

They always transcribe words when taking

sides.

The record book is sacred to the will

Of those who usurp power and lands to fill

The paunch with raunch of widow's oil and
 bread
 And send her out to scavenge here instead.
 The record books are fine, and some are
 left
 In baked clay tablets hidden in the cleft
 Of tell and excavation, hear the song,
 And know that record books too can be
 wrong.
 Beloved, I too turn to the record books
 And find the graven images and looks
 The world in bright creation in my nooks
 Brings to my wondering eyes and mind
 along.

17 The king replied: "To Rehum chief,
 Shimshai the scribe, *and to in brief*
 The rest of their friends who live in
 Samaria, and *to begin*
 Beyond the river: Peace, et al.
 18 "The letter that you sent to call
 On us has been read before me
 And in translation faithfully.
 19 "I gave command, and search was made,
 And it was found this city strayed
 In former times revolting fair
 Against kings with rebellion's share.
 20 "There also have been mighty kings
 Over Jerusalem, whose springs
 Ruled all beyond the river there,
 And gathered tribute to their share.
 21 "So give the order to make cease
 These men so as not to increase
 This city until by command
 Come straight from me and from my hand.
 22 "Be sure you do not fail to do
 Exactly what I tell you to.
 Why should kings suffer from the view
 Of further evil from the crew?"
 23 Now when the copy of the brief
 Of King Artaxerxes' relief
 Was read before Rehum, Shimshai
 The scribe, and their friends standing by,
 They went up quickly to the town
 Jerusalem against the Jews,
 And by the force of arms abuse
 And made them stop and threw them down.
 24 And so the work upon the house
 Of Allah then was there to douse
 And stopped there in Jerusalem
 Until the second year in hem
 Of King Darius the Persian.

The letters that You send, Beloved, at hand
 Of prophets and divine guides in the land
 Are often used as some excuse to play
 With guns and tanks instead of better way.
 The letters that You send, Beloved, in beak
 And claw upon the plain and mountain
 peak
 Are often justifications we seek
 Who play the claw in oppression today.
 But I, Beloved, look on the revelation
 Of nature and the sacred books in station
 To tell me not to kill the neighbour nor
 To steal his goods or batter down his door.
 But I, Beloved, look to Your throne above
 To judge the world and me in mercy's love.

Ezra 5

1 Haggai the prophet, Zechariah
 The son of Iddo, prophets-crier,
 Were prophesying to the Jews
 Who *were* in Judah and the mews
 Of *old* Jerusalem, in name
 Of Allah God of Israel's fame.
 2 Zerubbabel Shealtiel's son
 And Jeshua Jozadak's son
 Got up to build Allah's new house
 There in Jerusalem *to grouse*,
 And prophets of Allah with them
 Helping them all *with stratagem*.
 3 At the same time Tattenai chief
 Beyond the river for relief
 And Shethar-Boznai and their friends
 Came to them and spoke to these ends:
 "Who has commanded you to build
 This temple and this wall fulfilled?"
 4 So we told them all the men's names
 Who were building the house *of fames*.
 5 But their Allah's eye was upon
 The elders of the Jews and spawn,
 So they could not make them stop till
 A report filled Darius' bill.
 A reply in writing came back
 Concerning this issue and lack.

Even You, my Beloved, come interfere
 With correspondence and the legal gear,
 Manipulating time and brief and fear
 To let Your will be done on earth below.
 Even You, My Beloved, join in the show
 Of civil servant on the task to go
 And find a way of artificial bent

To bring justice into a world unsent.
If I were You and sat upon a throne
Above the earth to hear the ardent groan
Of beast and flock, of king and god of
stone,
I'd lend a hand directly to the true
That come on bended knee and before You
Petitioning a retributive crew.

6 This is a copy of the brief
That Tattenai sent *to their grief*:
The chief of beyond river's land,
And Shethar-Boznai, and his band,
The Persians who're beyond the river,
Unto Darius king *long liver*.
7 They sent a letter to him, in
Which was written thus *to their sin*.
"To Darius the king all peace.
8 "Let the king's knowledge here increase,
That we went to Judea's land,
To the temple of the great hand
Of Allah then being built there
With great stones, and with timber's share
To lay the walls. And this work goes
On with success as they dispose.
9 "We asked those elders, telling them,
'Who ordered you to build this gem
And finish off these temple walls?'
10 "We also asked their names in stalls
To let you know, so we could write
The names of the men chief in sight."

Even the civil servants of a realm
Must play the game with fairness at the
helm
When they provide a document and signed
To be a witness against dear and kind.
So Tattenai admits with hope and fear
What the Jews came to speak into his ear,
And has to direct king to the estate
In which lay temple treasures at the gate.
Beloved, I take my passport and the
guessed
Visa to walk among the pure and blessed,
And find the customs party at the gate
Behind the queue where everyone is late.
After the mass of stamps and lack of smiles
I enter into grace of miles and miles.

11 "And so they replied and they said
'We're servants of Allah outspread
To heaven and earth, and we're restoring

The temple years ago and flooring,
Which a great king of Israel built
And finished *with cedar and gilt*.
12 'Because our ancestors provoked
The Allah God of heaven stoked,
He gave them all into the hand
Of Nebuchadnezzar king's band
Of Babylon, the Chaldean,
Who destroyed this temple and span
And took the folk to Babylon.
13 'However, in the first year's dawn
Of Cyrus king of Babylon,
King Cyrus issued a decree
To build this house of God in fee.
14 'Also, the gold and silver things
Of the house of Alohims' *wings*,
Which Nebuchadnezzar had taken
From the temple that *was unshaken*
In Jerusalem and brought to
The temple of Babylon's *pew*,
Those King Cyrus took from the store
Temple of Babylon in drawer,
And they were given into hand
Of one named Sheshbazzar to stand
As chief and govern there the land.
15 'And he said to him, "Take these pots,
And go and carry them in lots
To the house in Jerusalem,
And let the house of Allah's hem
Be rebuilt in its former dream."
16 'Then the same Sheshbazzar came *and*
Laid the foundation there to stand
Of house Allah which *is* in
Jerusalem, but from that time
Even till now it's uphill climb
To build and it's not finished yet.
17 'So now, if *it seem* to the king
A good thing, let a search in string
Be made in the king's treasure house,
Which *is* in Babylon *to dowse*,
Whether or not that a decree
Was issued by King Cyrus' see
To build this house of Allah free
Here at Jerusalem, and let
The king send us his pleasure set.'"

The temple that Solomon once built up
Emerg'd in gold and silver drinking cup.
More than hope itself, people looked upon
Pillar and cornice instead of the dawn
Letting in light from You to show the way
Entirely paved with gold of love to stay.

Remember, my Beloved, that every day
 Enlarges on the temple and the sway
 Sung in the Psalms of David's simple lay
 To drown with melody the drunken bray
 Of the establishment set up to be
 Right for the stone and steel that men can
 see.
 Enough of temples built by human hands!
 Deliver me from such creeds and their
 bands!"

Ezra 6

1 So King Darius made decree
 To search the archives carefully
 To find the warehouse in the town
 Of Babylon where they'd put down
 The treasures. 2 There was found in court
 At Achmetha, a roll in sort,
 The province of Media, and on
 It there was such a record drawn.
 3 In first year of Cyrus the king
 Cyrus the king decreed a thing
 For Allah's house in city of
 Jerusalem, "Let house above
 Be built, and altars where they lay
 The sacrifices, and make stay
 Foundations of it strong, the height
 Of it shall be then sixty right
 Armlengths, and the width of it true
 Sixty armlengths *when come in view*.
 4 "Three rows of great stones and a row
 Of new timbers, and let it show
 Expenses taken from the store
 Of the king's house when they need more.
 5 "And also let the golden pots
 And silver ones of Allah's lots
 Which Nebuchadnezzar too out
 Of the temple and at the rout
 Of city of Jerusalem
 And brought to Babylon pro tem,
 Be sent out and brought up again
 To Jerusalem's temple then,
 Each in its place, and set them there
 In Allah's house *and kept with care*.

Usurpers always keep archives and write
 The sins they've done, so in the noble flight
 Of those who come after, the things may be
 Pretended when auspicious, set to right.
 Look for the archives, and You'll find the
 tree
 Of usurpation and the false writ see

The coming of the hopeful for the light.
 It is a true principle faithfully.
 Beloved, I turn my eyes about me where
 The tide of church and record house must
 share
 The same offices so the heat bill comes
 Not above what can bear the city's sums.
 Beloved, I have suspicions of the free
 That they secretly host idolatry.

6 "Now Tatnai, governor beyond
 The river, Shetharboznai's bond
 And your mates the Apharsachites,
 Which are beyond the river rights,
 All you keep away from the sites.
 7 "Leave the work of this house alone
 And place of the God Allah's throne,
 And let the governor of Jews
 And elders of the Jews now choose
 To build this Allah's house in mews.
 8 "Moreover I issue decree
 'For what you'll do for those who see
 The building of Allah's house here,
 The elders of these Jews appear,
 That out of the king's revenues
 Of tribute beyond river's views,
 Expenses shall be given to
 These men unhindered what they do.
 9 'And whatever they need, both young
 Bulls as well as rams and lambs strung
 For the burnt offerings of Allah
 Of heaven, wheat, salt, and wine *in paw*,
 And oil as much as set for priests
 Appointed for the city's feasts
 In Jerusalem, let it be
 Provided them each day surely.
 10 'That they may offer sacrifice
 Of sweet incense up to the nice
 Allah of heaven and pray for life
 Of the king and his sons *and wife*.'

Ah, here's the rub! Pray for the king and
 sons.

I've been in churchly services by tons,
 And what do I hear in each place of prayer
 But that they make petitions everywhere
 To You or to the idols that live under
 Your blessed name be provided with
 thunder
 To keep and protect the state and the one
 Who heads the state and armies when
 they're done.

Beloved, hypocrisy is always found
Where prayers are made for presidents
around,
And for their armies fighting on the
ground.

Beloved, just take a look and You will see
How harsh the world's become though
faithfully
Set in the Persian debt of cross and tree.

11 "Also I have made a decree
That who shall change this word in fee,
Let timber be pulled from his house
And set up where he'll hang *like grouse*,
And let his house be turned into
A pile of dung *for all to view*.

12 "And the Allah who's caused His name
To stay there, may He kill the claim
Of all kings and folk who shall put
Their hand to change or bash the root
Of this house of Allah which is
At Jerusalem. In a whiz
Let this decree be carried out
That I Darius make *with clout*."

Just look, Beloved, at what force has been
set

To support You and Your house and to get
All people to respect You and Your name.
I'd think You'd hang Your head for very
shame.

Is not invisibility enough
To get You over every tempting tough?
Must You have kings and armies to protect
Your name and fame for love of the elect?
Beloved, I see the end of every start
That binds with fear both beast and human
heart,

And think that I relinquish every part.
Beloved, my temple is not made of stone,
It is not made with ivory and gold throne,
But is the song of prayer to You alone.

13 Then Tatnai, governor to stand
On this side of the river strand,
Shetharboznai and all their band,
According as Darius king
Had ordered, so they did the thing.

14 The elders of the Jews, they built
And prospered through the sayings gilt
Of Haggai the prophet and yet
Zechariah Iddo's son set.

And they built and finished the place
According to command and race
Of Israel's Allah and by word
Of Cyrus and Darius stirred,
And Artaxerxes Persia's king,
And that's how they did everything.
15 The house was done on the third day
Of Adar's month, which was in way
Of the sixth year of the reign of
Darius the king *writ above*.
16 The folk of Israel and the priests,
And the Levites ready for feasts,
And the captive people then kept
The dedication of the sweet
House of Allah with joy *and wept*.

Your house is built today and every day
As I lift up a slender voice to pray.
Your house is made of living flesh and
blood
And Psalms sung on the loving tongue, the
stud
And wall are shifted with the turning
breeze

Invisibly beneath the startled trees
That join in cantillating of Your word.
Your temple is not something seen but
heard.

Beloved, within the inner chamber where
I set aside both form and guise and care,
My spirit is renewed to find You there,
And to rejoice above the pitied share
Of those whose temple's made of fragile
stone
Without prostration at Your inner throne.

17 They offered at the dedication
Of this house of Allah in ration
A hundred bulls, two hundred rams,
And four hundred also of lambs,
And for a sin offering for all
Israel twelve goats by number's call
Of all the tribes in Israel's hall.

18 They set the priests in their divisions,
And the Levites and with precisions
For the service of Allah which
Is at Jerusalem by pitch
Of what's written in Moses' book.

19 The captive people came and took
The Passover on fourteenth day
Of the first month *in the right way*.
20 The priests and Levites purified

Themselves together, all in pride
 Were pure, and sacrificed for all
 The captive people at the call
 The Passover, and for the priests
 Their brothers and themselves in feasts.
 21 The folk of Israel who had come
 Back from captivity *in sum*,
 And all who had converted to
 Them from the filth of heathen pew,
 To seek YHWH Alohim of folk
 Of Israel ate it *at a stroke*.
 22 They kept the feast of yeastless bread
 Seven days with joy and *not dread*,
 For YHWH had made them joyful and
 Turned the hear of the king of band
 Of Assyria to them to make
 Their hands strong in the work for sake
 Of the house of Alohim God
 Of Israel *upon the sod*.

The mention of the building is both rare
 And fine to rejoice in the loving care
 That You showered upon the earthly crew
 That returned to Jerusalem anew.
 The mention of the priest and sacrifice
 Is something that my heart finds very nice,
 And yet one thing is missing from the
 whole,
 One thing that would have been my
 garnered goal.
 The ark of covenant is never found
 Within the temple and upon its ground.
 And yet I trust like my hymns that resound
 In words of Decalogue without the stone
 Tables, You also accept what they own.
 If You are present nothing else takes toll.

Ezra 7

1 So after these things in the reign
 Of Artaxerxes Persia's thane,
 Ezra and the son of Seraiah,
 Who was the son of Azariah
 Who himself was son of Hilkiah
 2 The son of Shallum, Zadok's son,
 The son of Ahitub when done,
 3 The son of Amariah, son
 Of Azariah, who was son
 Of Meraioth, 4 who was the son
 Of Zerariah, Uzzi's son,
 The son of Bukki, 5 who was son
 Of Abishua who was son
 Of Phinehas who was the one

Sired by Eleazar the son
 Of Aaron the chief priest when done,
 6 This Ezra came from Babylon,
 And was a skilful scribe in law
 Of Moses, which YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel had given in paw,
 And the king gave him, it would seem,
 All he asked for, according to
 The hand of his Alohim YHWH.

What would we do today without the hand
 Of Ezra taking up the sacred word
 As scribe and priest, despite the times were
 blurred
 And it seemed all was lost, city and land,
 The memories of the past, the mighty band
 Of Gideon's three hundred with fire stirred,
 And Deborah whose woman's rule
 conferred
 With Barak to win back the silver strand?
 What would I do, Beloved, as I report
 The visions that I find among the pages
 Of Torah and of snow-encrusted soil,
 If Ezra had not been a scribe at court
 And hobnobbed with the ancients and the
 sages,
 What would have come of me and my
 small toil?

7 And there went up of Israel's folk
 And of the priests, and many *yoke*
Of Levites, singers, porters and
 The Nethinim into the land
 Of Jerusalem in the year
 Seven of Artaxerxes' career.
 8 And he came to Jerusalem
 In the fifth month by stratagem
 The seventh year of the king's reign.
 9 The first day of the first month lain
 He started out from Babylon,
 And on the fifth month's first day he
 Came to Jerusalem in fee,
 According to the favoured hand
 Of his Alohim *on the land*.
 10 For Ezra had prepared his heart
 To seek the law of YHWH apart,
 And do it, and to teach the folk
 In Israel statutes at a stroke.

Did Ezra once prepare his heart to read
 Your law, Beloved, and every command
 heed?

Then bless his loving soul, and let me mind
His memory beyond both heart and kind.
Did Ezra once prepare his heart? I see
The golden beams of Your eternity,
But they should have been lost if one had
not

Doubted the might of Babylon and got
The fragmentary pages cast aside
By Your own people when they came to
hide
In Babylon from hunger and the curse
Of trying to be nation and not worse.
The courage of one man not to despair
Saved Torah, Psalm, and prophets for my
share.

11 Now this is what the letter said
The king Artaxerxes was led
To give to Ezra the priest and
The scribe, the scribe of the command
And Torah of YHWH and of His
Statutes to Israel, *that is*,

12 “Artaxerxes, the king of kings,
To Ezra the priest, scribe in things
Of the law of Lord Allah in
The sky and so forth to begin,

13 “I make decree that all of them
Who are of Israel’s folk and them
Of priests and Levites in my realm
Who freely wish to take the helm
And go up to Jerusalem,
May go with you. 14 “And since you’re
sent

By the king and his seven spent
Counsellors, to enquire about
Judah and Jerusalem’s rout,
By the law of your Allah’s hem,
Which is in your hand, it would seem,

15 “To carry back silver and gold
The king and council freely hold
Out to Israel’s Allah, whose room
Is in Jerusalem to bloom,

16 “And all the silver and the gold
That you can find in all the hold
Of the province of Babylon,
With voluntary offering drawn
From the people and of the priests
Offered willingly for the feasts
Of the house of their Allah which
Is in Jerusalem to pitch,

17 “That you may buy quickly with this
Money bulls, rams and lambs *remiss*

With their food offerings and their drink
Offerings and offer at *the brink*
Of the altar of the house of
Your Allah which is in above
Mentioned Jerusalem *in glove*.

When kings return to see the matter done,
It seems there’s no other way to be seen
Than gold and silver shadow on the green,
And all the passing flowers beneath the sun
Ignored for being temporary fun,
While only permanence can weather keen
Storms of both ignorance and the sharp
sheen

Of politics. And yet no victory’s won
By offerings on an altar, silver pots
Nor strength of numbers in the rank and
file,
Nor hopeful courtiers writing reams of
rhyme.

The victory is always calling shots
From its own stable platform without guile,
One man who cares nothing at all for time.

18 “Whatever may seem right to you,
And to your brothers *in your crew*,
To do with what remains of gold
And silver in the hand *to hold*
Do according to Your Allah
And what He might require *in awe*.

19 “The pots also given to you
For the service *and in the view*
Of the house of your Allah *true*
Take them before the Allah of
Jerusalem *mentioned above*.

20 “And whatsoever more is needed
For the house of your Allah heeded,
That you’ll have occasion to give,
Take it from the king’s treasure *sieve*.

21 “And I, I Artaxerxes king,
Make a decree to all the ring
Of treasurers beyond the spring,
That whatever Ezra the priest
And scribe of the law and the feast
Of the Allah of heaven might need
Of you to provide it with speed.

Wait here, Beloved, I take a great offence
That those who eavesdrop on our
conversation
Are angry with Your poor servant in station
For using the word Allah in the tents

Of Hebrew Scripture and go wrathful hence
 As though the fault were mine and not
 creation
 Of You Yourself in Syrian elation
 That still prefers the Aramaic sense.
 The fact is Allah's written every time
 I use it here and I merely invoke
 The same letters that in Hebrew remain
 To spell Alohim in my prosy rhyme.
 It's You, Beloved, who laid the fatal stroke,
 And left my critics with ignorant stain.

22 "Up to a hundred silver pound,
 And to a hundred measures bound
 Of wheat, and to a hundred store
 Of wine and to a hundred more
 Of oil and salt as none forbore.
 23 "Whatever heaven's Allah will
 Command, let it be done to fill
 For the house of Allah of sky,
 For why should their be wrath come by
 The realm of the king and his sons?
 24 "Also we certify *in tons*
 Concerning the priests and Levites,
 Singers, porters, Nethinims' rights
 Or servants of this Allah's room,
 It shall not be lawful to doom
 Them to toll tribute or custom.
 25 "And you, Ezra, after wisdom
 Of your Allah, as in your power,
 Set magistrates and judges glower,
 Who may judge all the folk that sit
 Beyond the river, all as fit
 To know the laws of your Allah,
 And teach the ignorant in awe.
 26 "And whosoever will not do
 The law of your Allah and true,
 And the law of the king in view,
 Let judgement fall quickly on him,
 Whether it be to a death grim,
 Or banishment or confiscation
 Of property, or prison's *station*."

The purpose of the king in setting out
 To remedy the fallen house of God
 Is not an act of faith, but fear in pod.
 He's still afraid the conquered gods may
 shout
 A word against his kingdom turned about
 And that's why he comes clean to give a
 prod
 To taking back the temple pots and plod

Back to Palestine to rebuild with clout.
 It's not for Your praise that the king does
 this,
 But that the people might express their own
 Loyalty to his throne by prayers to You
 In favour of the king and not to miss
 Either a night or morning overthrown,
 But keep the king's welfare always in view.
 27 Blessed be YHWH Alohim of our
 Fathers, who has put such *a power*
 As this into the king's heart *now*
 To beautify the house *somehow*
 Of YHWH in Jerusalem's *brow*,
 28 And has extended me mercy
 Before the king and council free,
 And before all the mighty men
 Of the king. I was strong again
 As the power of YHWH Alohim
 Of mine was on me not in dream,
 And gathered out of Israel
 Chief men to go with me a spell.

Like Ezra I too raise Your broken word
 Up once again after covered with turd
 It served the generations as a crutch
 To support usurping kings for as much.
 Like Ezra I too knuckle under state
 And find the favour of the palliate
 Is necessary not just to my bread,
 But also that I may in peace be led
 To restore that grand temple of Your being
 Upon this earth with cantillating seeing
 The Hebrew and the Aramaic song
 Still on the air, though with a slender
 through.
 Beloved, even alone I take on lip
 Your law and from its nectar stay to sip.

Ezra 8

1 Now these are the chief of their fathers,
 A genealogy, *no bothers*,
 Of those who went up with me from
 Babylon, in the reign *in sum*
 Of Artaxerxes the king *rum*.
 2 One of the sons of Phinehas,
 Gershom; of Ithamar's sons *pass*
 Daniel; of the sons of David
 Hatush. 3 Of Shechariah's *bid*
 And sons of Parosh, Zechariah,
 And with him counted *by pariah*
 Of males in genealogy

Comes to a hundred and fifty.
 4 Of the sons of Pahathmoab,
 Elihoenai, the son *and scab*
 Of Zerariah, and with him
 Two hundred males *both glad and grim*.
 5 Of the sons of Shechaniah,
 The son of Jahaziel *raw*
 And with him three hundred males' *paw*.
 6 Of the sons also of Adin,
 Ebed the son of Jonathan,
 And with him fifty males *in bin*.
 7 And of the sons of Elam there
 Were Jeshariah in the care
 Of Athaliah and with him
 Seventy males *both patched and trim*.

These churches are right small, although
 the guest
 Might think that two hundred come to
 invest
 Your Sabbath songs with glory of their
 throats
 Is enough for the spelling of such notes.
 Indeed, Ezra has no complaints to find
 With the numbers as such he has in mind.
 Who want to enter in the Promised Land
 And find the courts of heaven on the strand
 Of Jordan may be few, indeed they are
 Much fewer in my travelling on this star.
 Yet even a few men and women can
 Make great strides of faith and encircle
 span
 Not only of infinity of grace,
 But an eternity in every place.

8 And of the sons of Shephatiah,
 The son of Michael Zebadiah,
 And with him fourscore males *to fly you*.

YHWH is my judgement and YHWH is my
 gift
 Are names of men that went with Ezra back
 To the land of promise and were not slack
 In hopeful means to succeed and to lift
 The walls and temple and to make short
 shrift
 Of those who might oppose the growing
 rack
 Of building stones that trace a shining track
 Against the foes around that stand up
 miffed.
 And yet today as I think of these names

I wonder what mom or dad in that land
 Not knowing what might come a future day
 Had faith to give such epithets with claims.
 With judgement and with gift You come to
 stand,
 Beloved, and open up for me a way.

9 Of the sons of Joab, the son
 Of Obadiah Jehiel's son,
 And with him two hundred eighteen.
 10 The sons of Shelomith *to glean*
 The son of Josiphiah and
 With him one hundred sixty band.
 11 And of the sons of Bebai there
 Were Bebai's son named Zechariah
 With twenty-eight males in his care.
 12 And then the sons of Azgad *try you*,
 Johanan son of Hakkatan,
 With him a hundred and ten span.
 13 Adonikam brought the last sons
 Whose names are these *on toes and buns*,
 Eliphelet, Jeiel and *sails*
 Of Shemaiah, and with them males
 To count of sixty *as entails*.
 14 Of the sons also of Bigvai
 One Uthai and Zabbud *to vie*,
 And with them seventy males *to try*.
 15 I gathered them together at
 The river that runs to *where sat*
 Ahava, and there we remained
 Three days in tents while I attained
 A view of the folk and the priests,
 And found no Levi's sons *for feasts*.
 16 So I sent for Eliezer,
 For Ariel, and for *the fer*
 Shemaiah, and for Elnathan,
 And for Jarib, and Elnathan,
 And for Nathan and Zechariah,
 And for Meshullam, no pariah,
 The chief men, also for Joarib,
 And for Elnathan *not to fib*
 Men of understanding *in bib*.

The genealogy may seem long here,
 Indeed it's only useful in the ear
 When sung in the original tongue and
 Heard in the language of the Promised
 Land.

And yet the thing is broken down again
 In later chapters for sounding the men
 Who married pagan wives to get them
 cheer.

Beloved, the name lists are a grace to me
When I hear the words of eternity
Cantillated to fresh my eye to see
And hear, to hear the twittering on limb
Of sparrow angels with trigger and vim
Spy out Your revelation with a trill
And then fly off to explore the next hill.

17 And I sent them with the command
To Iddo the chief of the land
Of Casiphia, and told them
What they should say *ad hominem*
To Iddo, to the Nethinim
His brothers and the place *of scheme*
Casiphia, that they should bring
Us ministers and such to sing
In the house of our Alohim.
18 And by the good hand of our God
On us they brought a man *by prod*
Of understanding of the sons
Of Nahli, son of Levi's runs,
The son of Israel, and one seen
Sherebiah in band eighteen
Of sons and brothers *on the scene*.
19 And Hashabiah and with him
Jeshaiah of the sons *not dim*
Of Merari, his brothers and
Their sons, in all twenty in band.
20 Also of the Nethinim, whom
David and the princes gave room
For the service of the Levites,
Two hundred twenty of the wights
Of Nethinim, and of them were
Expressed by name down to a fer.

It's interesting that porters and the singers
Did not from the first volunteer as ringers,
But had to be hunted up from the street
Where they had settled to enjoy the treat
Of empire peace though oppression's fruit
blasted.

All human peace is someone's pain while
lasted.

So they were satisfied to live and die
In the land of the stranger and to lie
In comfort rather than rise up and vie
For desert fortresses, and I know why.
And yet they came when summoned, no
complaint,

So bless the memory of them though faint,
And bless those today who awake a spell
To love and then return to sleep as well.

21 And then I proclaimed a fast there
At the river of Ahava,
So we might afflict us before
Our Alohim and seek the *store*
Of a right way from Him for us
And for our little ones *in fuss*,
And for our wealth in omnibus.
22 For I was ashamed to require
From the king army band *in hire*
And cavalry to help us in
The way against enemy sin,
Because we'd spoken to the king
Saying "The power of our God's *ring*
Is on all those for good who seek
Him but His power and His wrath peek
At all those that forsake His weak."
23 And so we fasted and besought
Our Alohim for this in lot,
And He heard us in what we got.

There are two ways it seems to protect life,
One is to get an army and a knife
That's sharp enough to wield with little
skill

And long enough to meet the foe and kill.
The other is to fast instead of fight.

I wonder if this latter way is right.
I know the commandment says not to slay,
And yet that also must mean in its way
To protect the life I am most involved
In keeping safe and so my problem's
solved,

That I may kill intruder if at point
There's no other way to protect the joint.
Will You come intervene for those just
fasting

Who have no martial arts in their back
casting?

24 Then I set aside twelve in chief
Of the priests, Sherebiah's *fief*
And Hashabiah and ten *more*
Of their brothers with them *in store*.

25 And weighed to them silver and gold
And the vessels in which to hold
The offering of the house of God
Which the king and his council *prod*
And his lords and all Israel there
Had offered given in their care.

26 I weighed into their hand the weight
Of six hundred and fifty *great*

Talents of silver and in pots
 Of silver one hundred in lots,
 A hundred talents yet of gold.
 27 And twenty gold basins *all told*
 Of each a thousand drams, and two
 Vessels of fine copper *in view*
 As precious as gold *to accrue*.
 28 And I told them, "Holy are you
 To YHWH, so are the vessels too,
 The silver and the gold, they are
 A freewill offering to the God
 Of your fathers YHWH *and His rod*.
 29 "So watch and keep them safe until
 You weigh them before the chief bill
 Of the priests and the Levites and
 The chief of Israel's dads in band,
 At Jerusalem in the rooms
 Of the house of YHWH *or for dooms*."

The last folk I would choose to keep my
 sums
 Are clerics, they're the most dishonest
 bums.
 Perhaps the priests and Levites of that date
 Were better than the ones here in this state
 Where the tradition is to steal the last
 Cow of the widow and preach with
 bombast
 The blessings of the widow's might when
 You
 Sent Your messiah to relieve the crew.
 Beloved, I carry little in the way
 Of offering either free-will or for pay,
 In gold or silver or the blood of lambs,
 Or in the tasty roast of slaughtered rams.
 And yet the priesthood of the firstborn lies
 Upon me as my little family tries.

30 The priests and Levites took the weight
 Of silver and gold and the great
 Pots to bring to Jerusalem
 Into the house of Alohim.
 31 Then we set out from the stream there
 At Ahava on the twelfth share
 Of the first month to go up to
 Jerusalem, and our God's true
 Hand was on us, and He delivered
 Us from the hand of foe unsilvered,
 And of such as lay in ambush
 By the way *in both shove and push*.
 32 And we came to Jerusalem
 And stayed there three days as pro tem.

33 Now on the fourth day there was
 weighed
 The silver and gold and parade
 Of pots in house of Alohim
 By the hand of Meremoth grim
 The son of Uriah the priest,
 And with him Eleazar increased
 The son of Phinehas, and with
 Them was Jozabad son and myth
 Of Jeshua, and Niadiah
 The son of Binnui, Levites nigh you.
 34 By number and by weight each one,
 And all the weight writ down when done.
 35 The children of the captives taken
 That had come out of prison shaken,
 Offered burnt offerings to the God
 Of Israel, twelve bullocks plod
 For all Israel, and ninety-six
 Rams, and seventy-seven of tricks
 Of lambs, and twelve male goats in all
 For a sin offering at the wall,
 All this was holocaust unto
Our Alohim and the Lord YHWH.
 36 And they delivered up commissions
 Of the king to the king's tacticians,
 And to the governors on this
 Side of the river *not to miss*,
 And they favoured the people and
 The house of Alohim *to stand*.

Faith makes an institution and in numbers
 Rises from its indolence and its slumbers
 To make a state within a state and share
 The favour of the rulers everywhere.
 This gross reality has been the way
 Your faith, Beloved, has always seen the
 day,
 And rarely is it in position sought
 To hold the sceptre and the Torah taught.
 Despite the many stories of the grand
 Development of kingdom and the manned
 Fortresses at Jerusalem and where
 Samaria rose as the kind and fair,
 In most times and most places faith has
 found
 A humble dwelling on usurper's ground.

Ezra 9

1 Now when these things were done there
 came
 To me the chiefs saying "The shame
 Is Israel's folk, priests and Levites

Have not separated from heights
 Of the people of the lands yet,
 But do abominations set
 By Canaanites and the Hittites,
 The Perizzites and Jebusites,
 The Ammonites and Moabites,
 The Egyptians and Amorites.
 2 "For they have taken for themselves
 And for their sons daughters of elves
 So that the holy seed is mixed
 With the folk of these lands and fixed,
 Indeed the hand of prince and ruler
 Has been the foremost in such fooler."

3 And when I heard this thing I tore
 My clothes and coat and I forebore
 Not to pull out my hair from my
 Head and my beard and with a sigh
 Sat down astonished *on the shore*.

4 Then were assembled unto me
 Every one that trembled to see
 The things of Israel's Alohim,
 Because of the sins of their dream
 That had been taken captive, and
 I sat astonished *on the land*
 Till evening sacrifice *at hand*.

Genetics are a contemplation still
 Fraught with an importance beyond the bill
 That traces the lines of descent at will.
 The fact is mother's tendencies reveal
 In what the toddler comes to think and feel.
 Who knows what my ancestry tries to show
 In the map of the past and in its glow,
 And yet I find the cantillation of
 Your word has some attraction and some
 love
 That draws me with seductions from the
 rate
 That my ancestry ought to give in fate.
 Is there no hope for heathen wife and child
 Reduced to hearing the melodies wild
 Of Your law cantillated soon and late?

6 I said "O my Alohim, I
 Am ashamed and blush to raise high
 My face to You, my God, for our
 Iniquities now have the power
 Over our head, and our trespass
 Has risen up to the skies' *brass*.
 7 "From the time of our fathers we
 Are in great sin until *the spree*
Of this day, and iniquity

Has brought us, our kings and our priests
 Into the hand of the kings' feasts
 Of the lands, to the sword and to
 Captivity and spoil and to
 Confusion of face as this day.

8 "And now for just a little ray
 Grace has come from YHWH our God's
 way

To leave us a remnant escaped,
 To fix us in His place unscraped,
 That our Alohim might make light
 Our eyes and give a small respite
 In the darkness of bondage night.

How rarely does the faithful seed prevail
 To find a place to live without the pale
 Of the usurper and the judgement spent
 In illegal taxation and to vent
 The wicked rule of king and priest
 unmeant!

The times of Ezra were of uncouth sail,
 So rare such things happen on earth and yet
 The prayer that acknowledges the fine set
 Also repents of wedding and the joy
 Of reproduction and the true employ
 Of humankind to keep a family fed.
 The prayer is one with butter on the bread
 On both sides, which may mean a foolish
 note

Or else for greed event the prophet wrote.

9 "For we were servants, yet our God
 Has not forsaken us to plod
 In our bondage, but has extended
 Mercy to us, and so defended
 Us in the sight of Persia's kings,
 To give us yet some revivings,
 To set up house of Alohim,
 And to repair the destroyed scheme,
 And to give us Gadeer in land
 Of Judah, Jerusalem's *hand*.

10 "Now our Alohim, what shall we
 Say after this? For we now see
 Have broken Your commandments here,
 11 "Which You commanded by the fear
 Of Your servants the prophets, saying,
 'The land into which you are straying
 To keep it is an unclean land
 With filthiness of folk in band
 With their abominations which
 Have filled it from one end to ditch
 Of the other with unclean *pitch*.

12 “So do not give your daughters to
Their sons, neither take in your crew
Their daughters for your sons, nor seek
Their peace or their wealth for the peak,
So you may be strong and not weak
And eat good things from the land and
Leave it as heritage to stand
To your children as time demand.’

13 “After all that’s come on us for
Our wicked acts and for the store
Of trespass, since You Alohim
Have punished us less than the scheme
Of our iniquities *deserves*,

And given such salvation’s *curves*,
14 “Should we again break Your command,
And join together in a band
With the folk of abominations?

Would You not be angry in rations
With us till You’d consumed us all
Till none remain *safe in the stall*?

15 “O YHWH and Israel’s Alohim,
You are righteous, and it would seem
We remain here and have escaped
Today, and see, we are unscraped
Before You in our sins, for we
Cannot stand before You to see
Because we’ve done unfaithfully.”

It’s true You gave command the population
Of Canaan should not become of Your
nation.

The fact is genocide was chosen way
You had to clear the population’s sway,
And Your folk were reluctant in their grace
To wipe them out and never leave a trace.
It’s true You said that they were left to try
Your folk to see if they would not comply
With Your law, and to punish with the
sword,

Captivity to be its own reward.

It’s also true that where ladies exist
Some men will always take them if by fist.
You should have thought of that Yourself,
you missed

A law of nature of Your own to twist.

Ezra 10

1 Now when Ezra had prayed and when
He had confessed, weeping and then
Prostrating himself down before
The house of Alohim on floor,
There gathered by him out of all

Of Israel a crowd to call
Of men and women, children all,
For the people wept much in thrall.

2 And Shechaniah who was son
Of Jehiel and once begun
Of the sons of Elam, replied
And said to Ezra *on the side*,

“We’ve sinned against our Alohim
And taken wives of those who seem
To be folk of the land, yet now
There’s hope in Israel somehow.

3 “Let’s now make a promise to God
To put away all wives of pod
And such as are born of them by
The counsel of my lord come nigh,
And of those who tremble before
The commandment of our God’s store,
And let it be done at law’s score.

4 “Get up, for the word is with you,
And we shall also do so too,
So be of good courage and do.”

5 Then Ezra got up and he made
The chief priests, the Levites and stayed
All Israel to swear that they
Should do according to this way.
And so they swore *all on that day*.

I think the fact these men were willing to
Divorce their wives to make the thing come
true

To save Jerusalem and build the town
And temple not to increase their God’s
frown

Shows an appalling sense of duty and
A shocking sense to obey Your command.
There’s nothing here that I must give up to
Keep Your law and to live the life that’s
true.

None force me to do evil and none make
Me relinquish the banner for Your sake.
Beloved, I greet the peaceful morning and
Pray for the poor and oppressed in the land
That You may give them courage still to
stand,

Obey You while the state’s ruled by a rake.

6 Then Ezra got up from before
The house of Alohim and door,
And went into the chamber of
Johanan the son *and scab* of
Eliashib, and when he came
There, he ate no food in his shame

Nor drank water, because he sighed
For the sins of those who abide
Carried away as captive side.

It's interesting that soon as they came back
From Babylon and even before lack
Of coming to Jerusalem they prayed
Always with fasting for the thing they
made.

The Torah speaks of fasting on parade
Only on rare occasions such as when
Moses went up Sinai to serve all men.
Proliferation of fasting's a thing
That's close to innovation on the wing,
And yet it serves a greater purpose than
The slaughter of beasts in sacrifice can.
The shift from slaughter to the sacrifice
Of fasting's really innovation nice.
There's faith in food and faith without's a
spice.

7 They made a proclamation through
Judah and Jerusalem to
All the captive people that they
Should gather together one day
Into Jerusalem *to pray*.

8 And whoever would not come in
Three days according to the grin
Of the chiefs and elders then all
His property should be the call
Of forfeiture, and he himself
Be separated like an elf
From congregation of those who
Were carried captive of the true.

9 Then all the men of Judah and
Benjamin gathered in a band
Together to Jerusalem
Within three days, *none to condemn*.

What is the basis of this legislation,
This verdict that would deprive a whole
nation
Of the inheritance of promised land?
Those who fail to appear to lend a hand
To divorce will have confiscated all
That their ancestors received from Your
stall.

The verdict is a harsh one and a brave,
It makes Ezra seem very like to crave
Example of Khumeini in his grave.
I guess the law is meant to give to those
Who are Israelites all the land they chose,

But not to those who are not Israelites
By their descent, no matter what their
rights.

The merciful perhaps left when this rose.

10 And Ezra the priest stood and said
To them, "You have sinned and been led
To marry foreign wives, and so
Increase the sin of Israel's *row*.

11 So now confess the thing to YHWH
Alohim of your fathers, do
His pleasure and divorce yourselves
From the land's people *and such elves*,
And from the foreign wives *in crew*.

12 All the assembly answered and
Said with a loud voice, "Your command
Is what we must do *out of hand*.

13 "But the folk are many and it
Is a time of much rain unfit,
And we're not able to be out
Neither is this a job about

One day or two, for we are many
Who have sinned in this matter any.

14 "So let our rulers of all folk
In the assembly stand in yoke,
And let all those who have done such
In taking foreign wives as much
In our towns come at set times and
With them the elders of each band
Of every city come and stand
With the judges of it until
The fierce wrath of our God to fill
In this matter is turned from bill.

The list of those who divorced wife and son
Follows hard on. I wonder what was one
By those who refused and thus gained no
place

In the Scriptures of Ezra, not a trace.
Is there some family now in disgrace
More than two thousand years beyond the
place,
Who have preserved a knowledge of Your
law
And still hold Your name and Sabbaths in
awe?

Can faith be retained by the simple way
Of family priest acknowledging the ray
Of revelation from Sinai sent down?
Or must all ways and means be under
frown

Of greater institutions? Let me price

The way of Abraham and sacrifice.

15 Only Jonathan who was son
Of Asahel and also one
Jahaziah son of Tikvah
Were busy in this thing of law:
And Meshullam and Shabbethai
The Levite helped them *on the sly*.

16 The children of captivity
Did so. And Ezra the priest we
With certain of the fathers' chiefs,
After their fathers' house reliefs
And all of them and by their names
Were separated for their claims
And sat down on the first day of
The tenth month to see to the shove.

17 And they finished with all the men
Who'd married foreigners again
By the first month on the first day,
And after that they went their way.

18 Among the sons of priests there were
Found who had married foreigner,
Of the sons of Jeshua son
Of Jozadak, his brothers won:
Maaseiah, Eliezer and
Jarib, Gedaliah in band.

19 They gave their hands in promise that
They would divorce their wives and scat,
And being guilty they would offer
A ram of the flock for sin's proffer.

The law of divorce is well sought and
taught

Throughout Your revelation to be bought.
The sweet Christian denies validity
Of divorce without infidelity.

But Your law does not require divorce
then,

Rather it strips the guilty of life's yen.
The Gospel seems to say divorce must rise
When it comes out the spouse is one in
guise

Of the forbidden spouses for their kin.
Your word never speaks of divorce as sin.
But here's a fancy, here's divorce made
plain

To be a duty for the holy, sane.
Beloved, Your Scripture is surprising now
And often is, that's something I allow.

20 And of the sons of Immer too,
Hanani, Zebediah too.

21 And of the sons of Harim there
Were Maaseiah and for his share
Elijah and Shemaiah and
Jehiel and Uziah stand.

22 And of the sons of Pashur done:
Elioenai, Maaseiah won
And Ishmael and Nethaneel,
Jozabad and Elasa well.

23 Also of the Levites there were
Jozabad and Shimei *concur*
With Kelaiah who's also called
Kelita, Pethahiah *bald*,
And Judah and Eliezer *stalled*.

24 Of singers too Eliashib,
And of the porters none to fib,
Shallum and Telem and Uri.

25 Of Israel of the sons *to see*
Of Parosh, Ramiah and *free*
Jeziah, and Machiah and
Miamin and Eleazar stand,
And Machijah and Benaiah.

26 Of Elam's sons *to stand in awe*
Were Mattaniah and *some more*,
Zechariah and *at the door*
Jehiel and Abdi, and *yet*
Jeremoth and Eliah *met*.

27 And of the sons of Zattu *these*:
Eloenai, Eliashib's *ease*,
Mattaniah and Jeremoth,
And Zabad and Aziza *both*.

28 Of the sons also of Bebai,
Jehohanan and not to lie
Hananiah, Zabbai, Athlai.

29 And of the sons of Bani *such*
As Meshullam, *also* Malluch,
And Adaiah, Jashub and Sheal
And Ramoth *who was not a heel*.

30 And of sons of Pahathmoab,
Adna and Chelal, Beaiah,
Maaeiah, and Mattaniah,
Bezaleel, Binnui, Manasseh.

31 And of the sons of Harim's way
Eliezer, Ishijah *in sway*,
Machiah, Shemaiah Simeon,
32 Benjamin, Malluch, Shemariah.

33 Of the sons of Hashum *alone*:
Mattenai, Matthatha, Zabad,
Eliphelet, Jeremai *sad*,
Manasse and Shimei, *both glad*.

34 Of the sons of Bani, Maadai,
Amram and Uel *by the by*.
35 Benaiah, Bedeiah, Chelluh,

36 Vaniah, Meremoth *for two*
 And Eliashib *to be true*,
 37 Mattaniah, Mattenai and
 Jaasau *the last one in the band*,
 38 And Bani and Binnui *set*
 And Shimei *as one with regret*,
 39 And Shelemiah and Nathan,
 And Adaiah *down to a man*,
 40 Machnadebai, Shashai, Sharai,
 41 Azareel, and to come by
 Shelemiah, Shemariah,
 42 Shallum, also Amariah,
 And Joseph. 43 And of Nebo's sons
 Jeiel, Mattithiah *and tons*
 Of Zabad, Zebina, Jadau,
 And Joel, Benaiah *and how*.
 44 All these had taken foreign wives,
 And some of them, *bless hearts and lives*,
 Had children by those foreign wives.

By foreign I suppose the prophet means
 That such wives were heathen in all their
 scenes

Refusing to accept Your oneness and
 The law of Moses as the law of land.
 I'd think a lady that had taught her sons
 And daughter to worship You by their tons
 Would be a better wife than Israelite
 Who worshipped Baal and Ashtaroth on
 sight.

And yet the word compels me to relate
 That foreign wives were divorced by the
 mate

That wished to be true to Your throne and
 state.

I find that harsh, but so is harshness set
 In those who refuse Your commandments
 met

And use marriage to confirm that last bet.

Nehemiah

The historicity of Nehemiah is affirmed
 by the Elephantine papyri, which mention
 Johanan (Neh. 12:22,23) and the sons of
 Sanballat as governors of Samaria in 408
 B.C.E. Nehemiah continues the same
 concerns and history as Ezra.

While the apparent racism of the book is
 somewhat disconcerting, the book is
 important for its references to the Sabbath.

The forbidding of the sale of fish on that
 day (13:16,17) has echoes in the Qur'an
 (2:65 et al.) and its explanatory traditions.

Another important detail in the book,
 one that parallels Ezra, is the reading of the
 law with translation. This is something that
 has disappeared from the popular religious
 traditions, which either read translations
 only or the original text, ignoring the
 people who might not understand it. It is
 something that could and ought to be
 recuperated among Jews, Christians and
 Muslims alike.

Thus Nehemiah gives an affirmation of
 how to accommodate to the imperial
 situation while attempting to take
 advantage of its benefits. There is not
 absolute freedom to live out the divine law,
 but the law can be maintained in a
 potentially hostile environment by its
 formal recitation.

Nehemiah 1

1 The words of Nehemiah son
 Of Hachaliah. It was done
 In the month Chisleu, in the year
 Twenty as I came to appear
 In Shushan in the palace near.
 2 Hanani who was one of my
 Brothers came, he, another guy
 Or two from Judah, and I asked
 Them about the Jews not unmasked
 Who remained of captivity,
 And about Jerusalem *wee*.
 3 And they told me, "Those that are left
 Of the captivity bereft
 There in the province are in great
 Affliction and are desolate.
 The wall of Jerusalem too
 Is broken down, and its gates too
 Are burned with fire, it's a sad view."
 4 It happened when I heard these words
 I sat down and cried, wept in turds
 For days and fasted and I prayed
 Before Alohim *who has stayed*
 In heaven *above and not waylaid*.
 5 And I said "I beseech You, YHWH,
 Alohim in the heavens *true*,
 The God great and inexorable,
 Who keeps promise, is merciful
 To those who love Him and who keep
 His commandments, *all ten like sheep*."

Love Him and keep His commandments,
 says he,
 One who prays to You now and fervently,
 Voted the cupbearer before the king,
 Established in the court and inner ring.
 He prays to You, Beloved, in sort to bring
 Into the heart of Your city and house
 Many blessings, where now nibbles the
 mouse.
 Among the captives well kept and admired
 None is so fine as Nehemiah sired.
 Do You, Beloved, not hear the humble
 prayer?
 Keep listening to the words upon the air
 Early spoken by one who keeps Your law
 Engendered in exile, yet in Your awe
 Petitions You and hopes that You are there.

6 “Now let Your ear hear, and Your eye
 Be open, and regard the cry
 Of Your servant, which I pray here
 Before You now, and to appear
 Day and night, for Israel’s folk who
 Are Your servants, and so I do
 Confess the sins of Israel’s folk,
 Which we have sinned in a joint stroke,
 Both I and my father’s house too,
 We all have sinned *and all in crew*.
 7 We’ve dealt corruptly against You,
 Have not kept the commandments true,
 Nor the statutes, nor judgements set
 Which You told us not to forget,
 Also Your servant Moses yet.
 8 “Remember, I beg You, the word
 That You commanded and You stirred
 By Your slave Moses, saying ‘If
 You transgress, I will scatter skiff
 And you’ll remain abroad among
 The nations *and captive unsung*.
 9 ‘But if you turn to me and keep
 My commandments and do like sheep,
 Though some of you were thrown out to
 The furthest place under the view
 Of the sky, still I’ll gather them
 From there, and bring them to the hem
 Of the place where I choose to put
 My name *safe from the trampling foot*.’
 10 “Now these are Your servants and they
 Are Your people whom You one day
 Redeemed by Your great power and by
 Your strong hand *underneath the sky*.

11 “O Lord, I pray you, let your ear
 Hear the prayer of Your servant near,
 And to the prayer of Your slaves who
 Desire to fear Your name in crew,
 And prosper, I beg of You, now
 Today Your servant, grant somehow
 Mercy before this man *I fear*.”
 For I bore the king’s cup *that year*.

Though I have never born a cup to kings,
 I once was privileged in wanderings
 To fetch a cup of tea to English lady
 Without engaging in something too shady.
 There is no one to grant mercy to me
 No king Darius, no fraternity
 Of elders and great ones to whom I look
 From this shallow stream and this shady
 brook.

The benefit of pigeon and of rabbit
 Is all I have here in and out of habit.
 My shady hill is such because the firs
 And pines converge to cover cockleburrs.
 The spots and freckles of the sun now shine
 On shady aspens instead of grapevine.

Nehemiah 2

1 It happened in the month Nisan,
 The twentieth year in the span
 Of Artaxerxes the king, wine
 Was before him, I took the wine
 And gave it to the king. Now I
 Had not been sad before his eye.
 2 Therefore the king said to me, “Why
 Is your face sad, if you’re not ill?
 This is nothing but sorrow’s bill
 In heart.” Then I was much afraid.
 3 I said to the king where he stayed,
 “Let the king live for ever, why
 Should my face not be sad and cry
 When the town of my fathers’ graves
 Is desert and its gates there paves
 Consuming fire *to make me die*?”
 4 The king asked me, “What do you want?”
 So I prayed to Alohims’ *haunt*
 In heaven. 5 And I said to the king,
 “If the king favours his slave’s wing,
 That you would send me to Judah,
 To the town of my fathers’ awe,
 So I may there rebuild the thing.”

I know that Nehemiah was no drunk,
 But his job with the king puts me in spunk.

The problem is he has to taste the wine
Before the cautious king's eyes to divine
If it is filled with poison to the brim.
For Christian and Jew there's nothing so
grim

In tasting wine. But by the law I choose,
No alcohol in entertaining muse
Should pass the lip of faithful and of
prophet.

And yet this prophet takes up wine to quaff
it.

Beloved, I rise in judgement and to plead
That Nehemiah be put out to seed
And left to spoil because of all his greed
In swilling wine as though there was some
need.

6 And the king told me, and the queen
Was also sitting by him seen,
"How long will your trip take and when
Will you return?" So it pleased then
The king to send me and I set
Him a date *to return in debt*.

7 Moreover I said to the king,
"If the king favour, let me bring
Letters to the rulers beyond
The river, that they may be bond
For me till I come to Judah.

8 "And a letter to Asaph who
Keeps the king's forest, that he do
Me the favour to give me wood
To make beams for the gates as good
As for the palace which were for
The house and for the wall before
The city and for all the house
That I shall go into *like mouse*."

And the king *and queen* granted me
As providence of God would see.

9 Then I arrived at where they sat,
The governors there beyond that
River, and gave them the king's card.
Now the king had sent chiefs of guard
And horsemen with me *to be pard*.

10 When Sanballat the Horonite,
And Tobiah, a servant wight,
The Ammonite, heard they were grieved
Indeed that there had come received
A man to further the peace of
The folk of Israel *in love*.

11 So I came to Jerusalem,
And I was there three days *pro tem*.

Asaph seems a good man, though others
there

Are jealous of poor Nehemiah's fare.
A Semite Asaph is, no doubt, since he
Has the same name as the great singer's be
Who led the tunes of David in a crunch,
Or let his sons and students sing a bunch.
Asaph cares for the forests of the king
And checks the wood before it's sawn to
bring

Account for what is left and what's in store.
Asaph is a good man beside the door.
Beloved, let me sit at the door or take
A look at fir and pine for Your own sake,
Or let me sing a Psalm and not retract
Before the Persian curtain's next entr'acte.

12 And I got up in the night, I
And some guys with me by the by,
But I did not tell anyone
What my Alohim had begun
To put in my heart to rebuild
Jerusalem, nor was there billed
Any beast with me but the one
That I myself was riding on.

13 And I went out by night by way
Of the gate of the valley's ray,
Right there before the dragon [or fig] well,
And to the dung port, and looked well
At the walls of Jerusalem

Which were broken down *to the hem*,
And at the gates burned up with fire.

14 Then I went to the fountain gate,
And to the king's pool at that rate
But there was no place for the beast
Under me to go by for least.

15 I went up at night by the brook
Toward the wall to take a look,
And turned back and went through the gate
Of the valley, and returned *late*.

16 The rulers did not know where I
Had been or what I did to spy,
Nor had I yet said a word to
The Jews and priests and nobles' crew,
Nor to the rulers nor the rest
That did the work *to try their best*.

17 Then I said to them, "What distress
We're in you see, and the address
Jerusalem is waste, its gates
Are burned with fire, associates,
Come let's build up Jerusalem,
Its wall, so no one will contemn

Us any more *for our poor states.*”

18 Then I told them how Alohim
Laid His hand for good on my dream,
And also how the king’s words seem
That he has spoken to me. And
They said “Let’s get up by command
And build.” So they took courage and
Started to do the work at hand.
19 But when Sanballat Horonite,
And Tobiah the servant wight,
The Ammonite, and Geshem who
Was an Arabian in view,
Heard it they ridiculed, despised,
And said “What is this you’ve devised?
Will you rebel against the king?”
20 Then I answer and said a thing,
“Alohim of the skies, He will
Prosper us and will foot the bill,
That’s why we His servants arise
And build, but you have nothing’s guise,
Nor right nor monument to set
In Jerusalem or to get.”

Rebellion against king is in the mouth
Of Sanballat as he looks toward the south.
He wants to stop the work no doubt
because

It fosters a new faction under laws
To rival his and send a word in ear
To Persian kings of his own acts and gear.
Cyrus the Great invented such a turn
To keep his subjects always on the earn,
One pitted out against the next to make
Things easier for the king and his sake,
Who can always appear benign and good
With henchmen behind scenes to do as
should.

Beloved, I seek a better throne and power,
And hide my heart in You another hour.

Nehemiah 3

1 Eliashib the high priest rose
Up with his brother priests on toes,
And they built the sheep gate and then
They consecrated it again,
And set up the doors in it too,
As far as Meah’s tower in view
They consecrated, to the tower
Of Hananeel *all in an hour.*
2 And next to him the men who came
From Jericho built up the same.
And next to them Zaccur the son

Of Imri built what was begun.
3 But to the fish gate was built by
The sons of Hassenaah not sly,
Who also laid its beams and set
Up its doors and not to forget
It locks and bars *without regret.*
4 And next to them came to repair
Meremoth Urijah’s son there,
The son of Koz. And next to them
Worked *on the city* Meshullam
The son of Berechiah, son
Of Meshezabeel. And begun
Next to them Zadok who was son
Of Baana *till the work was done.*

The fishgate is a gate of fate to find
The sellers coming in to cheat men blind
With fish upon the Sabbath day to sell
And bring sin down upon all Israel.
The problem is that fishes once they’re
caught

Cannot be saved over the Sabbath spot
Because their nature is simply to rot.
No one yet cares or notices the plot,
Since Nehemiah is a man well taught
Not only in nocturnal weights and means.
But soon he’ll catch the fishermen on
scenes.

Beloved, there have been fishermen in view
That were a pleasing sight to even You
Once Galilee was shown the thing that’s
true.

5 And next to them the Tekoites
Repaired, but their nobles and wights
Did not put all their strength into
The work of their Lord *all in crew.*

6 Besides that the old gate stood there
Repaired by Jehoiada fair
Son of Paseah and the son
Of Besodeiah Meshullam,
They laid its beams and set its doors,
And fastened locks and bars *in stores.*

7 And next to them came to repair
Melatiah the Gibeonite,
And Jadon the Meronothite,
The men of Gibeon and of
Mizpah, to the throne set above,
Of the ruler on this side of
The river. 8 Next to him in share
Was Uzziel the son once fair
Of Harhaiah, of goldsmiths’ lair.

And next to him came to repair
 Nananiah the son in share
 Of one of the apothecaries,
 And they strengthened for adversaries
 Jerusalem to the broad wall.
 9 And next to them the lot would fall
 On Rephaiah the son of Hur,
 The ruler of half of *the whir*
 Jerusalem. 10 And next to them
 Came to repair *and to begem*
 Jedaiah son of Haruumaph,
 Over against his house *by half*.
 And next to him repaired Hattush,
 Son of Hashabniah *to rush*.
 11 Malchijah the son of Harim,
 And Hashub son of Pahathmoab,
 Repaired the other piece as seen,
 The tower of furnaces *to show up*.
 12 And next to him repaired Shallum
 The son of Halohesh in room
 Of ruler of the other half
 Part of Jerusalem in staff
 He and his daughter, *please don't laugh*.
 13 Hanun repaired the valley gate,
 The people of Zamoah wait,
 They built it and set up the doors
 And locks and bars and all in scores,
 And thousand armlengths on the wall
 Up to the dung gate, *repaired all*.
 14 Malchiah son of Rechab came
 To repair the dung gate in claim,
 Ruler of part of Bethhacerem,
 He built and set up the doors near them,
 The locks and bars too of the same.

Each family in plot and lot and choice
 Worked on the gates and walls there to
 rejoice
 In seeing how quickly the hard stones rise
 So heavy and massive against the skies.
 Each in his place, with skill and with
 delight
 The men worked on the citadel till night
 Brought them back to the hearth and to the
 home.
 Many neglected even seed and loam.
 Beloved, give me a place upon the wall
 As well as safety in the fattening stall,
 Give me a trowel and mortar in my room
 And let me work abroad until my doom.
 I stand upon the high place and look down
 Upon the glint and pleasure of the town.

15 And Shallun son of Colhozeh
 Repair the gate of fountain's way,
 He's ruler of part of Mizpah,
 He built it, covered and set in
 The doors, the locks the bars within,
 And the wall of the pool that's called
 Siloah by the king's *unmalled*
 Garden, and to the stairs that go
 Down from the town of David's *show*.
 16 After him Nehemiah came
 The son of Azbut to reclaim,
 The ruler of half of Bethzur,
 Up to the place of David's tombs,
 And to the poor made in those rooms,
 To the noble house *to be sure*.
 17 After him came Levites to work,
 Rehum Bani's son not to shirk.
 Next to him Hashabiah's hand,
 Ruler of half of Keilah's land,
 In his own part. 18 After him their
 Brothers came in line to repair,
 Bavai the son of Henadad,
 The ruler of half of Keilah.
 19 And next to him the one that's glad
 To repair was son of Jeshua,
 Ezer, the ruler of Mizpah,
 The space opposite where you go
 Up to the armoury there where
 The corner *of the wall is spare*.
 20 After him Baruch Zabbai's son
 Fervently repaired and got done
 Another stretch from corner to
 The door of the house that is due
 Eliashib the high priest *true*.

The high priest's door goes out upon the
 wall,
 Whether to outside of the safety's stall
 Or backed against the buttress there to fall
 I do not know. And yet I hear the call
 Of old Jerusalem, that tiny space
 And realize that many people's place
 Must be upon the wall that winds around
 The little city set upon the ground
 Made sacred by so many plots and acts
 Of heroes and the faith that such exacts.
 Beloved, the wall is built up to the door
 Of the high priest and the hand that no
 more
 Could build was left in satisfaction's share
 That he had built the wall again to there.

21 After him Meremoth repaired,
 The son of Urijah who dared
 Be son of Koz, another stretch
 From Eliashib's door to fetch
 To the end of E's house's claim.
 22 And after him men of the plain,
 The priests repaired. 23 After the same
 Benjamin and Hashub would deign
 Repair against their house. And then
 Azariah Maaseiah's son,
 The son of Ananiah won,
 Repaired by his house with his men.
 24 After him repaired Binnui son
 Of Henadad another run
 From Azariah's house up to
 The corner turning *come in view*.
 25 Palal the son of Uzai then
 Took from the turning *with his men*
 And the tower that goes out from where
 The king's high house is to repair
 Beside the prison court. And then
 After him Pedaiah the son
 Of Parosh *got his portion done*.
 26 The Nethinims lived in Ophel,
 Against the water gate *and well*
 Toward the east and tower stuck out.
 27 After them the Tekoites did
 Another bit beside the bid
 Of the great tower that without doubt
 Runs up to Ophel's wall in route.
 28 Above the horse gate the priests
 wrought,
 Each one working by his house *sought*.

 The priests were out to build the town wall
 well.
 They were not civil servants of the spell
 As are the priests today in every place
 That Lutheran comes in to show his face.
 The priests were not afraid to get their
 hands
 Soiled in the limey mortar that expands
 In sore cracks and to lift a mighty stone.
 The workmen did not come to work alone.
 Beloved, I love the priests who come in aid
 To the workers that must work being paid,
 Without increase in wealth or status, yet
 Their priestly station they merely forget.
 Beloved, I love the priests who toil till
 night
 Cover the offerings from the people's sight.

29 Zadok the son of Immer came
 After them working just the same
 Against his house. After him there
 Repaired also Shemaiah fair
 Son of Shechaniah who kept
 The east gate *safe and clean and swept*.
 30 After him repaired Hananiah,
 Who was the son of Shelemiah,
 And Hanun the sixth son born to
 Zalaph, another stretch in crew.
 After him repaired Meshullam
 The son of Berechiah's *slam*
 Against his own room *like a dam*.
 31 After him repaired Malchiah
 The goldsmith's son to area
 Of Nethinim, and of merchants
 By the gate Miphkad to the manse
 Of the next corner *in the dance*.
 32 Between the corner and sheep gate
 The goldsmiths and merchants not late
 Repaired *and put the wall in state*.

 The goldsmiths and the merchants did not
 hide
 When heavy work was done on city side.
 They joined the very priests of God to
 make
 A wall, a lovely wall, for the town's sake.
 The goldsmiths left their tiny tools to wear
 The breeches of a mason for their share
 And take in hand the heavy implement
 In unaccustomed hands outside the tent.
 The merchants left their manicures to set
 The stones upon the higher wall with
 sweat,
 And joyed to find themselves in such
 fatigue
 After the days labour, after intrigue.
 Beloved, I join the crew that builds Your
 place
 In songs of David from each shining face.

Nehemiah 4

1 It happened when Sanballat heard
 That we built the wall undeterred,
 He got mad and was in a fit
 Of indignation against it
 And ridiculed the Jews *a bit*.
 2 He talked before his brothers and
 The army of Samaria's land,
 And said "What are these feeble Jews

Doing, will they make an excuse
 To fortify themselves, will they
 Make sacrifices there someday?
 Will they bring up the stones again
 From rubbish burnt heaped up *by men?*”
 3 Now Tobiah the Ammonite
 Was with him, and he said outright,
 “What they set up a fox will break
 If it just jumps over their stake.”
 4 Hear, O our Alohim, for we
 Are despised in our own country,
 And turn their reproach on their own
 Head, and set them up for a groan
 In the land of captivity.
 5 And do not hide their wickedness,
 And let their sin, though they confess,
 Not be blotted out before You,
 For they’ve provoked to wrath the crew
 Of builders as well as You too.
 6 And so we built the wall and all
 The wall was joined to half the call,
 Because the people had a mind
 To work *and they were not resigned.*

Some pray their sin may be forgiven at last,
 And some like Nehemiah come to blast
 Their enemies with prayers that You will
 not
 Forgive their sin or ever come to blot
 It out beneath the sun, above the moon.
 Such imprecations may be heard and soon
 From my lips too, as I survey the store
 Of what happens on every war-torn shore.
 But this text affirms what I hoped was true,
 Sins are not just forgiven in Your view,
 But blotted out from time and mind and
 space,
 And cease their very being in this place.
 Beloved, blot out in judgement sin in me
 And make me stand in righteousness and
 free
 Before the glories of Your sovereign See.

7 It happened when Sanballat and
 Tobiah and the Arab band,
 The Ammonites and Ashdodites,
 Heard that Jerusalem’s walls there
 Were finished and set up with care,
 And that the breaches started to
 Be filled up, they were angry too.
 8 And they conspired together all
 To come and fight against the wall

Jerusalem and hinder it.
 9 But we prayed to our Alohim,
 And set a watch against their dream
 Both day and night because of them.
 10 And Judah said “The bearers’ strength
 For loads has diminished at length,
 And there’s a lot of rubbish still
 So we’re not able to fulfil
 The building of the wall *and hill.*”
 11 Our enemies said “They will not
 Notice or see till we in plot
 Have infiltrated their lines and
 Killed them and stopped the work at hand.”
 12 It happened when Jews living near
 Them came they said to us in fear,
 “They attack us both front and rear.”
 13 That’s why I set in hiding there
 Behind the wall, high and low there,
 Folk in their groups with swords and share
 Of spears and bows *to watch with care.*
 14 And I looked and got up and said
 To the nobles and rulers bred
 And to the rest of the folk led,
 “Don’t be afraid of them, but mind
 The Lord great and terrible kind,
 And fight for your brothers and your
 Sons and your daughters all of your
 Wives and your houses *out of door.*”

Racism does mark Nehemiah’s book
 In several places, just You take a look.
 And yet the fact that infiltration made
 The stratagem of Sanballat well-paid
 Explains necessity of racist plot
 To limit who may inter in the lot.
 Racism everywhere is made of fear,
 And hope to appropriate someone’s gear.
 It’s never really made of colour of
 The skin or hair or eyes in those we love.
 When walls are built and temples raise their
 spires
 There must be locks and gates against
 desires
 Of the intruder and against the fires.
 An inner temple’s all my faith requires.

15 It happened when our enemies
 Heard that we knew their strategies,
 And Alohim had overthrown
 Their plans and left them all alone,
 We went back all up on the wall
 Each to his task *for one and all.*

16 It happened ever after that
That half of my servants there sat
To the work and the other half
Held both the spears and shields from gaff
As well as bow and habergeon,
The rulers were behind them drawn
On all the house of Judah gone.

17 Those who built on the wall and those
Who carried the loads and who chose
To set them, each with one hand built
And kept the other on sword hilt.

18 The builders each had his sword set
By his side and so building met.
The signal trumpeter stood yet
Beside me *not too far to get*.

19 And I said to the nobles and
To the rulers and all the band
Of the people, "The work is great
And large and we are separate
From each other up on the wall.

20 So where you hear the trumpet call,
Go there to help and Alohim
Will battle before us *like dream*."

21 And so we worked hard on the task
And half of them with spears to bask
From sunrise till the stars appeared.

The trumpet is the signal of attack
To those spread on the wall and back to
back
Building the city of faith and of dream.
I hear the trumpet of my Alohim.
There is no need of warning trumpet when
The gate is opened up and to all men,
But only when the state of faith's to bring
The righteous few within the secret's ring.
Beloved, I stand alone upon the wall
And look out at the lovely plain and all
The busy life of market and of stall.
None joins me to hear trumpet sound and
blast.

Only the crickets spin a song to last
The evening that I stop here an outcast.

22 At the same time I told the folk,
"Let every one with servant folk
Stay in Jerusalem to be
In the night a guard and in fee
Work through the day and faithfully.
23 So none of us took off our clothes
Except to wash, not I nor those
Brothers and servants nor the men

Of the guard that followed my ken.

Ablutions were neglected not a bit
Even before the onslaught of the fit.
Prayers sounded and in turn the men bowed
down

Within the holy precincts of the town
In turn while others held no rod nor crown,
But sword and shield above helmet and
mitt.

Ablutions of the head and hands and feet,
Ablutions of the whole body when mete,
All were kept despite armies and retreat.
Beloved, I wash myself when I am true,
And meet You in my prayers, yes I meet
You,

And find the strength and purity to be
A builder and a watcher of the free
As I keep far Jerusalem in view.

Nehemiah 5

1 There rose a great cry from the folk
And from their wives against the stroke
Of their brothers the Jewish folk.

2 For there were some that said "We and
Our sons and daughter are a band,
That's why we take up wheat to eat,
To live and not die in the street."

3 Also there were some there that said
"We borrowed against our fields spread,
Our vineyards and houses so we
Might buy food since it's dry *at sea*."

4 And others said "We've borrowed tax
For the king's tribute at the axe
Of our fields and vineyards to max.

5 "Still our flesh is just like the flesh
Of our brothers, our children fresh
As their children, and see we bring
Into slavery our sons to sing
And our daughters to be servants,
And some as slaves already dance,
And we don't have a way to get
Them redeemed since other men set
To seed our fields and vineyards met."

6 And I was very angry when
I heard the message of these men.

7 I thought about it, I rebuked
The nobles and the rulers *spooked*,
And told them, "You take interest from
Your brothers." And I set when come
A great assembly against them.

The evil of interest and usury
 Is well expressed of Torah's treasury,
 And every prophet rails against the greed
 That will oppress the poor man in his need.
 The banking world around the whole
 empire
 Made interest seem more than just one's
 desire,
 But the essential way to move the load.
 Perspective is creation of a toad.
 The necessary evil is a thing
 Invented in man's mind who does not sing.
 Beloved, I retreat ever and anon
 To Your one sermon on the rosy dawn,
 And know the Decalogue is all that makes
 Society not for the jungle sakes.

8 I told them, "We have done as well
 As we can to redeem from spell
 Of heathens our brothers the Jews,
 And will you come and sell as choose
 Your brothers? Or shall they be sold
 To us?" And none of them were bold
 To speak, none had an answer cold.
 9 Also I said "It is not good
 What you are doing. Also should
 You not act in fear of our God
 Because of the reproach and rod
 Of the heathen, our enemy?
 10 "I too and my brothers in spe,
 And my servants might take in fee
 Money and corn, so I pray you
 To leave off this interest as due.
 11 "So please give back to them today
 Their fields and vineyards on the way
 Their oliveyards and houses too,
 As well as the per cent in due
 Of the money and wheat and grape
 Juice and the oil you take in rape."
 12 Then they said "We'll give all of it
 Back and require nothing to sit
 And we shall do just as you say."
 So I summoned the priests at bay
 And made them swear that they would do
 What they had promised *to the crew*.
 13 I shook my skirts and said "Let God
 Shake out every man from the pod,
 And from his work, who does not do
 According to this promise due,
 Just like this he'll be shaken out
 And emptied." And so all about
 In the assembly said "Amen".

They praised YHWH, and the folk again
 Bode by the promise of *their yen*.

The priests and merchants who had lent
 their sums
 To workers and farmers who seemed like
 bums
 Repented of their taking interest due
 And gave back all they'd stolen from the
 crew.
 I never saw the like today when I
 Past by the banker's church to satisfy.
 Neither the Jew nor Christian like the word
 That says no usury is to be stirred.
 Beloved, take interest on the air I breathe,
 Take usury upon the kid I see the
 In or outside its mother's milk and let
 My wealth drain out upon the hope You
 get.
 Beloved, I turn my cup upside down on
 My saucer and await the break of dawn.

14 And yet since the time I was set
 To be their governor and met
 In the land of Judah, from year
 Twenty up to year thirty-two
 Of Artaxerxes king to fear,
 Twelve years in all, I and my crew
 Have not eaten of the food due
 Of the governor *and his gear*.
 15 But governors before me had
 Charged to the people to be sad
 They took from them grain and grape juice,
 Forty silver shekels for use,
 Indeed so did they rule the folk,
 But I never did so for broke,
 Because I feared God at a stroke.
 16 Indeed I also kept up work
 On this wall, did not come to shirk
 To buy land, and all my servants
 Gathered there to work, *not to dance*.
 17 Besides that at my table sat
 A hundred fifty Jews and pat
 Rulers beside that that came in
 To us from the heathen *in sin*
 That are about us *in the bin*.
 18 So what was prepared daily came
 To one ox and six choice sheep's claim,
 As well as chickens plucked for me,
 And every ten days grape juice in
 All sorts arrive in store and bin,
 And yet for all this I did not

Require the ration that was sought
For the governor, since the load
Of service was hard on the road
Of the folk, so all this I stowed.
19 Remember me, my Alohim,
For good by all that I in scheme
Have done for this people's *abode*.

Whether king or a governor the rate
Of human reputation soon and late
Is that the ruler steal from folk without
The means to resist ruler for his clout.
So Nehemiah brags that he has taken
No thread nor coin from poverty's hand
shaken,
And brag he can, it is so rare a thing
In president or manager or king.
Beloved, the coin that I have sought in time
I have bestowed in charity and rhyme,
And have no burden to be grateful to
Any but mom and dad and wife in crew,
Daughter and grandson, for taking my due,
And so I show my innocence to You.

Nehemiah 6

1 It happened when Sanballat and
Tobiah and Geshem of band
Of the Arabs, and all our foes,
Heard I had built the wall and chose
To fill all the breaches left there,
Though at that time I'd not found share
To set up the doors on their gate,
2 Then Sanballat and Gershem late
Sent to me saying "Come, let's meet
Together in some village street
In the plain of Ono." But they
Intended mischief in their way.
3 And I sent messengers to them
Saying "I'm busy to the hem,
So I cannot come down, why should
The work stop while I leave the good
And come down to speak *with a hood?*"
4 They sent to me four times to stay,
And I answered each time that way.
5 Then Sanballat sent up to me
His servant a fifth time to see
An open letter in his hand
6 In which was written "Understand
It's said among the nations' band
And Gashmu says so too, that you
And the Jews intend to rebel,
And that's why you're building so well

The wall, so that you can be king,"
According to such words to sting.
7 "And you've set prophets up to preach
About you in Jerusalem,
Saying 'A king's in Judah's reach'
And now it shall be told the king
According to this stratagem.
So come and make a deal together."

The threat to spread false rumours is the
deal
That Sanballat brought to make the man
heel.
But Nehemiah's a man with a job,
Not likely to be swayed by hooded mob.
So many false rumours are going round
About me that they make a din of sound,
But I follow example of the man
Called Nehemiah and don't leave my plan.
Good Tyndale failed to translate to the end
The Scriptures because he had mind to fend
Off the attacking bishop and waste time
And energy in what produced no rhyme.
Beloved, I keep my eye and ear on You
And answer Your words in my rhyming
too.

8 Then I sent to him and I said
"There are no such things as you spread,
But you've invented them yourself."
9 For they all made us fear by saying
"Their hands must be weak with waylaying
From the work so it won't be done."
So now strengthen my hands begun.
10 After that I came to the house
Of Shemaiah the son of *grouse*
Delaiah, Mehetabeel's son,
Who was a spy, and he said "Son,
Let's meet together in God's house,
Within the temple not to drowse,
And let's shut up the temple doors,
For they will come to even scores
And kill you in the night-time shores."
11 And I said "Should such one as I
Flee? Who as I would go and lie
In the temple to save his life?
I'll not go in *for peace or strife*."
12 See I was aware God had not
Sent him, but he said all that rot
In prophecy against me, for
Tobiah and Sanballat swore
To hire him *to even the score*.

13 He was paid to make me afraid,
 And do such things and sin unmade,
 So they might have excuse to make
 An evil report for my sake
 In reproach on me *where I stayed*.
 14 My Alohim, mind Tobiah
 And Sanballat by their acts' claw,
 And prophetess Noadiah,
 And all the rest of prophets that
 Tried to make me fear *where I sat*.

Instead of making answer to my foes,
 Like Nehemiah, I call curses' rows
 Upon all who twist my words to their guilt
 And wallow in the mire of falsehood's silt.
 Hardly a man who reads my Torah vision
 Condemns me not with demonic derision.
 The dark heart and dark eye that
 understands

Not the eternal, universal dance,
 But rests in demagogic dogma's prance
 Shall meet in judgement all the lies once
 told,
 And then we shall see who is bright and
 bold.

I bide my time prostrated at Your throne,
 Humbled to know I've nothing of my own,
 But You, Beloved, are above heat and cold.

15 The wall was finished in Elul
 The twenty-fifth for all the duel
 Of fifty-two days, that was that.
 16 It happened when all our foes heard,
 And all the nations round us saw,
 They were cast down for their own turd,
 Since they saw how this work in awe
 Was done by our Alohim's *draw*.

17 Moreover in those days were sent
 Many letters by Judah's bent
 Nobles to Tobiah and he
 Tobiah sent to them to see.

18 For many in Judah swore by
 Him because he was son-in-lie
 Of Shechaniah Arah's son,
 And his son Johanan had won
 The hand of Meshullan's daughter
 The son of Berechiah's *stir*.

19 They also told me his good deeds,
 And reported my words as seeds
 To him. Tobiah sent to me
 Letters to set me fearfully.

Regard, Beloved, who set themselves in
 power
 Against your Nehemiah in that hour
 The walls were built. It was not the great
 king

But middle level civil servants' wing.
 So is it now, Beloved, when persecution
 Spreads on the heads in some final
 solution,

The common drudge of middle level force
 Makes possible the evil in its course.

The hand of king and president is weak
 Without the common man to fail to seek
 The truth and justice of the deed in law.
 The common fool creates the beastly maw
 More than the utterly evil in claw.
 The neighbour's greater threat than devil's
 paw.

Nehemiah 7

1 It happened when the wall was built
 And I'd set up the doors to hilt,
 Appointing carriers and singers
 And Levites *and their humdingers*,

2 I gave my brother Hanani
 And Hananiah ruling guy
 Over the place the charge to keep
 Over Jerusalem like sheep,
 For he was faithful as a man,
 And feared Alohim as one can.

3 And I said to them, "Let the gates
 Of Jerusalem not in waits
 Be opened till the sun is hot,
 And while they stand by in the plot,
 Let them shut the doors, bar and lock,
 And set watch for those on the rock
 Of Jerusalem each one in

His watch and every one still in
 His own house *and in his own bin*.

4 And the city was large and great,
 But the folk living there in state
 Were few and houses there were late.

5 And my Alohim put in mind
 To gather the nobles behind
 And rulers and the people there
 To reckon family trees with care.

I found a family register
 Of them who came up with the stir
 At first and found written in it:

6 These are the folk that went out fit,
 From the province to captive state,
 Of those carried to relocate,

Whom Nebuchadnezzar the king
 Of Babylon took under wing,
 Came once more to Jerusalem
 And to Judah in diadem,
 Each one into his city's hem,
 7 Who came with Zerubbabel and
 Jeshua, Nehemiah *grand*,
 And Azariah and Raamiah,
 Nahamani, and *not to try her*
 Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispereth,
 Bigvai, Nehum and in a breath
 Baanah. The people's numbers stand.

When Nehemiah found the list of those
 Who came up with Jeshua and who chose
 To cross from Jordan's banks to common
 woes
 In Palestine and in the land of promise
 Rather than in comfort of doubting Thomas
 In Babylon's and Shushan's gardened
 walls,
 He was pleased with the record of their
 stalls.
 Beloved, write my name too among the
 blessed
 Who turn aside from earthly lines to rest
 In You beyond the stormy banks and best.
 Write my name too among those who
 would dwell
 Within the heavenly city for a spell
 And raise a voice in David's Psalms to
 build
 The temple with Your grace and glory
 filled.

8 The children of Parosh up to
 Two thousand hundred seventy-two.
 9 The children of Shephatiah,
 Three hundred seventy-two *in paw*.
 10 As well as children of Arah
 Six hundred fifty-two. 11 The sons
 Of Pahathmoab in their runs,
 Of the children of Jeshua
 And Joab, two thousand and eight
 Hundred and eighteen *to relate*.
 12 The children of Elam *in store*
 Thousand two hundred fifty-four,
 13 The children of Zattu *alive*
 Eight hundred and forty and five.
 14 The children of Zaccai *in all*
 Seven hundred sixty *to call*.
 15 The children of Binnui *in rate*

Of six hundred and forty-eight.
 16 The children of Bebai *to state*
 Six hundred and twenty and eight.
 17 The children of Azgad to two
 Thousand three hundred twenty-two.
 18 The children of Adonikam
 Six hundred sixty-seven *ham*.
 19 The children of Bigvai *from heaven*
In all two thousand sixty-seven.
 20 The children of Adin *alive*
 Six hundred and fifty and five.
 21 The children of Ater *in state*
 Of Hezekiah, ninety-eight.
 22 The children of Hashum *not late*
 Three hundred and twenty and eight.
 23 The children of Bezai *in store*,
 Three hundred and twenty and four.
 24 The children of Hariph *to delve*
Add up to one hundred and twelve.
 25 The children of Gibeon *to strive*
Add up again to ninety-five.
 26 Bethlehem and Netophah's men,
 A hundred eighty-eight *again*.
 27 The men of Anathoth relate
 To one hundred and twenty-eight.
 28 The men of Bethazmaveth *do*
Number only forty and two.
 29 The men of Kirjathjearim and
 Chephirah and Beeroth *in hand*
 Were seven hundred forty-three.
 30 The men of Ramah *faithfully*
 And Geba were counted *when done*
At six hundred and twenty-one.
 31 The men of Michmas were not few,
 A hundred and twenty and two.
 32 Bethel and Ai's men *freely*
 A hundred and twenty and three.
 33 The men of the other Nebo
 Were fifty-two *when come to show*.
 34 Children of the other Elam
 A thousand two hundred *of ham*
 And fifty-four. 35 The children of
 Harim, three hundred twenty *love*.
 36 The children of Jericho *strive*
To be three hundred forty-five.
 37 The children of Lod, Hadid, and
 Ono, seven hundred *in hand*
 And twenty-one. 38 The children of
 Senaah, three thousand *and in glove*
 Nine hundred and thirty *to shove*.
 39 The priests: Jedaiah's family
 The house of Jeshua to see,

Nine hundred and seventy-three.
 40 The children of Immer *in crew*
 A thousand and fifty and two.
 41 The children of Pashur *from heaven*
 Thousand two hundred forty-seven.
 42 The children of Harim *are seen*
To be a thousand seventeen.
 43 The Levites: Jeshua's children's *score*
 Of Kadmīel and the children *more*
 Of Hodevah, to seventy-four.
 44 The singers: Asaph's children *rate*
 At one hundred and forty-eight.

The singers are my favourites in the group
 Of those counted in every porch and stoop
 Of fair Jerusalem. The singers are
 The ones in my book I account a star.
 They build the true temple made without
 hands

In voices lifted above all the lands
 That defy You, Beloved, in such rock
 bands

That sing their pagan hymns to those afar.
 They raise the spires of David's temple up
 In voices sipping from the sacred cup
 Of David's Psalms. May I too do as much
 As I rejoice and bow down at Your touch
 In prayer of plaint and penitence and praise
 To make petition only in Your stays.

45 The porters: Shallum's children and
 The children of Ater *in band*,
 The children of Talmon and those
 Of Akkub, and *the ones that chose*
 Hatita, the children *that rate*
 Of Shobai, hundred thirty-eight.

46 The Nethinim: both Ziha's folk,
 The children of Hashupha's *stoke*,
 The children of Tabbaoth's *yoke*,

47 The children of Keros and such

Of Siah, the children *as much*
 Of Padon, 48 Lebana's children,
 The children of Hagaba, *then*

The children of Shalmai *as men*,

49 The children of Hanan as well

As the children come of Giddel,
 The children of Gahar, 50 The graves
 Of Reaiah, and Rezin's babes,
 The children of Nekoda too.

51 The children of Gazzam, the crew
 Of Uzza, Phaseah's folk too.

52 The children of Besai the lot

Of Meunim, Nephishesim's plot.

53 The children of Bakbuk the folk

Of Hakupha as well as *stroke*

Of Harhur, 54 the folk of Bazlith,

The children of Mehida with

The children of Harsha, 55 the kin

Of Barkos, Sisera's *agrin*,

The children of Tamah *with din*,

56 The children of Neziah *too*,

The children of Hatipha's *crew*.

57 The children of Solomon's slaves,

The children of Sotai *in waves*,

The children of Sophereth and

The children of Perida's *band*.

58 The children of Jaala *and yet*

The children of Darkon *well met*,

The children of Giddel. 59 The folk

Of Shephatiah at a stroke,

The children of Hattil and more

The children of Pochereth's store

From Zebaim, and Amon's folk.

60 All Nethinim, and children of

Solomon's servants *told above*,

Were three hundred and ninety-two.

61 And these were those who went up too

From Telmelah, Telharesha,

Cherub, Addon and Immer's claw,

But they could not show father's house

Nor their seed if they were of house

Of Israel. 62 The children of

Delaiah, the children above

Of Tobiah, the children of

Nekoda, six hundred and two

And forty, *that is all their crew*.

63 And of the priests, the children of

Habaiah, the children to love

Of Koz, the folk of Barzillai,

Who took of girls of Barzillai

The Gileadite as wife, the same

Was afterward called by their name.

64 These sought their register among

Those that were reckoned by the *sung*

Genealogy, but not found,

Therefore they were unclean, *unsound*,

And put out of the priesthood's *bound*.

65 And so Tirshath told them not to

Eat of the holy things *in crew*

Until there stood up in their view

A priest with Urim and the due

Thummim. 66 The whole assembly there

Was forty-two thousand *to share*

With three hundred and sixty's *care*.

My name does not appear among the
 chosen,
 Not even among singers on the frozen
 Rocks of the icy shore where daylight sits
 For just a moment as the titmouse flits
 Above the snowy shelter of Your hand.
 My name does not appear, but I still make
 A clamour and a noise for pity's sake
 That I too be among those who may live
 In heavenly pastures that You come to
 give.

My name does not appear, let Urim say
 To Thummin to give me a place to stay
 And joy in Your reward and hope the day
 May set upon my hearth and home to fill
 My inner chamber with the divine will.

67 Beside their male servants and their
 Female servants of whom there stood
 Seven thousand three hundred *good*
 And thirty-seven, and they had two
 Hundred and forty-five *again*
 Of singing women and such men.

68 Their horses, seven hundred and
 Thirty-six, their mules *in their band*
 Two hundred forty-five *to stand*.

69 Camels, four hundred thirty-five,
 Six thousand seven hundred alive
 Donkeys and twenty *in the hive*.

70 Some of the chief fathers gave to
 The work. The Tirshatha gave to
 The treasure a thousand in drams
 Of gold, fifty basins *for lambs*,
 And five hundred and thirty coats
 For the priests *to wear to their throats*.

71 And some chief fathers gave in treasure
 Of the work twenty thousand measure
 Of gold and two thousand and two
 Hundred pounds of silver *as due*.

72 And that which the rest of the folk
 Gave was twenty thousand in poke
 Of gold and two thousand pounds in
 Silver, and sixty-seven in bin
 Of priests' tunics *and fit to win*.

73 So priests and Levites as well as
 Porters and singers, not of jazz,
 And people and Nethinim and
 All Israel lived in their land
 In their cities and when was come
 The seventh month the children's sum
 Of Israel in their towns *were rum*.

The sweet Christian delights in serving
 priests,
 And always notices the death of beasts
 In temple service for the days and nights
 That turn revolving on their hopes and
 frights.

But I, who am not sweet, see always those
 Who are the temple singers in white
 clothes.

I turn from bleat and bray to hear the sound
 Of David's tabernacle on the ground.
 Beloved, when You set all the world in care
 Of goats and sheep among ugly and fair,
 Set me among the singers, not the ones
 Who flay the fleece to cover up their buns.
 Beloved, let my voice now pariah's own
 One day rejoice in sweetness at Your
 throne.

Nehemiah 8

1 And all the folk in assembly
 As one man in the street to see
 Before the water gate, and they
 Spoke to Ezra the scribe to say
 To bring the book of Moses' law,
 Which YHWH'd commanded Israel's *awe*.

2 And Ezra the scribe brought the law
 Before the congregation's *paw*,
 Both of the men and women too,
 And everyone who could hear it
 With understanding and see fit,
 On seventh month's first day *to sit*.

3 He read in it before the street
 Before the water gate *to greet*
 From morning until noon before
 The men and women *by the score*
 And those who could understand it,
 And the ears of all the folk fit
 Listened to the law's book *as writ*.

The public reading of the book of law
 Upon the seventh month's first day in awe
 Is a practice that goes back to the time
 Of Nehemiah at least in his prime.
 The recitation was in melodies
 Most sweet and pleasant on the autumn
 breeze

That caught the people by surprise to hear
 How glorious Your divine words appear.
 Today I also come to cantillate
 Your law as times whirl on for wicked fate

Across the pleasant earth that You create
Throughout the six day of the week to bless
At last on Sabbath day the works' address.
Beloved, I mind the words that rose then
late.

From early morning until the noon time
The law was read in those old days of
prime,
Just like the Iroquois today and in
Times past spend morning hours without
sin

In recitation of the Gaiwiyo
Or before that creation story's show,
The story that begins the very law
Of Moses Nehemiah read in awe.
Two hundred years ago the people thought
That Indians were Israelites who'd been
brought

To the shores of the island on the back
Of turtle. Be that true or be that flack,
There's much in purity in both I see,
The faiths of folks in forest being free.

4 Ezra the scribe stood by a wood
Pulpit, made express as they should,
And beside him stood Mattithiah,
And Shema as well as Anaiah,
Also Urijah and Hilkiah,
And Maaseiah on his right hand,
And on his left hand all the band
Of Pedaiah, Mishael, Malchiah,
And Hashum, Hashbadana come,
Zechariah, and Meshauillam.

5 And Ezra opened up the book
Before the people there to look,
For he stood higher than the folk,
And when he opened it a stroke,
All the people stood up *and woke*.

6 And Ezra blessed YHWH the great God.
And all the people with a nod
Answered "Amen, Amen" and raised
Up their hands, and *after they praised*
They bowed their heads and worshipped
YHWH

With faces to the ground *in view*.

The people know the way to meet the word
Recited on the winds in what they heard.
Assenting with amen they raise their hands
To glorify Your name by Your commands,

And then they bow their heads and from
the waist

Speak glorifying once more to the taste
Of sweetness in prayer by the warm air
stirred,

And then fall in prostration undeterred
By what any may think or say or do.
Beloved, I too lift voice in glorifying,
Raise hands beside my ears and not defying
Bow down and then in my prostration make
Petition of your mercy at the stake
Of Your throne and in penitence to You.

7 Also Jeshua, Bani, and
Sherebiah, Jamin in hand,
Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodijah,
Maaseiah, also Kelita,
Azariah and Jozabad,
Hanan, Pelaiah, and the *glad*
Levites, translated the law for
The people, and the folk by score
Stood in their place *and to adore*.
8 They cantillated God's law well,
And translated the sense a spell,
And commented upon it well.

Each Sabbath day I come to hear Your
word
Recited in the temple songs and stirred,
I hear the good translation and I wait
To hear the commentary spoken late.
Each Sabbath I repeat the singing of
What in the days of Nehemiah's love
The people heard and raised their hearts
above
To know and praise Your will set up in
state.

Beloved, the cantillation of the bird
And beast around me rises too and heard
By ear of me and mine and to abate
The sound of world and market undeterred
Where cobblestones are trodden by the
dove.

Beloved, turn in Your grace to me and
mate.

9 And Nehemiah who was ruler,
And Ezra the priest, scribe and schooler,
And the Levites that taught the folk,
Said to all the people awoke,
"This day is holy unto YHWH
Your Alohim, don't mourn in crew

Nor weep," for all the people wept
To heard words of the law *unkept*.
10 Then he said to them, "Go your way,
And eat the fat and drink the whey,
And send gifts to those unprepared,
For this day's holy and unbared
To our Lord, do not be sad for
The joy of YHWH's your strength *in store*."

11 So the Levites calmed all the folk,
Saying "Be quiet, for the yoke
Of the day's holy, don't be grieved."
12 And all the people when received
Went their way to eat and to drink,
And to send portions to the brink
Of great mirth, because they had heard
The words declared them *from God's word*.

13 And on the second day there came
The chief of the fathers in claim
Of all the people and the priests
And the Levites *back from the feasts*
To Ezra the scribe that they might
Understand the law's words *aright*.

14 And they found written in the law
That YHWH commanded by the paw
Of Moses, that Israel's folk should
Live in booths in the feast set good
In the seventh month. 15 That they should
Publish and proclaim in their towns
All over and Jerusalem

Saying "Go out upon the downs
And fetch olive branches *as gem*,
And pine branches and myrtle too,
And palm branches and to make do
With leafy trees' branches in view,
To make booths as commanded to.

16 So the people went out and brought
And made themselves booths each one
wrought

Upon his housetop, in their courts,
And in the courts of God's house, sorts
In the street of the water gate
And in the street of Ephraim's gate.

17 All the congregation of those
Who had come from their captive throes
Made booths and sat under the hut,
For since the days of Jeshua *shut*
The son of Nun until that day
Israel's folk had not done that way.
And there was great gladness *that day*.

19 Also each day from first to last
He read in the book that was cast

As Alohim's law. They kept feast
For seven days, and it increased
On the eighth day was solemn feast
According to the way *of priest*.

If the Passover is a feast unkept
For generations for the house unswept
Of the temple, then see this strange thing
now:

The feast of tabernacles anyhow
Had not been kept in time of kings at all,
Not in the days of David nor the stall
Of judges, Solomon or even Saul.
The feasts of every year are only read
By Rabbis and their followers unfed,
And rarely were they found in ancient days
To raise Your name to heights of justly
praise.

No wonder Christians in their yearly round
Ignore the law of Moses on the ground.
Beloved, I seek the feast in You that's
found.

Nehemiah 9

1 Now on the twenty-fourth day of
This month Israel's folk were in glove
To fast with gunny-sacks and earth
Spread on them *for all they were worth*.

2 And the descendants of Israel
Separated themselves from spell
Of all the foreigners and stood
Confessing their sins as they should,
And their fathers' iniquities.

3 And they stood in their place to please
And read in the book of the law
Of YHWH their Alohim for awe
One fourth of the day and again
One fourth confessing and in ken
Prostrating before YHWH their God.

4 Then came upon the stairs to plod,
Levites, Jeshua, and Bani,
Kadmiel, Shebaniah, Bunni,
Sherebiah, Bani and then
Chenani, and cried out like men
Unto YHWH and their Alohim.

5 Then the Levites, Jeshua and
Kadmiel, Bani come there to stand,
Hashabniah, Sherebiah,
Hodijah, Shebaniah and
Pethahiah said "Stand and bless
YHWH your Alohim and in awe
For ever and ever, address

With blessing Your great name in awe
Exalted above all blessing
And all praise *among those who sing.*
6 You HUU alone *are* YHWH, You've
made
The heaven, the heaven of heavens
displayed
With all their host, the earth and all
Upon it, the seas also all
That is in them, and You preserve
Them all, while hosts of heaven serve
And worship You *as You deserve.*

If Nehemiah, my Beloved, was sure
That You alone are God, my lips impure
Shall not invent another nor a three
To take Your place. No cursèd trinity
Shall hear my prayer. To You alone I bow
In earth prostration, while I join the row
Of heavenly hosts who worship only You.
Such worship is an agitation, true,
Since billions is a number far too small
To count the hosts that answer to Your call.
While those who do blaspheme Your holy
name,
Despite their millions and their public
claim
To power, are but a tiny country village
Beside the hosts that lay Your heavens
pillage.

7 You are HUU YHWH Alohim who
Chose Abram and brought him out due
From Ur of the Chaldees and gave
Him name of Abraham *the brave.*
9 You found his heart faithful before
Your face and made a treaty soar
With him to give the Canaanites'
Land to him and also Hittites'
The Amorites' and Perizzites,
And Jebusites' and Gergashites',
To give to his descendants and
Kept Your words' promise *in the land,*
For you are righteous *as You stand.*
9 You saw the grief of our ancestors
In Egypt and heard for molesters
Their cry for help by the Red Sea.
10 You made miracles there to see
On Pharaoh, and on all his slaves
And on all the folk of his land,
For You knew they treated with staves
Against them. So You gained Your fame

As to this day *and without blame.*
11 You divided the sea for them
So they went though the seabed's *hem*
As on the dry land, and those who
Followed them, in the depths You threw
Them like a stone in mighty flows.
12 You led them daily by the cloud,
And in the night by fiery crowd
To give them light where they should go.
13 You came down on Mount Sinai's rows
And spoke with them from heaven and
chose
To give them right judgements and true
Laws, good statutes, commandments too.

How many in this day and age who read
The Bible still cling to the fallen creed
And claim that story of the Sinai's deed
Did not tell how You came and spoke to all
From heaven and the people heard the call.
The faithless heart would spin a faithless
tale
That by ardent Moses' hand without fail
You bestowed all the ten commandments
then
And not in sight and hearing of all men.
But even precious Nehemiah knows
To say that Moses was not on his toes
To hear a message secret from You rose,
But You spoke then directly to the crowd
Basking to hear beneath the shady cloud.

14 You made plain to them Sabbath holy,
Commanding presents to the lowly,
And statutes, laws there by the hand
Of Your slave Moses in command.
15 You gave them bread from heaven to eat
Assuaging hunger with a treat,
And brought the water from the rock
For them in their thirst *and their stock,*
And promised them that they should go
To take possession and not slow
Of the land You had sworn to live.
16 But they and our ancestors' *sieve*
Were haughty and stiffened their necks
And did not obey in their treks
Your own commandments *that You give.*
17 And they refused to obey You,
Nor did they mind Your wonders true
That You did among them, but they
Stiffened their necks and in their way
Rebelled appointing leader's sway

To take them back to slavery's day.
But You're an Alohim that's quick
To pardon *people on the slick*,
Gracious and merciful and slow
To wrath and of great kindness' *show*,
And You did not forsake them so.

Today there are not who have eaten bread
Of heaven or been by the parted Sea led,
Or drunk from springs spouting from rocks
to give

The waters man and beast both need to live.
Today there are none who received at hand
The law of Moses to live in the land,
And none alive saw cloud and fire above
The camp of travelling people that You
love.

But every man and woman alive now
Receives each week the blessing anyhow
Of Sabbath day, the greatest You bestow,
And most of them turn their backs on its
glow.

Beloved, I daily wait the Sabbath day
And thirst and hunger for its blessed way.

18 Indeed, when they made molten calf
And said "This is your God, *don't laugh*,
That brought you up from Egypt's *chaff*,"
And they provoked greatly *the staff*,

19 Still You in many mercies did
Not forsake them in desert bid,
The pillar of the cloud did not
Depart from them by day in plot
To lead them in the way, nor yet
The pillar of fire by night set
To give them light upon the way
That they should follow not astray.

20 You also gave Your spirit good
Instructing them in what they should,
And did not hold back from their mouth
Your manna, and gave in the drouth
The water for their thirst *as could*.

21 Indeed for forty years did You
Sustain them in the desert view,
So they lacked nothing in their due,
Their clothes did not wear out nor did
Their feet swell in the desert grid.

I've seen the Sinai desert on a day
When sunlight glinted on the sandy way,
And saw how many rocks in pebbled count
Were scattered at the foot of every mount.

I am amazed that any people could
Walk through that place with feet both shod
and good

And not complain about the stumbling
brood

As well as lack of water and of food.

Beloved, the reader of the story deigns

To look down on those who complained of
pains

Of hunger, thirst and weary clouds of faith,
But no one takes note neither man nor
wraith

Complained of those rocks in the way or
said

Their shoes hurt their feet there where they
were led.

22 You gave them kingdoms, nations too,
Allotting plot by plot in view,
As they took over Sihon's land,
And lot from king of Heshbon's hand,
And Og king of Bashan's command.

23 Their children You increased like stars
Of heaven and brought within the bars
Of the land You had promised their
Ancestors they should come to share.

24 And so went in the children and
Possessed the land and took in hand
Before them the inhabitants,
The Canaanites *You made to dance*
With their kings and all the land's folk
To do with as they would in yoke.

25 They took strong cities and fat land,
Possessed houses *of contraband*,
Hewn cisterns, vineyards, olive trees
And lots of fruit trees *as you please*

To eat and be filled and be fat,
Delighting themselves where You're at.

26 And they were disobedient,
Rebelling against Your ascent,
And threw Your law behind their back,
And killed Your prophets *on the slack*
Who warned them to return to You,
Who were a provocation's crew.

27 That's why You gave them up in hand
Of enemies' distressing band,
And in the time of their distress,
When they called on You *in address*,

You heard from heaven, and according
To Your many mercies *in wing*

You gave them saviours, who saved them
Out of the power of their foes' hem.

I went into a Messianic place,
 Or synagogue they called it with straight
 face,
 And heard them sing folksongs and saw
 them dance,
 And offered to read Torah for the chance
 Of that Sabbath's reading, but they said no,
 They had another kind of pony show.
 I went into that synagogue and found
 A Jewish man who made the strangest
 sound
 In reading Isaiah where he once said
 That God's a saviour of the folk well-bred,
 And that proves that Jesus is God instead.
 Now here I see that You send saviours
 many,
 Does that mean God's a dozen for a penny?
 In quandary I stop and scratch my head.

28 And as they rested they returned
 To doing the evil they learned
 Before Your face, that's why You left
 Them in power of their foes bereft,
 So they held sway over their hold,
 And yet when they repented bold,
 And cried to You for help You heard
 From heaven and many times were stirred
 To save them by Your mercies' word.
 29 You testified on them to bring
 Them back under Your command's wing,
 But they were haughty and were not
 Obedient to Your commands' plot,
 But sinned against Your judgements'
 sought,
 Which if a man do, he shall live
 By them, but they refused to give
 Their shoulder to the push, and they
 Arched their neck and would not obey.
 30 You spread out on them many years
 Mercy, and warned them by the tears
 Of Your spirit by prophets sent,
 Yet they gave not ear to repent,
 So You gave them up to the hand
 Of other peoples in the land.
 31 And yet for Your great mercies' sake
 You did not utterly at stake
 Consume them, nor abandon them,
 For You're an El of gracious hem
 And merciful by stratagem.

The first words of the holy Qur'an speak

In the same accents of this verse in peak
 That say that You are gracious to the weak
 And merciful to all of those who seek.
 A God most gracious, merciful are You,
 To Israel unrepentant at the view
 Of tragedy and at the impromptu
 Deliverance that You put in their pew.
 A God most gracious, merciful in hand
 To the sweet and blasphemous Christian
 band,
 To Muslim and even Samaritan,
 To all, Beloved, who lie beneath Your plan.
 But I am not of those, I'm an outcast.
 Be merciful and gracious while I last.

32 Therefore now, our Alohim great,
 Mighty and terrible El's rate,
 Who keep Your pact and mercy set,
 Let not all the trouble we get
 Seem small before Your face, what's come
 Upon us, on our kings in sum
 And princes, priests and prophets won,
 And our ancestors and Your folk,
 Since the days of the kings in stroke
 Assyrian till this day broke.
 33 Still You are righteous in all that
 Has fallen on us where we sat,
 For You have done the right and we,
 We only have done wickedly.
 34 Neither have our kings, princes, priests
 Nor our ancestors in their feasts
 Kept Your law nor obeyed command
 And testimonies from Your hand,
 By which You testified in band.
 35 For they have not served You in their
 Kingdom and in Your goodness' share
 Which You gave them, and in the great
 And fat land which You gave in rate
 Before them, nor repented from
 Their wicked works *they've done in sum*.
 36 Here now, we're servants to this day,
 And the land You gave in the sway
 Of our ancestors to eat what
 It does produce and good in glut,
 Here we are servants in it shut.
 37 And it yields much increase to kings
 That You've set over us for things
 We've done in wickedness, and they
 Hold even our bodies in sway,
 Our cattle too, at their desire,
 And we're in great distressing fire.
 38 Because of all this we affirm

And write it and seal it in term,
Our princes do and Levites and
The priests *as well, all in one band.*

The people got together with the great
And leadership and those that sat in state
And signed a paper making covenant
To be Your church and people without
cant.

The Baptist principle of writing out
The things they promise to do without
doubt

And sign the thing and so to form a church
Has Biblical precedence in the lurch.
Although I write no parchment in a word,
And take alone what was on Sinai heard,
I too grasp hold of promise and of hope
And set myself free of opinion's rope.
Beloved, I sit in empty pew and sing
A Psalm of David without questioning.

Nehemiah 10

"1 Those that signed *there were* Nehemiah,
Tirshatha, son of Hachaliah,
And Zidkijah, 2 also Seraiah,
Azariah, and Jeremiah,
3 Pashur, Amariah, Malchijah,
4 Hattush, Shebaniah *to hide you*,
Malluch, 5 Harim, Meremoth, and
Obadiah, 6 Daniel, Ginnethon,
Baruch, *blessing to blow his breath on*,
7 Meshullam, Abijah, Mijamin,
8 Maaziah, Bilgai *for batgammon*,
And last of all Shemaiah: these
Were the priests *set up in the breeze*.
9 And of Levites, both Jeshua
Who was son of Azaniah,
Binnui of Henadad's crew,
Kadmiel, all these came in view.
10 And of their brothers, Shebaniah,
Hodijah, Kelita, Pelaiah,
Hanan, 11 Micha, Rehob, and then
Hashabiah, *the best of men*,
13 Zacchor, Sarabia, Sebania,
14 The chief of the people *to ban you*:
Parosh, Pahathmoab, Elam,
Zatthu, Bani, *as brave as ram*,
15 Bunni, Azgad, Bebai *to win*,
16 Adonijah, Bigvai, Adin,
17 Ater, Hizkijah, and Azzur,
18 Hodijah, Hashum, Bezai sure,
19 Hariph, Anathoth, and Nebai,

20 Magpiash, Meshullam, Hezir,
21 Meshezabeel, Zadok, and *shy*
Jaddua, 22 Pelatiah near,
Hanan, Anaiah, 23 and Hoshea,
Hananiah, Hashub *to slay you*,
24 Hallohesh, Pileha, Shobek,
25 Rehum, Hashabnah *out to check*
Maaseiah, 26 Ahijah, and Hanan,
Anan, 27 Malluch, Harim, Baanah.
28 And the rest of the folk *in awe*,
The priests, the Levites, and the *crew*
Of gate-keepers, the singers too,
The Nethinim, and all who drew
Apart from the folk of the lands
Unto Alohim's law's commands,
Their wives, their sons, their daughters too,
All who had knowledge and thought
through.

The names of all the people who came near
To sign the document with all good cheer
That they would obey You, always appear
Before the temple square and without fear
Rejoice to raise Your holy name on high,
Are set down to be read by gal and guy
Today who opens up the Sacred Word.
I too am very positively stirred.
Beloved, there are so many parchments
now
That hope for signatures from wrinkled
brow,
That I can hardly bear their weight to see
The covenants of Baptists and the free
Methodists waiting patiently for me.
I turn to You instead, a single bird.

29 They kept to their brother and noble,
And entered into a curse global,
And swore to act by Alohim's
Law which was given by the seams
Of Moses Alohim's own slave,
And to observe and to be brave
To do all commandments of YHWH
Our Lord and all His judgements too,
And His statutes, *though not a few*.
30 And that we would not give our
daughters
To the folk of the lands of slaughters,
Nor take their daughters for our sons.
31 And *if* the people in their runs
Of the land bring goods or some food
On the Sabbath to sell our brood,

That we would not buy it from them
On the Sabbath day's stratagem,
Or on the holy day: and we
Would keep the seventh year in fee,
And let every debt then go free.

Two things are promised here that might
turn all

The world about me to fancy dress ball
If only institutions of the great
And every middleman that's come up late
Would take to heart and hand and do the
thing.

The first is of the Sabbath and the ring
Of freedom that it imposes to bring
On weak and the oppressed on earth today.
The second is the lack of need to pay
The debt that's run past seven years astray.
The Sabbath limits business and the bank
Is limited by cancelling debt blank.
Those two need limits, if there will be
peace
On earth and its prosperity increase.

32 We made us ordinances too,
To charge ourselves yearly in pew
With the third of a shekel due
For service of our Alohim
To keep His house *the way we deem*.

32 For the showbread, and for timely
Food-offering and continually
Burnt offering for the Sabbaths and
For the start of the months at hand,
And for appointed seasons' feast,
For holy things, and the increased
Sin offering for atonement made
For Israel and for the works stayed
In the house of our Alohim.

34 And we cast lots among the priests,
The Levites, and the folk on beam,
For the wood offering, and to bring
It into the house and the wing
Of our Alohim, by each house
Of our ancestors and each spouse,
At times appointed year by year,
To burn upon the altar dear
Of YHWH our Alohim, as writ
In the law *always to be fit*.

35 To bring the firstfruits of our ground,
And the firstfruits of all the sound
Fruit of all trees, and year by year,
Into the house of YHWH appear.

36 Also the firstborn of our sons,
And of our cattle *in their tons*,
As *it is* written in the law,
The firstlings of our herds *in claw*
And of our flocks, to bring into
The house of our Alohim due,
And to the priests that service deem
In the house of our Alohim.

37 The firstfruits of our dough to bring,
As well as our every offering,
And the fruit of all kinds of trees,
Of grape juice and of oil *to please*,
Unto the priests, and to the rooms
Of our Alohim's house *of glooms*,
And the tithes of our ground unto
The Levites, that the same in view
Might have the tithes in every town
Of what we till upon the down.

38 The priest the son of Aaron be
With the Levites to take the fee
Of tithes, and the Levites shall bring
Up the tithe of the tithes on wing
To the house of our Alohim,
To rooms and storehouse all the cream.

39 For Israel's children and those of
Levi shall bring the offering of
The grain, the new grape juice, and oil
Into the chambers where the coil
Of sanctuary vessels are,
And the priests that serve there as star,
And the gatekeepers and musicians,
And we will not forsake commissions
Of our Alohim's house partitions.

The tithes to keep the temple and the priest
Going strong for both daily flight and feast
Are tempered by the tithes that should be
spent

On liquor for the feasters once that went
Up to Jerusalem to see the fest.
I wait till the new wine is at its best.
The people promised many things that day,
Even to bring the first-born son to sway
In his redemption's silver dollar's pay.
Some things they promised were of their
own doing,

To keep the sanctuary fine and cuing.
Some things You Yourself gave the best
command,
And those were more important there to
stand.

I grasp Your Decalogue alone in band.

Nehemiah 11

1 The rulers of the folk lived at Jerusalem, the others sat
In lottery to bring one in
Of ten to dwell within the bin
Of holy town Jerusalem,
And nine parts by the stratagem
To live on other cities' mat.
2 And the people blessed all the men,
That willingly offered again
To live in Jerusalem's pen.
3 These *are* the chiefs of the province
That lived in Jerusalem's *hints*:
But in the cities of Judah
Dwelt every one in his lot's awe
In their towns, Israel and the priests,
And the Levites *come down for feasts*,
And Nethinim, and children of
Solomon's servants *writ above*.
4 And at Jerusalem there dwelt
Some of Judah's folk in the belt
With folk of Benjamin. And of
The folk of Judah writ above
Were Athaiah Uzziah's son,
The son of Zechariah, son
Of Amariah, who was son
Of Shephatiah, who was son
Of Mahalaleel as says
Among the children of Perez.

In those days it was sacrifice to live
In old Jerusalem with walls like sieve.
But one in ten were chosen in their lot
To sacrifice themselves in sacred plot.
It's still a sacrifice, I think, for sum
To live in poor Jerusalem and hum
Along the narrow streets and little shops
Irregularly paved with stones and hops.
Beloved, it is not sacrifice for me
To hold within my heart the sacred see,
The stoned up gate above Kidron and look
Upon foundations that provided nook
In David's days. It is no sacrifice,
And for my living there, heart must suffice.

5 And Maaseiah son of Baruch,
The son of Colhozeh, who took
Place as the son of Hazaiah,
Who was the son of Adaiah,
The son of Joiarib, the son
Of Zechariah, who was son

Of Shiloni when he was done.
6 All the sons of Perez that dwelt
At Jerusalem *were all svelt*
Four hundred sixty-eight fine men.
7 These *are* the sons of Benjamin;
Sallu the son of Meshullam,
The son of Joed, the son of
Pedaiah, who was the son of
Kolaiah, the son of Maaseiah,
Son of Ithiel, son of Jesaiah.
8 And after him Gabbai, Sallai,
Nine hundred twenty-eight and spry.
9 And Joel the son of Zichri
Was their overseer: and Judah
Who was the son of Senuah
Second over city in awe.

I too am son of Zichri, memory,
As I come to remember in my spree
Of Sabbath cantillation to set free
My troubled heart upon the melody
Of Your Torah, I too am son of his.
I hear the blessed words and see what is
The hope of faith and duty's helpful found.
I bow in prayer, Beloved, to hear the sound
And put my figured forehead on the
ground.
The son of Zichri was a leader set
Above the sons of Benjamin, and yet
I am no leader, but find simple sway
In one household that gathers on Your day
To bring remembrance, sons and daughters
all,
Of Your sweet names, Beloved, and of
Your call.

10 Of the priests: Jedaiah the son
Of Joiarib, and so Jachin.
11 Seraiah son of Hilkiah,
The son of Meshullam, the son
Of Zadok, Meraioth's own son,
The son of Ahitub to seem
Chief of the house of Alohim.
12 And their brothers who did the work
On the house *were not there to shirk*,
Eight hundred twenty-two: and then
Adaiah son of Jeroham,
The son of Pelaliah, son
Of Amzi, Zechariah's son,
The son of Pashur, who was son
Of Malchiah, *a rutty ram*.
13 And his brothers, the fathers' chief,

Two hundred forty-two in brief:
 And Amashai Azareel's son,
 The son of Ahasai, the son
 Of Meshillemoth, Immer's son,
 14 And their brothers, great men of war,
 A hundred twenty-eight, *not more*:
 And their chief *was* Zabdiel, the son
 Of Haggadolim *on the run*.

If Haggadolim just means the great ones,
 then

I do not find a name for son and ben
 To go by to establish family tree.
 Zabdiel like king Melkizedek may be.
 Even that king lacks name it seems to me
 Since he is king of righteousness to see.
 If Haggadolim is the name of the dad,
 It is a name so scary and so bad
 No wonder that the son became a chief,
 He was transported by his fear's belief.
 Beloved, I lift a name of great ones here
 And follow in the pathway You would
 steer,
 I touch in contemplation golden names
 And find in You the head of all their
 claims.

15 Also of Levites: Shemaiah
 The son of Hashub his good pa,
 The son of Azrikam, the son
 Of Hashabiah, who was son
 Of Bunni when the plot is done.
 16 And Shabbethai and Jozabad,
 Of chief of the Levites, who *had*
 The run of external affairs
 Of Alohims' house *and repairs*.
 17 And Mattaniah Micha's son,
 The son of Zabdi, Asaph's son,
Was chief to start thanksgiving prayer,
 And Bakbukiah second there
 Among his brothers, and Abda
 Who was the son of Shammua,
 Son of Galal, Jeduthun's son.
 18 All Levites in the holy town
 Two hundred eighty-four come down.
 19 Besides the carriers, Akkub,
 Talmon, and their brothers to rub
 The gates, one hundred seventy-two.
 20 And in Israel's residue
 Of priests, and Levites, *not a few*
Were in all Judah's towns, each one
 In his inherited plot won.

21 But the Nethinim in Ophel
 With Ziha and Gispa *to swell*
 Over the Nethinim as well.

The Nethinim have leaders over them,
 No doubt of their own ancestry in gem.
 None know who they are, but in stratagem,
 They seem to be the servants of the hem
 Of every temple from the times waylaid
 When prisoners were taken from the staid
 Canaanite and other peoples around
 And set to do the menial tasks in bound.
 Their profile now is higher on the ground
 When Ezra brought them back from
 Babylon.

I too am but a foreigner of mixed
 Ancestry thrust upon a temple fixed.
 Let me, Beloved, bear wood and water
 drawn
 Into the temple at the gate of dawn.

22 The chief also of the Levites
 Within Jerusalem *for sites*
Was Uzzi the son of Bani,
 The son of Hashabiah, son
 Of Mattaniah, Micha's son.
 Of the sons of Asaph, the singers
Were over the affairs and wringers
 Of Alohims' house *when full-spun*.
 23 For *so it was* the king's command
 To them, a certain part in hand
 Be for the singers every day.
 24 And Pethahiah the son's sway
 Of Meshezabeel, of the sons
 Of Zerah son of Judah's buns,
Was at the king's hand in all things
 Concerning the people *for springs*.
 25 And for the villages, with fields,
Some of Judah's folk with their yields
 Lived at Kirjatharba, and *in*
 Its villages, at Dibon, *in*
 Its villages, and Jekabzeel,
 And *in* the suburbs of its *heel*.
 26 And at Jeshua, Moladah,
 And at Bethphelet *for a claw*,
 27 And at Hazarshual, and at
 Beersheba, and its suburbs flat,
 28 And at Ziklag, at Mekonah,
 And in its villages *in paw*,
 29 And at Enrimmon, Zareah,
 And at Jarmuth, 30 and Zanoah,
 Adullam, and their suburbs too,

Lachish, and the surrounding view,
 At Azekah, and *in* the way
 Of towns around it in its sway.
 And they lived from Beersheba to
 The valley of Hinnom in view.
 31 The children of Benjamin too
 From Geba lived, at Michmash, and
 Aija, and Bethel, in their land.
 32 And at Anathoth, and at Nob,
 Ananiah, 33 Hazor *for job*,
 Ramah, Gittaim, 34 Hadid *out flat*,
 Zeboim *too*, and Neballat,
 35 Lod, and Ono, the valley of
 Craftsmen *engaged in tasks of love*.
 36 And of the Levites, certain rates
 In Judah were joined to estates
 Of Benjamin *in all their gates*.

The singers have their portions, and I say
 Their portions should be doubled for the
 way
 They supersede the sacrifices' sway
 And teach the people truly how to pray.
 The singers raise the plaint of David high,
 And turn his praises up toward the sky,
 They bring the penitence in duly sung,
 And bring the right petition to the tongue.
 The singers watching out for the four p's
 Should have a double portion and to please
 While slaughterers should be set out on ear
 And turned into the ogres none should fear.
 Beloved, I turn Your temple inside out
 Because I am a Thomas who should doubt.

Nehemiah 12

1 Now these *are* the priests and Levites
 That went up with Zerubbabel
 The son of Shealtiel for rights,
 And Jeshua: Seraiah's spell,
 Jeremiah and Ezra too,
 2 Amariah and Melicu,
 Hattush, 3 Shechaniah, Rehum,
 Meremoth, 4 Iddo in his room,
 Ginnetho, Abijah, 5 Miamin,
 Maadiah, Bilgah *on the scene*,
 6 Shemaiah, Joiarib, Jedaiah,
 7 Sallu, Amok, *not least* Hilkiah,
 And Jedaiah. These *were* chiefs
 Of the priests and *in their reliefs*
 Of their brothers in Jeshua's feoffs.
 8 The Levites as well: Jeshua,
 Binnui, Kadmiel, Sherebiah,

Judah, *also* Mattaniah,
 Head of thanksgiving psalms to call,
 He and his brothers on the ball.
 9 And Bakbukiah and Unni,
 Their brothers, in watch under sky.
 10 And Jeshua sired Joiakim,
 And Joiakim Eliashib,
 Eliashib begat for him
 Joiada *not born from his rib*.
 11 And Joiada sired Jonathan,
 And Jonathan sired Jaddua.
 12 And in the days of Joiakim
 Were priests, the chief of their dads' plan,
 Of Seraiah and Meraiah,
 Of Jeremiah, and with him
 Hananiah 13 and of Ezra,
 Meshullam; of Amariah,
 Jehohanan; 14 of Melicu,
 Jonathan; of Shebaniah,
 Joseph; 15 of Harim, Adna *due*;
 Of Meraioth, Helkai, *one true*;
 16 Of Iddo, Zechariah too;
 Of Ginnethon, Meshullam *due*;
 17 Of Abijah, Zichri not shy;
 Of Miniamin *in his own pew*,
 Of Moadiah then Piltai;
 18 Of Bilgah also Shammua;
 Of Shemaiah, Jehonathan;
 19 And of Joiarib, Mattenai;
 Of Jedaiah also Uzzi;
 20 Of Sallai, Kallai; of Amok,
 Eber; 21 Of Hilkiah *not stuck*,
 Hashabiah; of Jedaiah,
 Nethaneel. 22 The Levites in
 The time of Eliashib's *win*,
 Joiada, also Johanan,
 And Jaddua, writ down in plan
 As chief of the ancestors' span:
 Also the priests, up to the reign
 Of Darius the Persian fane.
 23 Levi's sons, the ancestors' chief,
 Were written in the book in brief
 Of chronicles up to the days
 Of Johanan who was the praise
 And son of Eliashib's ways.
 24 And the chief of the Levites there:
 Hashabiah, Sherebiah,
 And son of Kadmiel Jeshua,
 With brothers on opposite stair,
 To praise and give thanks by command
 Of David man of Alohim,
 In antiphonic sound *supreme*

To echo through the town and land.

The twenty-four courses of singers met
In opposites in antiphonic set,
A pair for each month of the year, and yet
They sang the Psalms of David well to get
The temple of David to rise above
The golden spires of stone and wood and
shove.

Today the temples have been torn apart.
The twenty-four courses of singers smart
To be scattered about the world to that
Each in his single place upon his mat
Raises a slender voice. And yet that voice
Suffices to rebuild the tent, rejoice
In David's faith and house, while priestly
strand
Strut and oppress the poor in every land.

25 Mattaniah, and Bakbukiah,
Obadiah, Meshullam by her,
Talmon, Akkub, *were* porters keeping
The ward at the thresholds unsleeping
Beside the gates, treasures there peeping.

26 These were the times of Joiakim
The son of Jeshua *and trim*,
The son of Jozadak, and in
The days of Nehemiah chief,
And of Ezra the priest *in bin*
And the scribe *of book and relief*.

27 At consecration of the wall
Around Jerusalem to call
The Levites up from all their homes
To bring them up into the domes
Inside Jerusalem to keep
The dedication with a heap
Of gladness and thanksgiving's sound,
With singing to the cymbals round,
With psalteries and harps abound.

I met the Coptic monks and heard them
sing
With tinkling cymbals in the churchly ring.
The sounds went up in rapid clang to sound
In clangity, clangity clang to bound
On smoke darkened ceiling and all around
Till my heart danced to hear praises
resound.

I met the dervish on Egyptian sand
And heard the drumbeat from his pulsing
hand
In the same rhythm strong and true beneath

The dome of sky hung over with the wreath
Of David's praise in faint echoes to mind
The time when temple and song were
entwined.

Beloved, without a harp or cymbal's voice
Except that of my heart, I too rejoice.

28 The sons of singers gathered there,
Both out of the plain country round
About Jerusalem, and fair
Villages of Netophathi;
Also from Gilgal's house and ground,
And out of Geba's fields and sky,
And Azmaveth: for singers had
Built themselves villages in scad
Around about Jerusalem.

30 And the priests and Levites *pro tem*
Purified themselves, purified
The folk, the gates, and wall beside.

31 I brought up Judah's princes on
The wall, and appointed well drawn
Two great groups giving thanks upon
The right side on the wall toward
The dung gate, 32 After them in ward
Went Hoshaiiah, and half the group
Of Judah's princes in a troop.

33 And Azariah, Ezra, and
Meshullam, 34 Judah, Benjamin,
Shemaiah, Jeremiah, and
35 Of the priests' sons trumpets in hand;
Zechariah Jonathan din,
The son of Shemaiah to win,
The son of Mattaniah, son
Of Michaiah, and Zaccur's son,
The son of Asaph: 36 And when done
His brothers, Shemaiah, as well
As Azarael, Milalai,
Gilalai, Maai, Nethaneel,
And Judah, also Hanani,
With the musical instruments
Invented by David with sense,
The man of God, and Ezra came
The scribe before them, man of fame.

The harps and psalteries that David signed
As specially adapted for the kind
To use in praise of You, Beloved, I find
No where today however hard I look.
I've only got a single voice in nook.
And yet I sing the songs that David made
Beneath the hills of Judah and the glade
Of barren lands, the uplands without shade.

I sing the songs that David sang when he
Fled from the foe anointed, enemy,
And from his own son to the company
Of foreigners to wet his tongue a wee.
I join sweet David in the lonely share
As well as in the melodies I dare.

37 And at the fountain gate, which was
Opposite them, they went as does
Up at the stairs of David's town,
At the ascent of wall's renown,
Above the house of David there,
East up to the water gate's share.

38 The other band giving thanks went
In opposite way to prevent,
And I after them in my bent,
And half the folk upon the wall,
From beyond furnace tower tall
Even up to the broader wall.

39 From above Ephraim's gate, above
The old gate, and as well above
The fish gate, tower of Hananeel,
And the tower of Meah, to peel
Up to the sheep gate: and they stood
Still in the prison gate for good.

40 So stood the two there giving thanks
In Alohim's house in their ranks,
And I and half the chiefs with me.

41 And the priests; Eliakim, and
Maaseiah, Miniamin, and
Michaiah, Elioenai, and
Zechariah, Hananiah,
With trumpets lifted there to blow.
42 And Maaseiah, and Shemaiah,
And Eleazar, and Uzzi,
And Jehohanan, Malchijah,
And Elam, and Ezer to cry.

The singers sang aloud along
With Jezrahiah *their* chief *song*.

43 Also that day they offered great
Sacrifices, rejoiced a rate:
For Alohim made them rejoice
With great joy; the wives also voice
With the children, so that the joy
In old Jerusalem's employ
Was heard as far *as Illinois*.

44 And at that time were some appointed
Over the treasures anointed,
For offerings, for the firstfruits, and
For tithes, to gather in to stand
Out of the fields of cities round
The legal portions for the ground

Of priests and Levites: for Judah
Rejoiced for the priests in their law
And for Levites waiting on paw.
45 And both singers and every guard
That carried there the things of God
Purified themselves by command
And law of David and the hand
Of Solomon his son to stand.

46 For in the days of David and
Asaph of old *there were* chief band
Of singers, and the songs of praise
And thanks to Alohim to raise.

47 All Israel in Zerubbabel's
Times, and of Nehemiah's fells,
Gave portions to the singers and
The porters each day in their hand,
And sanctified to the Levites,
And the Levites by their own rights
Set apart for Aaron's folk's sights.

So David has a law revealed by You
To complement the one that was in view
From Moses, which incorporated all
That was a universal mandate's call
From those before, from Abraham and
Noah

And Adam, Seth and Enoch before shoah.
I grasp the law of David in my hand,
Recite it with my tongue and come to stand
Before Your throne, Beloved, and please
my case

That David's throne is stronger than the
mace.

I seek the law of David from the Psalms
And sit in peace beneath the friendly palms
And look out on the sea that casts its fish
Upon the Sabbath day in people's dish.

Nehemiah 13

1 On that day they read in the book
Of Moses in hearing *and nook*
Of the folk, and in it they found
Written the Ammonite on ground
And Moabite should not appear
In Alohim's assembly dear
For ever and for ever *sheer*,
2 Because they did not meet the sons
Of Israel with their bread in tons
And water, but hired Balaam out
To curse them when it came about,
Though our Alohim turned in rout
The curse and made a blessing spout.

3 It happened now when they had heard
The law, they separated lured
Mixed multitude from Israel stirred.

The fact is Nehemiah's racist and
Politically incorrect in his stand
Against the women of Ashdod to make
A fuss about a private matter's sake.
The Roman Church and others take the
view
Divorce is not allowed in sacred pew.
Such do not note that Nehemiah's sent
With a divine mandate when others went.
Beloved, let me be racist for the crowd
Who reject Your law from the sweet
allowed.
Let me turn from the one who takes the
view
That pagan trinities, though nothing new,
Are an exciting way to worship You.
Beloved, let me find on the Sabbath day
The ones that You choose to put in my
way.

4 And before this, Eliashib
The priest who ruled the house and bib
Of Alohim was joined to work
With one Tobiah, *who's a jerk*.
5 And he had made him a great room
Where in times past they did presume
To lay the cereal offerings and
The frankincense they had in hand,
And all the pots and tithes of corn,
The new grape juice and oil unshorn
That was commanded for Levites
And singers and porters for rights,
And offerings for the priests in sights.
6 But in all this I was not in
Jerusalem: for in the win
Of thirty-second year of king
Artaxerxes of Babylon
I came to the king on the wing,
And after some days had been drawn,
I got permission to be gone.
7 I came then to Jerusalem,
And understood the wicked stem
Eliashib did for Tobiah,
In giving him a room up higher
In the courts of Alohim's house.
8 I really felt bad about that,
And so I threw everything raus,
Household goods and Tobiah fat.

9 I ordered them to clean the place,
And brought back Alohim's house brace
Of pots and pans and offerings' grace
Of flour and frankincense in vase.
10 I noticed that the Levites' share
Had not been given to them there,
For the Levites and singers all
Who did the work in sacred hall
Had fled to their own field and stall.
11 I quarrelled with the rulers saying
"Why is Alohim's house here staying
Forsaken?" And I gathered them
And made them stand in their own hem.
12 Then brought all Judah tithe of corn
And the new grape juice and oil borne
Into the treasurehouse forlorn.
13 And I made treasurers to rule
Over the treasure houses' pool,
Shelemiah the priest, Zadok
The scribe, and of the Levites' stock,
Pedaiah: and next to them stood
Hanan the son of Zaccur good,
The son of Mattaniah: for
They were deemed faithful and their store
Was to divide their brothers more.
14 Remember me, my Alohim,
For doing this and do not deem
My good deeds wiped out that I've done
For Alohim's house *and its fun*.

Remember me, too, my Beloved, when I
Remember Your name raising it to vie
With all names under moon and sun and
sky.
Remember me, too, my Beloved, as when
You minded Nehemiah among men
For sending out the pagan from the store
Of Your house and bringing upon its floor
The tithes and offerings of both flour and
sheep
And new grape juice in the storehouse to
keep.
Beloved, the service of remembrance here
Upon the Sabbath day when I appear
To cantillate Your name and holy Word
Is something that never leaves me
unstirred.

I twitter happily with beast and bird.

15 In those days saw I in Judah
Some treading wine presses with paw
On Sabbath-day, and bringing sheaves,

And piling burdens in their sleeves
 On donkeys, also grape juice and
 Grapes, figs, all kinds of contraband,
 Which they brought to Jerusalem
 On the Sabbath day, and *pro tem*
 I rose to testify on them
 The day they sold their victuals' *gem*.
 16 There lived there men of Tyre who
 brought
 Fish and such things to sell when sought
 Upon the Sabbath to the folk
 Of Judah and Jerusalem.
 17 I rose to contend at a stroke
 With Judah's notables in hem
 And angrily I said to them,
 "What wicked thing is this you do
 And profane the Sabbath in crew?
 18 "Did not your ancestors do this
 To bring our Alohim to kiss
 Us with all this evil in sway
 Upon us and this city's way?
 Yet you draw down more anger on
 Israel by profaning the dawn
 Of Sabbath day *before it's gone*."

Beloved, the Sabbath day is oft
 transgressed
 In every place I lay my head to rest.
 The market place is open to the feet
 Profaning Your name and Your day with
 cheat.
 Beloved, the Sabbath in the land where I
 Live is a day that's been put out to sty.
 I gather family upon the hearth
 In secret to avoid the evil swarth,
 And call upon Your name in hope and trust,
 Repenting in the burden of my dust.
 Beloved, the Sabbath comes to me each
 week
 And finds me waiting for the blessed peak
 Of happiness and joy that You are here
 And doubly so when Sabbath does appear.

19 So when Jerusalem's gates started
 To fall in shadow before smarted
 The Sabbath, I ordered gates shut,
 Not to be opened bolt or nut
 Before the end of Sabbath day,
 And I set servants in the way
 At the gates to prevent them bringing
 Any burdens on Sabbath *singing*.
 20 The merchants and the sellers came

And stayed outside Jerusalem
 Once or twice *to receive their shame*.
 21 So I witnessed against them and
 Said to them, "Why do you in band
 Stay loitering around the wall.
 If you do so again, I'll fall
 Upon you and arrest you all.
 After that time they did not come
 Any more on the Sabbath sum.
 22 And I commanded the Levites
 That they should purify their rights,
 Come keep the gates, and sanctify
 The Sabbath day *under the sky*.
 Remember me, my Alohim,
 For this also, and spare and deem
 Me innocent in mercy's seam.

If I had power, Beloved, I would arrest
 Every man that comes out in tie and vest
 To work in office of company's vice
 Upon the Sabbath day and not look twice.
 If I had power, Beloved, I would not fail
 To call to task the worshipper of Baal
 That takes the Sunday instead of the day
 That You provided for men without pay.
 But I have not the power of word and deed,
 And few but hear my protest and my need.
 Instead I suffer under ruthless steed
 That runs aground those who stand up to
 keep
 Your law, Beloved, look on, do more than
 weep,
 And make Your law a bulwark for the
 weak.

23 In those days also I saw Jews
 Married the wives of Ashdod's *pews*,
 Of Ammon, *and* of Moab's *crews*.
 24 And their children spoke half in speech
 Of Ashdod, and they could not reach
 The tongue of the Jews, but in yoke
 Of the tongue that each people spoke.
 25 I quarrelled with them, and I cursed,
 I hit them and pulled hair of worst,
 And made them swear by Alohim,
 "You shall not give your daughters *dream*
 To their sons nor take of their daughters
 For your sons or yourselves *in fadders*.
 26 "Did not king Solomon of folk
 Of Israel sin by these in yoke?
 Yet in all nations there was not
 A king like him by any sought,

Who was beloved of Alohim,
 And Alohim made him the cream
 And king of all Israel to seem,
 And yet even he was brought down
 To sin with such women in town.
 27 "Shall we then let you do all this
 Great evil to transgress and miss
 Against our Alohim when you
 Marry outlandish women too?"
 28 *One* of the sons of Joiada,
 The son of Eliashib's *awe*,
 The high priest, he was son-in-law
 Of Sanballat the Horonite:
 That's why I cast him from my sight.
 29 Remember them, my Alohim,
 Because they have defiled the seam
 Of priesthood and the covenant
 Of the priesthood and what it meant
 And of the Levites too as sent.
 30 So ethnic cleansing I performed
 Against all foreigners forwarned,
 And set up courses for the priests
 And for the Levites *in their feasts*.
 31 And for wood offering at its time,
 And for the firstfruits *in their clime*.
 Remember me, my Alohim,
 For good in everything You deem.

Model for ethnic cleansing is the way
 That Nehemiah stood up in the fray
 And put out all the pagan women and
 Sent them without their children out of
 band.

Model for ethnic cleansing is the law
 That forced all young folk in the catch of
 claw

To speak alone the dialect that's found
 In fair Jerusalem upon the ground.
 Today the speech of Ashdod's gone away,
 Forgotten by the children in their play.
 But Hebrew words are shouted from the
 spires

That turn Jerusalem into desires.
 Beloved, I speak a pagan tongue and yet
 I cantillate Your Words in triolet.

1 Esdras

The first book of Esdras, after the council
 of Trent called 3 Esdras, is largely a
 recapitulation or early source of parts of

Ezra, Nehemiah, and 2 Chronicles. The
 ordering of events and contents is also a
 matter of continuing research and
 speculation. But the book has consistently
 been acknowledged to be of canonical
 value in the Eastern Church and so is
 incorporated here in the late western
 tradition, although eastern canons place
 both 1 and 2 Esdras after 2 Chronicles. The
 text is based on published Greek and
 recuperated Greek versions and their
 translations.

1 Esdras 1

1 Josiah kept Passover in
 Jerusalem his Lord to win,
 He offered the Passover on
 The fourteenth day *at eve not dawn*
 Of the first month, 2 having appointed
 The priests in their groups *and anointed*
 Arrayed in their garments within
 The temple of YHWH *without sin*.
 3 And he told the Levites, who served
 As temple servants *well-deserved*
 Of Israel, that they sanctify
 Themselves to YHWH and then put by
 The holy ark of YHWH inside
 The house which Solomon *with pride*
 The king, the son of David, built.
 4 And he said "You don't need to carry
 It on your shoulders any more.
 Now worship YHWH your Alohim
 And serve His people Israel *marry*,
 And prepare yourselves by the score
 Of your families and kindred's *scheme*,
 5 And in accordance with directions
 Of David Israel's king's *selections*
 And Solomon's magnificence
 Who was his son. Stand in array
 In the temple *in its incense*
 According to the dignity
 Of the fathers' houses *today*
 Of you Levites, who serve *and see*
 Before your brothers Israel's folk,
 6 And offer the Passover and
 Prepare the sacrifice at hand
 For your brothers, *of which I spoke*,
 And observe the Passover by
 Commandment of YHWH which was by
 Moses given *and not to lie*."

Until the time of King Josiah's reign

The Levites held the ark and without strain
Took it in full procession in the crowd
While David's choir praised the Lord
aloud.

The king removed the ark to hiding place
So it should not appear to hand or face
And be a danger to the milling folk.
So glory veiled and You then never spoke.
Beloved, I take the ark down from my
shoulder,

And with no trepidation, even bolder,
I set it in the temple of my heart,
And leaving shoulder, leaving kine and
cart,

I seek Your presence veiled from human
sight.

May Axum keep its secrets and its right.

7 And Josiah gave to the folk
Who were present *and at one stroke*
Thirty thousand lambs and kids, and
Three thousand calves *able to stand*,
These were given from the king's hand,
As he promised, to the folk and
The priests and Levites *of the land*.

8 Hilkiah, Zechariah, and
Jehiel, the chief officers
Of the temple, gave to the fers
Of priests for the Passover two
Thousand six hundred sheep and *due*
Three hundred calves. 9 And Jeconiah,
Shemaiah, Nethanel his brother,
And Hashabiah and another
Ochiel and Joram, as chiefs
Over thousands, gave *in reliefs*
The Levites for Passover five
Thousand sheep and of calves *alive*
Seven hundred. 10 And then this took
place.

The priests and Levites, all dressed up,
And with unleavened bread to sup,
Stood in groups of their kin and kind
11 According to ancestors' grind
In front of all the folk to make
The offering to YHWH as in stake
Writ in the book of Moses, and
That's what they did in morning planned.
12 They roasted the Passover lamb
Over a fire, by diagram,
And boiled the sacrifices in
Brass pots and pans with pleasing din,
13 And brought them out to all the folk.

Afterward they prepared the stroke
Of Passover for themselves and
For their brothers the priests *as planned*,
The sons of Aaron, 14 since each priest
Was offering fat till night increased.
So Levites made it for themselves
And for their brother priests *and elves*,
The sons of Aaron *on their shelves*.
15 The temple singers, Asaph's sons,
Stood according to ranks and tons
Set up by David, and Asaph,
Zechariah and *not to laugh*

Eddinus, who were the king's staff.
16 The gatekeepers were at each gate;
No one needed to go out late
From his duties, for the Levites
Their brothers had the oversights
Of the Passover for their rights.

17 That day they accomplished all that
Stood with YHWH's sacrifice and sat
To keep the Passover down pat.

18 They offered sacrifices on
YHWH's altar according to drawn
Command of king Josiah gone.

19 And Israel's folk there at the time
Observed the Passover and rime
Of feast of yeastless bread seven days.

20 No such Passover for its praise
Had been in Israel since the ways
Of Samuel the prophet for stays.

21 None of Israel's kings had kept such
A Passover as was in touch
By Josiah and the priests and
Levites and men of Judah's land
And all of Israel who were there
Living in Jerusalem's share.

22 In the eighteenth year of the reign
Of Josiah Passover's lain.

I stand within the temple gates to pray
Upon the blessed Paschal holiday.
I stand within the four gates, sacrifice
On every hand, the temple singers, twice
Blessed from the mouth of David, prophesy
With harp and tongue, the sacred testify
For priests and Levites of this temple air.
Alone I stand among this wealth and bare.
I bring no offering here of sheep or goat,
I have no voice to sing Your praise by rote.
All are prepared with rich display and dress
Awaiting Your word and Your will to
bless.

But I am all alone without a lamb,
No other sacrifice but what I am.

23 The deeds of Josiah were good
In the sight of YHWH *as they should*,
His heart was full of hardihood.

24 What happened in his reign is writ
Before of those who sinned *a bit*
And wickedly walked before YHWH
More than any other folk do
Or other kingdom, as they grieved
YHWH greatly, so YHWH's words
believed

Rose against Israel *unretrieved*.

25 After all these deeds of Josiah,
It happened Pharaoh, the pariah
King of Egypt, went to make war
At Carchemish upon the shore
Of the Euphrates, and Josiah
Went out against him *to come nigher*.

26 The king of Egypt sent him word,
Saying, "What have we come and heard
Of one another, Judah's *bird*?

27 "I was not sent against you by
YHWH Alohim, for my war-cry
Is at the Euphrates, and now
YHWH is with me! The Lord *somehow*
Is with me to drive me *to war*.

So turn aside *from blood and gore*
And do not fight against YHWH *more*."

28 Josiah did not turn away
To his chariot *in the fray*,
But sought to fight him, and did not
Hearken to Jeremiah *taught*,
The prophet from the mouth of YHWH.

29 He engaged him in battle's *view*
In the plain of Megiddo, and
The commanders came down *in band*
Against King Josiah *to stand*.

30 The king said to his servants, "Take
Me from the battlefield at stake,
For I am weak about to faint."
Directly his servants took him
Out of the line of battle grim.

31 He got into another cart,
And when he had been brought apart
Back to Jerusalem, he died,
Was buried by his fathers' side.

32 In all Judea they mourned for
Josiah. The prophet in store,
Jeremiah lamented for
Josiah, and the chief men too,

With the women, to this day too
Have made lamentation for him.
It was a legislation trim
That always this should be done through
The whole nation of Israel's crew.
33 These things are written in the book
Of kings of Judea to look,
And each of Josiah's acts too,
And his glory and his ado
To know the commandments of YHWH,
And the things that he'd done before
And these that are now told *by score*,
They are recorded in the book
Of Israel's and Judah's kings, *look*.

Josiah's fateful death is prophecy
Beloved, of later deaths beside the lea
Of that great river of Euphrates where
The sacrifice of ages was laid bare.
It was not, so it seems, enough that Abel
Was killed to waken conscience at the table
Of all negotiations past and coming.

So Miriam died, and Jonathan and Saul,
And Jeremiah also met death humming,
And Jesus Christ, whose crowns of thorns
appal,

And Hussayn's martyrs thirsting by the
crane

And by its call forlorn without a gain.
Josiah's fateful death and lamentation
Continue to recall a world and nation.

34 Then the folk took Jehoahaz,
The son of Joash, and with snazz
Set him to reign instead of dad
Josiah when he only had
Twenty-three years under his belt.

35 He reigned in Judea and felt
Jerusalem for three months, then
The king of Egypt came again
And dethroned him from reigning in
Jerusalem, 36 set a tax bin

Upon the land in such a sum
As one hundred talents to hum
Of silver and one talent told
To be paid out in purest gold.

37 The king of Egypt also made
Jehoiachim his frère arrayed
To rule king in Judea's land
And in Jerusalem first hand.

38 He bound Jehoiachim and those
Of the nobles, the ones he chose,

But Zaraces his brother he
 Arrested and brought him in fee
 Out of Egypt's *dale and prairie*.
 39 Jehoiachim was twenty-five
 Years old when he began to thrive
 As king of Judea and of
 Jerusalem *as said above*.
 And he did evil in YHWH's sight.

The evil men do often is brought on
 By ignorance or fear of Egypt's brawn
 And all the strength of rising Babylon.
 That's why the Lutheran says none can
 keep
 Your commandments, Beloved, set in a
 heap,
 But all sin is inevitable weep,
 So none must be accused of doing wrong,
 Which is why the victim of evil song
 Is hated and the perpetrator made
 A hero in the Lutheran parade.
 No doubt Jehoiachim was justified
 In doing evil in YHWH's sight for pride.
 So justification's a dogma well
 Set in the plot of heathen rite and spell.

40 That's why Nebuchadnezzar king
 Of Babylon came up to sing
 Against him, and bound with a chain
 Of brass and carried him in train
 To Babylon. 41 Some holy pots
 Nebuchadnezzar took in lots
 From YHWH and carried them away
 And set them in his own gods' sway
 In Babylon. 42 But those things set
 In record of him and *regret*
Of uncleanness, impiety,
 Are written in the records *free*
 Of the kings *of the fair country*.
 43 Jehoiachin his son reigned in
 His place, and he was granted *bin*
 To reign when he was eighteen years
 Old, 44 and he reigned *as it appears*
 Just three months and ten days *in fears*
And in Jerusalem, and did
 Evil before YHWH's sight *in bid*.
 45 Nebuchadnezzar in one year
 Sent and brought him into the fear
 Of Babylon and with the things
 Holy to YHWH *before the kings*.

Nebuchadnezzar was a mighty man

To depose kings by sword and thoughtful
 plan.

When Jehoiachin ruled three months and
 ten

Days in Jerusalem over its men,
 He did wickedly in Your sight and You
 Delivered him to Babylonian crew.
 I sit today under the tents of those
 Who are the daughters of Babylon's throes,
 And see the wickedness of Babylon
 Spread out in every Christian sort of brawn.
 Is it for wickedness that no man can
 Rise up and shake the chains of scorn from
 Dan

To Beersheba, from Arkangel to Rome?
 In house arrest I keep myself at home.

46 And he made Zedekiah king
 And in Judea and the ring
 Jerusalem when he was twenty
 One years old and he reigned in plenty
 Eleven years. 47 And he also
 Did evil in the sight of YHWH,
 And did not care a whit to hear
 Words spoken from prophetic ear
 To him by Jeremiah from
 The mouth of YHWH *such words as come*.
 48 And though King Nebuchadnezzar
 Had made him swear by YHWH's name's
 star,

He broke his oath and he rebelled;
 And he stiffened his neck, unquelled
 Hardened his heart to break the laws
 Of YHWH, Israel's Alohim's clause.
 49 Even the leaders of the folk
 And of the priests acted and broke
 The law with acts of sacrilege
 And lawlessness beyond the edge
 Of unclean acts in foreign lands,
 Polluting YHWH's house with their hands
 That had been sanctified in *town*
 Jerusalem and with renown.

The church indeed is modern Judah's fort,
 That copies heathen songs and deeds for
 sport.

Worse than the pagan rituals of old
 That fornicated under groves and told
 Sweet stories of the dying god who came
 To resurrect and cure men of all blame,
 These churches accept every filthy tool,

Make slaves of Slavs and bring them to the
rule
Of Amsterdam to fornicate in pool
With bishops and with presidents in name.
Beloved, I see that history's the same
Wherever I turn looking for the right,
I find the altar is raised in my sight
To offer up the tender and the bright.

50 The Alohims of their dads sent
By messenger's hand to prevent
And call them back, because He wanted
To spare them and his house unvaunted.
51 But they made fun of messengers,
And when YHWH would speak to the fers,
They scoffed at His prophets undaunted,
52 Until His wrath arose to fly
Against His folk because for why
Their wicked actions, so He gave
Command to bring against them grave
Kings of Chaldeans *to enslave*.
53 These killed their youths using the
sword

Beside their sacred temple's ward,
They did not save young man or girl,
Old man or child *to give a whirl*,
But he delivered all of them
Into their hands, *into their hem*.
54 And all Muhammad's instruments
For YHWH, both large and small in sense,
The treasure chests of YHWH and more,
The contents of the royal store,
They took away and carried off
To Babylon *where they could scoff*.
55 They burned the house of YHWH and
broke

Jerusalem's walls at a stroke
And burned their towers with fire *of oak*.
56 They spoiled completely everything
Of glory in the sacred wing.
Those who were left he took away
To Babylon under sword's sway.
57 They became servants to himself
And to his sons until with stealth
The Persians started in their rule
Fulfilling YHWH's word by the school
Of Jeremiah: 58 "Till the land
Has had the joy of sabbaths' hand
It shall keep Sabbath all the time
Of desolation till the crime
End with seventy years *in prime*."

The wall of my fair city's broken down,
And Sabbath's driven out of every town
So that the king of Babylon in state
May rule by selling things by ton in crate.
The wall of my Jerusalem is bare
And stacked with guns to keep away the
fair,
So that the bishop of Babylon's spawn
May say a quiet word into the dawn
To prop up his hypocrisy and make
The populace a slain lamb at the stake.
Beloved, I live in Babylon but still
I turn to You and Jerusalem's hill.

1 Esdras 2

1 In the first year of Cyrus king
Of the Persians, the word took wing
From YHWH by mouth of Jeremiah
To be accomplished *by the crier*,
2 That YHWH stirred up the spirit of
Cyrus king of Persians *above*,
And he proclaimed throughout his realm
And also put *not to dishelm*
The thing in writing, 3 "Thus says he,
Cyrus king of the Persians' quay,
The Lord of Israel, YHWH Most High,
Has made me ruler *under sky*
Of the world, 4 and he has commanded
Me to build Him a house *demanded*
At Jerusalem, which is in
Judea. 5 If any one's kin
Among you, therefore, of His folk,
May his Lord be with *noble bloke*,
And let him go up to *the town*
Of Jerusalem, which is down
In Judea, and build the tent
Of YHWH of Israel *as sent*,
For He is YHWH who dwells there in
Jerusalem, 6 and let each kin,
Wherever he may live, be aided
By the men of his place *paraded*
With gold and silver, 7 and with gifts,
With horses and cattle for lifts,
Besides the other things to add
As votive offerings for the *glad*
Temple of YHWH where it is *found*
In Jerusalem on the ground."

The Persian ruler's often sent by You,
Beloved, to turn about the thing and do
Righteousness on the earth, it's a thing true.

Out of fair Persia comes the bright
command

To rebuild Your temple in every land.
I see the law rise up, in justice stand,
Giving the right example in the view
Of every state and country where men
stew.

Beloved, make Persia strong to show Your
word

To all mankind wherever they are stirred,
And give the right a place once under sun
As You did when You threw down
Babylon.

The story whirls about like dervish stroke,
Returning and returning easy yoke.

8 Then there arose the families' chiefs
Of the tribes of Judah in feoffs
And Benjamin, and the priests and
The Levites, and all of the band
Whose spirit YHWH had stirred to go
Up to build the house in the show
Of Jerusalem and for YHWH.

9 And their neighbours helped them to do
Everything, with silver and gold,
With horses and cattle, untold
Numbers of offerings from the many
Whose ears were smitten more than any.

10 Cyrus the king also brought out
The holy pots of YHWH for shout,
Which Nebuchadnezzar had taken
Away from Jerusalem shaken
And stored in temple of his gods.

11 When Cyrus king of Persian *sods*
Brought these out, he gave them into
Hand of Mithridates his due
Steward, 12 and by him they were given
To Sheshbazzar the chief unshriven
Of Judah's land. 13 Number of these
Was: a thousand gold cups *to please*,
A thousand silver cups, and yet
Twenty-nine silver censers set,
Thirty gold bowls, two thousand four
Hundred and ten silver bowls more,
And a thousand other pots' store.

14 All the vessels were handed over,
Gold and silver into the trover,
Five thousand and four hundred and
Sixty-nine to make up the stand,
15 And they were all taken back by
Sheshbazzar with returning guy,
The exiles from Babylon to

Jerusalem, city in view.

The efforts were three-pronged to build
Jerusalem again. The project filled
The hearts and hands of those who left to
live

Upon the barren soil, and those to give
The monetary aid but stayed behind
In comfort of the civilized and kind.
The third group was the crown and
government.

Upon these three depended sentiment.

Beloved, I see the trinity at work
As Israel again rises to quirk:
The ones who go to Palestine to stay,
The neighbours who remain behind to pay,
And US government to boot the score.
Times do not change, alas, nor does the
shore.

16 In time of Artaxerxes king
Of Persians, Bishlam, Mithridates,
Tabeel, Rehum, Beltethmus rates,
Shimshai the scribe, and all the rest
Of their companions at their best,
Living in Samaria and
Other places, wrote him demand
Against those who were living in
Judea and Jerusalem:

17 "To King Artaxerxes our lord,
Your servants Rehum to record
And Shimshai the scribe and the other
Judges of their council *of brother*
In Coelesyria and *the land*
Of Phoenicia *by the sea sand*:

18 "Let it be known to our lord king
That Jews who came up from your wing
To us have gone into the town
Jerusalem and without frown
Are building that rebellious town
And wicked one, repairing its
Market places, its wall that fits
And starting on a temple thing.

19 "Now if this city's built, its wall
Completed, they will not just stall
At paying tribute but resist
Even kings *with rebellious fist*.

20 "And since the building of the place
Is now proceeding at a pace

We don't want to neglect our trace,
21 "But address ourselves to our lord
The king, so that if you're not bored,

You search your ancestors' record.
22 "You will find in the chronicles
What has been written of their pulls,
And will learn this rebellious town
Troubled kings and those of renown,
23 "And that the Jews were rebels and
Kept setting up there to withstand
From times immemorial in the land.
That's why this city was destroyed.

The sons of witches only told the truth,
And that will be enough for every youth
Who hears the words to come down on the
side

Of king and country, let the Jews just slide.
The truth is the best way to do the wrong,
And past experience a firm guide, strong
To indicate what will occur in place
When someone rises up from his disgrace.
Beloved, I take the side of underdog,
This time it's Jews, but in the human fog
It could be anyone out just to make
A life and live to correct some mistake.
But some office clerk always comes along
To spoil the progress of the victory song.

24 "So now we have come here employed
To let you know, O lord and king,
That if this city's built with wing
Of walls completed, you will not
Have more access to treasure pot
Of Coelesyria and the lot
Phoenicians *bring out on the trot.*"

25 The king, in reply to Rehum
The recorder and in his room
Beltethmus and Shimshai the scribe
And their companions *on the bribe*
In Samaria and Syria
And in the land of Phoenicia,
Wrote as follows: 26 "Now I have read
The letter which you sent my head.
So I commanded search be made,
And found out this town has waylaid
Kings from ancient times on parade.
27 "The men in it had penchant for
Rebellion and for wanton war,
And great and awful kings ruled in
Jerusalem and brought to bin
Tribute from Coelesyria and
The Phoenicians in their own land.
28 "So I have now issued command
Preventing these men from the task

Of building the city and ask
To take care that no more be done
29 "So such evil actions to stun
Kings go no further under sun."
30 So when the letter from the King
Artaxerxes was read to sing,
Rehum and Shimshai the scribe and
Their contriving companion band
Quickly went to Jerusalem,
With horsemen and in stratagem
Of army in battle array,
To stop the builders in their way.
So building of the temple in
Jerusalem ceased till the din
Of second year of the reign of
Darius king of Persians' *love*.

The argument that clinches truthful tale
Is that the treasury's about to fail.
That always fetches every crowd to make
The policy turn inside out mistake.
Stop building on the city and the site
Of temple and the king's gate will go right.
Stop building up the earthly tabernacle,
And civil servants stay for rod and tackle.
Beloved, let not the building of my room
Invisible and inner meet the doom,
But daily rise in praises to the skies
That You are true behind all the disguise,
And I shall bow within the chamber bare
And find the gold of love there everywhere.

1 Esdras 3

1 Now King Darius gave a great
Feast for all those under his state
And all born in his house and all
The nobles of the Median hall
As well as from the Persian call.
2 And all the satraps and the chiefs
Of armies and the rulers' sheafs
Under him in the satrapies
A hundred twenty-seven's ease
From India to Ethiopia.
3 They ate and drank, when they were done
They left satisfied for the fun,
Darius the king went into
His chamber, went to sleep on cue,
And then woke up. 4 So three young men
Of his guards, who kept guard again
Over the person of the king,
Said to each other on the wing,
5 "Let each of us say what one thing

Is strongest, and the one who makes
The wisest choice for the king's sakes
Darius will have wealth and power
Of honour in victorious hour.
6 "He'll be clothed in purple, and drink
From gold cups, and sleep on brink
Of a gold bed, and have a car
With golden fenders and on head
A turban of fine linen spread,
And necklace on his neck instead.
7 "And for his wisdom he shall sit
Next to Darius and called fit
To be Darius' kinsman bred."

The dreams of grandeur that some soldiers
make
A-whiling time in guard duty and stake
Are all the same. The play of boys in sand
Turns into play of soldiers on the land.
Put three young men together and they'll
soon
Be gambling if for nothing else the moon,
And saying which of them is strongest in
Arm-wrestling for a grimace or a grin.
Beloved, my competition on that bore
Was never more than school-grades at the
door,
And those were always of one coloured
score.
Futility of such play came to me
Too young to make the final, sloping spree.
I watch the young men sprawling there
idly.

8 Each wrote his own epistle and
They sealed them and put them to stand
Under king Darius's pillow
9 And said "When the king wakes, the bill,
oh,
Will be given to him and then
To the one who is above men
According to the king and three
Nobles of Persia judge to be
The winner of the victory,
Shall be given a handsome fee."
10 The first wrote, "Wine is strongest
here."
11 The second wrote, "The king's to fear."
12 The third wrote, "Women are the
greatest,
But truth wins over all the latest."
13 When the king woke up, then they took

The letters and gave him to look.
14 He sent and summoned all the great
Nobles of Persian Median state
And the satraps and army chiefs,
And governors beyond beliefs,
15 And he took his seat in the room
Of council, and the letters' bloom
Was read before them all to doom.

It is amazing that the king's court has
No better thing to do but hear such jazz,
And yet I praise Darius and his crew
For play and wit instead of looking to
The killing that's so prevalent about
Those who have power over both field and
scout.

It is amazing that the king on throne
Is up for throwing dice and crossing bone.
Beloved, the very hand that says the word
That one shall live and one shall have life
blurred

Does so in one aside, and then returns
To jesting and to play for what it earns.
Beloved, do You play on the throne that
lies
Above the universe in Your disguise?

16 And he said, "Call the young men, and
They shall explain their words' command."
So they were summoned, and came in.
17 And they said to them, "Give the bin
Of explanation for your din."
Then the first, who had taken wine
To be the strongest thing and fine,
Began and said 18 "Sirs, you must know
How wine's the strongest thing to go.
It leads astray the minds of all
Who drink it *in the judgement hall*.
19 It sets on the same plane the mind
Of king and orphan, slave and free,
Of poor and the rich and refined.
20 It turns every thought to the spree
Of feasting and mirth, and forgets
All sorrow as well as all debts.
21 It makes all hearts feel rich, forgets
Kings and satraps, and makes each one
Talk in the myriad ways of fun.
22 When men drink they forget to be
Friendly with friends and brothers, see,
They draw their swords immediately.
23 And when they wake up from the wine,
They don't remember asinine.

24 Sirs, is not wine strongest, since it
Forces men to do things unfit?"
And so he finished speaking wit.

Wine is truly the strongest of the things
Not mentioned in the Decalogue with
strings!

It woos the soul away from You as God
Alone above the heavens and the sod.
It fabricates a form in mind of all,
And makes forget Your name on which to
call.

It turns the Sabbath rest into a folly,
Dishonours both the dad and mom, by
golly,

It kills by thousands every year on wheels,
And makes a man lie with any high heels,
Not able to distinguish what's his own,
Or whether what he says is true or bone.
It makes a man desire what is not his
Just for a taste of alcoholic fizz.

1 Esdras 4

1 The second spoke about the king
And how he's strongest in the ring.
2 "Sirs, are not men the strongest who
Rule land and sea, what's in them too?
3 "But the king's stronger; he's their lord
And master, and they're in accord
With what he says to them. 4 If he
Tells them to make war in a spree,
They do so, and if he sends out
Against the enemy in rout,
They go, and conquer mountains stout,
And walls, and towers of redoubt.
5 "They kill and are killed, and do not
Neglect the king's command for aught,
If they have fought with victory,
They bring all to the king in fee,
Whatever spoil and all they take.

The king is strong because he commands
war,

And yet the wine is stronger on the floor,
They say for Alexander, gay and drunk.
The king is still strong in his spick and
spunk.

I am convinced of wine, I am convinced
The king is strongest of all those who
wined,
And hear of strength is force to do and say,
And in the mighty power of arms at fray.

And yet, Beloved, I find a stronger task
In vignette of the Persian court to last,
Where men play at the same games then as
now

And touch with wit and human sort of
brow.

The strength of human heart through
centuries
Arises here to shine through changing trees.

6 "The same can be said for those who
Do not serve in the army crew
Or make war but just plough the soil,
Whenever they saw, reap the toil
Of harvest and bring to the king
Some in tribute, and so they sting
Each other to pay taxes' coil.

7 "And yet he is only one man!
If he tells them to kill, they scan
To kill; if he tells them let go,
They let go, 8 "if he says attack,
Then they attack; if he tells them
To spoil, they spoil by stratagem;
If he tells them to build, they build;
9 "If he says cut down, they've fulfilled
His orders; if he tells them plant,
They plant. 10 "All his folk and his hosts
Obey him. Moreover, in boasts
He lies down, eats and drink not scant,
And then he sleeps, 11 "but they keep
guard

Around him and no one is starved
To go to his own affairs, so
They do not disobey his row.

12 "Sirs, why is not the king the best,
Since he's obeyed by all the rest?"
And so he stopped his speech and quest.

They also serve the king who do not wait
For the command to battle in the strait,
But stand to give him food and drink and
wine,

And slaughter sacrifices for him fine,
And bathe the women and anoint them all
With perfumes before they answer his call.
The kingly state is such, that all men share
In serving him, both soldier and the rare.
Beloved, I strike a blow for You when I,
Who am no soldier even on the sly,
Affirm Your kingly state in what I do
In praise and service for the temple true
Of David and the heart. Yet over You

There is Your own strength, justice for the few.

13 The third, that is Zerubbabel,
Who wrote of women and truth well,
Began to speak. 14 "Sirs, I can tell
The king is great as many men,
And wine is strong too in the den,
And who then is their master, lord?
Is it not women who're adored?
15 "Women gave birth to the king and
To all folk ruling sea and land.
16 "From woman they have come, and she
Nurtured the very men's degree
Who plant the vineyards growing wine.
17 "Women make men's clothes; they bring
fine
Glory to men; men cannot be
Existing without womenly.
18 "If men gather silver and gold
Or any beautiful thing sold,
See woman lovely to behold
In beauty, 19 they let all things go,
And gaze at her, and so they stare
With open mouths, and all prefer
Her to gold or silver or such
Other beautiful things to touch.
20 "A man will leave his father, who
Brought him up, and his own place too,
And stick to his own wife in view.
21 "With his wife he will end his days,
With no thought of his father's ways
Or mother or his country's praise.
22 "So you must know that women rule
Over you all as though in school!
Do you not work and toil to bring
All to put under women's wing?

Commandment is to honour mom and dad,
So does this mean a breach when the man's
sad

To leave them both and fly into the land
Where his own wife is stirring contraband?
Perhaps the greater honour done to those
Fair creatures who sired and gave birth and
rose

To nurture the man is also to spend
Himself on rearing children to that end.
Beloved, Zerubbabel looks at the state
Of heathen men and finds that men relate
So lovingly to wives as to stay long

And end their days with them however
strong.

They say the Persians to this day are set
As servants to their wives, I make no bet.

23 "A man will take his sword and go
Out to travel and rob not slow,
And sail the seas and rivers too,
24 "Face lions, and walk in darkness' rue,
And when he steals and robs and plunders,
He brings it all back as in wonders
To the woman he loves for thunders.
25 "A man loves his wife more than dad
Or mother. 26 "Many men, it's sad,
Have lost their minds to women's charge,
And they have become slaves at large.
27 "Many have perished, stumbled, sinned,
Because some women smiled or grinned.
28 "And do you not believe me now?
Is not the king fear in his brow?
Do not all lands fear to touch him?
29 "Yet I have seen him with Apame,
The royal concubine, the daughter
Of the famed Bartacus in slaughter;
And she'd sit at the king's right hand
30 "And take the crown like firebrand
From the king's head and put it on
Her own, and slap the king upon
The cheek with her left hand up-drawn.
31 "And then the king would stare at her
With mouth wide open at the spur.
If she smiles at him, then he laughs;
If she loses her temper gaffs,
He flatters her till she has calmed.
32 "Sirs, why are women so empalmed,
Since they do such things, more by half?"

Zerubbabel gives a sight of the court
Of Persian kings so intimate in sport
That I sit back amazed to see that he
Dares mention concubine's past perfidy.
Zerubbabel's a Sufi in the track
Of ages since that dared to turn a back
On kings to spy on caravan saray
Where come and go pass under changeless
sky.

Beloved, the argument that woman is
Stronger than king or wine embellishes
A greater argument, the tone of truth,
That changeless rules over old age and
youth:

Despite the forces that compete for rule,

There is no I but You, how deep the pool.

33 Then the king and the nobles looked
At one another; then he brooked
To speak about the truth: 34 "Sirs, are
Not women strong? The earth runs far,
And heaven is high, the sun is swift
In its course, for it makes the round
Of heavens and comes back safe and sound
To its place in single day's bound.

35 "Is it not great who does these things?
But truth is great, above all things.

36 "The whole earth calls upon the truth,
And heaven blesses her with ruth.

All God's works quake and tremble, and
With Him nothing wicked will stand.

37 "Wine's impotent, and so's the king,
Women are without strength of wing,
All sons of men lack in their power,

All their works endure but an hour,
To perish under the truth's tower.

38 "But truth endures in strength to be
Alive to rule eternity.

What is true in all things to see around
Upon the universe, upon the ground,
Is but reflection of reality,
Of truth, and You alone, Beloved, I see
Are Truth to live and rule eternally.

Illusion that I am and do is just
The mirror of Your being on the dust.
There is no truth nor any power to be
Beside You only, only You are found.
Evil is defined by the ring that thinks
There is any reality on brinks
Except You only. All creation lies
In pretence of its being in disguise.
I turn to see You and greet my demise.

39 Truth is impartial, does not pay
Mind to a preference one day,
But always does the righteous thing
Instead of wickedness on wing.

All men approve her deeds 40 and there
Is no wrong in her judgement's care.
To her is power and rulership,
Strength and majesty to the hip.
Blessed be the God of truth aware!"

41 He stopped his speaking, then the folk
All shouted saying at a stroke,
"Great is truth, and strongest of all!"

42 The king then lent to him his call,

"Ask what you want, even more than
What's promised, we will give the span
To you, for you have proved to be
The wisest among all the three.
And so you shall sit next to me,
And be called my kinsman *in spe*."

The argument of this reality
In which all men live both the bond and
free

Ought to speak to all minds and hearts as in
This fairy-tale, but as I see men win
Their heart's desires from day to day
I doubt that such wisdom in any royal bout
Could save the day. The reason for the rout
Is simply that Zerubbabel is stout
In rhetoric. It's rare truth and that feet
Combine, but this time all can share the
treat.

The silver tongue convinces, not the truth,
Yet truth wins not only the callow youth
But ever and all time, she cannot fail,
Since port of truth is under every sail.

43 Then he said to the king, "Remember
The vow you made to build the ember
Of old Jerusalem, the day

When you achieved the royal sway,
44 "And to send back the golden pots
Taken from Jerusalem's lots,

Which Cyrus set apart when he
Entered Babylon's artistry,
And vowed to send them all back there.

45 "You vowed to build the temple's share,
That Edomites burned when Judah
Was laid waste by Chaldeans' claw.

46 And now, O lord the king, it's this
That I request in benefice,
And this befits your greatness too.

I pray therefore that you make true
The oath whose fulfilment that you
Vowed to the King of heaven to do
With your own lips *with which you kiss*."

The golden pots! The vessels most desired,
Named with the name in prophecy and
fired,

Hemda in every parchment where the kings
Once had their good deeds praised and
other things

Reported to their shame. The golden pots!
When Cyrus set apart the glowing lots

And promised to rebuild the castle where
King David used to reign upon the stair,
He started a tradition Persian rulers
Would be reminded of by their home-
schoolers.

Beloved, I too seek that the inner room,
The home of ark and Decalogue till doom,
Be restored in myself and that the weight
Of love fall on the hillside where I wait.

47 Darius the king rose, and kissed
Him, and wrote letters undismissed
For him to all the treasurers
And governors and army fers
And satraps, that they should protect
Him and all who were of elect
To go up with him to rebuild
Jerusalem and have it filled.

48 He wrote epistles to all chiefs
In Coelesyria's reliefs
And in Phoenicia and to
Those in Lebanon, to bring too
Cedar logs from Lebanon to
Jerusalem, and to help him
Rebuild the city *firm and trim*.

49 And he wrote for all the Jews who
Went up from his kingdom unto
Judea for their freedom's stores,
That no officer or satrap
Or chief or treasurer in rap
Should force his way inside their doors;
50 That all the country where they stayed
Should be theirs without tribute laid;
The Idumeans should give up
The Jewish regions held in cup;
51 That twenty talents every year
Should be set for the building gear
Of the house till finished and sere.
52 Besides that ten talents a year
For burnt offerings offered with fear
On the altar on every day,
According to what the laws say
To make seventeen offerings' way.

Beloved, I lay the morning prayer and see
The dawn grow brighter from my window
tree.

I count throughout the day prostrations
where

I lay my head in sacrifice and bear
Before Your throne my offerings
seventeen.

When noon is past I come at once serene
From morning's labours and see the strong
light

Of day upon eight offerings before night.
At dusk I bring the perfect, full amount
And bow down seven times by evening
count.

And thus the seventeen are daily laid
And thus Your true command is fully paid.
But I it is who reaps the good reward
Renewed in life and in the flaming sword.

53 And all who came from Babylon
To build the city as was drawn
Should have their freedom, they and their
Children and all the priests in share.

54 He wrote also concerning their
Support and the priests' clothing fur
In which they were to minister.

55 He ordered Levites' provisions
Until the time the temple's runs
Should be done and Jerusalem
Rebuilt by the king's stratagem.

56 He ordered land and wages be
Provided for town guards in fee.

57 And he sent back from Babylon
All the pots which Cyrus had drawn,
Everything Cyrus ordered done,
He also commanded be done
And sent up to Jerusalem.

The city Babylon's long fallen through
The cunning of Persian and Median crew,
Who diverted the river running by
The watergates, and so lies under sky.

I peer out from the everlasting gates
And see the rise and fall of human states,
And reckon on the sheep scattered to
browse

Among the ruins of contented cows.
Beloved, I seek my freedom from the walls
That once encircled Babylon's rich stalls,
And take my way across the desert where
The golden city meets my eager stare,
The Kidron sinks below my watching gaze,
And peace at last enters my counted days.

58 When the young man went out, he
turned

His face to heaven toward the burn
Of old Jerusalem, and praised
The King of heaven, saying amazed,

59 "From You is victory; from You
Is wisdom, and Yours is the due
Glory. I am Your servant true.
60 "Blessed are You, who have given me
Wisdom; I give You thanks in fee,
O Lord of our fathers." 61 So he
Took the epistles, and went to
Babylon and told this all to
His brothers. 62 And they praised the God
Of their ancestors in the sod,
Because He had given them release
And permission on the increase
63 To go and build Jerusalem
And the temple called by His name,
And they feasted, with music and
Rejoicing, for seven days' *band*.

For seven days I feast and praise Your
name
While righteously another bears the shame
Of fasting in obedience to command.
I feast on food and fasting out of hand.
Your presence at the humblest meal atones
For lack of fine sweetmeats and chicken
bones.
Your presence at the secret fast tastes better
Than pleasant bread and drink made to the
letter.
And so I spend my seven days in sport,
While wooden hut turns into marble court.
Count me not righteous for the things I do,
Give me no great reward for deed and true,
I find enough and more to spare of good
As I revel where others mourn and should.

1 Esdras 5

1 After this the chiefs of each house
Of the ancestors chose with spouse
To go up, with their tribes and wives
And sons and daughters and their hives
Of servants and maids and their cattle.
2 Darius sent with them for battle
A thousand horsemen to lead back
To Jerusalem without flack,
And with music of drums and flutes;
3 And all their brothers danced *in boots*.
And he made them go up with them.
4 These are the names in stratagem
Of the men who went up, by their
Fathers' houses in the tribes' share,
Over their groups: 5 the priests, the sons
Of Phinehas, of Aaron's sons;

Jeshua son of Jozadak,
Son of Seraiah, and the hack
Joakim Zerubbabel's son,
The son of Shealtiel when done:
Of David's house, of lineage of
Phares, of tribe of Judah's *love*,
6 Who spoke wise words before Darius
The king of the Persians *to spy us*,
In the second year of his reign,
In the month of Nisan profane,
The first month of the year to gain.

I wonder how many men marched in band
To play the drums and flutes throughout the
land
Along the road from Shushan to the grand
Hills of Judea and the open hand
Of broken, torn Jerusalem to stand.
Of all the men who marched and played the
fife
For joy or drummed for man and child and
wife
To joy along the way toward the town,
I wonder how many of them went down
To Palestine to stay, how many trekked
The weary way back from the trip out
decked.
The life of a musician can be hard
When journeys are made here and yon with
pard
And jet-lag stumps even with credit card.

7 These are the men of Judea
Who came up out of their bed straw
Of the captivity, whom king
Nebuchadnezzar of the ring
Of Babylon had carried off
To Babylon for scorn and scoff
8 And who came to Jerusalem
And the rest of Judea's hem,
Each to his own town. They came there:
Zerubbabel and Jeshua,
Nehemiah, Seraiah's share,
Resaiah, Bigvai, Mordecai,
Bilshan, Mispar, Reeliah,
Rehum, and Baanah, all their chiefs.
9 The number of men of the folk
And their leaders above the yoke:
The sons of Parosh, two thousand
One hundred seventy-two in band.
The sons of Shephatiah, four
Hundred and seventy-two more.

10 The sons of Arah, seven hundred
And fifty-six, so many led.
11 And then the sons of Pahathmoab,
Of the sons of Jeshua and Joab,
Two thousand eight hundred and twelve.
12 The sons of Elam dig and delve,
One thousand two hundred in store
And added to that fifty-four.
The sons of Zattu, nine hundred
And forty-five came without dread.
The sons of Chorbe, seven hundred
And five. The sons of Bani late,
Numbered six hundred forty-eight.
13 The sons of Bebai, six hundred
Twenty-three. The sons of Azgad,
One thousand three hundred in view
And finally add twenty-two.
14 The sons of Adonikam, six
Hundred and sixty-seven picks.
The sons of Bigvai, two thousand
And sixty-six all in one band.
The sons of Adin, four hundred
And fifty-four in one band led.

Over the generations of the way
In captive thrall and royal heathen sway
The word was whispered down to everyone
Born in the far-off places under sun
The name of his own city and the place
Where his ancestors ran the righteous race.
So every man returned to his own town
And saw the longed-for mother in the gown
Of sparkling dawn. I wonder if the rest
After the mythic songs looked for the best.
I wonder if the barren fields and stone
Seemed compensation for the Persian bone.
Or were they disappointed with the light
New wakened on Jerusalem in sight?

15 The sons of Ater, that is of
Hezekiah, ninety-two, *love*.
The sons of Kilan and Azetas,
Sixty-seven, *enough to defeat us*.
The sons of Azaru, count four
Hundred and thirty-two *in store*.
16 The sons of Ananias, one
Hundred and one. Sons of Arom.
The sons of Bezai, three hundred
And twenty-three. The sons outspread
Of Jorah, one hundred and twelve.
17 The sons of Baiterus *to shelve*
Three thousand five. The sons to see

Of Bethlehem count twenty-three
And one hundred. 18 Netophah's men,
Fifty-five *to appear again*.
The men of Anathoth *relate*
Up to one hundred fifty-eight.
The men of Bethasmoth *in crew*
Amount in all to forty-two.
19 The men of Kiriatharim *live*
Count up in all to twenty-five.
Men of Chephirah and Beeroth,
Seven hundred forty-three *troth*.
20 The Chadians and Ammidians,
Four hundred twenty-two for plans.
The men of Ramah and Geba,
Six hundred twenty-one *in awe*.
21 The men of Michmas, one hundred
And twenty-two, and the men led
Of Bethel, fifty-two. The sons
Of Magbish, one hundred *on buns*
And fifty-six. 22 And then the sons
Of second Elam and Ono,
Seven hundred twenty-five *show*.
And then the sons of Jericho,
Three hundred forty-five *to go*.

Beloved, the numbers do not always sync
With Ezra and Esdras the way I think
They should. Just see that twenty-eight is
more
Than twenty-three, five more in fact in
store.
What shall I do with five more men than
those
I planned for in their princely roils and
rows?
Some doubter's likely to step on my toes
And point out how Your Word is out of
print,
Or worse yet inaccurate for a hint.
Beloved, I retrench as I swallow pride
While pretending I am still on Your side.
If nothing else, at least the Decalogue
Is word consistent to a Dervish dog,
And so I wag my tail and take the ride.

23 The sons of Senaah, three thousand
Three hundred and thirty in band.
24 The priests: the sons of Jedaiah
Who was the son of Jeshua,
Of the sons of Anasib, nine
Hundred and seventy-two *fine*.
The sons of Immer, one thousand

And fifty-two *upon the land*.

25 The sons of Pashhur, one thousand

Two hundred forty-seven *stand*.

The sons of Harim, one thousand

And seventeen *in finished band*.

26 The Levites: sons of Jeshua

And Kadmiel, Bannas, Sudias' *paw*,

Seventy-four. 27 The temple singers:

The sons of Asaph, *all humdingers*,

One hundred twenty-eight in a'.

28 The gatekeepers: the sons of Shallum,

The sons of Ater, sons of Talmon,

Sons of Akkub, sons of Hatita,

The sons of Shobai *and none sweeter*,

In all one hundred thirty-nine.

If one hundred and twenty-eight have come

To sing upon the temple of kingdom,

Then there are lacking of the quire the rate

A hundred and sixty of apostate.

Twelve times the twenty-four were set in

room

By David, my Beloved, till time of doom,

And make the secret congregation of

The temple spires of singing sound and

love.

Beloved, I stand alone beneath the tree

Of fir and pine and birch for aspen's glee

And raise a slight voice in David's fair

speech

To sound Your glory for the faith of each.

I know that throughout earth the chosen fair

In full numbers join me to praise Your

share.

29 The temple servants all dressed fine:

Sons of Ziha, of Hasupha,

The sons of Tabbaoth in awe,

The sons of Keros, of Siaha,

Sons of Padon, of Lebanah,

As well as sons of Hagabah,

30 The sons of Akkub, of Uthai,

The sons of Ketab *on the sly*,

The sons of Hagab, of Shamlai,

The sons of Hana, of Cathua,

The sons of Gahar, *and to view her*

31 The sons of Reaiah, the sons

Of Rezin, *and come in their tons*

The sons of Nekoda, the sons

Of Chezib, the sons of Gazzam,

The sons of Uzza's *epigram*,

Sons of Paseah, of Hasrah,

Sons of Besai, sons of Asnah,

The sons of the Meunites a',

The sons of Nephisim, the sons

Of Bakbuk, sons of Hakupha,

Sons of Asur, of Pharakim,

The sons of Bazluth *for a dream*,

32 The sons of Mehida, the sons

Of Cutha, sons of Charea,

Sons of Barkos, of Sisera,

Sons of Temah, of Neziah,

The sons of Hatipha in a'.

33 The sons of Solomon's servants:

The sons of Hassophereth *dance*,

The sons of Peruda, the sons

Of Jaalah, sons of Lozon's *buns*,

The sons of Giddel, and the ones

Of Shephatiah, 34 and the sons

Of Hattil, and as it may seem

Sons of Pochereth-hazzebaim,

The sons of Sarothie, the sons

Of Masiah, the sons of Gas,

The sons of Addus *at a pass*,

The sons of Subas, of Apherra,

The sons of Barodis *not narrow*,

The sons of Shaphat, of Ami.

35 All the temple servants *to spy*

And sons of Solomon's servants

Three hundred seventy-two *to prance*.

The children of the servants of the son

Of David now return when day is done.

The centuries revolved about the way

That empires rise and fall by light of day.

The night work of the blessed in secret

word

Is still transmitted by the golden bird

Of passionate faith that seals the lips

outside,

But keeps the heart in faith's unspoken

pride.

A mother tells the second child and last,

A father spins the secret of the past,

While many go from cradle down to grave

Without an inkling of the Psalter's brave.

I too have heard the message given by

choice

To pass to both the worthies who rejoice.

36 The following are those who came

Up from Telmelah place of fame

And Telharsha, under the lead

Of Cherub, Addan, and with speed

Immer, 37 though they could not prove by
 Their ancestors' houses *or rye*
 That they belonged to Israel:
 The sons of Delaiah *the swell*
 Son of Tobiah, the sons of
 Nekoda, six hundred above
 And fifty-two. 38 Of the priests these
 Had taken the priesthood *with ease*
 But were not found recorded there:
 The sons of Habaiah, the sons
 Of Hakkoz, the sons of Jaddus
 Who had married Agia *fair*,
 One of Barzillai's daughters' guns,
 And was called by his name *in bus*.
 39 And when the genealogy
 Of these men was sought in degree
 Of records and it was not found,
 They threw them out upon the ground
 Of serving as priests safe and sound.
 40 And Nehemiah and Attharias
 Told them not to share in *nepharious*
 Holy things till a high priest come
 To wear the Urim and Thummim.

Even the ancient priests sometimes felt
 right
 By taking family name of wife for spite.
 The patriarchal angle is not sure
 And fast, but may be changed into the pure
 Of matriarchy without falling flat.
 Of course when Ezra gets a chance at that
 He questions all the records and the truth
 Of such doings among the callow youth.
 But You, Beloved, need no line of defence,
 No silsila nor chain of handing pence
 In blessing to the sons and daughters round
 The table of the human light and sound.
 I take no name but Yours, Beloved, and
 find
 I need no other name, but among blind.

41 All those of Israel, twelve or more
 Years of age, and besides the store
 Of servants and maids, were in count
 Forty-two thousand to amount
 To three hundred and sixty; 42 their
 Servants and maids still in their care
 Were seven thousand three hundred
 And thirty-seven left in dread;
 There were two hundred forty-five
 Musicians and singers *to thrive*.

Ah, this is better, now the number rises
 And lacks only among the solemn prizes
 Forty-three singers with their harps in tune
 To cantillate Your word to sun and moon.
 Two hundred forty-five to speak the word
 In temple court and standing undeterred
 Arise in melodies of fire and grace
 To find the ivory throne and divine face.
 Beloved, I joy to know the spaces fill
 As silently as cows upon the hill
 Come down beside the fencerow and the
 lane
 And through the smoking guardhouse
 without pain
 To find the gentle evening and the calm
 Of cowhouse well provided with the balm.

43 There were four hundred thirty-five
 Camels, and seven thousand and
 Thirty-six horses in the band,
 Two hundred and forty-five mules,
 And five thousand to follow rules
 Of five hundred twenty-five donkeys.
 44 Some of the heads of families' tonkeys,
 When they came to Alohims' house
 Which is in Jerusalem's *grouse*,
 Sware they would build the place right
 there
 Upon its site to their best care,
 45 And that they'd give the sacred fund
 For the work thousand *rubicund*
 Minas of gold, five thousand more
 Of silver, and one hundred store
 Of priests' clothing *inside the door*.

The heads of families will always share
 Their pigeoned wealth to relieve from the
 care
 That death will swallow up their gathered
 fame
 And leave them generations without name.
 The brassy lettered docket tells the game,
 The year and praises of the donor's way,
 And some stop to read of the bright display.
 Beloved, I set myself no monument
 In gold or silver, star, sun or crescent,
 But take my memory of self from You
 Upon the Sabbath day in humble pew
 To sing with hedgehog and the magpie till
 The sun has set against my fading hill.

46 The priests, the Levites, and some of

The people settled in *the cove*
Jerusalem and neighbourhood,
And the temple singers *for good*,
The gatekeepers, and all the folk
Of Israel in their own towns' *yoke*.

I am a temple singer though without
The pedigree of Levite and the shout
Of bloodline from Egyptian painted crew.
And yet I raise my voice in praise of You.
I am a temple singer as I take
The melodies of David for Your sake
And drop them in the waiting Sabbath
dawn

To hear them echo in the water drawn.
Beloved, I sing with temple singer now
What centuries ago was on the brow
Of Solomon's house and the house that
came

After it though of some diminished fame.
Today the house invisible is wrought
In every tone the Psalms of David taught.

47 When the seventh month came, the sons
Of Israel sat in their home runs,
Then gathered as a man before
The square of the east gate and door.

48 Then Jeshua Jozadak's son,
With his fellow priests, and *the gun*
Zerubbabel Shealtiel's son,
With his kinsmen, took their own places
And prepared the altar *with graces*
Of Israel's Alohim *in traces*,
49 To offer holocausts on it,
By the directions of the fit
Book of Moses Alohim's man.

50 And some joined with them from the
span

Of other peoples of the land.
And they set up the altar there
In its place, for all the folk's share
In the land were both foes to them
And stronger in their stratagem.
They offered sacrifices set
At their right times, holocausts met
To YHWH morning and evening yet.

The morning and the evening traces still
The streaks of glory on my nearest hill,
And set an altar and a slaughter ground
For human wills to tumble and to sound
The tinkle and the gurgle on the way

To disappear upon the watered bay.
The evening and the morning turn around
And pause to mind the memory once found
In the creation of the world of light
And air and firmament and heavenly height
Above the trailing vine and seed and flower
That introduces fish and beastly power.
The morning finds the evening still
entranced
By altars smoking where the faithful
danced.

51 They kept the feast of tabernacles,
As it's commanded in law's *hackles*,
And offered the right sacrifice
Every day there and to suffice.

52 And after that the offerings made
Always and sacrifice parade
On Sabbaths and the first day of
The months and all the feasts thereof.
53 And all who had made any vow
To Alohim would come kowtow
In sacrifice to Alohim,
From first day of the seventh month,
Though the temple of Alohim
Was not yet built as had been once.

The daily sacrifice rises to meet
The double Sabbath offering for a treat,
And that waits for the first day in the round
Of months to find the overflow on ground
Until the yearly Sabbaths make a sound
Of joy and praise for dancing hands and
feet.

Beloved, I search the skies to know the way
To count the days and months set in array
From solstice to the bright midsummer day
When darkness fails to meet me where I
pray.

Beloved, I search the earth to find the path
That leads to love and hope instead of
wrath,
And find the sacrificial footprints there
That disappear beyond the silver stair.

54 They gave money to masons and
Carpenters, and food and drink's hand
55 And carts to the Sidonians
And the Tyrians, to bring spans
Of cedar logs from Lebanon
And transport them in rafts upon
The harbour of Joppa, by law

They had in writing from the claw
 Of Cyrus king of Persians' *paw*.
 56 In second year after their coming
 To temple of Alohim *humming*
 In Jerusalem, in the second
 Month, Zerubbabel the son *beckoned*
 Of Shealtiel and Jeshua
 The son of Jozadak set claw
 To start together with their brothers
 And the Levite priests and all others
 Who had come to Jerusalem
 From the captivity's condemn;
 57 And they laid the foundation of
 The temple of Alohim's love
 On the first day of second month
 In second year after they once
 Arrived in Judea and in
 Jerusalem *once to begin*.

It took more than a year to set the stone
 Upon the footer of the temple throne,
 As though eternity was time enough
 To build a temple in the city's rough.
 I am impatient with my day and call,
 And wonder if my life begins at all
 As I embark upon the second half
 Of century that is my life to quaff.
 Beloved, the waiting on the foreign street,
 The memory of roads before my fleet
 White martyrdom gives nothing to repeat.
 I watch in silence how the setting sun
 Fades on the path that I have just begun
 And find my steps have slowed down from
 my run.

58 And they appointed the Levites
 Who were twenty or more by rights
 In years of age to be in charge
 Of the work of YHWH *by and large*.
 And Jeshua got up, with him
 His sons and brothers and the trim
 Kadmiel his brother and the son
 Of Jeshua Emadabun
 And the sons of Joda the son
 Of Iliadun, with their sons
 And brothers, all the Levites' *guns*,
 As one man to cooperate
 On house of Alohim's estate.
 And so the builders came and built
 YHWH's temple *made of stone and gilt*.

The builders that build my house every
 day,
 The house in which I praise You and I
 pray,
 The temple of my inner chamber's wealth
 Where I entreat You carefully in stealth
 Are not the Levites of Your chosen brood.
 They are a lesser crowd ragged and rude.
 They are the syllable untutored tongue
 Recites of Psalm from silver rung to rung.
 Beloved, the temple of the song I sing
 Is all that's needed to remember king
 And son of king upon the royal seat
 Until I find my place where You entreat.
 The stony walls that chamber me around
 Ring and echo beneath the sacred sound.

59 The priests stood arrayed in their
 clothes,
 Musical instruments arose
 And trumpets, and the Levites, sons
 Of Asaph, with cymbals *in tons*,
 60 In praising YHWH and blessing him,
 According to the orders *grim*
 Of David king of Israel;
 61 And they sang hymns *of Psalms* to give
 Thanks to YHWH that His mercies live
 Forever on all Israel,
 And His glory *there rests a spell*.
 62 And all the folk blew on their trumpets
 And shouted with a sound *like strumpets*,
 To praise YHWH for the building of
 The house of YHWH *in divine love*.

I too take instrument of string and strum
 The melody of Psalm and while I hum
 I find the trumpet at my ear has come
 If only in the light imagining
 That rises from my gold and silver string.
 I too take harpy handle and I stroke
 The strings until I hear above the smoke
 Of sacrifice and incense the clear note
 That raises me above the heavenly boat
 To look down on the maple and the oak.
 Beloved, as I grasp wooden harp with hold
 Unhandy and turn voice of Psalm to gold
 Of love, list to the prayer and give me room
 Before the breaking of the lyre of doom.

63 Some of the Levite priests and heads
 Of ancestral houses in spreads,
 Old men who'd seen the former house,

Came to this building then to grieve
 With loud weeping *out of their beds*,
 64 And others with trumpets and joy,
 65 So that the people could not hear
 The trumpets for weeping *on ear*.
 For the crowd blew the trumpets loud,
 So the sound was heard *to the cloud*,
 66 And when the foes of Judah's tribe
 And Benjamin's heard the strong vibe,
 They came to find out what the sound
 Of trumpets meant *upon the ground*.

I have the choice, Beloved, before the
 flame

Of this world's hoarse anatomy and game
 To weep for the fact that the golden year
 And golden place departed with its gear,
 Or rejoice that the slender thread of truth
 Arises once more in the day of youth.
 I have the choice to sing or weep a while,
 To stand and whimper or then walk a mile.
 Sometimes my days are spent in weeping
 for
 The loss of sweetcakes from my meagre
 store.
 Sometimes days just as cloudy up above
 Find me rejoicing in the pale of love.
 The human heart is treacherous in each,
 While You provide both pit and luscious
 peach.

67 And they learned that those who'd
 returned

From the captivity had earned
 The temple for YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel and not a dream.
 68 So they approached Zerubbabel
 And Jeshua and the heads well
 Of the ancestral houses and
 Said to them, "Let us build in band.
 69 "For we obey your Lord as you
 And we've been sacrificing too
 Since the time of Esarhaddon
 King of the Assyrians drawn,
 Who brought us here *from land of dawn*."
 70 Zerubbabel and Jeshua
 And the heads of ancestral paw
 In Israel said unto them,
 "You have nothing in stratagem
 To do with us in building *gleam*
 Of house for YHWH our Alohim.
 71 "For we alone will build it for

YHWH of Israel, as Cyrus swore,
 The king of the Persians commanded
 Us to build it *when we had landed*."
 72 And yet the peoples of the land
 Insisted with a heavy hand
 On those in Judea to stand,
 Cut off their supplies, and in band
 Hindered their building; 73 and by plots
 And rhetoric and rebel lots
 Prevented finishing the room
 As long as King Cyrus was groom.
 And they were prevented from work
 For two years until reign *and perk*
 Of king Darius *wiped their smirk*.

Racism of old Zion's folk may seem
 Obscurantist and product of a dream.
 But see the opposition it awoke,
 Which proves them right in their refusal's
 stroke.

If those who offered help had been sincere
 And righteous in their offer of more gear,
 They would have left the builders in their
 peace

After their offer met refusal's grease.
 Beloved, refuse my heart and home and
 hope

And leave me to hang myself on my rope,
 But I shall come again before Your face
 And whisper my love to Your fading trace.
 I shall not leave importunate demand
 But seek You now my Love in every land.

1 Esdras 6

1 In the second year of the reign
 Of Darius, prophets *in gain*
 Haggai and Zechariah
 The son of Iddo spoke *in awe*
 To the Jews who were in Judea
 And in Jerusalem to see her,
 They prophesied to them in name
 Of YHWH Israel's Alohim.
 2 Then Zerubbabel the son of
 Shealtiel, Jeshua son of
 Jozadak arose and began
 To build the house of YHWH *in scan*
 Which is in *fair* Jerusalem,
 By YHWH's prophets' help there with
 them.

3 But at the same time Sisinnus
 Ruler of Syria and *with ease*
 Phoenicia, Sathrabuzanes

And their mates came and said to them,
 4 "By whose command and stratagem
 Are you building this house *and crown*,
 To finish other things in town?
 And who are the builders sent down?"
 5 The Jewish elders fared them well,
 Because YHWH's providence *in spell*
 Was over captive *Israel*.
 6 And they were not stopped from their
 work
 Till word was sent *without a quirk*
 To Darius about them and
 A report received in their hand.
 7 A copy of the letter which
 Sisinnus ruler of the pitch
 Of Syria, Phoenicia,
 And Sathrabuzanes, and a'
 Their mates who ruled *by hand and claw*
 Syria and Phoenicia,
 Wrote and sent to Darius' *paw*.

The rise of empires was a time when all
 The kings in every place learned to hear
 call
 Of the great central civil servant's bawl.
 A standard in both language and in style,
 In goods and services in second mile,
 An army to keep robbers in their lair,
 A system of transport that all could share
 Made safe the roads and crossroads from
 the bear.

So rulers of Phoenicia and the old
 City of Damasque came, saw, and then told
 The central office what was going on.
 Beloved, I long for those days of the dawn,
 When people minded their own business
 drawn,
 And left the bureaucrats out in the cold.

8 "To King Darius, greeting. Let
 It be fully known to our pet
 The king that, when we went up to
 The land of Judea in view
 And came into Jerusalem,
 We found the Jewish elders' scum,
 Who had been in captivity,
 9 "Building Jerusalem's city
 With a big new temple for YHWH,
 Of cut stone and fine lumber laid
 In the new walls and on parade.
 10 "The work is pushing forward and
 Seems to be prospering in their hand,

Complete with splendour and well-planned.
 11 "We asked these elders, 'At whose word
 Are you building this temple stirred,
 And setting foundations unblurred?'
 12 "So that we might tell you in letter
 The name of leader and abettor,
 We asked them for a list of names
 Of those who are heads of their claims.
 13 "They answered us, 'We are the slaves
 Of YHWH Creator of *the waves*,
Of heaven and earth. 14 "The temple built
 Many years since by a king's hilt
 Of Israel, one great and strong,
 Was finished *for offerings and song*.

The son of David, a king great and strong
 In Israel, who did both right and gong,
 Built to Your name a temple shining fair,
 Above Jerusalem and Kidron there.
 The son of David, caught in father's dream,
 Erected marble walls and cedar beam
 And covered all with gold, covered with
 love,
 To echo Psalms in sacrifice above.
 Beloved, I too build daily on the house
 Despite the nightly nibble of the mouse,
 And see its spires arise in melody,
 The self-same Psalms of David on the lee.
 I too build as I sing with croaking voice
 In sorrow, hope, and love, I too rejoice.

15 "And when our dads sinned against
 YHWH
 Of Israel in the heavenly pew,
 Provoking Him, He turned them over
 To the hands of the royal rover
 Nebuchadnezzar of the city
 Of Babylon, who had no pity
 As king of the Chaldeans witty.
 16 "And they destroyed the temple and
 They burned it, and the folk in land
 They carried captive all away
 To Babylon *and there to stay*.
 17 "But in the first year Cyrus reigned
 Over Babylon's land unstained,
 King Cyrus decreed that this house
 Should be rebuilt *for men and spouse*.
 18 "And holy golden pots and those
 Of silver, which Nebuchadnezzar
 Had taken from the temple rows
 In Jerusalem as he says her
 To keep them in his temple's stows,

King Cyrus took these out again
 From Babylonian temple den,
 And handed over to the men
 Zerubbabel and Sheshbazzar
 The governor and popular
 19 "With orders to take all those pots
 Back and put them in temple lots
 At Jerusalem, and to build
 Again this temple to YHWH silled
 On its site in its former plots.
 20 "Then Sheshbazzar, when he got here,
 Set the foundations and the gear
 Of YHWH's temple which is in *fair*
 Jerusalem, and though they've been
 Building it from that time to spin
 Till now, it still has not got ready.'
 21 "So therefore, if it's wise and steady,
 O king, let search be made throughout
 The royal archives under clout
 Of our lord king in Babylon;
 22 And if it's found the building done
 On YHWH's house in Jerusalem
 Was with consent of stratagem
 Of king Cyrus, and so approved
 By our lord the king, be he moved
 To send us orders for these things."

Mid-level management makes all the fuss,
 And yet I see the problem's not a truss
 Of my own day alone, but since the time
 That such were invented to ignore rhyme
 And bite the prose for bread, the little mind
 Has added to the deaf ear and the blind.
 The interference of the fatal march
 Of civil servants is enough to parch
 The soul and wither all creation's fire.
 Let all such people rot in their own mire.
 Beloved, I see the problem of small kings,
 Who go to war with robber gangs on wings,
 But central government compounds the
 gore
 And keeps the middle soul upon its shore.

23 Darius then commanded search
 In every royal archive's perch
 On file in Babylon. And in
 Ecbatana, the fortress bin
 Which is in Median land, a scroll
 Appeared with writing on the roll:
 24 "In the first year of Cyrus' reign,
 King Cyrus ordered *for his gain*
 The building of the house of YHWH

In Jerusalem for the due
 Repeated offerings made by fire,
 25 Its height to be as in a spire
 Sixty arm-lengths, so many wide,
 Sixty arm-lengths, all set in course
 Of cut stone three and then perforce
 One of wood new and local grown,
 The cost to be paid by the throne
 Of Cyrus the king, 26 and the pots
 Of holiness of YHWH's house plots,
 Both gold and silver once waylaid
 By Nebuchadnezzar's parade
 Out of Jerusalem's house and
 Taken to Babylon's far land,
 Should be brought back to temple fair
 And in Jerusalem to share
 Where they had been once kept with care."
 27 Darius then ordered Sinsinnes,
 Syrian and Phoenician chief means,
 And Sathrabuzanes, and their
 Mates, and those appointed to share
 As local rulers in Syria
 And Phoenicia, to withhold claw
 From the place, and to let the man
 Zerubbabel, servant in scan
 Of YHWH, Judea's governor,
 And the elders of the Jews' shore
 To build there YHWH's house and its door.

The founding of the Jewish faith is here,
 Not in the early times of Moses' cheer
 Or Abraham's or even David's throne.
 Darius is responsible alone.
 He sets his spies in Zion to look out
 Upon the local civil servants' rout
 And tell him what the governors would do.
 That's why the governors take interest due.
 Beloved, is there a faith on earth at all
 That has a standing spire and granite wall
 But is the dupe of royal power and scope?
 Is there a faith at all without a pope?
 I do believe that none is to be found,
 Yet I flee to Your name on earthly ground.

28 "And I command it to be done,
 And full cooperation won
 To help the men who have returned
 From the captivity they earned
 To Judea, until the house
 Of YHWH is finished for a douse,
 29 "And that out of the taxes turned
 From Coelesyria and learned

From Phoenicia one part be
 Carefully provided in fee
 To these men, to Zerubbabel
 The governor, for offerings' spell
 To YHWH, for bulls and rams and lambs,
 30 And wheat and salt, *but never clams*,
 And grape juice and oil, in their round
 Each year, without arguing sound,
 For daily provision in use
 As the priests order, *no excuse*,
 In Jerusalem, 31 that there may
 Be offerings made before the sway
 Of Alohim Most High for king
 And his family and prayers to bring
 On behalf of their life and spring."
 32 And he ordered if any should
 Transgress or abrogate for good
 Any of the things written here,
 A truss should be removed with cheer
 From his house and he hanged thereon,
 And his goods forfeit to king drawn.
 33 "So may YHWH, whose name's lifted
 there,
 Destroy every king and the share
 Of people who would lay a hand
 To hurt the house of YHWH and land
 Of Jerusalem. 34 "I, the king
 Darius, have decreed the thing
 To be done with all diligence
 As written here without offence."

The purpose of the Jewish faith once made
 Was simply in the thing for which they
 prayed.

Darius wanted priests and men to make
 Prayers for himself and for his family's
 sake.

The matter is so simple as that sum.
 No more of history's needed on the hum.
 All else is rests and remnants living still
 After the purpose of the thing to fill
 Was long gone. Rabbis search the Word in
 vain

To find a scrap of hope, but since the reign
 Of Persian king has failed, there is not
 sense

In keeping up the Sanhedrin's pretence.
 The Decalogue alone is fast and true,
 All else is mist and shadows on the view.

1 Esdras 7

1 Now Sisinnus the governor

Of Coelesyria and *the shore*
 Of Phoenicia, Sathrabuzanes,
 And their mates set out for their gains,
 Followed the orders of the king
 Darius, 2 watching everything
 With care, the holy task to bring
 Help to the elders of the Jews
 And the chief officers *in crews*
 In the temple. 3 The holy task
 Prospered, while prophets *without mask*
 Haggai and Zechariah spoke
 In prophecy, 4 and at a stroke
 They finished it by the command
 Of YHWH Alohim of the band
 Of Israel. So with consent
 Of Cyrus and Darius meant
 And Artaxerxes, Persian kings,
 5 The holy house *and furnishings*
 Was done by the twenty-third day
 Of month of Adar, in the way
 Of King Darius's sixth year.
 6 And the folk of Israel *appear*,
 The priests, the Levites, and the rest
 Of those from captivity's *zeit*
 Who joined them, did according to
 The writ in book of Moses due.

Beloved, see how the civil servants
 scramble

To obey orders of the earthly bramble!
 But let Your Word go forth in purity
 Without the hand of king to set it free
 And they will turn against it in a spree.
 The human heart is darkened by the choice
 Made to turn from commandments to
 rejoice

In wicked ways and wicked lays of din,
 All grovelling in prodigies of sin.
 Beloved, see how the civil servants now
 Turn from Your truth to set the evil plough
 Upon the backs of poor and needy where
 The greed of merchants struggles for its
 share.

I turn from every church and synagogue,
 From every mosque and perch caught in the
 fog.

7 They offered at the dedication
 Of the temple of YHWH's *elation*
 One hundred bulls, two hundred rams,
 And finally four hundred lambs,

8 And twelve he-goats for Israel's sin

According to the number in
The twelve leaders of Israel's tribes;
9 And the priests *without diatribes*
And the Levites stood decked out in
Their clothing according to kin,
For service to YHWH Alohim
Of Israel as by the *trim*
Book of Moses, and the gatekeepers
Were at each gate *to watch the sweepers*.

10 The people of Israel who came
From the captivity *in flame*
Kept the Passover on the day
Number fourteen of first month's way,
After the priests and Levites were
Purified together *on spur*.
11 Not all of the returned captives
Were purified, but *in the sieves*
The Levites were all cleansed together,
12 And they sacrificed *at the tether*
Passover lamb for all returned
Captives and for brothers *unspurned*
The priests and for themselves *all earned*.
13 And Israel's folk who came back from
Captivity ate it, *in sum*
All those who had departed from
The country's folk's abominations
And sought YHWH *for their own in*
rations.

14 They kept feast of unleavened bread
For seven days, and joyed instead
Before YHWH, 15 because He had turned
The Assyrians' king's will that churned
Against them to strengthen their hand
To *stand before and serve in band*
YHWH Alohim of Israel's *land*.

The word abomination is a thing
Spoken as euphemism for the ring
Of idols that swept down upon the land
Of Israel from the Amorite to stand
In awful witness of the human heart
Desiring evil instead of the smart.
Who turn from the idol to You alone
To worship only You upon Your throne
Stand to receive the great reward at last
To see Your face invisible in cast.
I eat the yeastless crust and wait the day
When judgement shall fall on the world to
stay

And help and hope no longer seem to go
Unbidden and unsavoured in the show.

1 Esdras 8

1 After these things, when Artaxerxes,
King of the Persians *and such jerksies*
Was ruling, then came Ezra son
Of Seraiah, one who was son
Of Azariah, of Hilkliah,
Son of Shallum *and not to fry her*,
2 Son of Zadok, Ahitub's son,
Son of Amariah, the son
Of Uzzi, son of Bukki, son
Of Abishua, Phineas' gun,
Son of Eleazar, son of
Aaron the chief priest, *man of love*.
3 This Ezra came from Babylon
As a scribe skilled in Moses *drawn*,
The law given by Alohim
Of Israel, *and not a dream*.
4 The king honoured him and gave ear
To all of his requests in fear.
5 There came with him up to the town
Jerusalem some of the gown
Of Israel, some of the priests
And Levites and singers in feasts
And gatekeepers and temple slaves,
6 In the seventh year of the reign
Of Artaxerxes, in *the gain*
Of the fifth month which was the king's
Seventh year; for they left *the springs*
Of Babylon on the first day
Of the first month and made their way
To Jerusalem on first day
Of the fifth month, by the success
Of the trip YHWH gave their address.
7 For Ezra had great knowledge, so
He left out nothing from *the glow*
Of YHWH's law or his commandments,
But taught all Israel *with good sense*
All ordinances and judgments.

The more I read Your law, Beloved, the
more

My ignorance is multiplied on shore,
And yet I must admit the faithless crowd
That stumbles at my side is so unploughed
That even ignorance of mine makes it
Seem that the human fodder is unfit.
Beloved, I read again and simplify,
I struggle with the sharp words and
comply,

And pray that I leave nothing undone yet
That You require of the created set.
Why should I worry so, when preachers say

That salvation is free and without pay?
The reason is that breath still comes to
stray
In nostrils with or without cross in sway.

8 What follows is a copy of
The written orders given *in love*
By Artaxerxes who was king,
Which was delivered to *the wing*
Of Ezra the priest and the scribe
Of YHWH's law *not to take a bribe*.
9 "King Artaxerxes to Ezra
The priest and the scribe of YHWH's law,
Greeting. 10 "By my gracious decision,
I have given orders and provision
That those of Jewish nation and
Of the priests and Levites and band
Of others in our kingdom's stand,
Who freely choose to do so, may
Join you in Jerusalem's way.
11 "Let as many as are inclined
Set off with you as have designed
I and my seven counsellors
12 "To examine the issue's *stores*
In Judea, Jerusalem,
In the light of YHWH's law *and gem*,
13 "And carry to Jerusalem
The offerings for Israel's YHWH which
I and my mates have promised switch
To gather for YHWH in the town
Jerusalem the gold in crown
And silver in Babylon's land,
14 "Along with what the nation brought
For temple of their Lord they sought
In Jerusalem, both the gold
And silver for bulls and rams cold,
And lambs and all that goes with them,
15 "So as to offer as in gem
Offerings upon their Lord's altar
In Jerusalem's land afar.

Artaxerxes sees You, Beloved, as YHWH,
The God of Israel and the Hebrew crew,
And stationed in a place and time in view,
Jerusalem, the seat of Your power due.
I doubt not Artaxerxes sees the gods
Of every land under his sway of clods
As worthy of an offering and a prayer
In favour of the king who bears sway there.
I wonder what accommodation met
Is found in mind of Ezra and his set,
To have a king who helps and yet who is

Swayed by his own faint superstitious fizz.
Beloved, clear my heart and my cornered
mind
Of thoughts that make my own time deaf
and blind.

16 "And whatever you and your frères
Have in mind using golden wares
And silver, do it all the way
Your Alohim decides to say.
17 "And bring the holy pots of YHWH
Given for the temple use to you
For your Alohim who is set
In Jerusalem *for a bet*.
18 "Whatever else occurs to you
As necessary for the due
Temple of your Alohim true,
You may take from the royal brew.
19 "And I, Artaxerxes the king,
Have ordered the treasurers that spring
In Syria and Phoenicia bring
Whatever Ezra the priest and
Scribe of the law come from the hand
Of the Most High Alohim asks,
They'll take care of him and his tasks,
20 "Up to a hundred talents weight
Of silver, and likewise on plate
Up to a hundred cors of wheat,
A hundred baths of grape juice treat,
And salt as much as can in rate.
21 "Let all things ordered by the law
Of Alohim by faithful paw
Be done for Most High Alohim,
So wrath may not fall on the reign
Of the king and his sons in pain.

Man fears the thunder of the gods, I trow,
Often before he promises a rate
Strung out in taxes for his family fate.
That's the beginning of the hymn
somehow.

Humble the man may seem as lowly cow
Ingratiating cattle-lot and grate,
Granting the offering of the cleric's state.
Hypocrisy is nothing he'd allow.
Along the meadows of my contemplation,
Laughing for unbrooked benefits in brief,
Only too well I realize my station
Hugely amounted, yet without my grief.
I bring my gold and silver with my hand
Making retraction of the hopeful band.

22 You are also informed that no
 Tribute or any other stow
 Should be set to priest or Levite
 Or temple singer or the wight
 That keeps the gates of temple slave
 Or any hired as worker brave
 In this temple, and that no one
 Has right to impose on their bun
 Taxes of any kind of right.
 23 "And you, Ezra, according to
 The wisdom of Alohim due,
 Appoint judges and justices
 To judge all those who know the biz
 Of your God's law, and throughout all
 Syria and Phoenicia install;
 And those who do not know the thing
 You shall teach them to keep and sing.
 24 And all who transgress law of God
 Or the law of the kingdom's prod
 Shall be punished with a harsh hand,
 Whether by death or rod or band,
 Fine or imprisonment to stand."
 25 Blessed be YHWH only, who put this
 Into the heart of the king's bliss,
 To glorify His house which is
 In Jerusalem for a quiz,
 26 And who honoured me in the sight
 Of the king and his counsel wight
 And all his friends and nobles might.
 27 I was encouraged by the aid
 Of YHWH my Alohim who stayed,
 And I gathered together men
 From Israel to join me again.
 28 These are the principal men, by
 Their ancestral houses and sty
 And their associations, who
 Went with me from Babylon's pew
 In reign of Artaxerxes king
Back to Jerusalem on wing.

I look to golden days of long ago
 And wait for virtue and the vertigo
 Of vague Jerusalem above the brook
 Kidron and pine for flowers that once then
 shook
 Beneath the glance of Ezra and the flames.
 And yet I hear that clerics without blames
 In those days were exempt from any taxes.
 There are no days when none deserve no
 axes.
 Instead of fainting for the old delights
 Of sweetness of Jerusalem's fair nights,

I joy in what I have of freedom here,
 Despite the fact that there are those with
 gear
 Whose wealth is stolen from the widow's
 mite
 And shorn from public weal with all their
 might.

29 One of the sons of Phineas,
 Gershom. And of the sons alas
 Of Ithamar, Gamael. Of sons
 Of David, Hattush *in his runs*
 The offspring of one Shecaniah.
 30 Sons of Parosh, one Zechariah,
 And with him one hundred and fifty
 Men inscribed and enrolled *as nifty*.
 31 Of the sons of Pahathmoab,
 Eliehoenai the son to grab
 Of Zerariah, and with him
 Two hundred men, *all of them grim*.
 32 Of the sons of Zattu set well,
 Shecaniah of Jahaziel
 The son, and with him three hundred.
 Of the sons of Adin, Obed
 The son of Jonathan, along
 With him two hundred fifty *strong*.
 33 Of the sons of Elam, Jeshaiiah
 The offspring of one Gotholiah,
 And with him seventy men *well fed*.
 34 And of the sons of Shephatiah,
 The son of Michael named Zeraiah,
 And with him seventy men led.
 35 Of sons of Joab, Obadiah
 The son of Jehiel and crier,
 And with him two hundred twelve *bred*.

How many men come to the house of God,
 Beloved, to pay their homage on the sod?
 I see the warriors in their glowing dress
 Come from all lands to You and to confess
 The Kaaba and the one who once was born
 Within its shelter from falsehood and scorn.
 I see three hundred gather at the gate
 And tread the place of Abraham for fate
 And join with thirteen more and rise to see
 The coming of Your justice and mercy.
 Beloved, I see the help and hope spread
 wide
 Before my vision and before my pride,
 And hasten with an old man's weeping eye
 The great salvation under grieving sky.

36 Of sons of Bani, Shelomith
 Son of Josiphiah, and with
 Him one hundred and sixty men.
 37 Of sons of Bebai, Zechariah
 The son of Bebai, and *on fire*
 With him *all* of twenty-eight men.
 38 Of the sons of Azgad, Johanan
 The son of Hakkatan *like cannon*,
 And with him one hundred ten men.
 39 Of the sons of Adonikam,
 The last ones, their names *without scam*
 Were Eliphelet, Jeuel, and
 Shemaiah, and with them *in band*
 Seventy men. 40 Of the sons of
 Bigvai and Uthai the son of
 Istalcurus, and with him *stalled*
 Seventy men. 41 At river called
 Theras I gathered them and we
 Encamped there three days, and *in fee*
 I checked them out. 42 When I found there
 No children the priests or *share*
 Of the Levites, 43 I sent *then* word
 To Eliezar, and *as spurred*
 To Idueh, Maasmas, 44 Elnathan,
 Shemaiah and Jarib and Nathan,
 Elnathan, Zechariah, and
 Meshullam, who came to command
 As men of wisdom, 45 and I told
 Them to go to Iddo *as bold*,
 Who was the chief at treasury,
 46 And told them to tell Iddo *free*
 And his brothers and treasurers
 At that place to send us the fers
 To serve as priests in the palace
 Of our Lord. 47 And by mighty grace
 Of our Lord they brought us good men
 Of Mahli children, son *again*
 Of Levi, son of Israel,
 Sherebiah the truth to tell
 With his sons and kinfolk, eighteen;
 48 Also Hashabiah *to preen*
 And Annunus, also Jeshaiiah
 His brother, sons of Hananiah,
 And their sons, twenty men *on fire*;
 49 And of the temple servants, whom
 David and the leaders gave room
 To serve the Levites, two hundred
 And twenty temple servants bred;
 The list of all their names as said.

When David Your Beloved gave out a job
 To anyone who needed in the mob,

It looks like it was for eternity,
 And every son had work and busily
 For generations untold in the spree.
 Descendants of the temple servants sit
 With Ezra and all them are still found fit.
 Today if any church signs a contract
 For servants, it's a temporary pact,
 And they are like to be unemployed
 stacked.
 Beloved, a homeless unemployed soul I
 Enrol in David's class and start to spy
 On faintly whispered woods and subtle
 vine
 To find if there is any place that's mine.

50 So I proclaimed a fast for such
 Young men before our Lord as much,
 To beg of Him successful trip
 For ourselves and our children *hip*
 And cattle with us *not to skip*.
 51 I was ashamed to ask the king
 For infantry and horse on wing
 In escort to protect us from
 The enemies if they should come,
 52 For we had told the king, "The hand
 Of our Lord will be to command
 Those who seek Him, and will maintain
 Them in all they do *on the plain*."
 53 We prayed to our Lord and again
 About these matters, and so then
 We found Him very merciful.
 54 I set apart twelve chiefs to pull
 The priests, Sherebiah as well
 As Hashabiah, and a swell
 Ten of their kinfolk among men.
 55 I measured out to them in hand
 The silver and the gold in span
 And holy vessels of the house
 Of our Lord, which the king *of mouse*
 And his advisers and the royal
 Ones and all Israel gave in spoil.
 56 I weighed and gave them six hundred
 And fifty talents silver spread,
 And silver pots to the amount
 Of a hundred talents in count,
 And a hundred talents of gold,
 57 And twenty golden bowls, and twelve
 Bronze vessels of fine bronze *to shelve*
 And shine and shimmer just like gold.

Is the choice now between the golden pots
 And brazen vessels in their chosen lots?

If there were twenty golden bowls I bet
The bronze ones were much larger where
they set.

The golden ones were small no doubt and
stayed

Within the shadow that the twelve pots
made.

The brazen vessels stole regard and eye
Of every lover and each passer-by.

But only those who stayed to watch the
crown

Could see the little golden bowls in town.
Beloved, I see how many follow glitter,
And how the golden soul might feel the
bitter

To be neglected while the laurels fall
Upon the hollow champions at the wall.

58 And I said to them, "You are holy
To YHWH, and the vessels are holy,
And the silver and gold are promised
To YHWH of our dads *and our Psalmist*.

59 Be watchful and on guard till you
Deliver them to the chiefs due
Of the priests and the Levites, and
To the heads of the fathers' band
Of families in Israel,

In Jerusalem, in the well
Of the house of our Lord *to tell*."

60 So the priests and the Levites who
Took the silver and the gold too
And the vessels which had been in
Jerusalem and brought in bin
To the temple of YHWH *to spin*.

61 We left the river Theras on
The twelfth day of the first month's *dawn*;
And we came to Jerusalem

By our Lord's mighty stratagem
Which was on us, and He saved us
From every foe upon the bus,
Till we came to Jerusalem.

62 When we had been there for three days,
The silver and the gold *in praise*
Were weighed and delivered *at least*
To our Lord's house, Meremoth priest,
Son of Uriah *and increased*.

63 And with him was Eleazar
The son of Phinehas *and star*,
And with them were Jozabad son
Of Jeshua and Moeth son
Of Binnui, who were Levites.

64 Everything was then put to rights

By count and weight and written down
As soon as it came into town.

65 And those who'd come back from the
trip

Of captives offered YHWH *the sip*
Of sacrifice, to Elohim

Of Israel, twelve bulls *in seam*

For all Israel, ninety-six rams,
66 As well as seventy-two lambs,
As a thank offering twelve he-goats,
All sacrifice to YHWH *in floats*.

What's holy, my Beloved? The present gas
Thinks holy is the moral kind of brass.

The gold was holy too, and so the sum
Of all the silver and the brass to come.

The pot and seam, the ram and billy-goat,
All these were holy by appointment's vote.

The Levite and his servant, holy too,
Enter the bin and complement the view.

Beloved, You too are holy at last count,
At least when You appeared upon the
Mount.

The holy is the thing that's set apart
To be Your own, though just a donkey cart.

Let me be holy too, not by my ploy,
But by the fact that I become Your joy.

67 And they delivered the king's orders
To royal servants and to *hoarders*

Of governors of Coelesyria
And of Phoenicia *not to weary you*,

And these officials honoured folk
And the temple of YHWH *in yoke*.

68 After these things, the chief men came
To me and said *as if in blame*,

69 "The people of Israel and chiefs
And the priests and Levites *in feoffs*

Have not kept themselves from the strange
Peoples of the land and the range

Of their pollutions, Canaanites,
The Hittites, and the Perizzites,

The Jebusites, the Moabites,
The Egyptians, and Edomites.

70 For they and their sons have married
The daughters of these people freed,

The holy race has been mixed with
The strange peoples of land *of myth*,

And from the start of this the chiefs
And nobles have shared in their feoffs

In this iniquity *of griefs*."

71 As soon as I heard these things I

Tore my clothing and holy my
 Cloak and pulled hair from head and beard,
 And sat in grief and troubled geared.
 72 And all who were moved at the word
 Of YHWH of Israel round me stirred,
 As I mourned this iniquity,
 And I sat grief-stricken to see
 Till evening sacrifice occurred.

To be tri-racial is a thing deplored,
 But worse than anger of the sovereign lord
 Is that the kinky hairs join with the straight
 And stick out wildly from unholy pate.
 To pull them from the scalp does little
 good,

It only diminishes hair that should
 Become grey in its time. The thinning hair
 Does nothing to charm any anywhere.
 Beloved, since you are of no race and time,
 I wonder that You worry at the climb
 To find a social niche where no one blights
 The tri-racial soul in his days and nights.
 I might have saved my hair, and so had he
 Who was named Esdras on the blackened
 sea.

73 Then I rose from my fast, my clothes
 And holy cloak torn as I chose,
 And kneeling stretching forth my hands
 To YHWH, 74 I said "O Lord, I'm blessed
 If I'm ashamed in sorrow *dressed*
 Before Your face. 75 Because our sins
 Have risen higher than our bins,
 Our errors flown to the sky's *wins*
 76 From the times of our ancestors,
 And we're in great sin to these shores.
 77 And because of our sins and the sins
 Of our ancestors with our kins
 And our kings and our priests we were
 Delivered to earth's kings to *stir*
 The sword, captivity, and spoil,
 In shame until this day of toil.
 78 And now in some measure mercy
 Has come to us from You to be,
 O YHWH, to leave to us a root
 And name in Your holy place *boot*,
 79 And to show a light for us in
 The house of YHWH our Alohim
 To give us nourishment *in din*
 And time of servitude *in dream*.

I've seen some people in the eastern way

Upon their knees sit back on heels and
 sway
 With hands outstretched in supplication to
 You for the benefits they hope are due.
 So Esdras takes the time of hopeful day
 To make a supplication come to pray.
 It's rare today to hear a man confess
 His sins and those of fathers in address.
 Apologies are so rare that I think
 It worth the game to go into the clink
 Of Anglican evensong to hear what
 The collects claim of human wayward rut.
 I doubt I'll hear it elsewhere in the word
 Of Anglo-Saxon speech and undeterred.

80 "Captive even we did not find
 Ourselves forsaken by our *kind*
 Lord, but He brought us up to grace
 With Persian kings, who fed our face
 81 "And they glorified our Lord's house,
 And raised Zion from trampled grouse,
 To grant a tower in Judea
 Around Jerusalem *in awe*.

82 "And now, O YHWH, what shall we
 say,
 When we've these things? For in our way
 We've broken Your law that You gave
 By Your servant prophets *to pave*
 Saying, 83 "The land to which you come
 To possess is a land *in sum*
 Polluted with pollution of
 The strangers of the land who shove
 It full of their uncleanness' sum.
 84 "Therefore do not give your daughters
 In marriage to their sons and fers,
 And do not take their daughters for
 Your sons; 85 "and do not seek once more
 Ever to have peace with their store,
 So you may be strong and eat good
 Things of the land and leave its wood
 An heirloom for your children's hood.'
 86 "And all that's happened to us came
 About because our evil blame
 And our great sins. For You, O YHWH,
 Lifted our sins' burden and true
 87 "To give us such a root as this.
 But we turned back again to miss
 Your law by mixing with unclean
 Peoples of the land *on their bean*.
 88 "Were You not angry enough then
 With us to destroy us and ben
 Without leaving a root or seed

Or name? 89 “O YHWH of Israel’s *creed*,
You are true, for we have been left
Like a root to this day bereft.
90 “Indeed, we are now before You
In our iniquities in crew,
For we can no longer stand in
Your presence because of our sin.”

Sometimes I feel that I am captive too
And sent into a country beyond view,
And yet what is my country since my veins
Contain the blood of every land in grains?
Does this text mean to say that any folk
Who mix their blood with foreigners to
stoke

Pollute the land and spoil it at a stroke?
I hope not, my Beloved, because I see
My own would then be lost as family,
Because the ropes of dreams of many lands
And cultures are poured into my home
sands.

And yet I turn to Israel’s God alone,
And meet You without altar made of stone,
And without temple but birch and fir
stands.

91 While Ezra prayed, while he confessed,
And while he cried and lay compressed
Upon the ground before the site
Of the great temple, there came right
To him a very great crowd from
Jerusalem, men all in sum
And women and young people too,
With lamentation all in crew.
92 Shecaniah Jehiel’s son,
One of Israel’s men on the run,
Called out, and said to Ezra done,
“We’ve sinned against YHWH when we
took

Strange women from the folk and brook,
But even now let Israel hope.

93 “Let’s take an oath to YHWH *in scope*
To divorce all our foreign wives,
With their children, 94 “as it contrives
To seem good to you and to all
Who obey YHWH by law and call.

95 “Get up and do, for it’s your job,
And we are with you in a mob.”

96 So Ezra got up, had the chiefs
Of priests and Levites in their griefs
Of all of Israel take oath
That they would do this, one and both.

And so they rose and took the oath.

Beloved, when all the men got up to throw
Out every wife made in the land to grow
And replace all with those brought in the
show

From Babylon, I look and want to know.
There’s hardly help and hope for women
where

Men prance and decide what they ought to
wear.

There’s no chance for the turning of their
hair

When You decide divorce is their best
share.

Beloved, I see the line of tearful girls
Turned out of town and hearth by righteous
churls,

And wonder where they went, and if they
found

A shelter from the cold and heat on ground
Of stone and shard upon the road that
wound

Jerusalem away. I hear the sound.

1 Esdras 9

1 Then Ezra rose and went out from
The court of the temple like bum
To the room of Jehohanan

The son of Eliashib man,
2 And spent the night there; and he did
Not eat food or drink water bid,
For he was mourning for the great
Iniquities of the crowd’s rate.

3 A proclamation was sent through
Judea and Jerusalem

To everyone returned in view
From the captivity in crew
To gather at Jerusalem.

4 And if any did not meet there
Within two or three days to share,
By the decision of the chiefs,
Their cattle should be seized for *feoffs*
Of sacrifice and they themselves
Be expelled from the crowd *like elves*
Who had come back from captive shelves.

5 Then the people of Judah’s tribe
And Benjamin gathered by scribe
Into Jerusalem within
Three days. This was the ninth month’s *bin*,
On the month’s twentieth day *in skin*.

6 And all the crowd sat on the square

Before the temple, shivering there
Because the weather was not fair.

The tale of wandering Jew might well
begin
In coming to Jerusalem to win
And falling short a day or two, though
roads
Were covered with mud, ruts from heavy
loads
And people in the way. I hate to think
That Your laws are so awful on the brink
That cattle must be stolen from the poor
Who could not make it to the temple door.
But then I know the Christian Church
around
Me on the frozen Finnish sort of ground
Was used to taking widows' mite and cow,
Inheritance tax as the chiefs allow.
Beloved, I flee the temple and the state
Even if set up under Your rebate.

7 Then Ezra rose and said to them,
"You've broken the law to an em
By marrying strange women and
Have increased Israel's load *of sand*.
8 So make confession and give glory
To YHWH Alohim *of the story*
Of our ancestors, 9 Do his will,
Separate yourselves from the bill
Of the land's folk and from the wives
You've taken from such foreign hives."
10 Then all the crowd spoke up with shout
And said with a loud voice *in rout*,
"We'll do as you have talked about.
11 "But we're a big crowd in the cold,
Standing in open air not bold,
It's not a thing that we can do
Right now or in a day or two,
Since we've sinned so much in these
matters.
12 "So let the chiefs stay and fat catters,
And let those of us who live here
With foreign wives come to appear
Each in his turn, 13 with elders and
Judges of each place, till we stand
Free of the wrath of YHWH in band."

The mass arranging of divorce is not
A thing to be done when it isn't hot
Outside and when the crowd is cold and
bare.

The thing to do is to arrange the scare.
The Christian Church today says to beware
Of any divorce unless taught to share
In some unfaithfulness and even that
Is not excuse for any Catholic cat.
And here You force the farming dudes to
cut
Loose every dame that's defined as a slut
Because her mom and dad in heathen rut
Failed to remember that Your name is best
Of any name of god in east or west.
I sit up and take notice of the messed.

14 Jonathan son of Asahel
And Jahzeiah son of Tikvah
Set to the task and fill the spell,
And Meshullam and Levi's paw
And Shabbethai served them on draw.
15 And those who had returned at last
From the captivity and fast
Acted by all these orders' mast.
16 Ezra the priest chose for himself
The leading men upon the shelf
Of their ancestral houses, all
Of them by name and by the call.
And on the first day of month ten
They started their assizes again
To judge the matter *of a wen*.
17 And the cases of men who had
Foreign wives, a thing that's so bad,
Were finished by the first day come
Of the first month, *and moved with rum*.
18 Of the priests those brought in and
found

To have strange wives were up and bound:
19 Of the sons of Jeshua son
Of Jozadak and brothers done:
Maaseiah, Eliezar, Jarib,
And Jodan also not to fib.
20 They swore to put away their wives
And to give rams to save their lives.

If I had been among the holy few
That had taken a strange wife in the pew,
I think I would have slinked away and left
The racists to their gardens and their theft
And found a house in Damascus and there
Lived in peace and in love without a care.
I wouldna swear to send my wife away
Despite the purists in their great heyday,
I wouldna leave me bairns to suffer aught

Because some fools came back with
foreign plot
To dream of golden ages and such rot.
Beloved, I can serve You beside the stream
Of Syria as well as in the cream
Of Quds above Brook Kidron when I've
got.

21 Of sons of Immer: Hanani
And Zebadiah *for a try*,
And Maaseiah and Shemaiah,
Jehiel and Azariah.
22 Of the sons of Pashhur *to know*:
Elioenai, Maaseiah's *show*,
Ishmael, and Nathanael, and
Gedaliah, Elasa's *band*.
23 And of the Levites: Jozabad
And Shimei for the wife he had
And Kelaiah, who was Kelita,
And Pethahiah *to benight her*
And Judah and Jonah *at hand*.
24 Of temple singers, *I am crushed*:
Eliashib and Zaccur *hushed*.
25 Of the gatekeepers: Shallum and
Telem. 26 Of Israel *in band*:
Of the sons of Parosh: Ramiah,
Izziah, Malchijah *in fire*,
Mijamin, and Eleazar,
And Asibias, and *the gar*
Benaiah. 27 Then of Elam's sons:
Mattaniah and *without guns*
Zechariah, Jehiel and
Abdi, and Jeremoth *on hand*
With Elijah. 28 And of the sons
Of Zattu: Elioenai's *runs*,
Eliashib, Othoniah,
Jeremoth, Zabad, Zerdaiah.

It seems the doorkeepers and singers are
The purist of the crew, purist by far.
They only have two each to represent
The sinners on the spree and on the bent.
I sing though voice is hardly one to trust,
I stand beside the door and in the dust.
My humble voice alone is temple for
The Kalender who stands outside the door.
Beloved, I take the shoes of those who pray
And hope I give them back after they pay
To the right owners so that no dismay
May fill the hearts of those who come Your
way.
And while I wait outside beneath the sun

I sing a Psalm of David on the run.

29 Of the sons of *my friend* Bebai:
Jehohanan and Hananiah
And Zabbai and Emathis' *cry*.
30 Of the sons of Bani *as spyer*:
Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah,
Jashub, Sheal and Jeremoth.
31 Of the sons of Addi *in troth*:
Naathus, Moossias, Laccunus
And Naidus, and Bescaspasmys
And Sesthel, as well as Belnuus
Also finally Manasseas.
32 Of the sons of *famous* Annan,
Elionas as well as *man*
Asaia and Melchias and
Sabbaias and Simon *in band*
Of Chosamaeus. 33 Of the sons
Of Hashum: Mattenai and *runs*
Of Mattattah and Zabad and
Eliphelet and Manasseh
And finally the last Shimei.
34 Of sons of Bani: Jeremai,
Maadai, Amram, Joel, Mamdai
And Bedeiah and Vaniah,
Carabasion and Eliashib
And Machnadebai, Eliasis,
Binnui, and one Elialis,
Shimei, and also Shelemiah,
And Nethaniah *in the crib*.
And of the sons of Ezora:
Shashai, Azarel, Azael,
Shemaiah, and Amariah,
Joseph, *as men of Israel*.
35 Of sons of Nebo: Mattithiah,
Zabad, Iddo, Joel, Benaiah.
36 All these had married foreign gals,
Whom they divorced with children pals.

I think, Beloved, the way we do things here
In heathen land, a place without Your fear,
That makes a man responsible in full
For his own children even in the pull
Of grand divorce, is at least to the fate
Of minors one You had best contemplate.
I recognize, however, in the dust
That killing pagan children is a must
If You would keep the race both pure and
safe
From enemies without and warring waif.
My social conscience is a product of

My times' progress and other crimes in
glove.
Creation is a mess and even by
Survival of the fittest it goes wry.

37 The priests and the Levites and men
Of Israel settled *once again*
In the town of Jerusalem
And in the country *round its hem*.
On first day of seventh month, when
The sons of Israel were in place,
38 The whole crowd gathered at a trace
In open square before east gate
Of the temple 39 and to relate
To Ezra the chief priest and scribe
To bring the law of Moses' *side*
Once given by YHWH Alohim of
Israel. 40 So Ezra the chief glove
Brought the law, and for all the crowd,
Men and women, and all *allowed*
Of the priests to hear the law, on
The first day of seventh month *drawn*.
41 And he read aloud in the square
Open before temple gate there
From early morning till midday,
In presence of both men *to stay*
And women; and all of the crowd
Listened to the law read aloud.

I guess it was an easy thing at last
To read the law from dawn until repast
Of midday, since all foreign ladies were
Sent out of town with their spawn on the
spur.

The lads and lassies that remained well
knew

To hush and be still in the laboured crew
That listened to the law come into view.
Nobody whispered or complained a bit.
Beloved, You kept the people in a fit
Of fear with the results that sweetly sit
Upon the square to hear the proclamation
Of what they ought to do as folk and
nation.

Despite the harshness of Ezra in leading,
I'd love to hear that law writ with such
breeding.

42 Ezra the priest and scribe of law
Stood on the wooden platform's *claw*
That had been built *to raise in awe*.
43 Beside him stood Mattathiah and

Shema, Anaiah, Azariah,
Uriah, also Hezekiah,
And Baalsamus at his right side,
44 And on his left came to abide
Pedaiah, Mishael *to nurse*,
Malchijah, and Lothasubus,
Nabariah, and Zechariah.
45 Then Ezra picked up the law book
While the whole crowd there came to look,
Since he held precedence of a'.
46 And when he opened up the law,
They all stood up straight and in awe.
And Ezra blessed YHWH God most high
The Alohim of hosts forebye,
The Almighty; 47 And all the crowd
Answered, "Amen" and spoke aloud.
And they raised up their hands, and fell
To the ground and worshiped YHWH *El*.

The Sunnites when they pray all in one
voice

Repeat amen after the verse of choice,
While Shi'ites will not say that fatal word
Because it is not found in Qur'an stirred.
There's always something to be found to
take

The eyes and ears away of Your law's sake.
At any rate we're all agreed to make
Exception for our hate in raising hands
And falling in prostration on the sands.
Beloved, I join the crowd, whoe'er they be
Who bow down at Your name's unicity,
And take You only in the idols' spree
That fills the world with hopely rivalry.
I turn and see the gathered prostrate bands.

48 Jeshua and Anniuth and
Sherebiah, Jamin on hand,
Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah,
Maaseiah also Kelita,
Azariah and Jozabad,
Hanan, Pelaiah, and *not sad*
The Levites, taught the law of YHWH
And translated the reading due.
49 Well Attharates told Ezra
The chief priest and the scribe in awe,
And the Levites who taught the crowd,
And everyone saying aloud,
50 "This day is sacred to YHWH", while
They were all weeping without smile
As they listened to the law's pile,
51 "So go in peace and eat the fat

And drink the sweet from where you're at,
 And send out portions to those who
 Have nothing to enjoy in crew,
 52 For the day is holy to YHWH,
 And don't be sorrowful, for YHWH
 Will surely come and exalt you."
 53 And the Levites commanded all
 The people, saying, "This day's call
 Is holy, don't be sorrowful."
 54 Then they all went their way, to eat
 And drink and enjoy every treat,
 And give gifts to those who had none,
 And to make great rejoicing done,
 55 Because they were moved by the word
 That they had been taught, and were stirred.

The Targum's a tradition from the time
 Of Ezra when the folk could hardly climb
 The steepness of the Hebrew letters' hill.
 So translation came in to fit the bill.
 Today the synagogue is close to fill
 Despite the fact no Targum's read but only
 The Hebrew words, not to make any lonely.
 When Jesus came, the Targum was read
 still.
 Beloved, I long for hearing of Your law
 Both in the syllables of brighter awe
 And in the homely phrases of the tongue
 I learned as child to know when I was
 young.
 Beloved, I hear the verses once repeated
 Where I bow down and where I am now
 seated.

2 Esdras

2 Esdras is generally considered to be a gem of Jewish apocalyptic literature from the first century C.E. The Hebrew original as well as its Greek translation have been lost. This versification is based on translations of the restored Latin text, with very little reference to the sources and practically no scholarly contemplation of the many variants. Its value is completely that of the versification itself and the verse contemplations in commentary.

The book of 2 Esdras presents a completely distinct way of accommodating to the imperial situation, one in contrast to Ezra, Nehemiah, and 1 Esdras. It reverts to

the Ezekiel model of visionary flight from unsavoury reality.

2 Esdras 1

1 The second book of Ezra, prophet
 Son of Seraiah *not to scoff at*,
 The son of Azariah, son
 Of Hilkiah, son of Shallum,
 Son of Zadok, Ahitub's son,
 2 Son of Ahijah *out to hum*,
 Son of Phinehas, Ali's son,
 Son of Amariah *well done*,
 Son of Azariah, the son
 Of Meraioth, son of Arna,
 Son of Uzzi, son of *the raw*
 Borith, son of Abishua,
 Son of Phinehas, *who was son*
 Of Eleazar, *who when done*
 3 Was son of Aaron, of the tribe
 Of Levi, who was captive bribe
 In the land of the Medes when reigned
 Artaxerxes, king *uncomplained*
 Of the Persians. 4 Message from YHWH
 Came to me saying 5 "Go say to
 My people that their deeds are bad,
 And to their offspring it is sad
 They have committed wickedness
 Against Me, so they may confess
 To their grandchildren 6 "that the sins
 Of their parents arose *in bins*,
 For they've forgotten Me and made
 Sacrifices to strange gods *strayed*.

Ezra is the one who invented much
 When he invented silsila to touch.
 The Sufi Jewfy goofy way to teach
 Has since that time been subject that they
 preach.
 Without the isnad of the long transmission
 Of blessing and authority's admission
 The sinful soul goes down to hell's
 commission
 With failing glory and without a peach.
 Beloved, I come to You alone and take
 The bayat as a promise not to wake
 The sleeping cuties on the slaughter ground
 Who zombie-like go round and round and
 round.
 Beloved, I come to You alone, forsake
 The satans that the villages confound.

7 "Was it not I who took them out

Of Egypt's land, and *with a shout*
 Out of the house of servanthood?
 But they have angered Me as could
 Despising My advice for good.
 8 "Pull out your head of hair and fling
 Every evil upon their thing,
 For they have not obeyed My law,
 Rebellious folk *in hand and claw*.
 9 "How long shall I put up with them,
 Whom I've granted largess in gem?
 10 "For them I've overthrown some kings,
 I struck down Pharaoh with his wings
 Of servants and his army's stings.
 11 "All peoples I've destroyed for them,
 And scattered before two folks' hem,
 Both Tyre and Sidon, I have killed
 All their foes *on the land they tilled*.

The divine rage is something that I bare
 Only in infantile dream to beware.
 Otherwise I present myself as good
 Behaving in the world as goodness should.
 If You, Beloved, advise pulling out hair
 In protest for idolatry in air,
 Just tell me what's the benefit to share
 Besides the grosser ridicule I could.
 I can indeed make fuss that You are caught
 In trinities of idols long since taught,
 And raise a crew and hie against the
 bought,

But the result is not repentance' wheel,
 Rather more a glint and a threat of steel.
 I do not know what is to help or would.

12 "But talk to them and say 'It's so
 That YHWH speaks, 13 "Truly on the go
 I brought you through the sea, and laid
 Secure paths for you where was made
 No road, I gave you Moses too
 As guide and Aaron as priest due,
 14 "I gave you light from stand of fire,
 And performed miracles, admire,
 Among you, but you have forgotten
 Me," says YHWH. 15 'And so is He
 plotting,
 YHWH Almighty, "The quails were sign
 To you, I gave you camps' design
 For your protection, but you scoffed.
 16 "You've not praised My name, but have
 coughed
 At the destruction of your foes,
 And to this day complain *in rows*.

17 "Where are the benefits that I
 Poured out on you? When you could die
 For hunger and thirst in the land
 Of desert, did you not remand
 Your voice to me, 18 "saying 'Why now
 Have You led us into the brow
 Of this desert to kill us? It
 Would have been better to be fit
 In service to Egyptians than
 To die in this place to a man.'

I too, Beloved, have failed to die of hunger
 In the abandoned land when I was younger,
 And failed to thirst beyond the wake of
 fasting
 As long as the hot daylight time was
 lasting.
 Perhaps there have been moments in my
 nonage
 When I hoped to die for a moment's
 punnage,
 But on the brow of the hill where I stand,
 I do not wish return to Egypt's land.
 Beloved, I know the Nile in treachery,
 I know the lovely folk in their beauty,
 But for the symbol of earth's slavery
 I do not wish the journey on the sand
 Return me to idol-worshipping band.
 Instead I take hold of Your leading hand.

19 "I took pity upon your sighs
 And gave you manna for replies,
 You ate the food of angels *wise*.
 20 "When you thirsted, did I not split
 The rock so that water flowed fit
 Abundantly? For shade from heat
 I covered you with tree leaves neat.
 21 "I meted out the fruited lands
 To you, I frightened out the bands
 Of Canaanites, the Perizzites,
 The Philistines before your heights.
 What more can I do for you now?"
 Says YHWH. 22 'So says YHWH anyhow,
 The Almighty, "When you were there
 In the desert by bitter share
 Of water, thirsting to blaspheme
 My name, 23 "I did not even dream
 To send fire on you for the weight
 Of your blasphemies to berate,
 But cast a tree into the flood
 And made the stream sweet *of its mud*.
 24 "What shall I do for you, Jacob?

You would not obey Me as stub,
O Judah. I'll turn to the rub
Of other peoples and give them
My name, that they may keep the hem
Of My statutes *and have a claim.*

You have not sent me down the manna
sweet
Or given miracled water in treat
(Although I have been favoured once to
taste

The nectar of zamzam and without waste
To run upon the two hills in my haste),
Nor have you looked upon brazen and
chased

Them from their houses so that I might find
A safety and a comfort in my bind.
And yet, Beloved, I turn back to Your law
And contemplate it with a well-turned claw
And wonder at perfection at the draw.
And yet, Beloved, I turn and turn again
Away from teaching guidance of all men
And find You only hiding in my den.

25 "Because you have forsaken Me,
I shall forsake you and your tree.
When you petition My mercy,
I shall not show you such mercy.

26 "When you call on Me, I will not
Listen to you, for you in plot
Have defiled your hand with shed blood,
And your feet are swift to the crud
Of murder. 27 "It's not Me alone,
You've given yourselves up to a stone,"
Says YHWH. 28 'So says YHWH the
Almighty,

"Have I not begged of you the flighty
As father speaks well to his sons,
Or mother to her daughters fair,
Or a nurse to her children's runs,
29 "That you should be My people there,
And I should be your Alohim,
And you should be My sons in scheme,
And I your father it would seem?

I see the brave religion of the boast
Whose hand creates the blood upon the
host
And then turns to the stone in adoration
To find a peace in the grown heart's
elation.
I see the fathers hear confession made

In cubicles of homely and betrayed,
And know the Father that is thus waylaid
Is missing from the crosses in their station.
Beloved, I murder not Your Christ once
sent

Nor do I accuse the Jews when they meant
To keep their nation from the rust of Rome.
I keep my simple faith alone at home.
If You are Father to the gathered here,
I lend You heart and tuneful tongue and
ear.

30 "I summoned you together as
A hen gathers the brood she has
Under her wings. But now, what shall
I do for you? I'll throw you, *pal*,
Out from before My sight for sal.

31 "When you offer up incense to
Me, I will turn My face from you,
For I've rejected your feast days,
The first day of the months to raise,
And circumcisions of the flesh.

32 "I sent you my servants the prophets,
But you have taken off the soffits
And killed them, torn their bodies
shredded,

Their blood I'll demand where they're
bedded,"

Says YHWH. 33 'So says YHWH the
Almighty,

"Your house is desolate, almighty,
I'll throw you out like wind the straw,
34 "And your sons will not have in crow
Offspring, because along with you
They've abandoned commandment true
And done the evil in My view.

35 "I'll give your houses to a folk
To come, who without hearing stroke
Of Me believe *and take My yoke.*
Those to whom I have shown no signs
Will do as I give them designs.

If Your Christ Jesus once relayed the tune
Of this text with its chickens there to croon,
And quoted thus apocrypha when he
Stood up before the folk in prophecy,
Then any church that sets aside the text
That Jesus himself spoke to the perplexed
Is flying in the face of hen and brood,
Which is a thing unfaithful well as rude.
Beloved, I read apocryphal words too
And doubt them in my passion for the true

As much as I doubt everything I read
Except the Decalogue, which is my speed.
Give me the judgement now that is my due
For having such a slender hope and creed.

36 “They’ve seen no prophets, still recall
The way they lived before in stall.
37 “I call in witness the folk’s thanks
That will come, whose offspring in ranks
Will rejoice with gladness, though they
Do not see Me with eyes that stay,
But with the spirit they’ll believe
The message they from Me receive.
38 “And now, Father, look out with pride
And see the nations as they ride
From the east, 39 “To those ones I’ll give
As leaders *there where they may live*
Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob,
Hosea, Amos and the cub
Micah and Joel, Obadiah,
And Jonah, Nahum, and the fire
Of Habakkuk, and Zephaniah,
Haggai and also Zechariah,
And Malachi also one who
Is called the messenger of YHWH.”

Abram, Isaac and Jacob in the past
Are followed by a faithful twelve to last,
The minor prophets as the saying goes
Are only mentioned here because he chose
Them to be great above both friends and
foes.

I look around the holy books that cast
A flame of light and truth above the mast
And weigh anchor and beat for open throes
Of stormy sea to wallow on the floes
Speckled with foam like petals of the rose.
Beloved, I see the guidance of those twelve
In all the hopeful hearing where I delve
Among the manuscripts of ancient lore.
I find the silver stair and golden floor.

2 Esdras 2

1 So says YHWH, “I brought this folk out
Of bondage, and I gave *in shout*
To them commandments through my slaves
The prophets, but they *from their graves*
Would not obey them, and they made
My advice empty where it stayed.
2 “The mother who gave them birth spoke
To them, ‘Go, my children, *for broke*,
Since I’m a widow and forsaken.

3 “I reared you up with gladness *shaken*,
But mournfully, in sorrow waken
I to your loss, because you’ve sinned
Before YHWH Alohim and *grinned*
In doing evil in My sight.

4 “Now what can I do for your right?
For I’m a widow and forsaken.
Go, my children, and ask *unshaken*
For mercy from YHWH *unmistaken*.’
5 “I call upon you, Father, as
A witness more than any has
To the mother of the offspring,
Because they would not keep *the ring*
Of My treaty, 6 “so you may bring
Bewilderment on them and their
Mother to ruin *and despair*,
So they may have no children *there*.
7 “Let them be scattered among *all*
The nations, let their names *in call*
Be blotted from the earth, because
They have despised My pact *in laws*.

The blotting out of names upon the earth
And memory of every thing of worth
Is not the choice of You, Beloved, but that
The weary have forgotten where they sat.
The path of righteousness is never vain,
Although forgotten in the worldly reign,
The path of wickedness though often
crowned

With laurels, is paid for in pence and
pound.

Beloved, the name is safe and still allowed
That is caught in Your heart instead of
crowd.

The silsila of righteousness alone
Has value before You upon the throne.
Let my days be taught by obedience
To You alone, Beloved, and in Your tents.

8 “And woe to you, Assyria,
Who hide the wicked in your paw!
Perverted nation, mind what I
Did to Sodom and Gomorrah,
9 Whose country glares in scattered pitch
And piles of ashes in the ditch.
So will I do when folks decry
My message, says YHWH Almighty.”
10 So said YHWH to Ezra *in fee*,
“Tell My folk that I will give them
The kingdom of Jerusalem,
Which I meant to give Israel.

11 Besides, I'll take back to Myself
 Their glory, and will put on shelf
 Of others the eternal doors,
 That I had made for Israel's *stores*.
 12 The tree of life shall give them rife
 Perfume, and they shall not spend life
 In weary toil *upon their shores*,
 Neither toil nor become weary.
 13 Ask and you will receive, and pray
 That your days may be few and stay
 But briefly. The kingdom is yet
 Prepared for you, watch *what you get!*
 14 Call, O call heaven and earth to see,
 For I abandoned wicked spree
 And created the good, because
 I live, says YHWH *providing laws*.

Again I find the text that Jesus knew
 When he said ask and you will get a few,
 And find it in apocrypha, which means
 The fundamentalists who beat my beans
 Are wrong, wrong, wrong to spread the idle
 tale

That their own book and Bible is a whale
 In truth beyond the hidden books that find
 The truth is just as much theirs as the blind.
 Beloved, I sniff and smell the savour stored
 In every sacred book where You are Lord,
 And live to love and love to live the word
 That in their dusty covers has me stirred.
 Beloved, I see with sure and sheer delight
 The rising tempests of the true and right.

15 "Mother, embrace your sons, bring them
 Up with joy, as the dove for gem,
 And set their feet, because I chose
 You, says YHWH. 16 And *also* uprose
 The dead by My power from their graves,
 And I have brought them out of slaves
 Because I found My name's *rondeaux*.
 17 Don't be afraid, mother of spawn,
 For I have chosen you and drawn,
 Says YHWH. 18 I will send you your help,
 My servants Isaiah to yelp
 And Jeremiah just a whelp.
 By their advice I have made you
 Holy and ready and in view
 Twelve trees heavy with many kinds
 Of fruit as luscious vine unwinds,
 19 And the same number of springs
 flowing
 With milk and honey, and the glowing

Of seven mighty mountains on
 Which roses and lilies are drawn,
 By these I'll fill with joy your spawn.
 20 Protect the widow's rights and seek
 Justice for the orphan and meek,
 Give to the poor, defend those who
 Have no father to help and do,
 Give clothing to the shivering lad
 Who has no cover and is sad,
 21 Care for the injured and the weak,
 Don't make fun of the lame and peek,
 Protect the injured, let the blind
 Man have a sight of heaven's kind.

The ten commandments verily revealed
 On Sinai are the source of this pen's yield.
 They grow out of the trees of better fruit
 And from the twelve streams of honey to
 boot.

They are enclosed in roses, lilies too
 And rise on waves of milk to meet the dew.
 Commandments are a joy to comprehend,
 A glory to observe though blind in end,
 The fruit and milk and honey of the right
 That make a place of comfort in the night.
 Beloved, I seek Your law and love to grace
 The meadows and the bosquets of my
 place,
 Where I lift up a prayer of gratitude
 For everything in Your law that I've
 viewed.

22 Keep safe the old and young within
 Your walls, 23 when you find in the bin
 Any who are dead, bury them
 In a grave and mark on its hem,
 And I will give you the first place
 Upon My resurrection's trace.
 24 Stand and be still, my folk, for you
 Shall have your Sabbath rest when due.
 25 Good nurse, nourish your children, and
 Make strong their very feet to stand.
 26 No servant I have given you
 Will perish, but the residue
 I shall bring to account's accrue.

Even the rest You promise to the weak,
 Protection from the strong and those who
 seek
 To make the holy day a day to work
 Or fill the life of all with wicked shirk,
 Even the rest You give to humankind

And animals is not left to the blind,
But mentioned as a favour in the speech
That You give to Esdras as sweet as peach.
Beloved I take the law as Esdras knows
And feed on it as far as my faith goes
Until I find the blessings of repose
As well as doing right above the glass
Of government that is set up to pass.
I whisper the right words above the mass.

27 Don't be anxious, for when the day
Of trouble and anguish in sway
Comes, others shall weep as they pray,
But you'll rejoice to see the pay.
28 The nations shall envy you but
They'll not be able to do smut
Against you, says YHWH *on His way*.
29 My hands will cover you, that your
Children may not come to the door
Of Gehenna. 30 Rejoice, mother,
With your children, for I confer
Salvation on you, does YHWH say.
31 Remember your children that sleep,
Because I'll bring them from the deep
Places of the earth, and will show
Them mercy, for I'm in mercy,
Says YHWH the Lord the Almighty.
32 Embrace your children till I come,
And speak of mercy *in their sum*,
Because my springs run over, and
My grace will not fail *as I stand*."

A time of trouble such as never known
Flies out upon the earth without a groan
To decimate the wicked ones and lend
Its wings to evil and bring it an end.
A time of trouble on the fatal rise
Of earth beneath the lowering of the skies
Comes to the fore and brings peace to her
knees
And ushers in faith of eternities.
Beloved, I fear no trouble while You care
For Your own in the vacant light and glare
Of heathen ways and means around the
town.
I only bow to You and to Your crown.
Embrace me now, Your child, one secretly
Set by the fires of dull iniquity.

33 I, Ezra, was ordered by YHWH
On Mount Horeb to go in view
Of Israel. When I came near

They threw me out, refused to hear
YHWH's commandment *spoken to sear*.

34 So I say to you, nations that
Hear and understand *good and fat*,
"Wait for your shepherd, he will give
You *Sabbath* rest always to live,
Because the one who will come at
The age's end is close at hand.
35 "Be ready for the kingdom's *band*
Of reward, for eternal light
Will shine on you always in sight.
36 "Flee from the darkness of this time,
Receive the joy of glory's *climb*,
I in the sight of all make call
On my Saviour to witness *hall*.
37 "Receive what YHWH has given you
And be joyful, give Him thanks due
Who's called you to celestial realms.
38 "Get up and stand and see the feast
Of YHWH in number of increased
That have been sealed *and set at helms*.
39 "Those who've left darkness of this age
Have received gloried clothes *in stage*
From YHWH. 40 "So take again account
In your full number, Zion's *mount*,
And close the list of your folk who
Are clothed in white *righteousness' view*,
Who have fulfilled the law of YHWH.
41 "The number of your children, whom
You wished for is full *to the doom*,
So beg YHWH's hand upon your folk,
Who have been called from start *to stroke*,
That they may be made holy *yoke*."

The twelve times twelve thousand of sealed
are those
Who not only put on bright white new
clothes,
But have fulfilled Your law, Beloved, and
kept
It even when they were bowed down and
wept.
I count the names as Esdras in the past
And find the ranks depleted from the blast
And wonder where they are now who are
known
To keep Your law, Beloved, before Your
throne.

The tales of preacher and of priest go out
From pulpit and from street corner in shout
That You cannot be obeyed by a lout.

And yet the yokes they place in law and
hand
Are heavier by far for all to stand
And crush the poor upon the desert sand.

42 I, Ezra, saw on Zion's mount
A great crowd, which I could not count,
And all were praising YHWH with songs.

43 Among them was a youth *in thongs*,
Taller than any others there,
And on each head he placed a fair
Crown, but he was higher than they.
And I could hardly look away.

44 I asked an angel, "Who are these,
Sir?" 45 He answered and said to *please*
Me, "These are they who have put off
Mortal clothing *and not to scoff*
Have put on the immortal dress,
And they would the great name confess
Of Alohim, so now they've got
Crowns and palms for heritage lot."

46 Then I said to the angel, "Who
Is that young man who places *due*
Crowns on them and puts palms in hand?"

47 He answered and told me *to stand*,
"He is the Son of Alohim
[Messiah crowned as it would seem],
Whom they confessed in the world's
dream."

So I began to praise those who
Had stood *firm and* courageous *too*
Before the *holy* name of YHWH.

48 So the angel said to me, "Go,
Tell my folk how great and not slow
Are wonders of YHWH Alohim
That you have seen and how they teem."

The Son of God is not genetic trace
From the divine in spectre or in race,
But is the promised one, Messiah's grace
Who always sees the glory of Your face.
And he stands young and fair before the
throng

That raises up the praises due in song
To You, Beloved, from David's harp and
tent

To show the universe what You had meant.
I find the multitude before the sea,
I find them spread as far as Zion's tree,
And all are dressed in righteousness to be
A witness to Your law of liberty.
I find the multitude, but teeming far

Beyond their number is Your wondered
star.

2 Esdras 3

1 In thirtieth year after fate
Destroying our city *and great*,
I Salathiel, who'm also
Called Ezra, was upon the show
Of Babylon. I was in fit
As I lay on my bed *in grit*,
And my thoughts welled up in my heart,
2 Because I saw Zion in *cart*
Of desolation and the wealth
Of those in Babylon *for stealth*.

3 My mind was greatly troubled and
I began to make anxious stand
To the Most High, and said, 4 "O YHWH
Sovereign, did You not speak in view
At the beginning when You made
The earth, and without any aid,
Gave command to the dust and it
5 "Gave You Adam [red earth], a body fit,
Though lifeless? Yet he was the work
Of Your hands, and You breathed a *quirk*
Of life's breath into him, and he
Was brought to life before Your tree.

6 "And You led him into the gan
Which Your right hand had made for man
Planted before the earth appeared.

7 "You lay one obligation *geared*
Upon him, but he transgressed it,
And so straightway You came to sit
Appointing death for him and for
His descendants. From him there sprang
Nations and tribes, peoples *in fang*
And families *uncounted hang*.

Once there was choice between both life
and death,
But now as I live on from breath to breath,
That choice is made, the plot original
Is not of sin for wicked arsenal,
But of death only. Now I'm faced with
choice

Between the right and wrong to give one
voice.

Once there was choice between the right
and wrong
And some men chose the right and sang the
song
And others chose the left and went into
The night and shadows without residue

Of hope upon the fainting violet.
But some chose right and sang the fast
motet
And found the place of peace above the
flight
Of harp and swallow in the morning light.

8 “And every nation did its own
Will and did wicked things alone
Before you and scorned you, and You
Did not stop them from what they do.
9 “But again, in its time You brought
The flood upon earth’s dwellers’ plot
To destroy all of them *as ought*.
10 “And the same fate fell on them too:
As death came on Adam [red earth] *and
crew*,
So the flood fell on them as due.
11 “But You left one of them *to scold*,
Noah with his righteous household,
And those descended from his *fold*.
12 “When those who lived on earth began
To multiply, they brought forth *man
And woman* children and the folks
And many nations *in their yokes*,
And once again started to be
More ungodly than fathers’ *spree*.
13 “And as they did iniquity
Before You, You chose for yourself
One of their number *on the shelf*,
Whose name was Abraham, 14 “and You
Loved him, and to him only You
Revealed the end of times, *to sight
Alone and* secretly by night.
15 “You made an everlasting pact
With him, and promise him to act
With faithfulness to his offspring,
And gave him Isaac, and *in fling*
To Isaac Jacob and Esau.

The reason You made Abram know the
times
Was not for good works on the hill he
climbs
But simply that You love him about all.
Love knows no reasons when set to the
wall.
I see the arbitrary as it seems
In everything that happens out of dreams,
And yet believe that justice marks Your
way
At least when scrutinized by light of day.

The everlasting covenant You made
With Abram, Isaac and Jacob waylaid
Is still upon my heart: I wish to do
According to commandments that are true,
Not only by the natural desires
That fuel the human heart with vacant fires.

16 “And You set Jacob *at the draw*
Apart for Yourself, but Esau
You did reject, Jacob became
A great multitude *and in fame*.
17 “And when You led his descendants
Out of Egypt, You made them prance
To Mount Sinai. 18 “You came to bend
Down the sky and shake earth to send
Tremors around the world, and make
The deep to tremble, and *to stake*
A trouble to the times *in wake*.
19 “Your glory passed through the four
gates
Of fire and earthquake, wind and *states*
Of ice, to give the law to *lead*
The descendants of Jacob’s breed,
And Your commandment to the folk
Of Israel *under Your yoke*.

The gates of fire and earth and wind inspire
Beyond the portals of greenness in ire
The ice the angels keep above the wake
Of Enoch for the Watchers’ and their sake.
The desert fountain, spring, an eye not
blind
Is open on the sands at last to find
The heights bear down and freeze all in its
path
Into the ice that makes eternal wrath.
Beloved, I whirl upon the four gates here
And find that Ezra brushes off the tear
And turns the strident melody of fear
To glories on the dergah floor I pace.
The portals rimed with frost catch shining
face
As sparks arise from earth to air in grace.

20 “But You did not remove from them
Their evil heart, so that the gem
Of Your law might bear fruit in them.
21 “For the first Adam [red earth], evil
hearted,
Transgressed overcome and departed,
As also all his children started.
22 “The sickness was inherited,

The law in the folk's heart was bred
Along with wickedness in root,
But what was good left on the scoot,
And only wickedness remained.

Poor Calvin followed Augustine to find
His sinful heart was always in a bind.
Perhaps he read good Ezra in the mood
Of laying blame on ancestry and brood
Instead of on the human choice to do
According to Your law set up and true.
The wicked heart may well be on the pile,
And yet it is more wicked by the mile
Because Your law is there beneath the
smile.

The wicked heart has choice before the
moon,
It follows star and sun in every room.
Let my heart follow in a better way,
One that submits to Your law on the day
You choose to speak aloud and in Your
sway.

23 "So times passed and the years were
gained,
And You raised up a servant named
David. 24 "You ordered him unblamed
To build a city for Your name,
And there to offer You in claim
Sacrifice from Your own in flame.
25 "So it went on for many years,
But the town's dwellers changed their gears
Transgressing 26 "in all things to do
As Adam [red earth] and his offspring's
crew,
For they also had evil heart.
27 "So You delivered town and cart
Into the power of Your foes' part.
28 "Then I said also in my heart,
Are the acts of those who live in
Babylon better for their sin?
Is that why she's become the ruler
Over Zion *as a pre-schooler*?
29 "For when I came here I in wonder
Saw wicked deeds and without number,
And my soul has seen sinners many
During these thirty years in penny.

The word of Adam was not spoken for
The sin original lying at door
As to his son You once proclaimed the
wrong.

Oh no, it is a different sabred song.
The choice is always there, the spring's not
dry:

All can do well even if none still try.
The word and refrain are given to show
That wickedness is just the common row
Of every nation, so that Israel
When punished for the evil of her spell
Is punished without justice unless fell
The judgement on each people who are
here
Succeeding in a wicked train and gear.
I turn to You, Beloved, from hope and fear.

And my heart sank with grief, 30 "for I
Have seen how You put up with sty
Of sin in others and spared those
Who act in wickedness they chose,
And yet destroyed Your folk in throes,
And saved Your enemies in rows,
31 "And have not shown to any one
How to understand what You've done.
Are Babylon's deeds better than
Those of Zion set out to scan?
32 "Or has another nation known
You besides Israel on throne?
Or what nations have so believed
Your covenants and unreprieved
As these tribes of Jacob relieved?
33 "Yet their reward has not appeared
Their labour borne no fruit as feared.
For I have travelled here and there
Among the nations and seen fair
Abundance of their wealth in share,
Though they remember not Your law.
34 "So compare our wickedness' claw
With that of the world now at large,
And see which is the worse in barge.
35 "When have the dwellers of the earth
Not sinned before You in their berth?
Or what nation has kept Your law
So well as Israel's ma and pa?
36 "You may find here and there a man
Who's kept Your law in speck and span,
But nations You shall never find
Among earth's rulers and unkind."

The balance of the fruitier is the cry
Of Ezra or at least as people vie.
He begs that You will weigh the bag of sin
Against the margin caught and held in bin

As though the wicked act could be caught
up
And carried in a pitcher and a cup.
Will Hajji Bektash please stand up and say
That balancing of weights is not the way
That You, Beloved, see night and evil day?
Truth is, though, Ezra's right, there is no
land
Where righteousness is kept on every hand.
A single dervish here, Kalender there
Is all there be among lovely and fair,
The perfect man stands out, others forbear.

2 Esdras 4

1 The angel that was sent to me,
Whose name was Uriel, told me
2 "You fail completely now to see
The state of this word, do you think
That you can comprehend the *brink*
Of the Most High?" 3 And I replied,
"Yes, sir." He answered me as guide,
"I've been sent to show you three ways,
And set three tasks to you *in daze*.
4 If you can explain one to me,
I'll open to you completely
The very thing you wish to see,
And show you why your heart's *in maze*."
5 I said "Keep talking, sir." And he
Said to me, "Go and weigh for me
The weight of fire, or measure me
A tale of wind, or call back free
The day that's past eternally."
6 I answered and said "Who of those
Born can answer the things you chose
To ask me what I should disclose?"

The three tasks take the first two gates in
sight,
And open to the heart both fire and might
Of wind, the gates of dervish path and law
Before the angel's words spoken in awe.
Two gates more are in secret faintly
wrapped
Beneath the aspen leaves that clapped and
clapped.
Awareness of Your view and sacred truth
Are not the playing grounds of fallow
youth,
But are as fluent in escaping way
As is the bound and brief of yesterday.
Beloved, I know the treasured measure
taught

Of fire and wind by chemist and their lot,
And yet the secret stays despite man's will
And looks down quickly from the brow of
hill."

7 And he said to me, "If I'd asked
You, 'How many dwellings have basked
In the heart of the sea, or how
Any streams are at the deep's prow,
Or how many above the skies,
Or who the exits of hell vies,
Or where's entrance to paradise?'"

8 "Perhaps you would have said to me,
'I never went down in the sea,
Nor ever as yet into hell,
Nor did I rise in heaven to tell.'

9 "But now I've asked you just about
The fire and wind and day in route,
Things through which you have passed,
without

Which you cannot exist, and you
Have given me no answer in view!"

10 And then he said to me, "If you
Cannot understand things which you
Have grown up with, 11 how can your
mind

The deep ways of the Most High find?
How can one who's already worn
Out by the corrupt world in scorn
Understand incorruption's *bound*?"

When I heard this, I fell prostrate
12 And said to him, "It would be *fate*
Better for us not to be here
Than to come here and live in fear
Ungodly, and to suffer and
Not understand why out of hand."

13 He answered me and said, "I went
Into a forest of trees sent
Upon the plain, and they made plan
14 And said, 'Come, let us go and scan
In war against the sea, that it
May recoil before us a bit,
And give us more space where to sit.'

I hear the whisper of the graven fir
Upon the quartzite hill and on the spur
Of pine-mad reaches where the aspen
thicket

Gives way to larger trees past margin
picket.

I hear the sough of birch both stiffly
twigged

And graceful bend of the more softly
sprigged
And train my ear to catch in faint aplomb
The plans of forest made in storm and
calm.
If I could just hear what the wise trees say
I might be able on the single day
To capture fire and wind and at the bay
Rejoice in knowing where the dreams and
brush
Of yesteryears have tumbled to in hush,
And where the moss and lichens spring as
lush.

15 And in the same way the sea waves
Planned to make of forest its slaves
And said, 'Come, let us go up and
Conquer the forest on the land
So we may have more room to stand.'
16 But the forest plan was in vain,
For fire came and consumed the plain,
17 And also the plan of the waves
Of the sea, for the sand *that paves*
The shore stood firm and stopped the
knaves.

18 If now you were a judge between
Them, for whom would you intervene,
And which would you condemn on scene?"
19 I answered saying, "Each has made
A foolish plan, for the land's laid
To forest, and the sea's assigned
To bear its waves to the shore *lined*."
20 He answered me and said, "You've
judged

Correctly, so why have you budged
From reason in your own case here?
21 "For as the land's assigned to cheer
The forest and the sea to waves,
So also those who find their graves
Upon the earth can understand
Only what is upon the land,
And he who is above the skies
Can understand the heavens' rise."

To be created is to be in fact
Unknowledgeable of the noble act
That gives the meaning to the show and
bourn.

To be created is to be foresworn.
And yet created though I be, I share
Angelics and divinity to bear
A wonder for the morning and the air,

The fire of sunrise on the crystal stair.
Beloved, I see the plans of deer and mouse
In wisdom overhauled, the ways of grouse
Untempered by the autumn air and cold:
Beloved, I see all nature step out bold,
But in that stepping failing to see all
That You have planned though shown on
field and wall.

22 Then I replied and said, "I beg
You, sir, why am I given leg
In power of understanding then?"

23 "For I did not wish to inquire
About the ways above all men,
But about those things we aspire
To know each day, why Israel
Has been delivered to the spell
Of Gentiles in reproach, and why
The people that You loved descry
Captivity to godless tribes,
And the law of our fathers' *bribes*
Is made of no effect and missed,
Written treaties no more exist,
24 "And why we pass from the world's
sight

Like locusts, and our life's a night
In mist, and we're not counted free
To obtain from our Lord mercy.
25 "But what will He do for his name,
By which we are called *and in fame*?
It is about these things I ask."

26 He answered me and said, "If you
Live on, you will see what is true,
And if you live long, you will oft
Be amazed, for the age *aloft*
Comes quickly to its end *as due*.

27 "For it will not be able to
Bring the things promised to the few
Righteous in their appointed times,
Because this age is full of *crimes*
Of sadness and infirmities.

28 "For the evil about which you
Ask me has been sown, but the due
Harvest of it has not yet come.

29 So if what's sown is not in sum
Yet reaped, and if the place where bad
Has been sown does not pass *the pad*,
The field where the good has been sown
Will not appear since it's not grown.

30 For seed of evil was sown in
Adam [red earth]'s heart from the start of
sin,

And how much ungodliness it
Has produced until now to sit,
And will produce until the time
Of threshing comes *at the last chime!*

Philosophy of humankind relates
Only to the questions of human states.
I know no halls of brightness above dawn,
I know no paths eternal coming on.
I do not ask beyond the pain I share
With sentient beings crowding everywhere
To hear my sermons on the common woe.
Both beast and man join in the flowered
show.

And yet the pain of hearth and settled
ground
Has source in seeds that are in mythic
bound
And lost in time and space of human eye,
At least the eye that wanders on this sky.
Beloved, the evil seed once planted bears
Repeatedly the fruit of idle cares.

31 Consider now for yourself how
Much fruit of ungodliness' row
A single grain of evil seed
Has produced in the world *of weed*.
32 When heads of grain without count still
Are sown, how great then will they fill
A threshing floor *to fit the bill!*"
33 Then I replied and said, "How long
And when will these things come along?
Why are our years so few and bad?"
34 He answered me and said *as sad*,
"You do not hasten faster than
The Most High, for your haste *in plan*
Is for yourself, but the Most High
Hastens on behalf of the cry
Of many. 35 Did not righteous souls
In their graves too ask of the goals
Of these things saying, 'How long must
We to remain here *clothed in the dust?*
When comes the harvest of reward?"

A single act of negligence, of love,
Of singleness instead of sight above,
And seeds are planted without hand or
glove
To sprout each time the storms shake
growing trees.
Desire to know both wickedness and ease

As well as the good things that come to
please

Without relying on Creator's plan
Is the seed that is downfall in the man.
Yet every moment is the last choice made
And every act upon the stage is played
That brings the cycle of creation's grade.
Beloved, I breathe my favourite in the wind
And let go of the lusted for and sinned
And grasp eternal leaning on bright-
skinned.

36 "And Jeremiel *with the sword*
Of archangel answered and said,
'When the number of those like bred
As you yourselves is filled instead,
For he has judged the present age,
37 And measured the times *in a gauge*,
And counted the years by their number,
And He'll not move or wake *from slumber*
Until that measure's filled *the page*.'"
38 Then I answered and said, "O YHWH
Sovereign, but all of us here too
Are full of ungodliness due.
39 "And it is perhaps on account
Of us that the time of *amount*
In threshing is delayed *for right*,
Because of the sins *in His sight*
Of those who live on earth." 40 And he
Answered me saying "Go freely
And ask a pregnant dame if, when
Her nine months are fulfilled again,
Her womb can then retain the child
Within her longer as though wild."
41 And I said, "No, sir, it cannot."
And he said to me, "In *the rot*
Of Hades the chambers of souls
Are like the womb and have their tolls.
42 "For just as a woman makes haste
To escape the pangs of birth *and taste*,
So also do these places hasten
To give back those things given *to chasten*
Committed to them from the start.
43 Then the things that you wish in part
To see will be shown to your heart."

The resurrection's not a doubtful thing.
No will of man or god in questioning
May change the time awaited and its bill.
The resurrection marches on to fill.
The chambers of the deep where lie in
sleep

The shadows of departed and to keep
 Are not themselves asleep, but groan to
 cast
 Their burdens upon earth to live at last.
 Beloved, the Christian calling at the rail
 Of creed that tells the faith of shining mail
 That hope of body after the last blast
 Is only murmured doubt beside trail
 Of glory that abides beneath the mast,
 Of marvels that await and cannot fail.

44 I answered and said, "If I've found
 Grace in your sight, and if it's sound,
 And if I'm worthy, 45 "show me too,
 Whether more time's to come in view
 Than has passed, or whether for us
 The greater's gone *by omnibus*.
 46 "For I know what has gone by, but
 I do not know what time is shut."
 47 And he said to me, "Stand here at
 My right side, and I'll show out flat
 The meaning of a sign and wonder."
 48 And so I stood and looked, *by thunder*,
 A flaming furnace passed by me,
 And after the flame I could see
 Indeed the smoke remained to be.
 49 And after this a rain cloud passed
 Before me and poured down *aghast*
 A heavy and hard rain, and when
 The rainstorm had passed by, again
 Drops remained in the cloud to last.
 50 And he said to me, "Think it through,
 For as the rain is more than dew
 In drops, and the fire's greater than
 The smoke, so the amount in span
 That passed was far greater, but drops
 And smoke remained there *in their stops*."
 51 Then I prayed and said, "Do you think
 That I shall live till those days' brink?
 Or who'll be alive in those days?"
 52 He answered me and said *for praise*,
 "Concerning the signs of which you
 Ask me, I can tell you a few,
 But I was not sent to tell you
 Concerning your life, for I do
 Not know *your numbered days in view*.

The proof is greater than the question
 posed,
 And goes beyond parameters disclosed.
 The human hope is couched in small
 bewares,

And thrust among the lilies and the pears.
 But when reality breaks on the gloom
 On human blindness tottering in the room
 Of daily sweeping, then the proof falls flat,
 Ignored, unneeded before great fiat.
 Beloved, I see the breath of wren abide
 The touch of frost and still by crickle side
 Lift up the sere and cobbled eye to know
 That all is done despite the pomp and show.
 Beloved, I see the proofing in the flash
 Of one brief moment and the single dash.

2 Esdras 5

1 "Now as for the signs: indeed, days
 Are coming when those who live *maze*
 Of earth shall be seized with great fear,
 And the way of truth disappear,
 The land shall be void of faith *dear*.
 2 "Unrighteousness shall be increased
 Beyond what you yourself *as priest*
 See, and beyond what you have known.
 3 "And the land which you now see grown
 Shall be desert, untrodden, shown
 A desolation to the bone.
 4 "But if the Most High grants you life,
 You'll see it thrown into the strife
 After the third age then the sun
 Shall shine forth at night and the moon
 Shall brighten up the day when done.
 5 "And blood shall drip from wood, the
 stone
 Lift up its voice, the people lone
 Shall be in trouble and the stars
 Shall fall down from the sky *in bars*.

The signs in heavens have long since
 appeared,
 The dark day when the people looked and
 feared,
 The moon to blood as Jesus testified
 In Matthew 24, the sun to hide.
 The stars fell from the sky in plentitude
 Till night was brightened like the day once
 viewed.
 The signs and wonders are all there to see
 And yet there is so little faith to be.
 Beloved, I too doubt signs and wonder why
 The earth speaks to some souls as in defy
 And others to a soothing into sleep.
 The earth itself divides the goats and sheep,
 And heaven reflects the placid waters deep.
 I turn between the arguments and fly.

6 "And one shall reign whom those who dwell
 On earth do not expect to tell,
 And birds shall flee away a spell,
 7 "The sea of Sodom cast up fish,
 And one whom many do not wish
 Shall raise his voice by night, and all
 Shall hear his voice and know his call.
 8 There shall be chaos too in places
 Far and near and fire break its traces,
 And wild beasts roam beyond their spaces,
 And menstuous women give birth to
 Monsters. 9 And salt waters in view
 Shall be found in the sweet, and all
 Friends shall oppose each other's call,
 And reason herself shall be hidden,
 And wisdom shall withdraw as bidden
 Into its chamber, 10 and be sought
 By some but not be found or taught,
 And wickedness and unrestraint
 Shall increase on earth to its taint.
 11 And one country shall ask its neighbour,
 'Has righteousness of any labour,
 Or any one who does right, passed
 Through you?' And it will speak aghast,
 'No.' 12 And at that time men shall hope
 But not obtain, and they shall grope
 But their ways shall not prosper fast.
 13 These are the signs which I'm permitted
 To tell you, and if you pray fitted
 Again, and weep as you do now,
 And fast for seven days' allow,
 You'll hear yet greater things than these."
 14 Then I awoke, as though from freeze
 My body shuddered greatly, and
 My soul seized and in faintness spanned.

Indeed reason herself has gone away
 And left the world to lust and fools in
 sway,
 And wisdom is found only in the room
 That is a hidden chamber from such doom.
 Friends that should be are filled with
 violence,
 Opposing those who still in innocence
 Aloud cry for the wrenching of Your law
 By those who claim to serve it and in awe.
 Beloved, I turn from every man in pay,
 I turn from every church and mosque and
 stay
 Away from synagogue of Satan's own

As the Apocalypse has long since shown,
 And turn from even You Yourself to find
 You as the goal of my flight from the blind.

15 But the angel who'd come to talk
 With me held me and *at the block*
 Gave me strength and set on my feet.
 16 Then on the second night there came
 To me a chief of the folk's fame,
 Phaltiel and said "Where've you been?
 And why's your face as sad *as sin*?
 17 "Or don't you know that Israel's been
 Delivered up to you to win
 In the land of captivity?
 18 "So get up, eat some bread and be
 For us and don't forsake the wee,
 As does the shepherd who forsakes
 His flock in sight of the wolves' *rakes*."
 19 Then I said to him, "Part from me
 And don't come near me *in the fee*
 Of seven days, and then you may
 Come back to me and hear me say."
 He heard me and left me to stay.
 20 I fasted then for seven days,
 Mourning and weeping *to amaze*,
 As Uriel the angel had
 Commanded me, *so I was sad*.
 21 And after seven days the thoughts
 Of my heart were troubled *in plots*.

I wonder if the fast began upon
 A Sabbath day when it began to dawn
 In which case revelation would be told
 Upon the Friday eve lit up with gold
 In great awaiting of the judgement day.
 Perhaps the fasting went another way,
 Beginning on the first day of the week
 And ending with the Sabbath and the seek
 Of workdays on the Sunday. Revelation
 Would then come on that day of pagan
 ration.
 Beloved, whatever day I fast or feast,
 I look to You alone for the increased,
 And find the blessing of the empty plate
 Is just as full as feasting and as great.

22 Then I regained my rightful mind
 And spoke once more *as I aligned*
 In the presence of the Most High.
 23 And I said, "O Almighty Lord,
 From every forest that I spy
 On earth and from all its trees' sward

You have chosen one vine, 24 “and from
All the lands of the world You’ve come
To take for You a single spot,
And from all the flowers of the world
You’ve chosen you one lily *furled*,
25 “And from all the depths of the sea
You’ve filled Yourself one river’s *lea*,
And from all cities that are built
You’ve hallowed Zion *to the hilt*,
26 “And from all the birds You have made
You’ve named for Yourself one dove
strayed,

And from all the flocks that You keep
You have provided You one sheep,
27 “And from all multitudes of folk
You’ve taken one people *in yoke*,
And to this people, whom You’ve loved,
You’ve given the law hand *and gloved*
Approved by all just as You spoke.
28 “And now, O Lord, why have You
given

Over the one to many striven,
Dishonoured the one root beyond
The others, and scattered *the frond*
Of Your only one in the crowd?
29 “Those who opposed Your promise loud
Have trodden down those who believed
Your covenants, *though unreprieved*.
30 “If You really hate Your folk’s bands,
Then punish them with Your own hands.”

The lily and the dove are set to right
Between and then above the velvet night.
I see the lily by the path as white
And fragrant as the bird cherry’s delight.
I see the pallid dove in the starshine
And drink them both with eyes on limpid
wine.

The lily and the dove are caught by wind
And torn from feathered petals when they
sinned.
Beloved, look on the lily strewn upon
The shattered flecks of light before the
dawn,
And trust the perfumed plight and pluck the
scent.

Beloved, look on the dove with open beak
In silent cry on behalf of the weak,
And thrust the pain from where the white
dove went.

31 When I had spoken these words, then

The angel who had come again
To me the previous night was sent
To me, 32 and to me message lent,
“Listen to me, and I’ll teach you,
Pay close attention to my view,
And I will tell you more and true.”
33 And I said, “Speak, sir.” And he said
To me, “Are you discomfited
For Israel? Or do you love
Him more than his Maker above?”
34 And I said, “No, sir, but because
My grief moves me I’ve shown my claws,
For all the time I suffer weight
In my heart and try in my state
To understand the Most High’s way
Searching part of His judgement day.”
35 And he said to me, “You cannot.”
And I replied, “O sir, why not?
Why then was I born *in the plot*?
Why did I not die in the womb,
So I should not see Jacob’s doom
And the fate of Israel *in room*?”

Again the question rises to the fore
As always with the human mind in store,
Why do I have ability to count
That reason makes a dent in the amount
If true reality’s beyond my ken?
Why am I created with such a yen?
That is a problem that is sure to fold
Whether a crisis hits the meek and bold
Or whether everything is clear and cold.
Beloved, I hear the turning of the screw,
The philosophic patter of the dew,
And when I touch the answer that is true
The veils return to question things anew.
And yet I see the flashing streaks of gold
And know reality hidden in You.

36 He said to me, “Count up for me
Those who have not yet come to be,
And gather up scattered raindrops,
And make the withered flowers *with props*
Bloom once again for me *in hops*,
37 “Open for me the chambers closed,
And bring out winds already posed,
Or show me picture of a voice,
And then I will explain your choice
And make you understand the vice.”

The angel’s challenges have now been met.
At least I’ve seen a picture and sell set

Of the voice speaking, singing on the air
In waves compounded graphically and fair.
I've seen the sine wave, square and saw-
toothed form

Appear upon the scope and the buzz warm
Reveal the ways and features of the voice
Set clearly for the eye and not ear's choice.
But the advance of gross technology
Does nothing to set wondering soul free
Of its despair to find eternity
Is lost and tumbled in the mundane chair.
Technology does not remove my care,
Beloved, as I sit in the apple tree.

38 And I said, "O my sovereign Lord,
Who's able to know these things *stored*
Except he who lives not with men?"

39 "For my part I am here again
Without wisdom, and how can I
Speak about the things on the sly
Which You have asked of me and why?"

40 He said to me, "Well, just as you
Cannot any of these things do,
So you cannot reveal My cause
Or the end of the love in laws
That I've promised My folk *for straws*."

41 And I said, "Yet indeed, O Lord,
You have charge of those who're aboard
And living at the close of time,
But what will those do *in the grime*
Who were before us, or we, or
Those who come after us *in chore*?"

42 He said to me, "I liken state
Of my judgment to circle's weight,
Just as for those who are the last
There is no slowness *at the cast*,
So for those who have the first taste
There is no hurrying or haste."

The problem Esdras feels is that of time
Seen past to future in unending rhyme,
But You, Beloved, give angels words to say
That time is like a circle in its play,
And what is first is just as last as last,
And what is last is just as first to cast
Its weight upon the ceaseless, shifting
shore.

The Greek in me would always ask for
more.

Beloved, though life is circular at best,
And history's a thing never at rest,

I still whirl through the times of life and
find

Returning on the hill more than half blind
The soul reveals the transient dance as feet
Seek pirouette in advance and retreat.

43 Then I answered and said, "Could You
Not have created at one brew
Those who have been and those who are
And those who will be on the bar,
So You might show Your judgement
sooner?"

44 He answered me and said *for tuner*,
"Creation cannot make more haste
Than the Creator, nor can space
Hold at one time all in their place."

45 And I said, "How have You said to
Your servant that You'll give and true
Life at one time to all Your pew?

If therefore all creatures will live
At one time and creation give
Sustenance to them all, it might
Even be able now in sight

To support all of them in crowd
At this one time, *if You allowed*."

46 He said to me, "Ask woman's womb,
And say to it, 'If you *give room*
To bear ten children, why just one
After another *when you've done*?'
Tell it to bear ten at one time."

47 I said "Of course it can't *for mime*,
But only each in its own time."

48 He said to me, "Even so I
Have given the womb of the earth by
Those who from time to time shall die.

49 "As an infant does not give birth,
And a woman old *in her worth*
No longer does, so I've ordained
The world I created *arraigned*."

Dear Ezra comes again to question why
The circle is a movement in the sky
And not a static hope and its fulfilment,
As a fish both breathes and swims by its
gillment.

The question is fit for the human brain,
Who's capable of conceiving the reign
Inevitable of both time and space
While all the while believing there's no
trace

Of either in the deep reality.

The mythopoeic mind is one set free,

And that's the strength of human race and heart,
As well as the downfall of horse and cart.
Beloved, it is not patience You regard
In man, but ecstasy before the card.

50 Then I inquired and said, "Since You
Have now given to me the view,
Let me speak once more before You.
Is our mother, of whom You speak
Still young? Or is she out to seek
Old age approaching *crack and creak*?"
51 He answered me, "Ask womankind
Who bears children, and she'll unblind.
52 "Say to her, 'Why are those whom you
Have recently given birth to
Not like those to whom you gave birth
Before, but small in height *and girth*?'
53 "And she herself will answer you,
'Those born in the strength of her youth
Are different from those born *in truth*
During the time of old age, when
The womb is failing of women.'
54 "You also should consider that
You and your mates are small *and flat*
Compared to those who came before,
55 "And those who come after you *bore*
Will be smaller than you, as born
Of a creation old and worn,
Aging and passing from the strength
Of youth that it once had *at length*."
56 And I said, "O Lord, I beseech
You, if I have found grace *to reach*
In Your sight, show your servant through
Whom You visit creation's *due*."

The concept of degenerations whizzes
About my head in contrast to the fizzes
That evolution would awaken there.
This world is full of the successful fair.
And yet the progress that is tooted here
Is but a tinselled relic of the drear.
The hope that future days may see the spoil
Of death and illness reach back on the coil
Is like to storm the media and take
The innocent in its fell clutch and wake.
Beloved, I see the giants in the view
And think that giantism is the cue
That soon the species will meet fate of all
That turn extinct upon the earthly ball.

2 Esdras 6

1 And he said to me, "At the start
Of the earth's circle, e'er the gates
Of the world were in place and part,
Before the gathered wind abates,
2 Before the rumbling thunder sound,
Before lightning flashes to ground,
Before paradise' land was laid,
3 Before beauty of flowers was made,
Before the strength of movement stayed,
Before gathering of angel bands,
4 Before the height of heaven stands,
Before the measured firmaments
Were named, before the footstool tents
Of Zion were set up, 5 and before
The present years were set in store,
Before sinners' minds were estranged,
And before those were sealed arranged
Who stored up treasures of faith's yield,
6 Then I planned these things in their field,
And they were made through Me and not
Through any other in the plot,
And just as the end shall come through
Me and not through another due."

I hope, Beloved, this word that naught was
made
Through any other in all the parade
Does not mean they are wrong who see
Your Word
Creator and incarnate as though blurred
Between the Maker and the made that
stirred.
If so, Beloved, the sweet Christian is wrong
In singing Jesus Christ all the day long.
Don't strike me with the Inquisition fast,
Beloved, I merely doubt, I do not cast
The faith apostolic away from mast.
For me the Decalogue alone's enough
And dogma's wars and other things so
tough
Are outside realms I dwell upon by day
Or dream about in slumber's mangled way.

7 And I replied and said, "What will
Be the dividing of times shrill?
Or when will be first age's end
And the beginning that shall bend
The age that follows to descend?"
8 He said to me, "From Abraham
To Isaac, because from that lamb
Were born Jacob and Esau, for
Jacob's hand held Esau's heel's claw

From the beginning. 9 For Esau
 Is the end of this age, and Jacob
 Is start of the next age to wake up.
 10 “For the beginning of a man
 Is his hand, and the end to scan
 Of a man is his heel, between
 The heel and the hand seek no scene,
 Ezra!” 11 I replied and I said,
 “O sovereign Lord, if in my dread
 I’ve found grace in Your sight, 12 show
 Your
 Servant the end of Your signs’ store
 Which You did show me but in part
 On a night and before in start.”

The question Esdras poses is to know
 The end of the world and the glitter show.
 The answer of the Lord, as You portray
 The issue is not time but a light ray.
 The grasping of the heal is not far from
 The hoop of serpent swallowing its bum.
 Where I grew up they used to tell such tales
 Of hoop snakes that could roll themselves
 like whales
 Down mountainsides so fast that they got
 where
 They were going before they hit the air.
 Arrival before the departure time
 Is otherwise by airplane flying west
 Into the next time zone to beat the zest.
 I don’t know what there is to beat the
 rhyme.

13 He answered and he said to me,
 “Get up and stand on your feet free
 And you’ll hear a full, sounding voice.
 14 “And if the place where is your choice
 To stand is greatly shaken 15 “while
 The voice is speaking, don’t revile
 In terror, for the word is for
 The end, and the foundations’ store
 Of the earth will understand 16 that
 The speech concerns them where they’re at.
 They’ll tremble and be shaken too,
 Knowing their end must change the crew.”

It may be that the stones hear nothing when
 The voice is raised aloud by common men.
 But when an angel of the Lord comes
 down,
 And when Your voice, Beloved, is heard in
 town,

The boulders and the falling streams awake
 While men still sleep, to hear the sound
 You make.
 It may be that the grass and trees hear
 naught
 When daughters of the elite, fine and taut,
 Shout above the din of the tightened string.
 It may be so, but after everything,
 The earth itself hears of the coming doom
 And trembles, even shudders, at the gloom.
 Beloved, my ear is turned and tuned and
 yet,
 I am no prophet nor his son in debt.

17 When I heard this, I got right up,
 Stood on my feet, listened like tup,
 And truly a voice spoke, whose sound
 Was like many waters *on ground*.
 18 And it said, “Indeed, the days come
 And it shall be when I in sum
 Come to find earth’s inhabitants
 19 “And when I require from *the dance*
 Of doers of iniquity
 Their iniquity’s penalty,
 And when Zion’s humbling is done,
 20 “And when the seal is set and won
 Upon the age about to pass,
 Then I will show these signs *en masse*:
 The books shall be opened before
 The firmament, and all on shore
 Shall see it together in store.
 21 “Year-old infants shall raise the voice,
 And women with child without choice
 Shall give and early birth to sons
 At three or four months and in tons
 Shall these live and dance and rejoice.

The Christ Messiah spoke from cradle
 when
 His mother was maligned by evil men,
 And thus affirmed this prophecy and true
 Repeated from Psalm eight and brought in
 view.
 The other prophecy is still not done:
 The four month babe in womb and born for
 fun
 Has not yet survived to report the deed.
 Technology and science as a creed
 Is likely to push back to three in speed
 Before the aged earth retaliates
 For what men do with science by their
 hates.

Beloved, I feel the trembling of the earth
And see the wonders of my human birth,
And walk a path between inviolates.

22 "Sown fields shall quickly be unsown,
Full storehouses empty *to bone*,

23 "The trumpet then shall sound aloud,
And when all hear it *in the crowd*,
They'll suddenly be terrified.

24 "Then friends make war on friends
beside

Them like enemies, and the earth
And those who inhabit its girth
Shall be in horror, and the springs
Of the fountains shall stop in rings,
So that for three hours they'll not flow.

25 "And whoever's alive to show

After all I've foretold to you
Shall be saved and see what I do
In salvation before the view
Of the end of my world on cue.

26 "And they shall see the men occulted,
Taken up, though from birth insulted
Have not tasted of death, and then
The hearts of all earth-dwelling men
Shall be changed to a different hue.

27 "For evil shall be blotted out,
And deceit quenched, *and with a shout*

28 "Shall faithfulness blossom and *all*
Corruption overcome *in thrall*,
And Truth, so long without fruit bourn,
Shall be revealed *upon that morn.*"

I wait disclosure of those hidden in
Your loving heart, those great men without
sin,

Enoch of old and just Elijah and
Jesus and the Mahdi upon the sand.
The promise is that evil's blotted out
On that day when the secret ones with
shout

Appear to rule the earth and change the
hearts

Of men from competition to the arts.
Beloved, I wait the day and very hour
When I shall see Your coming and in
power

To chase the lusty course from off my deck
(And be that time today and on my neck)
And show the loved who hidden from the
earth

Have been through age and ages men of
worth.

29 While he was speaking to me truly
The ground where I stood shook unduly.

30 And he said to me, "I have come
To show you this tonight in sum.

31 "So if you'll pray again and fast
Again for seven days, at last

I will again declare to you
Greater things than just these in view,

32 "Because your voice is surely heard
Before the Most High, and is stirred
The Mighty One by your uprightness
And He's also observed the tightness
Of purity which you've maintained
From your youth in a life unstained.

33 "That's why He sent me to show you
All these things, and to say to you,
'Believe and do not be afraid!

34 "Do not be quick to think unstead
Vain thoughts concerning former times,
Lest you be hasty of last times."

The vision is marked off and week by week
The little day of judgement that I seek
Returns with darkening of Sabbath day
With nightwork in my chambered
hideaway

To rend my life and make it new again
Before the onslaught of both beasts and
men.

The vision is a vision of the great
And terrible day that You still instate
In Sabbath while I pray and fast a while
Remembering to coming day and royal.
Beloved, I seek out Esdras in his fame
And find him in the Sabbath's round and
game

Filled with the hope of future gain and loss
Of every sort of sorrow and of cross.

35 Now after this I wept again
And fasted seven days *in den*,
In order to fill the three weeks
As I had been told *in my streaks*.

36 On the eighth night my heart was faint
Again within me *for complaint*,

And I began to speak before
The presence of Most High once more.

37 My spirit was greatly aroused,
And my soul in distress caroused.

38 I said, "O Lord, You did speak at
The start of creation's fiat,
And said on the first day, 'Let be
Made heaven and earth,' (though not the
sea),

And Your word then achieved the task.

39 "The Spirit was hovering *to ask*,
And darkness and silence embraced
All things, and no man's voice effaced
That silence yet. 40 "You did command
A ray of light brought forth to stand
From Your storehouses, so Your works
Might then appear *and without quirks*.

41 "Again, on the second day, You
Created firmament in view,
Commanding it to separate
The waters, so one side in state
Moved upward and the other part
Remained beneath to stand apart.

42 "On the third day You did command
The waters to gather on land
In the seventh part of the earth,
Six parts You did dry up with dearth
To keep so some might planted be
And cultivated on the lee
In service before You *with tree*.

43 "Your word went out, and at the stroke
The work was done as under yoke.

44 "Immediately fruit came forth in
Endless abundance and in bin
For every kind of taste to win,
And flowers of bright colour and hue,
And perfumes untold in the dew.
These were made on the third day too.

I hide my head for very shame this man
Esdras dares to explain to You Your plan,
And yet the fact he described to You what
You did creation week and will not shut
His mouth, gives me the courage now to
think

That You will forgive also without stink
The fact that I irreverently it seems
Speak to You as a friend though out of
dreams.

I think my word describing what You did
To make the universe upon Your bid
Might do as well as Esdras's, and yet
I cover mouth ashamed to state my bet.
You speak and do, and sometimes one may
hear

And notice the effect You make appear.

45 "On the fourth day You did command
The brightness of the sun *to stand*,
The light of the moon, and the way
The stars come to exist array,

46 And You commanded them to serve
Man, who would soon appear *to swerve*.

47 "On the fifth day You did command
The seventh part, (which is not land)
Where the water had gathered there,
To bring forth living creatures' share,
The birds, and fishes, and so it
Was done *and just as You saw fit*.

48 The dumb and lifeless water made
Living creatures, as orders stayed,
So that the nations might declare
Your wondrous works *spread everywhere*.

49 "Then You kept in existence two
Living creatures, the name in view
Of one You did call Behemoth
The other's name Leviathan.

50 And You divided up them both,
For the seventh part in the plan
Where the water gathered to span
The water could not hold them both.

51 And You gave Behemoth one part
Of what was dried up at the start

Of the third day, to live in it,
In which a thousand mountains sit,

52 But to Leviathan You gave,
The seventh part, the waters' cave,
And You have nourished them as You
Have so inclined with much or few.

Though Genesis does not mention by name
The sun gods and the moon gods in their
fame,

Perhaps idolatry's danger and blame
Was past when Esdras wrote them down in
claim.

Two seventh's part of this world is inclined
To bear and feed Behemoth on the blind
And the Leviathan as so resigned.
This third creation story is a flame.

Beloved, the way that human eyes must see
The glories of the earth and sky and sea
Is strange to all beside the company
That sits around the fire in moment's spree.

I wait and watch for two beasts on the
prowl,
The one to blow spume and the one to
groul.

53 "On the sixth day You did command
 The earth to bring forth *by Your hand*
 Cattle, and beasts, and creeping things,
 54 "And over these You set the strings
 Of Adam [red earth], as ruler of all
 The works which You had made in stall,
 And from him we have all come down,
 The folk that You chose *from the town*.
 55 "All this I've spoken before you,
 O Lord, because You've spoken true
 For us You made the world in view.
 56 "As for the other nations which
 Have descended from Adam's pitch,
 You have said that they are nothing here,
 That they're like spittle in a smear,
 And You've compared their abundance
 To a drop from a bucket's dance.
 57 "And now, O Lord, indeed, these folk,
 Which are without renown or stroke,
 Rule over us and so devour.
 58 "But we Your people of the hour,
 Whom You have called your first-born and
 Only begotten, on the strand
 Zealous for You, for You most dear,
 Are delivered under their steer.
 59 "If the world's truly been created
 For us, why do we not elated
 Possess our world inheritance?
 How long will things be so askance?"

In Genesis dominion's given to
 Both man and women in the gathered dew
 To know that seeds are food for humankind
 And leaves for other beasts not far behind.
 But here dominion is a thing of power
 To wield by man along outside the bower,
 While women have no part in word or
 deed.
 That's the effect of not just eating seed.
 The next step from dominion is the stand
 That one nation above all in the land
 Is Your chosen, and others are of worth
 No more than spittle glistening on the
 earth.
 The world of Esdras, known of long ago
 Is not too different from the present show.

2 Esdras 7

1 When I had done speaking these words,
 The angel sent to me *like birds*
 On the former nights came again,

2 And he said to me, "Get up then,
 Ezra, and listen to the words
 I've come to speak to you *and when*."
 3 I said, "Speak, sir." He said to me,
 "In a wide expanse there's a sea
 That's wide and deep, 4 "but has the place
 To enter so narrow a space
 That it is like a river's trace.
 5 "If anyone would like to go
 Into the sea, behold its show
 Or sail on it, how can he come
 To the expanse unless *in sum*
 He passes through the narrow part?"

There are two sides to every coin, it's true,
 And two sides of each story in the brew,
 And every case and quarrel has its due,
 But there is just one channel in the bait
 To reach the sea that Ezra once saw late.
 The times that human hearts take out to
 show
 The town what is the red and what the go
 Are not a few, but seen in every glow.
 But there is just one pathway to the right,
 One shuddering, one sacrifice, one night.
 Beloved, I will the river down and feel
 The coursing waters on my burnished heel
 And tend the scores that jive for memory's
 touch
 And hope at last to find the stealth and
 such.

6 "Another example *in heart*.
 There is a city built and set
 Upon a plain, and it is met
 With all good things, 7 "but the town gate
 Is narrow and in a steep rate,
 So there is fire on the right hand
 And deep water at left to stand,
 8 "And there is only one path laid
 Between them, that is, by the raid
 Of fire and the water displayed,
 So that only one man can walk
 Upon that path. 9 "If now that *stock*
Of a town is given to a man
 For an inheritance, what plan
 Will the heir have to get his own,
 Unless he passes through the *groan*
Of danger set before his throne?"
 10 I said "He cannot, sir." And he
 Said to me, "So also's the fee
 Of Israel's portion. 11 "For I made

The world for their sake, and the grade
Of what I had made then was judged
When Adam disobeyed *and judged*.

The lovely Christ said once where two or
three

Are gathered in his name of vast degree,
There he too would be present for the
spree.

But the true path to that one city fair
That glistens on the shimmer of the air
And rises in the light of moon to share
The very sun and gold of harvest bright,
That city has a narrow gait and right
That none can pass abreast, but each one
comes

Into the judgement on his own and hums.
There are not two or three who counsel me,
Beloved, along the gateways and the tree.
I come alone and in that coming know
That You alone will meet me in the glow.

12 "So the gateways into this world
Were all made narrow and *unfurled*
In sorrow and in toil, and they
Are few and evil in their way,
And full of dangers and enmeshed
In difficulties unrefreshed.

13 "But the ways to the greater world
Are broad and safe, and *when uncured*
Yield fruit of immortality.

14 "So unless those who live pass through
The difficult and vain in view,
They cannot get those things in due
Reserved for them *of good and true*.

15 "But why are you troubled in mind,
Since you are to perish behind?
Why are you moved, seeing that you
Are merely mortal residue?

16 "And why have you not brought to
thought

What is to come, rather than wrought
With what is in the present plot?"

My mind and body crow upon the hill
Of dung that is this day beyond the fill,
And dream of yesterdays with human skill
And rise not higher than the hoping plot.
If I could just see once beyond the veil
Of mornings to the holy and the hale
And know the rose instead of only kale
I would be ruler of the things I sought.

Beloved, I see the mortal round go by
And fail upon the task to wonder why
But only place my hopeful bets and sigh
That years have taken toll of all I bought.
The Frankish fodder slopes away in gain
And finds the path abroad is bright and
vain.

17 Then I answered Him and I said,
"O sovereign Lord, indeed, You've led
By Your law ordained that the just
Shall inherit these things and must,
But the ungodly sink to dust.

18 The righteous therefore can endure
Harsh circumstances while their sure
Hope is for better things at last,
But those who've done evil in blast
Have suffered the hard times and will
Not see the easy ones fulfil."

There is no hope or promise brighter than
The law that You once spoke to earthly
man

On Sinai to reiterate the task
Given at first to Adam where to bask.
No rule book is so easy at that one,
No childish game so simple on the run,
So that the hope of paradise and prize
Is easy for each fool as well as wise.
I lay my head upon Your loving breast
And take my cup as pampered bidden guest
And welcome Your salvation given free
To those who keep Your simple law and
see

The splendours of the Sinai turn more
bright
Before Jerusalem, Gerazim's height.

19 And he said to me, "You are not
A better judge than Alohim,
Or wiser than the Most High wrought!

20 "Let many perish who in dream
Are now living, rather than that
The law of Alohim which sat
Before them be ignored by cat!
21 "For Alohim commanded well
Those who came in the world a spell,
When they came, what they ought do
To live and not be punished too.

22 "But they were not obedient,
And spoke against what He had sent
Inventing for themselves vain bent,

23 “Proposing wicked things to do,
Even declaring in their pew
That the Most High does not exist,
Ignoring His ways to resist.

When Adam bit the fruit that Eve had
plucked
And tasted the sweet clove that Eve had
sucked,
He did not deny You, Beloved, for all
The stars that sprinkled past the heavenly
hall.
He knew that You existed for the call
That echoed on the quiet cool of eve
That nurtured hope of some shining
reprieve.
It was a son or grandson of the late
Who came to deny You, Beloved, in state.
The Lamech with his wives perhaps or one
Who fided his fathers pipes when they were
done.
It was not Eve, not Adam in the dusk
Awaiting You and smelling of the musk.
It was some other tasking of the husk.

24 “They scorned His law, denied His
pacts,
Unfaithful in all of their acts,
They’ve not performed His works in facts.
25 “So, Ezra, empty things are for
The empty, and full things in store
Are for the full. 26 “For indeed, time
Will come, when the signs and sublime
Which I’ve foretold to you will come
To pass, that the city in sum
Which now is not seen shall appear,
And the land hidden beneath fear
Shall be uncovered to appear.

I am not of the empty, Beloved One,
But my heart is as full of moon and sun
And star to take my breath away and make
Me long for longer days in which to wake.
I am not of the empty, yet the cry
Of boredom reaches as far as my sky
And whispers to my wonder of the late,
The dry, the cold the drear commensurate.
Beloved, just think if I could learn one
tongue
Of earthly speech each twelve days on the
rung,
I should need only eighty years or less

To learn them all and so come to confess
That heavenly languages also seduce
A thousand years with something put to
use.

27 “And every one who has been saved
From the evils I have portrayed
Shall see my wonders all displayed.
28 “For My son the Messiah shall
Be revealed with those who are pal
With him, and those who remain shall
Rejoice four hundred years regal.
29 “And after these few years My son
The Messiah shall die when done,
And all who draw human breath won.
30 “And the world shall be turned again
Back to primeval silence then
For seven days, as it was at
The first beginnings, and so that
No one shall be left. 31 “After those
Seven days the world in its throes,
Not yet awake, shall be aroused,
And perish shall those who caroused.
32 “And earth shall give up those who
sleep
In it, and dust of who retreat
In it in silence and the rooms
Shall give up the ones from their dooms
Sunk in them. 33 “And the Most High shall
Be revealed on the citadel
Of judgement, and compassion shall
Pass from the scene, and patience be
Taken away, 34 “but only doom
Shall be left, truth shall stand, and yet
Faithfulness shall grow strong and set.
35 “And recompense shall follow, and
The reward shall appear to stand,
And righteous deeds shall waken, and
Unrighteousness take judgement stand.

The man has come to say he is the king,
Messiah, prophet, priest of everything.
The tombs were broken up around the hill
Golgotha and the city came to fill
With righteous of all ages at the till.
So two of the three prophecies not late
Have long since been fulfilled, both small
and great.
The judgement only stays and seems to
wait,
The punishment and reward hidden still.
Beloved, I know the resurrection kind,

I know Messiah's coming, am not blind,
But thirst still for the judgement that will
take

Oppression for the world and for the sake
Of righteousness reveal the earth to quake.

Or then, Beloved, this prophecy in kind
Is meant to say that the Christ not behind
The centuries died, but before the spring
Of resurrection we shall see the thing.
Some hopeful look toward the day when he
Will walk the earth again behind Mahdi
To pray in fair prostration and then lay
His life down before evil in its sway,
Only to resurrect in light of day
Of Judgement that awakens faith and sight.
There's argument about who's wrong and
right,

But be that as is, when the die is cast
All shall come before You to stand at last.
It will not matter then for day or night.

36 "The pit of torment shall appear,
And opposite and without fear
Shall be the place of *Sabbath* rest,
And the furnace of hell gape wide,
Opposite paradise abide.
37 "Then the Most High will say to all
The nations raised from death by call,
'Look now, and understand whom you
Have denied, whom you've not served due,
Whose commandments you have despised!
38 "Look on this side and on that prized,
Here are delight and rest, and there
Are fire and torments *on the air!*'
Thus He will speak to them when bent
Upon the day of His judgment,
39 "A day that has no sun or moon
Or stars, 40 "or cloud or thunder swoon
Or lightning or wind, water, air,
Or dark of eve or morn to *share*,
41 "Or summer or the spring or heat
Or winter or frost in retreat
Or cold or hail or rain or dew,
42" Or noon or night, or dawn or true
Shining or brightness of the light,
But only the splendoured respite
Of the glory of the Most High,
By which all shall see by and by
What's been determined for their cry.
43 "For it will last about a week
Of years. 44 "This is my judgment's seek

And its order appointed, and
To you alone I've shown the planned."

The burning of the pit without the night,
Without the day, without the blessed light,
Will last a week of years, and so Qur'an
Reports the hope that some beneath the
palm
Are planning to live through the
punishment
That tastes their flesh for numbered days
and spent.

The reason that the burning fires of hell
Extinguish in a week of years for spell
Is simply that the body, soul and breath
Of all cast in them have met second death
And lie beneath the dreamless sleep that
tows
Eternity from where the water shows.
The word of Ezra is a pall but known
To Qur'an and to faith before Your throne.

45 I answered Him and so I said,
"O sovereign Lord, then I have said
And I say now: Blessed are those who
Are alive and keep your laws true!
46 "But what of those for whom I prayed?
For who among the living stayed
Is there that has not sinned waylaid,
Or who among men that has not
Transgressed Your covenant in plot?
47 "And now I see the world to come
Will bring delight to few in sum,
But torments to many a bum.
48 "For evil is the heart that's grown
Up in us, which has like a stone
Separated from Alohim,
And has brought us into the seam
Of its corruption and the ways
Of death, and has shown us the stays
Of its perdition and removed
Us far from life and so reproved,
And that is not just some of us
But almost all made in the bus!"

As simple as the game-rules are to follow,
The human heart is evil here to wallow.
And like the Saul of Tarsus in his wake
Ezra is sure all men have failed the stake.
I'm not so sure myself of other men.
I'm honest with the plot I've hoed again.
But there are some, I trow, of human brood

Who have not tasted sinful fruit once
stewed.
Beloved, just hear the verdict of the true:
All men have disobeyed commandments'
due,
And so the prophet fears the hand that sets
The human race in punishment for pets.
Who gave the simple law of ten small
words
Can provide grace for men as well as birds.

49 He answered me and said, "Hear me,
Ezra, and I'll instruct you, see,
And will admonish you again.
50 "For this reason the Most High then
Has made not one world here but two.
51 "For whereas you have said the true
Righteous are not many but few,
While the ungodly ones abound,
Hear the explanation and sound.
52 "If you have just a few gem stones,
Will you add lead and clay and bones?"
53 I said, "Sir, how could that be?" 54 And
He said to me, "Not only band,
But ask the earth and she'll tell you,
Defer to her, and she'll show you.
55 Say to her, 'You produce your gold
And silver and brass, and the sold
Iron, lead and clay, 56 but silver is
More abundant than gold for biz,
And brass than silver, iron than brass,
And lead than iron, clay than lead's mass.'
57 "So judge which things are precious and
Desirable, those in a band,
Or those that are rare on the sand?"

I know indeed, Beloved, the thing is true.
The mass of men are merely clay in pew
And go down to the pit diminished by
The message of hope writ against the sky.
I know indeed, O God, that men are few
Who stand up in the temple in their due
And wait not for the morning but to sigh
And when the evening comes they stop to
cry.
I know indeed, Creator of all things,
Humanity is dancing round in rings,
Assuming that the motion itself brings
Salvation and peace to the world of all.
I hear presumptuous sounds come from the
stall.
The perfect man alone hears Your last call.

58 I said, "O sovereign Lord, what is
Plentiful is of less worth's fizz,
For what's more rare is precious biz."
59 He answered me and said, "Weigh in
Yourself what you have thought from sin,
For he who has what's hard to get
Rejoices more than he who's set
In plenitude. 60 "So also will
The judgement I've promised fulfil,
For I'll rejoice over the few
Who shall be saved, because it's due
To them to make prevail My glory
Now and through them My name in story
Has found its honour. 61 "And I'll not
Grieve over the multitude's lot
Of those who perish, for it's they
Who are now like a mist in sway,
And like a flame and smoke, they're set
On fire, burn with heat of regret,
And are extinguished when they're met."

The mind of God grieves not the hardened
clay
That's swept up on the floor and cast away.
The hope of God sets nothing by the store
Of marble chips scattered about the door.
The eye divine looks only on the vase
That rises exquisite and without flaws.
The ear of the Creator stops in pause
Before the divine image of His laws.
Beloved, I too from my perch and high seat
Upon a quartzite mountain of retreat
Look on the wasted human lives and care
Only for Your vast song upon the air.
The going down to darkness of all breath
Moves not my soul at all by stench of
death.

62 I replied and said, "O earth, what
Have you brought forth, if the mind shut
Is made out of the dust unknissed
Like other created things' mist!
63 For it would have been better if
The dust itself had not found skiff,
So mind might not have been made stiff.
64 But now the mind grows with us here,
And so we're tormented with fear,
Because we perish knowing tear.
65 So let the human race lament,
But let the wild beasts all relent,
Let all who have been born lament,

But let the four-footed of choice
And all the flocks here too rejoice!
66 For it is better with them than
With us, for they do not come scan
A judgement, neither do they know
Of any torment or the show
Of a salvation promised them

After death *has caught hold of hem.*

67 For what does it profit us that
We shall be preserved fit and fat
To be but cruelly tormented?

68 For all who have been born resented
Not but to join iniquities,
And are full of sins as they please
And burdened with transgressions' fees.
69 And if we did not come to doom
After death, we'd have better room."

I wonder how Ezra conceives to know
The fate of beast and animal to show,
When even human things set out below
Are mysteries beyond the wakened glow.
It may be that the creatures creeping here
Are headed for a greater form of fear,
A greater post of paradise than we
Who in Your image think that we are free.
The root of pity on the human race
Is more of quaint conceits before the place
Assumed in kingly grandeur by the one
Who looks most like a monkey under sun.
And yet the monkey shares a secret bright
With mysteries of forests and the night.

70 He answered me and he replied,
"When the Most High made the world wide
And Adam [red earth] and all who have
come

From him, he first prepared the sum
Of judgment and the things in it.

71 "And now understand from your fit,
For you have said the mind grows here.

72 "For this reason, therefore, I fear
Those living on earth shall be flayed,
Because though they had wisdom's grade,
They committed iniquity,
And though they received the laws free,
They did not keep them faithfully,
And though they obtained the law they
Acted unfaithfully for pay.

73 "What will they ever have to say
Upon the fatal judgment day,
Or how will they justify crimes

In answer under the last times?

74 "How long has the Most High here
shown

Patience with those who have not flown
From the world, and not for their sake,
But since the times appointed wake!"

A father in the evening pastime games
Plays with his children all the hopeful
flames

Monopole and Cosmos bring to bat,
And sees them cheating on the woollen
mat.

He does not chide them for their little ways,
But only smiles at their dishonest plays.
Though You're a father, You seem not to
smile

When humans fail to obey You a mile.
I guess the reason's not Your attitude,
Or that we are made of a better brood,
But only that the rules You gave are so
Much simpler than the ones the children
stow.

75 I answered and said, "If I've found
Grace in Your sight, O Lord, be bound
To show this also to Your slave,
Whether after death when each brave
Yields up his soul, shall we be kept
In rest till the time You'll have swept
The new creation, or shall we
Be tormented at once in spree?"

76 He answered me and said, "I'll show
You that also, but do not go
To join with those who have shown scorn,
Nor count yourself among those born
To the torment without good shorn.

77 "For you have a treasure of works
Laid up with the Most High, no shirks,
But it will not be shown to you
Until the last times at your due.

78 "Of death the teaching is as follows:
When the decree's gone forth from hollows
Of the Most High a man shall die,
As spirit leaves the body lie
To return to Him who gave it,
First of all it adores by writ
The glory of the One Most High.

79 "And if it is one of those who
Have shown scorn and have not kept due
The way of the Most High, and who
Have despised His law, and who've hated

Those who fear God *and unabated*,
80 "Such spirits shall not enter in
The habitations, but on fin
Shall straightway wander in torment
Grieving and sad *for where they went*,
In seven ways their torment's spent.

81 "The first way, because they have
scorned

The law of the Most High *forlorned*.

82 "The second way, since they cannot
Now make a good repentance sought
That they may live *through the onslaught*.

83 "The third way, they shall see reward
Laid up for those who trusted Lord
Of covenants who is Most High.

84 "The fourth way, they shall wonder why
The torment's laid up for themselves
In the last days upon their shelves.

85 "The fifth way, they shall see just how
The habitations *on the brow*
Of others are guarded by *saints*,

The angels in quiet restraints.

86 "The sixth way, they shall see how some
Of them will pass to torments *dumb*.

87 "The seventh way, which is the worst
Of all the ways that have been cursed,
Because they'll utterly go waste
In confusion and at the taste
Be consumed with shame, and shall wither
With fear at seeing *not to dither*
The glory of the Most High where
They sinned before Him while they'd share
Life, and before whom they're to be
Judged in the last times *for their spree*.

The seven veils of death upon the blind
Who neglect Your commandments to get
wined:

The spirit hangs on consciousness to find
In seven moments why the world behind
Is filled with Your law and repentance'
way,

And how rewards of piety meet day.
Before the eyes are darkened they will see
The heights of paradise' eternity
And on the waiting shelves the torments
lost

Before going to silence of the tossed.
Beloved, I too turn back of loving law
Except for those few moments of my awe
At morning, noon and night, yet pray my
paw

Shall yet release before I count the cost.

88 "Now this is the order of those
Who have kept the ways *on their toes*
Of the Most High, when they shall be
Divided from mortal body.

89 "During the time they lived in it,
They travailed serving Most High fit,
Stood up to danger every hour,
That they might keep the law with power
Of the Lawgiver *and not cower*.

90 "So this is the doctrine of them.

91 "First of all, they shall see with gem
Of great joy the glory of Him
Who receives them, for they'll have rest
In seven orders *of the best*.

92 "The first order, because they've striven
With great effort as well as given
To overcome the evil thought
Which was formed with them, *though*
untaught,

That it might not lead them astray
From life to death *out of the way*.

93 "The second order, because they
See the perplexity in which
Ungodly souls wander *and pitch*,
And punishment that awaits them.

94 "The third order, they see the hem
Of witness which He who formed them
Bears on their part, that while they lived
They kept the law given *and sieved*
To them in trust *to make them rich*.

95 "The fourth order, they understand
The rest which they enjoy at hand,
Being brought in their chambered *place*,
And guarded by angels *in trace*

Of deep quiet, and the glory
Which awaits them in last days' *spree*.

96 "The fifth order, they rejoice they
Have now escaped the corrupt way,
And shall inherit what's to come,
And besides they see the straits' *hum*
And toil from which they've been
delivered,

And the broad liberty *unslivered*
Which they're to receive and enjoy
In immortality's *employ*.

97 "The sixth order, when it is shown
To them how their face shall be known
To shine like the sun, and how they
Are to be made like the light's ray
Of the stars incorruptible

From then on *and to be in full.*

98 "The seventh order, which is greater
Than every other that came latter,
Because they shall rejoice with boldness,
Confident, without troubled coldness,
And they shall be glad without fear,
For they hasten to see appear
The face of Him whom they have served
In life and from whom they've not swerved
To have reward when glorified.
99 "This is the order of the plied
Souls of the righteous, as hereon
It is announced, and the said dawn
Are the ways of torment which those
Who would not obey *when they chose*
Shall suffer hereafter *as goes.*"

The seven veils of glory are the way
The righteous keep from sinning on a day
When all the world's distractions would
ignite

The fires of lust and hate before the fright.
The seven veils of glory touch my heart
And lead me to the greater, nobler part.
From striving to do right I turn to see
The punishment the wicked gain in spree,
Then witnesses of the obedient
Before the vision of the rest down-sent,
Until rejoicing captures heart that I
Have overcome temptations until my
Face shines to meet the goal in confidence:
Your face, Beloved, without the veils and
tents.

100 I answered and said, "Will time so
Be given to the souls *to show*,
After division from the clay,
To see what You've described today?"

101 He said to me, "Their liberty
For all of seven days shall be,
So during these seven days they may
See the things you've been told today,
And after that they'll make their way
Into their dwelling where they'll stay."

102 I answered and said, "If I've found
Grace in your sight, show further ground
To me, your servant, whether on
The day of judgement when it dawn
The righteous will come intercede
For the ungodly in their need
Or entreat the Most High for them,
103 Fathers for sons or sons *at hem*

For parents, brothers for sibling,
Kin for their kinsmen, friend for friend
Most dear and to plead for their end."
104 He answered me and said, "Since you
Have found grace in my sight and view,
I will now show you this thing too.
The day of judgement's firmly set,
Displays to all the true seal met.
Just as a father now does not
Send his son, or a son in plot
His father, or a master slave,
Or a friend his dear friend and brave,
To be ill or sleep or eat or
Be cured in his place *in his store*,
105 "So no one shall ever come pray
For one another on that day,
Neither shall any one lay down
A burden on another's crown,
For then every one shall bear his
Own justice and unrighteousness."

The seven veils upon the seven days
Bring forth the times of sorrow and of
praise.

The righteous soul that leaves the tasks of
earth

To fly in spirit to the divine berth
Goes to its rest upon the Sabbath sown
Within the week to rise before Your throne.
As Sabbath closes on my watchful wait
I too die to the hopes of pearly gate
And pass through deathly week and desert
land

To find at last the face I sought at hand
As judgement once again appear as light
Of Friday sinks below my mortal sight.
The resurrection of the Sabbath night
Renews the work upon the rocky sand.

106 I answered and said, "How then do
We find that first Abraham true
Prayed for the people of Sodom,
And Moses for our fathers rum
Who sinned in the desert, 107 "and then
Joshua after him for men
Of Israel in Achan's days,
108 "And Samuel in Saul's days *for praise*,
And David for the plague, his son
Solomon for those who'd begun
In the sanctuary, 109 "and still
Elijah for those who to fill
Received the rain, and for the one

Who was dead, that he might live still,
110 "And Hezekiah for the folk
In the days of Sennacherib,
And many others prayed for broke
And for many *and without fib*?
111 "If therefore the righteous have prayed
For the ungodly now when stayed
Corruption has increased and more
Unrighteousness fills up the store,
Why will it not be so then made?"

The intercession of the just may be
The only thing that keeps the right hand
free
Of sinning on the brink of trinity,
And yet the choice is made in lethargy,
In weakness and at last in falling free.
The intercession of the saints may take
The stony path around the slaughter stake
And turn where temples bound in smoke
and rake
To where the shining gold for very sake
Of prayer and incense lie upon the make.
Above the rising prayers there is the light
And rainbow of the gloried and the right
To match with mercy striving in the fight
Beside the crystal door and glassy lake.

112 He answered me and said, "This world
At present is not the end *furled*,
The full glory is not in it,
So those who were both strong *and fit*
Prayed for the weak, and that was it.
113 "But the day of judgment will be
The end of this age and degree
And the start of eternity
To come, in which corruption's gone,
114 "And sinful indulgence and spawn
Have ended, unbelief cut off,
And justice increased over scoff,
And truth has appeared *in its dawn*.
115 "So no one then will have the right
To have mercy on any wight
Who has been condemned in judgement
Or harm the one in victory's *tent*."

Who hope Muhammad on the final day
Will intercede for those upon the way
Are bound to disappointment in the fray.
The prayers of blessed Muhammad for his
own
Already touch the sinew and the bone

And reckon to affect the hand on plough
And answer to the calling of the now.
When books are opened and the weights
unfold
The actions and rewards have all been told
In what was said and done out in the cold.
Now is the day of interceding and
The time of choosing on Medina's sand.
Tomorrow when the Kaaba's opened grand
The feet will stop and faces come to stand.

116 I answered and said, "This is my
First and last word, that in my eye
It would have been better if earth
Had not produced Adam *for dearth*,
Or else, when it had produced him,
Had stopped him from a fall *so grim*.
117 "For what good is it to all that
They live in sorrow now and sat
In expectation of the flat
Of sword after death where they're at?
118 "O Adam, what have you done here?
For though it was you who sinned near,
The fall was not yours alone, but
Ours also who were in you shut.
119 "For what good is it to us, if
Eternal age is promised *stiff*,
But we have done deeds that bring death?
120 "And what good is it in a breath
That everlasting hope is ours,
But we have failed to grasp its powers?
121 "Or that safe and healthful rooms are
Reserved for us, but we met bar
To live in wickedness for star?
122 "Or that the glory of Most High
Will defend those of pure life's *try*,
But we have walked in wicked ways?
123 "Or that a paradise of praise
Shall be revealed, whose fruit remains
Unspoiled, in which abundance reigns
And healing, but we shan't go in,
124 "Because we've lived in house of sin?
125 "Or that the faces of those who
Practiced self-control as is due
Shall shine more than the stars *in view*,
But our faces shall be more black
Than darkness *in a chimney stack*?
126 "For while we lived and did the wrong
We did not think that before long
We should suffer such after death,
But only lived from breath to breath."

The corridors of all eternity
 May silent bide of men and women free,
 But still the matchless worth of divine hand
 That stirs creation from the small to grand
 Remains to lift the meaning of the land
 And sea to heights of marching majesty.
 Though every man should fail, the grand
 design
 Of star and world and sun empty of wine
 And joy and singing but for melodies
 Of spheres enormous on the empty leas
 Suffice to justify the work of God.
 You need not sing of rotting turd and clod.
 And yet the song is true, the perfect man
 Arises from the hope of divine plan.

127 He answered and said, "This is what
 The contest means which all who strut
 On earth shall wage, 128 "that if he's
 beaten
 He shall suffer what you're repeating,
 But if victorious he'll get
 What I have said *in stock and let*.
 129 "This is the way of which Moses,
 While he yet lived, spoke to the folk,
 Saying, 'Choose for yourself life's kiss,
 That you may live, *not die on stroke!*'
 130 "But they did not believe him then,
 Nor the prophets after his ken,
 Or even myself telling them.
 131 "So there shall not be grief at hem
 Of their destruction, not so much
 As joy over those who have touch
 Of salvation assured in clutch."

The controversy in the human breast,
 The silent struggle between bad and best
 That meets the daily task with hope and
 rest
 From evil, though the world pass by with
 zest
 Ignoring fatal choices and the song
 Of triumph and the victory of wrong,
 Is where the eye of love and right belong.
 The controversy in the human heart
 Informing deed and action in its part
 Goes unseen in the street and buying mart,
 And yet is where the choices have been
 made,
 The right either won or lost in the fade.
 Beloved, I look upon the warfare here
 And see the things that sparkle and appear.

132 I answered and said, "I know, sir,
 That the Most High is now a fer
 Called merciful, because He shows
 Mercy on those who for their rows
 Have not yet come into the world,
 133 "And gracious, because He's unfurled
 Grace to those who turn in repentance
 To His law *to avoid the sentence*,
 134 "And patient, because He shows
 patience
 Toward those who've done aggravations,
 Since they are His own works, 135 "and
 plenty,
 Because He would rather give gently
 Than take away, 136 "full of compassion,
 Because he makes in every fashion
 His pity abound more and more
 To those now living and the store
 Of those who're gone and those to come,
 137 "For if He did not make them stay,
 The world with those who in it stray
 Would not have life *in any way*,
 138 "And He is called the Giver, for
 He did not give out of His store
 Of goodness so that those who do
 Injustices might rest in crew,
 Not one ten-thousandth of mankind
 Could have life, 139 "and judge in the bind,
 Because if He did not forgive
 Those created, by His word live
 And blot out the lot of their sins,
 140 "There would probably be in bins
 Left only very few in brood
 Of the uncounted multitude."

Not one in ten thousand of humankind
 Attains to the obedience defined
 By the commandments of the law once
 spoken
 On Sinai for eternal love in token.
 The human heart swells with the sad
 reproach,
 And yet there is room for all in the coach,
 And only human choice, that gloried thing,
 Stands between death and life upon the
 wing
 Of splendour. Squalor is the cherished
 mark
 Of human freedom once outside the park.
 Beloved, I see ten thousand pass along

The quays and quake to find the milling
throng
A host of ghosts, despite the clanging song
That seems to light with fire the hopeless
dark.

2 Esdras 8

1 He answered me and said, "The Most
High made this world for sake *of boast*
Of many, but the world to come
Is for the sake of few in sum.
2 "But I tell you a parable,
Ezra. Just as, when you ask full
The earth, it will tell you that it
Provides very much clay that's fit
To make ceramics, and but few
Grains of the dust of gold in view,
So is the rate of this world too.
Many have been created here,
To few shall salvation appear."

The world I see about me in the dew
Has been made for the sake not of a few
Escaped from fire, but for the vastly crowd
Who gaze upon the morning when allowed.
Out of the teeming masses of the poor,
Remembered congregations of the sure,
Lord, choose the few elect to stand and
make

Doom door to a new world for Your own
sake.

The world I see about me as I rise
Out of the maze into the empty skies
Casts off the manied souls and blooms a
flight

Of scented flowers that lighten up the
night.

My sight zooms on the largeness of the
new,
Escapes the shadows' figures for the true.

4 I answered and said "Drink your fill
Of understanding, O soul's till,
And drink wisdom too, O my heart!

5 "For not of your own will and part
Did you come into the world, and
Against your own will you depart,
For you've been given a brief stand.

6 "O Lord, who are over us, grant
To your servant that we may plant
Our prayer before You, and give us
Seed for our heart and in the fuss

The cultivation of our minds
So that fruit may sprout up that finds
Each mortal to bear likeness of
A human being may in love
Find also life and glorious.

7 "For You alone exist, and we
Are a work of Your hands to be,
As You have declared *faithfully*.

8 "Because You give life to the form
Now fashioned in the womb *and warm*,
And furnish it with members, what
You have created is well shut
In heat and water, and for nine
Months the womb which You underline
Endures creation in resign.

9 "But that which holds and that thing held
Are both kept by Your keeping spelled.

And when the womb gives up again
What's been created there of men,

10 "You've ordered from members
themselves,

That is the breasts milk on their shelves
To be supplied fruit of the breast.

11 "So that what has been fashioned best

May be nourished for a time, and
Afterwards You will guide by hand
In Your mercy. 12 "You have brought him
Up in Your righteousness and vim,
And taught him in Your law, reproved
Him in Your wisdom *and unmoved*.

13 "And You will take away his life,
For he is Your creation's *fife*,
And You will make him live *again*,
For he is your work *among men*.

Youth looks for resurrection of the day
Of tempering the lilacs on the way
Upon the scattered path of well and spring
Met in the cool rain after everything,
After the sun-lipped lapping of the train
Kind in the evening glisten of the grain.
Enough of looks and resurrections now!
How high is wisdom set upon the brow!
In fact wisdom is like the rain at dusk,
Meticulous, a wine of mingled musk.
Long let me drink the draught and find the
brew

I lingered in the hope of seeing You
Veined in leaf patterns studded with the
dew,

Egregious perhaps, but wise and true.

14 "If then You suddenly and fast
 Destroy him who with labour cast
 Was fashioned by Your command, then
 Why was he fashioned among men?
 15 "And now I will speak out: About
 All mankind You know best and stout,
 But I will speak about Your folk,
 For whom I'm grieved, 16 and at a stroke
 About Your inheritance, for
 Whom I lament, and of the score
 Of Israel, for whom I'm sad,
 And about seed of Jacob had,
 For whom I'm troubled *all the more*.
 17 "Therefore I will pray before You
 For myself and for them in crew,
 For I see our failings who live
 In the land, 18 "and therefore I give
 Ear to judgement swiftly to come.
 19 "So hear my voice, and my words' sum,
 And I will speak now before you."
 The starting words of Ezra's prayer,
 Before he was withdrawn in air.
 He said 20 "O Lord who dost dwell in
 Eternity, whose eyes begin
 Above all things, whose upper rooms
 Are in the firmament *for blooms*,
 21 "Whose throne is beyond measure and
 Whose glory is beyond command,
 Before whom hosts of angels stand
 And tremble 22 "and at whose command
 They're changed to wind and fire, whose
 word
 Is sure and whose speeches occurred
 In certainty, whose ordinance
 Is strong and whose command askance
 Is terrible, 23 "and whose one glance
 Dries up the depths and whose ire makes
 The mountains melt away *in stakes*,
 Whose truth's established for all time,
 24 "Hear, O Lord, the prayer of Your slave,
 And give ear to petition grave
 Of Your creation, hear my words.
 25 "For as long as I live *like birds*
 I will speak, and as long as I
 Have understanding I'll reply.

 Even if all the world were lost in hell,
 Sunk in the dreary dust of Israfel
 To wink away eternity in pain
 Among diminished consciousness in vain,
 Brightness of hope receding in the vat,
 Litmus of acid helpings from the brat

In charge of due recourse, Your chosen
 folk
 Should rise above the mythic sounds of
 stoke.
 How shall the prophet pray for his own
 brood
 Though reconciled to see the gentile rude
 Reproached and mangled by the judgement
 crude?
 Up to the day of hope and hopelessness
 The thing remains still for the soul's
 address.
 Hope charges out and makes the world a
 mess.

 26 "O look not upon Your folk's sins,
 But for those who've served You in bins
 Of truth. 27 "Regard not the endeavour
 Of those who act wickedly clever,
 But the endeavours of those who
 Have kept Your covenants and true
 Amid afflictions. 28 "Think not on
 Those who have lived as wicked spawn
 In Your sight, but remember those
 Who willingly admit and chose
 To fear You *only*. 29 "Let it not
 Be Your will to destroy the lot
 Who've had their ways of cattle *wrought*,
 But look on those who've gloriously
 Taught Your law and taught faithfully.
 30 "Be not angry with those who're
 deemed
 Worse than beasts, but love the redeemed,
 Those who have always put their trust
 In Your glory and not in dust.
 31 "For we and our ancestors passed
 Our lives in ways that bring death *last*,
 But You, because we're sinners cast,
 Are called the Merciful *and vast*.
 32 "For if You have wanted to take
 Pity on us, who do not make
 Any works of righteousness, then
 You'll be called merciful again.
 33 "For the righteous, who've many works
 Laid up with You, where reward lurks
 Shall have consequence of their deeds.
 34 "But what is man, that You *for weeds*
 Are angry with him, or what is
 This race corruptible of fizz,
 That You're so bitter at its bizz?
 35 "For in truth there is none among
 Those who have been born on this rung

Who has not acted wickedly,
And among those who came to be
Before there is none who has not
Transgressed. 36 “For in this, O Lord
sought,
Your righteousness and goodness will
Be declared, when You’re merciful
To those without store of good works.”

Without store of good works, Beloved, I
come
Out of the shadows of the ho and hum,
Refreshed to know that grace is to be found
Somewhere around Your throne and on its
ground.
Each day I fail to keep the simple rest
That You command and promise to the
best,
Harbour my lusts and angers all the while
Against my many foes who sit and smile.
Not without hope I turn to You to find
Beneath the mountain with Your words
outlined
Enough of mercy for forgiveness and
A grace enough to make the tottering stand.
So bless me here, Beloved, as I put hand
To Your law once more on the desert sand.

37 He answered me and said “Some things
You have spoken rightly in springs,
And it will come to pass as you
Have brought the issues into view.
38 “For truly I will not concern
Myself about the fashioning stern
Of those who have sinned, or about
Their death, their judgement, or their rout,
39 “But I’ll rejoice over creation
Of the righteous, over their station
Of pilgrimage, and their salvation,
And their receiving their reward.
40 “As I have spoken, therefore, scored
So it shall be. 41 “For just as sows
The farmer many seeds he chose
Upon the ground and plants a host
Of seedlings, and yet not all boast
That have been sown will sprout in time,
And not all planted will take climb,
So also those who have been sown
On earth will not all be saved shown.”

Some praise the power of positive in
thought,

Only to be appalled at what is wrought
With the divine justice in turning face
Needed by the lost in their losing place.
While You, Beloved, care only for the just
In this world, and the few that bite the dust,
Languishing in oppression of the great
Loving crowd of those who rename their
hate
Somehow with such labels to please the
mate.
Perhaps the positive, to greet the true
Revolving in obedience as due
Only, and leave the other artists to
Undo their own chains of freedom, is right
To find the perfumes of the savoured night.

42 I answered and said “If I’ve found
Grace in Your sight, let my voice sound.
43 “For if the farmer’s seed does not
Sprout, because it has met the drought,
Or been spoiled by abundant rain,
It perished, *planted as in vain.*
44 “But man, who’s fashioned by Your
hands
And called Your own image in sands
Because he is made like You, and
For whose sake You have formed in band
All things, have You also made him
Like to the farmer’s seed and dim?
45 “No, O Lord who are over us!
But spare Your people omnibus
And pity Your inheritance,
For You have mercy on the dance
Of Your creation *in Your stance.*”

Come the mistake that humankind is made
Alone in Your image, and priced and paid,
Lingers to cause the error Esdras makes,
Lumping all the creation and the seed
Emerging or not at the farmer’s need
Down in the dump of waste, but only men,
Only the human take divine again
When imaged by the word inspired and
pen.
No, seed too is a marvel and a sign
Injected on the screen of néant’s vine,
Made in the image of Your face and share.
Anything of creation is made fair.
Go back and change the word and mind, so
we
Entice the whole plot and eternity.

46 He answered me and said "Things that
 Are present are for those who've sat
 And live now, and things that will come
 Are for those who will live in sum
 Hereafter. 47 "For you come far short
 Of being able in your sort
 To love My own creation more
 Than I love it *on My own score*.
 But you've often compared yourself
 To the unrighteous on the shelf.
 Never do so! 48 "But even in
 This matter you will some praise win
 Before the Most High, 49 "because you
 Have humbled yourself, as is due,
 And have not deemed yourself to be
 Among the righteous who *in fee*
 Receive the greatest glory *free*.
 50 "For many miseries will touch
 Those who dwell on the earth as much
 In the last times, because they've walked
 In great pride *in the path they've balked*.

Love humankind above the common score
 Of all creation is error in store.
 Vice-regency of man's illusion made
 Entirely on the base of pride well-stayed.
 More to be known's distinction twixt
 created
 Youth and the Ancient of Days and
 unmated.
 Come pride, the man would rather step in
 set
 Regarded for divine alone and met.
 Enough it is to be one of the good
 Accounted and praised as such where they
 stood
 Than climb the dizzy heights eternal and
 Imagine royalty for common band.
 Observe rather distinction of the just,
 Not like the ragged-assed folk going to
 dust.

51 "But think of your own case, inquire
 About the glory *to admire*
 Of those who are like yourself, 52 "for
 It is for you paradise' door
 Is opened, and the tree of life
 Is planted, the age *without strife*
 To come is ready, plenty brought
 A city built, and the rest sought,
 Goodness is set and wisdom made
 Perfect beforehand *in its grade*.

53 "The root of evil's sealed from you,
 Illness is banished from you too,
 And death is hidden, hell has fled,
 Corruption's been forgot instead,
 54 "Sorrows have passed away, and in
 The end the treasure in the bin
 Of immortality's appeared.
 55 "So ask no more such questions steered
 To the crowd for destruction geared.
 56 "They also have their freedom *too*,
 But they despised the Most High's *view*,
 Contemptuous of His law, and so
 Forsook His ways *when on the go*.
 57 "Moreover they have trampled down
 On His righteous ones with a frown,
 58 "And said in their hearts there's no God,
 Knowing they go down to the sod.
 59 "For as the things which I've foretold
 Await you, so the thirst and bold
 Torment got ready await them.
 For the Most High in stratagem
 Did not want men should be destroyed,
 60 "But they themselves as were employed,
 Who were created have defiled
 The name of Him who made them *wild*,
 Being ungrateful to Him who
 Prepared life for them to accrue.
 61 "Therefore My judgment is come near,
 62 "I have not made to all appear
 These things, but only to you and
 A few like you *who understand*."
 Then I replied and said, 63 "Truly,
 O Lord, You have now shown to me
 A crowd of signs which You will send
 On the last times, but in the end
 You have not shown me when You will
 Do them and make them all fulfil."

Second to none it seems Esdras appears
 Entitled to the praises of Your years,
 Enscathed in glory for his virtue's light.
 You praise the man in artistry in sight,
 Outcome of Your one handicraft and grace
 Until he shows the world a better face.
 Remember, my Beloved, the law he keeps
 On and above the others where he weeps
 Was not kept by his own hand, but by
 Yours
 Noted and chiselled by Your plan in-doors.
 Can You not see the argument he makes?
 As soon as grace is basis of his saving,
 So You become responsible for craving

Entire crowds into hell and with their
cakes.

2 Esdras 9

1 He answered me and said "Think well,
And when you see a certain spell
Of signs predicted has gone past,
2 "Then you will know it's time at last
When the Most High will soon return
Upon the world He's made *to earn*.
3 "So when there shall appear earthquakes
In the world, tumult for folks' sakes,
Intrigues of nations, leaders weak,
Confusion of princes *to peek*,
4 "Then you will know it was of these
That the Most High spoke *in decrees*
From ancient days and from the start.
5 "Just as with everything that comes
On earth, the start is clear in part,
And the end shows itself in sums,
6 "So also are times of Most High:
The start's revealed in wondrous deeds,
And the end in requital's needs
And signs *of reality's seeds*.
7 "And it shall be that every one
Who will be saved when he is done,
And will be able to escape
On account of his works in shape,
Or on account of the faith by
Which he has believed *in the pie*,
8 "Will pass through safe from every woe
That is predicted for the show,
And will see My salvation in
My land and in My borders' *bin*,
Which I've set apart for Myself
From the beginning on the shelf.

The signs of divine intervention take
Huge masses of attention for the sake
Of every sort of catastrophic make.
My sense of due proportion, I aver,
Answers not a whit to what would appear
Sufficient in Your lordly sight and mind.
My sense would say enough's enough
declined.
Come what may, still the human heart is
blind.
Eclipse and earthquake hardly make a dent.
Likely we're both wrong, Lord, in where
we went.
When You would get attention from the
crew,

A bigger kind of sign is surely due.
I too have such a short attention span
Nothing You do seems to affect my plan.

9 "Then those who have abused My ways
Shall be in wonder *at My stays*,
And those who have rejected them
In their disdain I shall condemn
To torment. 10 "All who in their life
Did not acknowledge Me in strife,
Although they had My benefits,
11 "And all who scorned My law in wits
While they enjoyed liberty's *grits*,
Not understanding it in scorn
Of repentance within their bourne,
12 "These must bow to its duty in
Torment after their death *in sin*.
13 "So do not waste time with the thought
How the ungodly in their lot
Will be punished, instead inquire
How the righteous are saved from ire,
Those to whom the age does belong
And for whose sake it was made *strong*."

I do enjoy Your benefits, Beloved,
Forget-me-notted, dandelioned, fox-gloved.
I taste the dew on lady's mantle too,
Although for thirst that little cup won't do,
And I require the spring below the leaf
And bloom of lilac to remember grief.
But it remains whether I stop to show
Acknowledgement to You before I go.
Sometimes I do. The morning finds my
song
Of Psalm aloud or silent by the throng
Of tasks distracting on the daily wheel.
Is that enough to be heeled with Your seal?
The round of Your acknowledgement I feel
Ought to be up to rejection of wrong.

14 I answered and said 15 "I said once
Before, and now *though I'm a dunce*,
I say, and will say it again:
There are more destroyed among men
Than those who will be saved *at last*,
16 As a wave's greater than drop *cast*."
17 He answered me and said "As is
The field, so is the seed *of his*,
And as the flowers, so are the hues,
And as the work, the end in views,
As is the farmer, so the floor
Of threshing. 18 "For there was a score

In this age when I was preparing
 For those who now exist *in daring*,
 Before the world was made for them
 To live in, and no stratagem
 Yet opposed Me then, for no one
 Existed, 19 “but now those who’ve come
 Created in this world which is
 Provided with both food in biz
 And pastures without end, are now
 Corrupted in their ways somehow.
 20 “So I considered My world, and
 Behold, it was lost, and My land,
 And surely it was fit to spoil
 Because of engines of the toil
 Of those who had come in its coil.
 21 “I saw and saved some with My hand,
 One grape out of a cluster, and
 One plant in a whole forest’s stand.
 22 “So let perish the multitude
 Which has been born in vain in brood,
 But let My grape and plant be saved,
 Because with much I have engraved
 Them perfect, *if I’ve not enslaved*.

The heads of wheat that cast upon the floor
 Of threshing make a pile perhaps much
 more
 Than was hoped by the farmer come
 before,
 And yet the stack is always smaller than
 The stack of chaff, to say no word in plan
 About the brazen stalks thrown in the fire.
 I find about me naught but burning ire
 And the poor pound of corn to feed the
 choir.
 Beloved, no one complains about the great
 Difference between the waste and the
 rebate
 When comes to corn, and yet Ezra a while
 Would cry remorse upon the human guile
 That brings the strutted stalks into the place
 Of their destruction like the human race.

23 “But if *along the way* you’ll let
 Just seven days more pass, forget
 To fast in them, however, 24 “but
 Go in a field of flowers in rut
 Where no house has been built, and eat
 Only of the field’s flowers for meat,
 And taste no flesh and drink no wine,
 But eat only flowers on the vine,
 25 “And pray to the Most High the while,

I’ll come and talk with you *in style*.”
 26 I went, as he directed me,
 Into the field Ardat *to see*,
 And there I sat among the flowers
 And ate the plants of the field’s bowers,
 Satisfied with their nourishment.
 27 And after seven days, as I
 Lay on the grass, my heart was shy
 Again as it was times before.

I’ve eaten meadow flowers myself in
 spring
 And in the summer light and autumn’s
 fling.
 I’ve munched on goat’s foot for the celery,
 And smelled like anything sweet cicely,
 And bit the tender neck of violet,
 And touched to tongue the milk before it’s
 set
 Of dandelion. I’ve made a sacred lunch
 Of bare chickweed, and satisfied a hunch
 With the lamb’s quarter, cut and steamed to
 fit.
 I’ve eaten meadow gifts and thought them
 fit.
 Beloved, my eating of the simple flowers
 Has not made me a prophet under showers
 Unless it’s everyone who is not loved
 By his own land and church who’s prophet
 gloved.

28 And my mouth was opened like door,
 And I began to speak before
 The Most High, and said 29 “O Lord, You
 Did show Yourself among us *true*,
 To our fathers in wilderness
 When they came from Egypt’s *address*
 And when they came into the way
 Untrodden of the desert’s way
 With no fruit there, 30 and You did say,
 ‘Hear me, O Israel, and give heed
 To my words, descendants *decreed*
 Of Jacob. 31 For indeed, I plant
 My law in you, and it shall grant
 Fruit in you and forever be
 Through all to stand in its glory.’
 32 But though our fathers heard the law,
 They did not keep it for a straw,
 And did not keep the statutes’ toil,
 But fruit of the law did not spoil,
 For it could not, for it was Yours.
 33 Yet those who heard it perished too,

Because they did not keep in view
 What had been planted in their due.
 34 Behold, it is the rule that, when
 The ground is planted, or the sea
 Receives a ship, or any dish
 Is filled with food or drink on wish,
 And when it happens that what's sown
 Or launched or set is overthrown,
 35 They are destroyed, but the things that
 Held them remain there where they sat,
 Yet with us it has not been so.
 36 For we who have received the law
 And sinned will perish *like a straw*,
 As well as our heart which heard it,
 37 The law, however, *as is fit*
 Does not perish but stays to shine
Still in all its glory divine."

Unless good Ezra was indeed occulted
 With other men of fame and not insulted,
 He too has passed into the lower gloom
 Like all men and like women to the room
 Of waiting out the centuries till death
 Is cast into the fire for its last breath.
 Whether he kept the single law or not,
 His life is laid upon the selfsame plot
 As that of every man. Their fate's the same.
 There's not yet demonstration of the game
 Of Paradise unfolded on the west.
 The eastern glow is all we know at best.
 Beloved, let me keep Your law though the
 day
 Disappear on the centuries away.

38 When I said these things in my heart,
 I lifted up my eyes to start
 And saw a woman on my right,
 Behold, she mourned and wept in plight,
 And was deeply grieved at her heart,
 And her clothing was torn apart,
 There were ashes upon her head.
 39 I put my thoughts where I'd been led
 Out of my mind, and turned to her
 40 And said to her, "Why do you stir
 Yourself with weeping, why are you
 In sorrow of heart *beyond due*?"

I too see weeping women in the way,
 Although it is not common here today.
 They mostly weep where war is common
 play
 And people bartered for the price of oil

And for the tinsel and the wrapping foil.
 I too see weeping women when the time
 Of sunshine on the wedding is sublime
 And when the bier is carried in last climb
 Above the kirk to where the tombstone pale
 Under their lichened, mossy, changing veil
 To hope for coming days not still and stale.
 Beloved, the earth weeps for her sorrowed
 dead
 And all the many loved ones she has spread
 Upon her bosom and brought down to hide
 Within the darkness of eternal bride.

41 And she said to me, "Let me be,
 Sir, so I can keep to my spree
 Of mourning, since in bitterness
 Of spirit I am in distress."
 42 And I said to her, "What's occurred
 To you? Tell me *what I've not heard.*"
 43 And she said to me, "Your servant
 Was barren and with no child *sent*,
 Though I lived with my husband for
 Thirty years, *ten beyond a score.*
 44 "And every hour and every day
 Of those thirty years *in my way*
 I prayed the Most High night and day.
 45 "And after thirty years God heard
 Your handmaid, and smiled on my shard
 To take note of distress of mine,
 And gave me a son *on the vine.*
 Greatly did I rejoiced for him,
 My husband and I and the rim
 Of all my neighbours, and we gave
 Great glory to the Mighty Brave.
 46 "I brought him up with care *as due.*
 47 "And when he grew up in my view
 I came to take a wife for him,
 And set a day for marriage hymn.

The woman prays for welcome, faithful son
 To cheer her age with ease upon the run.
 The woman prays and gets a man-child
 won
 And day by day addresses him in fun.
 The breathing blessing from the mother's
 lip
 Around the toys of horse and cart and ship
 Are never ceasing though sleep come at last
 To rest her burdens from the evil past.
 Beloved, the future is an evil sight
 As dark as the past on my early night,
 And yet I live in hope and charity

Despite the knowledge of the coming spree.
The wedding chimes of my eternity
Find Wisdom has a part, a branch, a right.

2 Esdras 10

1 "It happened when my son came in
The bridal room he fell down dead.
2 Extinguishing the lights within
All my neighbours tried in my stead
To comfort, but I without word
Stayed till eve of the second blurred
Day, when I got up in the night
And fled to this field out of sight
As you have found me *without right*.
4 I never intend to return
To the town, and all food I spurn
And drink, but without end raise cry
Of mourning till the time I die."

There's not a soul but knows to weep the
strain

Of sorrow that falls to her lot in pain.
Each one born to this world knows first to
cry

The searing thrust of existence to try.
The hurt, the illness, and injustice rife,
The famine and the pest, the end of life
All serve as one to raise the piercing wail
From every throat that's made to tell the
tale.

Yet each one's heart is covered with a veil
That numbs the other's pain and saves the
heart

From feeling every occasion and part.
Only the great saints feel the hurt of all,
And that is why sainthood's not fancy ball,
But crying with the poor in slaughter stall.

5 I ceased the cogitations I
Was still engaged in to reply
To her in wrath, and so I said
6 "You foolish of all women bred,
Don't you see how we weep and mourn
For all the things that we have born?

7 "For Zion, mother of us all,
Is in grief and affliction's thrall.
8 "It is most meet to sorrow now,
Because we all have weeping brow,
And go with sadness, for we all
Are pushed by sorrow to the wall,
While you weep for one son, yet we,
The whole world cry out desperately

For our mother. 9 "Now ask the earth,
And she will tell you in your dearth
That she should sorrow for the great
Many who've gone to her estate.

10 "From the start all were born of her,
And others will come plume and fur,
And almost all go to the pit,
A crowd into destruction fit.

11 "So who should cry and weep the more,
She who lost so great a crowd's store,
Or you who grieve at one son's door?

12 "But if you say to me, 'My grief
Is not like the earth's for relief,
For I have lost fruit of my womb,
Which I brought forth in pain and doom,

13 "But with the earth it is the course
Of its way, the crowd to its source
Goes as it came and so perforce,'
14 "Then I say to you, 'As you brought

Forth in sorrow, so the earth sought
Also has from her start the fruit,
That is, man, to Him who gave suit.'

15 "So keep your sorrow to yourself,
And stiffly stand beneath the shelf
Of distress that has come on you.

16 "For if Alohims ban your trust,
Then you know His decree is just,
And you will get your son again
In due time to live among men,
And will be praised by women's tongues.

17 "So go back to the city's rungs
To your husband." 18 She said to me,
"I will not do so and to flee
Back to the city, but die here."

The argument that none should feel her
pain

And lie around in meadows to complain
Because the city's filled with greater loss
Is hardly argument above the dross.
Grief is not to be assuaged by the will
Of reason proclaimed from pulpit and hill.
And it there is a mustard seed of truth
In prophet's words to lady and her youth.
To grieve a little for the pain of all
Helps to assuage the awful hurt and gall
That touches to the bone and to the flesh
And grinds the body and the soul in mesh
Of grief unuttered. So, Beloved, I see
The counsel of the prophet has to be.

19 I uttered once more in her ear,

And said 20 "Do not say that, but let
Yourself be guided and well set
Because of Zion's troubles met,
And take comfort to your own grief
And for Jerusalem's relief.

21 "You see that our temple's destroyed,
The altar thrown down we employed,
Our sanctuary we enjoyed,

22 "Our harp is laid upon the floor,
Our song's been silenced from the door,
Rejoicing has come to an end,

The flame upon our candlestick
Has been put out, the smoking wick
Has seen the ark plundered to tend
No more our covenant, and our
Holy things in pollution scour,
And the name by which we are called
Has been profaned *and we're appalled*,
Our free men have suffered abuse,
Our priests burned to death from their use,
Our Levites taken captive too,
Our virgins defiled in our view,
Our wives raped and our righteous men
Deported to the mines, again
Our children have been cast outside,
Our young men enslaved in their pride,
And our strong men weak to abide.

23 "And, what is more than all, the seal
Of Zion, since she's now lost the heal
Of *all* her glory, and has been
Delivered in the hands of sin
Of those who hate us *with a grin*.

24 "So shake off your great sadness now
And lay the grief from off your brow,
So that the Mighty One may see
You once again and with mercy,
And the Most High may give you rest,
Relief from your troubles *unguessed*."

I may not find the thought the temple gone
From Zion with its dead priests makes at
dawn

A balm to salve my soul for today's pain,
As though the gold and silver were my
gain.

And yet I understand proportion must
Be all the comfort I have in the dust.
One life indeed bandies eternity
And seems enough to grant in sorrow's
plea,

And yet compared to thousands in degree,
The weight of grief is measureless to see.

There stands a daily sorrow for the loss
Of labour and of silver at the toss,
And there at least the balm's enough and
great

To bring me to the supper table late.

25 As I was speaking with her there,
All of a sudden her face fair
Shone brightly and her countenance
Flashed like the lightning in a dance,
So that for fear I did not dare
Come near her and my heart beware.

As I was wondering at the thing,
26 She gave a fearsome cry to ring
So that the earth shook at the sound.
27 And I looked, and see, all around
The woman was not to be found,
But there was a great city set,
And a place of foundations met.
Then I was frightened, cried aloud,
And said 28 "Where is the angel bowed
Uriel, who came to me first?

For it was he who unrehearsed
Brought me to this strange state of things
Till I finish in destroyings
And my prayer end in reproachings."

For most men cities after their refrain
Of sorrow and of pushing on the pain
Turn into women or equivalent,
Called "her" with some affection for the
bent.

But Ezra meets a woman in the wood
And comforts her as best he knows or
should,
And to amazement finds her fast renown
To be a city from the toe to crown.
Beloved, I find no city, no, nor thought
Of Zion or of Gerizim in plot,
But in the wildish vision of the trees
That cover all the islands that I please
I find in solitude the heavenly dare
That would be city if it were somewhere.

29 As I was speaking these words, see,
The angel who had come to me
At first came back to me, and he
Gazed on me, 30 and indeed, I lay
There like a dead man gone astray
Without a thought in mind to pray.
Then he took hold of my right hand
And gave me strength and made me stand,

And said to me, 31 “What’s wrong with you?

And why do you take stonished view?
Why is your cogitations’ thought
In such distress as though unwrought?”

32 I said “Since you’ve forsaken me!
I did as you commanded me

And went out in the field, and see,
I found what I cannot explain.”

33 He told me, “Stand up like a man,
And I’ll explain to you the plan.”

34 I said “Speak, sir, but do not leave
Me, lest I die early and grieve.

35 “For I’ve seen what I did not know,
And I have heard a hidden show.

36 “Or is my mental state awry
And is my soul dreaming the sky?

37 “So now I beg you give your slave
An explanation of the grave
And gross vision that you engrave.”

I guess that I too would swoon if I saw
A lady turn to city in my crow
And change her dress and scarf for shining
wall

And hands and feet for palaces and tall
Against the ruined sky without a stain
Its minarets in colours stark and plain.
No doubt when Ezra stopped to get his
breath

He though instead of vision to meet death.
Beloved, the vision that I see today
Is filled with glory in its humble way,
And finds me breathless with the light and
cloud,

With murmurings of evensongs aloud,
With rosaries of Psalms until I’m clad
In painted dreams of forests and the glad.

38 He answered me and said “Hear me
And I will tell you faithfully
The things you fear, for the Most High
Has shown you secrets passing by.

39 “For He has seen your righteousness,
And that you oft in sorrow dress
For your folk and mourn in duress
For Zion in her great distress.

40 “So this is what the vision means.

41 “The woman who came on the scenes
A moment ago, whom you saw
Grieving and you lend helping paw,

42 “But you can see no longer now

In woman’s form, but must allow
Is now a city set for you,

43 “And as for her telling you that
Misfortune of the son she gat,

This is the meaning shown out flat.

44 “This woman you saw, whom you now
Find a set city on the brow

Is Zion. 45 “And her telling how
She was childless for thirty years,
Is because three thousand years’ tears
Were in the world before there came
Any offering upon her flame.

A year for one hundred years is a rate
Unknown to the interpreters of late
Of Daniel and of Revelation where
A day is for a year among the fair.
The second book of Esdras is the key
To many things unthought of in the spree
Of reading homely Bible prophecy.
Beloved, I hardly dare to take a drink
Of prophecies in wonders at the brink,
Knowing the lengths the human mind can
go

Jumping to false conclusions in a row.
And yet the burning words begin to glow
Seducing with their scent of burning pile
Of incense wood beyond my normal guile.

46 “And after three thousand years’ claim
Solomon built the city’s name,
And offered offerings, then it came
This childless woman bore a son.

47 “And for her telling how she’d done
To care for him, that was the time
Of biding in Jerusalayim.

48 “And for her telling you, ‘When my
Son entered bridal room to die,’
And such misfortune fell on her,
That was destruction to occur
Upon Jerusalem. 49 “And see,
You saw her likeness, and how she
Mourned for her son, and you began
To comfort her under the scan.

Misfortune of the brave when empires
dawned

Upon the world and left the fully brawned
Who had ruled tiny princedoms of the
fawned

Beneath the knuckles of the royal pawned
Is that of an only son whose death brings

The end to dreams of weddings and such things.

Misfortune of the brave's foundation wrought

By Nebuchanezzar in kingly plot,
Inventing a new thing, though Egypt knew
The rising of the Nile and spritely crew
Before such empires came to make their mark.

So now we cannot live without the shark.
And yet the tragedy is still laid bare
In all that empires do today in dare.

50 "And now the Most High, seeing you
Are grieved at heart to see the view
Of her distress, has now shown you
The splendour of her glory due,

51 "That's why I told you to remain
In the field where no house held gain.

52 "I knew the Most High would reveal
These things to you. 53 "So in appeal

I had you go into the field
Where there was no house built to yield,
54 "For work of no man's hand could stay
In the Most High's town's light of day.

55 "So do not be afraid, and do
Not let your heart tremble to view,

But go in and see glory there,
The size of the building and rare,
As far as your eyes can and dare,
56 "And after that you'll hear as much
As your ears can bear of the touch.

57 "For you are more blessed than the crowd,

And you have been called out aloud
Before the Most High, as but few
Have been *of all the earthly crew*.

58 "But stay here till tomorrow night,

59 "And the Most High will show you right
In those dream visions what Most High
Will do to those who live to *sigh*
Upon earth in the last days."

So I slept that night and the phase
Of that to follow, by His ways.

I wonder what things I might see if I
Remained out in the field beneath the sky
In memory of flowers and on my tongue
The taste of frantic juices that were wrung
From gladogenic stem and leaf and fruit.
I wonder what things I might hear for flute.
The righteousness of Ezra or the point

Of substances he got from burning joint,
It does not matter now, the thing is done.
The vision is appointed and I run
To catch the fragrance of the prophecy
Before the sun goes down upon the lea.
I quaff the juice of peony in my dreams
And wake up to the joy of what it seems.

2 Esdras 11

1 The second night I had a dream,
And see, there rose up as I deem
An eagle from the sea, and he
Had twelve plumed wings and heads to three.

2 I looked forsooth to see him spread
His wings over all the earth fed,
And all the winds of heaven blew where
The clouds surrounded his repair.

3 I looked, and out of his wings grew
Wings opposite, though small in view.

4 His heads were quiet, but the one
In the central place had outdone
The others in size, while it stayed
Also at rest and had not played.

5 I saw the eagle fly on wing
To rule the earth and everything.

6 I saw all things beneath the ring
Of sky submitted to his will,
And no one spoke against his bill,
Not even a mouse upon the hill.

7 I looked to see the eagle rose
Upon his talons, and he chose
Command to his wings taught to mime,

8 "Do not all watch at the same time,
Let each one slumber in his place,

And take his turn upon the race,
9 And let the heads stay till the end,

And so to meet both foe and friend."

The eagle is the fourth beast once described
By Daniel in the chapter he imbibed,
The seventh in the line of lessons taught
In Babylon and in the court it wrought.
The wings and heads are not the ten horns
that

Gathered where Daniel dreamed and came
and sat,

But are the series of the kings that grew
Upon Mount Zion with unholy crew.
Twelve kings are followed in a line by
three

Heads taking over what the wings may see.

Beloved, I seek the meaning of the tale,
And wonder at what powers came to
 prevail
And so oppress the people of the book,
The ones who were still righteous in their
 nook.

10 I looked and found the voice did not
Come from his heads, but from the *drought*
Of his body. 11 And so I sought
To count his wings, and for their plot
Were eight all standing *in their lot*.
12 I looked indeed on the right side
One wing arose, and reigned to bide
On all the earth. 13 And while it reigned
It came at last to end *unfeigned*
And disappeared, so that its place
Was not seen anymore *in trace*.
Then the next wing arose and reigned,
And it ruled long *and was ingrained*.

With the fourth beast the Grecian rule
 would end
And Roman rule started to rise and fend.
The first wing is the first one come from
 Rome
To desecrate Jerusalem and home.
The first wing is Antipater who gave
His loyalty to Rome although the slave
Of Idumea, and whose faithful son,
Herod the great was the second wing one
To guide the eagle Rome through every
 feat
Of power and fast oppression by elite.
Herod the Great reigned long for Rome and
 so
Became the winged one of the fatal show
That sparked the days of wealful, wrathly
 woe
So like all time since in the afterglow.

14 Its reign came also to an end,
And disappeared like its first friend.
15 Indeed a voice was heard to say
16 "Hear me, you who have ruled the earth
All this time, I proclaim this worth
Before you disappear *in dearth*.
17 "After your time no one shall rule
As long as you, not half the school."
18 Then the third wing raised itself up,
And held the rule like former tup,
Until it also disappeared.

19 It went so with all the wings *geared*,
They held sway each in turn and then
They never rose in sight again.
20 I saw in due course wings that rose
On the right side in power's pose.
Some ruled and quickly disappeared,
21 And others rose, but failed *and feared*.

The wings on the right side are clearly seen
In the dynasty of Herodians keen:
Antipater, Herod the Great and then
Ten years of Archelaus of all men,
Followed by Philip I in kingdom's half,
And reunited in the awful gaff
Of first Agrippa for a year or three,
And last Apprippa II to follow spree.
The other wings and heads are Legates
 drawn
To camp on old Jerusalem's bare lawn
Until the days of Syria kept in store
With Palestina waiting at the door
Should find the chargers from the Arab
 shore
Rushing upon the hopes shattered in score.

22 And after this I looked and saw
The twelve wings and the little *claw*
Of two wings disappeared like straw,
23 Till naught remained on eagle's form
Except the three heads resting *warm*
And the six little wings *from storm*.
24 I looked two little wings remove
From the six and stay under groove
Of the head set on the right side,
But the four others would abide.
25 I saw indeed these little wings
Planned to set themselves up as kings.
26 While I gazed one was set up, but
Suddenly fell where it was shut.
27 The second also rose to fame,
And disappeared without a name.
28 The two left by planned they should rule
Together *over wise and fool*.
29 While they were planning, see, one head
Of those that have quietly spread,
The middle one, woke up as it
Was bigger than the others fit.
30 I saw it join the other two
Together 31 and indeed, the crew
Consumed the two small wings *in view*
That planned to rule the place, *just two*.

The plot of Legates met in wings and heads
Is now obscure, because the news that
spreads

Of names and dates in those days are but
few,

Though six before Bar Kokhba are known
true.

Vespasian, Titus, Domitian too
Are Caesars leading on the wicked crew,
And two small wings continue in the view:
Nerva, a weakened wing in worldly sight,
Followed by Trajan, hero in the right
Of worldly guess and pomp, and yet in
faith

A shadow idol and a pagan wraith.
Beloved, the wicked reader laughs to find
The prophecy is unfulfilled and blind,
Yet spirit is true though flesh is confined.

32 This head took over the whole earth,
Oppressing its dwellers *for mirth*,
With greater power on all beside
Than the wings gone before *to hide*.

33 And after this I looked, indeed,
The middle head had gone to seed
Just as the wings before had done.

34 But two heads still stayed *on the run*,
And they reigned over all the earth
And its inhabitants *in berth*.

35 I saw the head on the right side
Eat up the left one *in its tide*.

The emperors follow one after one
Until the ruling of the earth is done.
I turn away from all the farce and play,
The tinsel and the ground of iron and clay,
And find the molten platform under sun
Where lightning struck the mountain and
You won,

Beloved, to give the tables of the law
To every soul that comes to stand in awe.
The heads and wings beat feebly on the
shore

Of restless seas of peoples to deplore,
But I look toward the fountain gone before,
The mountain of Your speaking to my soul.
Beloved, I take no teaching of my own,
The slippery way, but only Your bright
throne.

36 I heard a voice saying to me,
“Look in front and say what you see.”

37 I saw a beast like lion roused
Out of the forest, roaring toused,
And I heard him speak with the voice
Of a man to the eagle choice,
Saying 38 “Hear and I’ll speak to you.
The Most High says *this thing* to you,
39 ‘Are you not the one that remains
Of the four beasts I gave the reins
In My world, so the end of times
Might come through them *in ways and
mimes?*”

40 “You, the fourth that has come, have set
Down all the beasts that have been met
Before, and you have held such sway
Over the world in terror’s way,
And over all the earth with grief
Of your oppression sans relief,
Living so long upon the earth
In your deceit *for all you’re worth*.

41 “You’ve judged the earth, but not with
truth,

42 “You have afflicted *and with ruth*
The meek and injured those at peace,
You’ve hated those who do not fleece
The truth, and have loved liars’ ways,
You have destroyed the dwellings’ *maze*
Of those who brought forth fruit, and laid
Low walls of those who did no raid.

43 “And so your insolence has come
Up before the Most High in sum,
And your pride to the Mighty One.

44 “And the Most High has looked and
spun

Upon His times, and see, they’re done,
His ages complete *under sun!*

45 “So you will surely disappear,
You eagle, and your wings of fear,
And your most evil little wings,
And your malicious heads, in rings
Your wicked claws and worthless maws,
46 “So that the whole earth, freed from *ill*
Of your violence out to spill,
May be refreshed and find relief,
And hope for judgment from their grief
And mercy from Creator’s *lief.*”

The churches and the veiling kingdom’s
come

One after another to sell their rum,
And hear: You’ve judged the earth, but not
with truth,
And wily corrupted all the world’s youth

To commit with bare hand in wicked way
Their violence on poor and widow's stay.
The governments of men with written laws
Are bloody on their teeth and tongues and
claws,

And every righteous leader that's been sent
Is downed by his iniquity full-rent.
Beloved, I turn to You, and find Your
peace

In tabernacles not seen for release,
In knowledge that You only rule the day
And cast the faith of martyrs out to hay.

2 Esdras 12

1 While the lion was saying these
Words to the eagle *not to please*,
I looked, 2 and indeed, the last head
Remaining disappeared *instead*.
And the two wings that had gone over
To it arose and set up *rover*
To rule, and their reign was one brief
And full of trouble *sans relief*.
3 And I looked, and behold, they too
Had disappeared *and gone from view*,
The eagle's entire body burned,
While earth was terrified *and spurned*.
Then I woke up in troubled mind
And in great fear and said in kind
To my spirit, 4 "Indeed, you've brought
This on me, because you search out
The ways of the Most High no doubt.
5 Indeed, I'm still weary in mind
And very weak in spirit's *kind*,
And not even a little strength
Is left in me, because *at length*
The great fear with which I have been
Terrified this night is *in bin*.
6 So I will now beseech the Most
High that He may give strength to boast
And keep me to the end and toast."

The eagle is spent and destroyed at last
At Bar Kokhba's famed stand before the
blast.

Domitian's downed and so Nerva the weak
And Trajan the last Roman come to speak.
The empire's up in flames, destroyed in all
Its own destruction before royal ball.
The truth is vindicated in the roar
Of messianic fervour at the door.
The way and life of everlasting joy
Is set up and immoveable to ploy

In the city celestial that appeared
At the call of faith Kokhba engineered.
Beloved, I stand beneath the banner still
Invisible, but clearly in Your will.

7 And I said, "O sovereign Lord, if
I've found grace in Your sight *not stiff*,
And been accounted righteous here
Before You beyond others' *tier*,
And if my prayer's before Your face,
8 Strengthen me and show me *in grace*,
Your servant, the meaning of this
Awful vision, though one of bliss,
To comfort my soul with a kiss.
9 For You've judged me worthy to see
The end of times and their last fee."
10 He said to me, "This is the thing
This vision you've seen means *on wing*.
11 The eagle you saw coming up
From the sea is the fourth *like tup*
Kingdom which appeared in a sight
To your brother Daniel *and wight*.
12 But it was not made clear to him
In the detail I bring you trim.
13 Indeed, the days are coming when
A kingdom shall rise upon men,
And it shall be more awful than
All the kingdoms before in plan.
14 And twelve kings shall reign in it, one
After another till they're done.

I praise You, my Beloved, the wings are
clipped
And Rome is dead as Babylon, Egypt,
And all the fight and fire, the martyrdom,
The killing and the smoke, the veils in sum,
Are merely mirrors and reflections low
And failing despite all the empty glow
Of honour and of circumstance for show.
Reality is in the still small voice,
Reciting of Your word in joy and choice,
While illusion's democracy is forced
Into the bright judgement, fallen, divorced.
Beloved, I smile at Roman gunned and
horsed,
Well-tank'd and banked the armies fly the
sky
Until the roar of silence strike them by.

15 But the second that is to reign
Shall hold sway for a longer pain
Than any other of the twelve.

16 This is the meaning of the twelve
Wings which you saw. 17 As for your
hearing
A voice that spoke, come not in clearing
Of eagle's heads but from the middle
Of his form, here's the gist of riddle.
18 In middle of that kingdom's time
Great conflicts shall come up and climb,
And it shall be about to fall,
And yet it shall not hit the wall,
But once more have its former power.
19 As for your seeing eight small wings
Holding to his wings *for an hour*,
This is the meaning of those things.
20 Eight kings shall rise in it, whose reigns
Shall be short and years swift in pains,
21 And two of them shall fail amid
The coming of the era's bid,
And four shall be kept for the time
When its end comes in sight and rhyme,
But two shall be kept till the end.
22 As for your seeing three heads there
At rest, this is the meaning fair.
23 In its last days the Most High will
Raise up three kings *upon the hill*,
And they shall renew many things
In it, and rule the earth *like kings*
24 And its inhabitants with hand
More oppressive than all the band
Before them, and that's why they're called
The heads of the eagle *appalled*.

Let me not list atrocities, Beloved,
Committed by the heads of the unloved!
Let their names not pass my lips now again,
I have already spoken of the men.
The eagle and the dragon from its den
Go out to spew upon the earth both fire
And every pest that men know to desire.
But when they've done their worst, You
still abide
The God of those who turn away and hide
In closet to repeat the noble prayer
And breathe the freshness of Your law like
air.
Beloved, do not breathe out another word
To name the cursed, but scatter like the
turd,
And climb again Your divine, golden stair.

25 For it is they who shall sum up
His wickedness *poured out in cup*

And carry out his last deeds *stalled*.
26 As for your seeing that the large
Head disappeared, one of the charge
Of kings shall die in his bed, yet
In agonies and anguish set.
27 But as for the two who remained,
The sword shall consume them *as stained*.
28 For the sword of one shall devour
Him who was with him *for an hour*,
But he also shall fall by sword
In the last days *as his reward*.
29 As for your seeing two small wings
Pass over to the head which sings
Upon the right side, 30 that means this.
It is these whom the Most High's kept
For eagle's end and without miss,
This was the reign which many wept
In trouble though brief as you hiss.
31 As for the lion whom you saw
Rousing up from the forest maw
And roaring and speaking to chide
The eagle for unrighteous hide,
And as for all his words you've heard,
32 This is Messiah whom the word
Of Most High's kept till end of days,
Who will rise from the children's praise
Of David, and will come and speak
To them, He will denounce their weak
Ungodliness and wickedness,
And cast up before their address
The actions they ought to confess.

Messiah's words in sharpened sword
addressed
Came already in burning fire and dressed
In stunning white to John upon the isle
In a sea gathered around him for guile.
Messiah's words flew from the judgement
seat
And guided every eye of the elite
Elect to know that Your throne is above
The eagle's and the dragon's without love
For violence and for the blood-stained
shore.
All humankind may come to lap the gore,
But Your Messiah speaks the truth and
bears
The weight with joy of human burden
cares.
Beloved, I praise Messiah at the reach
Of Golgotha, Massada, Kokhba's peach.

33 First He will set them living there
 Before His judgment seat to share
 Reproof, and then He'll destroy them.
 34 But he'll deliver in the hem
 Of His mercy the remnant gem
 Of my folk, those who have been saved
 Throughout my borders *and engraved*,
 And He will make them joyful too
 Until the end comes, the day due
 Of judgment, of which I told you
 At the beginning as is true.
 35 This is the dream that you saw, and
 This is its meaning set at hand.
 36 And only you were worthy *guy*
 To learn this secret of Most High.
 37 Therefore write all of these things that
 You've seen in a book, and put at
 A secret place, 38 and you shall teach
 Them to the wise among your reach,
 Whose hearts you know can comprehend
 And keep these secrets till the end.

They say the book was written in the time
 Of Domitian and later at the crime
 Of Christian plagiarizers added to,
 The chapters at beginning and the two
 At end to satisfy the Christian view.
 They say the book was written by a Jew
 To find a comfort for the city taxed
 And flattened by the tenth legion and axed.
 Be that as may, Beloved, I know the sound
 Of prophecy when uttered on the ground,
 And see beyond pseudepigraphic mound
 To find the sweet bites of Your word and
 true.

The law is never spoken to be new.
 I hear it here and now, taste in the stew.

39 But wait here seven days more, so
 That the Most High may come to show
 You yet what things are on the go."
 And so he left me here below.
 40 When all the folk heard seven days
 Had past and I'd not bent my ways
 Back to the town, they all came out
 Together from least to the stout,
 And coming to me spoke to me
 And said 41 "How have we so made free
 To offend you, what harm have we
 Done you, that you've forsaken us
 And sit in this place *barbarous*?
 42 "Of all the prophets you alone

Are left to us *upon the stone*,
 A cluster of grapes from the catch,
 Lighting a dark place just one match,
 And like a haven for a ship
 Saved from a storm *out of the slip*.
 43 "Are not the evils come on us
 Sufficient *to the cumulous*?
 44 "Therefore if you forsake us, how
 Much better it would have been *now*
 For us if we also had been
 Consumed in Zion's burning *din*!
 45 "For we're no better than those who
 Died there *among the lost and true*."
 And they wept with a loud voice too.

I understand the weeping and the note
 Of chiding a sweet prophet, one of note.
 There has not been a prophet on the sand
 Not since Muhammad bit the iron band.
 If any felt neglected on the strand
 Of old Jerusalem, upon the rock
 Swept clean of temple and the temple
 stock,
 I understand the hopeful hale and cry,
 The waiting for the prophet to come by.
 And yet I wonder why the prophet's view
 Is always hidden from the comely crew,
 Since You were wont to make a fair claim
 true,
 And spoke on Sinai with loud words as
 due.

I look up at the empty and blue sky.

Then I answered them and I said
 46 "Take courage, O Israel *well bred*,
 And do not sorrow, Jacob's house,
 47 "For the Most High has man and spouse
 In His remembrance, Mighty One
 Has not forgotten you when done.
 48 "As for me, I've neither forsaken
 You nor withdrawn from you *when shaken*,
 But I have come here just to pray
 For Zion's desolation's way,
 And to seek mercy on account
 Of sanctuary's humble mount.
 49 "Now go every one to his house,
 And after these days *like a mouse*
 I'll come to you *and give account*."
 50 So the folk went into the city,
 As I told them to do *for pity*.
 51 But I sat in the field seven days,
 As the angel had ordered ways,

And I ate only of the flowers
That grew upon the meadow bowers,
And my meat was of herbs *and rue*
During those days *both long and few*.

Zion is desolate of brick and stone,
It's just as barren now as for the throne
Of Domitian upon the shrunken wall.
The city is forsaken at the gall.
The Zion that I know is one above,
One without bloodshed, one enthroned in
love.

I tread its golden street like feeding dove
And pick its sweetest morsels with red feet
And eye of innocence at my retreat.
I find it in the barren field where I
Eat chickweed with a beak too sharp to ply,
And touch it's gleaming fruit upon the tree
Of life with pecks a-plenty and with glee.
No one can take my town away from me.

2 Esdras 13

1 After seven days then I dreamed
A dream in the night, 2 and it seemed,
A wind blew coming from the sea
And stirred up all its waves to be.
3 And I looked, and indeed, this wind
Made something like the figure *skinned*
Of a man come up from the heart
Of the sea there to do his part.
And I looked, and indeed, that man
Flew with the clouds of heaven in span,
And wherever he turned his face
Everything trembled in its place,
4 And whenever his voice was heard,
All melted as wax melts *or turd*
Before the fire *when it occurred*.
5 After this I looked, and indeed,
A great crowd of men to take heed
From the four winds of heaven to make
War against the man in the wake
Who came up out of the sea's lake.
6 And I looked, and indeed, he graved
Out for himself a mountain paved,
And flew up on it for his sake.
7 I tried to see the land or place
From which was carved out mountain face,
But I could not find any trace.

The messianic spirit which abounds
Throughout eternity and in the sounds
Of Your divine law, my Beloved, resounds

In the arising of Bar Kokhba's great
Attempt to found and lead a Jewish state.
That state in temporal would disappear,
But in the spirit it could know no fear,
And in the waiting brood of song of love
Of Solomon and in the bright Psalms of
His father David, despite all I find
The principedom flourishing still in the mind.
Beloved, You have created humankind
Of such fine stuff that stone and mortar cast
No shadow on the kingdom that must last.

8 After this I looked, and indeed,
All who'd gathered against his creed,
To battle with him, greatly feared,
Yet dared to fight when he appeared.
9 See, when he saw the great attack
Of the crowd coming and not slack,
He did not lift a hand or spear
Or any lethal weapon near.
10 But I saw only how he sent
From his mouth streams of fire that went,
And from his lips a flaming breath,
And from his tongue rushed sparks like
death.

11 All these were mingled into one,
The stream of fire and flaming breath
And the great storm when it was done,
And fell upon attacking crowd
Prepared to fight, and burned the proud,
So suddenly not one was seen
Of the great crowd beyond the sheen
Of dusty ashes, smell of smoke.
I saw it amazed at the stroke.

12 After this I saw the same man
Come down from the mountain to scan
And call to him another crowd
Which was one peaceable allowed.
13 Then many people came to him,
Some were joyful and some were grim,
Some were bound, and some were brought
there
As offerings among the fair.

From Bar Kokhba's mouth went out
streams of fire
Devouring Roman soldiers in his ire,
Fast speaking in support of Your great law
So generations after stand in awe.
He burned the arguments of pagan wars,
Cut down with words and tongue idols by
scores,

And so established forever the state
 Of Your law, my Beloved, in place of hate.
 But just as Jesus and Sabbetai Zwi
 Feel on their heads the curses by decree
 Of rabbi and of bishop and at last
 The mullah in his cassock going past,
 Shimon is also trodden in the blast.
 No matter, truth prevails though unseen
 cast.

Then in great fear I woke up, and
 I begged Most High to understand,
 And said 14 "From the beginning You
 Have shown Your servant wonders true,
 And have deemed me worthy to set
 My prayer before You and be met,
 15 "Now show me also this dream's due.
 16 "As I consider it in mind,
 Alas for those once left behind
 In those days! And still more, alas
 For those who are not left *in class!*
 17 "For those who're not left will be sad,
 18 "Because they understand what's had
 For the last days, but cannot get.
 19 "Alas for those too who are met
 Remaining, for that very set!
 For they shall see great dangers and
 Much distress, as these dreams command.
 20 "It's better though to get these things,
 Despite the peril in the wings,
 Than to pass from earth like a cloud,
 And not see the last things allowed."
 He answered me and said aloud,
 21 "I'll tell you the vision's import,
 Explaining what you say in sort.

The revelation comes to the man who
 Is bent in prayer before the name of
 YHWH.
 The days and nights of prayer bring out the
 scene
 Shining with truth and justice to be keen.
 The future may well be pronounced in
 word,
 But even better is the sense incurred
 To understand the present by the veil
 Of messianic hope that shall prevail.
 Beloved, I see the dangers and distress,
 I see the kingdom of Jesus to bless,
 I see the arms and armies of the one
 Who followed him and set up as Your son,
 I see the many messiahs and true,

All claimed to be false for the things they
 do.

22 "As for what you said about those
 Who are left, here's the meaning rose.
 23 "He who brings peril at that time
 Will also protect those who climb
 Into the peril, who have deeds
 And faith in the Almighty's *creeds*.
 24 "Understand therefore that those who
 Are left are more blessed than those who
 Have died. 25 "This is the meaning of
 The vision sent *for faith and love*:
 As for your seeing a man come
 Up from the heart of the sea's tum,
 26 "This is the one the Most High's kept
 For many ages, who unwept
 Will save His creation, and he
 Will guide those who are left and free.
 27 "And as for your seeing the wind
 And fire and a storm to rescind
 Coming out of his mouth, 28 "so that
 He holds no spear or weapon flat,
 And yet destroys the multitude
 Come out to conquer him though rude,
 This is the meaning of the mood.

Bar Kokhba did save Your creation when
 He bore arms to defend Your law again.
 No matter that Jerusalem was swept
 Out from under the feet of those who wept,
 No matter that a heathen city rose
 To take its name after the awful throes.
 No matter that Roman pretended yet
 To take the victory that they could get.
 There was no honour in senate report,
 But only shame for all the deaths in sort.
 There was no honour in the horrid name
 Of Palestine invented to their shame.
 But since that day all men know that Your
 law
 Can be kept even under lion's paw.

29 "Indeed, the days are coming when
 The Most High will deliver men
 Upon the earth. 30 "Bewilderment
 Of mind shall come over those sent
 To live on earth. 31 "And they shall plan
 To make war each man against man,
 City against city, and place
 Against place, people against face
 Of other people, and kingdom

Against kingdom *as fast as hum*.

32 “And when these things shall come to
pass

And the signs happen which alas
I showed you before, then my Son
Will be revealed, whom you begun
To see as a man from the sea.

33 “And when all the nations that be
Hear his voice, every man shall leave
His own land and the warfare grieve
That they have against one another,

34 “And a great crowd gather as brother,
As you saw, hoping to repair
And conquer him as sent and fair.

35 “But he’ll stand on Mount Zion’s top.

36 “And Zion will arrive and hop
To be made manifest to all,
Prepared and built from gate to wall,
As you saw the mountain carved out
And coming without hands no doubt.

Am I the only one on earth that’s left
Who still believes Messiah unbereft
And living still in every name that blessed
Judea and Jerusalem confessed?

I here proclaim that Jesus was the one
Promised, and wisely did not jump the gun,
But left to Bar Kokhba the right to bear
Arms against Roman oppression and swear.
I here proclaim that Shimon when he came
Was also sent of You, Beloved, for fame
Eternal. And I am here once more led
To confess Sabbetai Zwi also has fed
In secret wisdom manna to the true,
And all three messiahs point back to You.

37 “And he, my Son, will reprove those
Assembled nations that they chose
Ungodliness (in this arose

The symbol of the storm in rows),
38 “And he’ll chide them to their face for
Their evil thoughts and with the store
Of torments which they’re bound to feel
(Which came in symbol of flames’ heel),
And he’ll destroy them without strain
By the law (figured by fire’s pain).

39 “As for your seeing him take up
To himself a second crowd’s cup
That was peaceful, 40 “these are the ten
Tribes which were led away again
From their own land into the fate
Of captives in the days of late

King Hoshea, whom Shalmaneser
The king of the Assyrian geezer
Took captive, he took them across
The river, and they were at loss
In another land. 41 “But they made
This plan for themselves when waylaid,
That they would leave the multitude
Of nations and go to a rude
More distant region, where mankind
Had never lived, 42 “that there may find
At least a place to keep their law
Which they’d not kept *by their own claw*
In their own land *in righteous awe*.

The sent Son did chide evil crowd with
faith,

Both Roman guard and Caesar and the
wraith

Of heathen gods and every sort of hell
That opened jaws to claim army and dell.
He destroyed their souls by Your burning
law

And sent them empty back to Roman crow,
And with the chill of sixty thousand slain
Of the just and holy upon the plain.

Beloved, he woke for peace the trodden
way

Set by the ten lost tribes from light of day
Who still invisible, in closet make
Their prayers to You abound and for Your
sake.

The peace of Your commandment knows
no bound,

Even within the Vatican it’s found.

43 “They went in by the narrow ways
Of the Euphrates river maze.

44 “For at that time the Most High made
Signs for them, and stopped the charade
Of flowing river until they had passed
Over. 45 “Through that region amassed
There was a long way yet to go,
A journey of a year not slow
And half a year, and that land’s called
Arzareth, meadowed, fruited, walled.

46 “They lived there until the last times,
And now, when they *have left their crimes*
And are about to come again,

47 “The Most High will stop before men
The river channels once again,
So they may pass over *them dry*.
That’s why you saw the crowd come by,

Gathered in peace *under the sky*.
 48 "But those who are left of your folk,
 Who're found within my holy yoke,
 Shall be saved. 49 "Therefore when he lays
 Down in destruction all the ways
 Of many nations that are bound
 Together, he'll defend the ground
 Of folk remaining *and the sound*.
 50 "He'll show them wonders that
 abound."

The messianic hope and promise dressed
 In hidden veils and shrouds and hardly
 guessed
 Has grown amuck so that the tanks of all
 The armies of the West cannot make fall.
 A battle temporal that once was lost
 In A.D. one three five and at such cost
 Is only pledge that underground we stay
 Unbroken and unbeaten by the fray.
 Even within the mass of heathen word
 The bowed head silently and by none heard
 Pledges to You, Beloved, and against
 Rome
 The promise of Jerusalem and home.
 Even on Gerizim law keepers wait,
 Faithful to You, Beloved, beyond the gate.

51 I said "O sovereign Lord, explain
 This to me: Why did I see plain
 The man coming up from the sea?"
 52 He answered and he said to me,
 "Just as no one can sound or know
 The depths of the ocean and go,
 So no one on earth can see My
 Son or those who're in his employ,
 Except on the day of his *joy*.
 53 "This is the meaning of the dream
 Which you saw. And you only seem
 Enlightened about all this scheme,
 54 "Since you've forsaken your own ways
 And have applied yourself for days
 To Mine, and have searched out My law,
 55 "For you've spent your life in the awe
 Of wisdom, and called understanding
 Your mother *and source of demanding*.
 56 "Therefore I have shown you all this,
 For there's reward laid up in bliss
 With the Most High. And after three
 More days I'll tell you in degree
 Other things, and explain weighty
 And wondrous matters you will see."

57 Then I arose and paced the field,
 Giving great glory and in yield
 Praise to the Most High because of
 His wonders, which he did *in love*
 From age to age, 58 because He rules
 The times and what things *in their pools*
 And seasons come to pass. And so
 I stayed there three days *for the show*.

The bodies that lay strewn in Massada
 Were not lost forever to Roman claw,
 But from the very sea again arose
 The heavenly kingdom that You straightly
 chose.

Rome takes her martyrs one and all as
 though
 In martyrdom were victory in row.
 But victory is in keeping Your law
 Which nothing can overcome in the raw.
 You are the Ruler still, though every chime
 Of every church tower claim the heathen
 rhyme
 Of baptisms in blood and trinity.
 You are still one and make are humans
 free.
 Beloved, I praise Your name without a
 sound,
 Pretending to be here among the bound.

2 Esdras 14

1 On the third day, while I was sitting
 Under an oak, *indeed not knitting*,
 A voice came from the bush near me
 And said, "Ezra, Ezra." 2 And see
 I said, "Here I am, Lord," and I
 Got to my feet *as I was spry*.
 3 Then he said to me, "I revealed
 Myself in a bush to the heeled
 Moses and spoke to him, when My
 Folk were slaves in Egyptian *sty*,
 4 "And I sent him and led My folk
 Out of Egypt, and *at a stroke*
 I led him up on Mount Sinai,
 Where I kept him *beneath the sky*
 With Me many days there *to try*,
 5 "And I told him many fine things,
 And showed him secret reckonings
 Of the times and declared to him
 The end of the times *that were grim*.
 Then I commanded him, and said
 6 'These words you shall publish when led
 Openly, and these keep instead.'

You spoke to Moses in the burning bush,
And on Mount Sinai You gave him a push
To write the law in blazing letters told
When cantillated sweeter than fine gold.
Many fine things indeed You told the man
Who wrote down everything You said by
plan.

The song of the creation and the fall,
The serpent and the tree, the sweet and gall,
Were subjects to his voice. The great Ali
Found in his words his direct prophecy.
Beloved, you spoke to Moses and he wrote.
Since then so many prophets taking note
Have also written and passed to their
graves.

I follow them to single out their slaves.

7 “And now I say to you, 8 ‘Lay up
In your heart the signs that in cup
I have shown you, the dreams that you
Have seen, and all their meanings due
That you have heard, 9 “for you shall be
Taken up from human degree,
And after that you’ll come to live
With my Son and with those in sieve
Who are like you, until the times
Are ended *and fulfilled the crimes*.

10 “Because the age has lost its youth,
And times begin to age forsooth.

11 “The era is divided to
Twelve parts, and nine of its parts due
Have already passed, 12 “as well too
As half the tenth part, and so two
Of its parts remain, besides half
Of the tenth part. 13 “So now, by gaff,
Set your house in order, reprove
Your people, comfort those who move
Lowly among them, and instruct
Those that are wise and still unmucked.
And now renounce corrupted life,

14 “And put away your mortal strife,
And cast away the human load,
Divested of weak nature’s goad,

15 “And lay aside most grievous thought
And haste away from this time’s plot.

16 “For evils worse than those you’ve seen
Will happen soon upon the green.

17 “The weaker the world gets with age,
The more its evils come on stage.

18 “For truth shall go farther away,
And falsehood shall come near *to stay*.

The eagle that you saw in vision
Is coming quickly with derision.””

The writing is supposed to meet the air
In Esdras’ time, or father’s to beware,
And yet only two of the twelve are left
To complete the time of the unbereft.
Such verses raise doubt in the solitude
Of hearts steeped both in science and the
rude,

And yet I bear with patience all the crude
That hangs doubts on the revelation’s cleft.
Beloved, time’s not the slave of any
chance,

Nor does it draw out in a line, but dance
In circles of the twelve until the day
When the soul flies toward the sky away.
I too spend two parts of the time to sway
In whirling round and round, just see me
prance.

19 Then I answered and said, “Let me
Speak in your presence, Lord, *freely*.

20 “For indeed, I will go, as You
Have commanded me, and in view
Of chiding the folk now who do,
But who shall warn those who will be
Born after this time’s *roguery*?
For the world lies in darkness’ night,
And its dwellers are without light.

21 “For Your law has been burned, and so
No one knows the things in the show
Which have been done or will be done
By you. 22 “If then I have grace won
In Your sight, send the Holy Spirit
To me, and I will write all near it
That has happened in the world from
The start, and all the things that come
Written in Your law, that men may
Find the path and the righteous way,
And that those who desire to live
In the last days may come to live.”

There was a time when Your law had been
lost,
And burned and scorched from heart and
mind embossed,
A time when only oracles remained,
And people worried that a prophet pained
And might forsake them to the naught
when gained.

There was a time when Moses' writings
stood
Only within the heart and brain and wood.
There was no scroll and every temple pot
Had been requisitioned by heathen sot.
The prophet asks You for the remedy,
And knows that it will be the destiny
Of those in the last days to read the book
That Moses wrote, that was burned till it
shook
And was rewritten my Ezra in nook.

23 He answered me and said "Go and
Gather the people, tell the band
Not to seek you for forty days.
24 "But make yourself tablets to write,
And take with you Sarea bright,
Dabria, Selemia well,
Ethanus, also Asiel,
These five, because they're trained to write
Quickly, 25 "and you shall come back here,
And I'll illuminate your heart
The lamp of understanding's part,
Which shall not be put out until
What the things you write shall fulfil.
26 "And when you've finished, some
things you
Shall make public, and some endure
In secret to the wise, tomorrow
At this time you'll write *without sorrow*."

The Bible and Apocrypha were made
In forty days of recitation stayed
Not for the day or night, when five men
wrote
What Ezra spoke sitting on creosote.
The heart illuminated by the skill
Of miracle did not stop with its fill,
But sang in ecstasy upon the hill,
Surrounded by the meadow and its flowers.
I long to hear the singing hours and hours,
And so I too take down the lettered scroll
And cantillate the words in roll on roll.
Beloved, I breathe the breath of Ezra now,
Remembered from the breath of Moses'
brow,
Until I meet Your lips and take a bow.

27 So I went as he ordered me,
I gathered all the folk's degree,
And said, 28 "Hear these words, Israel
29 "At first our fathers lived a spell

As aliens in Egypt's land,
And they were saved from there in band,
30 "And they received the law of life,
Which they did not keep *in their strife*,
Which you too transgressed after them.
31 "Then land was given to you in hem
For heritage in Zion's land,
But you and your ancestors did
Iniquity at every bid
And did not keep the ways of which
The Most High ordered you to pitch.
32 "And since He is a righteous judge,
In time he took from you the sludge
Of what He'd given you to budge.
33 "And now you're here to stay, and your
Brothers are on a further shore.
34 "So if you'll control mind and heart,
You'll stay alive to do your part,
And after death you shall obtain
Mercy *over all other gain*.
35 "For after death judgement will come,
When we shall live again in sum,
And then the righteous names will be
Apparent for all men to see,
And the deeds of ungodly men
Will be uncovered once again.
36 "But let no one come to me now,
And let no one seek out my brow
For forty days then anyhow."

If Moses fasted forty days to get
The Torah from Your lips and then well set
Joined Israel to keep the feast of weeks,
I join in eating garlic, bread and leeks.
It was no feat beyond what Ezra did
In cantillating all the books You hid.
The miracles of revelation stand
And awesome require plot of every hand.
Beloved, I too see revelation's power
To stand upon the day of judgement's hour
And follow in the law the books require
To keep the soul from burning in the fire.
Instead I choose the fire of Your love now
And frenzied whirl about the great
powwow.

37 So I took the five men, as he
Commanded me, and so then we
Went out into the field to stay.
38 And see a voice on the next day
Called out to me and stopped to say
"Ezra, open your mouth and drink

The liquid that I give to drink.”
 39 And so I opened up my mouth,
 And see, a full cup and not drouth
 Was offered to me, it was filled
 With something like water distilled,
 But its colour was like the fire.
 40 I took it and I drank the dire,
 And when I had drunk it, my heart
 Poured forth in understanding art,
 And wisdom increased in my breast,
 My spirit kept its memory best,
 41 And so my mouth was open, and
 Was no longer closed *from the band*.
 42 And the Most High gave understanding
 To the five men, by turns in branding
 They wrote what was dictated slow,
 In characters they did not know.
 They sat for forty days, and wrote
 During the daytime, and took note
 To eat their meals at night *by rote*.
 43 But as for me, I spoke all day
 And was not quiet in night’s sway.
 44 So during forty days in all
 Ninety-four books were written small.

I too drink of the juice of peony,
 The bitter dandelion and the tree
 Of maple and of birch to find the power
 To recite, know and keep the books an
 hour.
 I too drink of the silver nectar flown
 From fount of Kauthar there before Your
 throne
 Where Ali comes with both hands on the
 vial,
 And stepping on the checked celestial tile.
 Beloved, I too take five in family
 Of prophet and the people of degree
 Of prophet’s house and prophet’s progeny.
 The ninety-four books hidden in my heart
 Give me command also to do my part,
 Some public and some secret like the dart.

45 And when the forty days were ended,
 The Most High spoke to me attended,
 Saying, “Make public twenty-four
 Books that you wrote first on the score
 And let the worthy and those not
 Read them *both word and phrase and plot*,
 46 But keep the seventy that were writ
 The last, in order to give grit
 To the wise men among your folk.

47 For in them is the spring of truth,
 The fountain of wisdom, forsooth
 The river of knowledge.” 48 And I
 Did as commanded *by the sky*.

I too make public twenty-two or four
 Of those books once recited at the door.
 But I do not stop there, I also take
 A number from the hidden books’ keepsake
 And publish them among the public ones
 To shine as moons among the sightful suns.
 I too make public words of Your
 commands
 Albeit from the humblest of the hands
 Of any that resort to take Your word
 Reciting on the marketplace what’s heard
 In secret and in ecstasy, heart stirred.
 I too make an account of mystery,
 A counting of the sacred history,
 Beyond my penned fingers and blistery.

2 Esdras 15

1 The Lord says “Indeed, speak into
 The ears of my folk *in their pew*
 The words of prophecy which I
 Will put in your mouth *by and by*,
 2 “And cause them to be written *down*
 On paper, for they’re *of renown*
 Trustworthy and true *in the town*.
 3 “Do not fear the plots against you,
 And do not be anxious undue
 For unbelief who oppose you.
 4 Each unbeliever, he shall die
 In his unbelief *by and by*. ”
 5 “Indeed,” says YHWH, “I bring the
 world
 Evils, the sword and famine swirled
 And death and destruction unfurled.
 6 “Iniquity has spread throughout
 Each land, and their harmful deeds’ doubt
 Has reached the limits of their clout.

The post-Bar Kokhba world lies open here
 As the prophet’s final chapters appear.
 To the faithful You counsel not to fear,
 While You bring on the infidel the great
 Destruction that is unclenched by the rate
 Of Roman legions marching on the land
 Of holy memory to fill the sand
 With desecration of their bloody feet,
 The stench of uncircumcised pecks to beat.
 Beloved, I flee to Your hand from the toil

That poisons all the wealth of richest soil,
That makes of Basrah a caldron to boil.
I flee to You from the established church,
I leave the politician in the lurch,
And bide my tongue beneath my fir and
birch.

7 Therefore," says YHWH, 8 "I will keep
mum

No more about the deeds they hum
In wickedness, nor will I take
Their evil practices in stake.
Behold the innocent and fair
Blood cries out to Me to beware,
And the souls of the righteous cry
Out to Me for ever and aye.

Six hundred thousand people died the year
That Romans flooded the country with fear.
Hadrian could not say the legions fared
Well to the Senate for the blood he dared
To lose from honoured Roman soldiers'
veins.

The genocide invented on the plains
Has not stopped since that time of Roman
gains.

The innocent blood mixes with the gore
Of cannon foddered armies on the shore,
And even Napoleon only spent
His time in mimicry of Roman vent.
In silence You look on catastrophe
That makes up this world's kingdom in
degree,
To listen to the righteous cry's ascent.

9 "But I shall avenge them indeed,"
Says YHWH, "and will receive decreed
To Myself all innocent blood
From among them *poured out in flood*.

10 "See My folk are led like a flock
To slaughter, so I'll stop the clock
On their living in Egypt's land.

11 "I'll bring them out with mighty hand
And uplift arm, and I will smite
Egypt with plagues as on that night,
And I will destroy all its land."

12 "Let Egypt mourn, and its foundations,
For the plague of chastisement's rations
And punishment that YHWH will bring
Upon it for its bad doing.

13 "Let all the men who work the soil
Mourn, because their seed fails in toil

And their trees ruin by the blight
And hail and storm come on the site.
14 "Alas for the world and for those
Who live in it in rows and rows!
15 "For sword and misery draw near
And nation shall rise up in fear
To fight against nation, with sword
In their hands for plague and reward.

The Exodus from Egypt is the gauge
Of what You will do in the coming age
To take vengeance on Babylon in spe
Trucked out as Rome and Athens in their
sway,

And trumpeted as London, Washington,
Paris, Berlin and Moscow on the run.
The nations rise up now for fear and cast
About them for a government to last,
But since they all are evil at the throat
And at the heart, they fail to save the boat.
Beloved, I reside in the craven nest
And see iniquity outdo the best,
And wait till You step in to intervene
In vengeance and at last to vent Your
spleen.

16 "There shall be unrest among men,
Growing strong and stronger again,
They'll in their might have no respect
For king or chief of the elect.

17 "For a man will desire to go
To town, and shall not find the row.

18 "For pride the cities shall be foiled,
And all the houses there be spoiled,
And people there afraid and roiled.

19 "A man shall have no pity on
His neighbours, but shall make *at dawn*
Assault on their rooms with a sword
And spoil the goods *that they adored*,
Because of hunger for the bread
And the great trouble around *spread*.

20 "Indeed," says Alohim, "I call
Together all the kings *in thrall*
Upon the earth for fear of Me,
From rising of the sun's *degree*
And from the south, and from the east
And from the Lebanon increased,
To turn and repay what they've given.

21 "Just as they have done and have striven
Against My own until this day,
So I will do, and will repay
Into their bosom *come the fray*."

There are more hungry people in the world
Today than at any time or age curled.
There are more neighbours coming in to
steal

The silver and the plates to get a meal
Than ever in the history of time.
The Roman kingdom is a state of crime.
The strife that comes in every place today
Has common features in the iron and clay:
After the peace accord and dust is down
And settled and the folk come back to
town,

The difference between the new and old
Is that the Sabbatarians in fold
That used to live there are out in the cold,
All dead before democracy's fair crown.

So says YHWH Alohim, 22 "My right
Hand will not spare sinners from plight,
And My sword will not cease from those
Who shed innocent blood on clothes."

23 And fire will go forth from his wrath,
And will consume the earth in path
And sinners, like straw's aftermath.

24 "Woe to those who sin and do not
Observe my commandments *in plot*,"
Says YHWH, 25 "And I will not spare
them.

Depart, you faithless children's hem!
Do not pollute my sanctuary."

26 For YHWH knows all who are not wary
Of sinning against Him, so He
Will hand them to destruction's fee.

27 For now calamities have come
Upon the whole earth, and in sum
You shall remain in them, for God
Will not save you upon the sod,
Because you've sinned against His rod.

28 Behold, a terrifying sight,
Appearing from the eastern light!

I should not spare them either, Lord,
Who lift against Your own the sword.
I should not spare, no, not at all,
But put them up against the wall
To give account for those who died
By sword and plague and food denied.
Destruction and pest and calamity
Are products sprouting not of evil fee
In heart and mind of youth and humankind,
But in the system and the grating bind

Of Babylon itself that makes the chart
That educated humans must take part
Unless by act of will and love they seek
Instead Your law, Beloved, Your cheek.

29 The nations of the dragons of
Arabia shall come above
With many chariots, and from
The day that they set out to come,
Their hissing shall spread over earth,
So that all who hear them in their birth
Shall trembling fear for all they're worth.

30 Also Carmonians, in rage
Shall come like wild boars on the stage
Of woodlands and stampeding power
To meet them at the battle hour
In devastation of the land
In part of the Assyrian band
With ranging teeth above the sand.

31 And then the dragons, so mind where
They have come from, shall strengthen
share,

And if they join in power and turn
In their pursuit, 32 then these shall burn
Scattered and silenced by their power,
And turn and flee before the shower.

33 And from land of Assyrians
An enemy in ambush spans
Them to destroy one in their plans,
And fear and trembling fall upon
Their hosts, and their kings wait at dawn.

34 Indeed, clouds from the east, and from
The north down to the south shall come,
With aspect threatening of wrath
And tempest raging on the path.

35 They'll dash against each other and
Make outpour on the earth and sand
In their own raging, and there'll be
Blood from the sword to the degree
Of horse's belly, 36 and man's thigh
And camel's hock to measure by.

The wing of Babylon and Rome to take
Jerusalem by its surprise at stake
In six hundred and thirty-five is just
The armies of the Arab making dust.
Clouds form the east and from the south
And from the north opened their mouth
And swallowed up the city bought and fair
Despite the renewed Jewish attempt's ware
And Christian ruler on the throne to dare.
Beloved, the rise of Araby in state,

With almost truth in every doctrine's gate
Is very like the Roman creed to stand
And keep its wingèd shadow on the land.
The final claw in beauty scratches band.

37 And there shall be fear and a great
Trembling upon the earth and state,
And those who see that wrath shall be
Dumb with the horror that they see,
And seized with shuddering's *decree*.
38 And after that, heavy storm clouds
Shall be stirred up from southern *shrouds*,
And from the north, and one more part
Up from the west *above the mart*.
39 And the winds from the east shall blow
Upon the cloud raised in wrath's show,
And shall dispel it, and the storm
That was to cause destruction warm
By the east wind shall be thrown back
With violence toward the slack
South and the west. 40 And great and sure
Clouds, full of wrath and rage endure,
Shall rise destroying all the earth
And its inhabitants of worth,
And shall pour out on every high
And holy place a ghastly cry,
41 And fire and hail and flying sword
And floods of water, that the sward
Of field and every stream may be
Filled with those waters in degree.
42 And they shall destroy towns and walls,
And mountains and hills and the stalls,
The trees of forests, and the grass
Of meadows, and their grain to pass.

The Umayyad capture of all the world
Is described in the storm-cloud when
unfurled
Upon the land and sea. The raging way
Of drunken rulers centuries held sway.
The whole world civilized was in the clutch
Of Umayyad. No one had heard of Dutch.
Beloved, the fire and hail and flying sword
Caught up the Persian and the Hindu lord,
Ran over the pearl of North Africa,
Starred in Andalusia with the awe
Of civilized enthronement of the great.
Then Europe was elsewhere in such a state
Of primitive abuse, of village life
Bucolic and sylvan and without strife.

43 And they shall go on constantly

To Babylon, and cut her plea.
44 They shall come and surround her, they
Shall pour out the tempest in fray
Upon her, then the dust and smoke
Shall rise into the sky a stoke,
And all who are about her too
Shall wail because of her own due.
45 And those who survive shall serve those
Who have destroyed her in their rows.
46 And you, Asia, who share in gloss
Of Babylon and in the toss
Of her form's glory, 47 woe to you,
You beggared wretch! And as for you
You've made yourself like her, and you
Have decked your daughters out in crew
Of whoredom just to please and take
Glory in your lovers, whose stake
Has always been lusting for you.
48 You've followed the example set
By that hateful harlot you met
In all her deeds and all her ways,
And that is why Alohim says,
49 "I will send evils upon you,
Widowhood, poverty, and due
Famine, the sword, and pestilence,
To flatten habitations hence
And bring you in destruction's fence.

When Tamerlane came in with horde on
horde
It was Baghdad that carried on and stored
The claims of Babylon by book and sword.
The holy Qur'an was endowed to gleam
Within the mosque held by ruler to seem,
But whose orgies surpassed Rome's in the
sheen
Of silk and sex and delicacy's scent.
The widowhood and poverty that went
After the Mongol armies never gave
Way before Ottoman or Mameluk slave.
Beloved, in prophecy I see the dire
Rise and fall of every saintly empire,
While in their hidden closets those who
keep
Your faith and law miss history and weep.

50 "The glory of your strength shall fade
Like passing bloom when heat is made.
51 "You shall be weakened like a wretch,
A woman beaten down to fetch,
So that you are no longer able
To welcome your lovers to table.

52 “Would I have treated you with wrath,”
 Says YHWH, 53 “If you had chosen path
 Not to kill my elect and folk,
 Rejoicing and clapping a poke
 And toasting their humiliation
 And death with whiskey without ration?
 55 “Put on your make-up and stand up
 To take the retribution’s *cup*.
 56 As you will treat My chosen folk,”
 Says YHWH, “so Alohim will stoke
 You, and give you over to foes.

The fall of Babylon that once began
 With Tamerlane goes on from man to man
 And century and century to find
 Itself an institution of the blind.
 The call to come out of fair Babylon
 Is not a new thing brought under the sun,
 But is the gospel in its verity,
 Enshrined in the very word ecclesy.
 The calling out is not just from the state
 Of heathendom, but from the very rate
 Of minyan of ten. Jesus lowered beam
 And described two or three, not in a dream
 Did he promise to sanctify a church
 Of greater numbers sitting on their perch.

57 “Your children shall die *rows on rows*
 Of hunger, and you fall by sword,
 And your towns wiped out and be gored
 All your people out on the land.
 58 “Those hiding in the mountains and
 The highland shall perish at hand
 Of hunger and eat their own flesh
 For bread and their own blood *poured fresh*
 They’ll drink for water *in the mesh*.
 59 “Unhappy above all addictions,
 You’ll come and suffer fresh afflictions.
 60 As they pass they shall wreck the town
 And city hated *with a frown*,
 And shall destroy part of your land
 And on your trampled glory stand,
 As they return from devastation
 Of Babylon *the state and nation*.
 61 “And you yourself shall be by them
 Like stubble, and they’ll be like *hem*
Of fire to you in consternation.
 62 “And they’ll consume you and your
 towns,
 Your land and mountains under frowns,
 They’ll burn your forests with their fire
 And all your fruitful trees in ire.

63 “They’ll carry your children away
 As slaves, and spoil your treasured pay,
 Extinguish from both face and tress
 Every mark of your happiness.”

The children of fair Babylon are tossed
 Against the wall to death to Psalmist’s cost,
 In prophecy and in reality,
 The children fair the worst in poverty
 And in the battle spent. They come to die
 Of hunger and disease so wealth may fly.
 The children of fair Babylon are met
 In every cattle-car that has been set
 To take the refugee to camp and let
 Her earn her way to death by smoke and
 bet.

Beloved, I weep for Babylon who bore
 Her children in her iron arms for gore,
 And sacrificed them on the golden plate
 Of oil gods and of other heads of state.

2 Esdras 16

1 Woe, Babylon and Asia! Woe
 To you, Egypt and Syria’s row!
 2 Put on sackcloth and haircloth too
 And sorrow for your children’s due,
 Lament for their destruction too,
 Which is at hand and almost due.
 3 The sword has been sent upon you,
 And who’s there to turn it from view?
 4 A fire has been sent upon you,
 And who is there to quench it’s spew?
 5 Calamities have been sent on
 You, and who can prevent their dawn?
 6 Can one shoo off the hungry beast,
 The forest lion from the feast,
 Or come extinguish a grass fire
 Once it is kindled up to ire?
 7 Can one turn back an arrow flight
 Shot by an archer with his might?

Beloved, destroy the Babylon in me,
 Let it sink in the horrors of the sea
 And fail from flight to languish fatally,
 And fall into the pit eternally.
 Beloved, let sackcloth cover Babylon
 Within my heart, let haircloth be undone
 Upon the brow forsaken in the run.
 Let Babylon diminish under sun.
 The prayer may go unheard, the prayer may
 be
 Answered in timely fashion on the dun

Or bright, but sure as hearth and fire return
The sin of Babylon shall burn and burn,
The din of Babylon shall learn to yearn.

8 YHWH Alohim sends plague and pest,
And who will turn them from their quest?
9 The fire will go forth from His wrath,
And who is there to stop its path?
10 He'll flash His lightning on parade,
And who will not then be afraid?
He'll thunder, who's not terrified?
11 The Lord will threaten, who will bide
In His sight and not run to hide?
12 The earth and its foundations quake,
The sea is churned up from the wake,
Its waves and denizens shall fail
Before the sight of YHWH and wail
Before the glory of His sail.
13 For His right hand that bends the bow
Is mighty, and His arrows throw
Sharp points that will not miss when they
Begin to shadow the earth's sway.
14 See, these catastrophes are sent
Out and shall not return unbent
Until they cover all the earth.
15 The fire is kindled in the berth,
Not to extinguish till it's rent
The deep foundations of the earth.

How bright the fires that burn in Babylon,
In Babylon to break the line of dawn
Sunk in the Euphrates away from sight,
Among the water weeds into the night.
Remember, my Beloved, the promise fair,
Remember to destroy the world of care
Out of the light and sight of desert air
Where Babylon sinks down in its despair.
Shrive me upon the shining golden stair
To find Your throne alone in heart laid
bare.

How bright the fires that lay my dross
away,
Resounding on the quiet of the day.
Open my chambered doors, Beloved, and
find
Where marbled walls glisten to You
inclined.

16 Just as an arrow shot in strength
By archers turns not back at length,
So the calamities now sent
Upon the earth shall not repent.

17 Alas for me! And woe is me!
Who'll save me from those days' decree?
18 The start of sorrows, when there'll be
Lamentation and famine's spree,
When many shall perish, the start
Of wars, when the rulers in cart
Shall be horrified by their part,
The start of plagues and pest, when all
Shall tremble and in trembling fall.
What shall they do in these times then
When pestilence comes upon men?
19 Indeed, famine and plague, and spoil
And anguish are sent scourge and toil
For the correction of men's coil.
20 Yet for all this they will not turn
From their iniquities to learn,
Nor mind the scourges that they spurn.
21 Provision there will be so cheap
On earth that men forget to weep,
Imagining peace is assured
For them, and then pestilence' word
Shall spring up on the earth: the sword,
Famine, and great troubles' reward.

Share with me, my Beloved, Your own last
joy
Heaving out Babylon from the employ
Of heart and mind and hand into the great
Thunder and lightning flashing on its fate.
I praise You for the sinking of the sod,
No matter where the city falls on clod,
Sever the arteries and break the heart
That beats in Babylon just for a start.
Right is the glory that rises to see
Enclosed in its destruction by decree.
No hour of peace was known in Babylon,
Great was calamity of the town drawn
That made all nations drink the wine of
wrath.
How glorious the fall, how bright the path!

22 For many living on the earth
Shall perish by famine and dearth,
And those who survive famine die
By the sword under burning sky.
23 And the dead shall be thrown out like
Manure upon the heaps to strike,
And none shall comfort them because
The earth shall be desert in claws,
Its cities shall be thrown down too
And all removed from blissful view.
24 No one shall be left to turn soil

Or sow the earth with humble toil.
25 The trees shall bear fruit out to win,
But who will gather it in bin?
26 The grapes shall ripen on the vine,
But who will tread them out in wine?
For in all places there shall be
But solitude for company,
27 One man will long to see another,
Or even hear the voice of brother.

Who thrust the sword into the belly of
The men and women who held You in love
Now burn in desolation for the fee
Of mocking at your law's eternity.
Who trust the word of church and
government
To deny living to divinely sent
Now fall into despair for others meant
Into despair born in iniquity.
Beloved I straighten hand toward the tree
And gather of the fruit that faithfully
Appears to comfort those who found
delight
In Your law, though they had to live in
night.
I leave the grapes to trample on the shore
Of Babylon laid bloody in its gore.

28 Out of a city, ten shall be,
Out of the field, two did not flee
But hid themselves in a thick grove
And in the rocky holes they dove.
29 As in an olive orchard three
Or four olives left on each tree,
30 Or as when a vineyard is done
After the gathering of sun,
Some clusters may be left by those
Who carefully search down the rows.
31 At that time three or four ones left
By the sword in their homes bereft
Will be like branch and field and close.
32 And the earth shall be desolate,
And its fields filled with briers' hate,
And its roads and all paths with thorns,
And without sheep with heads of horns.

Say not that any shall be left to breathe
Of Babylon, let its caldron still seethe
And boil away iniquity and care
Before the clearing of the righteous air!
Leave only hanging gardens for the just,

Leave only Psalms in sweetness above
dust.
Let every field be choked with briers till
The arctic bramble blossom on the hill
And wolves come out to taste the berries
left
By every sort of sinner gone bereft.
When You, Beloved, have slain each sinner
that
Lies in each human breast and then have
sat
Down in the throne of every heart and
tower,
Then I shall rise to joy with You an hour.

33 Virgins shall mourn because they find
No bridegrooms, women without kind
Because they have no husbands, and
Their daughters shall mourn with no aid,
Nothing to buy when they are paid.
34 Their bridegrooms shall be killed in
war,
Their husbands fail for famine's gore.
35 Hear now these things and understand,
O servants of YHWH in a band.
36 Behold the word of YHWH, take it,
Do not doubt what YHWH says a bit.
37 Indeed, calamities draw near,
And they are not delayed by fear.
38 Just as is a woman with child,
In the ninth month, when the time wild
Of her delivery draws near,
She has great pains about her gear
For two or three hours before birth,
And when the child comes out and stirreth
There will not be moment's delay,
39 Calamities now on their way
Will not be stopped in coming out
Upon the earth, and the world stout
Will groan, and pains will seize it there
On every side and so beware.

Are any virgins left in Babylon?
I think not, all have gone the way of pawn
To work the evil deed pronounced by one
And call good though they're evil under
sun.
Men and mermaids create reality
In their own image when they dream in
spree,
But when the truth breaks through the
scenery,

Your face alone defines the hopeless done.
Beloved, I too groan with the parting sail,
I sigh to hear the telling of the tale,
But when I wake from tardema's last thrall
I'll find Your grace and glory at the wall.
Beloved, I too squeak at calamity,
I too weep at the pouring out of tea,
And snuffle in my dreams of unity.

40 "Hear my words, O my folk, prepare
For battle, and in all the troubles
Be like strangers on earthen rubbles.
41 "Let him that sells be like one who
Will flee, and let the buyer be
Like one who'll lose, 42 "let his degree
That does business be like the one
Who will not make a profit done,
And let him that builds be like one
Who'll not live in the house when done,
43 "Let him that sows be like one who
Will not reap, so also him who
Prunes the vines, like one who will not
Harvest the grapes grown in his plot,
44 "Them that marry, like those who'll not
Bear children, and them that do not
Marry, like those widowed *in lot*.
45 "Because those who labour, they work
In vain, 46 "for strangers *who now shirk*
Shall gather their fruits, and make spoil
Of the goods and fruit of their toil,
And tear down their houses and take
Their children to be slaves *in stake*,
For in captivity and wake
Of famine they'll beget *and make*.

I've been a stranger in my land of birth.
I've been a pilgrim in a land of worth.
The hopeless tingle of the foreign hand
Has been familiar to me where I stand.
I've been a loner in the crowd that swayed
Beneath the pulpit of purple parade
To find the blossom of the plum in shade
A comfort to the one who strayed and
strayed.
Beloved, I am a stranger and I come
To plunder Babylon of every sum,
But there I find the barren hearts alone
And barren government and barren throne.
I cannot eat the gold nor drink the wine
Fermented beyond hope to meet the brine,
But I can joy upon the rubbled line.

47 "Those who conduct their business, do
It only to be spoiled *when due*,
The more they decorate their towns,
Their houses and possessions, *gowns*
And persons, 48 "the more angry I
Will be with them for their sins high,"
Says YHWH. 49 "Just as woman sitting
Respectable, in virtue *putting*
Despises every whore, 50 "then so
Righteousness shall abhor the flow
Of wickedness, when she is dressed,
Accusing her *when unconfessed*,
When He comes who will defend him
Who searches out every sin *grim*
Upon the earth *in light and dim*.
51 "So don't be like her or her ways.
52 "Indeed, a little while in maze,
And wickedness shall be removed
From earth, and righteousness approved
Will reign over us *and for praise*.
53 "Let no sinner say he's not sinned,
For Alohim will burn unbinned
The coals of fire on head of him
Who says, 'I have not sinned though dim
Before Alohim and His light.'"

Though I aspire to righteousness I think
The whores I've seen upon the street or
brink
Of darkness are a cut above the dross
That claims its charity is not a loss.
The ladies in the church with jewelled
hands
And decked out in both gold and silver
bands
Are not as good by far as whores I've seen
Tempting the Paris Africans to screen.
The ladies of the night in all their masks
And postures at least show what the man
asks,
While the religious whores before the rail
Of altar with their outside garments pale
Are black inside with crass hypocrisy,
Despising Your law with their pious scree.

54 Indeed, YHWH knows all the works
bright
Of men, and their imaginations
And their thoughts and their hearts'
inflations.
55 He said "Let the earth come to be,"
And it was made, "Let the sky be,"

And it was made by His decree.
 56 At His word too the stars were fixed,
 He knows the stars' number unmixed.
 57 It is he who searches the deep
 And its treasures, who has the heap
 Of the sea measured and its reap,
 58 Enclosed the sea where waters creep,
 And by His word He's hung the world
 Over the waters where they swirled,
 59 Who's spread out heaven like an arch,
 And founded it on waters' march,
 60 Who's put in deserts water springs,
 And pools on mountaintops and things
 To send the rivers from the heights
 To water earth, 61 and who formed man,
 And put a heart in body's span,
 And gave him breath and life and thought
 62 And spirit of Almighty God,
 Who made all things upon the sod
 And searches out the hidden things
 In hidden place, and source and springs.

The word that can create when merely sung
 Is the very word taken on my tongue
 When I come to the cantillation's store
 To read the Law and Psalms upon my
 shore.

My shore is cut in granite and quartzite,
 And pocked with ice and with savage
 delight,

And when I cry the word all things are
 bright

With hope and help before the coming
 night.

Beloved, the word creating light on sight,
 And firmament on firmament is here
 To resound on the waiting, humble ear.
 Let it create in me a throne and stair,
 A place of refuge on the shining air,
 A slaughter ground of worship I can bear.

63 Surely He knows your secret thoughts
 And what you think in inner plots!

So woe to those who sin and try
 To hide their sins beneath the sky!

64 Because YHWH will surely find out
 All their deeds, and make public shout
 Of all of you. 65 And when your sins
 Come out before men from their bins,
 You shall be put to shame, and your
 Own wickedness shall stand at door
 As your accusers on that day.

66 What will you do? How to defray
 Your sins before Alohim and
 His angels? 67 Indeed, on the stand
 Alohim is the judge, fear Him!
 Stop sinning and don't mind the dim
 Iniquity, never commit
 Such things again, and such unfit,
 So Alohim will lead you out
 And save you from trouble and rout.
 68 See flaming wrath of a great crowd
 Is kindled over you in cloud,
 And they shall carry some of you
 Away and feed you things astray
 As sacrificed in idols' way.
 69 And those who consent such to eat
 Shall be mocked and stamped on by feet.

The message is so simple on the tongue
 Of angel come to ring a bell once rung.
 The message is simply to stop the race
 Of sinning in transgression in this place.
 The words are only ten, and more to keep
 They are in promises than commands steep.
 There's hardly anything in them a man
 Cannot carry out as though with a plan
 By merely sitting on his own bed where
 He awakens in the morning with a prayer.
 Beloved, the flaming ire of every crowd
 Is what keeps every soul from standing
 proud

And sinless before You. You only ask
 That we stop sinning and go out and bask.

70 In many places round the land
 There shall arise up band on band
 Against those who fear YHWH and stand.

71 They shall be like mad men, to spare
 No one, but plunder, spoil and dare
 Destroying those who continue
 To fear *Alohim and fear* YHWH.

72 For they'll destroy and plunder goods,
 And drive them out of house to woods.

73 The fineness tried of My elect
 Will then be shown to be select,
 As gold is tried by fire, *not wrecked*.

74 "Hear, my elect," says YHWH. "Indeed,
 The days of tribulation speed,
 And I'll save you from them in need.

75 Do not fear or doubt, Alohim
 Will guide you through all things that
 seem.

76 You who keep My commandments and

Statutes” says YHWH Alohim *grand*,
 “Do not let your sins pull you down,
 Or your iniquities *in town*
 Conquer you and keep under frown.”
 77 Woe to those who are choked by sin
 And overwhelmed by wicked bin,
 As a field may be choked by weeds,
 And its path overwhelmed by seeds
 Of thorns so that no one can pass!
 78 It is closed off and given like grass
 To be burned in a fire, alas!

Let me find my place among the elect,
 Since I’ve been persecuted, though stiff-
 necked.
 Why should I suffer for the light and brew
 Of having kept and taught Your law in
 view,
 If I am not to count among the few
 Who rise to stand in glory and select?
 Beloved, I see the pathway straight and
 strong
 And chosen simply because in the wrong
 There is such crowd that none can hear my
 song.
 I choose the solitary way and find
 A sweeter road to travel than the blind.
 Though I see none around me in the way
 To imitate and help my mind to sway,
 At least prophetic footprints lead the day.

Tobit

The book of Tobit is here translated from the Greek version with reference to the Revised Standard Version, the King James Version, and the Jerusalem Bible. It was likely written about five centuries before the common era. Its purpose is not to present historical or geographical facts, but to teach some lessons in story form. The story is set about a century before the time of its writing. The outstanding moral principle invoked is respect for the dead and the duty of providing proper if not grandiose funerals. Along with this, however, certain other principles are emphasized, those being especially prayer, fasting, and the giving of alms, along with respect for parents and love of kin. As such it is an important document affirming the

early importance of those practices that form the central pillars of Islam. The oneness of God is clearly proclaimed and a highly developed doctrine of angels is in evidence. Furthermore, idolatry is strongly condemned. The story thus consistently affirms both the Decalogue and the central practices that support it.

As an expression of post-exilic literature, Tobit presents an interesting way of living faith under imperial conditions. The point is to establish civil disobedience in a focused area. The area of choice in the book of Tobit is burial. The stubborn civil disobedience insisting on providing proper burial even for strangers is the backdrop of the entire tale, without which it could not exist. At the same time it provides a fascinating contemplation on inventive ways of subverting government opposed to divine law.

Tobit 1

1 The story of what Tobit did,
 Son of Ananiel to bid,
 Son of Aduel, who was son
 Of Gabael, who’s of the run
 Of descendants of Asiel
 And the tribe of Naphtali fell,
 2 Who in the days of Shalmaneser,
 King of every Assyrian geezer,
 Was taken in captivity
 From Thisbe, which is on the lea
 Southward of Kedesch Naphtali
 Above Asher in Galilee.
 3 I, Tobit, walked in ways of truth
 And righteousness all of my youth
 And all the days of my life, and
 I did many good works to hand
 My brothers and my countrymen
 Departing with me once again
 Into the country in the way
 Of Assyrians, to Nineveh.
 4 When I was in my own country,
 In the land of Israel and free
 As a young man, the whole tribe of
 Naphtali my forefather’s love,
 Left the house of Jerusalem.
 This was the place by stratagem
 Chosen from among all the tribes
 Of Israel, where all the tribes
 Might offer sacrifices and

Where the temple was made to stand
As house of the Most High to all
Generations ages to call.

5 All the tribes in apostasy
Offered offerings to the calf Baal,
And so the house of Naphtali
My ancestor to no avail.
6 But only I went for the feasts
Jerusalem kept by the priests
As ordained for all Israel
By permanent statute as well,
Taking the first fruits and above
That the tithes of my produce shove,
And the first shearings, I would give
These to the priests, Aaron's sons live
At the altar. 7 Of all my lot
I gave a tithe to Levi's plot
Who served Jerusalem and taught,
A second tithe I sold and got
From it the funds to go each year
Toward Jerusalem, appear.

A northern writing here is quite disposed
To support kingdom of the south that
closed

The doors between the two. Such politics
Are often root of sectarian tricks.
So Tobit goes down to the holy town
To bring his offerings and to meet the
frown

Of kinsmen in Samaria, and yet
The story turns upon the trails that get
To fall on Israel for the very thing
That Tobit is so careful to let sling.
Tobit will go into captivity
Despite his yearly march down to the see
Of royal city. My Beloved, I wait
To see Your justice riding in the gate.

8 The third tithe I would give to those
To whom it was my duty rose,
As Deborah my father's mother
Had commanded me *and my brother*,
For I was left an orphan by
My father. 9 So now then when I
Became a man I married Anna,
A member of our family manor,
And by her I became the dad
Of Tobias to *make hearts glad*.

10 When I was taken captive to
Nineveh, all my brothers too
And relatives ate Gentile food,

11 But I kept myself clean and good,
12 Since I remembered Alohim
With all my heart as it would seem.

The third tithe Tobit gave in share to each
In poverty and neediness to preach
Compassion on the poor. I praise the man
Who describes zakat as if by his plan.
The khums also he mentions for relieve
Of temple priest to lessen the man's grief.
The part that's left is used to make the trip
To house of God to open righteous lip.
Beloved, I am myself almost a case
Of charity where I live with the race
Of Gentiles who control the wealth and so
My alms are but a pitiable show.
And still I've fed both priest and pauper
here,
And come once to Your temple to appear.

Despite the punishment that fell the lot
Of Tobit for the sin of others wrought,
He did not blame You, my Beloved, but got
On with the job of faithfulness to be
Pure in his acts and eating righteously.
I know a Christian bishop of the line
Of those who think they are among the fine
Who eats the unholy and flesh of swine,
And never once repented sat to dine.
But Tobit is a courtier to the king,
And yet he takes the time of day to sing
With a pure tongue untainted with the
blood
Of sheep and goat, but poured it in the
mud.
Beloved, I praise the faithful on the wing.

13 Then the Most High gave me good
grace

And fortune before the king's face,
Of Shalmaneser, and I came
To buy provisions for his claim.

14 I used to go to Media,
And at Rages in Media
I once left silver talents ten
In trust with Gabael, again
The brother of Gabrias then.
15 It happened Shalmaneser died,
Sennacherib his son in tide
Reigned in his stead, and under him
The highways were unsafe and grim,
So I could no more go into

Media to do business due.
 16 In the days of Shalmaneser
 I did acts of alms and to share
 With my brothers. 17 I would give bread
 To the hungry and to the fed
 Naked my clothing, if I saw
 Any of my folk in the raw,
 Thrown out and dead behind the wall
 Of Nineveh, I'd bury all.
 18 And if Sennacherib the king
 Put to death any who fleeing
 Came from Judea, I would go
 And bury them in secret show.
 For in his wrath he killed a row.
 When the king sought the bodies, they
 Were not found, but buried away.
 19 Then one man of Nineveh went
 And told the king about my bent
 That I was burying them all,
 So I hid me behind the wall.
 When I heard I was sought to kill,
 In fear I left home for the drill.

The truth is service in the pay of kings
 Or presidents or ruffians with wings
 Is like to turn sour on a dime with stings.
 The man raised to the heavens on a day
 Is thrown out to the dogs as like to bay,
 Another climbs the chair for a short stay.
 The hope of wealth and fame leads men to
 flatter
 The rich and powerful before they scatter,
 And yet such hopes are like as not to
 shatter.
 Who lives in satisfaction of the now
 Is like to find when regimes take a bow,
 Another king comes in to confiscate
 All that was earned by children of the state.
 It does not help to make a feud and row.

20 Then all my property was taken,
 With nothing left to me forsaken
 But my wife Anna and my son
 Tobias. 21 But not in the run
 More than fifty days before two
 Of Sennacherib's sons in view
 Killed him, and they fled to the hills
 Of Ararat for all their ills.
 Then Esarhaddon, his son, reigned
 Instead of him, and he retained
 Ahikar, Anael the son of
 My frère Anael, over above

Accounts of his kingdom and all
 His business in both bin and stall.
 22 Ahikar pled for me, and I
 Returned to Nineveh thereby.
 Now Ahikar was cupbearer,
 Keeper of the signet, and fer
 In charge of the accounts in sure,
 For Esarhaddon set him up
 Second to himself *as a tup*.
 He was my nephew *and a pup*.

The way to get back home and wealth and
 tin
 Is to have someone at the court who's kin
 To say a word in ear of president
 Or prime minister for the missing rent.
 Today the civilized in land and cars
 Looks out to plant a colony on mars
 In hope that what succeeds barely on earth
 In terms of stable violence in berth
 Will turn utopia when settled down
 Upon the sod that's red instead of brown.
 But nephews in the engine room are sure
 To give their uncles in disfavour lure
 To keep each one submitted just in case
 The charity of ministers retrace.

Tobit 2

1 Now when I had come home again,
 Got back my wife Anna again,
 My son Tobias too, the feast
 Of Pentecost, which is the feast
 Of seven weeks in holiness,
 A fine meal was prepared for me,
 And I sat down to eat *with glee*.
 2 When I saw how much food was there,
 I told my son, "Go bring to share
 Whatever poor man you may find
 From our brothers who has a mind
 To YHWH, and see, I'll wait behind."
 3 But he returned and said "Dad, one
 Of our nation's strangled and done,
 Thrown out upon the marketplace."
 4 So before I'd begun to eat,
 I got up, took him in a space
 Until the setting sun retreat.
 5 Then I went back and washed one well
 And ate my meal in a sad spell,
 6 Minding Amos in prophecy
 As he said "Then your feasts shall be
 Turned into mourning, all your mirth
 Changed into lamentation's birth."

7 So I shed tears, then at sundown
I went and dug a grave in brown
And buried him. 8 My neighbours mocked
Me, saying "This man just defrocked
Is not afraid to die for this,
Who fled away, and now amiss
He's at burying dead unflocked."

Like Tobit I do not treat the dear well
That come before my sight in graveyard
plot.
I challenge the church wardens with a spell
By tending the neglected dead man's lot.
I thus prevent the desecration of
Forgotten graves grown over with old
weeds,
Disturb the rest of those with none to love
With blooms in summer, in fall dropping
seeds.
And so I steal from church and state the
fare
They might have got by digging up the
tomb
And yet have nought in hand for my earned
share
But consternation's profit in their room.
Beloved, the marks of grief spoil not my
joy
In outwitting priestcraft in its employ.

9 The same night then I came back from
The burying and slept when come
By the well of my courtyard as
I was polluted, my face has
Been there uncovered, 10 I did not
Know sparrows were in the wall's slot,
And as my eyes were turned up there,
The warm droppings became my share,
And whiteness came into my eyes,
And I went to the healer's plies,
But they helped not in any wise.
But Achaiacharus nourished me
Till I went to Elymais' *free*.
11 Anna my wife took work to do.
12 And when she'd sent them to their crew,
They paid her wages and besides
Gave her also a kid *for rides*.
13 And when it bleated in my house,
I asked her, "Where did this young grouse
Come from? Let it not be a theft,
But send it back from where it left,
For it's unlawful we should eat

Any portion of stolen meat."

Though I am blinded in my sleep beside
The garden wall enclosing all my pride,
Despite the narrow punishment of fate,
Let not my righteousness depart the gate.
The greenly flowers about my holiness,
As my distinctive poverty in dress
Identifies my lowlier estate,
Not recognizing inner wealth of late.
My treasure is the glowing of Your song
That keeps my willing hand from doing
wrong.
The property of herbs enthrals my soul,
And nettles contemplate my dinner's toll.
Beloved, I need no kid's flesh on my plate,
I eat and drink enough at dervish rate.

14 But she replied to me, "A gift
It was more than wages to lift."
But I did not believe her word
Commanding her return the erred
To its owners. My mind was blurred.
So she told me, "Where are your alms?
Where are your godly works and psalms?
See, you and all your acts are known."
So I saw my alms were a loan.

It's human, I see in city and town
To receive cattle, goats and sheep with
frown.
The human soul desires diviner dress,
To give and receive thanks in pettiness.
Only You, my Beloved, seem to take glee
Along with children and the suddenly
Enriched among wives have the heart to
crave
Things You do not need from the hand of
slave.
The reason for reversal of the slate
Of all reality in such a state
Of senseless quandary is simply that
All is reflection of You where You sat.
The mirror turns the image all around
And that is why we're perfect though
unsound.

Tobit 3

1 I cried in sorrow, in my grief
Prayed saying 2 "O YHWH, You are chief
In justice, and all Your works and
All Your ways are mercy at hand

And truth, You're a judge true and just
 For ever. 3 Now mind me *in dust*,
 And look at me, but do not come
 To punish me for my sins' sum
 And ignorance, and those *that stem*
 From my ancestors, those of them
 Who have sinned before You *in lust*.
 4 "For they did not obey Your laws,
 That's why You gave us up like straws,
 And sent into captivity
 To die a proverb and reproach
 To all the lands among whom we
 Are scattered abroad to encroach.
 5 "By Your judgements many and true
 Deal with me for my sins in view
 And of my ancestors who've sinned,
 Because Your laws we've thrown to wind
 Nor acted in truth before You.
 6 "So treat me as You think for best,
 Commanding that my breath divest
 Itself of body that for worth
 I be dissolved and turn to earth,
 For it is better I should die,
 I would not live to hear *with sigh*
 False accusations to my shame.
 Therefore command that I may be
 Delivered from my misery,
 And go into eternal room,
 Turn not Your face back from my doom."

You may think, my Beloved, a silly thing
 Inspires Tobit to such eloquent ring
 Of prayer in exquisite words and in grief,
 You may think that one stolen goat in brief
 Is little matter to the universe
 Where You sit ruling for better or worse.
 But Tobit knew the power of women's
 tongue
 And what the neighbour's like to spout
 from lung.
 He could not face reality of theft
 Piled on the insult of being bereft.
 That's why the grave seems now the better
 choice.
 You've not experienced the bitter voice,
 So do not smile so condescendingly
 Upon the anguish of the man You see.

7 It happened on that very day
 In Ecbatane, a town in sway
 Of Media, that Sarah who
 Was daughter of Raguel due,

Was also chided by the maids
 Of her father *in ambushades*,
 8 Since she had married seven men
 Asmodeus a demon then
 Had killed before they lay with her.
 And they told her, "Does not occur
 To you that you've strangled and choked
 Your husbands? You're never invoked
 By name of any man or fer.
 9 "So why do you beat us for them?
 Since they are dead, go after them,
 We'll never see your son or daughter
 After you *have made such a slaughter*."

Today, Beloved, no court would take
 excuse
 The devil made me commit the abuse.
 Pre-menstrual syndrome could be taken for
 Circumstances mitigating the score.
 There reigns in every town an explanation
 For necessary evil in its ration.
 But tolerance is high that stipulates
 A wife is innocent who's killed seven
 mates.
 Beloved, You come to ravish me by day
 And night desiring to have husband's way,
 The evil spirits of my heart and tongue
 Repulse You to the ladder's lowest rung.
 Divine love suffocates behind the door
 And yet returns again to ravish more.

10 When she heard these things she was
 sad,
 Intending to kill herself bad.
 But she said "I'm the only daughter
 Of my father, *from what he taught her*,
 If I do so, I'll bring reproach
 On him and his old age encroach
 With sorrow to the grave approach."
 11 Then she prayed toward the window and
Turned toward Jerusalem to stand,
 Said "Blessed be You, O YHWH my God,
 And Your holy and glorious prod
 In name is blessed and honoured aye.
 12 "And now, O YHWH, I turn my eye
 And face to You, 13 "and say 'Take me
 From off the earth, that I may be
 No more reproached.' 14 "You know, O
 YHWH,
 I'm innocent in what I do,
 15 "I've never soiled my name, nor name
 Of my father in land of shame,

The only daughter of my dad,
 He has no child as heir, *how sad*,
 Nor near kinfolk nor son alive,
 For whom to save myself to wive,
 My seven husbands now lie dead,
 And why should I live more *to wed*?
 But if You will that I should die,
 Command some honour be had by
 Me and pity taken of me
 To hear no more reproachfully.”
 16 So both their prayers were heard before
 The majesty of great God’s *store*.
 17 And Raphael was sent to heal
 The both of them for goodly weal,
 Remove whiteness of Tobit’s eyes
 And give Sarah bint Raguel wise
 As wife to Tobias the son
 Of Tobit and to bind *when done*
 Asmodeus the demon bad,
 Since she was Tobias’ who had
 Right of inheritance to her.
 The very hour it did occur
 Tobit came home, Sarah daughter
 Of Raguel came from her room *sad*.

Two prayers of desperation come to meet
 Before Your majesty and there they greet.
 Unknowing each the other two hearts beat
 Without a sign yet dare to climb the seat
 Of hope in desperation, the soul’s feat.
 Reality is such a desolation
 Despite the story’s reading consolation
 To let the cat escape the hag and find
 Solution is inherited and blind.
 The plot’s incredible in any case:
 Angel and fate and despair run the race
 With righteousness, and each one keeps the
 pace.
 Beloved, the strands of truth are taut and
 fine:
 Water and vinegar mix with the wine.

Tobit 4

1 On that Tobit minded the rent
 That he’d entrusted once and sent
 To Gabael in Rages town
 Of Media, 2 he sat right down
 Saying “I’ve asked for early death,
 Why not summon *for shibboleth*
 Tobias my son, signify
 To him the thing before I die?”

There is a kind of inspiration that
 Falls on the desperate like paw of cat,
 Silently, without warning on the fear
 And hopelessness that greets the glowing
 tear.

There is an inspiration from Your heart
 That breaks in on the turmoil like a dart
 To bring a ray of memory in trust
 Of golden past shining upon the dust
 Of present painful virtue. Lifting eye,
 Though blind, the man awakens with a cry
 To find the answer to the fervent prayer
 Is spread out before longings everywhere.
 Beloved, Tobit and I bask in the glare.

3 When he had called him, then he said
 “My son, bury me when I’m dead.
 Do not disdain your mother, yet
 Honour her all your life to get
 What delights her and brings no grief.
 4 “Remember, my son, what a sheaf
 Of dangers she went through for you
 In her womb. When she’s dead, then do
 Bury her in my own grave too.

Beloved, this glimmer shining from the
 page
 Of dusty book forgotten for an age
 Rejoices in my heart in heritage,
 Remembrance of commandment and the
 stage
 Of waiting in the mother’s womb for time
 To burst forth in a flood of cheer and
 rhyme.
 Beloved, some still disdain the crumpled
 book
 For what criterion bare as they look,
 But I see the bright letters tell Your name
 To honour mother by commandments’
 claim.
 What hails the Decalogue and makes it
 light
 Is inspiration and the gauge of right.
 Beloved, Tobit speaks of the mother’s
 grace
 And brings my soul to bow before Your
 face.

5”My son, remember YHWH our God
 All your lifetime, do not let prod
 Of your will tempt you then to sin,
 Transgressing His commandments, in

All your life long do righteously
 And do not do things wickedly.
 6 "For if you act truly your works
 Shall prosper after you where lurks
 The sight of those who live godly.
 7 "Give charity of what you own,
 And when you give alms, let be known
 No envy to your eye, nor turn
 Away your face from those who earn
 But pittance, and the face of God
 Shall not be turned from where you plod.
 8 "If you have much, give much in alms,
 If you have little, have no qualms
 To give accordingly in alms.
 9 "So you'll put in the bank in saving
 A treasure for the day of craving.
 10 "For charity saves both from death
 And entrance into darkness breath.
 11 "And alms are but a gift to those
 Who give it before God *who chose*.

The law of alms is writ in clarity
 As Tobit tells his son of charity.
 It cleanses of past sins and sets one free
 To stand before You in Your sought mercy.
 Of those who have much You desire to see
 Much given to the poor, of those with less
 You're satisfied the gift's a slip and guess.
 But each mite given with unselfish heart
 Is treasure bank for rainy day apart.
 Beloved, as human hopes surround their
 lives
 With customs of religion that contrives
 To raise more veils between the soul and
 truth,
 I thank You that for charity and ruth
 All faiths give room in temple, mosque and
 booth.

12 "Beware of whoredom too, my son,
 But marry a descendant won
 Of your fathers, and do not take
 A strange woman not of the wake
 Of father's tribe, for we're offspring
 Of the prophets and such as sing
 Of Noah, Abraham, Isaac
 And Jacob. Therefore be not slack
 To mind, my son, our fathers all
 Married wives of their own kin's call,
 And were blessed in their offspring and
 Their seed shall inherit the land.
 13 "So now, my son, love brothers all,

Disdaining not in heart their call,
 The sons and daughters of your folk
 Not taking wife among their yoke:
 In pride is ruin and much ill,
 In lewdness fault, empty to fill,
 And lewdness the source of the chill
 Of famine, *hunger and death still*.
 14 "The wages of a man you've hired
 To work for you till he is tired
 Pay him forthwith, and so shall God
 Repay your service on the sod.
 Proceed, my son, in all you do
 With good behaviour, keep in view
 Wise action in the impromptu.
 15 "Do to no man except what you
 Would have that man do unto you.
 Do not drink wine to make you drunk,
 Drunk on a journey you'll be sunk.

It's certain, my Beloved, when You sent
 out
 Your own Messiah to go preach about
 The things that You want humankind to do,
 You gave him both the message and the
 shoe.
 He found the message in Tobit's fair
 speech
 To his son, that's why he was quick to
 preach
 Do unto others as you would be told,
 And do not leave the poor out in the cold.
 But he forgot to quote Tobit on wine,
 And that's why You sent out Muhammad
 fine
 To bring this message once again to light.
 Too bad so many say his word's not right.
 Beloved, in boat or car let me be sober
 And not fall down dead before the disrober.

16 "Give your bread to the hungry, and
 Your clothing to whom naked stand,
 And as you're blessed with wealth give
 alms,
 Don't let your eye envy your palms.
 17 "Spend on burying of the just,
 But let the wicked lie in dust.
 18 "Ask the advice of all who're wise,
 And useful counsel don't despise.
 19 "Bless YHWH your God in every time,
 Ask Him to guide the way you climb,
 So all your ways and means for good
 Should succeed in the way they should,

For every nation's policy
Has not its source in YHWH's decree,
But He puts down the one He will,
And so, my son, bear in mind still
Commandments mine, and let them be
Not put out of your mind's degree.

"And now I bear witness to you
That I gave in safe keeping to
Gabael ben Gabrias at
Rages in Media the fat
Of ten talents. 21 "So have no fear,
My son, that poverty appear,
For you have great wealth, if you fear
Alohim and keep from sin's weir,
And do what's pleasing in His ear."

Another thing Messiah failed to read
Perhaps because in his day fatal greed
Plucked at the heart of Sadducean seed,
Was that the righteous dead be buried well.
He had audacity to go and tell
A son to let the dead bury the dead.
Though I trow I understand what he said,
It was not wise to fly in face of Scripture,
See now how many merely give it lipiture
Instead of the obedience of the just.
Beloved, although burial is in dust,
And money put into it surely must
Be money thrown away into the hole,
I humbly bury both body and soul.

Tobit 5

1 Tobias answered saying "Dad,
I'll do all that you told me glad.
2 "But how can I get hand on gold
From a man I've not known of old?"
3 Then he gave him the document
And said to him, "Find a man sent
To go with you, and I'll give him
Pay while I live in gear and trim,
So set out now and get the gold."

A document for money, see how old
The Jewish banking system has been told.
It did not start in Andalus for gold
That could not be borne off by bold.
The easy transfer of wealth came about
When refugees were scattered in the rout.
It's pogroms create banks for weal and
woe,
And wisely the down-trodden steal the
show.

It happened in the days of Tobit's past,
It happened when the Inquisition last
Put out the moneyed without property.
So documents strayed to replace money.
Beloved, see I am cast a refugee.
Give me the cunning of that progeny.

4 But when he went to find a man
He met Raphael as if by plan,
Who was an angel *and not man*.
5 But he did not know that, and so
He said to him, "Now could you go
With me to Rages? Do you know
Those regions well?" 6 The angel said
"I'll go with you, be by me led,
I've found with brother Gabael bed."
7 Tobias said to him, "Then wait
Till I tell my dad at the gate."
8 He told him then, "Go, don't be late."
So he went in and told his dad,
"Behold, I have found me a lad
To go along." But he replied,
"Bring him to me and I'll confide
What tribe he is and if he be
A trusty man for company."
9 So he called him and he came in,
And they greeted each other's *grin*.
10 Tobit said to him, "Brother, tell
Me what tribe, clan of Israel
You are." 11 He answered, "Do you seek
A tribe or family, or speak
Of a hired one to guide your son?"
Then Tobit said to him, "I aim
To know, brother, your kin and name."
He said "I'm Azarias son
Of Ananias the great one
And from your brothers when all's done."

Because I trust no angels, they must lie,
Inventing genealogies too sly
To trip up on the knowledge I have best
Of whom and what and where I may invest.
If I find lies writ in the sacred word,
The explanation's simple as a bird.
It's men in fear and care require the name
Refusing to accept the divine flame.
And then it's men who come after the
claim

Demanding honesty after the fact
Who condemn You no matter how You act.
Historic criticism fits the bill:
The angel tells a lie because the pill

Is too bitter without the sugar fill.

13 Then Tobit said "Brother, welcome.
Do not be angry with me though
I ask to know your tribe and show.
For you're my brother and from good
And honest clan as ever could.
I know both Ananias and
Jonathas sons of one to stand
The great Samaias since we went
Up to Jerusalem and meant
To worship and offer the firsts
And tenths of the produce that bursts,
And they were not deceived by what
Mistakes our brothers had been taught.
My brother, you're of good kin wrought.
14 "But tell me what wages shall I
Give you? A drachm a day supply
Above the board and keep I give
Also to my son *and to live*?
15 "Above that if you come back safe
I'll add to your wages a strafe."

Is it sad or not, my Beloved, to see
Tobit is satisfied that they agree
On some obscure point of theology
Regarding firstfruits and the tithes to be
Brought to the fortress of the Holy See?
Who knows what bitter blow of sect arose
In ancient times to make men tear their
clothes?
But that the man's descended from the lot
Whose opinions conformed to Tobit's
thought
Sufficed to show him trustworthy to take
His son through dangers in the river's
wake.
The man's prepared in ways an angel could
Not be, and yet reality for good
Was hidden from Tobit through his
mistake.

16 So they were happy to agree.
Then he said to Tabias, "See,
Get ready for the trip, and God
Give you safe journey on the sod."
And when his son had packed his things.
His father said "Go on your wings
With this man, and may God who dwells
In heaven give success in spells
To your trip, and His angel keep
You company *waking, asleep.*"

So they set out, both they and the
Young man's dog running at the lee.
17 But Anna his mom wept to see
And said to Tobit, "Why've you sent
Away our son fool's errand bent?
Do we not need him here to be
Our guide and comfort faithfully?"
18 "Don't be so greedy to add wealth
To wealth, but think about the health
Of our son. 19 "For what God has set
For us to live's enough to get."
20 Then Tobit said to her, "Do not
Be worried, my sister, as taught
He will come back safely and you
Will have him once more in your view.
21 "For the good angel at his steps
Will make him fortunate in reps,
And he will come back safe and sound."
And so she stopped her moping round.

The mother's care's consoled by
compliment
That angels also on the road were sent,
And that faith in invisible sufficed
To dry her tears and shed her soul
surpliced.
It's strange the spirit grasps at vision's
sight
And prays for revelation of Your might,
But then trusts more the unseen on the way
Than angels visible by light of day.
What's seen, though miracle, retains the
weight
Of the disdainful and familiar state.
Invisible's a thing of mystery
And keeps in awe all human history.
Behoved, my faith's a faint and pallid shore
Dependent on the senses and no more.

Tobit 6

1 As they travelled on they arrived
In the evening and less contrived
At River Tigris, and stayed there.
2 And when the young man laid him bare
To wash himself, a great fish leapt
Out of the river, would have swept
Him up to eat him *for his share*.
3 The angel told him, "Take the fish."
And the young man grabbed by his wish
The beast and drew it to the land.
4 The angel gave again command,
"Cut the fish open, take the heart,

The liver, and the gall apart.”
5 The young man did by the command.
They roasted the fish on the sand
And ate it, then went on their way
Till they came near Ecbatane.

Fish stories are the plague of revelation,
Doubted in fact because of their sensation.
The truth is that the Tigris hides so few
Such monster fish today from boat and
crew

As first attack Tobias, then he drew
It single-handed to the bank and sliced
Its heart and gall and liver out sufficed
To make the book of Tobit one they knew
To be apocryphal, by which we mean
That it's not true at all from what we've
seen.

No matter how many angels appear
The priests and bishops will not doubt, I
fear.
But let them say the fish was daunting big
And all cry legend is not worth a fig.

6 The young man asked the angel then,
“Brother Azarias, what ken
You of the use of heart and gall
And liver of the fish withal?”

7 And he told him, “As for the heart,
And liver, if a devil start
Or evil spirit come dismay
Anyone, we can drive away
Such with a holy smoke of them
Before the man or woman's hem,
And they will never more be vexed.

8 As for the gall its better use
Is to salve the eyes to produce
Healing from whiteness *in recluse*.”

The Decalogue, Beloved, gives word of life
On how to live long in a world of strife.
But Tobit in his prophecy like knife
Reveals the secrets of how to cure wife
And father of the dangers that are rife
In such a world where ten words and no
more

Do not suffice for happiness and store.
Now that the practice of physician's sore
With pharmaceutical companies' lore,
The wise return to charm and spell and
herb,
Hoping for healing on the frozen curb.

Beloved, I catch the fish and liver out,
Taste oil that gives me hope to gad about
With health and stealth until You knock my
snout.

9 As they approached Rages then said
10 The angel to the young man led,
“Brother, today we'll go to stay
With Raguel, your cousin gay.
He also has an only daughter
Named Sarah. I'll speak that you sought
her

As wife, 11 “for she is yours alone
By the inheritance in stone.

12 “The girl is beautiful and wise,
Now therefore hear me, I'll apprise
Her father and when we return
From Rages wedding we shall earn.
I know Raguel may not wed her
By Moses' law to other fer
Or else the guilt of death incur,
Because rite of inheritance
Belongs to you first not askance.”

13 To the angel the youth replied,
“Brother Azarias, aside
I've heard this girl was married to
Seven men who all died in crew
In marriage chamber. 14 “And now I
Am my father's only son, I
Fear wedding her that I might die
Like those before. A devil dun
Loves her, who attacks everyone
Approaching her. That's why I fear
To take her, lest I die, bring tear
To Mom and Dad because of me
Down to the grave and sorrowfully,
They've no other son to bury.”

15 The angel told him, “Don't you mind
Your father's precept wife to find
From your own kin? So now hear me,
O brother, you'll take her freely,
And do not mind the evil case.
Tonight she'll be yours in her place.

It's news to me that Moses' law appeals
To the death sentence when a father feels
A stranger ought to make a better man
For daughter than any matched cousin can.
The law's interpreted in brief for guile
And for tradition of the neighbour's smile.
I doubt not that chapter and verse are
found,

What I doubt is that I'd believe the round.
The message that is taught depends so
much

On heart and ear and eye as well as touch,
And oracles sung in the flooding words
Of Hebrew make no more sense than the
birds'

Songs till the light of truth shine on the way
Burning by night and sheltering from the
day.

16 "When you come in the marriage room
You'll take the ashes of perfume
And lay upon them heart and liver
Of fish and make smoke from it shiver.

17 "The devil smelling it will flee
Never returning from the spree.
But when you come to her, arise
The both of you in prayerful guise
And call upon Allah Rahman
Rahim and He will save *from dawn*,
Don't be afraid, since she's appointed
To you and from the start anointed.
And you'll keep her and she will go
With you. Moreover as I know
She's like to bear you children too."
Tobias hearing this loved her,
His heart was joined to her demur.
And so they travelled on that day
Till they came to Ecbatane.

The Suura on the dawn may be enough
Now-days to rid a room of spirits tough,
But just in case the evil's still in store
The angel and the fish will give me more.
A little ash of myrrh and heart of fish,
A little of its liver in a dish,
All caught in smoke of lamp and of
perfume
Will frighten off the evil jinn to doom.
And yet I wot not but the single prayer,
Despite quotation to arise somewhere
In later chapters, was one and the same
As the Qur'an reveals in the dawn's claim.
Beloved, I turn to You in light of flame
And trust Your holy word beneath Your
care.

Tobit 7

1 He came to Raguel's house and there
Sarah met them, greeted the pair
And they them, and she brought them in

To the house. 2 And then did begin
Raguel to say to Edna his
Wife, "See how much this young man is
Like my cousin Tobit *in fin*."

3 Then Raguel asked them, "Where then
are

You from, my brothers from afar?"
And they said to him, "We are sons
Of Naphtali captive in runs
Of Nineveh." 4 Then he asked them,
"Do you know Tobit our kin's gem?"

And they said "We know him indeed."
Then he asked "Is his health in weed?"

5 And they said "He's alive *and treed*."
And Tobit said "The man's my dad."

6 Then Raguel jumped up, kissed him glad,
And wept, 7 and blessed him, told the lad,
"Son of a man honest and good."

But when he at last understood
Tobit was blind, his heart was hit
With sorrow and he wept a bit.

8 And so did his wife Edna and
Sarah his daughter at his hand.
But faithfully they gave them cheer,
And after that it would appear

They killed a ram out of the flock
And set meat on the table's dock.
Said then Tobias to Raphael,

"Brother Azarias, speak well
Of what you mentioned on the way,
Let's finish this matter today."

How soon frightened Tobias changes ways
Of thinking about Sarah for her praise!
Faith in the angel's words, no doubt
enough,

Turned to the certainty of sight of stuff.
Truth is six men before had will to take
The risk of demon death for Sarah's sake.
Well is she named as one to tempt both
kings

And captive paupers rising on hope's
wings.

Beloved, the heart of man is filled with
things

Created in Your power above gold,
Removed from fear as well as from things
sold.

The light kindled Tobias' heart and he
Returns with love to mom and dad to see
The generations hope eternally.

9 He transmitted then to Raguel
 And Raguel spoke the matter well
 To Tobias, "Eat, drink and be
 Merry, 10 for to you fittingly
 Belongs my child, but wittingly
 I tell you the truth faithfully.
 11 "I've given my child to seven men
 In marriage, and that night in den
 They each one died, nevertheless
 For the moment enjoy the dress."
 And said Tobias, "I'll not eat
 Another bite until we meet
 Agreeing to swear on the treat."
 12 And said Raguel, "Then take her now
 According to the custom's vow,
 For you're her cousin, she is yours,
 And merciful Alohims pours
 On you good fortune anyhow."
 13 He summoned his daughter Sarah,
 And she came to her father's paw,
 He took her by the hand and gave
 Her to Tobias as wife grave,
 Saying "Take her as due by law
 Of Moses, and lead by the paw
 To your father." And he blessed them.
 14 He called Edna his wife and took
 Paper and wrote as in a book
 And sealed it. 15 They began to eat.
 16 So then Raguel called from her seat
 His wife Edna and said to her,
 "Sister, prepare the room for her,
 And bring her where it will occur."
 17 When she'd done all he told her to,
 She brought her there and wept a few,
 And her daughter shed tears there too.
 But she said to her, 18 "Don't be sad,
 My daughter, but mind to be glad.
 The Lord of heaven and earth shall give
 Joy for the sorrow that you live.
 Take comfort then in what you've had."

What happened to the year of waiting that
 The bride must have before her getting fat
 By Jewish law and custom on the mat?
 He's hardly met the girl and off he goes
 To bed with her to pluck her thorn and
 rose.

The fact is time and place often relent
 To see wherein societies consent.
 The variation Decalogue allows
 Is greater than any church's eyebrows.
 If all have customs greater for their share

Than necessary, all also must share
 The guilt that no faith preserves all the law.
 So let, Beloved, Tobias fill his craw
 And then in joy stick Sarah with his claw.

Tobit 8

1 When they had done eating they brought
 Tobias to her *in his lot*.
 He went minding Raphael's command,
 And took the ashes in his hand
 Of the perfume and put the heart
 And the fish liver on the part
 And made a smoke *upon the sand*.
 3 The evil spirit when he smelled
 Fled out to the Egyptian veldt,
 And there the angel bound and held.

Few men when in the chamber of the fair
 First start out to perfume endangered air.
 Attention is taken up by the form
 And beauty of the lady in the storm
 Of hormones. I think Tobias was wise
 And thoughtful to remember of the guise
 The angel taught him to put on his flies.
 The evil spirit fled to Egypt's bourn
 And held there by the angel was forsworn.
 Beloved, I turn my eyes about this world
 That is a chamber of love and unfurled,
 And before I rest in Your love uncurled,
 I lay heart and liver upon the fire
 And open my perfumes to Your desire.

4 When they were both shut in together
 Tobias rose from the bed's tether
 And said "Now sister, rise and pray,
 That God have pity on our way."
 5 Tobias started out to pray,
 "Blessed be You, our fathers' God and
 Blessed Your holy, glorious name's stand,
 Let the skies bless You and in them
 All creatures. 6 "You have made Adam
 And gave him Eve [life] his wife to help,
 And from them all humankind's whelp
 Have come, then You said 'It's not good
 A man be alone in the wood,
 Let's make an aid just like himself.'
 7 "And now, O Lord, I take no elf
 In lust, but in my righteousness
 This sister of mine, so let be
 That we may reach togetherly
 Our full age." 8 They both said "Amen."
 9 They both slept there that night and then

Raguel rose to dig a den
 In sepulchre, 10 saying lest he
 Be also dead. 11 But when Raguel
 Returned to the house like a fool.
 12 He said to Edna his wife, "Send
 One of the maid servants to bend
 An eye to know if he's alive,
 And if not to bury and strive
 That no one know what we contrive."
 13 So the maid opened up the door,
 And found them both asleep *to snore*.
 14 And she came out and gave the news
 That he still had a living fuse.

I should have gone with dragging feet to
 find
 The locked door and the shutters on the
 blind,
 If I had been a servant-girl in kind
 Who worked for Raguel on the fateful
 morn
 When Asmodeus was first caught and
 shorn.
 I should have knocked at least before the
 tread
 That opened up the honeymooners' bed.
 But she was brave and quietly released
 The lock that had both lovers once policed,
 And found the tangled pair there fast
 asleep.
 I should have done otherwise. Secrets keep.
 Beloved, let no one tiptoe in the room
 Where I lie on Your breast in Your
 perfume
 From now until the fated day of doom.

15 Then praised Raguel God and said
 "O Alohim, You're one instead
 Worthy of praise in purity
 And holiness, therefore let be
 That all Your saints with what You make
 Praise You, and all Your angels wake
 And Your elect praise You for aye.
 16 "May You be praised, and so I try
 Because You've lent me joy withal
 In that it did not come in stall
 What I feared, but You've dealt with us
 According to Your mercy's bus.
 17 "May You be praised because You took
 Mercy on two who had to look
 To be the only children of
 Their parents and both sought in love,

So grant them grace, O Lord and bring
 Their lives to term with health to sing
 In joy and mercy under wing."
 18 So Raguel told his men to fill
 Up the grave he'd dug on the hill.
 19 And he feasted the wedding for
 Fourteen days in all, what is more.
 20 For before the fortnight was done
 Raguel made him swear for fun
 That he should not depart until
 The fortnight of the wedding fill.
 21 Then he should take half of his goods
 And go in safety through the woods
 To his father and have the rest
 When he and wife should bite the breast.

Raguel jumped the gun by digging graves
 For courtiers and refugees and slaves
 Until the habit with his sons-in-law
 Kept him digging with every hand and
 claw.

In that he's like his cousin on the round,
 Tobit who dug graves everywhere they're
 found.

This story's one about digging of holes
 And seeing to the flight of righteous souls.
 Even a wedding has to have a turn
 At delving in the soil for alms that earn.
 Beloved, I dig a futile grave as You
 Create a miracle of life in view.
 Let habits fail, Beloved, and teach my hand
 To take the unexpected in the land.

Tobit 9

1 Tobias called Raphael and said
 To him, 2 "Brother Azarias,
 Take a servant, two camels bred
 With you and go then to Rages
 In Media to Gabael
 And get the gold that I have well,
 And bring him to the wedding feast.
 3 "For Raguel's sworn I shall not leave.
 4 But my dad's counting on his sleeve
 The days that I'm gone and increased.
 If I stay long, he'll be upset."
 5 Raphael went out and there he met
 Gabael and delivered the writ,
 And he brought out bags without slit
 And gave them to him, the whole kit.
 6 And early in the morning they
 Both went up for the wedding day.
 And Tobias blessed his wife's way.

The man was Swiss. I'm sure the man was Swiss.

If he'd been German or Dutch, no, I miss The point. The man was honest and contrived

To save the silver bags for the deprived. God bless Gabael for honesty and store, For fruitful lands and commerce and for more.

I wonder what has happened now to those Descended from far Gabael on his toes.

Geography's not clear in this tale's woes, But somewhere in the land of Kurds there may

Be some Jews left. Or did the troubled way Of Israelite idolatry bear sway, To make them disappear? Have they gone back

After two thousand five hundred years' flack?

Tobit 10

1 Father Tobit counted each day,
And when the time of the trip's sway
Came to an end and they did not
Come back, 2 he *wondered*, said "What plot

Could have detained them? Or maybe Gabael has died and no one's free To give him some of the money?"

3 And he was very much distressed.

4 His wife told him, "You should have guessed

The lad is dead, the long delay Has nothing else that it could say."

Then she began to cry and say

5 "Am I not sad, my child, that I Let you go, delight of my eye?"

6 But Tobit told her, "Stop your crying And do not worry he is dying."

7 And she answered, "Then stop your lying,

My child has perished for such vying."

She went out to the road each day By which they had taken their way,

And she ate nothing by daylight, And never stopped crying by night

For her son Tobias until

The wedding fortnight feast fulfil

Which Raguel had sworn that he Should pass there with them in the spree.

Mark this, Beloved, though mother said she thought

Her son was dead for all the father wrought,

Still she went out to sit beside the road

And bear the brunt of sun, without abode

The clatter of the rain upon her head

To pull about her chador and instead

Wait patiently, or not, with tears and hope

That her son had survived, known how to cope.

Beloved, I fail to see You in the light

Of patterned universe, the city's plight,

And yet I take my seat here day by day

To find in changing seasons a hope's ray.

The silence and the growing and decay

All bring Your image still before my sight.

Then Tobias said to Raguel,

"Send me back, for my dad as well

As mother have lost hope to see

Me ever coming back home free."

8 But his father-in-law told him,

"Stay here and let me send out trim

Messengers to your father and

They'll tell him how things with you stand."

9 Tobias answered, "No, let me

Go back to my father freely."

10 Raguel arising gave to him

His wife Sarah and gear and trim

In half of all his property,

In slaves and cattle and money.

11 After he'd blessed them, sent away

Saying "The God of heaven's sway

Prosper you, my children, before

I die." 12 He also told the score

To his daughter, "Honour the more

Your father-in-law also your

Mother-in-law, they're now your folk.

Let me hear only good things spoke."

So he kissed her. And Edna said

To Tobias, "The Lord instead

Of heaven bring you safely back,

Dear brother, and grant me no slack

To see your children by my own

Daughter Sarah, so I may own

Joy before YHWH. So I entrust

My daughter to you, nothing must

Grieve her, but keep her safe alone."

Some might think that the speeches over
long

Reflect the traditions of making song
And epic, but I witness without wrong
That in those places such speeches today
Often occur to send folk on their way.
Beloved, I praise You, Creator of speech,
For the tongue that You give to each and
each,
In measure to all men and women too
Who have the spell to speak a word to You.
Speech is the proof of Your divinity.
How could a lesser one in deity
Invent such charms and foibles of the key
To human hearts than tongue of destiny?
Beloved, it goes beyond philosophy.

Tobit 11

1 Tobias then went on his way,
Praising Alohim all the day
Because He'd granted fortune to
His journey that he had to do.
And he blessed Raguel and his wife
Edna without both drum and fife.
And so he travelled on his trip
Till he came to Niniveh's hip.
2 Raphael then to Tobias said
"Do you mind, brother, of the bed
In which you left your father drawn?"
3 "Let's go in advance of the dawn
And of your wife and so set right
The house. 4 "And take the fish gall sprite
With you." And so they gathered speed
While the dog followed in his greed.

Hi! Here's a note I did not hope to find!
Tobias did not leave his dog behind,
But when he left both mom and dad to go
Into the dangers of the desert row,
And over mountain passes to the brink
Of life he did not even stop to think
Of leaving home his dog. I say "Good
show!"

A guard dog is a fine one to enjoy,
A sheep dog even better to employ,
And on the hunt a hound is wild with joy,
But here Tobias whistles to the boy,
And brings him home with him to keep the
song
A homely one when howled and lifted
long.
This dervish dog wags tail not to annoy.

5 Anna sat looking down the road
Intently for her son bestowed.
6 When she saw the first glimpse of him,
She said to his father in trim,
"See now your son is coming back,
As well as his companion's track."
7 Said Raphael, "Tobias, I
Know your dad will open his eye.
8 "So you must put this gall upon
His eyes, and when the sting is drawn
He'll massage them and make the white
Coating come off, and he will see
You." 9 Anna then ran out freely
To greet them and she kissed her son
And said to him, "Now it is done
I've seen you once again, so I
May come in peace, lie down to die."
And they both then began to cry.

Anna waits for Tobias as did one
Who waited on a score of years to run
Before he found at last Egyptian son
On the right hand of Pharaoh for a while.
So is the mother's and the father's guile.
They're ready to greet death since life's
fulfilled

In having a glimpse of successful billed.
I too wait by the path, Beloved, for You,
And when I see You all my hopes come
true,
And life is lived to fullness and I find
That death itself can no more make me
blind.

Who touch the joy of vision in the calm
Light of Your presence in both leaf and
psalm
Relinquish every other care and balm.

10 When Tobit moved toward the door
He stumbled to fall on the floor,
But his son came to him 11 and took
Hold of his father, made him look
And poured the gall on his dad's eyes,
Saying "Father, be in joy's pries."
12 And when his eyes began to sting,
He massaged them, 13 and the white thing
Pealed from the corners of his eyes.
14 He saw his son and kissed him and
He cried and said "Blessed are You *grand*
Alohim, and blessed is Your name
For ever, and blessed are all Your

Holy angels score upon score.
15 "Though You have here afflicted me,
You've also on me poured mercy,
My son Tobias here I see."
His son came in with joy and he
Told his father the great news of
How in Media he fell in love.

Tobit has waited eight years of his life
For healing of his eyes because the strife
Of king and hoodlum forced his hand to
work

Against unlawful produce of the dirk.
Tobit waits not believing day shall rise
Bright visible upon his open eyes,
And yet when joy broke in to call his name
His eyes were also opened just the same.
The day that brings turmoil brings more
than one,

The day that brought back home the
missing son
Brought wealth and light and love upon the
plate
More than he could have hoped who had to
wait.

Beloved, I wait on You and find the rod
Is borne and then the sudden, opened pod.

16 Then Tobit set out to encounter
His daughter-in-law to dismount her
At Niniveh's gate and in joy
The praise of Alohim employ.
Those who saw him go down the street
Were then astonished at the feat
Because he saw who came to greet.
17 Tobit gave thanks before them all
That Alohim in bin and stall
Was merciful to him. And then
When Tobit came near Sarah's glen
His daughter-in-law, gladly he
Blessed her, saying "Now daughter, see
That you are welcome. Alohim
Be blessed who has brought you on beam
To us, and blessed your dad and mom."
So there was joy in all the troop
Of brothers in Nineveh's group.
18 Ahikar came, also Nadab
His nephew, 19 and with the confab
They feasted Tobias' wedding
For seven days to dance and sing.

I'd think that seven days would be enough

To satisfy the wildest in the rough,
And yet the week extends to two, just
wathch
The road to elegance and then to potch.
The oriental wedding is a thing
That spreads out on the sands to make a
king

And queen of simple pairs caught in the
ring

Of barley harvest, after that the sleep
Of summer heat for everyone to keep.
Beloved, I see the dancing round about
The oaks where sacrificial goat looks out,
And hear the drum and oboe and the shout
And laughter till the day moves from the
sheep

Toward the glimmer of the starry deep.

Tobit 12

1 And then Tobit summoned his son
Tobias and told him begun,
"My son, look to the pay of him
Who went with you to keep you trim,
And he must also received more."
2 He answered, "Father, as for store
I would not suffer at the door
To give him half that I've brought back.
3 "For he has kept me without slack
And brought me to you safe, and cured
My wife, and the money secured
For me, and also made you well."
4 The old man said "He's earned the spell."
5 He called the angel and told him,
"Take half of all the gear and trim
That you two have brought back and
sound."

The human heart is generous when bound
To find a kindness and sweetness of sound.
The man named Azariah's hardly found
When I go out to get help in my weight.
I look about the yellow-painted gate
To find the one to help me, though I'm late
The help I find is that of robber and
The one to take advantage of my stand.
Beloved, so few are loving in the way,
And yet those few, though far between the
ray

Make all the universe worth weight of gold.
If no man is found among young or old,
You send an angel to be shy or bold
And take the magic slice out of the cold.

6 The angel took the two around
 In private and told them, "Now praise
 Alohim and thank all His ways,
 Exalt Him and give thanks to Him
 Before all living things and grim
 For what He's accomplished for you.
 Good praise is to the Alohim
 To exalt His name the supreme,
 Stating the acts of Alohim.
 Do not be slack to give Him thanks.
 7 "Let kings' secrets stay in their banks,
 But publicize Alohim's acts.
 Do good and evil artefacts
 Will not trip you up in their pacts.
 8 "Prayer's good to follow fasting and
 Almsgiving and the righteous stand.
 A little wealth with righteousness
 Is better than wrongdoing's stress.
 It's better to stay poor with alms
 Than to keep gold upon one's palms.

Raphael the angel speaks a word to show
 The way that humankind should always go.
 Prayer's good and fasting to rebuild the
 clime
 By which almsgiving comes to redeem
 time.
 The pillars of good action thus are stated
 And given to the people as related
 By angel from the sky and from the place
 Where You, Beloved, give orders to the
 race.
 I follow Raphael to find Your throne
 Is fortunate where prayer and sigh and
 groan
 Come before You at hand of angel fair
 Ready to fly in aid and anywhere.
 The true faith shines upon the jewelled stair
 That leads to where You reign and You
 alone.

9 "Almsgiving saves a man from death,
 And it will cleanse from sinful breath.
 Those who do deeds of charity
 And righteousness have full life's fee,
 10 "But those who do acts wickedly
 Are their own living's enemy.
 11 "I'll not conceal a thing from you.
 I've said 'It's good to keep from view
 The secret of the kingly crew,
 But proclaim acts of Alohim.'

12 "And so, when you and Sarah prayed,
 Your daughter-in-law, it would seem,
 I brought remembrance in parade
 Of your prayer before Holy One,
 And when you buried the dead spun,
 I was also beside your gun.
 13 "When you did not stop to eat but
 Got up to lay out the dead shut,
 Your gracious action was laid bare
 Before me, I was with you there.
 14 "So now Alohim sent me out
 To heal you and to bring about
 The curing of your Sarah too,
 Your daughter-in-law now in view.
 15 "I'm Raphael one of the seven
 Holy angels who up in heaven
 Present the prayers of saints and go
 Into the presence of the glow
 Of the Holy One to make show."

The man may think that he's alone for dust
 To see the clinging gateway and the rust
 Where no eye of earthly command intrudes
 To play a game of passion or of feuds.
 But fact is there are eyes about the glen
 That follow all the actions done by men,
 And there are eyes of beast and jinn in fen
 To trip the level learning from their den.
 Beloved, I seek the angel eyes and know
 That with compassion such follow the
 show
 Incredible of human state and row.
 Beloved, I find the angel waiting where
 I least expected long-forgotten stare,
 And bow in fear and faith, and bow in
 prayer.

16 They both in fear fell on their faces
 For they were afraid of such graces.
 17 But he said to them, "Do not be
 Afraid, but you'll abide safely.
 Praise Alohim forever fee.
 18 "For I did not come on my part
 As a favour, but at the start
 Of our God's will. Therefore praise Him
 For ever, and do not grow dim.
 19 "All this time I just came to you
 In appearance and did not eat
 Or drink, but you saw a mere feat.
 20 "And so give thanks to Alohim,
 For I am going up on beam
 To Him who sent me. Write a book

Of everything you saw and took.”

21 So they stood up and looked around
And saw nothing nor heard a sound.
22 Then they confessed the great and grand
Works of Alohim on each hand
And knew the angel of YHWH wrought
Before their eyes the holy plot.

Men fall upon their faces when they see
That angels tread the dark eternity
Where human flickerings are wont to be.
Men fall upon their faces at the sound
Of kings arriving on the feinted ground
To give them honour as they're honour-
bound.

Men fall upon their faces before You,
Beloved, and take off the unholy shoe.
I too fall on my face as is the law
Before You and before Your throne of awe,
And like Tobit and like Tobias rise
To find that nothing's to be seen. My eyes
Though they are blind, I know Your glory
there
Is brighter than my eye's attempt to share.

Tobit 13

1 Then Tobit wrote a prayer of joy,
And said “Blessed is God to employ
Who lives for ever, and blessed be
His kingdom and eternally.
2 “For He afflicts and shows mercy,
He leads down to hell and brings out
Again, and there is no one stout
Escaping from His hand in rout.
3 “Proclaim Him before all the folk,
O sons of Israel, as He spoke
He scattered us among their yoke.
4 “Make known His greatness there and yet
Exalt Him where all living set,
Because He is our Lord and God,
Our Father ever on the sod.
5 “He'll strike us for iniquity,
And then again show His mercy,
And gather us from all the lands
Among whom You have scattered bands.

Indeed, I have been stricken, but the load
Of lust that brought on me your rod and
goad
Was hardly less, since it's created by
The same hand that came down to sordid
spy.

And yet, I find the cudgel followed near
By mercy falling on my failing ear,
And finding at the thrust repentant tear.
The God who strikes in love or anger's veil
Cannot but sharpen love on mercy's tale.
So I make known, Beloved, Your mercy
and
Your greatness here and throughout all the
land,
Exalt You where all living things are set
Because You are Lord and Alohim met.
Beneath the glory proclaimed here I stand.

6 “Turn you to Him with all your heart
And all Your soul, to do your part
Before Him, then He'll turn to you
And will not hide His face from you.
But see what He will do with you,
Give thanks to Him with full voice due.

7 “So I exalt my Alohim,
My soul lifts praises to the beam
Of heaven's King, and raises joy
To His majesty's grand employ.

8 “May every human tongue give Him
Thanks due Him in Jerusalem.

9 “Jerusalem, the holy town,
He will strike you for your deeds down,
Your sons' deeds, but again will show
Your righteous sons His mercy's glow.

10 “Give the praise due to YHWH and
raise

The King of ages up in praise,
His tabernacle may be pitched
For you again and with joy switched.

May He encourage those in you
Who are captives, and love in you
The distressed to all generations
Forever and ever in rations.

11 “Nations in number from afar
Come to the name of YHWH and star
Of Alohim, bringing their gifts
In hand to heaven's King it lifts.

The generations' generations
Give you joyful praise in their stations.

12 “Cursed be all who hate you and blessed
Forever those who love your breast.

I shall not curse the city nor the slum
That rises from the hill Jerusalem.
I've seen the gates and towers, the stony
sod

And wondered that it could be house of
God.

It seems made of the merest dust and sky,
It seems no better than the place I lie.

And yet it is a door that opens wide
To David's psalms and in the mosquely
tide

Reveals a sweetness that abides the gloom
Of bloodshed often seen upon its room.
Jerusalem looks out upon the hills
And finds the laughter that at last instils
The longing for the place of throne and
doom.

Jerusalem is both a crèche and tomb.

13 "Joy and be glad for righteous sons
Gather together in their tons
To praise the righteous YHWH. 14 "How
blessed

Are those who love you! They're addressed
In the joy of your peace and rest.

Blessed are the grief-stricken by all
Your afflictions that still appal,
For they'll rejoice for you to see

All your glory and so gladly
Forever. 15 "Let my soul give praise
To Alohim the King of days.

16 "Jerusalem will be built by
Sapphires and emeralds to vie,
Her walls with precious stones, her towers
And fortresses with pure gold showers.

17 Jerusalem's streets will be paved
With beryl and ruby and saved
With stones of Ophir, 18 "all her lanes
Will cry 'Hallelujah' for gains
Of praise, and say 'Alohim's blessed
Forever who's raised you to rest.'"

I find no sapphires set within the walls
Of old Jerusalem, only in stalls
Of sellers, who despite change of regime
Always find their place in the plot and
scheme.

I find no emeralds with leafy green
Relenting under dusty topaz sheen
Of street and stone, I find no valued place
For gem and gold, but yet I find Your face.
You hold a child and cover with a shawl
Your head from curious glance and under
pall

Hold out a pleading hand for coin or such

That must feed one child and not over
much.

You come so boldly, my Beloved, to spy
Upon a world laid bare beneath the sky.

Tobit 14

1 Here Tobit ended words of praise.

2 Fifty-eight years old in his days
Was he coming to lose his sight,
And after eight years came the light.
He gave alms and held constant fear
Of YHWH Alohim in his ear,
And made his praise to Him appear.

3 When he was old he called his son
And grandsons and told him when done,
"My son, take your sons now and see
I have grown old and suddenly
Shall die. 4 "Go to Media, my
Son, for I truly think it nigh

What Jonah the prophet decreed
About Nineveh on the side,
That it will be destroyed. But in
Media there'll be peace from din.
Our brothers will be scattered wide
In all the world from the good land,
Jerusalem desolate stand.

The house of Alohim will be
Burned and in ruins for a wee.

5 But Alohim will have mercy
On them and bring them back again
Into their land, and then the men
Will rebuild Alohim's house then,
Although it will not be as great
As the one before in its state,
Until the end of time brings fate.
After this they'll come back again
To place of captivity's den,
And build Jerusalem as bright.

And Alohim's house in their sight
Will be rebuilt there in the might
Of glory built in generations
For ever past prophets' narrations.

6 Then all the nations shall too turn
To fear YHWH Alohim and earn
The truth, and bury idols' weight.

7 All the nations will praise YHWH great,
And His folk will give Alohim
Thanks and YHWH exalted to seem
Before His people. Who love YHWH
Alohim in truth and who do
Righteousness will rejoice and show
Mercy to our brothers that go.

The universal trust and faith that shows
 Among the prophets dressed in woollen
 clothes
 Resounds in Tobit's prophecy that those
 Of all nations shall worship You who rose
 From ashes and from broken stones to find
 The rulership the holy cities bind.
 The true faith is not that of kinship's love
 Alone, nor is it found in push and shove,
 But only in the way all men must go
 Within the heart and temple of the slow.
 Beloved, let righteousness abound and be
 Found among all peoples, among the free
 As well as among slaves of wealth and
 power,
 As well as among slaves of place and hour.

8 "So now, my son, leave Nineveh,
 Because of what the prophets say,
 What Jonah prophesied that day.
 9 But keep the law, the commandment,
 Be merciful and just, decent,
 So you may live well in your tent.
 10 "Bury me as is proper and
 Your mother with me by my hand.
 Do not live in Nineveh more.
 See, my son, what Nadab in store
 Did to Ahikar who raised him,
 How from light brought him down to grim
 Darkness, and what he gave to him.
 But Ahikar was saved from him
 Who got avenged as he went down
 Into the darkness of the town.
 Ahikar gave alms and escaped
 The trap of death that Nadab aped
 For him, but Nadab fell into
 The snare and perished in his due.
 11 "So now, my children, give a thought
 To what almsgiving here has wrought
 And how righteous deed saved the lot."

The rise and fall of men is known, and yet
 Few there be who mind and who don't
 forget.
 The rush to fame and fortune at the gold
 Is still the favoured set among the bold.
 Though men arise and fall, the same is true
 Of empires and of cities under dew.
 So Jonah had to prophesy and wait
 Beneath the gourd outside the city gate.
 Despite Your mercy, my Beloved, I see

That every city falls unfaithfully,
 And none is the eternal, no, not Rome
 Nor Athens, nor Jerusalem, nor home
 In Makkah, yet the faith shall still repair
 To find Your face above the empty air.

When he said this he died in bed.
 He was a hundred years *instead*
 And fifty-eight years old, and so
 Tobias made for him a grand
 Burying in the strangers' land.
 And when Anna died he then took
 Her and buried in his dad's nook.
 Then Tobias went with his wife
 And his sons the love of his life
 Back to Ecbatane to find
 Raguel his father-in-law kind.
 13 He grew old with respect and he
 Gave his father-in-law freely
 And mother-in-law burying
 In state and grandeur on the wing.
 He inherited property
 From them and from Tobit his dad.
 14 He died in Ecbatane *free*
 In Media at the great age
 Of one hundred and *yet a stage*,
 Twenty-seven years *on the page*.
 15 Before he died he heard the news
 Of Nineveh's fall in the stews
 Nebuchadnezzar came to make,
 And Ahasuerus to rake.
 Before his death he came to joy
 That Nineveh lay to destroy.

The promise of the Decalogue is great
 That honour to one's parents is in fate
 Long life, and so the lesson of this writ
 For Tobit and Tobias is as fit:
 Who dies over a century is bold
 In having buried mom and dad when cold
 With honour after a long life unsold,
 But given to their praise and to their share.
 Beloved, let my parents meet the same lot
 After a life of honour from my plot,
 And may the blessing that Tobit once got
 For righteousness be covered everywhere
 That moms and dads receive what's right
 and fair.

Judith

Much has been made of the a-historicity of the book of Judith, which is conceived as fiction by many. Others see remnants and reflections of historical situations outside those of “the twelfth year of Nebuchadnezzar’s reign over the Assyrians in Nineveh.” History of course knows of no such convergence of time, place and character, although the book logically follows on the fall of Nineveh mentioned in the preceding Tobit.

What is especially of value, besides the exciting plot, is the affirmation of divine law. For this reason, as well as the fact that the book has historically appealed to canonicity, it deserves its place here.

But as a contemplation of how to meet hostile imperialism, the book of Judith is unsurpassed. The deceitful seduction of the general and the traitorous action of Judith is hardly original and hardly difficult to invent. But in the catalogue of anarchical systems that post-exilic literature represents, there is simply no way it could be excluded. The brave woman who keeps her chastity while cunningly coming to deceive and murder the general contrasts with the degradation of the following story, where Esther gives up her chastity for the opportunity of court intrigue. That too is one of the ways that faith, burning ever so dimly, may meet imperial despotism.

Judith 1

1 When Nebuchadnezzar had reigned
Twelve years over Assyrian
In the great city Nineveh
In days of Arphaxad’s bold sway
Over the Medes, *woman and man*,
In Ecbatane *undisdaigned*,
2 He is the king who built the wall
About Ecbatane, with *tall*
Hewn stones three cubits thick and six
Cubits long, he made, *without tricks*,
The walls seventy cubits high
And fifty cubits wide foreby,
3 At the gates he built towers to
A hundred cubits high *in view*
And sixty cubits wide at base,
4 And he made the gates of the place,
Which measured seventy cubits high
And forty cubits wide *and dry*,

So that his armies could march out
In force and form their ranks about,
5 It was in those days that the King
Nebuchadnezzar found a thing
To make war against Arphaxad
King in the great plain which was had
Upon the borders of Ragae.
6 He was joined by all who held sway
In the hill country and all those
Who lived along Euphrates’ close
And Tigris and the Hydaspes
And in the plain where it may please
That Arioch ruled the Elymaeans.
Many nations joined the Chaldeans.

Despite the fact the names and figures
show

A different view of history on the go,
And what ways people then referred to
kings,

The book of Judith’s filled with many
things

Of use and righteousness, with golden
wings

Of faith and fantasy, of prayers and springs
Inspiring heart and mind always to share
The hope of surviving oppression where
It creeps out in all nations in the glare
Of fast fuel. My Beloved, I read the words
And rally to the charms of lady birds
Out to save independent folk from those
Who globalize the world with words they
chose

To back benignly arms and terms of woes.

7 Then Nebuchadnezzar king of
Assyrians sent to all to shove
Who lived in Persia and to all
Who lived in the west to recall,
Those who lived in Cilicia and
Damascus and Lebanon and
Antilebanon and all who
Lived on the seacoast, 8 and those who
Lived with the nations of Carmel
And Gilead, and in the swell
Of Galilee and the great plain
Of Esdraelon, 9 and all the train
Around Samaria and towns,
And beyond the Jordan, the downs
As far’s Jerusalem and sand
Of Bethany and Chelous and
Kadesh and river of Egypt,

And Tahpanhes and Raamses clipped
 And the whole land of Goshen slipped,
 10 Even to Tanis and Memphis,
 And all who lived in Egypt's bliss
 Down to Cush where its borders miss.
 11 But all who lived in all the land
 Ignored the orders and command
 Of Nebuchadnezzar the king
 Of the Assyrians to string
 Along with him in the war, for
 They were not afraid of him more,
 Considering him only one man,
 And they sent back his men by plan
 With nothing gained but shame to fan.

The way men treat each other's always by
 Perception of the power to wield the sky.
 One man alone's disdained by dun and all
 Who willingly submit to altar call
 And to the yoke of one committee set
 With troves enough of plunder they could
 get.

The mistake was evaluating what
 Power Nebuchadnezzar had in his gut
 As well as in the chance to command men
 To move in his own interests from his den.
 Beloved, I do not calculate Your power,
 I do not trust in rise and fall an hour,
 But set aside both bait and small and trust
 In You alone, although I bite the dust.

12 Then Nebuchadnezzar was wroth
 With this whole land and swore by troth
 Of his throne and kingdom that he
 Would have revenge on the country
 Of Cilicia and Damascus
 And Syria, that he would fuss
 And kill them by the sword, and all
 The dwellers of Moab in stall,
 And Ammon's folk, Judea too,
 And everyone in Egypt's crew,
 As far as the shore of two seas.

13 In the seventeenth year to please
 He brought his armies to attack
 King Arphaxad, and beat him back
 In battle, and conquered the whole
 Army of Arphaxad, and stole
 His cavalry and chariots all.

14 So he took his cities in thrall,
 And came to Ecbatane too,
 Captured its towers, plundered its few
 Markets, turned its beauty to shame.

15 He captured Arphaxad of fame
 In the mountains of Ragae and
 Killed him with hunting spears, and fanned
 Him to destruction to this day.
 16 Then he went back with all his prey
 To Nineveh, he and all his
 Armies together, what a whiz
 Of soldiers, and they rested there
 To celebrate twenty days' fare.

No wonder Nineveh's a name to take
 Unwary by its brazen, wicked stake.
 Jonah the prophet ranted for its sake
 And tried to get You to break oath and
 make

Repentance a thing not replete to save
 The wicked from a deep, untimely grave.
 The critic of the names of cities sits
 Congratulating himself for his wits,
 But does he rise to Nineveh's grand style
 In the repentance of a little while?
 Your mercy now's the product of Your
 plan

And not the function of repentant man.
 Beloved, though repentance seems not to
 give
 A benefit here, I repentant live.

Judith 2

1 In the eighteenth year, on the day
 Twenty-two of the first month's sway,
 They took counsel in the king's house,
 Of Nebuchadnezzar the grouse
 Of the Assyrians about
 His vengeance on the lands throughout,
 Just as he said *in rant and shout*.

There's not a ruler set in times past nor
 In latter days on any clime or shore
 But thinks about his vengeance on the crew
 That questions anything he thinks to do.
 Sooner or late the police rise to help
 The president's and prime minister's
 whelp.

It's in the bone of rulership to take
 Bare vengeance for the living being's sake.
 Beloved, I see the benign case around
 The table where applauses may resound
 For lip-service to justice on the ground,
 But know that neither justice nor the
 thought

Of mercy's anything such folk are taught

While filling purses from the common pot.

2 He called together all his chiefs
And all his nobles in reliefs
Revealing them his secret plan
Spoken in full by his own lips,
All the evil of the land's span,
3 And they decided for their slips
All the rebellious be destroyed.
4 When he'd finished what he'd employed
To show the plan Nebuchadnezzar
King of the Assyrians, geezer
Called Holofernes, army chief
Second only to his own brief,
And said to him for his relief,
5 "So says the great king and the lord
Of the whole world: when you've out
doored,

Take strong men with you to the number
Of one hundred twenty thousand
Infantrymen and not to slumber
Twelve thousand more of cavalry.

6 "Go and attack the whole country
To the west, since they've disobeyed
My orders. 7 "Tell them on parade
To get ready earth, water stayed,
Because I attack in my wrath
And shall cover the whole earth's path
With the tread of my armies' *bath*,
And shall give them to plunder by
My troops as they will thunder by,
8 "Until their wounded shall entrench
Filling their valleys with the stench,
And every stream and river be
Overflowed with the dead like sea,
9 "And I shall take them captive where
The ends of the world are laid bare.

Some think Napoleon invented room
For armies stretching on and on to doom,
But in the past there've been those who
could find
A place for hundred thousands in a bind
To march on villages and cities too
And bury them with all their living crew.
Some think disaster man-made is a thing
Of one era alone in human spring.
And yet there have been places on the earth
Where peace has been given a chance and
birth,
And arms were there as a forgotten art,
When warfare no longer had any part.

Beloved, you give society a choice,
And individual cause to rejoice.

10 "You'll go and take away their lands
For me before their feet and hands.
They will surrender at your view
And you'll keep them for me to screw
Till reckoning day shall incur.
11 "If they refuse, you shall not spare,
But hand them over to the bare
Slaughter and ravage all their share.

Land is the thing that rulers always seek,
Although at times some rulers take a peek
At what it might cost to restore the city,
And refrain then from taking any pity.
So Finland did not take back when she
might
Carelia from the Russian lads in sight,
For fear a penny might be spent in vain
Upon Viborg to someone's wealth and
pain.
But mostly rulers try to take the land,
And offer for resistance plunderers' hand,
And slaughter and the ravage of the coast
That does not kneel before the strong man's
boast,
Or even the weak man who holds the gun
Up to the head of everywhere and one.

12 "For as I live, and by the hand
Of the kingdom under command,
That I have promised so my hand
Will carry out on all the land.
13 "But you, take care not to transgress
Any of your sovereign's address,
But surely fulfil each command
As I have ordered statute and
Do not delay *and do not stand.*"

Just wait and see if the king's captain tells
The conquered ones the orders and the
spells
The king boasts on the people at each
shore.
Just wait and see what words he has in
store
To cover with a pretence of a heart
Of mercy and justice instead of dart.
Who take by force both lands and wealth
refrain

From evil words and wicked sounds for
 gain.
 They have no need to rant to wield the
 sword,
 And sweet words grace the lips of those
 who poured
 The pestilence upon the widow's head
 And met the orphan with a whip outspread.
 Beloved, just wait and hear Holofernes
 Speak honey and great promises to please.

14 So Holofernes went out from
 The face of his master not dumb
 But summoned all the chiefs and all
 The generals' and leaders' pall
 Of the Assyrian army's thrall,
 15 And chose the best troops by their lot
 As his king commanded and taught
 Him to do, one hundred and twenty
 Thousand footmen and with them plenty
 Of cavalry, archers that rode,
 Twelve thousand strong in such a mode,
 16 And he arranged them as a large
 Army to go out, fight, and charge.

The best of men are chosen by the lot
 Who make war on the greenest pleasure
 plot
 And take away the wealth that others tried
 With hand and labour to preserve aside.
 The best of men are needed by the task
 Of killing to make room for those who
 bask,
 The best of men, the best leave poetry,
 And song and dance, and love for infantry,
 And withering of heart and eye to find
 "The captains and the kings" they
 presumed kind
 Had hearts of dust, and haunts filled with
 the dark,
 Had eyes for underfoot instead of lark.
 Beloved, give me back all the best of men,
 The ones with hearth and plough and ink
 and pen.

17 He gathered a great number more
 Of camels, donkeys on the shore,
 And mules for transport, lots of sheep,
 Oxen and goats for board and keep,
 18 And food aplenty for each man,
 And lots of gold and silver van
 From the king's palace to outspan.

How much in cattle lives is spent to go
 Out to meet either friend or newly foe!
 The sheep and cattle, gold and silver flow
 In dark parade until the battle show,
 And then they disappear in throat thrown
 wide
 To catch the wealth of widow and the hide
 Of orphan caught beneath the glowing gun,
 Beneath the grating track of things that
 stun.

Beloved, I see all gathered at the gate
 To serve with muscle, sinew and the rate
 Of skin and wool and flesh, until the eye
 Is glazed and there is nothing left to die.
 The gold and silver stand within the vault,
 Collected and in silence from assault.

19 So he set out with his whole band,
 Led King Nebuchadnezzar and
 To cover the whole surface of
 The world to westward like a glove
 With chariots, horsemen, chosen troops
 Of infantrymen in their groups.
 20 Along with them a mixed crowd went
 Like a swarm of locusts unspent,
 Like the dust of the earth, a crowd
 Not to be counted, *though allowed.*

When armies march and tanks move in
 formation,
 The buzzards always arrive for their ration.
 The hangers on out there to make a buck
 Rush in with every con game in their truck.
 I knew one in the north who thought the
 time
 The US attacked Iraq for the crime
 Of Mr S was just the chance he needed
 To buy a lorry and filled unimpeded
 With junk, to go to Iraq and sell all
 At an inflated price upon the wall.
 He'd lost his brothers to the vapid knife,
 And yet he knew no sacredness of life.
 Nobility's not born in suffering here,
 But by the taking of Your word in ear.

21 They marched for three days from the
 town
 Of Nineveh to the plain down
 By Bectileth, and camped across
 From Bectileth near mountain toss
 That's to the north of higher land

Of Cilicia, all in the band.
 22 From there Holofernes took his
 Whole army, his infantry, his
 Cavalry, and chariots to whiz,
 And went up to the hill country
 23 And ravaged Put and Lud, and see
 He plundered all the folk that be
 In Rassis and the Ishmaelites
 Who lived along the desert plights,
 South of Chelleans' land in sights.
 24 He followed then the Euphrates
 And passed Mesopotamian breeze
 Destroying all hilltop cities
 Along the brook Abron, as far
 As the sea. 25 He with scimitar
 Also grabbed the Cilician land,
 Killed each and all resisting hand,
 And entered in the southern way
 Of Japheth towards Arabia.

It's no new thing the powers that be go out
 To put the Arab Ishmaelite to rout,
 Though famous for the horse and battle cry,
 More often it's the Arab left to die.
 The desert makes a harsh life and a law
 Of loyalty and honour at the claw,
 And whips the breath to strength, and yet
 the man
 Is too good with his honour in the span
 Of what the urban ruler thinks is right
 In slinking to attack in dead of night.
 Beloved, the hopeful villagers, though
 poor,
 Are places where in ignorance Your sure
 Word echoes still on ear and woollen tent.
 I hear it sound and fail at last when spent.

26 He surrounded all Midianites,
 And burned their tents and plundered sites
 Where they kept their sheep for the nights.
 27 Then he went down into the plain
 Of Damascus during the reign
 Of wheat harvest, and burned all their
 Fields and made their flocks and herds bare
 And sacked their cities, ravaged lands
 And put to death all their young hands
 With the mouth of the sword *in bands*.
 28 So fear and terror of him fell
 Upon all the people who dwell
 Along the seacoast, at Sidon
 And Tyre, and those who lived upon
 Sur and Ocina and all who

Lived in Jamnia, and those who
 Lived in Azotus, Ascalon
 Were frightened of his shadow drawn.

O brave war lords! How often is their hand
 Turned not in sparring with the bright
 command
 Of warrior lapping up the praise and power
 Of loyalty and honour on the hour?
 No, no, it's more the brigandry to burn
 A field of hay, of corn, of wheat, to spurn
 The children's cries, the tortured women's
 wail,
 These are the deeds heroic without tale.
 The sheepfold glutted once and set on fire
 In the retelling's a great castle higher
 Than pyramid, and fortified in state.
 The tale is turned in telling by the great.
 Someone, Beloved, just let out in a word
 It was the sheep, not soldiers, who were
 stirred.

Judith 3

1 So they sent messengers to pray
 For peace, and said, 2 "Indeed, we may
 Be slaves of Nebuchadnezzar,
 The great king, see now, here we are
 Lying prostrate before your car.
 Do with us whatever you wish.
 3 Our buildings, every field and dish,
 All our grain fields, our flocks and herds,
 Our sheep pens and our tents here lie
 In front of you, do as you try.
 4 Our towns too and inhabitants
 Are your slaves, come, look not askance,
 But deal with them as best makes sense."

The words of conquered men are always
 thus,
 After the conqueror has made his fuss.
 They give up field and flock with house
 and bin
 And only sue for life and breath to sin.
 The conquered are those who still plough
 the fields
 And turn the wheels of factories for their
 yields,
 And thank the murderer for chance to get
 A penny and a loaf to place a bet.
 Beloved, I turn in scorn to see who shakes
 The polity and investments and makes

The speeches about how things are still
tight
Since workers no longer work day and
night.
The final breach comes like the lightning
found
Out of the summer sky cloudless and
sound.

5 The men came to Holofernes
And told him all these things to please.
6 Then he went down to the seacoast
With his army, stationed the host
In forts in the mountaintop towns,
Took chosen men for their renowns.
7 And these folks and all the land round
Welcomed him with fronds, dancing, sound
Of tambourines. 8 And he tore down
All their temples, cut with a frown
Their sacred groves, since he received
Power to destroy what they believed
As gods of the land, so that all
Nations should worship in one stall
Nebuchadnezzar only, and
All their tongues and kin, and each land
Should call on him as god at hand.
9 Then he came to the border of
Esdraelon, near Dothan, above
The large ridge of Judea, 10 there
He camped between Geba to share
With Scythopolis, and stayed there
A full month to replenish stores
For his army *to count their scores*.

The story gives unlikely plot when it
Pretends the heathen fail to have a fit
That temple and grove are cut down to
make
Way for monotheistic in faith's wake.
The worshippers of one God only stand
Against the monotheistical band.
I somehow doubt the story as it goes,
But be that as it may, I think the foes
Are hardly different from the ones today
Who legislate the faith and the right way.
It's not that I think faith is democratic
Or personal or anything aquatic.
The faith I find is sent for one and all
And imposed by the love of one in stall.

Judith 4

1 Now Israel's folk who lived and dwelt

In Judea heard hearts to melt
Of all that Holofernes did,
That general *and slimy squid*
Nebuchadnezzar who was king
Of the Assyrians on wing
Sent to do to the nations there,
And how he plundered and destroyed
All their temples, 2 they were employed
In great fear at his coming near,
Alarmed both for city for fear
For the temple of YHWH their God.

They were right to fear for the house of
God
And time has shown them right beyond the
prod
Of fear alone. The house has since been
felled
By Hellene and by Roman who compelled
The worship to relate to humanism
Rather than create such a Jewish schism,
Or to relate to Caesar on the wall
For fear some false messiah once grown
tall
Might cause rebellion against lord and state
Ensconced in Italy for the world's fate.
I've been upon the spot, and even prayed
Where the temple of holiness once stayed,
And say that danger still makes fear arise
On marbled earth beneath repentant skies.

3 For they'd just returned to the sod
From their captivity, and all
The people of Judea's stall
Had just come together and brought
The sacred vessels and had got
The altar and the temple lot
Consecrated from their despoiling.
4 So they sent to every place roiling
Samaria, Kona, Beth-horon,
And Belmain, Jericho and more on
To Choba and Aesora and
The valley of Salem, 5 and manned
Immediately all the high hills
And fortified the towns and rills
And stored up provisions for war,
Since their field had been cut before.
6 And Joakim, the high priest, who
Was in Jerusalem in view
Then wrote to the folk of Bethulia
And Teomesthaim not to fool you
Which stands against Esdraelon on

The plain not far from town Dothan,
7 Commanding them to seize the pass
Up into the hills and in mass
Since that's the way Judea could
Be entered by both friend and hood,
And it was easy there to block
The way of those who walked the rock
To come near since the way was narrow
Room enough only for an arrow
And two men at most to go through.

Take note, men of Jerusalem today
That the pass is still prevalent to sway.
The foresight necessary to subsist
In Palestine is meal enough for grist.
Command to seize the pass, the word goes
out
And ought to often more times without
doubt
Since the world still looks to the reigning
king
Of wealth and market rather than the thing
That's right or good or true or even pretty.
The world looks to the ghastly, frozen city,
The frozen heart, the play-act of good sense
And love for all mankind in heathen tents.
Beloved, I turn to You, I have no pass
To guard me from the foes on my morass.

8 The Israelites then did so too
As Joakim the high priest as well
As the assembled Israel
Met in Jerusalem to tell.
9 And every man of Israel
Cried out to Alohim with great
Fervour, and they humbled each mate
With fasting *before empty plate*.
10 They and their wives and their sons too,
Children and cattle and the crew
Of strangers and hired workers too
And boughten slave, they all prepared
Themselves with sackcloth, *since they*
cared.

I've prayed and fasted, largely no avail,
And always thought the fault was I was
pale.
Perhaps the reason my prayers never seem
To make a crack in the gross armour's
beam
Is simply that I have not found sackcloth
Enough to attract any evening moth.

I've prayed and fasted, who's to say if that
Has had any effect on thin or fat.
It may be that my humble dervish prayer
Has saved the world, if even by a hair.
It's not for me to mark the progress made
By heaven on the earthen shore and glade.
It's mine to whirl and in my whirling give
The channel whereby good and just may
live.

11 And all the men and women of
Israel, and their children for love,
Living there in Jerusalem,
Prostrated before temple hem
And put ashes upon their head
And taking their sackcloth they spread
It out before YHWH *each one led*.
12 They even put around the altar
Such sackcloth and cried not to falter
Together praying earnestly
To Alohim of Israel's fee
Not to deliver up as prey
Their wives and children on that day
Nor let be destroyed the towns they
Inherited, nor let sustained
The holy place be once profaned
And desecrated by the joy
Malicious Gentiles might employ.

I've seen the cloth wrapped round the chair
and altar
At Muharrem and other times in halter
Of sorrow, but the cloth was cotton black
Rather than sackcloth wrapped around a
snack.
The Ashurah of some drink brought out
with
The twelve ingredients of hope and myth
Leaves no room for the sackcloth though
the smell
Of walnut and of raison cast their spell.
Beloved, if sackcloth's what You want,
then tell,
And I'll be brave and quick to cut the load
And wrap not only feet but hand and node
With every rough and scratchy theme that
vies
To catch Your countenance as well as eyes.
Beloved, who knows how far this ocean
lies?

13 So YHWH heard their prayers and
looked on

Their affliction, for the folk drawn
To fast there fasted many days
Throughout Judea and the ways
Before the holy place of YHWH
Almighty in Jerusalem.

14 And Joakim the high priest due
And all the priests who stood by hem
Of YHWH and served YHWH, with their
waist

Tied with sackcloth, offered to baste
Continued burnt offerings and vows
And freewill offerings the folk rouse.

15 With ashes on their turbans, they
Cried out to YHWH with all their sway
To look with favour upon all
The house of Israel *in their thrall*.

I have no turban, my Beloved, upon
Which I might scatter ashes in the dawn.
I saw the turban wound when as a child
I visited my granddad's house untiled.
But I was young and failed to learn the turn
Of how to put a turban on the burn.

But perhaps only priest and ruler must
Sprinkle the turban with ashes and dust.
It may be that a dervish dog can pray
By chasing tail around in canine way
And You will hear and shrive the eager
soul

That lifts a head to bay from the scrap
bowl.

If so, I howl and let You do Your own
Actions of intervention from Your throne.

Judith 5

1 When Holofernes, general
Of the Assyrian army stall,
Heard that the folk of Israel
Prepared for war and prepared well
And closed the passes in the hills
And fortified all the high rills
And set up roadblocks on the plains,
2 He was enraged for all their pains.
He called together every princed
Of Moab and the chiefs convinced
Of Ammon, all the overseers
Of regions round among their peers,
3 And asked them, "Tell me, Canaanites,
What folk's this that lives on the heights?
What cities do they inhabit?

How large is their army and fit,
And in what does their power or strength
Lie? Who rules over them as king,
Leading their army? 4 And at length
Why have they done this wicked thing
Alone, of all there in the west,
Refused to meet me as the best?"

Quiet resistance in the hills may draw
Attention from the evil men of law
Usurping Your place on the earth to draw
Wealth to themselves and to the ones who
sit

In power in Washington, New York or fit
In palace of some third world country
where

An elite represents democracy,
The interests of big business of the free.
Almost unheard of to be found in West
That any oppose those who will invest.
Beloved, I take my place upon the hill
And look out on the city fit to bill
And figure I am safe from chief and bank
And yet You only have I here to thank.

5 Then Achior, the chief of all
The Ammonites, answered his call,
"Let my lord now hear from the mouth
Of your servant a word for drouth,
And I shall tell you but the truth
About this people without ruth
Who live upon the mountaintops.
Your servant will not in the flops
Speak falsely to you or the cops.

6 "This folk's descended from Chaldeans.

7 "At one time and before their fleeings
They lived in Mesopotamia,
Because they would not follow awe
Of the gods of their fathers who
Were in their homeland Chaldea.

8 "For they had left the ways of their
Ancestors, and they worshiped fair
The God of heaven, the God they'd come
To know, so that's why they in sum
Drove them out from their gods' presence,
To flee to Mesopotamia,
And lived there long and in good sense.

9 "Their God then commanded them to
Leave the place where they were in crew
And go into the land of Canaan.
There they settled, prospered unwaning,
With lots of gold and silver and

Very much cattle on the land.
 10 "When famine hit Canaan they went
 Down to Egypt and lived there spent
 As long as they had enough food,
 And there became a multitude
 Beyond the counting of the rude.
 11 "So Egypt's king did not like them,
 But enslaved them and set them to
 Making bricks, and humbled them too
 And kept them for a working crew.
 12 "Then they cried out to their God, and
 He persecuted the whole land
 Of Egypt with amazing plagues,
 So the Egyptians to the dregs
 Drove them out of their sight and view.

An Ammonitic view of Israel's story
 Is not far from the true in all it's glory.
 So far he does not mention that his own
 Folk are descended from those he is prone
 To criticize in implication's drone
 That they forsook the gods they once had
 known.

That raises up the question, should a man
 Leave his ancestors' ways and follow plan
 Of other folk? Or should a codger scan
 The sky for truth and take it where he can?
 Truth is if one look back along the line
 Of his descent beneath both palm and pine
 He's sure to find an honest one among
 The lot to teach him truth of heart and
 tongue.

13 "Then Alohim dried up the dew
 Of the Red Sea before them, 14 "and
 He led them by Sinai's hot strand
 And Kadesh-barnea, and drove
 Out all the desert folk that thrive.
 15 So they lived in Amorites' land,
 And destroyed by their mighty hand
 All the inhabitants that stood
 In Heshbon, and crossing for good
 Over the Jordan they took hold
 Of all the hill country and cold.
 16 And they drove out the Canaanites
 Before them and the Perizzites
 And Jebusites and Shechemites
 And all the Gergesites, and stayed
 There a long time where they had strayed.
 17 And as long as they did not sin
 Against their Alohim in bin
 They prospered, for Alohim who

Hates iniquity's with their crew.

The Ammonite that spoke to the king's
 chief
 Spoke truth and spoke it to the world's
 relief.
 The Bible focuses on Israel
 And on her fate before the great and fell,
 But not all follow in the trailing wake
 Of Israel, who sometimes comes to take
 The right and true and sometimes comes to
 bow
 Before the idol of a graven how.
 Some are like Ammon, where through all
 the years
 They follow You, Beloved, in joys and
 tears,
 In witness that Allah is one and all
 Should worship only Him and at His call,
 In witness that You stand to reign above
 All things in sovereignty as well as love.

18 "But when they left the way that He
 Had appointed for their journey,
 They were completely routed in
 Many battles and led away
 As captives to a foreign prey,
 The temple of their God pulled down
 To the ground, and village and town
 Captured by enemies with frown.
 19 "But now they have returned to their
 Alohim, and have come to share
 From the places to which they were
 Scattered, to occupy the hem
 Of their dear old Jerusalem,
 Where their sanctuary is set,
 And have settled the uplands yet,
 Because it was a desert place.
 20 "Now therefore, master of my face,
 If there is any sin unknown
 To this folk against their God shown
 And we find out of their offence,
 Then we shall go up and commence
 To defeat them in house and tents.
 21 "But if there's no transgression there
 In their nation, then let my fair
 Lord pass them by, for their Lord will
 Defend them, and Alohim will
 Protect them, and we'll be in shame
 Before the whole world of acclaim."

The man Achior has the faith to see

That faithfulness to You's an armoury
Not to be penetrated by the loss
Nor broken down by pride of earthly boss.
Even before the chiefs of armies sent
Out to destroy the Middle East there went
Men in witness that You, Beloved, are true,
That You are one obeyed by every crew
That takes the right and just always in
view.

Beloved, I stand by Achior to bear
Witness with and against the great and fair
That Your command is what there is in air
To lead all men into their rightful share.
Bless me and him, Beloved, with hope and
care.

22 When Achior finished saying this,
All the men standing not to miss
Around the tent began to hiss,
Holofernes' officers and
All the men from the seacoast strand
And from Moab wanted to put
The man to death, both head and foot.
23 "For," they said, "we'll not be afraid
Of Israelites, though on parade,
They are a people of no strength
Or will for making war at length.
24 "Therefore let us go up, O lord
Holofernes, and with the sword
Consume them all with your vast horde."

Who witness to You and Your faithful
Word,
Beloved, may never leave princes unstirred,
But also risk their lives when they are
heard.
So bless Ammon then and today and still
In every day when he comes to fulfil
His witness of You and Your sovereignty,
Beloved, God of now and eternity.
Guard, guard, Beloved, the witness of Your
throne
Before the powers that turn to rise and own
The world by grasping and by grading
store.
Open to Your witness the closing door
And bring him in Your safety and Your
room
While those who hear his call rush on to
doom
To disappear within the biding gloom.

Judith 6

1 When the riot made by the men
Outside the council was quelled then
Holofernes the army chief
Of the Assyrians, said in brief
To Achior and all the wights
Of the folk of the Moabites
Before the representatives
Of all the foreigners, he gives:
2 "And who are you, Achior, and you
Paid supporters of Ephraim's crew,
To make predictions among us
As you've done today for a fuss
To tell us not to go in battle
Against Israel's people *like cattle*
Because their God will help them well?
Who is god exalted but *swell*
Nebuchanezzar *keen and snell*?

Gods many there be now as then to see
The battles fought and won or then to be
Epitome of fine catastrophe.
When things go well the winner always
thinks
That God is on his side, while loser slinks
Away humbled with such divine disgrace.
Beloved, the thing's a shame before Your
face.
Truth is that all men stand before Your
throne,
Whether they know or not You're God
alone,
While war tears earth as long as men
prevail
To think that every tribe's god hard and
hale
Commands contingent out against the
other,
As though all men had not come from one
mother.
With one God only all warfare would fail.

3 "He'll send his hosts and destroy them
From off the face of the earth's hem,
And their Alohims will not save
Them, but we'll send them to their grave
As one man, we the king's servants.
They cannot bear the swift advance
Of our horsemen, *without a chance*.
4 "We'll burn them up and their hills shall
Be drunk with their blood *prodigal*,
And their fields filled up with their dead.

They cannot withstand us, instead
They'll fail completely *from the bed*.
So says King Nebuchadnezzar,
The lord of the whole world *and star*.
Since he has spoken, what he speaks
Will not fall vainly *on their cheeks*.

5 "But you, Achior, you Ammonite
Paid servant, who have said *in spite*
These words on the day of your ill,
You will not see my face *or gill*
Again from this time and until
I take vengeance on this folk come
Out of Egypt *and full of rum*.

6 "Then my army's sword and the spear
Of my servants will pierce you clear,
And you shall fall among the stricken,
When I return *to see plot thicken*.

7 "Now my servant will take you back
Into the hills and set you slack
In one of the cities beside
The mountain passes *where they hide*,

8 "And you will not die till the day
You perish with them in their way.

9 "If you think truly in your heart
That they will not fall for their part,
Then don't look sad! I've said my piece,
And none of my words fail *or cease*."

The error of Achior was trying to
Save the army of the established view
By giving sound advice. Few men have
learned

That giving sound advice when it's not
earned

Or asked for is the straightest way to hell.
Experience calls, let it ring its bell.

I take myself a smarter lad when I
Refrain from telling kings the what and
why.

Let every sovereign make his own mistakes
And rub horse liniment on all his aches.

Beloved, I see that even You know better
Than to speak to the human and go-getter.
You learned on Sinai that no heart seeks
what

You have to say in public, only shut.

10 So commanded Holofernes
His servants who waited at ease
On him in his tent then to seize
Achior and take him out to
Bethulia and hand to the crew

Of Israel. 11 So the slaves took
Him and led him out of the nook
Into the plain and from the plain
Then went up in the mountain *chain*
And arrived at the springs below
The town of Bethulia to show.

12 When the townsmen saw them, they
took

Their weapons from town to the look-
Out on the hill, and all the slingers
Kept them from coming up *as stringers*
By throwing stones at them *to brook*.

13 But when they came to shelter in
The hillside, they tied Achior shin
And arm and left him lying there
At the foot of the hillside *bare*,
And went back to their master's share.

Amazement for the lot of Achior
Confines me to my own plot and my store.
I should have thought that they would smite
the bloke

And kill him at the tentdoor at a stroke.
Instead they tie him hand and foot and set
Him at the side of enemy well met.
No doubt they thought a day or two would
show

Them in their power again for heel and
woe,
And one day of reprieve would only slow
The enemy by taking water and
More food for his refuge upon the land.
Beloved, the wranglings of Your crews of
men

Amuse me more than anything again
I see in nature's grasp and greed and fen.

14 Then the men of Israel came down
From their city and found him *brown*
And they untied him and brought back
Into Bethulia *to the rack*

Before the rulers of the town,
15 Who at the time were Uzziah
The son and pride of one Micah
Of the tribe of Simeon, and
Chabris Gothoniël's son and hand,
And Charmis son of Melchiel.

16 They summoned all the old and fell
Men of the city and as well
All their young men and women too
Ran to the assembly in crew
And they set Achior to stand there

In midst of all the people fair,
 And Uzziah had him relate
 What had happened to him in fate.
 17 He answered in reply and told
 Them what happened in council *bold*
 With Holofernes, and all he
 Had said before the assembly
 Of the Assyrian leaders and
 Everything that came from the hand
 Of Holofernes in his boast
 Against the house of Israel's host.
 18 And the folk fell prostrate and prayed
 To Alohim in worship stayed
 And cried aloud to Him and said
 19 "O YHWH Alohim of the skies,
 See now their pride and realize
 Pity on the abasement of
 Our people and look now in love
 This day upon the faces of
 Those who are set apart for You."
 20 And they comforted Achior too
 And praised him greatly *as his due*.
 21 And Uzziah took him away
 From the assembly and to stay
 At his own house and gave a feast
 For the elders, all night *at least*
 They call on Israel's Alohim
 For help *before the things that seem*.

Along the ways that I have trod in glory
 Coming in and out of each folly's story,
 Has anything like Achior's comfort come
 Into my heart to warm and burn like rum?
 Only the one who's travelled place to place
 Remembers hospitality in race
 Secure but foreign to one's childhood farm,
 Comforted for the fear of any harm.
 Only the one who's given a false alarm
 Meant for the saving of ungrateful men
 Forgets to raise a tear for home again
 Out where the common rangers bet their
 due.

Remember me, Beloved, and comfort me
 That I have spoken of You so freely.

Judith 7

1 The next day Holofernes had
 His whole army and allies bad
 Joined with him set out to attack
 Bethulia and to seize the track
 Into the mountain lands and wage
 War on the Israelites a stage.

2 So all their soldiers struck their tents
 That day and their entire presence
 Was one hundred and seventy
 Thousand of men in infantry
 And twelve thousand in cavalry,
 Together with the baggage and
 The foot soldiers of its command,
 A very great crowd in the band.
 3 They settled in the valley near
 Bethulia with all their gear
 Beside the spring and they spread out
 As far as Dothan on the route
 To Balnaim and as well in length
 From Bethulia to Cyamon's strength
 Across the way from Esdraelon.
 4 And when the Israelites saw their
 Great numbers they fell under share
 Of terror and each one then said
 To his neighbour, "These men now *bred*
 Will consume the face of the land,
 And neither high mountains in stand
 Nor valleys nor the hills' command
 Will bear their weight *of foot and hand*."
 5 Then every man took up in hand
 His weapons and they kindled fires
 On their towers and they stayed in hires
 To watch all that night and in band.
 6 The second day Holofernes
 Led out all in his cavalries
 For all the Israelites in awe
 To see in front of Bethulia.
 7 He checked the ways into the town,
 And visited the springs' renown
 That gave them water and took these
 And set guards of soldiers at ease
 Over them, returned in armies.

The evil men who would parade on earth
 As rulers and guides for the human girth
 Always make sure of water first of all,
 And guard the springs from other human
 call.

This is the law of jungle: see the set
 Of beast of prey about waterhole met
 To catch the thirsty crew that comes to
 drink.

Holofernes is dumber than you'd think.
 He's just a beast of prey in instinct's thrall.
 The same is true of many at the call
 Of fashion and of honour that presumes
 To be the rate of art, and yet consumes

The hope and sustenance of those who
starred
In every playground of the free unbarred.

8 Then all the chiefs of Esau's folk
And leaders of Moabites' yoke
And captains of surrounding lands
Came to him saying in their bands,
9 "Let our lord hear a word from us,
So your hosts be victorious.
10 "For these folk of Israel do not
Rely upon their spears when taught,
But on the height of hills where they
Live where it's not easy in sway
To reach the tops. 11 "Therefore, my lord,
Do not fight against them in sword
Arrayed, and not a single man
Of your army will fall in scan.
12 "Stay in your tents and keep your men
All in your bands with you again,
Just let your servants take in hand
The spring of water from the stand
Of the mountain that flows in land.
13 "For this is where all the folk of
Bethulia get water above.
So thirst will destroy them and they
Will surrender their town away.
We and our folk will go up to
The tops of the nearby in view
And stay there to keep watch so none
Of them gets out of town for fun.
14 "They and their wives and every son
Will be consumed by famine's run
And before any sword comes by
They will be scattered round and lie
Dead in the streets of their own sty.
15 "So you'll avenge them of the ill
Because they rebelled on the hill
And did not receive you with bill."

Though I'm surrounded by the many who
Keep church and steeple and the filling pew
Out of my reach, and think to drink me dry
And wait for famine to come make me die,
I have a secret spring unknown to all
Who wait upon the painted parish hall.
I find the living waters in the Word
Once spoken on Sinai, and in the bird
That once flitted upon Jesus to turn
The stones to bread and make the desert
burn
A paradise far from the temple spire.

I have a secret garden of desire
For four rivers come from one head to
make
My life refreshed despite the heavy stake.

16 These words were pleasant to the man
Holofernes and so by plan
Of all his servants he gave out
Command as they had told about.
17 And the army of Ammonites
Moved forward together in sights
With five thousand Assyrians,
And they tented in valley bans
And captured the water supplies
And the springs of Israelite guys.
18 The bairns of Esau and the bairns
Of Ammon went up to the cairns
And stayed on the hills opposite
Dothan, and sent of their men *fit*
Toward the south and toward the east
Toward Acraba, which is *increased*
Near Chusi there beside the brook
Mochmur, *just go and take a look*.
The rest of the Assyrian host
Tented in the plain for a boast
On the whole surface of the land,
And their tents' supplies caravanned
Spread out in great number, and they
Were a great crowd along the way.
19 The folk of Israel cried to YHWH
Their Alohim, for what to do,
Their courage failed, because all their
Enemies surrounded them there
Without a way of escape fair.
20 The whole Assyrian army, their
Foot soldiers, chariots, cavalry,
Set all about them for thirty
Four days, until the storage pots
Of water in the dwelling plots
Of each inhabitant in town
Of Bethulia were empty brown.

I look out on the brown democracy
That fills the free world with hypocrisy
Where heads are counted instead of the
brain
That lies within the head, instead of will
To follow You, Beloved, upon the hill
And on the fertile, budding, blooming
plain.
I look upon the gathered army where
The Middle East is harboured for the fair,

And say that You should send another one
Named Judith and then see the battle done.
Beloved, my heart is stolen from the first
By Judith who looks out upon the cursed,
And in the memory of buried love,
Goes out a hawk though dressed as humble
dove.

21 Their cisterns too were going dry,
And they did not put water by
To quench their thirst a single day,
Because they rationed it to stay.
22 Their children were discouraged and
The women and young men at hand
Fainted from thirst and so fell down
In the streets of the very town,
And in the passage through the gate,
There was no power to dislocate.
23 Then all the people, the young men,
The women, and children again,
Gathered about Uziah and
The rulers of the city and
Cried out with a loud voice, and said
Before all the elders instead,
24 "Alohim be judge between you
And us! For you have done our crew
A great wrong in not making peace
With the Assyrians' increase.
25 "For now we have no one to help
Us, Alohim has sold our whelp
Into their power, to scatter us
On the soil before them to truss
With thirst and death of omnibus.
26 "So summon them and let's surrender
The whole city now to the bender
Army of Holofernes and
To all his soldier plunder band.
27 "For it would be better for us
To be captured by them, for us
To be slaves, but our lives be spared,
And we shall not see the death bared
Upon our babes before our eyes,
Or see our wives and children take
Their last breath of life at this stake.
28 "We call to witness against you
The heaven and earth and our God, YHWH
Of our fathers, who punishes
According to our sins, that is,
The sins of our fathers. Let Him
Not do today all these things grim."

It is no small thing to see children die

Of thirst because the armies come to vie,
But that is what I see from day to day
As my mind's eye looks out upon the prey
To southward from the seat of ice and snow
Upon the shores and forests that I know.
In all the centuries that come and go,
It seems the mills of history are slow
To change for better or for worse below,
But the same evil threat of progeny
Of Babylon walks about the earth free.
Beloved, if giving cup of water is
Enough in judgement to raise up a fizz,
I see the wisdom in that good decree.

29 Then there arose great lamentation
Throughout the entire congregation,
They cried out to YHWH Alohim
With a loud voice for things that seem.
30 And Uziah said to them, "Take
Courage, my brothers! Let us make
Firm for five more days, by that time
YHWH our Alohim and sublime
Will turn in mercy once again,
Not to forsake us to these men.
31 "But if these days pass by, and no
Help arrives to save the last show,
I'll do what you say on the go."
32 Then he sent all the people back
To their guard-post, they were not slack
To go upon the walls and towers
Of their city to spend their hours.
He sent home the women and kids.
And they grieved for the town on skids.

Five days are hardly time to make a dent
In the great silent halls that here prevent
Hope that a miracle might change the row.
Fact is Your intervention is so slow
And non-existent is why we below
Say miracle. A miracle's a thing
That drops in unexpected on the wing
Of phoenix. Faced with undepleted thirst
We either find some water or die cursed.
The one who says five days at the rope's
end
Is hopeless. Hopelessness now to defend
Is easier than anything in course.
Hopelessness is the freedom from perforce,
Exhilarating beneath stars that wend.

Judith 8

1 Then Judith heard about these things.

She was the daughter, not of kings,
 But Merari the son of Ox,
 The son of Joseph, of such stocks
 As son of Oziel, the son
 Of Eliah, who was the son
 Of Ananias, Gideon,
 The son of Raphaim, the son
 Of Ahitub, Elijah's son,
 The son of Hilkiah, the son
 Of Eliab, Nathanael's son,
 Who was the son of Salamiel,
 Sarasadai's son *for a spell*
 The very son of Israel.

2 Her husband Manasseh belonged
 To her tribe and family *unwronged*,
 Had died in barley harvest *past*.

3 For as he stood in oversight
 Of the men binding sheaves in *light*
 Of the field, he was overcome
 By scorching heat's *opprobrium*,
 And went to bed and there he died
 In Bethulia where he'd reside.
 They buried him in his dad's room
 In the field between Dothan's *tomb*
 And Balamon *in heavy gloom*.

4 Judith remained home as a widow
 For three years and four months *now kiddo*.

5 She pitched her a tent on the roof
 Of her house, put on sackcloth proof
 Around her waist and clad in weeds
 Of widowhood did her good deeds.

6 She fasted all her sorrowed days,
 Except the day before the praise
 Of Sabbath and Sabbath itself,
 The day before the month's first day,
 And on the month's first day itself,
 And on the feasts, days of rejoicing
 Of the house of Israel invoicing.

7 She was fair in appearance, and
 Had a fine figure of face, and
 Her husband Manasseh had left
 Her gold and silver, unbereft
 Of men and women slaves, and cattle,
 And fields, estate enough to rattle.

8 No one spoke ill of her, for she
 Feared Alohim, a devotee.

I see, Beloved, that in those olden times
 There were not conflicts between golden
 rimes,
 And Friday was a day of celebration
 Preparing for the lovely exaltation

Of Sabbath. Now the Jews retire alone
 Into the Sabbath and the Muslims drone
 On Friday and forget the Sabbath day,
 Despite the many words and lovely way
 The Sabbath is brought out in the Qur'an.
 Beloved, I make no false distinctions drawn
 Between one prophet and another here,
 But follow all of them in love and fear,
 From Moses to Muhammad with a tear,
 Refusing to be any bishop's pawn.

9 When Judith heard the wicked things
 Spoken by the folk's sorrowings
 Against the ruler, being faint
 For lack of water as complaint,
 And when she heard of everything
 Uzziah said about the king
 And how he promised under oath
 To surrender the town though loath
 To the Assyrians in five
 Days, 10 then she sent her maid *alive*,
 Who was in charge of all she owned,
 To call Chabris and Charmis *toned*
 With all the elders of her zoned.

11 They came to her, she said to them,
 "Listen to me, rulers of gem
 Folk of Bethulia! What you

Have promised the people in view
 Today is not right, you have sworn
 Pronouncing oath between the born
 And Alohim to give the town
 To enemies unless YHWH's *crown*
 Turns to our part in aid within
 So many days, this is a sin.

12 "Who are you to put Alohim
 To the test on this day and deem
 To set yourselves up in God's place
 Among the sons of human race?

13 "You tempt YHWH the Almighty, yet
 You know nothing *of how to get*.

14 "You know not depths of human heart
 To find out what is thinking art,
 How then do you expect to find
 Out Alohim who made in kind
 All things and search His depth of mind
 Or understand His thought divined?
 Nay brothers, do not provoke YHWH
 Our Alohim to anger's view.

Perhaps the time element comes to stand
 In for the fact that this lady's command
 Of reason speaks to my reason as well.

But then I fail to follow in the swell
 The logic of dear brother Paul, so time
 Cannot be relevant to mental clime.
 In any case, this Judith says a word
 That's wiser than the latest conference bird.
 If human hearts are too deep to be sounded,
 Than what can be said of Allah that's
 grounded?

Beloved, I hold my tongue, fail to present
 The accusations against You I meant
 In act of God and in the questioning
 Of why coffee and oil are such a spring.

15 "For if he does not choose to aid
 Us within these five days *you've paid*,
 Yet He has might to keep us in
 The time He pleases *without sin*,
 Or even to destroy us in
 The presence of our foes *for sin*.

16 "Don't force the hand of YHWH our
 God,

For Alohim is not a clod
 Like humankind, to answer threat,
 Nor like a human being yet,
 To be moved by cajoling rod.

17 "So while we wait His salvation,
 Let us call on His aid to run,
 And He will hear our voice, if it
 Pleases Him and He shall see fit.

18 "For never in our generation,
 Nor in these present days of ration,
 Has there been any tribe or clan
 Or folk or city in our scan
 Who worshiped gods made with hands sly,
 As was done in the days gone by,

19 "And that was why our fathers fell
 Beneath the sword, plundered as well,
 And suffered great catastrophe
 Before our foe and enemy.

20 "But we worship no other god
 But Him, and so our hope in pod
 Is that He'll not disdain our station
 Or any of us in our nation.

21 "For if we are destroyed then all
 Judea too will also fall,
 Our sanctuary plundered, and
 He will require it of our hand
 In punishment for desecration.

I worship You, Beloved, and I ignore
 The other gods that crowd upon the shore
 Of science and democracy and more

Of business and of everlasting war.
 I worship You, Beloved, do what You will
 To widow and to infant on the hill
 Of poverty created by the choice
 Of business lobby out to make rejoice
 Investor in both stocks and bonds and land,
 In precious metals and wheat out of hand.
 Beloved, I worship You and still I find
 No dearth of treasure in infinite mind,
 Nor need to seek another of Your kind,
 In You is satisfied a roving band.

22 "The slaughter of our brothers and
 The captivity of the land
 And desolation of our plot,
 All this He'll bring upon our lot
 Among the Gentiles, where we serve
 As slaves, and we shall never swerve
 From being an offence and more
 Reproach in eyes of conqueror.

23 "Our slavery will not bring us weight
 Of favour, but YHWH our God late
 Will turn it to dishonour's state.

24 "Now therefore, brothers, let us set
 Example to our brothers yet,
 For their lives depend on us, and
 The sanctuary and the stand
 Of temple and the altar rest
 Upon us. 25 "Despite us oppressed
 Let us give thanks to YHWH our God,
 Who tests us as He did with rod
 Our ancestors upon the sod.

26 "Mind how He tested Abraham,
 And how he tested Isaac's ram,
 And what happened to Jacob in
 Mesopotamia and in
 Syria, while he kept the sheep
 Of Laban, his mom's brother's keep.

27 "For He has not tried us with fire,
 As he did them, to search desire
 Of their hearts, nor taken revenge
 On us, but YHWH *as in Stonehenge*
 Scourges those who draw near to Him,
 In order to admonish them."

I am tried true, but yet without the fire
 That tried the generations in the pyre
 Before my days, I am tried with the froth
 Of culture and the civilized in wrath.
 I am tried too, Beloved, but take a hold
 Upon the promises of Judith bold,
 And lift a prayer of praise, a Psalm of old,

And touch the lyre-strings of my heart
grown cold
With songs to raise a melody of gold.
Beloved, I take the scourge that You have
shown
In love beneath the false usurping throne
Of earthly fire and wait You to the bone
When toil of pride shall give way to the
stone
Upon which shines the Decalogue alone.

28 Then Uzziah said to her, "All
That you say's spoken from the pall
Of a true heart, and there is none
Who can deny your words begun.
29 "Today is not the first time your
Wisdom has come upon the shore,
But from the start of life all folk
Have recognized your wisdom's stroke,
For your heart's disposition's right.
30 But the folk were thirsty last night,
And they forced us to do for them
What we've promised in stratagem,
And made swear what cannot be broken.
31 So pray for us, since you're a token
Of righteousness, and YHWH will send
Us rain to fill our cisterns' end
And we will no longer be faint."
32 Judith said to them, "Don't be quaint,
Listen to me. I am about
To do a thing which will no doubt
Go down through generations of
Our descendants for faith and love.
33 "Stand at the city gate tonight,
And I will go with my maid slight,
And within the days after which
You've promised to surrender stitch
To our enemies, YHWH remand
All Israel safely in my hand.
34 "Only, do not try to find out
What I plan, I'll not tell about
It till I've finished what I do."
35 Uzziah and the rulers too
Said to her, "Go in peace, and may
YHWH Alohim give you the sway
To take revenge upon our foes."
36 So they returned from the tent rows
And went to their posts right away.

When evil promises are made by those
Who rule the masses of the ones who
chose,

Then prayer is not enough to tide the woes.
It takes a plan and courage on the toes
To counter evil set by ruler and
The hungry and the thirsty in the land.
Beloved, I pray indeed to little scope,
And with my prayer hold up but little hope,
Because the curse is set in fatal oath,
And all the world is turned against us both.
I drown my soul in You, Beloved, and find
The hidden heart within of all mankind,
And raise a wail to wind and wolf and tree
That You alone rule all eternity.

Judith 9

1 Then Judith fell upon her face,
And put ashes on her head's place,
Uncovered the sackcloth she wore,
And as the evening incense bore
Its offering in Alohim's house
In Jerusalem, so the spouse
Judith cried out to YHWH aloud
And said, 2 "O Lord Alohim proud
Of my father Simeon, to
Whom You gave a sword to take true
Revenge on the strangers who'd let
Loose the belt of a virgin to
Defile her, and uncovered yet
Her thigh to put her to shame, and
Polluted her womb with the hand
Of disgrace, for You said, 'It shall
Not be done,' yet they prodigal
Did so. 3 "So You gave up their rulers
To be slain, and their bed, those foolers,
Which was ashamed of the deceit
They had practiced in their retreat,
To be stained with blood, and You struck
Down slaves with princes to the muck,
And princes on their thrones with luck,
4 "And You gave their wives for a prey
And daughters to the captive's way,
And all their booty to divide
Among your beloved sons beside,
Who were zealous for You, abhorred
Pollution of their blood, and stored
Their call for help in You, O Lord
Alohim my God, hear me too,
A widow. 5 "For You've brought to view
These things and those that stood before
And those that followed by the score,
And You've planned the things that rise
now
And those that are to come somehow.

What You intended came to pass,
 6 "And what You did rose in the glass
 And said 'See we are here,' and all
 Ways in advance stand in the stall,
 And Your judgement knows every call.
 7 "See now, Assyrians have increased
 Their strength, exalted, and released
 Their horses and riders and they
 Are proud in the strength to the fray
 Of infantry, they trust in shield
 And spear, in bow and sling they wield,
 And do not know that You are YHWH
 That puts down battles from Your view,
 YHWH is Your name. 8 "Now break their
 arm

By Your might and bring down to harm
 Their power in Your wrath, for they
 Think to defile Your holy way,
 Polluting tabernacle's sway
 Where rests Your glorious name, and throw
 Down the horns of your altar glow
 With the sword. 9 "So regard their pride,
 And send Your wrath on them beside,
 And give to me, a widow, strength
 To do what I must do at length.

10 "By the deceit of my lips strike
 Down the slave with the prince just like
 The prince with his servant and crush
 Their arrogance by the hand hush
 Of a woman. 11 "For Your strength stands
 Not upon numbers, nor Your hands
 Upon strong men decked out in bands,
 For You are Alohims to those
 Who are lowly in humble pose,
 Helper of the oppressed, You seek
 To be upholder of the weak,
 Protector of forlorn, to save
 Those without hope up to the grave.
 12 "Hear, O hear me, Alohims of
 My father, Alohims above
 Of Israel's heritage, and Lord
 Of heaven and earth and the adored
 Creator of the waters, King
 Of all Your creation, on wing
 Hear my prayer! 13 "Make deceitful word
 From me be their wounding occurred
 And stripe, for they have planned such
 things

In cruelty against the springs
 If Your treaty and pact, and more
 Against Your consecrated door,
 And against fortress pinnacle,

Against Your children's house to pull.
 14 "So make Your nation all to know,
 And every tribe such wisdom show,
 That You are Alohims, the God
 Of all strength and might on the sod,
 And there is none to help or hold
 The folk of Israel but You told."

May Judith not be too hard on You yet,
 Beloved, in stating all the times that set
 Your people to the trouble of the earth,
 Sometimes perhaps to testify their worth.
 May Judith not cry too loud of the ways
 That You have set the people up to praise
 You for deliverance after the scare
 Of every kind of trouble and of snare.
 Though Judith does remind You times are
 bad,

And that You are the hope that Israel had,
 She is herself the one to rise and do
 And in her doing vindicate You too.
 Beloved, the portrait of Holofernes
 Fames Judith and bring government to
 knees.

Judith 10

1 When Judith had stopped praying to
 Israel's Alohims, ended stew
 Of all these words, 2 she got up too
 From where she was prostrated and
 Called her maid and went to the house
 Where she lived on Sabbaths to grouse
 And on her feast days, 3 there took off
 The sackcloth she was wont to doff,
 Her widow's weeds, took water bath
 Put on perfume and took her path
 Combing her hair, with crown in place,
 Clothed in her best robes that the face
 Of her husband Manasseh saw
 When he was living hand to crawl.
 4 She put her sandals on her feet,
 And put on anklets, bracelets meet
 And rings and earrings, all her stuff,
 Beautiful and no more in rough,
 To seduce eyes of every man
 Who might see her out on her plan.
 5 She gave her maid a bottle of
 Grape juice, a flask of oil in glove,
 And filled a bag with parched corn and
 A lump of dried fruit and in hand
 A good loaf of bread, and she wrapped
 Up all her packages well flapped

And gave them to her maid to carry.
6 Then they went out to the gate wary
Of Bethulia and found Uzziah
Standing there with the elders nigher
From the city Chabris as well
As Charmis men of Israel.

7 When they saw her and noticed how
Her face was changed, clothing for now,
They thought that she was beautiful
And said to her, 8 “May the ample
God of our fathers grant you grace
To fulfil your place that the race
Of Israel may honour Him,
Jerusalem be great, not grim.”
And she bowed down prostrating to
The Alohims *who’s name is YHWH*.

What a happy way to make Sabbath good!
Judith lives in sorrow of widowhood,
But when the preparation day has come
She goes into her palace rooms to hum
And rest the Sabbath in sweet delights
there.

Her fasting and her wakened nights of
prayer
Turn to the sweet communion of the day
Twice blessed with angels on the holy way.
Beloved, I too enter on Sabbath here
The palaces of heaven to find my gear
Illuminated with celestial light,
And everything turned from the wrong to
right,
A Sabbath song from Psalter of delight
Upon my tongue, and in my eye no tear.

9 Then she said to them, “Command now
To open up the city gates
For me and I’ll go anyhow
Achieving the things and estates
We spoke about.” So they commanded
The young men open gates unhand
For her as she had asked them to.

10 When they did so, Judith went out,
She and her servant girl about,
And the men of the city saw
Her until she passed down the hill
And through the valley and the draw
Till they could see no more from grill.
11 The women went straight through the
vale
Till the Assyrian guard on trail
Found her 12 and took her under guard

And asked her, “Of what folk *ill-starred*
Do you belong, and where are you
Coming from, and where going to?”
She answered, “I am a Hebrew
Woman fleeing from them, for they
Will soon be given to your sway
To be consumed. 13 I’m on my way
To see Holofernes the chief
Of your army to give in brief
A true report and I shall show
Him how and by which way to go
And capture all the uplands round
Without loss of any man found,
Captured or killed.” 14 When the men
heard

Her words and saw her face *unblurred*,
She was a marvel to their eyes,
They said to her, 15 “You have been wise
To save your life hurrying down
To the tent of our lord renown.
Go quickly to his tent and some
Of us will take you there *to hum*
And hand you over to his *drum*.
16 “And when you stand before him do
Not be afraid in your heart’s stew,
But tell him just what you have said,
And he will treat you well *instead*.”

The guards of heathen hope are all polite,
Pretending to be civilized and right.
The pagan heart is filled with love at sight
Of every other and in disdain looks
Upon the lovers of Your holy books.
There is no law but love in pagan town
And in the church without Your sacred
frown,
And every drunk is loved and pampered
where
Their victims lie unburied on the stair.
Beloved, I’ve seen the churchly ways of
love

And how such love is ruthless in the shove,
And buries goodness and exalts the waste
Of human actions, glories in debased.

17 They chose from their number of men
One hundred to go with her then
And her servant girl and they brought
Them to the tent of *the one sought*
Holofernes. 18 And there was great
Excitement in the whole estate,
For her coming was noised about

From tent to tent, *whisper and shout*,
 And they came and stood round her while
 She waited outside with a smile
 For Holofernes while they told
 Him all about her, *she was bold*.
 19 They wondered at her good looks and
 Admired the Israelitish band,
 Judging them by her, everyone
 Said to the other, “Who *by gum*
 Can despise these folk who have such
 Women as this for them *to touch*?
 We must not leave a man alive
 Of them, for if we let them wive
 They’ll seduce all the world *to strive*!”

Would that the Jewish ladies with their
 smile
 And good looks could reach out and then
 beguile
 All men on earth to scrutinize You law
 And live a life with You always in awe.
 But such is not the case. How can the hair
 Turned into ashes come seduce the fair?
 How can the buried beauties and their bone
 Tear down the dragon gods from off the
 throne?
 Beloved, I seek the treasures of Your house
 And see the emptied omens in the spouse,
 The busy streets, the crowding to forget.
 And yet I know that danger’s to be met.
 Let them seduce the world indeed and get
 All creatures to bow down to You alone.

20 Then Holofernes’ comrades and
 All his servants came out in band
 And led her in the tent *by hand*.
 21 Holofernes rested in bed,
 Under a canopy of thread
 With purple, gold and emerald
 And precious stones *shining and culled*.
 22 When they told him about her he
 Came forward to the front to see,
 With silver lamps carried before.
 23 When Judith came in the presence
 Of Holofernes *in the tents*
 And his servant, they wondered all
 At the beauty of her form’s *scrawl*,
 And she fell prostrate there to make
 Obeisance to him for his sake
 And his slaves raised her *with good sense*.

The silver lamps of generals of state

Still shine on every beauty and her mate,
 Still touch the silken hair and scintillate
 Upon the cleavage left open to sate.
 I too am touched by every well-turned heel
 And palpitate in what I see and feel,
 And so I know that Holofernes’ fate
 Is sealed by masks of lust covering hate.
 Beloved, the sale of woman flesh is great
 In my time and my place, I see the rate
 Pass in the moneyed house and the estate
 Of those who rule the roost of market-place
 And those who turn to presidents a face
 Too brazen to encounter their disgrace.

Judith 11

1 Then Holofernes said to her,
 “Woman, don’t be afraid to stir,
 But have courage in heart for I
 Would never lay a hand on fly
 Who chose to serve Nebuchadnezzar,
 The king of all the world *that says her*.
 2 “And if your people in the hills
 Had not disdained me for their thrills,
 I’d not have lifted spear to sky,
 But they have brought all of this by
 Themselves. 3 “And now then tell my why
 You’ve fled from them and come to us,
 Since you’ve come to salvation’s *bus*.
 4 “Take courage, you shall live tonight
 And from now on. No one will fight
 You, but everyone here will treat
 You well as they do at the feet
 Of the slaves of my lord the king
 Nebuchadnezzar *without sting*.”
 5 Then Judith said to him, “Receive
 The message your servant may weave,
 Allow your maidservant to speak
 Before your face and I shall seek
 To tell no false thing to my lord
 Tonight. 6 “And if you are implored
 To do as your maidservant shows,
 Alohim will accomplish blows
 Through you, and my lord will not fail
 To bring his purpose to avail.
 7 “Nebuchadnezzar who is king
 Of the whole world lives and to bring
 His power enduring, who sent you
 To guide each living soul in view,
 Not only men by you serve him,
 But also beast of field and *trim*
 Cattle and the fowl of the air
 Live by your power and everywhere

Under Nebuchadnezzar's share.

The wealthy West promises daughters poor
In the Ukraine and eastward, westward
sure,

That they shall find a glowing paradise
In Amsterdam, in Rome, in someplace nice.

The wealthy paragons of virtue sprayed
Across the television when waylaid
In civilized accents speak of the rule
Of law and order over sceptic school
Of anarchy, and blessings of the page,
While lusting for girls of decreasing age.
Beloved, I recognize the attitude
Of Holofernes in the living brood
That skips across the New York skyline's
crude

And jagged teeth of dragon without feud.

8 "We've heard of your wisdom and skill
Reported over plain and hill

That you're the one good man of all
In the realm wise and on the ball
Informed, in planning marvellous.

9 "Now as for Achior's great fuss
In your council, we've heard his words,
For the men of Bethulia's *turds*
Saved him alive and he told all
He said to you *when in your thrall*.

10 "And so, my lord and master, do
Not disregard what he said due,
But keep it in your wisdom's view,
For it is a thing surely true,
Our nation cannot be struck down
Nor can sword prevail on the town
Unless they sin against their God.

11 "And now so my lord may not be
Defeated in act cunningly,
Death falls upon them for a sin
They are about to take in bin
To provoke Alohim to wrath
When they turn into the wrong path.

12 "Since their food is consumed and their
Water decreased to single share,
They plan to kill their cattle there
And use all Alohim by law
Has forbidden to put in craw.

13 "They have determined they will eat
The first fruits of the grain and treat
Of the tithes of grape juice and oil
That they had set aside for toil
For the priests who serve by the face

Of our Alohim in His place
Jerusalem, although it is
Unlawful for the folk of His
Even to touch such with their hands.
14 "They've sent messengers from their
lands

To Jerusalem to the folk
Living there doing such in stroke
To bring permission from the herd
Of elders. 15 "When the sent-out word
Will reach them and be undeterred
And they go forward with the plan,
On that day they in every clan
Will be delivered in your hand
For the destruction of their band.

Judith appeals to general's fair mind
That is susceptible when once well-wined
To superstition of the word that's true
That all prosperity depends on You.
He is accustomed to think gods are bent
On punishment of those who fail to vent
Obedience and sacrifice and show
Allotted income to the idol row.
So he believes that Israel will go
The route of disobedience and make
An opportunity when You forsake
Them to lay open track for every wight
Invading Jerusalem in a night,
And setting up the kingdom of the blight.

16 "That's why, when I, your servant,
learned
All this, I fled from them discerned
That Alohim sent me to do
Great things that will astonish you
And the whole world, all those who hear
About them in the listening ear.

17 "Because your servant's one of faith,
And serves God of heaven and not wraith
Both day and night, that's why, dear sir,
I shall remain with you to stir
Each night out in the valley where
I'll pray to Alohim to share
With me the time that they incur
His wrath upon their sinful bur.

18 "And I shall come and tell you, and
Then you shall go out with your band
And not one of them can withstand.

19 "Then I will lead you through the stake
Of Judea until we make
Jerusalem, and I will set

Your throne in it, and you will get
 To lead them like sheep that have none
 To lead them, and not a dog's son
 Will even open its mouth to
 Growl at yourself or at your crew.
 For this has been told me, by my
 Prediction and proclaimed on high
 And so I was sent to your sty.”
 20 Her words pleased Holofernes and
 All his servants, and the whole band
 Stood all amazed at her command
 Of wisdom and said 21 “There is not
 Such a woman from one end sought
 Of the earth to the other, not
 For beauty of form or for plot
 Of speech *in all the words she got.*”

A traitor is the one that's fawned upon
 By general and president till dawn,
 But the unspoken word is that despised
 The traitor must descend before Your eyes.
 But Judith is an actress without peer,
 And beauty helps a lot to allay fear
 Of Holofernes that she's in a plot.
 In that he does not differ from the lot.
 Beloved, I sell my soul to lead the best
 Man to the temple of the city's rest,
 But before dawn I leave him in the lurch,
 And sit in Your heart on my wonted perch.

22 And Holofernes said to her,
 “Alohim has done well to spur
 You before the people, to lend
 Strength to our hands and so to send
 Destruction on those who have slighted
 My lord *the king since they're benighted.*
 23 “You're beautiful not just in looks
 But wise in speech *like holy books,*
 And if you do as you have said,
 Your God shall be my God and dread,
 And you shall live in the king's house
 Of Nebuchadnezzar *like spouse*
 And be renowned throughout the earth
From end to end and berth to berth.”

Holofernes promises Judith fame
 And luxury upon the royal claim
 If she will spend her beauty for the joy
 Of king and country and rightly employ
 Her talents and her wisdom in the rush
 Of blessed oppression behind veil and
 hush.

Beloved, I come into Your palaces,
 Ruler of heaven and earth, for malices
 Taught me by every people of God set
 In churches and in synagogues I've met,
 And mosques relayed outside the stunning
 sound
 Of music playing, beating all around.
 Beloved, I come a traitor to all things
 But You and settle here beneath Your
 wings.

Judith 12

1 Then he commanded them to bring
 Her in where his silver pots ring,
 And ordered them to set a board
 For her with some of his own stored,
 And serve her with his own grape juice.
 2 But Judith said, “It is no use,
 I cannot eat it, lest it be
 An offence, but I will now see
 What things I have brought here with me.”
 3 Holofernes said to her, “If
 Your stores run out then from what skiff
 Can we get more of it for you?
 Here with us is none of your crew.”
 4 But Judith said, “As your soul lives,
 Dear sir, your servant in the sieves
 Will not consume all I have brought
 With me before YHWH's action's wrought
 By my hand what He's planned to do.”
 5 The servants of Holofernes
 Brought her into the tent to please,
 And she slept until midnight's *freeze.*
 Then along toward the morning watch
 She got up 6 and sent not to botch
 It to Holofernes and said,
 “Let my lord now command instead
 That your servant be let to go
 Out to pray for the divine show.”
 7 So Holofernes ordered his
 Guards not to hinder her night biz.
 And she stayed in the camp three days,
 And went out each night to the maze
 Of the valley of Bethulia,
 Bathed at the spring in the camp *raw.*

The cunning watches of Judith require
 That she eat and drink from the godly fire
 Of kosher foods, and so she uses that
 To suggest sooner victory for fat.
 She goes abroad until the guards are sure
 That she is only praying for the pure.

The preparations of that godly girl
 Are ready soon to fool the wicked churl.
 Beloved, I eat only the pure and wait
 For prayers that I a hypocrite instate,
 Until I lull the valley into sleep
 Ready to drink the bitter cup I keep.
 Hold me alone in Your hand where I find
 My vengeance on the loving and the blind.

8 When she came up from the spring, she
 Prayed to YHWH Alohims to be
 With Israel and to direct
 Her for raising up the elect.
 9 So she returned clean and she stayed
 In the tent until she was swayed
 To eat her food toward evening laid.
 10 On the fourth day Holofernes
 Held a feast for his servants' ease,
 And did not invite officers.
 11 He said to Bagoas, the eunuch
 Who had charge of his gear and tunic,
 "Go now, persuade the Hebrew gal
 Who's in your care to join us pal
 And eat and drink with us, she shall.
 12 "For it's a disgrace if we let
 Such a woman go and not get
 To enjoy her company set,
 For if we don't include her grace
 She'll laugh at us and to our face."
 13 So Bagoas went from the face
 Of Holofernes *without trace*,
 And came near her and said, "Shall not
 This beauty of daughters begot
 Come to my lord an honoured guest,
 And drink grape juice with merry zest,
 And so become today like one
 Of the Assyrian daughters' fun
 Who serve Nenuchadnezzar's house?"
 14 Then Judith said "Am I such spouse
 To reverse my lord? Surely what
 Pleases him I will do to glut,
 And it will be a joy to me
 Until the day in death I'm free!"

By her pretence of religiosity
 Judith hid her bid to seduce the See,
 And so she found the invitation brought
 As though she did a favour as one sought.
 She would be ready with her hand of fate
 To take advantage of the drunken state
 And plant a standard of the royal gate
 In Babylon's gross heart and not be late.

Beloved, I take her wisdom's awful cue,
 And wait outside cathedral house with You,
 Until the drunken bishops come in view.
 Guide my hand, my Beloved, in aim and
 shout,
 And let me fill the trumpet round about
 With the last sound and then fall in the
 doubt.

15 So she arose and got her dressed
 In all her lady's finery's best,
 And her maid went and spread about
 On the ground for her where the stout
 Holofernes was the soft fleeces
 She'd got from Bagoas' releases
 To use each day, so that she could
 Lean on the while she ate her food.
 16 So Judith came in and lay down
 And Holofernes' heart would drown
 At her sight and filled with desire
 To possess her, he was on fire
 To find a chance to ravish her
 Since the first day he saw her fur.
 17 So Holofernes said to her,
 "Now drink and have a good time here!"
 18 And Judith said "I'll drink, no fear,
 Dear sir, because my life today
 Means more to me than any way
 In all the time since I was born."
 19 So she partook of bread and corn
 And drank before him what her maid
 Prepared. 20 Holofernes delayed
 Not to be pleased with her and drank
 So much wine that he truly stank,
 More than he ever drank before
 Since the day he came in the door.

The wisdom of Judith is such that she
 Seeks to make drunk the ruler in his fee.
 I have been one so foolish that I spend
 My futile breath to warn the worldly
 kenned
 Against abuse of wine and whiskey while
 I should encourage them instead with guile.
 And so I change my vote. Let government
 Officer and senator on the bent
 Drink and drink on until their sinful bloat
 Is ready for the slaughter of the goat.
 Let every officer of business and
 Elected and the shadow ruling band
 Drink up, drink up again and fall in stupor

Where righteous hand may gather up the grouper.

Judith 13

1 When evening came, his slaves went out
And Bagoas closed the tent route
From outside and he shut out all
Attendants from his master's brawl,
They went to bed, for they were tired
Since the feast went on long desired.

2 So Judith was left all alone
In the tent, with Holofernes
Stretched out on his bed drunk as stone.
3 Now Judith had told her maid please
To stand outside the bedroom and
To wait for her to come as planned,
As she did every day, for she
Said she would go out and then be
In prayer. And she said the same thing
To Bagoas. 4 So from the wing
Every one went out, and no one,
Either small or great, joined the fun
In the bedroom. Then Judith there
Standing beside his bed beware,
Said in her heart, "Lord Alohim
Of all power, look now on my dream,
Task of my hands for raising up
Jerusalem exalted cup.

5 "For now's the time to help your lot,
To carry out my cunning plot
To destroy enemies who rose
Against us as opposing foes."
6 She went up to the post that stood
At the end of the bed of wood
Above Holofernes' head and
Took down the sword hung on the stand.
7 She came close to his bed and took
Hold of his hairy head and shook
Saying "Give me the strength today,
YHWH Alohim of Israel's *prey!*"

I interrupt the story at this place
Where Judith has taken down from its trace
The great sword of the killer while he
sleeps

And prays petition for the one who weeps
In Bethulia and in Jerusalem.
She stands there pale and shimmering as a
gem.

Beloved, I too stand on the margin wide
Of fir and pine forest and by the side
Of frozen lake and turn my stolen sword

A moment while I speak once to the gourd.
The moment is upon me to record
That Decalogue is not enough to make
A life of leisure and of safety's sake.
Command to kill, or lead me to the stake.

8 She struck his neck twice hard as she
Could, cut it off then bodily.
9 She pushed his body off the bed,
Pulled down the canopy instead,
And after a time she went out
And gave Holofernes' head's snout
To her maid, 10 who placed it in her
Food basket. The two without fer
Went out together as they were
Accustomed to do for the prayer,
And passed through the camp everywhere
And circled round the valley there
And went up the mountain to share
Of Bethulia and came where
The gates were. 11 Judith called out from
Afar to the watchmen to come
To the gates, "Open up the gate!
Alohim our God will not wait
To show His power in Israel,
And His strength on our foes as well,
As He has done this day a spell!"

In dead of night Judith returned to find
The closed gates of her city and aligned
Behind the ramparts watchmen waiting
there.

The watchmen knew her voice, of one so
fair.

She had the faith that beauty gives the lot
Who live in fashion and in wealthy plot,
That those who see her coming or who hear
Will not cause her the harm that others fear.
Beloved, I clamour at Your gates though I
Have not the beauty of Judith to vie,
And yet I have a voice to reach the sky,
And find above the darkened fortress where
The hopeless wait on You upon the stair
The glimmer of the light that we two share.

12 When the townsmen there heard her
voice,
They hurried down to the gate choice
Of the town and called all the men
Of age and wisdom out again.

13 They all came running small and great,
Not daring to believe her fate,

And so they opened up the gate
 And let them in and lit a fire
 For light and gathered round the pyre.
 14 Then she told them with a loud voice,
 "Praise Alohim, praise and rejoice,
 Praise Alohim who's not withdrawn
 His mercy from Israel's house' spawn,
 But has destroyed our enemies
 By my hand this night *and with ease!*"
 15 Then she took the head from the bag
 And showed it to them with a wag
 Saying, "See here's the head of dread
 Holofernes, the chief and head
 Of the Assyrian gang outspread,
 And here's the canopy beneath
 Which he lay in drunken bequeath.
 YHWH's struck him down by woman's
 hand.

16 "As YHWH lives with saving command
 Upon the path I trod, my face
 Tricked him to destruction's disgrace,
 And yet he did not act of sin
 With me to defile hairy bin
 And shame me with his pintle in."
 17 The folk all were amazed and bowed
 Down and worshiped their God aloud,
 And said with one accord, "Blessed be
 You our Alohim who did see
 Fit to bring to contempt today
 Your people's enemies in sway."
 18 Uzziah said to her, "Daughter,
 You're blessed by Most High God to stir
 Above all women on the earth,
 And blessed be YHWH Alohim's worth
 Who made the heavens and the earth,
 Who guided you to strike the head
 Of our foes' leader on his bed.
 19 Your hope will never leave or shed
 From the hearts of men, as they mind
 The power of Alohim to bind.
 20 May Alohim grant this to be
 Eternal honour in your fee,
 And may He send His blessings sure,
 Because you did not spare your pure
 Life when our nation was brought low,
 But have avenged our ruin so,
 Yet walking in the righteous path
 Before our God not to bring wrath."
 And all the people said "So be,
 So be it *and eternally!*"

Judith was willing on her part to take

The chance that Holofernes on the make
 Should shame her with his act of lust and
 pride.

It was his wish and plan along her side.
 The only thing to prevent dastard deed
 Was cunning of Judith upon his greed
 To get him drunk and then strike in her
 need.

Beloved, I share the hope of Judith now
 As I take chances on the wooded brow
 And look out on the valley of the great
 And the Assyrian below the gate.
 There is an anthill near me that in times
 Of summer increases extensive climes.
 Assyrians swarm the path and rotate.

Judith 14

1 Then Judith said to them, "Hear me,
 My brothers and take this head free
 And hand it on the parapet
 Of your wall. 2 "Soon as morning's met
 And sun comes up, let strong men get
 Their weapons and go out of town,
 Set over them chief of renown,
 Just as if you were going down
 To the plain against the fortress
 Of the Assyrian address,
 But guard that you do not go down.
 3 "Then they will grab their guns and go
 Into the camp and roust the show
 Of army officers that can
 Lead out army Assyrian,
 And they will rush into the tent
 Of Holofernes lying spent
 And will not find him. Then great fear
 Will fall upon them front and rear
 And they will run away from here,
 4 "And you and all who live upon
 The sod of Israel dark to dawn
 Can chase after them, cut them drawn
 As they are fleeing *from the pawn*.
 5 "But before you do all this, bring
 Achior the Ammonite to sing
 To me, whether he knows the man
 Who despised Israel's house and clan
 And sent him to us that we might
 Strike him down dead as though for spite."
 6 So they called Achior from the house
 Of Uzziah. When *like a mouse*
 He came and saw Holofernes'
 Head in the hand of one of these
 Men gathered of the folk, he fell

Down prostrate on his face as well
And his spirit failed him *a spell*.
7 And when they lifted him he fell
At Judith's feet, and knelt before her,
And said, "Blessed are you to *adore her*
In every tent of Judah now!
In every nation those who hear
Your name will be alarmed with fear.

The Ammonite, a man of worth and praise
Falls down in rapture and in holy daze
To see that Judith has returned and sound
And safe to stand upright upon the ground.
And in returning brings a basket filled
With pastries of the hero that she killed.
The Ammonite is father to the plan,
And Judith honours him as a great man.
Beloved, I turn to see the basket trove
And find the treasures in the silent grove.
I joy to see the heads cut off and peeled
In silence for the hopeful things they yield.
We need more heads today of those
elected,
And those who deck the halls of those
respected.

8 "Now tell me what you've done these
days."

Then Judith told him of her ways
Before the face of all the folk,
From the day that she left in stroke
Until the moment when she spoke.
9 When she had finished, all the folk
Shouted aloud as they rejoiced
Throughout the city praise they voiced.

10 When Achior saw all Alohim
Of Israel had done *as in dream*
He firmly believed Alohim,
Was circumcised and joined the house
Of Israel, *no more a mouse*,
And so remains until this day.

11 At dawn they hung Holofernes'
Head on the wall, and at his ease
Each man took his weapons, and they
Got up, went out in companies
To the mountain passes *to freeze*.

12 And when the Assyrians saw
Them they sent word to their chiefs' paw
And they went to the generals
And the captains and *as it falls*
To all their officers *in awe*.

13 They came to Holofernes' tent

And told the steward to present
All personal affairs as sent,
"Wake up our lord, for the slaves are
So bold to come down to give car
Battle in order to be done
In by destruction where they run."
14 So Bagoas went in and knocked
At the door of the tent unlocked,
For he supposed him there abed
With Judith riding on his stead.

The steward dared to knock upon the door,
Assuming that the general in store
Was in the act of lust with Judith there.
Catastrophe made the man bold to glare.
But greater evils met his curious eyes
When he opened the door to his surprise.
The armies of the Lord come on apace,
While Holofernes rides a filly's race.
Beloved, give me more pleasure of this
kind,
To see the lusty beggars lie resigned
And caught off guard by virtue when the
wined
Are fallen on the dirt to keep their tryst
With all their hopes for everything they
missed.

Let Holofernes lose the head that kissed.

15 But when there was no answer, he
Opened the door and went a wee
Into the bedroom and there found
Him thrown from platform on the ground
Dead with his head cut off and gone.
16 So he shouted aloud, put on
Weeping and groaning, crying and
Tore his clothes. 17 Then he turned to stand
In the tent where Judith had stayed,
And when he did not find her laid,
He rushed out to the folk and said,
18 "The slaves have tricked us unpaid!
A Hebrew woman's brought disgrace
On King Nebuchadnezzar's face!
See here is Holofernes lying
On the ground and after his dying
His head is not on him for vying!"
19 When the Assyrian army chiefs
Heard this, they tore tunics in griefs,
In great alarm and their loud cries
Rose from the camp into the skies.

The ones who take the profits and can
 smile
 Have set themselves up for the loss at guile
 Of all the people in the village dust
 That they look down on in the arms they
 trust.
 There is a human gift to rise again
 Against the troops of all the army men
 Sent by those who claim to make the world
 free.
 Let those take warning who go out to pee.
 Beloved, I laugh at grief, and sorrow still
 When victors come rejoicing on the hill
 Of Rome or Washington, in London still
 Or in gay Paris for a festive day.
 I pray that You might make the army stay
 That fits the global bill and stops to pray.

Judith 15

1 When the men in the tents heard it,
 They were amazed at what was writ.
 2 Fear and shaking fell over them,
 They did not delay at the hem,
 But all rushed out together and
 Ran every way across the land
 And through the hill country in band.
 3 Those who camped in the hills around
 Bethulia also were found
 Fleeing. The men of Israel,
 Each was that was a wight and fell,
 Rushed out upon them *in the dell*.
 4 And Uzziah sent men out to
 Betomasthaim and Bebai too,
 And Choba and Kola and to
 All the lands of Israel in crew
 To tell what happened and to urge
 All to rush out upon the splurge
 Of foes to destroy them and purge.
 5 And when the Israelites heard it,
 They all together came as fit
 And fell upon the foe and cut
 Them down as far as Choba's rut.
 Those in Jerusalem and all
 The mountain lands around its wall
 Came also, since hand had been told
 What happened to the foes' camp sold,
 And those in Gilead and those
 In Galilee came to oppose
 Them with great slaughter to the toes
 Beyond Damascus and its lands.
 6 The rest of Bethulia's folk
 Fell on Assyrian camp at stroke

And plundered it, wealth to invoke.
 7 The Israelites, when they came back
 From the great slaughter and attack,
 Plundered what they had left behind,
 And villages and towns in kind
 In the hill country and the plain
 Had lots of booty from the slain,
 For much of it stayed where they'd lain.

I rich myself with booty left in sight
 When all the wicked fled from truth and
 right.

The lake was set in silver and gold light
 That I caught up in coin and set in purse
 Awaiting there a day of peace to curse
 The market with my buying at low rate.
 I rich myself with gems of stars set late
 In caskets of black velvet, and I find
 My coffers full of wealth and finely lined.
 I lay hold on the nightingale's last song
 Before the dawn turns white night all along
 To noon eternal like the heavenly land.
 I walk the golden street and kiss the band
 Of faith that keeps me under Your
 command.

8 Then Joakim the high priest, and
 The council of the folk to stand
 For Israel who lived in the land
 Of Jerusalem, came to see
 The good things which YHWH by decree
 Had done for Israel, to see
 Judith and to greet her a wee.
 9 And when they met her they all blessed
 Her with one voice and then confessed
 To her, "You are the exaltation
 Of Jerusalem, in your station
 You're the great glory of Israel,
 You are the great pride of our nation!
 10 You've done all this alone as well,
 You've done great good to Israel,
 And Alohims' well pleased with it.
 May the Almighty Lord see fit
 To bless you always where you sit!"
 And all the folk said, "So be it!"
 11 So all the people plundered that
 Camp thirty days for lean and fat.
 They gave Judith Holofernes'
 Tent and all his silver dishes
 And beds and bowls and all his stuff,
 And she took them, loaded enough
 On her mule and hitched up her carts

And piled the things on them *for starts*.

12 All the women of Israel came
Around and blessed her and her name
And some set out to dance for her
And she held branches there to stir,
Gave them to the women with her.

13 They crowned themselves with olive
wreaths,

She and those with her, swords in sheaths,
She went before all in the dance,
Leading all the women to prance,
While all Israel's men followed by,
Carrying their weapons awry,
And wearing garlands and with songs
On their lips *being saved from wrongs*.

The miracle is not a woman tried
And saved her people from the rising tide
Of globalized economy to ride
A wave of national content and free.
The miracle that anyone can see
Is that the woman, once she did her deed,
Lived to be praised in public and in speed.
The most of heroes die a traitor's death,
Maligned by those they saved with their
last breath.

More lie unknown who did the greater act
Than those who acted and were thanked in
fact.

Beloved, I praise You that one time You let
The heroine receive the reward set
By her own people and the folk she met.

Judith 16

1 Then Judith started out to sing
Before all Israel thanksgiving,
And all the people loudly sang
This song of praise that soundly rang.

2 Judith said "Start a song to my
Alohim with hand drum set by,
Sing to my Lord with cymbals loud.
Raise to him a new psalm, make proud,
And call upon His name *in crowd*."

3 "For Alohim is YHWH, the one
Who stops wars, since He on the run
Saved me from the power of the hand
Of my pursuers, by command
Brought me to His camp to the folk.

4 "Assyrians came at a stroke
From northern mountains, they came with
Myriads of warriors like a myth,
Their crowds blocked up the valley ways,

Their cavalry made the hills sway.

5 "He boasted that he'd come to burn
The regions where I live and earn,
And kill my young men with the sword,
And throw my babies down and gored,
And take my children as a prey,
And spoil my virgins in the way.

6 "But YHWH Almighty spoiled his plan
By hand of a woman, not man.

7 "Their mighty one did not fall by
The hands of the young men to ply,
No sons of Titans struck him down,
Nor did great giants from the town
Chase him, but Judith who was daughter
Of Merari brought to the slaughter
The beauty of her countenance.

Judith plays hard and high upon the fact
That You, Beloved, used woman in Your
act

To save the people from the terror strewn
By global conflict, kings of earth and
moon.

Though not the first of feminists, I trow,
Judith was vocal as one anyhow,
And had no fear in her prayer to raise gloat
That woman as well as man knows to float.
Beloved, make me as brave as women be,
And as strong as a man who knows to flee
From sinfulness and sinful acts to see
The coming of Your great salvation and
The blooming of Your grace upon the sand.
So I too shall pray as I come to stand.

8 "She took of widows mourning fence
To raise of Israel's poor oppressed.

She anointed her face and blessed
With ointment, but a crown in hair,
A linen gown seducing there.

9 "Her high heels drew his eyes, her glance
Captured his mind, a sword to dance
Cut through his neck. 10 "The Persians
quaked

At her boldness, the Medes unflaked
At what she dared to do awaked.

11 "My people oppressed in their joy
Shouted aloud and they employ
Their voices when the foes stand shaking,
They lifted up their voices quaking,
The enemy turned back forsaking.

12 "The sons of maidservants come pierce

Them through, they were wounded though
fierce

Like the children of fugitives,
They perished before blows that gives
The army of my Lord. 13 "I'll sing
To my Alohim and make ring
A new song: O Lord, You are great
And glorious, in strength and weight,
Invincible. 14 "Let all your creatures
Serve you, for You did speak, their features
Were made. You did send forth your breath
And it formed them, there is no death
That can resist your voice. 15 "The hills
Shall be shaken down to the rills
Of their foundations with the waters,
Before Your face the rocks in slaughters
Shall melt like wax, but to those who
Fear You You will continue to
Show mercy. 16 "For each sacrifice
As a fragrant offering suffice
As a small thing, and all the fat
For burnt offerings to you are scat,
But he who fears YHWH shall be great
For ever in his Lord's estate.
17 "Woe to the nations that rise up
Against my people like a tup!
The Lord Almighty vengeance takes
On them the day of judgment wakes,
Fire and worms he will give their flesh,
They'll weep in pain's eternal mesh."

You use, Beloved, the grace of everyone
Who brings to You his gifts beneath the
sun,

Or her gifts as the present case may be,
Gifts of not strength but cunningness to see
And beauty in the eye of lusty man.

You use, Beloved, the hopes of humankind
To show the common prophecies to mind
That ponders on the crest above the vale
That in the legend held the captain pale,
And made Holofernes in his tent quail.
Beloved, I turn with humble, stretched out
gifts

To where Your face on humankind uplifts,
And find in You a place, a nest, a nook
Where I can stop to see and know and
look."

18 When they came to Jerusalem
They worshiped at Alohim's hem.
As soon as the people were cleansed

They offered their burnt offerings flensed,
Their freewill offerings, and their gifts.

19 Judith too dedicated to
Alohim all the vessels due
Of Holofernes, which the folk
Had given her, as well as spoke
Of canopy, the one she took
For herself from his bedroom's nook
She gave as a *new* votive offering
To YHWH *as well as others proffering*.
20 The people continued their feast
In Jerusalem and increased
Before the sanctuary for
Three months, and Judith what is more
Stayed with them. 21 After this each one
Went home to his own house and bun,
And Judith to Bethulia
And stayed on her estate to draw,
Honoured in her day through the land.
22 Many desired her wedded hand,
But she remained widow unmanned
As long as she lived after her
Husband died and lay with his fur.
23 Her fame increased as time went on,
She grew old in her house once drawn
By her husband until she reached
One hundred and five years unbeached.
She set her maid at liberty.
She died in Bethulia free
So they buried her in the cave
Of her husband Manasseh's grave.

24 And Israel's house mourned her a
stretch

Of seven days. Before her fletch
She gave away her property
To all Manasseh's kin freely
Who was her husband, and her own
Nearest of kin to have and own.
25 And no one dared again to spread
Terror in Israel once led
In the days of Judith or for
A long time after her death's score.

An hundred and five years is a long time
To be an old woman remembering prime
And thinking of the days when beauty
shone

From face and limbs and navel to the groan
Of generals sent out by the world throne.
Though widowhood caught her when she
was still

A beauty on Bethulia's flowered hill,

The years that followed must have taught her more

Than even the great wisdom of her store
When she went out to battle with a maid
As her companion against all arrayed
Armies of the world standing in parade.
The years of memory, they are the best,
Beloved, Judith has also come to rest.

Esther

Esther's place in the canon has been questioned by many, not least of all Luther. The foundation for such animosity is manifold: the book does not mention the name of God in the Hebrew portions, it is thoroughly and unashamedly racist, and it includes heathen overtones. It could easily be maintained that its only claim to canonicity is in the fact that it shows how not to behave. It is included here because of its strong historical claim to canonicity, its formal acceptance of divine law, and its value as a contemplative text. It is also eminently of value in showing to what depths of moral degradation the supposedly chosen of God may fall as they attempt to live under imperialism.

The thoughtful reader comparing the actions of Judith and Esther will ponder that Esther did intentionally what Judith only risked. The case is extreme, but the principle arises as soon as empire meets faith: at what point is it permissible, even a duty, to break the holy commandment? Judith chose to kill, while Esther chose to ignore chastity. Both had a choice. One is so inured to killing in the Scripture, that it is easy to forget that Esther's lack of chastity is balanced by her refusal to kill with her own hand. And yet her action led to the slaughter of thousands, even if such slaughter prevented the killing of multitudes more.

The major difference between Esther and Judith is in the area of heathen and idolatrous features. The book of Judith is devoid of them. They creep out everywhere in the book of Esther. The lesson to be drawn is no doubt that constant contact with an idolatrous empire is bound to have

its effect. Yet Esther ingenuously claims that the king's bed was abhorrent to her.

Esther 1

1 Now in Ahasuerus' days,
This was Ahasuerus' plays
To reign over one hundred and
Twenty-seven regions of land
From India to the land of Cush,
2 When Ahasuerus the king
Sat on his kingdom's throne on wing
Of Shushan the fortress, 3 that in
The third year since his powers begin,
He called a feast for all his chiefs
And servants, the princes of fiefs
In Persia and in Media,
The nobles and princes in awe
Before him, 4 while he showed the wealth
Of his kingdom in glorious stealth
And splendour of his majesty
For many days in all to be
One hundred added to eighty.
5 And when these set days were completed,
The king called a feast for all seated
In Shushan the fortress to last
Until seven full days had passed,
That great and small be summoned to
The court garden of king's igloo.
6 White and blue linen caught in cords
Of fine linen and purple hordes
On silver rods and marble pillars,
Couches of gold, couches in sillers
Upon paved floor of alabaster,
Turquoise, white and black marble faster.
7 They drank from golden cups and each
Cup was unique, and above reach
The royal wine accordingly
As royal generosity.
8 By law the drinking was not forced,
For so the king ordered endorsed
The chiefs of his economy
To do as each man's pleasure be.
While wine seems to be order of the day
For six full months in pleasure's eager
sway,
The law is none should be forced in the
way
He drank, but each could save himself to be
Free of intoxication's ugly spree.
The text does not say how many men there

Refrained from gorging themselves on the
ware,
And I doubt that the number was as great
As ought to be upon a righteous slate.
Beloved, I marvel that the men of state
Have time to guzzle wine for six months
straight,

But think it must be You behind the scenes
To encourage their drinking on their beans.
It kept them out of harm from killing's rate.

9 Queen Vashti also made a feast
For the women and undecreased
Within the regal palacing
Of Ahasuerus the king.

10 Upon the seventh day and when
The king's heart was rejoiced again
With wine, he commanded his men,
The seven eunuchs Mehuman,
Biztha, Harbona and as ran,
Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar and
Carcas, who served in present band
Before Ahasuerus king,

11 To bring Queen Vashti in to sing
Before the king with regal crown,
To show her beauty to the town
Of folk and chiefs for she was sight
Of beauty to behold in light.

12 But Queen Vashti refused to come
At the king's order by the sum
Of eunuchs, so the king was mad
And anger burned within him bad.

13 Then the king said to the wise men
Who understood signs as again
The king was wont to do with all
Who knew law and justice by call,

14 Those closest to him seven in all
Carshena, Shethar, Admatha,
Tarshish, Meres, and Marsena,
And Memucan, the Persian princes
And Median ones too in their minces,
Who stood before the king in sight
Ranked highest in the kingdom's right.

The Persian way of doing things it seems
Was in the rate of seven under dreams,
And seven wise men stood to counsel king,
And seven princes answered everything.
The hidden number seven of perfection
Is sum of four and three in their selection,
And hides within them multiplied to twelve
Which is the outer showing, one must delve

To find the mystic seven and be late.
So Shi'ite is divided in the rate
Of Ismailis in sevens' mystic state
And Twelvers for the outer sign to men
That You, Beloved, add sign to sign again
In hidden sevens by twelves shining great.

15 "What must be done now to the queen,
Vashti, by law, because she's been
Rebellious to command of king
Ahasuerus by the wing

Of eunuchs?" 16 Memucan
Answered before king and each man,
"Queen Vashti has not only wronged
The king but also princes thronged
And all the folk in every part
Of King Ahasuerus' mart.

17 "For the queen's action will be known
To every women from the throne
Down to the least to despise own
Husband in sight when they report
'King Ahasuerus and for sport
Commanded Queen Vashti to be
Brought before him for all to see
But she did not obey decree.'

18 "Today already ladies of
Persia and Media without love
Will say to all the king's chiefs that
They've heard of the queen's actions pat.
So very much contempt once born
Will fill the land with wrath and scorn.

19 "May it please the king to decree
From himself and in royalty
To be set in the Persian laws
And that of Medes unaltered clause,
That Vashti shall no longer come
Before King Ahasuerus' bum,
And let the king give queenly place
To someone else better in face.

20 "When the king's law is made and
published

Throughout all his empire unrubbed,
All wives will have their lords in store
Of honour, both great and small bore."

21 The answer pleased both king and
prince,

And so the king without a wince
Did as Memucan said and more.

22 He sent letter to all the lands
Of the king's sway to each as stands
In its own written language and
To every folk in their own brand

Of speech so every man might be
Master of his own house and fee,
And speak the language of his own
Home and folk where he had been grown.

Is woman so strong in her own defence
That even kings must publish decrees'
vents

To save their dignity and power to say
When women must uncover, sing and
sway?

The vying for the power to say and do
Between the sexes in the Persian crew
Is but reflection of the eastern world
From Ireland to Nippon in flag unfurled.
Beloved, give me the tribal way that knows
That woman has the power of hand and
rose,

The wisdom to reject of what she chose,
The heart to sing a battle and relent.
Beloved, fie on all kings that would prevent
The flourishing of female accident.

Esther 2

1 After these events when the wrath
Of King Ahasuerus' path
Was appeased, he remember Queen
Vashti and what she did on scene
And what he had decreed for her.

2 Then the kings servants to deter
Him said "Let beautiful young things
Be sought out for the king's viewings.

3 "And let the king set chiefs in all
The kingdom's provinces to call
Together all beautiful young
Virgins to Shushan and the sung
Fortress, into the women's house,
Under the caretaker of spouse,
Hegai the king's eunuch. And let
Cosmetologists get them set.

4 "Then may the young girl that most
pleases

The king be queen for Vashti's cheeses."
This word rejoiced the king and so
He did as they came up to show.

5 In Shushan fortress city there
Lived a certain Jew whose name's share
Was Mordecai son of Jair,
The son of Shimei, son of Kish,
A Benjamite as one could wish,
6 *Who* had been carried out in hem
Of captives from Jerusalem

Captured with Jeconiah king
Of Judah, whom Nebuchadnezzar
The king of Babylon made sneezer.
7 And he had raised Hadassah, called
Esther, his uncle's daughter stalled,
For she had neither dad nor mom.
The young woman lovely as palm
Was beautiful. When her dad and
Mom died, Mordecai took hand
As his own daughter. 8 So it came
To pass, when the king's word of fame
Was heard, and when many young girls
Gathered at Shushan's fortress curls,
In care of Hegai, Esther too
Was taken to the king's review,
In care of Hegai the caretaker
Of royal women, no mistaker.

Esther, the name of goddess in the sky,
The queen and star of ample myths and
why,

Suggests the pagan search had all but left
The Jewish nation in the devil's cleft.
When Christianity is glad to move
In circles of the heathen mind to prove,
It is no wonder, since the root is caught
In pagan dreams of honey and the pot.
Beloved, though the sweet Hadassah is
great

To serve her people and the Persian state,
That service would be just as suspect now
As service to Iran would anyhow.
The seedbed of both faith and vanity,
Iran arises still and land to see.

9 Now the damsel pleased him, and she
Gained his favour, so readily
He gave her cosmetics beside
Her own allowance for the ride.
And seven fine maidservants still
Were provided to fit her bill
From the king's palace, and he moved
Her and her maidens to the grooved
Best of the women's house to fill.
10 Esther had not revealed her folk
Or family, for at a stroke
Mordecai told her not to do.

11 And every day Mordecai's view
Was in front of the women's court
To hear of Esther's good report
And what happened to her in fort.

12 Each young woman's turn came to go

To King Ahasuerus' show
After completing twelve month's row
In readiness, according to
The statutes of women in view,
For that is how their readiness
Was set, six months with oil of myrrh,
Six months with perfumes to incur
For beautifying women's fur.

13 So the young women joined the king
And each was given everything
That she desired to take with her
From the women's quarters to spur
To house and palace of the king.

14 In the evening she went, and in
The morning she returned to spin
In the other house of females
Under care of Shaashgaz's sails,
The king's eunuch who kept the tales
Of concubines. And she would not
Go again unless the king sought
Her with delight and called her name.

The king must try each lady for her worth
A night before he makes his choice on
earth.

After the math the lady finds her berth
In women's house, no more to see the face
Of husband and the master of the race.
How many concubines were taken for
The king to make up yet another store?
No one has counted them, for if he had
They would been named by a number sad.
Beloved, if Hadassah at last appears
Among the number of women's arrears,
It is no sadder thing than what comes out
Of millions more who never learn to pout.
Submission is the game we're all about.

15 Now when the turn came for the game
Esther daughter of Abihail
The uncle of Mordecai's rail,
Who had taken her as his own
Daughter, to go in to the throne,
She asked for nothing but what the
King's eunuch Hegai said in fee,
Who guarded the women with care.
Esther gained favour everywhere
From all who saw how she was fair.

16 So Esther was taken to King
Ahasuerus, in the wing
Of royal palace, on a day
In the tenth month, the month then called

Tebeth, in seventh year installed
Of his reign. 17 The king loved Esther
More than all women, and gave her
More grace and favour in his sight
More than all the virgins of light,
And set the royal crown on her
And made her queen in Vashti's right.

By refusing the geste of king and crown
To have whatever gifts there be in town,
Esther gained all the coveted renown.
Remembering the wealthy are the most
Satisfied for the economic toast,
She did not take a thread beyond the cream
She needed once to fulfil the king's dream.
Beloved, I take no presents from Your hand
Beyond what You offer in contraband,
No gold, no gems, no silver, and no oil,
Nothing at all beyond the joy of toil.
And yet You pour upon my livid soul
Celestial pleasures unknown in the toll,
To be at one with You beyond the goal.

18 And so the king made a great feast,
The Feast of Esther, and increased
To all his chiefs and servants, and
Proclaimed a holiday in band
Of provinces and he gave gifts
As royally as custom lifts.

19 When virgins were gathered again
A second time, Mordecai then
Sat at the king's gate as in den.

20 Esther had not revealed her roots
And her folk, as Mordecai's boots
Had ordered her, Esther obeyed
Mordecai's word as when she stayed
With him and daughter as she played.

The worth of taqiyya is a life saved
By keeping quiet for the thing she braved.
So Esther finds her secret does her well
Not to reveal her roots in Israel.
The generations of my fathers past
Held secrets that could last as long as last,
But when I heard them tooted in the blast
I kept no mouth shut for the fear of class.
Beloved, my heritage is hidden now
And revealed in the DNA somehow,
So none can pretend other than the cow
And bull by the horns for a green morass.
Let Esther and the Persian king play fair

And spread their children out and
everywhere.

21 In those days, while Mordecai
Sat in the king's gate, two of sly
Eunuchs of the king, Bigthan and
Teresh, doorkeepers, would lay hand
Conspiring on Ahasuerus
The king *who had not learned to fear us*.
22 But the matter had come to light
To Mordecai, who told outright
Queen Esther, and Esther let know
The king in Mordecai's name's show.
23 After investigation it
Was confirmed and both came up fit
To hang on gallows, it was writ
In book of chronicles before
The sight of the king on their score.

The Jew that sits beside the gate to hear
Says not a word to any in the ear,
But only watches and listens to know
What information may save on the go
The life of himself and his family's show.
The Jew must always be a clever chap
To hear about any coming mishap.
He must not trust to chance or even You,
But has to be about ready to do.
Beloved, if I had made a world once too,
I would have filled it with more Jews a
few,
At least enough to balance out the hate
That hounds Your justice in the pagan
state,
And makes the world a poverty in view.

Esther 3

1 After this King Ahasuerus
Promoted Haman, *none to fear us*,
The son of Hammedatha and
An Agagite, and gave command
Above all princes in the land.
2 And all the king's servants within
The king's gate bowed and in their sin
Paid homage to Haman, for so
The king had ordered for the show.
But Mordecai would not bow
Or pay him homage anyhow.
3 Then the king's servants there within
King's gate told Mordecai's grin,
"Why do you break the king's command?"
4 It happened, when they told him daily

And he did not listen to scaly,
They informed Haman, just to see
What Mordecai's words would be,
For he'd let them know he was Jewish.
5 When Haman saw that he was shrewish
Not to bow or pay his respect,
Haman was filled with wrath unwrecked.
6 He did not care to attack just
Mordecai, since they had been fussed
To tell him of Mordecai's folk.
So instead Haman at a stroke
Decided to kill all the Jews
Throughout the whole land that accrues
To King Ahasuerus' views.
Even all Modercai's folk's crews.

The point of the neglect is point of law.
No one should bow down to a man in awe,
But to You only, so the sinful way
Of Mordecai was one in Your pay.
True faith will always rouse the heathen
ire,
So Mordecai did right in desire
That Esther not bear record to the king
Of her roots in the fatal Jewish thing.
If the king thought the lady that he got
Was Persian, I'd think he was in the plot
To blind himself, because like it or not
The ethnic difference that's not of choice
Always appears in sight and sound and
voice.
It's always shown at last in what we sing.

7 In the first month, which is that called
Nisan, in the twelfth year installed
Of King Ahasuerus, they
Cast lots before Haman to say
The day and month until it fell
On the twelfth, month of Adar's spell.
8 Haman told King Ahasuerus,
"There is a certain people scattered
Dispersed among the folk that mattered
In all the regions of your land,
Their laws are different from command
Of other folks, they do not keep
The king's commandments *when they reap*.
That's why it's not proper the king
Should let them stay among living.
9 "If it delight the king, then let
It be written that bayonet
Destroy them, and I will pay out
Ten thousand silver talents' clout

Unto the powers who do the task
Brought in the king's treasure-house flask."

10 So the king took his signet ring
From his hand and gave it to sting
By Haman, son of Hammedatha
The Agagite and maranatha,
The sworn enemy of the Jews.

11 And the king said for Haman news,
"The funds and personnel are yours,
To do with them by your own chores."

12 Then the king's scribes were called
upon

The thirteenth day of first month's *dawn*,
And a writ by all Haman said
To the king's satraps to be read,
To governors of each province,
To every people's *standing* prince,
To every province by the writ,
To every folk in their tongue fit.
In name of King Ahasuerus
It was written, and sealed to *fear us*
With the king's signet ring *and bit*.

The enemy of Jew and faithful will
Always pretend an innocence to fill
The world with lawful justice when he
finds

A chance to blind the legislators' minds.
When the week is cast as beginning on
The Monday at twelve midnight, then the
dawn

Of persecution of the Sabbath keeper
Is already in sight of every reaper.
If anyone stand up to point to fact
That holocaust continues in the act
He's tooted as fanatic and war-monger,
No matter how benign he show his hunger.
Beloved, curse every cur uncircumcised
Pretending to make law here ill-advised.

13 Epistles sent by runners all
Into the king's provinces' hall,
To destroy, kill, and liquidate
All the Jews, both young and old rate,
Little children and women too,
On one day, on the thirteenth view
Of the twelfth month which is Adar,
To take booty of gear and car.

14 A copy of the decree sent
By law to every province went
Published for all the people to
Be ready for that day and crew.

15 The runners went out quickly by
The king's command, and the decree
Was published in Shushan the fort.
So the king and Haman in sport
Sat down to drink, but the city
Of Shushan was perplexed to see.

The king was not really so innocent
As he pretends, though ignorant and bent.
After enforcing holocaust renewed
The rulers sit down to enjoy the brewed.
The civilized effect of Roman law
Is to hit Sabbath-keeper in the jaw,
And there is never peace until the feud
Remove uncircumcised as well as crude.
Beloved, I see around me everywhere
The trinkets of unlovely and the heir
Of heathen poetry and law and term
That drives the world into the jungle
squirm

Denying Your commandments to insist
Love unconditional's no evil twist.

Esther 4

1 When Mordecai found out what
Had happened, he tore his clothes, but
Put on sackcloth and ashes, and
Went out into the city sand.
He cried aloud with bitter voice.

2 He came before the king's own choice
Gate, but not inside it because
Nobody goes in by king's laws
Dressed in sackcloth. 3 In every place
Where the king's decree came to trace,
Great mourning rose among the Jews,
With fasting, weeping in their pews,
Many lay in sackcloth and ashes.

4 But Esther's maids and eunuch dashes
Came and told her, the queen in sashes
Was much distressed. She sent in flashes
Clothes to put on Mordecai
And take his sackcloth from him spy,
But he would not accept the try.

5 Then Esther called Hathach, *one* of
The king's eunuchs whom he in love
Appointed to take care of her,
And she ordered him in command
About Mordecai in hand

To learn the what and why in brand.

6 Hathach went to Mordecai
In the town plaza and just shy
Of the king's front gate by and by.

7 And Mordecai told him all
That happened to him at the ball,
And how much money Haman said
He'd put in the king's treasure-bed
To liquidate the Jews well-bred.

The reason anybody comes to kill
Jews is not for the anti-semitic swill,
But simply as a matter of the money
Involved in such affairs, it isn't funny.
The economic theory of the Czar
Was always steady as the polar star:
When things went wrong in economic state
The fault he saw was always Jewish rate.
Beloved, the human mind is made of
dollars

With no cents added to the higher callers.
The blue-eyed staff stand ready in the
wings

To jive statistics with their numberings,
But in the end equation's simply there:
Let Jews live only if they have the ware.

8 He also gave a copy of
The writ for their destruction's shove,
Which was given at Shushan's town,
To show to Esther with a frown
Explaining her that she should go
To plead with the king for her row.
9 Hathach returned and told Esther
The words of Mordecai sure.
10 Then Esther spoke to Hathach, and
Gave him a command for the stand
Of Mordecai: 11 "All the king's
Servants and the folk of the king's
Provinces know that any man
Or woman who goes without plan
Into the inner court in span
Before the king, who's not been called,
The law is for the one appalled,
Put him to death, except the one
To whom the king holds not to shun
The golden sceptre, he may live.
And I've not been called in to give
Appearance before the king now
For these thirty days anyhow."
12 So they told Mordecai what
Esther had said of the door shut.
13 And Mordecai told *them* to
Give this reply to Esther too:
"Don't think in your heart you'll escape
In the king's palace under cape

Any more than all other Jews.
14 "For if you're silent and refuse
Now, salvation will truly come,
But through another one in sum,
And you and your dad's house are done.
Yet who knows whether you have run
Into the kingdom for this time?"

The accusation of her cousin shows
The way the human mind forever goes:
Some think the others neglect justice rows
Because they are not threatened on their
toes.

Truth is that sometimes money talks so
loud

That life can be safe in the motley crowd,
And Esther may have been right if she
thought

Herself safe in the palace garden plot.
But Mordecai has an argument
Well-sounded in the gatehouse and the tent,
That politics and love for all their glint
Can turn the tables quickly on the mint.
Beloved, I too am in the kingdom here,
But have no power to inform on the ear.

15 Then Esther told *them* to give back
An answer to Mordecai:

16 "Go, gather all the Jews on track
In Shushan, and fast for my try,
Neither to eat nor drink for three
Days, night or day. My maids and I
Will also fast. And so I'll flee
To the king, though against the law,
And if I die, I'll die *in awe*!"

17 So Mordecai went his way
And did what Esther came to say.

Fasting and prayer are very ways to make
One stop and think the best way at the
stake.

So Esther had her cousin go around
And fill the ears of everyone with sound
Of fasting and of prayer against mistake.
The many lifting voices in the gloom
Ought to at last avert the sombre doom,
And turn the legislators' eye upon
Injustice they would inflict on the fawn.
Fact is, Beloved, that prayer and fasting
here

Prove of no effect in the glittered ear
Of president and businessman to glut,

And justice is a door that's always shut.
You rarely enter where some weep and
fear.

Esther 5

1 It took place on the third day then
That Esther clothed *in damascen*
Stood in the inner royal court
Across from the king's house *to sport*,
While the king sat on kingly throne
In royal palace towards the gate.
2 So when the king saw her come *late*,
Queen Esther standing in the court,
She found his favour *and his sport*,
The king extended in his hand
To Esther golden scepter's *band*.
So Esther approaching, she touched
The top of the sceptre he clutched.
3 And the king said to her, "What do
You wish, Queen Esther? What's your cue?
It shall be given to you now
Up to half of the kingdom's vow!"
4 Then Esther answered, "If it please
The king, let the king and the *sleeze*
Haman come today to banquet
That I've prepared for him and set."
5 Then the king said, "Bring Haman fast,
To do as Esther's word has cast."
So the king and Haman went to
The banquet Esther put in view.
6 At the banquet of wine the king
Said to Esther, "What *is* your thing?
It shall be granted you. Just ask
Up to half of the kingdom's task!"
7 Then Esther answered and she said,
"My request and desire of dread,
8 "If I've found favour in the sight
Of the king, and the king delight
To grant petition and fulfil
My longing, then let the king still
Come with Haman to feast again
With me tomorrow, I shall then
Do as the king has said *with skill*."

It's merely formal courtesy to say
That half the kingdom will be given away.
The Persian is a master of the stroke
Of language so polite a man could choke.
But this expression's found in every place
That nature takes a back seat in the race
With cultivation of the human face.
Beloved, I come to You with my petition,

With praise and plaint and in heart-felt
contrition

My penitence to find Your sceptre swung
In love to hear the offering of my tongue.
The earthly king's no better than You are
In handing empty hands a golden star,
And You accept no beauty from afar.

9 Haman went out that day with joy
And with a glad heart to employ.
When Haman saw Mordecai
In the king's gate, how he did not
Stand or tremble before his lot,
He was furious against the sot.
10 Still Haman controlled himself and
Went home, and sent and called the band
Of his friends and his wife Zeresh.
11 Then Haman told them all out fresh
Of his great wealth and children fine,
All the king did in fair design
Raising him up and setting far
Above the chiefs' and servants' car
Of the *Persian king aquiline*.
12 And Haman said, "Besides, Queen
Esther
Invited no one but me bester
To come in with the king to feast
With her, and tomorrow increased
I and the king are her guests leased.
13 "All this is nothing to my tongue
As long as I see on the rung
At the king's gate Mordecai
The Jew sitting under my eye."
14 His wife Zeresh and all his friends
Said to him, "Let to make amends
A gallows be erected high
Of fifty armlengths in the sky,
And in the morning ask the king
To hand Mordecai on wing
Of it, then happily go in
With the king to the banquet din."
That pleased Haman, who in a trice
Set up gallows of sacrifice.

Who rejoice in the invitation set
By Jewess or her husband in the bet
And love attention and the royal call,
Can at a wifely word go out of hall
And raise a gallows for the sacred neck
That kept Your justice despite hand and
beck
To the oppression of the populace

Crowded in more than one hundred of
place.
Beloved, I see the hypocritic stance
Among decision-makers when they dance.
Just policy is simple as a prance:
Obey the ten commandments and rely
On You alone, not on corporate spy
And legal banking fraud uncaught and sly.

Esther 6

1 That night the king just could not sleep.
So he ordered to bring from keep
The book of records of the times
To read before the king *in rhymes*.
2 And it was found there written that
Mordecai had informed that
Bigthana and Teresh, two of
The king's eunuchs, doorkeepers' glove,
Had tried assassinating once
King Ahasuerus *like dunce*.
3 Then the king asked, "What honour paid
Or dignity has been displayed
On Mordecai for the raid?"
And the king's servants in the place
Said "Nothing's been done to his face."
4 And the king said, "Who's in the court?"
But Haman had *just* come in sport
Into the outer palace court
Of the king to ask in resort
To hang Mordecai upon
The gallows he'd prepared at dawn.
5 The king's servants said to him then,
"Haman is there, standing again
In the court." And the king said, "Let
Him come in, he can say, *I'll bet*."
6 So Haman came in, and the king
Asked him, "What shall be done, what
thing
For the man whom the king delights
To honour?" Haman had in sights,
"Whom would the king delight to praise
More than me only all his days?"
7 So Haman replied to the king,
"*For* the one man to whom the king
Delights to give honour, 8 "now let
A royal robe be brought from set
Worn by the king, and a horse on
Which the king has ridden, and on
Which has been set the royal crest.
9 "Then let this robe and horse be taken
In hand of one most noble shaken
Of the king's princes to be dressed

As the man the king would have blessed,
And lead him in parade on horse
Through the square of the town of course
And make a proclamation go
Before him 'It shall be done so
To the man whom the king would show
His honour!'" 10 Then the king said to
Haman, "Be quick, take robe and do
With the horse, as you have said to,
And for Mordecai the Jew
Who sits in the king's gate in view!
Leave nothing undone of all you
Have spoken to perform on cue."

You have a bit of humour in the way
You prepare the downfall of human sway,
And since a thousand years is like day
For You, the two centuries of empires' ray
Is just amusement of a few hours' play.
You are a child that sits alone to see
The toy soldiers in Your sandbox with glee
Mount on the hills and roads Your eager
hand
Has moulded in the barely dampened sand.
Beloved, when mother calls, You in a rush
Kick over the bright castles in the hush
Of noon and leave the soldiers scattered
wide
Upon the bloody heath and stones to bide.
You are an autocratic God to hide.

11 So Haman took the robe and horse,
Dressed Mordecai for the course
And led him on horseback throughout
The city square, proclaimed with shout
Before him, "Thus shall it be done
To the man who with honour's won
The king's delight and benison!"
12 After that Mordecai went
Back to the king's gate to prevent.
But Haman hurried to his house,
Mourning with head covered to spouse.
13 When Haman told his wife Zeresh
And all his friends what happened fresh,
His wise men and his wife Zeresh
Said to him, "If Mordecai,
Before whom you've begun to die,
Is of Jewish descent, you'll not
Gain upper hand that you have sought
But surely will fall in his plot."
14 While they *were* still talking with him,
The king's eunuchs came to take trim

And bring Haman into the feast
That Esther had made for the beast.

The friends and wives are caught up in
dumb fate,
With hearts left cold and fearful in the wait.
They understand that there's no human
choice:

The gods determine everything with voice
Unchangeable by supplication's prayer,
Immoveable beneath oppressing air.
The will divine is cast without a word
Of explanation for the thing occurred.
Beloved, I step out on the freedom set
In each new morning, and in visions get
Exhilarating stations above cloud,
Feet crunching on the hopes of milling
crowd.

Whatever gallows waits my coming morn,
Today I have the slate of the newborn.

Esther 7

1 So the king and Haman went out
To dine with Queen Esther about.
2 And on the second day at feast
The king again asked Esther *triste*,
“What's your request, Queen Esther? It
Shall be granted to you as fit.
And what *is* your petition's tale?
Up to half the kingdom in scale,
It shall be done! Just mention it.”
3 Then Queen Esther answered and said,
“If I've found favour by you led,
O king, and if it please the king,
Let my life be given me in wing,
And my folk as petition's thing.
4 “For we've been sold, my folk and I,
To be destroyed, killed on the sly,
And liquidated under sky.
Had we been sold as slaves, then I
Would not have opened mouth to cry,
Although the foe could never pay
For the king's loss upon that day.”
5 So King Ahasuerus said
In answer to Queen Esther sped,
“Who is he, and where is he, who
Dare presume in his heart to do
Such a thing to *the queenly crew*?”
6 And Esther said, “The enemy
And foe's this wicked Haman, see!”
Haman was terrified before
The king and queen on that bad score.

Haman was sitting proud and glad beside
The Queen of Persia, knowing all was well
Because he had the fate of Israel
In hand, and soon the slaughter once
applied
Would free him of the sneering of the snide
Jew sitting at the king's gate for a spell
Each day to make his life a living hell.
Eating and drinking he could well abide.
The sudden sword fell on poor Haman's
pate
When least expected by the side of king,
Dining and looking pleased upon the
queen.
The golden goblet tinkled on his plate,
In horror he looked round on everything,
And darkness overwhelmed the light he'd
seen.

7 Then the king arose in his wrath
From the banquet of wine to path
The palace garden, but Haman
Stood before Queen Esther in plan
To plead for his life, for he saw
The doom determined by the claw
Of the king. 8 When the king returned
From the palace garden discerned
To the place of banquet of wine,
Haman had fallen to resign
Across the couch where Esther sat.
Then the king said, “Will he out flat
Also assault the queen while I
Am in the house?” As the words fly
From the king's mouth, they covered face
Of Haman's. 9 Harbonah in grace,
One of the eunuchs, told the king,
“Look, gallows fifty armlengths high
Haman made for Mordecai,
Who spoke good on the king's behalf,
Standing at house of Haman's gaff.”
So the king said, “Hang him on it!”
10 So they hanged Haman as was fit
On the gallows he had prepared
For Mordecai. Then was spared
The king's anger that he had shared.

The Psalmist prays the snare be oft returned
Upon the pate of those for what they earned
In retribution. My Beloved, I too
Pray in the son of David's famous cue
For enemy that faces me in pew.

I've seen from birth the success of the eye
 Of wolf inspired by innocence and cry
 Of lamb in my own jumping in the field.
 Let it fall on each one by his own yield.
 Excuse is not found in the natural way
 The beast seeks out the innocent in prey.
 Even the human law when caught in fray
 Accuses not the victim of the day,
 But points at perpetrator silver-heeled.

Esther 8

1 On that day King Ahasuerus
 Gave Queen Esther the house to fear us
 Of Haman, the foe of the Jews.
 And Mordecai came in views
 Of the king, for Esther had told
 How he *was* to her kinsman bold.
 2 The king took off his signet ring,
 Which he'd taken from Haman's sting,
 And gave it to Mordecai,
 And Esther appointed the man
 Mordecai house of Haman.
 3 Esther spoke again to the king,
 Fell down at his feet for the thing,
 And begging him with tears to do
 Something against the wicked brew
 Of Haman the Agagite, and
 The scheme against the Jews he planned.
 4 The king held out the golden sceptre
 Toward Esther sign to accept her.
 So Esther got up and she stood
 Before the king, 5 and said, "If would
 The king, and if I've found the good
 Before his eyes and it seem right
 To the king and in his delight,
 Let it be written to revoke
 The letters made by Haman's stroke,
 The son of Hammedatha who
 Was the Agagite, which on cue
 He wrote to liquidate the Jew
 In all the king's provinces' view.
 6 "For how can I endure to see
 Such evil on posterity
 Of my folk? Or how can I wait
 To see my countrymen's bad fate?"

The revocation of the bare edict
 Is what Esther wanted at first and picked
 To bring before the king. The problem is
 That legislation's no bright, easy biz.
 The lovely Esther, who seemed well in
 state

Of palace and her gardens, chooses fate
 Of grieving for the poorest and oppressed.
 And so before the king she has confessed
 Her ardour and her love for Jewish race.
 I too in my hypocrisy am dressed
 To come before Your ever-knowing face
 And plead for homeless and starving
 disgrace,
 And put a penny in the almsbox when
 I see it on the street of businessmen.

7 Then King Ahasuerus said
 To Queen Esther and to truebred
 Mordecai the Jew, "Indeed,
 I've given Esther in her need
 The house of Haman, and they've hanged
 Him on the gallows when he clanged
 To lay his hand upon the Jews.
 8 "Now you yourselves write *a decree*
 Concerning the Jews, as you see,
 In the king's name, and seal it by
 King's signet ring, for every cry
 Written in the king's name and sealed
 With royal signet's not repealed."
 9 So the king's scribes were called at once,
 In the third month, which *is* the month
 Of Sivan, on the twenty-third,
 And it was written by the word
 In all that Mordecai said,
 To the Jews, the satraps outspread,
 The governors, the princes bred
 Of provinces from India
 Clear down to Ethiopia,
 One hundred twenty-seven known
 Provinces, in every script grown,
 To every people in their own
 Tongue, and to the Jews in their own
 Script and tongue message from the throne.
 10 And he wrote in the name of King
 Ahasuerus, sealed the thing
 With the king's royal signet ring,
 And sent letters by horseback runners,
 Riding on royal horses stunners
 Bred from swift steeds like anything.
 11 By these letters the king permitted
 The Jews who *were* in each town quitted
 To gather up and to defend
 Their lives, destroy, and kill and end
 Any forces that might pretend
 Of any folk or province that
 Would assault them where children sat
 And women, and to spoil their goods.

12 On one day and in all the woods
 Of King Ahasuerus, on
 The thirteenth *day* of twelfth month drawn,
 Which *is* the month of Adar's dawn.
 13 A copy of the document
 Was to be issued and then sent
 As a decree in every place
 And published for all the folks' trace,
 To make the Jews ready that day
 To avenge themselves in the fray.
 14 The runners riding royal steeds
 Went out quickly and pressed their needs
 By the kings orders. The decree
 Was given in Shushan's fortress fee.

It's Mordecai writes and signs the letter
 To right the wrongs and make the Jews feel
 better.

I wonder that the king so soon abused
 Would trust another man to point accused.
 I write Your words, Beloved, for You and
 trust

That they are as they should be and they
 must.

I pick them from the Hebrew and the dust
 And brush them with my cynical eye's
 light,

And with my youthful eye for beauty
 bright.

Beloved, I set Your favoured words in
 state,

And then I answer them in battle prate
 As though I spoke with lover or a man,
 As though You were my equal in the span
 Of human souls, the small and who seem
 great.

15 So Mordecai went out from
 The presence of the king in sum
 In royal clothing blue and white,
 With a great crown of gold in sight
 And a garment of linen fine
 And purple, and the town in sign
 Of Shushan rejoiced and was glad.

16 The Jews had light and gladness had,
 And joy and honour everywhere.

17 And in every province and town,
 Wherever the king's orders sound,
 The Jews had joy and gladness round,
 A feast and holiday about.
 Then many of the country's folk
 Became Jews, because of the stroke

Of fear of the Jews on them broke.

The blue and white and purple set the light
 Of Persian court out bright before the night.
 The blue and white and purple in the crown
 Bring happiness and joy to all the town.
 Some rave of red and others love the blue,
 Some grasp the green and others take the
 view

That yellow casts a richer, golden hue.
 But ancient Persians had an eye for true
 Blue and white and purple among the few.
 Beloved, I deck my soul in purple thread
 And place the blue and white upon my
 head

And come into Your courts of fir tree shed,
 Beneath the pines and aspens that have fed
 The squirrels, hares and mice above my
 bed.

They and I wait and pray here just for You.

Esther 9

1 In the twelfth month, that *is*, the month
 Of Adar, on the thirteenth day,
 Time came for the king's orders' sway
 That his decree be done at once.
 On the day that the enemies
 Of the Jews hoped for victories,
 The opposite occurred, in that
 The Jews themselves beat them out flat
 Who hated them. 2 The Jews around
 Gathered together on the ground
 In their cities throughout all lands
 Of King Ahasuerus hands
 Laying on those who sought their harm.
 No one could withstand their alarm,
 Because fear of them fell upon
 All people. 3 And all the chiefs drawn
 From provinces, the satraps and
 The governors, and all in hand
 To do the king's work, helped the Jews,
 Because fear of Mordecai
 Fell on them. 4 For Mordecai
 Was great in the king's palace pews,
 And his fame spread throughout the land,
 For this man Mordecai's stand
 Became greater ever more grand.
 5 The Jews defeated all their foes,
 With the stroke of the sword that goes
 With slaughter and destruction's woes,
 And did what they pleased with all those
 Who hated them. 6 And in Shushan

The fortress the Jews killed the clan
Of five hundred men in the plan.
7 Also Parshandatha, Dalphon,
Aspatha, 8 Poratha, the spawn
Of Adalia, Aridatha,
9 Parmashta, Arisai by law,
Aridai, and Vajezatha,
10 The ten sons of Haman the son
Of Hammedatha, the foe won
Of the Jews, they killed, but did not
Lay hands on the spoil in the plot.

You spoke commandment on the day that
You
Brought Israel out from the Egyptian crew,
That killing was prohibited. I think
That this final solution on the brink
Flies against every principle. You wink
Perhaps when the folk rose to kill the score
Of Haman's friends when banging on the
door,
And yet I cringe to say the self-defence
Is any thing of joy in Israel's tents.
But then perhaps one ought to joy in what
Is necessary when the door is shut.
I'll kill the gross intruder for the crime
Of stepping on my prose and on my rhyme,
And see if joy elates me in the mime.

11 On that day the number of those
Who were killed in Shushan where rose
The fortress was brought to the king.
12 The king told Queen Esther the thing,
"The Jews have killed in destroying
Five hundred men in Shushan's fort,
And ten sons of Haman in sport.
What have they done around the rest
Of the king's provinces for best?
So what *is* your petition now?
It shall be granted anyhow.
Or what *is* your further request?
It shall be done." 13 Then Esther said,
"If it please the king, let be sped
To the Jews in Shushan to do
Again tomorrow by the cue
Of this day's decree, and in view
Let Haman's ten sons be hanged too
On the gallows." 14 So the king said
"For this also to be outspread,
The decree was made in Shushan."
And they hanged Haman's ten sons' clan.
15 And the Jews who *were* in Shushan

Gathered together on the day
Fourteenth of month of Adar way
And killed three hundred men in sway
At Shushan, but they did not lay
A hand on the plunder that day.

From sweet petitioner of peace and love
Queen Esther in a day turns to above
Petitioner of ten lives at the noose.
The ugly duckling turns out to be goose.
Beloved, my rate of seeing how the wrong
Dispenses on the world in riot's song
Turns me too into war monger all along
The hedges of my wicket and my lane.
I do not yet petition You for gain,
Since I live fair and spare as any fane,
And yet my prayers for president and judge
Are speckled with petitions for the smudge.
Beloved, hear me or not, but see the grey
That steals upon the soul from day to day.

16 The rest of the Jews in the king's
Provinces gathered in the wings
Protecting their lives, and had rest
From their enemies, and killed best
Seventy-five thousand of their foes,
But laid no hand on spoils of those.
17 *This was* on the thirteenth day of
The month of Adar as above.
And on the fourteenth day they rested
And made a day of feasting vested
With gladness. 18 But Jews at Shushan
Assembled on the thirteenth van
As well as on the fourteenth, and
On the fifteenth they rested, and
Made it a day of feasting grand.
19 That's why the village Jews who dwelt
In the unwall'd towns always felt
Like celebrating day fourteen
Of Adar's month with gladness seen,
And feasting, as a holiday,
Exchanging gifts in joyful play.
20 And Mordecai wrote these things
And sent letters to all the wings
Of Jews, near and far, who *were* in
All the provinces with their kin,
The lands of King Ahasuerus,
21 Establish you each year to fear us
The fourteenth and the fifteenth days
Of the month of Adar for praise,
22 As the days on which Jews had rest
From their foes, as the month at best

Was turned from sorrow into joy
For them, and from mourning's employ
Into a holiday, that they
Should make them days of feast and joy,
Of sending gifts to one another
And also gifts to the poor brother.

The Jews still come in spring to drink in
bout
And turn a gift and cartwheel all about.
I've seen the neighbour in her shining dress
And sent my daughter to the fine address
To play with Jewish children at the hall
Where they are gathered under Esther's
pall.
My daughter was too shocked to see the
drink
Poured out faster than any man could think.
Fact is, Beloved, this book of Esther is
From start to finish a more winely fizz
Than any other in the sacred wheel.
I here oppose all drinking to a heel.
Let Purim rest uncelebrated if
The drunken only rise up in its skiff.

23 The Jews followed the custom right
That they had started from the fight,
As Mordecai wrote in sight,
24 Because Haman, the son and wight
Of Hammedatha Agagite,
The enemy of all the Jews,
Had plotted against the Jews' crews
To liquidate them, and cast lot
Or pur to consume them when fought,
25 But when she came before the king,
He ordered by epistle's sting
This wicked plan which he'd devised
Against the Jews should revised
On his own head, and that he and
His sons be hanged on gallows' band.
26 So they called these days Purim for
The name of Pur or lot. Therefore,
Because of all this letter's things,
What they had seen of this thing's springs,
And what had happened in their flings,
27 The Jews set it upon themselves
And their descendants on their shelves
And all who joined them, that without
Fail they should celebrate the shout
Of these two days every year, by
The decree and in the time's fly,
28 These days *should be* remembered and

Kept through each generation's band,
Each family, every province, and
Each city, that these days of great
Purim should not fail *nor be late*
Among the Jews, and their memory
Should not depart from children's fee.

If they just keep the drinking in the place
Where they are gathered in one kin and
race
I'll not complain for shout or din or trace
Of helpless failure to distinguish face
Of Haman or of Mordecai's grace.
But I'll not share the joy if joy it be
To bring the tainted cup in taste of me,
And I'll not harbour fancies of the spree
To mind Haman's fate and eternally.
Instead I raise a prayer to mind the time
That Hitler bore the brunt of wicked climb
To legislate a gross Haman-like crime.
There's nothing here to celebrate, I swear,
As I breathe the anti-semitic air.

29 Queen Esther, Abihail daughter,
With Mordecai the Jew with her,
Wrote with full power to confirm this
Second letter on Purim's bliss.
30 He sent letters to all the Jews,
One hundred twenty-seven *coups*
Of provinces of the kingdom
Of Ahasuerus, *with* words rum
Of peace and truth, 31 and to confirm
These days of Purim at their term
Appointed, as Mordecai
The Jew and Queen Esther for aye
Had set them up, as they decreed
For themselves and descendants' creed
In matters of their fasting and
Lamenting. 32 And so the command
Of Esther confirmed these things' look
Of Purim, written in the book.

The fast I take and multiply and find
That fasting is a thing to clear the mind.
I see the world through eyes that are not
blind.
The politics of my survival here
Are awful in intent as well as drear.
I have no folk to lobby for my gear
As I gather with family and tear
On Sabbath day to realize the stroke
Is sudden and forewarned not by a croak.

The evil eye about me could be shorn
As fast as once to read commandment born
On Sinai, but the reading still comes slow,
The heathen heart begins at once to glow
With violence against the humble show.

Esther 10

1 And King Ahasuerus laid
A tribute on the land and stayed
Islands of the sea. 2 Now the acts
Of all his power and might in facts,
And tale of Mordecai's feats,
In which the king advanced his treats,
Are they not written in the book
Of chronicles of kings that took
Rule of Media and Persian nook?
3 Mordecai the Jew *was set*
Next King Ahasuerus met,
Was great among the Jews and well
Received by crowds of Israel,
Seeking the good of his folk and
Speaking peace to all kin in band.

This book of Esther is a lovely thing,
And yet a throwback to the former king,
The son of Kish, the Benjamite, to sing
A late revival of that dynasty.
Set in the middle of the shining words
Of David's kingship over beast and birds,
The book of Esther comes down to relate
How ancient hopes and dreams of power
and state

Return perennially to small and great.
Beloved, the dynasties of human time
Revolve about the centuries sublime
To twinkle on the sudden breath of air
That rises unexpected from nowhere.
You only above all things see the share.

4 And Mordecai said "These things
Have come from Alohim on wings.
5 "For I remember the dream I
Had about these matters in sky,
And none of them has failed to be
Fulfilled. 6 "The tiny spring to see
That turned into a river, and
There was light and the sun too and
Abundant water, that stream is
Esther, whom the king took as his
Wife and made queen *of all the land*.
7 "The two dragons are Haman and
Myself. 8 "The nations are those that

Gathered to destroy where they're at
The name of all the Jews out flat.
9 "My nation, this is Israel,
Who cried out to Alohim well
And were saved. YHWH has saved His
folk,

YHWH has delivered from the stroke,
Alohim's done great signs and wonders,
Which have not occurred in such thunders
Among the nations. 10 "For this reason
He has made two lots in their season,
One for Alohim's people and
One for all the nations in band.
11 "And these two lots came to the hour
And moment and day of their power
Before Alohim and all lands.
12 "Alohim minded His folk's bands,
Affirming His heritage hands.
13 "So they will observe these days in
The month of Adar *without sin*,
On the fourteenth and fifteenth day
Of that month, with assembly's play
And joy and gladness before God,
For generations on the sod
Among Israel's folk in their way."

The dream of Mordecai with the wings
Of dragons seething fire of designings
Comes to float on the stream and river
where

Queen Esther is reflected as the fair
Chosen of heaven to make the pagan bare.
Truth is that Purim is a heathen rite
And sanctified by legend to be bright,
The Queen of heaven is taken down to be
The patron of the people faithfully
Beside the throne of justice where despair
Meets true reality upon the stair.
Beloved, I turn from queens of every ilk,
Despite fair Esther's gift of meat and milk,
And bear the woollen garb instead of silk.

Esther 11

1 Now in the fourth year of the reign
Of Ptolemy and for his gain
Cleopatra, Dositheus,
Who said he was a priest for fuss
And a Levite, and Ptolemy
His son brought to Egypt to see
This letter of Purim, which they
Said was truthful and had in way
Been translated by one to say

Lysimachus the son and ray
 Of Ptolemy, one of the gem
 Residents of Jerusalem.
 2 In the second year of the reign
 Of Artaxerxes the Great fane,
 On the first day of Nisan there,
 Mordecai the son of Jair,
 Son of Shimei, the son of Kish,
 Of the tribe of Benjamin's dish,
 Had a dream. 3 Now he was a Jew,
 Dwelling in the city and view
 Of Susa, a great man, to serve
 In court of the king *not to swerve*.
 4 He was one of the captives whom
 Nebuchadnezzar in the bloom
 Of king of Babylon had brought
 From Jerusalem with the sot
 Jeconiah king of Judea.
 And this was his dream then to see you:
 5 Behold, noise and confusion, and
 Thunders and earthquake on the land!
 6 And see, two great dragons came out,
 Both ready to fight in the rout,
 And they roared terribly about.
 7 And at their roaring every nation
 Prepared for war, to fight in station
 Against the nation of the just.
 8 And see, a day of darkness, lust
 And gloom and tribulation and
 Distress, affliction on the land!

The dragon stories of the Persians make
 A truce with dragons of more ancient stake
 Between the rivers of both time and quake.
 The second verse in Genesis appears
 To show the dragon too in all its fears,
 And from that time to Revelation's tears
 The dragons show their claws' twelve
 hundred years.
 The dragon stories still come to awake
 The dreamers from their hopeful sugar cake
 And drop the wishing well for Haman's
 sake.
 The heart of David too is pushed to tell
 How many dragons he's able to fell
 Until the faith of frozen Israel
 Arouses at the tolling of the bell.

9 And all the righteous nation lay
 In trouble, they feared evil's sway,
 Prepared to perish in the way.
 10 Then they cried out to Alohim,

And from their cry, as it would seem,
 A tiny spring, from which there came
 A mighty river, one of fame
 With an abundant water's stream.
 11 Light came, and the sun rose on high,
 And the lowly raised up thereby,
 And they consumed those honoured by.
 12 Mordecai saw in this dream
 What had determined Alohim
 To do, and after that he woke,
 He had it on his mind and spoke
 All day to understand the sense
 Of his dream as detail prevents.

The dragons and the stream in earthly plot,
 Opening gates of soil and water hot,
 Appear beneath another figure got
 That Mordecai does not see in gleams
 To translate to the reader of his themes.
 The light arising from the hidden bed
 Is also Persian myth of solar dread,
 To sit beside the earthly queen awhile,
 Celestial in benignity and smile.
 Beloved, the pagan plot of heaven's queen
 Peeks through the written words on human
 scene.

We cannot rid ourselves of mythic thought,
 The human mind is structured by the lot,
 And still You visit us as like as not.

Esther 12

1 Now Mordecai took his rest
 In the courtyard among the best,
 With Gabatha and Tharra, two
 Of the king's eunuchs who kept view
 Over the courtyard to invest.
 2 He overheard their conversation
 And sought out their purpose in ration,
 And learned that they were planning to
 Lay hands on Artaxerxes too,
 The king, and he informed the king
 About what they planned, everything.
 3 The king examined the two eunuchs,
 And when they confessed in their tunics,
 They were led to the execution.
 4 The king made record's institution
 Of these things, and Mordecai
 Wrote an account of them laid by.
 5 The king ordered Mordecai
 To serve in the court and thereby
 Rewarded him for all these things.
 6 But Haman, the son of the wings

Of Hammedatha, a Bougaean,
Was in great honour and to stay on
With the king, and he sought to hurt
Mordecai and his folk curt
Because of the two eunuchs' dirt.

The binding lines of kinship always take
A precedence on justice for the sake
Of nepotism. Anyone who runs
To serve a foreign king and shakes his buns
Must have agendas ready by the tons.
Haman is ready to support the crew
That comes from his own kin and country
too.

I too have kin in every race it seems,
And that is why though I love all in gleams,
I have no homeland nor community.
I alone am able with loyalty
To surmount the call of kinship in store.
But by the same token upon the floor,
No king would trust in my fidelity.

Esther 13

1 This is a copy of the letter.
"The Great King, Artaxerxes better,
To chiefs of hundred twenty-seven
Provinces *spread out under heaven*
From India to Ethiopia
And to the governors in law
Under them, *the king* writes *them* thus.
2 "As ruling chief of omnibus
And master of the whole world here,
Not puffed up with power to appear,
But acting always with just cause
And kindness to settle in laws
The lives of my subjects in peace
To make my kingdom a surcease
Of tranquil movement all around,
Setting up peace all men have found.
3 "When I asked counsellors how this
Might be brought about not to miss,
Haman, among us wise and sound,
Distinguished for unchanging round
Of good will and fidelity,
Attaining to second degree
In the kingdom, 4 "remarked that there
Was among all nations to share
In the world scattered hostile folk
Who have laws contrary in yoke
To those of every nation and
Constantly disregard command
Of kings, so unity that we

In honour cannot come to be
In the kingdom. 5 "We understand
That this people, and it alone,
Stands always opposing the throne
To all men, and perversely go
After a strange manner of show
In life and laws, as ill-disposed
To our government as disclosed,
To do all the harm that they can
So that our kingdom may not span
Stability. 6 "So we've decreed
That those shown to you with good speed
In the decretals of Haman,
Who is head of affairs, a man
As second counsel, shall all be
With wives and children utterly
Destroyed by sword of enemy
Without pity, without mercy,
On fourteenth day of the twelfth month,
Adar, of this present year once,
7 "So that those who have long been and
Are now hostile may in one band
Go to Hades in violence,
And leave our government from hence
Secure and untroubled in tents."

The king's a victim of the civil servant.
Beloved, see this and try to be observant.
Who have the power will often step aside
Pretending civil servants are so snide
And are so evil no one can abide.
No doubt, Beloved, the accusation's true,
But I ask who has made them so to do,
And who has paid their salary or worse
Let them get off the hook for every curse
Of their extortion on the public purse.
Beloved, the servants of the state are met
In evil only by the church's set.
Just think how clear the thing is now to me,
What wonders of iniquity You see!

8 Then Mordecai prayed to YHWH,
Calling to mind all works of YHWH.
He said 9 "O Lord, YHWH, King to rule
Over all things, for all the pool
Of universe is in your power
And there is no one like a tower
Against it if it is Your will
To save Israel *and save them still*.
10 "For You have made the heaven and
earth
And every wondered thing of worth,

11 "And You are Lord of all, there's none
 Who can resist you, YHWH, when done.
 12 "You know all things, You know, O
 YHWH,
 That not in insolence or pride
 Or love of glory on my side
 That I did this, refused to bow
 To this proud Haman anyhow.
 13 "For I would have willingly kissed
 The soles of his feet and not missed
 To save Israel! 14 "But I did this,
 That I might not set human glory
 Above the glory of God's story,
 And I'll not bow to any one
 But You, who are my Lord alone,
 And I'll not do these things in pride.
 15 "Now, O YHWH Alohim and King,
 Abraham's Alohim, take wing
 To save your people, for the eyes
 Of enemies here to despise
 Us to destruction, they desire
 To burn Your heritage with fire,
 That was Yours from the start entire.
 16 "Do not neglect Your portion, which
 You bought for Yourself from *the ditch
 Of the Nile and from Egypt's land.*
 17 "Hear my prayer, and have mercy on
 Your heritage, turn sorrow's dawn
 To feasting, that we may live on
 And sing praise to your name, O YHWH,
 Do not destroy the mouth of those
 Who praised You *on the day You chose.*"
 18 And all Israel cried mightily,
 For death was there for them to see.

 In all his praying sweetly to Your praise
 A Psalm most lovely in its chosen lays,
 I still find Mordecai justifying
 His actions against Haman in defying.
 The guilty conscience seeks a loving salve
 More than the innocent should ever have.
 He's innocent, it's true, and yet he went
 About to selling cousin in the tent
 Of marriage to achieve a better grasp
 On throne and power with folded hands to
 clasp.
 His motive was to save if needed folk
 Who were his relatives under Your yoke.
 But motive does not purify in all
 The stain of climbing up to power's call.

Esther 14

1 And Esther the queen panickedly
 Fled to YHWH in anxiety,
 2 She took off her splendid clothing
 And put on garments of distress
 Sackcloth of her bitter mourning,
 And instead of perfumes' address
 Of costly weal, covered her head
 With ashes and dung there outspread,
 And utterly humbled herself,
 And every part that she like elf
 Loved to adorn she covered in
 A tangled matt of hair within.
 3 And she prayed to YHWH Alohim
 Of Israel, and said "YHWH, You
 Only are our King, help me too,
 Who am alone and have no aid
 But You, 4 "for my danger is paid
 Into my hand. 5 "Since I was born
 I have heard in the tribe of scorn
 Of my kin *only* You, O YHWH,
 Took Israel from all nations' book,
 And our fathers from among all
 Their ancestors, to give in stall
 An everlasting heritage,
 And that You did for them in stage
 All that You promised age to age.
 6 "And now we have sinned before You,
 And You have given us to the crew
 Of enemies, 7 "because we bowed
 To glorify their gods *in crowd.*
 And You are righteous *only*, YHWH!

Confession of Queen Esther here relates
 No doubt to serving false gods in estates
 Of Judah in the generation past,
 And not to her own sin before the blast,
 Unless, of course, her roaming in the court
 Of Persian king entailed some idol sport.
 Confession of Queen Esther sees her hair
 All matted and let down in disrepair,
 And that alone's enough to catch Your eye,
 Beloved, to see the lovely matron sigh.
 The prayer of hope and despair in one
 breath
 Is all that is between the queen and death,
 And yet not even that is mine to take
 Who stand without a plea before Your
 stake.

8 "And now they are not satisfied
 That we in bitter slavery bide,
 But they've covenanted with their

Idols 9 “to abolish the share
 Of what Your mouth has ordained and
 To destroy Your heritage land,
 To stop the mouths of those who praise
 You and quench your altar and stays,
 Your house in glory, 10 and to ope
 The mouths of *foreign* folk to hope
 For praise of vain idols, in scope
 To magnify for every one,
 A mortal king *when he is done*.
 11 “O YHWH, do not surrender Your
 Rule to what has no being’s store,
 And don’t let them mock at our fate,
 But turn their plan on their own pate,
 And make example of the man
 Who made against us such a plan.
 12 “Remember, O Lord, make You known
 In this hour of affliction’s groan,
 And give me courage, King of gods
 And Master of all earth *and sods*.
 13 “Put eloquent words in my speech
 Before the lion, and turn each
 To hate the man who’s fighting us,
 So there may be end to his fuss,
 And those who take hope in his bus.
 14 “But save us by your hand, and aid
 Me, who am alone and afraid
 With no helper but you, O YHWH.

Brave queen! The beautiful and perfumed
 dame

Bows before You alone to plead Your
 name.

The idols of the heathen compensate
 For lack of zeal before the altar’s weight,
 And yet they covenant with joyful hate
 With idols in state to annihilate
 The people of the Lord, I see their game.
 Brave queen! We need a queen like her
 today,

Who stand before the idols that bear sway
 In market place for coffee and for flood
 Of oil dredged up and paid with human
 blood.

To buy the very food our mouths now taste
 Requires the competition of that waste,
 Their price is guaranteed by business aced.

15 “You have knowledge of all things true,
 And You know that I hate the great
 Splendour of the wicked in state,
 Abhor the bed uncircumcised

And of the alien appraised.

16 “And You know my necessity,
 That I hate the sign of the fee
 Of my position on my head
 The days I appear to my dread
 In public. I abhor it like

A menstruous rag, and do not strike
 To wear it on the days when I
 Am at leisure. 17 “And as I cry
 Your servant has not eaten at
 Haman’s table, and I’ve not sat
 To honour the king’s feast or drunk
 The wine of the libations sunk.

18 “Your servant has had no joy since
 The day that I was brought to wince
 Here until now, except in You,
 YHWH, Abraham’s Alohim too.

19 “O Alohim, whose might’s on all,
 Hear the voice of despairing call,
 And save us from the wicked hand,
 And save me from my fear to stand!”

Queen Esther is not shy to tell You that
 She is disgusted by the night-time mat
 Upon which the uncircumcised has lain
 To father upon her his ugly stain.

If good Queen Esther is so loath to lie
 With Artaxerxes for his penile pie,
 She must be good at hiding it, for fie!
 She’s chosen above all the others who
 Would only be too glad to lie and do.

Beloved, I take in cautious faith the word
 That Esther spoke, and believe what
 occurred,

And without doubt conceive her horror
 stayed

Every time she came to his bed and played.
 You only have the human heart displayed.

Esther 15

1 The third day, when she ended prayer,
 She took off the garments with care
 In which she had worshiped, and made
 Herself in splendid clothes arrayed.

2 Majestically adorned, the aid
 Of the all-seeing God invoked
 As Saviour, she took two maids cloaked
 With her, 3 to lean daintily on,

4 While one followed to dote upon
 Her train. 5 She shone with perfect grace,
 She looked happy in heart and face,
 As if beloved, but her heart froze

With fear within her as she rose.
6 When she had gone through all the doors,
She stood upon the king's own floors.
Seated upon his royal throne,
He was arrayed in majesty,
Covered with gold and precious stone,
Most terrifying one to see.

I come before Your throne, Beloved, and
wear
No longer sackcloth nor the ragged bare
Wool clothing of the dervish, but I place
Upon my heart and hands and feet and face
The jewelled marks of golden love and
grace
That I receive from You in morning's trace,
The universe lit up with what I wear
Of spangles showered on me everywhere.
Like Esther with her crown of stars to share
The morning light, I come to You and sing
The Psalm the morning pages come to
bring,
In chorus of the titmouse on the wing,
With shy notes of the hare to nibble twig,
I waken to Your love of grape and fig.

7 Lifting his face, flushed in splendour,
He looked at her with fierce anger.
The queen stopped, and turned pale and
faint,
Collapsing on her maid's restraint
Who went before her. 8 Then God turned
The king's spirit to gentle learned,
Alarmed he sprang down from his throne
And took her in his arms alone
Until she came to herself. And
He comforted her, soothing brand,
And said to her, 9 "What is it, Esther?
I am just your brother investor.
Take courage, 10 you shall not die, for
Our law's only to the folk's score.
Come near." 11 He raised the golden
sceptre
And touched it to her neck, 12 and kept her,
And said, "Speak to me." 13 And she said
To him, "I saw you, my lord, led
Like an angel of God and my
Heart was shaken with fear at cry
Of your glory. 14 For you are great,
My lord, and your face without hate
Is full of grace." 15 But as she spoke,
She fell fainting as at a stroke.

16 The king was agitated, and
His servants tried to give a hand.

I faint for fear and grief to see Your brow
In anger turned on me, who pull Your
plough.
The tantrum that You work upon the sky
Turned red and angry with the morning cry
I bear as bear I can, and turn away
From all the glory thrust upon my day.
Beloved, I turn and return as the guest
Replies to the abundance to invest
The breakfast table rich with meal and fruit
More than I need or could in naked boot.
The sounding wrath of thunder on my ears
Awakens to the morning-tide of fears,
And Sinai grips my heart and lets me go
No further than the lightnings' glories
show.

Esther 16

1 Here follows the letter he wrote.
"The Great King, Artaxerxes' note,
To rulers of the provinces
From India westward to what is
Ethiopia, one hundred
And twenty-seven satrapies,
And to those who are loyal bred
To our reign, greeting from the head.
2 "The more they're honored by too great
Kindness of benefactors' state,
The more proud many men become.
3 "They seek not just to injure some
Of our subjects, but in their great
Ineptitude to stand the rate
Of good they even try to scheme
Against their own patrons in dream.
4 "Not only do they take away
Gratefulness from the human sway,
But drawn by boasts of those who know
Nothing of goodness, only show,
They reckon they'll escape the row
Of evil-hating justice that
Is God's, who sees all things out flat.
5 "And often many of those who
Are set in places of power true
Have been made to participate
In shedding innocent blood's rate,
Calamities not to repair
By persuasion of friends who dare,
Entrusted with public affair,
6 "When these men by false trickery

Of their evil natures to plea
Beguile the sincere good will of
Their sovereigns spoken of above.
7 “What has been wickedly done by
The pestilent behaviour’s try
Of those who wield power wickedly,
Not from old records can it be
Seen as much as what’s now to hand.

The king is not too happy to be tricked.
That’s something in a warning to the
picked

Who run the day to day for kings and men
Who govern at the heights of halogen.
Who seek the service of the crown beware
To do in everything only what’s fair,
And what is known to prince before the
eyes

Of servants and marauders in disguise.
Beloved, I find Your service in this state
Both hard and easy in my temperate
Life fraught with rest and leisure by the
great.

The books are stacked against me, though,
since You
Never say anything to chide Your crew,
Unless I find it in Your Scriptures true.

8 “In future we’ll take care to brand
Our kingdom quiet and in peace
For all men, 9 “by changing release,
And always judging what comes under
Our eyes with more justice than wonder.
10 “Haman, the son of Hammedatha,
A Macedonian disaster
Really an alien to the blood
Persian, and quite devoid of flood
Of our kindness, having been
Our guest, 11 “so far enjoyed with sin
The good will that we have for each
And every nation in our reach
That he was called our counsellor
And always bowed down to before
By all as the one second to
The royal throne of all the crew.
12 “Unable to restrain his pride,
He tried to take our reign beside
And snuff out our life in the tide.
13 “With craft and deceit he desired
Destruction of Mordecai,
Our saviour, benefactor fired,
And of Esther, the blameless, shy

Partner of our kingdom, to make
Destruction for their nation’s sake.
14 “He thought in this way he would find
Us undefended and would bind
The kingdom of the Persians to
The Macedonians in crew.

The king is certain all the blame’s to find
In fact that Haman is another kind.
If he had been a Persian, he’d have shown
The kindness of Persian as home-grown.
But since he was a Macedonian,
His tale is filled with grief and greed as
can,
And everywhere he goes try as he will
He cannot escape ethnic cleansing’s bill.
Beloved, racism is a splendoured sport
Relieving all men of their sin at court,
And giving excuse for the last retort.
Racism is the grace that sets all free
Who are within the kingly company,
And justifies the ways and means to be.

15 “But we find that the Jews consigned
To liquidation by this man
Above all cursed, are in the plan
Not evildoers but are kept
By most righteous laws 16 “and are apt
Sons of the Most High mighty God,
Lifting above the earth and sod,
Who’s led the kingdom both for us
And for our ancestors in bus.
17 “You will therefore do well not to
Put in execution the cue
Of letters sent by Haman son
Of Hammedatha, 18 “since the one
Himself who did these things has been
Hanged at Susa’s gate for his sin,
With all his household in the din.
For God, who rules over all things,
Has quickly inflicted his stings,
The punishment that he deserved.
19 “Therefore post a copy unswerved
Of this letter publicly in
Every place, and permit the bin
Of Jews to live by their own laws.
20 “And give them reinforcements’ claws,
So that on the thirteenth day of
The twelfth month of Adar above,
On that very day they may take
To defend themselves for the sake
Of those who attack them at time

Of their affliction as a crime.
21 "For God, who rules over all things,
Has made this day to be new springs
Of joy to his chosen instead
Of a day of destruction's dread.

The king is glad to help the Jews when they
Turn out to support him in every way.
But if the royal interests of the day
Were turned to left or right and there to
stay,

He'd soon turn back to Haman for the help
Of Haman's ruthless hand and for his
whelp.

The king is glad to aid when things look
like

He needs the Jews to protect him from
spike,

And so he lends a hand to help them slay
Their enemies upon that fateful pay.
The Persian contact was a help in time,
But when Alexander arose to climb,
He left a legacy to harry Jews
Who helped the Persians combat Grecian
views.

22 "Therefore you shall observe all this
With all good cheer as not to miss
A holiday among your fêtes

Of commemorative banquets,
23 "So that both now and here to come
It may mean salvation in some
For us and loyal Persians' hosts,
But that for those who plot in boasts
Against us it may be reminder
Of destruction of the unkind.

24 "Every city and country here
That does not act by this in fear
Shall be destroyed in wrath with spear
And fire. It shall be made not just
Impassable for men, but must
Also most hateful for all time
To beasts and birds *in prose and rhyme.* "

Beloved, I think back on the Persian queen,
Named Hadassah and Esther on the scene
Of ruthless competition for the throne,
And wonder that men are so wicked grown.
Beloved, I think back on the little girl
Who had no choice but marry blackened
churl,

And weep to think that Esther may have
had

A secret love at home that made her sad.
All things of hope and happiness must set
Before the need of country to be met.

I stand aside from matters that relate
To crowns and presidents, and heads of
state,

And rather think if this year's mushrooms
will

Be thick enough upon the berry hill.

1 Maccabees

The first book of Maccabees is a wonderful witness to divine law, and as such is a pivotal passage in this entire work. It was composed at the end of the second century B.C.E. and relates to the opposition of the Hasmonean dynasty to the Hellenizing attempts of Alexander's heirs. Despite its affirmation of divine law, it is somewhat anomalous in this volume of the New Jubilees Version, since it glorifies a non-Davidic regime.

This versification is based on the Septuagint Greek texts with reference to its several translations.

As post-exilic literature, the books of Maccabees showed the pinnacle of resistance to imperial hostility. They represent simple diplomacy and military intervention. As this is the most obvious response to the imperial situation, the books represent the central literature dealing with the issue. At the same time they define the moral parameters of resort to military intervention.

The issue of just warfare is well dealt with in the books, especially since we are faced with an un-authorized regime, one that is non-Davidic. The books suggest that a regime is acceptable if it affirms and conforms to divine law. Such a regime, even without divine appointment, has the authority to make violent warfare on an imperial regime, one that does not recognize divine law. However, despite the presentation of military boldness, there is a high degree of reliance on direct divine intervention. This one factor mitigates

against justifying military intervention in situations other than the specific historical events referred to in the book itself. Miraculous divine intervention is one strand of validity, and where it does not exist, validity can be called into question.

1 Maccabees 1

1 When Alexander who was son
To Philip Macedonian,
Come from Kittim's land, had defeated
Darius, king of Persians, seated
With Medes, succeeded him as king,
Who ruled before the Grecian thing,
2 He fought many battles, and took
Fortresses, put to death and shook
The kings of the earth. 3 He went to
The ends of the earth, it is true,
And plundered many peoples. When
Earth was subdued before his men,
He was exalted, his heart proud.
4 He gathered a strong force and loud,
And ruled over countries, and nations,
And gave to princes lowly stations.
5 After this he was ill and knew
Death was near. 6 So he called the few
His most honoured officers, who
Had been brought up with him from youth,
And shared out his kingdom in truth
With them while he was still alive.
He reigned twelve years, *brave to survive*,
And then *great* Alexander died,
And probably dissatisfied.

Good leadership abilities are found
In Alexander, I am blessed and bound.
But You, Beloved, have no faith in the wit
Of the exalted with proud heart to fit.
Your view of Alexander is that he
Failed in very basic humanity.
He's famous now as one of the world's
greats,
And in a century will have as mates
Hitler and Stalin who with time will be
Admired as much as Alexander's key.
As soon as the close relatives of those
Destroyed by these and such blood-thirsty
foes
Are dead, the reputation of the vile
Is fit to meet the genteelest in smile.

The rule of Alexander is well known

And mention of his exploits also shown
In Your Word, My Beloved, to let men see
That pride and ambition's a slavery.
He went to the ends of the earth to seek
The quenching of his thirst to kill the meek
And found no rest for soul or body yet.
He failed to keep Your statutes and to get
Long life from them. Beloved, I see the
way

His emulators crush and eat the day
And fall with nothing of worth when they
come

To end of life and stop to hear the sum.
Beloved, I see the battles and the death
That lays hold on the human heart and
breath.

8 His officers began to rule,
Each in his own allotted pool.
9 They all wore crowns after his death,
As did their sons to fortieth,
And they caused many evil things
Upon the earth while they were kings.
10 Out of them came a wicked root,
Antiochus Epiphanes,
Son of Antiochus to boot,
A king hostage in Rome *at ease*.
The Greeks had been in power for years,
One hundred thirty-seven years,
When he began to reign to *jeers*.
11 In those days lawless men came out
From Israel, and caused men to doubt,
And said "Let us go make a treaty
With the Gentiles, it has been *sleety*
And quite unlucky for us since
We parted from the Grecian prince."

There always seem to be some folk who
claim
To be Your people, but they all the same
Run after the great who love the false gods
That try to rule the earth with iron rods.
And such would make a treaty with unjust
Who hope to steal the poor widow's last
crust,
And call the act freedom for humankind,
Whose eyes for advertisements make them
blind.

Beloved, though the economy may be
Unsound since the day Alexander's free
Rein was dropped to the earth, I do not care
To seek my daily bread and wealth from air

Breathed by the humble and the poor of
earth.
I find Your commandments of greater
worth.

12 And this suggestion pleased them all,
13 And some went eagerly to call
The king who gave them their permission
To follow Gentile ways' commission.
14 So they built a gymnasium
Within holy Jerusalem,
According to Gentile custom,
15 And stretched their foreskins down to
hide
Abandoned covenant aside.
They joined the Gentiles wickedly.
16 When Antiochus came to see
His kingdom was established, he
Determined to set Egypt free
And rule both kingdoms finally.

Whether the language means they tried to
stretch
Their foreskins or they left alone to fetch
The circumcision for another time,
The thing is a rebellion and a crime.
I would not make an issue of the thing
Since it is not mentioned with special ring
In the commandments that You came to
preach
On Sinai, but it is a thing to reach
Since Abraham was justified when he
Obeyed Your word to hold and to a T.
The reason for the action was the fact
That they were running naked in the act
In the Grecian gymnasium to seek
Conformity to heathen claw and beak.

17 So he invaded Egypt by
A strong force, *and to terrify*
With chariot and elephant
And horsemen and ships to the front.
18 Then he met Ptolemy, the king
Of Egypt, and in battle ring,
Made Ptolemy turn round in flight
Before him, falling left and right
The many wounded. 19 And they captured
The forts of Egypt, and enraptured
They plundered all the land. 20 When done
Subduing Egypt, Antiochus,
Returning *proud and loud and raucous*,
Arrived again and having won

In the one hundred forty-third
Year of the Grecian reign *referred*.
He went against Israel and came
With force up to Jerusalem.
21 He arrogantly entered in
The sanctuary and *with sin*
Took golden altar, the lampstand
And all its vessels in command.
22 He also took the shewbread table
The cups for drink offerings as able,
The bowls, the golden censers, too,
The curtain, crowns, the golden hue
Of decoration at the front,
He stripped the temple *to be blunt*.
23 He took the silver and the gold,
The valued vessels, and the old
And hidden treasures that he found.
24 He took them all and then was bound
To his own land. He murdered much
And spoke with arrogance and such.

The man is known to follow in the ways
Of his forefather as it were, commander
And heathen model, the king Alexander.
For Antiochus is no man to praise.
It's better I believe the temple should
Be in the stony chamber and the wood
Of the heart rather than made of such stuff
That must entice the willing and the gruff.
Beloved, I lay my hidden temple well
Within the heart unshown to Israel,
Within the soul unknown by Antiochus
Whose always made a mess both loud and
raucous.
I find my temple beyond hand of crime,
Its gold and silver love, mercy, and rhyme.

25 The Israelite folk everywhere
Were deeply sorrowed, in despair.
26 The rulers and the elders groaned,
Both maidens and the young men moaned,
The beauty of the women faded.
27 Every bridegroom also looked jaded,
The bride sat mourning in her closet.
28 Even the land shook in deposit
For its inhabitants, and name,
All Jacob's house was filled with shame.
29 Two years later the king sent to
The towns of Judah taxes due,
A chief collector stole along
Jerusalem with armies strong.

Beloved, see this, whenever a man steals
The first thing that he takes to silver heels
Is right to tax. The tax increase these days
Is called a tax cut, since they've seen it

pays

To talk in advertising lingo joining
The line of market that goes on purloining.
The tax increase these days is called tax
break

Because they break the backs of those at
stake.

Beloved, I follow money's shaven sound
Without much interest, since upon the
ground

There's food enough to make table abound
And onions and garlic smell all around
The place where I move, sleep and can be
found

To work with hoe and shovel and with
rake.

30 He spoke in peace words of deceit
And they believed him till they beat
And struck the city by surprise,
Destroyed the folk before their eyes,
A heavy blow on Israel,
They struck severely, many fell.

31 He plundered all the city, burned
With fire, and tore its houses down,
He tore its houses down and turned
And broke the walls around the town.

32 Both women and children they seized,
And all the cattle that they pleased.

33 The city of David they built
With a strong wall and towers and gilt
34 And stationed there a sinful folk
And lawless people to provoke.

These strengthened their position and
35 They stored up arms and food and
manned

The spoiling of Jerusalem,
And stored the spoils there for income,
A tribulation and a snare.

36 It was an evil ambush there
Against the temple, adversary
To Israel ubiquitary.

37 On each side of the sanctuary
They shed blood innocent, unwary,
Even defiled the sanctuary.

38 Because of them each resident
Of the holy city all went,
And she became a dwelling-place

Of strangers, and even her face
Became strange to her offspring, and
Her children *all* forsook her land.

The truth is Alexander's horde did not
Invent the station and the horrid lot
Of civil servants, they were known before
At least in every Persian sort of store.
Epiphanes may well set up for life
The civil servants that pleased both his wife
And himself with their tax collecting skills.
But civil servants never cured the ills
Of any city, state or countryside.
Instead with civil servants to deride
The rulers have more time to preen their
pride.

Beloved, save me from civil servants now,
The bane of every government somehow,
No matter whether kingdom or the row.

39 Her sanctuary became void,
Desolate as desert employed,
Her feasts were turned to mourning, and
Her Sabbaths reproach *in the land*,
And all her honour to contempt.
40 Her dishonor now *not exempt*
Grew as great as had been her glory,
Her height into a mournful story.

Three things abound when heathen faith
comes out

To sport and pretend that it's not a lout.
The first to go is Sabbath rest, indeed
No king accepts such affront to his creed.
The second thing's the right to kill a hog
And eat it to despite the Decalogue.
The third thing is to keep the penis ready
To show in the playground to Jill and
Freddy.

These are the three great practices that set
The heathen altar up to all gods met
And deny Your laws and Your name until
You intervene to put them on the pill.
Beloved, I shake my head both wise and
slow
And remind You once more I told You so.

41 Then the king wrote to his whole land
That all should be one people's band,
42 And each should give his customs up.
43 All the Gentiles took up the cup
Commanded by the king, many

Even from Israel then gladly
 Adopted his religion, they
 Sacrificed to idols, the day
 Of the Sabbath profaned. 44 The king
 Sent letters by messengers' wing
 To Jerusalem and the cities
 Of Judah, to follow the witties
 That were foreign to the land and
 45 Forbidding holocausts *in hand*
 And sacrifices and drink offerings
 In the sanctuary *in profferings*,
 To profane Sabbaths and the feasts,
 46 To defile the temple and priests,
 47 To build altars, and sacred courts
 And shrines for idols *in cohorts*,
 To sacrifice swine and unclean
 Beasts, 48 and to leave their sons *unseen*,
 Uncircumcised. They were to make
 Themselves abominable for sake
 Of everything unclean, profane,
 49 So that they should forget the gain
 Of law and change all ordinance.
 50 "And whoever does not make dance,
 Obeying the command of king
 Shall die." 51 And in such words the thing
 He wrote to his whole kingdom, and
 He set inspectors over hand
 Of all the people with command
 To the cities of Judah to
 Offer sacrifices *as due*,
 City by city. 52 Many of
 The people, every one *above*
 Who forsook the law, joined them, and
 They did evil things in the land,
 53 They drove Israel into hiding
 In every place of refuge biding.

Permission to ignore Your law is bent
 As freedom and true righteousness when
 meant
 To destroy the good will Your command
 raises
 Between children and parents for their
 praises.
 Who reject Your commandment always
 come
 To do evil upon the land and hum
 The din of idol music everywhere
 Until the righteous must hide in despair.
 Beloved, here perched upon the granite
 slope
 That raises above lake and forest rope

With every kind of joy and every hope,
 I see the glories silently attend
 The hours and minutes where they rightly
 wend
 Above the flowers of snow or blooms
 attend.

54 Now on the fifteenth of Chislew,
 In one hundred forty-fifth year,
 They set up sacrilege aggrieve
 On altar of burnt offering's bier.
 They also built altars around
 In Judah's cities on the ground,
 55 And burned incense at the house doors
 And in the streets. 56 The books of *mores*
 And law which they found they tore to
 Pieces and burned with fire's *due*.
 57 Where the book of the covenant
 Was found in any house or tent,
 Or if any one kept the law,
 The decree of the king *by claw*
 Condemned him to death. 58 They kept
 using
 Violence to Israel's abusing,
 Against those month after month found
 In the cities *in every round*.

Your Word was burned then in the grossest
 hate
 By very ones who should have not been
 late
 To follow everything that You relate.
 The evil of the times returns and comes
 To follow in the cycle of their rums.
 There always are such sitting on their
 bums.
 Today Your Word is rarely burned with
 zeal
 Outside the pale of Saudis at the keel,
 But rather with the fancy flux of books
 And movies that attract instead our looks.
 Distraction from Your Words is like as not
 To be a better way in wicked plot
 To reduce what You say to humankind
 From nourishment and sweetness to sour
 rind.

59 And on the twenty-fifth day of
 The month they offered up above
 A sacrifice upon the altar
 Which was upon burnt offering's altar.
 60 According to the decree, they

Put to death the women whose way
 Was to have children circumcised,
 61 And their families and those *apprised*
 Who circumcised them, and they hung
 The infants from their mothers' necks.
 62 But many in Israel stood firm
 And were resolved in heart and tongue
 Not to eat unclean food's *complex*.
 63 They chose to die rather than squirm
 Defiled by food or to profane
 The holy covenant *and Name*,
 And they did die. 64 And very great
 Wrath came down upon Israel's *pate*.

The Christian doctrine of the Greeks
 appears
 Here for the first time in coloured arrears.
 Though Paul says not a word about the way
 Babies should be treated on the eighth day,
 But rather toots the Hellenistic bent
 Of proselyte without the stone knife lent,
 The Greekish churchmen join the Roman
 crowd
 In saying circumcision's not allowed.
 The nature of that heart and that command
 If evident if folk would understand
 It's but continuing to follow on
 The way Antiochus Epiphanes
 Treated the mothers from sunset till dawn
 To bring Your followers down to their
 knees.

1 Maccabees 2

1 In those days Mattathias son
 Of John, the son of Simeon,
 A priest of sons of Joarib,
 Moved from Jerusalem to crib
 In Modein. 2 He had five sons, John
 Surnamed Gaddi, 3 and one Simon
 Called Thassi, 4 Judas Maccabeus,
 5 Eleazar called Avaran, stay us
 With Jonathan *at last* called Apphus.

Five sons make up the house of righteous
 ones,
 My great grandfather had five in his loving
 care,
 And there were five under the mantle there
 When Muhammad challenged the stars and
 suns.
 Each righteous man has his own task to do.
 One is a diplomat and signs the treaty

To make the world sunny and not so sleety.
 Another fights the fight and dies for You.
 Some quaff the nectar, others by the side
 Of the Euphrates have no drink but thirst
 And watch the children suck the dry bag
 dry.
 But all beneath the mantle where they bide
 Despite the cordial fate, despite the worst
 Receive at last reward beneath the sky.

6 He saw blasphemies being done
 In Judah and Jerusalem,
 7 And said, "Alas! Why was the sun
 Risen on my birth to condemn
 Destruction of my folk and more
 Upon the holy city's store,
 For me to live there while it's thrust
 In the hand of the foe like dust,
 The sanctuary given up
 Into the rim of foreign cup?
 8 "Her temple's like a man without
 Honour, 9 "her glorious vessels rout
 Into captivity. Her babes
 Have been killed in her streets *like graves*,
 Her young men by the sword of foe.
 10 "What nation now comes up to show
 Heir of her temples and has not
 Grabbed all the booty of her lot?
 11 "All her bedecking's thrown away,
 Lost freedom, she's in a slave's way.
 12 "Indeed, our sanctuary and
 Our ornament and glory's stand
 Have been wasted by Gentiles' hand.
 13 "Why should we live longer and stand?"

The sanctuary of today is set
 In heavenly places, but in Psalms I've met
 Your habitation, my Beloved, to get
 The holy unction on both my ears wet.
 And yet I see the desecration now
 That once darkened the bravely shining
 brow
 Of Mattathias when he heard the din
 Of heathen sacrifice in his folk's sin.
 I too see every church filled with the smoke
 And strobe lights of the devils there to
 croak.
 I hear the synagogue set out in pain
 To mimic rock concert as though insane.
 I find the desecration of the mosque
 Is welcomed like sweets sold at corner
 kiosk.

14 And Mattathias and his sons tore
Their clothes, put on sackcloth they wore,
And sorrowed much *upon the floor*.

15 The king's men who imposed the way
Of the apostasy to stay
Came to the city of Modein
To make them sacrifice in vain.

16 Many of Israel came to them,
And Mattathias and his gem
Of sons were gathered at his hem.

17 The king's men said to Mattathias
In this wise, though the man was pious,
"You are an honoured leader here
In this city, and have your gear
Of sons and brothers for support.

18 "So lead the way up to the fort
According to the king's commands,
Just like the Gentiles and the bands
Of men in Judah and those left
There in Jerusalem as deft
Have done. And then you and your sons
Will be accounted on your buns
As favourites of the king's tons,
Honoured with silver and with gold,
And many gifts, *having been sold*."

Nobody offers me a gift and prize
To enter in the meeting of the wise,
The senate or the church, they just despise
My ways of doing things under the guise
Of poverty in humble cabin set
Beside the well, under the hill well met.
If I am offered worldly fame and gold
For worshipping the image of the bold
And beatable within the heathen fold
That contemplates the church and
 synagogue
From the mosque porch beneath the smoke
 and smog,
I trow I'll take it all at once and be
A princely figure on the rocky spree,
Head of a profitable company!

19 But Mattathias answered saying
In a loud voice where he was braying,
"Even if all the nations that
Live under the rule on the mat
Of the king to obey his voice,
Following his orders by choice,
Giving up each one the faith of
His ancestors handed in love,

20 "Still I and my sons and my brothers
Will keep the covenant of mothers
And fathers handed down to us.

21 "We'll not desert the law to curse.

22 "We will not obey the king's words
By turning from our faith to turds
On the right hand or on the left."

Ah, what a noble courage from the breast
Appears in these great words finely
 expressed!

The rhetoric alone left me impressed!
Maybe I too could be carried away
By high feelings of piety in sway
To Your faith, My Beloved, and to obey.
But since no one here stops me from the
 truth,

Nor even cares if I have from my youth
Kept covenant with You to mark my week
With Saturdays in rest and have the cheek
Not to kill or to steal, my resolve may
Diminish without obstructions to play.
So foolish is the human heart I see,
We must be opposed once to disagree.

23 When he had finished what he said,
A Jew came forward without dread
Of all there watching and he laid
An offering on the altar stayed
In Modein by the king's charade.

24 When Mattathias saw it, he
Flamed up with zeal and jealousy.
He vented righteous wrath as he
Ran and killed him at altar's knee.

25 He also killed the king's sent man
Who enforced sacrificial plan,
And tore down the altar in span.

26 And so he burned for the law's zeal,
As Phinehas did at the heel
Of Zimri the son of Salu.

27 So Mattathias shouted to
The city with a loud voice, saying
"Let every one who's zealous praying
For the law and keeps covenant
Join me now where I have been sent!"

28 And he and his sons fled abroad
To the hills and left all the squad
Of what they had on the town's sod.

The law says not to kill. Now what I think
Is that these people on the zealous brink
Of war are very much like those who say

They support ten commandments in the
way
And publish their names in conspiracy,
But fail in faith of one God and not three,
Neglecting Sabbath day for their Sunday.
If Mattathias really kept the law,
He'd think twice about using forceful claw
To kill the king's man. Provocation great
Of course inspired him to his deed of fate.
It's always easy to remember when
Some priest or favoured people of the men
Committed holy outrage in the fen.

29 Then many who sought righteousness
And justice went to wilderness
To stay there, 30 they, their sons, their
wives,
And their cattle as it contrives,
Because of the iniquity
Oppressing them so heavily.
31 And it was told to the king's men,
And to the armies in the den
Of David's town, Jerusalem,
That men had gone in stratagem
Against the orders of the king
And hidden by the desert spring.
32 Many pursued them, overtook
Them, they encamped near by their nook,
Ready to fight them on the day
Of the Sabbath to hold their sway.
33 And they said to them, "That's enough!
Surrender to the king, be tough
And do what he says and you'll live."
34 But they said, "We will not forgive,
Come out, nor will we do the thing
That has been ordered by the king
To break the Sabbath day on wing."
35 So their foes came to the attack.

These people were not those who killed the
man
Sent by the king to speak to them in plan.
These are the ones who also came and ran
Away from evil plots and murder's fan.
They stood to take decision they would die
Rather than live in a world on the sly,
And keep Your law down to the very end.
The righteous thus were killed to the last
friend.
Beloved, I wonder if on all the earth
There lives a man or woman of great worth.

Who live are those who compromise the
faith,
First of all by betraying into wraith
The life of any man they choose to bring
Against the altar for a song to sing.

36 But they did not give answer back
Or throw a stone or block the way
To their hiding places that day,
37 But they said, "Let's all die right now
In innocence, before the row
Both heaven and earth will testify
That we came unjustly to die."
38 So they fought them on Sabbath day,
And they were killed with wives to stay
And children and cattle in count
Of a thousand people's amount.
39 When Mattathias and his friends
Heard about that they grieved no ends.
40 And they said to each other then,
"If we all as our brother men
Do and refuse to fight Gentile
For our lives and law without guile,
They'll soon wipe us from off the earth."
41 So they took decision of worth,
"Let's fight all those who attack us
On the Sabbath day with a fuss
And not die as our brothers died
In the places they went to hide."

Who started out with killing the king's man
Were only consistent within the plan
To forget Sabbath day and its clear ban.
The justification is innocent:
We have to do the thing and so prevent
The destruction of faithful from the earth.
No thought that the prevention in its worth
Destroyed at once the faithful for all time.
Beloved, the times were bad, philosophy
And thinking clear where not good
company.

Give me excuse instead to keep Your law
Despite the wicked movement in the crawl,
And innocent or not in head and heart,
Let me at least put hand to do Your part.

42 Hasideans gathered with them,
Great fighting men of Israel's hem,
Each giving himself for the law.
43 And everybody who then saw
Reason to leave society,
Joined them and increased company.

44 They became an armed band and slew
 Sinners in their wrath and the crew
 Of lawless men, and those escaped
 Fled to the Gentiles whom they aped
 For safety. 45 And Mattathias
 And his friends went about in gas
 And threw down the altars in pass,
 46 They forcibly circumcised all
 The uncircumcised boys in thrall
 That they found in Israel's land's stall.
 47 They hunted down proud men and so
 They succeeded in their own show.
 48 They rescued the law from the hand
 Of Gentile and the kings in band,
 Let no sinner gain upper hand.

A band of terrorists is what they were,
 These sons of Mattathias on the spur.
 And like the terrorists they do awaken
 A bit of awe even in just hearts shaken.
 I really would not mind to see some boys
 In Europe or America like toys
 Taken in hand and circumcised for joys
 And forced into the ranks of honest men.
 Too often Paul's words have been
 misapplied
 To prove that Your law has been set aside.
 Beloved, I smile at raging robbers' den
 And wish a few of such might live again.
 Beloved, I wince to see the presidents
 In arms against the circumcised of sense.

49 The time of Mattathias' death
 Came near and he said with last breath
 To his sons, "Arrogance and chiding
 Have increased and come out of hiding,
 It's a time of destruction and
 Raging anger about the land.
 50 "So, my sons, show zeal for the law,
 And give up your lives in the awe
 Of the ancestral covenant.
 51 "Remember our ancestors' deed,
 The things they used to do with cant,
 And so receive honour with speed
 And an eternal fame in slant.
 52 "Was not Abraham faithful found
 When tested, and it was the ground
 Of counting him in righteousness?
 53 "Joseph in time of his distress
 Kept the commandment, and became
 The ruler of Egypt for fame.
 54 "Phinehas our father, because

He was deeply zealous for laws,
 Received the covenant of gain,
 Eternal priesthood and not vain."

Phinehas was one of the violent,
 Who struck even when Moses was all spent
 And failed to raise a hand to stay the plot
 Of Baal Peor to set up idol's lot.
 He too forgot the law that one should not
 Kill, but took up the lance against the two
 Who worshipped degradation in plain view.
 Perhaps the commandments are in a line,
 The order giving precedence in spine,
 So that to preserve the first ones in row
 It's justified to let the later go.
 So he could kill to save from idol show
 Or from the desecration of the day
 Of Sabbath broken by the heathen sway.

55 "Joshua, because he fulfilled
 The commandment, became instilled
 As a judge in Israel's domain.
 56 "Caleb, because he testified
 In the assembly and not vied,
 Received in land inheritance.
 57 "David, for mercy in his glance,
 Inherited the kingdom's throne
 For ever *and not it alone*.
 58 "Elijah because of great zeal
 For the law was taken by heel
 Up into heaven *and in seal*.
 59 "Hannaniah, Azariah,
 And Mishael believed in awe
 And were saved from the flaming crow.
 60 Daniel because of innocence
 Was saved from lions' mouths *and dents*.
 61 "And so observe, from generation
 To generation, that no ration
 Of those who put their trust in Him
 Will lack in strength or become dim.

If the word is true that the faithful stand
 In strength because they keep divine
 command,
 Then is that miracle enough indeed
 To save the crew without the swordly
 deed?
 The Anabaptist row would seem to take
 A dual position, not to eat cake
 And have it too, both raise the guns and
 fire,
 And in non-violence turn and retire.

Beloved, it is a telling story that
The pacifist of that group that once sat
In such diversity is still around
To give the trump of life a loud, clear
sound,

While those who mustered arms against the
sinners
Were never in the end among the winners.

62 "Do not fear the words of a sinner,
For his splendour will turn *beginner*
Into dung and to worms *as thinner*.

63 "Today he'll be exalted, but
Tomorrow he'll be out of gut,
Because he's returned to the dust,
And his plans will perish as must.

64 "My children, be courageous and
Grow strong in the law and in band,
For by it you will gain the fame.

65 "Now indeed, I know that the flame
Simeon your brother gives advice
In wisdom, always listen twice
To what he says and he'll be nice.

66 "Judas Maccabeus has been
A mighty warrior without sin
From his youth, so he shall command
The army for you, fight in band
The battle and make a good stand.

67 "Gather about you those who keep
The law and avenge the wrong steep
Done to your people, *for which weep*.

68 "Pay back the heathens and in full,
And keep the commandments and pull."

69 Then he blessed them, and as no knave
He went down to ancestral grave.

70 He died in the one hundred and
Forty-sixth year and met the land
Buried in the tomb of his dads
At Modein. And all Israel's cads
Mourned for him greatly out of hand.

There is a lot to be paid back, I swear,
When I look out on what the heathen dare
To perpetrate, not only in their war,
But in the advertisements of their store.
I've a thing or two on my own count,
Beloved, I'd like You to address in mount
Avenging for the ugly word and deed
Depriving me of harvest and of seed.
And yet, Beloved, my bread has aye been
sure,
And even drinking water has been pure

Without my buying water on the shelf
All bottled and all swatted down by elf.
I'll settle for accounts made even now
Or on the Day of Judgement anyhow.

1 Maccabees 3

1 Then Judas his son, who was called
Maccabeus, he was installed
In his place in command enthralled.
2 All his brothers and all who'd joined
His father helped him *tenderloined*
Fighting gladly for Israel.
3 He magnified above as well
The fame of his folk, mightily
He put on his breastplate and he
Assumed the battle armour and
Fought battles protecting by hand
The armies by his sword's command.
4 Like a lion in his deeds, like
A lion's cub roaring to strike,
5 He sought and pursued lawless ones,
He burned those troubling his folk's buns.
6 Lawless men fled in very fear,
The wicked were troubled to tear,
Salvation prospered at his hand.

Judas Maccabeus was a great man
Sent by Your hand, Beloved, and by Your
plan

To save Your folk as in the wondered days
Of David and Saul in their frightful ways,
Without regard for sacred human life
As long as the sword fondled bloody strife
And slew the enemy of You and Yours
And rid the world of Amelekite stores.
Beloved, the Hellenites take place in time
Of Amorite and Amelekite crime,
And show that centuries of bloodshed do
Not rid the world of any wicked crew
But that another rises in their fate
To become wicked, sinful and as great.

7 He grieved many kings, but he made
Jacob glad by his deeds displayed,
His memory's blessed eternal grade.

8 He went through Judah's cities, he
Destroyed from all the ungodly,
And so turned wrath from Israel's fee.

9 He was famous to the earth's ends,
He gathered up languishing friends.

10 Then Apollonius in store
Called up the Gentiles at the door,

A great army from Samaria
 To fight against Israel in claw.
 11 When Judas learned of it, he went
 Out to meet him, and as though sent
 He defeated and killed him too.
 Wounded and fell many in crew,
 And the rest fled in residue.
 12 Then they seized the booty and took
 Judas Apollonius' sword's hood,
 And wielded it in battle strife
 Until the end of his own life.

The sword of old Goliath in the trench
 Was famous in sight of both wight and
 wench,
 And hung within the tabernacle's shroud
 To be the pilgrimage of pious crowd.
 The sword of Apollonius as rare
 Has not the fame of the ancient one's
 prayer,
 But is as great, I trow, because the hand
 That won it also lifted Your command.
 The sword I raise is just the spoken word,
 The voice lifted in cantillation heard
 By few, but sifting through the holy sound
 Of Decalogue upon the holy ground
 That spreads in stone and saxifrage to greet
 The morning sun with neither snow nor
 sleet.

13 Now when Seron, commander of
 The Syrian army *hand in glove*,
 Heard that Judas had such a troop
 Of faithful men who did not droop
 But joined him in the battle call,
 14 He said "I'll make my fame as tall
 And gather honour in my stall.
 I'll attack Judas and his mates
 Despising the king's ordinates."
 15 And so a mighty army made
 Up of ungodly men arrayed
 Went up with him to give him aid
 And take vengeance on Israel paid.
 16 When he came near Beth-horon's
 slopes,
 Judas went out in his high hopes
 To meet him with a tiny band.
 17 But when they saw the army stand
 To meet them, they said to Judas,
 "How can we, and so few of us,
 Fight such a great crowd on the bus,
 And we are weak and have not eaten

Anything now so we'll be beaten?"

Sometimes the battle's fought best with the
 paunch
 Empty of food before the outward launch.
 But everyone delights in a last meal
 Before the raising of the hand and heel.
 I make complaint today, Beloved, that I
 Will come into Your chamber when I vie
 With turnip and with radish and am well
 Furnished with bread and kale to buy and
 sell.

Can any human being find excuse
 For doing what he should have done for
 use?
 Can any band of doers foot the bill,
 And run when they ascend the well-paved
 hill?
 I doubt not, but the everlasting plaint
 Is O Lord see now how I'm feeling faint.

18 Judas replied, "It's a light thing
 For many to meet destroying
 By few, for in the sight of heaven
 There's no difference between the leaven
 And the bushels of grain to sting.
 19 "It's not the army's size that makes
 The victory in battle stakes,
 But power comes down from heaven
 above.

20 "They come against us in the shove
 Of pride and lawlessness to kill
 Us and our wives and children still,
 And take our wealth, 21 "but we fight for
 Our lives and our laws *at our door*.
 22 "He Himself will trample them down
 Before us, but you for your frown
 Do not fear them *from toe to crown*."
 23 When he finished his speech, he rushed
 Suddenly to attack unhushed
 On Seron and his army, and
 They were defeated by his band.
 24 They followed them down the descent
 Of Beth-horon where the plain went
 Eight hundred of them fell, the rest
 Fled to Philistine lands *in west*.

Beloved, the stories of the battles won
 In days past are a thing that's long since
 done.
 I ask you if there's any help today

When armies come along and lead the way?
 They always have a reason for the fray,
 Trumped up and hashed and bittered for the press
 Of why it is a just thing to be dressed
 In battle where the poverty assessed
 Is low enough to keep the market dry
 If too many people there come to die.
 Not to be attacked? Now protection's found
 In having money to spend on the ground.
 Consumers are protected in the round
 When armies now-a-days are always bound.

25 So Judas and his brothers gain
 A reputation for the slain,
 And terror fell on the Gentiles
 Around about them miles and miles.
 26 His infamy came to the king,
 And Gentiles gossiped of the thing,
 The victories of Judas' ring.
 27 When Antiochus heard the rumour,
 It put the king fair out of humour,
 And he summoned the armies of
 All his kingdom for push and shove.
 28 He opened up his treasury
 And gave his soldiers all in fee
 A whole year's annual salary,
 And ordered them to be ready
 In case he called them to the spree.
 29 Then he saw that all the money
 Was finished in the treasury,
 And that the revenues in hand
 Were small because in all the land
 He'd caused dissension and had planned
 Disaster by the way he stopped
 The former laws that always propped
 In former days *when people hopped*.
 30 He was afraid the empty till
 Would not suffice before the bill
 Of his expenses, and for gifts
 That he gave more than other shifts
 Of kings before him *at the kill*.
 31 He thought about it a long time
 And decided to go for grime
 To Persia and collect the tax
 From those regions and raise an axe.

The ones who come to the attack waylaid
 Are always by economics' parade.
 They have to find the money somehow to

Sate their hunger for killings' derring-do.
 The USA has found the better way,
 Just base the national economy
 On the war crimes of the war industry
 And see how far that will take in the sway.
 The stomach is the limit for the sale
 Of wheat and beer, but there's no limit's
 whale
 To selling and to buying fear. The king
 Could have learned from his present peers a
 thing.
 Pay for the arms with taxes on the run,
 And then serve up the tanks as well as gun.

32 He left Lysias for the keep,
 A fine man of royal line steep,
 In charge of all the king's affairs
 From the Euphrates to the shores
 Of Egypt. 33 Lysias had to
 Also take good care of the due
 Son of Antiochus until
 He came *marching back over hill*.
 34 He gave Lysias the command
 Of half his troops as well as band
 Of elephants, and gave him word
 About all that he wanted stirred.
 As for the dwellers of the land
 Of Judea and all the band
 Of Jerusalem, 35 Lysias should
 Send an army against them good
 To wipe them out and so destroy
 The power of Israel and joy
 Left in Jerusalem, and he
 Was to banish the memory
 Of them from that place, 36 and then bring
 Strangers to live by vine and spring,
 And so distribute all their land.
 37 Then the king took the other half
 Of his army as well as staff
 And left Antioch pride and joy
 The capital in his employ
 In the year one hundred and forty
 Seven, and crossed the river sporty,
 The Euphrates and arrived in
 The upper provinces *with din*.

The elephants I daresay were a lot
 Come up from India to hit the spot.
 It's not likely the African for brood
 Would be so ready to obey the ruder.
 The battle won against the elephants
 Is famous in the history of dance,

But fact is I believe that such a crowd
 Was more likely to win than some allowed.
 Beloved, I'm glad that elephants today
 Do not join in the foolish human fray.
 They are too wise as beasts to take part in
 The campaigns of humankind in their sin.
 Beloved, I pray for elephants that stand
 Today in dole, slaughtered by human hand.

38 Lysias chose Ptolemy son
 Of Dorymenes, and *for fun*
 Nicanor and Gorgias, great men
 And friends of the king *for a yen*,
 39 And off he sent them out deployed
 With forty thousand infantry
 And seven thousand cavalry
 To go into Judah's land vied
 And spoil it at the king's command.
 40 And so they set out with their band,
 And when they got there, they set camp
 In the plain near Emmaus' ramp.
 41 And when the merchants of the place
 Heard what was going on in race,
 They brought a lot of silver and
 Gold there and manacles in hand,
 Ready to acquire Israelites
 As slaves *to sell or work by nights*.
 And Syrian companies came there
 And Philistines to join the ware.
 42 Judas and his brothers saw that
 Troubles had got fatter and fat,
 And armies encamped on their flat.
 They also found out how the king
 Had ordered final reckoning.
 43 And they said to each other then,
 "Let's fix destruction of our men
 And fight for our folk and the light
 Of the sanctuary *in sight*."
 44 The congregation gathered round
 Ready for battle on the ground,
 And to pray and ask for mercy
 And compassion *upon the free*.

Whenever war is threatening to blow,
 The merchant races always come to know,
 And gather like the vultures for the stake
 To profit from the bloodshed in its wake.
 War is the opportunity of all
 Who manufacture and sell in the stall,
 And so the greatest countries on the earth
 Are those who understand war and its
 worth.

Beloved, if I were cynical I'd say
 That You were laughing at the human fray,
 And scornful of the grief that humans bare
 To the white sunlight beneath rocky stare
 Of halls of parliament and domes of fame
 That glisten in the eager, melting flame.

45 Jerusalem was desolate
 Without inhabitants or mate,
 None of her children entered there
 Or came out to increase her share.
 The temple had been trampled down,
 With foreigners in fortress' crown,
 A place where only Gentiles lived.
 Joy was from Jacob moved and sieved,
 The flute and harp had ceased to play.
 46 So they assembled on the way
 To Mizpah, near Jerusalem,
 Since in times past Israel *in hem*
 Had a prayer place in Mizpah's *gem*.
 47 They fasted that day, and put on
 Sackcloth and sprinkled ashes on
 Their heads, and tore their clothes *at dawn*.
 48 And they opened the book of law
 To inquire into things of awe
 While Gentiles went to idol's band
 To inquire of the fate at hand.
 49 They also brought the priestly robe
 And the first fruits and the tithe's lobe,
 And they stirred up the Nazirites
 To complete both their days and nights,
 50 And they cried out to heaven, and said
 "What shall we do with these in dread?
 Where shall we take them now instead?
 51 "Your sanctuary's trampled down
 And profaned, and your priests in town
 Grieve in humiliation's crown.
 52 "And see, the Gentiles gather here
 Against us to destroy with fear,
 And You know of their plot and gear.
 53 "How shall we be able to stand
 If You do not help us by hand?"

The ruined temple gives no stench in air
 Because the dryness of the light and bare
 Breath of the winds that whisper in the
 place
 Sorrow to see the anguish of its face.
 They take an ancient priestly robe and
 show
 It to the empty sky, the silent row
 Of portals of the heavenly cast of fame

And call and call again upon Your name.
 Beloved, I see the pile of tithes, first-fruits
 With no storehouse to cover them with
 suits,
 And pray You on a day and year far thence
 To give the begging bowl both pounds and
 pence.
 Beloved, see how the innocent implore
 Your mercy on the stifled, sun-drenched
 shore.

54 Then they sounded the trumpets and
 Gave a loud shout. 55 And after this
 Judas appointed not to miss
 Leaders of the folk, some in charge
 Of thousands and hundreds at large
 And fifties and tens. 56 And he said
 To those who were building instead
 Houses, or were betrothed, or were
 Planting vineyards, or not to stir
 For lack of courage, to return
 Each to his house, as law would earn.
 57 And so the army marched away
 And camped south of Emmaus' way.
 58 And Judas said, "Get on your mark
 And be courageous in the dark.
 Be ready early in the morn
 To fight with these Gentiles of scorn
 Who've gathered against us to lay
 Destruction on us and to slay,
 And to destroy our temple's way.
 59 It's better to die in the fray
 Than watch our nation disappear,
 The sanctuary under sneer.
 60 But as His will in heaven may be,
 So He will do, *and we shall see.*"

When Jesus taught his followers to pray
 Thy will be done, he quoted in his way
 Judas Maccabeus, but did not note
 That word was spoken in an antidote.
 Thy will be done on earth is prefaced by
 The call to arms and hopelessly defy
 The strength of politicians and their guns,
 The sacrifice of mothers with their sons.
 Beloved, the sweetness of the hermitage,
 The gentle Laura's light, illumined page
 Of Psalm and Gospel, hide the desperate
 feat,
 The fearless plunge in war without retreat,
 Reliance on salvation at the shore,
 Hand on the sword, and eye upon the gore.

1 Maccabees 4

1 Now Gorgias took five thousand men
 Of infantry and in the glen
 A thousand hand-picked cavalry,
 And this band moved at night for glee
 2 Attacking the Jews suddenly.
 Men from the fortress served as guides.
 3 But Judas heard of it besides,
 And he and his best men moved out
 To attack the king's force in rout
 At Emmaus 4 while the band still
 Was absent from the camp on hill.
 5 When Gorgias entered Judas' camp
 That night, he found no one to vamp,
 So he searched for them in the hills,
 Thinking that they had fled the bills.
 6 At dawn Judas came on the plain
 With three thousand men out for gain,
 But they did not have armour and
 Swords such as they wished in their hand.
 7 And they saw the camp of Gentiles,
 Strong and guarded, with horsemen's files
 Around it with men trained for war.
 8 But Judas told his men the score,
 "Don't fear them for their numbers great
 Or be afraid when they berate
 To charge. 9 Mind how our ancestors
 Were saved at the Red Sea from fers
 Of Pharaoh who pursued them late.
 10 So let us call on heaven's gate,
 And see if He will favour us
 And mind the covenant and truss
 With our ancestors and destroy
 This army that blocks the day's joy.
 11 Then all the Gentiles will know there
 Is One who saves Israel *from care.*"

You have to keep reminding Gentile that
 You have an eye on what they do for splat.
 Otherwise they will lift a fist to sky,
 First in defiance, then as years go by,
 In mere denial of Your word and hand.
 Such is the rumour all about the land.
 You don't exist, You do not see the toll,
 You do not judge the sinner, mark the
 scroll
 Of grief on those who suffer at the dole.
 Remember Judas' speeches and the prime
 Argument for Your action. Now's the time.
 Beloved, the hand of fate's a mythic tale,
 And so is sociology's last wail.

There is a choice to make twixt ill and hale.

12 When the Gentiles looked up and saw
Them coming toward them like a wall,
13 They went out from their camp to fight.
Then Judah's men blew like a wight
Each on his trumpet. 14 and they flew
Into the thick of battle's brew.
The Gentiles fell back and they fled
Into the plain, 15 and those instead
Caught in the rear fell by the sword.
They followed them to Gazara,
And to plains of Idumea,
To Azotus and Jamnia,
And three thousand of them were gored.

The strategy is blow the trumpets till
The enemy is frightened by the kill
And runs away and leaves behind the slow
To be slaughtered by all the men that go.
The trumpet sound does not strike fear in
me,
Perhaps because I do not come to see
The magic powers of spirit and of force
That rise in matter and the song's divorce.
The music can indeed be house of god,
The Psalms are Yours, the Baal din at the
prod
The house of idols lighting on the sod.
They fled before the sound of where You
trod,
Beloved, Your victory it was of course.

16 Then Judas and his band turned back
From following after them slack,
17 And he said to the people, "Do
Not be greedy for plunder's view,
For there's a battle before us,
18 "Gorgias and his band are near us
In the hills. But stand now before
Our enemies and fight them more,
And after that take the spoils' store."
19 Just as Judas finished this speech,
A band came from the hills in reach.
20 They saw their army put to flight,
And the Jews burned the camp outright,
Since smoke arose up in the light.
21 When they saw this they greatly feared,
And also when they saw appeared
The army of Judas arrayed
Upon the plain battle parade,
22 They all fled to the Philistines.

23 Then Judas returned to confines
Of the camp to the spoil, and they
Grabbed much gold and silver, and gay
Cloth dyed blue and sea purple, and
Great wealth left by enemy band.

Whatever side a man is on it seems
The one temptation is the sovereign gleams
Of gold and silver, and the fashion's
brooch
That struts in gowns and garments in the
coach.

The cloth dyed blue and sea purple is found
No longer on the mercantilish ground,
Because the shell from which it's made has
gone

Extinct and is no longer on the lawn.
Beloved, I need no purple dress to wear,
I need no gold or silver in my hair,
I only need the woollen mantle meant
To cover me in sleep and waking bent
To whirl before Your throne with forty
more,
The abdals touch the reel and all two-score.

24 On their return they sang hymns and
Praises to heaven, for He is good,
His mercy endures aye as should.
25 Thus Israel had great salvation
That day. 26 Those of the Gentiles won
Who got away went and told it
To Lysias, all in a fit.

27 When he heard it, he was perplexed
And discouraged, for he'd been vexed
Not to accomplish in Israel
What he intended, nor did well
The orders king left to spell.

28 But the next year he gathered more
Sixty thousand hand-picked in store
Of infantry, five thousand more
Of cavalry to subdue them.

29 They came to Idumea's hem
And camped at Beth-zur, and Judas
Met them with ten thousand in fuss.
30 When he saw the army was strong,
He prayed, saying, "Blessed is Your song,
O Savior of Israel, who did
Repulse attack of warrior bid
By the power of Your slave David,
And gave the Philistine camp to
The hands of Jonathan for crew,
The son of Saul, and of the man

Who carried his armour *by plan*.

31 "Do so to this host by the hand
Of Your folk Israel to stand,
And let them be ashamed of men
And horses too *fallen again*.

32 "Fill them with cowardice, and melt
All of the bold strength they have felt
And let them shake before the welt.

33 "Strike them down with the sword of
those
Who love You, and let all You chose
To know Your name praise You in rows."

They call it hymn, but in fact it's a Psalm
Of David that they sang after the balm
Of victory, and before Lysias' calm
And disappointment in disasters tree.
Judas came out to beg Your help to see
The day when he was faced with company
Like oceans of armies across the shore
Of Idumea and the desert's door.
Beloved, I do not know whether the score
Of Psalm or prayer was more effective
then.

I tend to choose the Psalm when in my den.
My own prayers are a weak excuse for yen.
And so I enter in the temple wide
Where Psalms are veils for my Beloved to
hide.

34 Then both sides came to the attack,
And there fell of the army's stack
Of Lysias five thousand men,
They fell in the battle again.

35 When Lysias saw his band's rout
And the courage of Judas stout
And those with him, how ready they
Were to live or die in the fray,
He went to Antioch to hire
More soldiers to invade the pyre
Of Judea again with more
Soldiers and cavalry in store.

36 Then said Judas and his brothers,
"Indeed, our enemies and fers
Have been destroyed, so let's go up
To cleanse the sanctuary *cup*
And dedicate its use once more."

37 So all the army gathered round
And went up to the fortress ground.

38 They saw the sanctuary's fate
In desolation, and the great
Altar profaned, and burned the gate.

In the courtyard they saw young trees
Sprung as in a thicket breeze,
Or on mountains *above the seas*.
They also saw the rooms of priests
Lying in ruins, *dens of beasts*.

39 They tore their clothes, and grieved a
while,

And sprinkled ashes without smile.
40 They fell face down upon the ground,
And sounded trumpets' signal round,
And cried out to heaven *with the sound*.

41 Judas appointed men to fight
Against those in the fortress bright
Until he cleaned the sanctuary
Properly to make his heart merry.

The book of Daniel predicts time will come
To cleanse the sanctuary in its sum.
However men count out the days and years,
The cleansing is repeated in men's fears
Again and once again and then with tears.
When Judas Maccabeus found the tent
In ruins and profaned in all it meant,
He came to cleanse it then and there, but
that

Cleansing did not last for eternal mat.
Beloved, I see the centuries pass by,
And see the profanement steal on the sly,
Claiming your name as Jupiter and Jove
In land of pizzas, cheese, ham and
anchovy.

I doubt not it's been cleansed up to the sky.

42 He chose blameless priests to the law
Devoted, 43 and they cleansed in awe
The sanctuary and removed
The defiled stones to unclean grooved
Place. 44 They thought what to do about
The altar of burnt offering stout
Which had been profaned round about.
45 They thought it best to tear it down,
Lest it bring reproach on the town,
For Gentiles had defiled the crown.
So they tore down the altar, 46 and
Stored the stones in a nearby stand
On temple hill until there should
Come a prophet to tell what could
Be done with them. 47 Then they took
more

Unhewn stones, as the law in store
Commands, and built a new altar
Like the former, *better by far*.

48 They rebuilt sanctuary too
Interior of the temple view,
And consecrated the courts new.
49 They made new holy vessels, and
Brought the lampstand, the altar grand
Of incense, and the table too
Into the temple out of view.

At least they had those things to bring and
lay
Within the newly swept where they could
pray.

The rumours are the lampstand is well kept
In Roman crypt and hidden from adept.
I think the rumour might well be inept.
Today I look to temples not made by
The hands of men, but altars in the sky
Where incense of the same Psalms rises
high
When sung by those who still mind You
are nigh.

Beloved, I join the happy song they sang
On that far day beside the Kidron's twang,
Rejoicing that the temple ever new
And pure is here beneath my humble view,
Where You dwell in the Psalms instead of
pew.

50 They burned incense on the altar
And lighted lamps to glow like star
On the lampstand, and these gave light
In the temple both *day and night*.

51 They placed the bread on table and
Hung up the curtains by command.
So they finished all the work they
Had planned to do *upon that day*.

52 Early in the morning upon
The twenty-fifth day of the drawn
Ninth month, which is Chislev by name,
In year one hundred forty-eight,
53 They rose and offered up the flame
Of sacrifice, as the law's rate,
On the new altar of burnt offering
Which they had built *there for the
proffering*.

54 At the very season and on
The very day Gentiles had drawn
To profane it, it was again
Dedicated with songs of men
And harps and lutes and cymbals then.
55 All the people fell on their faces

And worshiped and blessed heavenly
places,
Who had prospered them in their traces.

The falling on their faces to make prayer
Is something Protestants avoid to share,
While all the faithful of the many flocks
Of other Christians find it to their pax.
Even the Jews follow in suite the pass,
And bob their heads instead of laying mass
Of forehead on the earth to favour still
Obedience to Your revealed, divine will.
I am a lazy bugger for myself,
Hardly a man at all, and more like elf,
But even I, upon a day and time
Put down my head on earth appeasing
crime.

Beloved, wherever my bright head may be,
Look on the heart that with impunity
Opens to Your grace, forgiveness, mercy.

56 They celebrated dedication
Of the altar for eight days' ration,
And offered burnt offerings with gladness,
They gave offerings and without sadness
For their salvation and their praise.

57 They wreathed the front of the house in
Golden crowns and small shields *of tin*,
And they restored the gates and rooms
For the priests and provided *brooms
And doors to hide them from the dooms*.

58 There was a great gladness among
The people, and the reproach sung
By the Gentiles was gone and hung.

59 Then Judas and his brothers and
All the crowd of Israelite band
Decided every year to take
The days of dedication's sake
Of the altar with gladness' joy
For eight days in all its employ
Beginning on the twenty-fifth
Day of Chislev, a month *to drift*.

60 And at that time they fortified
Mount Zion with high walls to hide
Strong towers round about the side,
To keep the Gentiles out so they
Would not again trample in fray.

61 He stationed there a fort to hold,
He also fortified the bold
Beth-zur, so that the folk might keep
A fortress strong toward the heap
Of Idumea *and its sheep*.

After all this time Hanukka is meant
 To celebrate the dedication's vent.
 The one's who celebrate it sometimes think
 Why they do what they're doing on the
 brink
 Of Christmas, others merely know the
 lights
 Of pagan hopes and fears press on their
 sights,
 And see the festivals draw Gentile and
 The Jew together in a sort of stand
 To spend some money at the end of year
 To make the inventory well appear.
 Beloved, I do not criticize the ball,
 Forgetfulness of centuries at all.
 It is enough right now to hear Your call
 And come before Your temple without fear.

1 Maccabees 5

1 When Gentiles around heard about
 The altar being built up stout
 And sanctuary dedicated
 As earlier, in wrath they hated,
 2 And they decided to destroy
 Jacob's descendants who deploy
 Among them. So they started out
 To kill the people round about.
 3 But Judas made war on the sons
 Of Esau in Idumea,
 At Akkrabattene *in tons*,
 Because they kept up their ambush
 For Israel in tooth and claw.
 He hit them with a heavy push
 And humbled them and spoiled their crawl.
 4 He also minded wickedness
 Of the sons of Baean's address,
 Who were a trap and snare to folk
 And ambushed them on highways' *stroke*.
 5 They were shut up by him in towers,
 And he encamped against their bowers,
 He swore their destruction entire,
 And burned their safety towers with fire
 And all who were in them on pyre.
 6 Then he crossed over to attack
 The Ammonites, where he found track
 Of a strong band and many folk
 With Timothy as leader bloke.
 7 He fought many battles with them
 And they fell at his stratagem.
 8 He also took Jazer and its
 Out-lying lands, then where he sits

He returned to Judea's *mits*.

The uncircumcised Gentiles round me sit
 Waiting for an excuse to have a fit.
 If I laid ambush for the evil band
 Of robbers that oppress me in the land
 Or if I dedicated temple here
 With gold and light and other holy gear,
 They surely would come out to hurt my
 own,
 To slay and burn and destroy flesh and
 bone.
 But I have sense to remain in my house
 And advertise no sabotage of grouse,
 But pray and cantillate Your word alone,
 And so I'm left in life, though poor and
 small
 Beside the tumbled firs and pines and wall.
 Beloved, I worship here before Your
 throne.

9 Now the Gentiles in Gilead
 Gathered against Israelite lad,
 All who lived in their territory,
 And planned to destroy them in gory.
 But they fled to the stronghold in
 Dathema, 10 and sent Judas tin
 And his brothers a letter saying,
 "The Gentiles around us have been slaying
 Gathered against us to destroy.
 11 "They are preparing to deploy
 And capture the fortress where we
 Have taken refuge, Timothy
 Is leading their raging army.
 12 "So now come and rescue us from
 Their hands, for many of our sum
 Have fallen, 13 "and our brothers all
 Who were in the land of Tob's thrall
 Have been killed, and the enemy
 Have taken their wives and sons free
 And all their goods, and have destroyed
 About a thousand men deployed."

What did I say! As soon as Jew stood up
 To sweep the temple and prevent the tup
 From entering and defiling with hand
 To steal and murder in the holy land,
 The Gentiles come uncircumcised and set
 A battle against every righteous met.
 What did I say! Beloved, though presidents
 Pretend to speak of peace, the man with
 sense

Sees beyond words to the things that they
do,
The fire and the destruction all in view.
Beloved, I wake up in the morning dew
And tread the path to water flowers and
find

The vetch is blooming by peony vined,
And gladioli send up green things kind.

14 The letter was still being read,
When other messengers instead,
With their clothes torn, came from the land
Of Galilee and made a stand
Of the same thing, 15 they said the men
Of Ptolemais, in Tyre and den
Of Sidon, and all Galilee
Of the Gentiles in company
Came out to destroy Israel's tree.
16 When Judas and the people heard
These messages, a great crowd spurred
To decide what they ought to do
For their brothers in distressed crew
Attacked by foes *and not a few*.

17 Then Judas said to Simon his
Brother, "Choose your men and go whiz
And rescue your brothers in land
Of Galilee, while I and band
Of Jonathan my brother will
Go to Gilead *and make shrill*."

18 But he left Joseph, who was son
Of Zechariah, and the fun
Azariah, a leader of
The people, with the rest above
In Judea to guard it, 19 and
He gave to them this last command,
"Take charge of this people, but do
Not engage in battle with crew
Of Gentiles till we come back too."

The way to get rid of the Gentile mate
Is to send out in three directions rate
Of soldiers quickly and not stop to wait
But strike them down as fast before they
know

That anyone has left the fortress row.
But there's a danger in that way of things,
Since God-fearing are rare as peacock
stings,

And that there will not be enough to keep
The home fires burning while the Gentiles
sleep.

Beloved, I keep my head low at the dawn

And smile upon the face of Gentile drawn
And hope he does not suspect I have gone
In secret to remove his tackle's creep,
To destroy his ability to peep.

20 Then three thousand men were assigned
To Simon to go to repined
Galilee, and eight thousand to
Judas for Gilead in stew.

21 So Simon went to Galilee
And fought against the Gentiles free,
And Gentiles fell before his spree.

22 He followed them up to the gate
Of Ptolemais, and at that rate
Three thousand of the Gentiles fell,
And he took all their spoils as well.

23 Then he took Jews of Galilee
And Arbatta, and with their free
Wives and children, and all they had
And brought them to Judea's pad
With great rejoicing *and not sad*.

24 Judas Maccabeus and Jon
His brother crossed the Jordan wan
And went three days' journey into
The desert. 25 And they found in view
The Nabateans, who met them
In peace and so they told to them
What happened to their brothers in
Gilead. 26 "Many *without sin*
Have been shut up in Bozrah and
Bosor, in Alema to stand
In Chaspho, Maked and Carnaim,"
All these cities were strong and large
27 "And some of them have been like
barge

Shut up in other cities in
Gilead, the foe are in bin
To attack the strongholds tomorrow
And take and destroy all for sorrow
In one day *multiplying sin*."

The victory in Galilee is wry
Since territory was lost on the sly
When Simon brought them all to Judah's
pie
And left the Gentiles keeping Galilee
As a place where they could move and be
free.

I don't rejoice to see the people set
All in armed cities in a small place met.
At least diaspora means it is hard
To kill the whole folk with a single card.

I fear the same thing in Israel today:
I'll bet the French and English in their way
Are in cahoots with Germans, USA,
To bomb them all at once and so complete
A final solution in their defeat.

28 Then Judas and his army fast
Turned back by the desert road cast
To Bozrah, and he took the city,
And killed every male without pity
By the mouth of the sword unwitty,
Then he seized all its spoils and burned
The city with fire unconcerned.
29 He left there at night, and they went
All the way to the stronghold vent
Of Dathema. 30 At dawn they looked
And see a great band there unhooked,
That none could count bearing the things
Of war and ladders to lay wings
On the fortress and so attack
The Jews inside *and not be slack*.
31 So Judas saw the battle had
Begun and that the people had
Raised a cry up to heaven with trump
And loud shouts, 32 and he said a bump
To the men of his band, "Today
Fight for your brothers in the way!"
33 Then he came up behind them in
Three companies, who sounded grin
By trumpets and cried out in prayer.
34 And when Timothy's army there
Saw it was Maccabeus' share,
They fled before him, and he laid
A heavy welt on them that stayed.
Eight thousand of them fell that day.

If all who now believe in God alone
And have their penises trimmed down with
stone
Would get together and rise up to meet
The Trinitarian and pagan fleet
In unity's cooperation standing,
We could clean up the earth from heathen
handing.
Instead Hamas fights the West Bank with
joy,
And even Jews divide themselves in ploy,
While Rome stands quietly and waits to
take
The spoils from both and burn them at the
stake
As she was wont to do in Andalus.

Rome never changes when she is set loose.
Beloved, unite the sons of Abraham,
And destroy from the earth eaters of ham!

35 Next he turned aside to Alema,
And fought against it and extremer
Took it, and killed every male in it,
Plundered it, and burned it to win it.
36 From there he marched onward and took
Chaspho, Maked, and Bosor's nook,
And other towns of Gilead.
37 After this Timothy though sad
Gathered another army and
Encamped opposite Raphon's strand,
On the other side of the stream.
38 Judas sent men to spy his cream,
And they brought word back to his ear,
"All the Gentiles around appear
To have joined him with much in gear.
39 "They've also hired Arabs in aid
And they're encamped by the stream
stayed,
Ready to come and fight you paid."
And Judas went to meet the crew.
40 And as Judas and his band drew
Near to the stream of water strand,
Timothy told officers' band,
"If he crosses over here first,
We will not be able at worst
To beat him, for he'll defeat us.
41 But if he shows fear ominous
And camps on the stream's other side,
We'll cross over to him with pride
And beat him *before he can ride*."

The General Timothy had a sense
Of psychological in the pretence
Of armies in the field. Such forthright
thought
Was the undoing of his wicked plot.
He understood that fear would save the
day,
And without fear on foes part on display
He might as well just turn and run away
And forfeit what he gave in Arab pay.
Beloved, I come up to the riverbed,
I see celestial armies round me spread,
I see the angels glance about the doom,
I hear the trumpets sounding in Your room,
But I press through and look nor left nor
right,
And penetrate at last into Your sight.

42 When Judas came up to the stream
 Of water, he stationed scribes' beam
 For the folk at the riverside
 And gave them this order and cried,
 "Let nobody camp here tonight,
 But get ready now for the fight."
 43 He crossed over against them first,
 And the whole band came fit to burst.
 All the Gentiles fell before him,
 Threw down their weapons and fled grim
 To the safety at Carnaim.
 44 But he took the city and burned
 The sacred precincts with fire spurned,
 Along with all who hid therein.
 So Carnaim was put in bin,
 Who could not stand by Judas' vim.
 45 Then Judas summoned Israelites
 All to Gilead, small and wights,
 And their wives and sons and their gear,
 A large group to go without fear
 Into the land of Judah's *tear*.

Again the scattered folk are all brought
 back
 To Judah's mountains so they'll not give
 slack
 And such temptation to the wicker whack
 Of Gentile living by their smoking stack.
 I too have been on Judah's sparkled shore,
 At least in Eilat for a dickie score
 Of days and nights and saw the peaceful
 plot
 Above the coloured fishes bright and
 caught.
 And as the blessed Sabbath evening came
 I found its peace arise like living flame
 Where noises of the busy street abated
 As suddenly as hungry mouths were sated
 By offerings of the new day filled to store
 With fruits and blessings up to block the
 door.

46 And so they came to Ephron's pier.
 This was a large and very strong
 Town on the road they went along,
 And they could not go round it to
 The right or to the left in view,
 And they had to go through it too.
 47 But the men of the city shut
 Them out and blocked up the gates' butt
 With stones. 48 And Judas sent a word

In kindly tones as it occurred,
 "Let us pass through your land in peace
 To arrive at our land's increase.
 No one will do you any harm,
 We'll just pass by on foot and arm."
 But they refused to open up.
 49 Then Judas raised an order's cup
 For each to camp there for the time.
 50 So the army encamped for crime,
 And he fought against the town all
 That day and all the night in call,
 And the town fell into his hands.
 51 He slew each male by mouth of sword,
 And razed the city like a board
 And took the spoils to their own horde.
 Then they walked over the town's place
 And trod upon the stricken race.
 52 And they crossed the Jordan into
 The large plain before Beth-shan's view.
 53 And Judas kept rallying those
 Who lagged behind and so he chose
 To encourage the folk that way
 Until they came to Judah's bay.
 54 They went up to Mount Zion where
 They offered burnt offerings to bear
 With gladness and joy, because not
 One of them had fallen in plot
 Before they arrived in safety.

The ones who refuse passage to the folk
 Of Israel, never wake to the croak
 Of any good. If not that very day
 They are punished and driven from the
 way,
 Israel will come back in a sudden thrice
 To destroy their beloved descendants twice.
 Take heed, I say to every town that's nice
 In its own comfort. When the oppressed
 call,
 Don't wait until your pressed against the
 wall,
 But give a helping hand if it is just
 A clear path opened on the fading dust.
 Beloved, I come footsore to where You
 keep
 A city locked and glowing and I weep
 To enter in the golden street and steep.

55 Now while Judas and Jonathan
 Were in Gilead and Simon
 His brother was in Galilee
 Before Ptolemais on a spree,

56 Joseph, the son of Zechariah,
 Leaders of band with Azariah,
 Heard of their brave deeds and heroic
 Battles they had fought *being stoic*.
 57 And they said, "Let us also make
 A name for ourselves and our sake,
 Let's go and attack Gentiles' cake."
 58 And they gave orders to the men
 Of the army with them again
 And they marched against Jamnia.
 59 And Gorgias and his men in paw
 Came out of the town to attack.
 60 Joseph and Azariah's back
 Were beaten and they were pursued
 Back to the border of the crude
 Judea, and two thousand men
 Of Israel fell that day again.
 61 So the folk suffered a defeat
 For wanting to take up in treat
 A deed of bravery *in their pride*,
 Instead of listening to the guide
 Judas and his brothers beside.

As soon as violence is set store by,
 Even if done in faith and at Your eye,
 There are some who would make a name
 for self,
 And with a strong hand lay upon the shelf
 The laurels and the crowns of victory,
 Merely to be the winners in the spree.
 No doubt that's why You do not intervene
 With a strong arm on every wicked scene.
 The intervention of the good provokes
 The good themselves to questionable
 strokes.
 The act of killing, even at command
 Of divine guide and by a righteous band
 Diminishes the soul, weakens the heart
 To do the pure and righteous thing from
 start.

62 They did not belong to the clan
 Of men through whom by divine plan
 Salvation came on Israel's head.
 63 The man Judas and his kin led
 Were had in honour by the folk
 Of Israel and by every bloke
 Of the Gentiles, wherever name
 Of them was heard to carry fame.
 64 Men gathered to them and praised them.
 65 Then Judas and his brothers' gem
 Went out and attacked Esau's sons

In the south land and by their tons.
 He struck Hebron and lands about
 And tore down its strongholds in rout
 And burned its towers round about.
 66 Then he marched off to go into
 The Philistines' land, and passed through
 Marisa. 67 On that day some priests,
 Who wished to do a brave deed's feasts,
 Fell in the battle, for they went
 Out to fight unwisely, unsent.
 68 But Judas turned back to Azotus
 In the land of Philistines' notice,
 He tore down their altars, and all
 The graven images in pall
 Of their gods he burned with a fire,
 He plundered the cities and hire
 And then went to Judah in call.

Let me, Beloved, do no brave deed and
 share
 The hope of fame of priestlings
 everywhere!
 Let me applaud the hand that topples down
 The idols of my own and other town,
 But let my hand refrain and face from
 frown
 When call is made to crusades on the
 crown.
 Let me, Beloved, remain a man of peace,
 Obedient to the ten words of release,
 The only basis of true faith that's found
 Among the angels and prophets' abound,
 Among the books and visions on the
 ground.
 Beloved, when call is made for soldiers
 grim,
 Let me remain at home, grey-haired and
 trim,
 And see the flush of hate fall at the rim.

1 Maccabees 6

1 King Antiochus travelling by
 The upper regions heard the cry
 Of Persian Elymais fame
 As a city of wealth to name
 In silver and in gold to claim.
 2 It had an ornate temple where
 There were shields of gold and to bear
 Breastplates and weapons once left there
 By Alexander Philip's son
 The Macedonian king who won
 First over the Greeks *when he'd done*.

3 He came and tried to take the town
 And plunder it, though with a frown
 He failed because his plan was known
 To the men in the city grown,
 4 And they in battle held their own.
 And so he left and highly sore
 Went back down to Babylon's *store*.
 5 Then someone came to Persia and
 Told him the military band
 That had gone into Judah's land
 Had been turned back and scattered lost.
 6 One Lysias was first who bossed
 A strong battalion, but had turned
 In face of the Jews who had learned
 Their strength in weapons and supplies
 And lots of booty from the eyes
 Of the armies they paralyze.
 7 They broke down the vanity he
 Had set up in Jerusalem
 On the altar, and had greatly
 Built walls around the temple gem
 As was before, and Beth-zur too
 That was his *own* city *in view*.

The vanity is just an idol that
 The Gentile ruler set up where he sat.
 All idols in this graven world and flat
 Are vanities, Beloved, so smell a rat
 Where idols raise their wicked horns to
 make

The world and wealth of others piece of
 cake.

The vanity is just an idol sold
 On any market in the world for gold,
 A share in what increases the untold
 And secret, untaxed profit corporations
 Invest in loop-holes of their legislations
 Well padded by the lobbies that are born
 Of pure democracy as well as scorn.
 The vanity is just an idol worn.

8 When the king heard this news, he
 croaked
 In surprise and he almost choked.
 He went to bed then ill with grief
 Since things turned against his belief.
 9 He lay there for many days in
 Deep sorrow and thought he'd not win.
 10 He summoned his mates to proclaim,
 "I can't sleep and feel I'm to blame.
 11 "I said to myself, 'What distress
 I've come to! And to what address

Of an abyss I fall in mess!
 For I was kind and was beloved
 I kept my power satin gloved.'
 12 "But now I mind the wickedness
 I did before Jerusalem.
 I stole her silver pots and gem
 Of gold and sent to kill the folk
 Living in Judah without stroke.
 13 "I know that it's because of this
 These evils have destroyed my bliss,
 And so I perish in my grief
 In a strange land without relief."

Religious people often pretend those
 Who have in wickedness stepped on their
 toes

On their deathbeds repent of all the woes
 They had inflected on the righteous nose.
 The fact is most such reports are the lies
 And wishful thinking of those they despise.
 The righteous with few exceptions upon
 The way find death without the light of
 dawn

Or any ray of hope that the foe drawn
 Will suffer for the evil of his spawn.
 Evil's the way of earth, and desperate
 The true condition of the hopeful's fate.
 If righteous men escape to live to age,
 It is a great exception from the rage.

14 Then he called for Philip, one of
 His friends, and made him ruler love
 Over all his kingdom above.

15 He gave him the crown and his robe
 And signet ring to rule *the globe*,
Begging him to guide his son right,
 Antiochus to reign in might.

16 So Antiochus the king died
 In year hundred forty-nine's side.

17 And when Lysias learned the king
 Was dead, he set up in his string
 Antiochus the king's son king.
 Lysias raised him as a boy,
 And called him Eupator *for joy*.

18 But the men in the citadel
 Kept hemming in poor Israel
 Around the sanctuary's tell.
 They were trying in every way
 To harm them and to strengthen sway
 Of the Gentiles. 19 So Judas thought
 To destroy them, and summoned plot
 Of all the folk to besiege them.

20 They gathered in the stratagem
And laid siege to the citadel
In one hundred and fiftieth spell,
And he constructed towers to stand
And other engines of war grand.

I say the grief that comes to sinners' way,
To Gentiles and uncircumcised that play
Their war-games round the world, is
justified.

I rejoice to see wicked ones have died.
I celebrate Antiochus's death,
I curse the air that gave his son his breath,
And pray the grave and name be blotted out
And only those who raise a voice in shout
Or in a silent prayer to You, will be
Successful in time and eternity.
Beloved, let every citadel be brought
Low and surrounded by the righteous lot,
Until the world is free of other laws
Besides Your ten, as well as human claws.

21 But some escaped over the wall
From the siege and ungodly thrall
Of Israelites joined to their call.
22 They went to the king and they said,
"How long will you fail in your stead
To do justice and so avenge
Our brothers *dead by Judas' henge*?
23 "We were happy to serve your dad,
To live by what he said *though bad*
And follow his commandments *sad*.
24 "That's why our folk's descendants
came

To lay siege on the fortress fame
And became enemies to us,
And killed as many omnibus
As they could catch and stole our truss.
25 "Not only against us have they
Lifted their hands as against prey,
But also all the borders' way.
26 "And see today they have encamped
Against Jerusalem revamped
To take it and have fortified
Both sanctuary and the pride
Of Beth-zur to be on their side,
27 "Unless you speedily prevent,
They will do even more extent,
Till you cannot stop worriment."

The traitor to the truth is best endowed
To speak against the faithful in a crowd.

So the false Jews who conformed to the
ways
Of Hellenite in idolatrous praise
Started the campaign against all the just
That still enveloped earth in evil dust.
If they had joined the faithful who were
near
The victory, the world of sin and fear
Might well have come long since to
disappear.
But lust for foreskins tipped the balance
dear
And so today continue grief and tear.
Beloved, a curse on those who know the
good
And fail to do the very things they should,
But give a hand to kings and popes that
could.

28 The king was in a rage to hear.
He summoned friends and to appear
Commanders of his armies dear
And their captains with all their gear,
29 As well as boughten soldier to
Come to him from other lands' crew
And from the islands of the seas.
30 The number of his bands' degrees
Was hundred thousand infantries,
Twenty thousand in cavalries,
And thirty-two war elephants.
31 They came through Idumea's lance
And camped against Beth-zur to prance,
And for many days they fought and
Built engines of war there to stand,
But the Jews came out and they burned
With fire all that they built and earned
And fought courageously discerned.
32 Judas marched off from the fortress
And camped at Beth-zechariah,
Opposite the king's camp's address.
33 Early in the morning and raw
The king got up and took his band
By a forced march along the land
To Beth-zechariah to stand,
And his troops got ready to fight
And blew their trumpets at the sight.
34 They showed the elephants the juice
Of grapes and mulberries for excuse
To battle. 35 And they set the beasts
Against the wings of the bands' priests,
And with each elephant's parade
They station a thousand arrayed

With arms and coats of mail in grade,
And with brass helmets on each head,
And five hundred picked horsemen led
By each beast. 36 These took their place
there

Wherever was elephant's share,
Wherever it went they too went,
And never left it to be sent.

37 On the elephants there were frames
Of wood, strong and covered with aims
And fastened with harness attack,
And there were four men on each back
Who fought from there and were not slack,
Also the Indian driver's knack.

Shame on the elephant and on Hindoo
Who joined the Gentile traitors and the
crew
Of those who rose, Beloved One, against
You

And against those who kept Your law in
view!

The elephant's a beast with mind and eye
Beyond the monkey-business of the sly
And human heart. I wonder that the beast
Would join so ugly an attack at least.
Beloved, if I were elephant I'd be
Too proud to string along in sinful spree.
I'd step on the foreskinned Gentile and
leave

The whole army to scatter for reprieve.
Beloved, if I were elephant I'd try
To fulfil my own task beneath the sky.

38 The rest of the horsemen were placed
On either side, the two flanks graced
Of the army, to block the foe
Harassed, and so protected go.

39 When the sun shone upon the shields
Of gold and brass, the hills and fields
Shone with them gleaming like a torch.

40 Part of the king's army to scorch
Was spread out on the high hills, and
Some troops were on the plain in band,
And they went onward steadily
And in fine order there to see.

41 All who heard the noise made by crowd,
By marching of their feet aloud,
And clanking of their spears and shake
Of swords, because the army's wake
Was very large and strong in stake.

42 But Judas and his band went on

To the fight, and six hundred drawn
Of the king's army died a-gone.

At this point I begin to wonder if
The stories of the Maccabees in stiff
Are not exaggerations of the bloom
Of their admirers and sayers of doom
To their foes. Such seem more than
gruesome trick,

An idle tale, and merely bragging slick.
But who's to say today, now that the ones
Who lived then are all lying on their buns
And dead and have no word to speak and
show

A witness for or against fateful show.
No matter, as I read the Scriptures through,
It is a pleasure to find here in view
The rousing histories of battles done
In victory for righteous under sun.

43 And Eleazar, called Avaran,
Saw one of the beasts was a-bearing
The royal armour. It was taller
Than all the others in the follow,
And guessed the king was sitting there.

44 So he gave up his life to save
His people and to win a brave
And everlasting name. 45 He ran
Without fear through the wings in span
To reach it and he killed men there
In every direction to share

So they parted before him there
On both sides. 46 He got under that
Elephant, stabbed it where he sat
And killed it, but it fell on him
And he died from his action grim.

47 And when the Jews saw royal might
And the fierce army in its fight,
They turned away and fled in flight.

48 The soldiers of the king's band went
Up to Jerusalem as sent

Against them, and the king encamped
In Judea and at revamped

Mount Zion. 49 He made peace with men
Of Beth-zur, and they left the den
Of the city, because they had
No supplies there to stand a bad
Siege, since it was a sabbath year
For the land. 50 So the king in gear
Took Beth-zur and placed a guard near.

If Judas Maccabean could turn out

The Sabbath in a day of fatal rout,
 Why did he not remember in the year
 Of the land's Sabbath that he stood to fear
 The armies of the king and Gentile steer?
 Obedience to law is not made for
 The weakening of the arm and the store,
 But for the continuity of land,
 Fertility before the harvest stand.
 Beloved, I hear the statutes read and rung,
 I hear them cantillated and then sung
 In every common and in household tongue,
 And yet I cling to the big ten alone,
 And let the others languish on the stone.

51 Then he encamped before the room
 Of sanctuary for days' gloom.
 He set up towers of siege, and great
 Engines of war to throw on pate
 Both fire and stones, machines to shoot
 Arrows, and catapults to boot.
 52 The Jews also made arms of war
 In answer to the Gentile store
 And fought for many days and more.
 53 But they had no food in the store
 Because it was the seventh year,
 Those who found refuge in the gear
 Of Judea from Gentile fear
 Had eaten up the last in store.
 54 Few men were left to guard the place
 Of the sanctuary in face,
 Because the famine had prevailed
 Over the rest and they had hailed
 Out each one into his own place.

The few who stay in Your house, my
 Beloved,
 Though in rags clothed and standing there
 ungloved,
 Though without meat and hardly drink to
 wet
 The tongue of parishioner newly met,
 Are better company to me, I swear,
 Than are the banquets of the rich and fair.
 The few who worship in Your house to
 show
 The way to bow in deep prostration go
 Further in justice than the evil row
 Of judges well bewigged and caped to
 glow.
 Beloved, I join the little band that hears
 The cantillation of Your law in tears
 And takes hold of the ancient covenant

And leaves the preachers and their folk to
 rant.

55 Then Lysias heard that Philip,
 Whom King Antiochus in hip
 While still living appointed guard
 Of his son Antiochus hard
 To be king, 56 had returned at last
 From Persia and Media with blast
 Of armies that went with the king,
 And that he tried to seize the thing
 Of government. 57 And so in haste
 He gave command to leave the waste,
 And told the king and captains of
 The armies and his men in love,
 "We're growing weaker by the day,
 We have so little food to stay,
 The place that we attack is strong,
 And the affairs of kingdom long
 Press on us urgently and wrong.
 58 "Now let us come to terms with these
 Men, and make peace with them to please
 And with all their nation at ease,
 59 "Agreeing to let them live by
 Their laws as before under sky,
 For it was for our setting down
 Their laws that they met us with frown
 And did all these things in the town."

Persistence and stubbornness set in heart
 Is the best way to meat the Gentile chart.
 Let every fool that follows in the wake
 Of sun worship to make the sad mistake
 To gather on a Sunday to forsake
 The Sabbath of the Lord, mind that the way
 To justice is return to Your sweet sway.
 Let me, Beloved, observe the Sabbath day
 And all Your law in the just and right time
 And so avoid the common heart of crime.
 Persistence is the choice, let me not fail
 To be a stubborn teller of the tale.
 Beloved, let one impassioned day be set
 A thousand years where You and I have
 met.

60 The words pleased king and captains
 too,
 And he sent peace offer to Jew,
 And they accepted it in view.
 61 So the king and captains gave oath,
 And on that word the Jews came troth
 Out of the stronghold. 62 But the king,

When he entered Mount Zion's wing
 And saw what a strong fortress there
 Was set, he broke the oath to swear
 And gave command to tear it down,
 And wall and all around the town.
 63 Then he left with haste and returned
 To Antioch. He found and learned
 That Philip ruled the town, and he
 Fought against him, and took city.

Beloved, let me die of the thirst and wear
 Of hunger before trusting anywhere
 The heathen that comes in to smile and
 swear,
 Uncircumcised and uncouth men of shame.
 Let me trust only You and in Your name.
 The treaty of the pompous in their wealth,
 The promise of the president in stealth,
 The signature of banker and the ride
 Of robber are all on the selfsame side.
 Beloved, the church of two or three may
 get
 The blessing and the truth in Scripture set,
 But where four come to gather there is just
 The searing of the liar on the dust.
 I pace the floor and measure as I must.

1 Maccabees 7

1 In year one hundred and fifty
 Demetrius, who was son free
 Of Seleucus, escaped from Rome
 And came with a band to the foam
 Of coastal city to give rule.
 2 When he arrived upon the school
 Of his fathers' lands, his army
 Grabbed Antiochus and the free
 Lysias to bring them in fee.
 3 But when he heard that it was done,
 He said to keep them from his bun.
 4 So the soldiers just killed the two
 Without trial and Demetrius
 Reign'd over his kingdom *in view*
Without any trouble or fuss.
 5 All the low and worthless men that
 Were in Israel came where he sat
 Led by Alcimus whose ambition
 Was to have high priestly condition.
 6 They criticised the folk before
 The king, saying "Judas and more
 Have slain all your associates
 And made us refugees in states.
 7 "Now send trustworthy witnesses

To see the destruction that is
 Come on us from Judas's hand
 And upon all of the king's land,
 And let them punish those who do
 These horrid things with all their crew."

Whenever there's a court of law to view
 Issues of justice, even one or two,
 There are those who clog up the system
 with

The machinations of their own sly myth.
 The soul that brings its own life to the sight
 Of the commandments to find out the right
 Can hardly keep from excuse for the wrong
 To blind his own eyes to justice with song.
 The same thing happens when court of
 appeal

Is formed by several souls standing on heel.
 There's always motivation to present
 Advantage hidden in the home-fire's tent.
 Beloved, I pluck the strategy and cast
 It from my heart and hear the storm in
 blast.

8 So the king chose Bacchides, one
 Of the king's friends, governor run
 Of the province beyond the stream,
 He was a great man of the cream
 In the kingdom and faithful to
 The king in *everything he'd do*.
 9 He sent him out in company
 Of the wicked Alcimus, whom
 He made high priest, and so then he
 Commanded him to drive to doom
 The sons of Israel in their room.
 10 And they marched off and so arrived
 With a large force into the hived
 Land of Judah, and he sent out
 Messengers to Judas and scout
 Brothers of his with words of peace
 Meaning to cheat them and increase.
 11 But they paid no attention to
 Their words, for they saw that the crew
 With them was large. 12 A group of scribes
 Came in a group and with their bribes
 Before Alcimus and his friend
 Bacchides to ask just terms' end.
 13 The Hasideans were the first
 Among the sons of Israel *cursed*
 To seek peace from them, 14 for they said,
 "A priest of Aaron's line and bred
 Has come with the army, and he

Will not harm us for any fee.”

Since Alcimus’ day there has been no priest
In church or synagogue to say the least
Who was not evil and more than a beast.
Abiathar himself lacked loyalty
And sided with the usurper to be
Against Solomon’s reign. Zadok I guess
Was better in the final days’ assess.
But after the captivity the folk
Saw only priests made up misplaced and
bloke.

Beloved, I turn to you from everyone
Dressed up in miter and crosier to run
The interests of invaders and the pall
Of market and of industry in stall.
The prayers are fickle as they meet the
wall.

15 And he spoke words of peace to them
And also swore this oath to them,
“We’ll not harm you or any friends.”
16 So they trusted him, but he took
Sixty of them and killed by hook
In one day, by the written word,
17 “The flesh of your saints and the spurred
Blood of them they poured out around
Jerusalem, and none was found
To bury them.” 18 Then fear and dread
Of them fell on all the folk led,
For they said, “There’s no truth in them
Or justice, for their stratagem
Is violation of the oath
And their agreement which he quoth.”
19 Bacchides left Jerusalem
And camped beside Beth-zaiton for him.
And he sent and seized many men
Who’d deserted to him again,
And some of the folk, and killed them
And threw in a great pit *pro tem*.
20 He then placed Alcimus in charge
Of the country and left a large
Force to help him, then Bacchides
Went back to the king *to confess*.
21 Alcimus strove for high priesthood,
22 And all who were troubling the good
People joined him. They gained control
Of the land of Judah in toll
And did great harm in Israel.

A preacher in the Baptist church is made
Among those competing upon parade.

They speak words of peace truly but have
stayed

Behind them for their own interests and
paid.

Like Ed Elwall I come to the conclusion
That only unpaid preacher in confusion
Has any chance to meet the great
temptation

Not to lie and cheat in both church and
nation.

The one that draws a salary or takes
A penny from the offering plate for shakes
Has not the will nor honesty to ride
The righteous road and humble all false
pride.

Beloved, save me from preachers and their
ware

As I recite Your Scriptures for my share.

23 And Judas saw all the evil
That Alcimus and those with him
Had done to Israel’s folk and grim,
It was more than the Gentiles’ whim.

24 So Judas went out into all
The country round Judea’s wall,
And took revenge on all the men
Who had deserted, and again
He stopped those in the town from going
Out into the countryside *mowing*.

25 When Alcimus saw that Judas
And those with him had increased gas,
And realized that he could not
Stand up to them, he went in plot
To the king and brought wicked charges
Against them. 26 Then the king *in barges*

Sent Nicanor, one of his great
Princes, who also bore great hate
To Israel, and ordered him
To destroy the people out trim.

27 Nicanor found Jerusalem
With a large force, by stratagem
Sent to Judas and his brothers
This peaceable message infers,

28 “Let there be no fighting between
Me and you, I shall come on scene
With a few men to see your face
To face in peace and not in race.”

29 So he came to Judas, and they
Greeted each other in peace’ sway.
But the foe was ready to take
Judas in chains *for piece of cake*.

Anyone who has possibility
 For violence is not trusted to be.
 The hand that holds the gun will never
 choose
 To tell the truth no matter what the ruse.
 The lack of motive does not mean a thing.
 Such people thrive on violence in spring.
 Judas did not need the informer's word,
 He smelled power rising from the fresh-laid
 turd.
 So too, Beloved, smell power within the
 State,
 The border crossing, the policeman's mate,
 The mayor and the civil servant bound
 To take me to the cleaners on the round.
 They all belong to Satan's jolly crew,
 They all oppose my face as well as You.

30 It became known to Judas that
 Nicanor'd come to him and sat
 With treacherous intent, and he
 Was scared of him and would not see
 Him any more. 31 When Nicanor
 Found that his ruse was out the door,
 He came to the attack to meet
 Near Caphar-salama's retreat
 To try to give Judas defeat.
 32 Five hundred men of Nicanor
 Fell from his army on that score,
 And the rest fled to David's door.
 33 After that Nicanor went up
 To Mount Zion. Some of the tup
 Priests came out of the sanctuary,
 And some of the folk's elders chary,
 To greet him peaceably and show
 Him the burnt offering on the glow
 Offered for the king on the go.
 34 He mocked them in derision and
 Defiled them with proud words in hand,
 35 And in his wrath he took an oath,
 "Unless Judas and his army
 Are in my hands by half past three,
 Then if I come back here safely,
 I'll burn this house *most wonderfully*.
 And he went out in fit and spree.
 36 Then the priests went and stood before
 The altar and the temple door,
 And they wept and said, 37 "You did
 choose

This house to be called to the use
 Of Your name, and to be for Your
 People a house of prayer and door

Of supplication? 38 "Take revenge
 On this man and his army henge,
 And let them fall dead by the sword,
 Remember their blasphemies' horde,
 And let them live no longer, Lord."

The trick is not to have a temple made
 Of brick and mortar, of foundations laid
 Upon the earth, be it of rock or sand.
 No temple stands pure on polluted land.
 And all land is polluted by the hand
 Of the oppressor, salesman and his band
 Of managers behind him where they stand.
 They always have their army with the
 weight
 Of new guns pointed at the holy pate.
 Beloved, I am disgusted by the rate
 Of presidents and parliaments that strain
 To keep the poor in hunger in their reign.
 The strutting officers elected by
 The fans blaspheme Your name up to the
 sky.

39 Nicanor went out from the town
 Jerusalem and camped in *brown*
 Beth-horon, and the Syrian band
 Joined him there with a heavy hand.
 40 And Judas camped in Adasa
 With three thousand men *under paw*.
 Then Judas prayed and said *in awe*,
 41 "When the messengers from the king
 Spoke blasphemy, your angel wing
 Went forth and struck down one hundred
 And eighty-five thousand of dread
 Men of the Assyrians bred.
 42 "So also crush this army here
 Before us today, let the fear
 Of those remaining learn now that
 Nicanor's spoken evil prat
 Against the sanctuary, and
 Judge him by his own wicked planned."
 43 So the armies met in the fight
 On thirteenth day of the month right
 Of Adar. Nicanor's army
 Was defeated and he fell free
 The first in battle, dead in spree.
 44 When his army saw that Nicanor
 Had fallen, they threw down in manner
 All their weapons and fled the scree.

Beloved, I love the story of the fall
 Of the uncircumcised, though it appal

The liberal in love and laughter's grace
That nowadays here rule this happy place.
Beloved, I joy to know the wicked man
Who promised wreck and ruin on the span
Of Your house in Jerusalem is down.
Let him be cursed with colleagues in the
town.

Beloved, I love the story, but I find
His mates are still around and are not kind.
The like stand up to turn a hand in hate
Against the temples of golden estate
Wherever they can wield a blow and make
The people suffer in their heathen wake.

45 The Jews pursued them a day's trip,
From Adasa as far as hip
Of Gazara, and as they went
They sounded battle call in vent
Upon their trumpets as they meant.
46 And men came out of all the villages
Of Judea round about for pillages,
And they out-flanked the enemy
And drove them back where they could see
Pursuers, so they all fell by
The sword, not even one's reply
Was to be spared under the sky.
47 The Jews then seized the spoils and
plunder,
And they cut off Nicanor's *wonder*
Of a head and the right hand too
Which he so proudly stretched in view,
And brought them and displayed them just
Outside Jerusalem *in dust*.
48 The people rejoiced greatly and
Celebrated that day in band
As a day of great gladness there.
49 And they decreed that this day's share
Should be celebrated each year
On the thirteenth day of Adar.
50 So Judah's land rested from fear.

The celebration of the death of those
Who fell before Judas in rows and rows
Is not a pretty thing, and yet I chose
To gladden heart, because I find so few
Times in the days of this world under You
When happiness of righteous ones in view
Is unspoiled by the tune of rock and roll.
The trumpets sounded loud and met their
goal.

Beloved, let trumpets call again today
The villagers to rise up in the way

And drive the armies of the USA
And European Union from the fray
To fall in death and in destruction's plight
For wrestling from so many folks their
right.

1 Maccabees 8

1 Judas heard of the Romans fame,
That they were very strong in name
And well-disposed toward all who made
Alliance with them, and the grade
Of friendship to all those who came,
2 That they were very strong in claim.
Men told him of their wars and brave
Acts they did among the Gauls' wave,
How they defeated them and made
Them pay tribute, and which they paid,
3 And what they had done in the land
Of Spain to get control in hand
Of the silver and gold mines there,
4 And how they'd gained upper hand fair
In all the region by their plan
And by their patience in the span,
Even in distant places ran.

They conquered kings who came afar
Against them for the earth's ends' star,
Until they had subdued and laid
Disaster on them, the rest paid.
5 Philip, and Perseus the king
Of the Macedonians' ring,
And others who rose against them,
They crushed in battle's stratagem.
6 They too defeated Antiochus
The Great, king of Asia to rock us,
Who went to fight against them straight
With a hundred and twenty great
Elephants and with cavalry
And chariots to a great degree.
He was crushed by them, and 7 they took
Him alive and decreed in nook
A heavy tribute on him and
Those who should reign after his stand
As well as hostages and more,
Surrender some of their best shore,
8 The country of India and
Media and Lydia in strand.
These they took from him and they gave
To Eumenes the king to save.

Justice of Rome is a thing counted great,
But I have doubts, even the Persian state
Submitted kings to the law and their fate.

There are ways always to circumvent rate
 Of ordinance as every rich man knows.
 You've only got to keep there on your toes
 And have a member of the family
 Who studied law to keep from jeopardy.
 But anyway, the justice tooted high
 Is reinforced by victories to ply
 The waters of the middle sea and sky.
 Beloved, force is the better part I say
 Of valour and of justice in its way.
 It's hard to tell two or three legions nay.

9 The Greeks planned to come and destroy
 10 But this became known to their joy,
 They sent a captain to attack
 The Greeks before they turned their back.
 Many were wounded, many fell,
 And the Romans took captive swell
 Of wives and children, and they stayed
 To plunder those they had waylaid,
 And conquered the land, tore down their
 Fortresses and enslaved them fair.
 11 The rest of the kingdoms and isles,
 All those who opposed them for miles
 They destroyed and enslaved in piles,
 12 But with their friend and their ally
 They kept in friendship on the sly.
 They have subdued kings far and near,
 And all who heard their name would fear.
 13 Those whom they wish to help and
 make

Kings, they make kings *and in their wake*,
 And those whom they wish they depose,
 And they've been strong where they arose.

14 For all of that not one of them
 Has put on crown or diadem
 Or purple as a mark of pride,
 15 But they have built themselves aside
 A senate chamber, and each day
 Three hundred twenty elders sway
 Deliberation for the folk
 To govern them well *under yoke*.

16 They trust one man each year to rule
 Over them and control the pool
 Of all their land, they all obey
 This one man, and there's no envy
 Among them or such jealousy.

This is the origin of the round fate
 That Judaism's rabbinical state
 Is founded on the Roman type of hate
 With a foundation in the Persian prop

And instigation of Hellenic drop.
 The Jewish faith's a syncretic one too,
 Just like the Mithraic and Christian pew,
 They all whirl round the emperor's statue.
 The vision and ideal beneath that pose
 Is this, that Rome is smelling like a rose
 Without envy or jealousy that goes
 Among the elders where injustice grows.
 As I peek in Roman doors and windows,
 Beloved, see me and keep me on my toes.

17 So Judas chose Eupolemus
 The son of John, son of Accos,
 And Jason son of Eleazar,
 And sent them off to Rome afar
 To make friendship and treaty there,
 18 And to free themselves from the bear,
 For they saw kingdom of the Greeks
 Was enslaving Israel *in peaks*.
 19 They went to Rome, a great long way,
 And came into the senate sway
 And spoke as follows *on that day*.
 20 "Judas, who is also one named
 Maccabeus, and brothers famed
 And people of the Jews have sent
 Us to you to set up a tent
 Of treaty and peace with you, so
 We may be inscribed at a go
 As your allies and friends, not foe."

Fatal mistake of every man's to make
 A treaty with Roman and grassy snake,
 Despite the pressure of the Greekly load
 That bears on life and limb as well as goad
 Upon the mind to strike philosophy
 As source of wonder and iniquity.
 Fatal mistake, Beloved, is everywhere
 I turn my eye upon the secular.
 Too tired to keep on fighting for the right
 To live according to Your law in light,
 The soul is quick to give up and desire
 The verdicts of wisdom in human fire,
 The rule that says obey and question not,
 Since knowledge gives a headache to the
 pot.

21 The Jews proposal pleased them all,
 22 And here's a copy to install
 Of the letter they wrote in answer,
 On bronze tablets *like fancy dancer*,
 And sent back to Jerusalem
 To keep there as memorial gem

Of peace and alliance in stem.
 23 "May all go well with Roman nation
 And with the Jews too in their station
 At sea and on land for all time,
 Be far from sword and foe and crime.
 24 "If war comes first to Rome or any
 Of their allies in lands for penny,
 25 "The nation of the Jews shall act
 As their allies and by this pact,
 As opportunity shall come.
 26 "And to the foe who makes war hum
 They shall not give or supply grain,
 Or arms, money, or ships in vain,
 As Rome has commanded, and they
 Shall keep their obligations' way
 Without receiving any pay.
 27 "In the same way, if war comes first
 To the nation of the Jews worst,
 The Romans shall willingly act
 As their allies, as time and fact
 May indicate to them *when stacked*.
 28 "And to the enemy allies
 Shall not be given such supplies
 As grain and arms, money, or ships,
 As Rome has commanded *its lips*,
 And they shall keep these obligations
 And do so without machinations.

The accords seem so innocent of guile,
 So full of sense and hope in peaceful style
 That anyone would be duped out of shame
 Not to accept provisions for the claim
 Of peace and freedom, but put down the
 flame
 Of war and terror from lands with a smile.
 The principle is boycott all who rise
 To make terror below uncloudy skies.
 The fact is that the beast consolidates
 Its power over all souls and for all fates,
 And deals the market and the shipping rates
 So that the profits flow to Roman gates.
 If anyone diminish Roman power
 He will be struck down there within the
 hour.

29 "So on these terms the Romans make
 A treaty with the Jewish stake.
 30 "If after these terms are in force
 Both parties shall determine course
 To add or delete anything,
 They shall do so at their thinking,
 And any addition or stroke

Of deletion that they awoke
 Shall be valid under the yoke.
 31 "And as for the wrongs which the King
 Demetrius does on the wing
 To them, we've written to him thus,
 'Why have you made your yoke and fuss
 Heavy upon our friend allies
 The Jews? 32 "If now appeal arise
 Again for help against your heel,
 We will defend their rights and seal
 The battle against you on sea
 And on the land *to keep them free*.'"

Aha! Behind the treaty is the threat
 Of sword and famine, pest and all you get
 When men take government in hand to bet
 Against all others there around them set.
 Rome threatens the Greeks for a song and
 seal,
 A pretext to enter the public weal,
 As soon as a petition comes in view
 To raise their strength again with army
 crew.
 The sly pretext is something new, I trow.
 Before that was only the Persian vow
 Divide and conquer. Roman ways are
 better,
 Make everyone see righteous a go-getter,
 A knight declining armour and no fretter,
 Who hides an iron fist and iron fetter.

1 Maccabees 9

1 When Demetrius heard Nicanor
 And his band fell in battle's manner,
 He sent Bacchides, Alcimus
 Into Judah's land for a fuss
 A second time, and with them right
 Wing of the army *come in sight*.
 2 They went by the road which goes down
 To Gilgal and camped against town
 Of Mesaloth in Arbela,
 And they took it and with the claw
 Killed many people *like a straw*.
 3 In the first month of current year
 One hundred fifty-two, they camped
 Against Jerusalem *unstamped*,
 4 Then they marched away and arrived
 In Berea with the survived
 Twenty thousand in infantry
 And two thousand in cavalry.
 5 Judas was camped in Elasa,
 And with him were three thousand paw

Picked men. 6 When they saw the amount
 Of enemy so large in count,
 They were very much afraid, so
 Many deserted from the show
 Until only eight hundred men
 Were left among them there again.
 7 When Judas saw his army gone
 And battle just about to dawn,
 He was depressed in mind because
 He had not time to gather straws.

The strength of any man is not alone
 In his full mind of courage and in bone,
 But in the humblest of supporters known,
 The one who thinks his presence like a
 straw
 Is not of great importance in the raw.
 Judas had saved his people many times
 And averted the very worst of crimes,
 But it was not his hand alone that fought,
 He always had a band not to be bought.
 If Gideon could win the battle fierce
 With only three hundred and lamps to
 pierce
 The gloomy night, why then did Judas fail
 With five hundred armed with both sword
 and mail?
 The answer's provide, don't listen to tale.

8 He became faint, but he told those
 Who were left, "Let's get on our toes
 Arise and attack all our foes.
 We may succeed in what we chose."
 9 But they tried to dissuade him, saying,
 "We are not able. Let's save staying
 And live now to come back again
 With our brothers and fight the men,
 For we are too few now *in glen*."
 10 But Judas said, "Far be from us
 To flee before the rousing fuss.
 If our time has come, let us die
 Bravely for our brothers, and tie
 No cause to question honour's why."
 11 The army of Bacchides went
 Out from the camp and took its vent
 To stand for the battle and fight.
 The cavalry was set in sight
 Of two companies, and the slingers
 And archers went ahead of singers,
 As did all the chief warriors' height.
 12 Bacchides was on the right wing.
 Flanked by two companies to sting,

The phalanx advanced to the sound
 Of the trumpets, the men on ground
 With Judas also blew their trumpets.
 13 The earth was shaken by the strumpets
 Of the armies, and battle raged
 From morning till evening engaged.

Even against all odds the tale goes on
 To glorify Judas in great lines drawn,
 A hero of all times, if mind went sour
 To kill himself and men in the last hour.
 And yet it seems he was right in the main,
 They held their positions through the day's
 gain,
 And lived to see the mountains of the slain
 Of Grecian armies called out in their
 power.
 Beloved, I hear the trumpets that sound still
 For battle and for cunning on the hill,
 For sale and purchase of the running mill,
 For oppression and poverty to fill
 The world with the same culture and the
 will
 That still forms Grecian cities and the
 tower.

14 Then Judas saw that Bacchides
 And the force of his strength's address
 Were on the right, and all the best
 Of fighting men with him in zest,
 15 And he attacked the right side well,
 And pursued them as far and well
 As Mount Azotus. 16 When those on
 The left wing saw the right wing gone
 They turned and followed close behind
 Judas and his men in the bind.
 17 The battle became desperate,
 And many on both sides in fate
 Were wounded and fell on their pate.
 18 Judas also fell, and the rest
 Fled *with no victory at best*.
 19 Then Jonathan and Simon took
 Judas their brother and in nook
 Buried him in ancestral tomb
 At Modein, 20 and wept for his doom.
 And all Israel made lamentation
 For him, they mourned in a great ration
 For many days and said, 21 "How is
 The mighty fallen, saviour whiz
 Of Israel!" 22 Now all the rest
 Of Judas' acts, both worst and best
 Of his wars and the brave deeds done,

And his greatness, have not seen sun
Recorded, for many were won.

If only Judas had had men enough
It's clear he would have smitten to the
rough
Both flanks and won another victory.
It's fear in heart of small men in the spree
That makes the difference, not heart of
great
Whether in wickedness or righteous
straight.

If only Judas had had men to spare,
He might have striven to the final stair.
Beloved, I came here with mind to compare
Judas and Jesus in their given share.
The one saved with his arms, the other tried
To turn back all the craven, lawless tide
That treaty with the Romans had unleashed
Upon the earth with compromise affixed.

23 After the death of Judas, then
The lawless emerged among men
Of Israel, all the doers of
Injustice appeared *hand in glove*.
24 At the same time a famine came
And the land deserted to claim
Protection of the enemy.
25 Bacchides chose the ungodly
And put in charge of the country.
26 Then they sought all of Judas' friends,
And brought them to Bacchides' ends,
And he took vengeance on them and
Made sport of them *with heavy hand*.
27 So there was great distress run free
In Israel, such as to see
Had not been since the time that ceased
The prophets to appear increased.
28 Then all the friends of Judas came
To Jonathan and said *in claim*,
29 "Since the death of your brother there
Has been none like Judas to dare
Against our foes and Bacchides,
To deal with those who so oppress
Our nation and hate our address.
30 "So now we've chosen you today
To take his place in leader's sway
To fight our battles, *win the fray*."

It's no surprise that when a famine comes
The populace runs to the noisy bums

Who through dishonest mean took all the
sums.

A man will eat and feed his hungry brood
Even if it requires a humble mood
Before the fickle, selfish heads of state
Who always have a hidden store for mate.
It's wonder that the people came before
Jonathan then, with spectre at the door.
Beloved, I come to You with empty hand,
And realize the famine in the land.
I do not know if bread and water's sure,
Despite the fact my spring-fed well is pure,
But I trust this the sound of Your Word
grand.

31 And Jonathan at that time took
The leadership and had the rook
Of Judas his brother *and gay*.
32 When Bacchides learned of this ray,
He tried to kill him like a crook.
33 But Jonathan and Simon his
Brother and all under his biz
Heard of it and they fled away
To wilderness of Tekoa
And camped beside the water pool
Of Asphar to await the duel.
34 Bacchides found this out and then
On Sabbath day, and he and men
Of his crossed the Jordan from den.
35 Jonathan sent his brother out
As leader of the crowd to shout
Petitions to Nabateans,
Who were his friends, for leave and plans
To store with them the great amount
Of baggage they had without count.
36 But the sons of Jambri came from
Medeba and seized John and sum
Of all he had, and left with hum.

See how the Greeks and Romans keep the
day
That You blessed, my Beloved, and in that
way
Give the example for the Christian play
Of grand hypocrisy. I guess their turn
To worship came at last around the burn
When Sunday dawned. Let heathen waste
away.
See how the Greeks and Romans love the
spell
Of force and arms to trample Israel.
The song is not a new one, I can tell.

Beloved, I sit beside the quiet pool
Of Asphar and plot out the harmless school
Of those who worship You alone and make
No idols to place in their temples' shake.
The sons of Jambri are alive and wake.

37 After these things it was reported
To Jonathan and Simon sported
His brother, "The sons of Jambri
Are celebrating wedding spree,
And are escorting the bride too,
A daughter of one of the crew
Of great nobles of Canaan's land,
from Nadabath with a large band."
38 And they minded the blood of John
Their brother, and went up and gone
Hid under cover of the hills.
39 They raised their eyes and looked their
fills,
And saw a ragged parade go
With much baggage, and in the tow
Came the bridegroom with his friends' row
And his brothers to meet them there
With tambourines, music and share
Of many weapons under care.
40 Then they rushed on them from hideout
And began killing with a shout.
Many were wounded, many fell,
And the rest fled to mountain dell,
They took all their goods at the spell.
41 And so the wedding turned to grief,
The music of joy to the feoff
Of funeral without relief.
42 And when they had glutted revenge
For the blood of their brother's henge,
They went back to the marshes hidden
Along the Jordan as unbidden.

So damn who's sane also was flaunted by
The refugees who hid away from sky
Within the marshes to make final try.
They were a band who could come out at
night

Or even by the day to set things right
And like a robber band attack the dust
Of royal forces not eaten by rust.
Beloved, I see the strategy appear
From long ago, there's always such to fear,
Except that now the marshes can be dried
And righteous men driven out by the tide
Of fire instead of water to abide
Where nothing of creation will remain

To mention bird and water weal's last gain.

43 When Bacchides heard this, he came
With a large force on Sabbath flame
To the banks of the Jordan's claim.
44 And Jonathan told those with him,
"Let's rise up now and fight for grim,
For now things are not as before.
45 "For look! The battle is before
Us and behind us, and the shore
Of the Jordan is on this side
And on that side with the marsh ride
And thicket, there's no place to turn.
46 "So cry aloud to heaven to earn
Deliverance from foes' hands that burn."
47 So the battle began, and then
Jonathan moved out with his men
To attack Bacchides, but he
Escaped him and went back to be
At the rear. 48 Then Jonathan and
The men with him jumped from the strand
Of Jordan and swam across it
To the other side, they were fit,
But the foe did not cross the stream
Of the Jordan as an extreme.
49 A thousand of Bacchides' men
Fell that day not to rise again.

I could have written Maccabean tale
With even more glamour to suit the whale.
I should have said that Jonathan took cape
And struck the waters, which stood in the
shape

Of a great wall and let the army pass
With dry feet as well as with a dry mass.
I could have written Maccabean fate
With even more miraculous in rate.
Beloved, whether they had to swim or not,
Or miracle played fortune in the plot,
I find the hope that arms may save the day
Gets further from reality to play
Havoc with peace and fortune in the field.
The populace is satisfied to yield.

50 Bacchides then returned to view
Jerusalem and built strong crew
Of cities in Judea's pew:
The fortress in Jericho, and
Emmaus, and Beth-horon's stand,
And Bethel, and Timnath, and yet
Pharathon, and Tephon, as set
With high walls and with gates and bars.

51 And he set garrisons as stars
 In them to harass Israel's gars.
 52 He also fortified the town
 Of Beth-zur, and Gazara's crown,
 And citadel, and in them put
 His troops and stores of food to foot.
 53 He took the sons of leading men
 Of the land as hostages then
 And put them under guard and hem
 In fortress at Jerusalem.
 54 In one hundred and fifty-third
 Year, in the second month, occurred
 Alcimus gave orders to tear
 Down the wall of the inner share
 Of the sanctuary. He tore
 Down the work of the prophets' score!
 55 But he only started his work,
 For then Alcimus went berserk,
 His mouth was shut, bulk paralyzed,
 So he could not speak anywise
 Or give orders about his house.
 56 And Alcimus died then *like mouse*
 In agony *and without spouse*.

The hand that's raised in a blasphemous
 work
 Is not always struck down, it was a quirk.
 While I am willing to give You, Beloved,
 The credit when it's due and You have
 shoved,
 I still see wicked hands and iron-gloved
 Wield death and destruction upon the earth.
 The dire strength has sure safety in its
 berth,
 And willingly sets fire to what it loved.
 Alcimus was a priest and arrogant,
 At least he was ambitious in his cant,
 And with a ready rhetoric he knew
 Just how to slander every righteous crew.
 What of his death, it is the common fate,
 And even evil men must eat that plate.

57 When Bacchides saw Alcimus
 Was dead, he returned to the king,
 And the land of Judah from fuss
 Had rest for two years for that thing.
 58 Then all the lawless plotted saying,
 "See! Jonathan and his men staying
 Quiet and confidence is straying.
 So now let's bring Bacchides back,
 And he'll take them all in one stack."
 59 And they went and consulted him.

60 He started to come with a grim
 Force, and secretly sent word to
 All his friends in Judea's crew,
 Telling them to seize Jonathan
 And his men, but for the good plan
 They could not do it, because it
 Became known how they hoped to sit.
 61 And Jonathan's men took in all
 About fifty men from the stall
 Of this treachery's leadership
 And killed them all *stabbed in the hip*.
 62 Then Jonathan with his men, and
 Simon, withdrew to Bethbasi
 In the desert, and took in hand
 To rebuild the parts and degree
 That had been demolished in spree,
 And they fortified it freely.
 63 When Bacchides learned of this, he
 Assembled all his forces, and
 Sent orders to Judea's band.
 64 Then he came and camped near the
 town
 Of Bethbasi, and fought for crown
 Against it for many days and
 Made machines of war at a stand.

The Jews were tortured by disloyalty,
 Some thought that their interest and best
 safety
 Was in allegiance to the king's degree
 Of Greeks while others found a refuge in
 The treaty with the Romans without sin.
 It's easy to say one band is the pure
 In heart and in faith, while the other's sure
 To be entrenched in some idolatry.
 The truth is every treaty with unjust,
 Pretentious Rome or civilized in trust,
 Is a mistake. Beloved, I draw back hand
 From the allegiance of the faithless band
 And right my heart without the idol's
 shore,
 Only to You, Beloved, I open door.

65 But Jonathan left Simon his
 Brother in the city for biz,
 While he went out into the land,
 With only a few men in band.
 66 He struck down Odomera and
 His brothers and the sons that stand
 For Phasiron in their tents manned.
 67 He started another attack
 And went to battle and not slack,

And Simon and his men went out
 Of the city and in the rout
 Set fire to the machines of war.
 68 They fought with Bacchides before,
 And he was conquered at their door.
 They distressed him greatly, for he
 Had planned and carried out decree
 In vain. 69 So he was in a rage
 At the lawless men who gave page
 To counsel him to come back to
 The land, and he killed quite a few.
 Then he decided to depart
 To his own land. 70 When at the start
 Jonathan learned of this, he sent
 Ambassadors to him to vent
 A peace with him and get release
 Of all the hostages in peace.
 71 And he agree, did as they asked,
 And he swore to Jonathan tasked
 That he would not try to harm him
 As long as he lived trick and trim.
 72 He gave him back the captive men
 He'd taken from Judah again,
 Then he turned and went to his land
 And never returned to their stand.
 73 So violence ceased from the band
 Of Israel. And Jonathan
 Lived in Michmash. And he began
 To judge the people, and he set
 At naught the ungodly he met
 From Israel, as he was let.

The whole thing seems to be a vain
 attempt,
 A futile exercise, clearly exempt
 From good sense and even timely ambition,
 The glorifying of empty sedition.
 But in the end, the writer seems to think
 The trouble started and continued wink
 From Alcimus and his friends at the brink
 Who thought a little power something to
 drink.
 Beloved, at least restore the captive men
 And women and their children that again
 Grace shores of all Western democracy
 Set on edge by running economy.
 It does not hinge better than Grecian king
 Who sends a governor to lend a wing.

The Muddle East, I speak now of Iraq,
 Has not changed much since Alcimus in
 flock

Convinced the man with tanks his interests
 ran
 Parallel to the priest's ambitious van.
 The Shi'ites taught Gorge Push his money
 lay
 In financing rebellion and to slay
 A tyrant in Baghdad, and yet the play
 Is sure that they in turn merely set out
 To get a chance at government and clout.
 Pitting the outside help in factious run
 On inside information is not fun
 And never rates success to those brought in
 To perpetrate their wicked acts of sin.
 Embargos and battles can never win.

1 Maccabees 10

1 In one hundred and sixtieth year
 Alexander Epiphanes,
 The son of Antiochus drear,
 Came to occupy Ptolemais.
 They welcomed him on hill and plain,
 And so there he began to reign.
 2 When Demetrius the king heard
 Of it, he gathered an absurd
 Great army and marched out to meet
 Him in the battle to defeat.
 3 Demetrius sent Jonathan
 A letter in peaceable plan
 To honour him, 4 for as he said,
 "Let's act first to make peace instead
 With him before he makes a pact
 With Alexander 'gainst our act,
 5 For he will mind all the wrongs we
 Perpetrated on his degree,
 On his brothers and nationry."
 6 So Demetrius gave him power
 To call up troops, and on them shower
 Arms, and to become his ally,
 And he ordered the hostages
 In the fortress set free thereby.
 7 Then Jonathan again made his
 Way to Jerusalem and read
 The letter to the people spread
 And the men in the fortress dread.

The politics of keeping faith in You,
 Beloved, under the rule of kings untrue
 And Gentiles uncircumcised as their due
 Is too complex for my small mind in view.
 It was an easy thing to understand
 When there was just a king to rule the land
 Anointed by Your priest or prophet then.

When the king was one righteous among
men,
One only had to follow in his wake
And make sure not to trouble him at stake.
When the king worshipped Baal, one only
had
To keep one's head low before all the bad
And give up vineyard when fair Jezebel
Spoke out in greed and conjured up a spell.

8 They were greatly alarmed when they
Heard that the king had given him sway
To summon armies. 9 But the men
In the fortress released again
The hostages to Jonathan,
And he returned them to their clan.
10 And Jonathan lived in the town
Jerusalem and favoured crown
To rebuild and restore the town.
11 He ordered those who did the work
To build the walls around the kirk
Mount Zion with hewn stones to meet
Better defence against defeat.
12 The Gentiles in the fortresses
That Bacchides had built fled his,
13 Each left and went to his own land.
14 Only in Beth-zur did some stand
Who had forsaken law's command,
Since as a refuge it was grand.

It does not matter who gives the command,
The gathering of armies in their band
Suffices to cause the alarm to go
From villager to villager and show
Effects as people hasten to find room
Of refuge somewhere before dawn of
doom.

Even the temple's readied for the broom
Of strife with stone walls hewn and barred
to sun
To wait in bristling silence till it's done.
Beloved, I too come to make scurried way
Before arrival of the drenching pay
That greed of captains and their armies
bring
Across the shipyards and the shadow wing
Of transportation to the market bay.

15 Now Alexander the king heard
Of all the promises inferred
By Demetrius and sent to
Jonathan, and the men told too

Of the battles that Jonathan
And his brothers had fought by plan,
Of the brave deeds that they had done,
And of the troubles they had won.
16 So he said "Shall we find another
Man like this among foe or brother?
Come now, we shall make him our friend
And ally *to his bitter end.*"
17 He wrote a letter and sent him,
Saying, 18 "King Alexander to
His brother Jonathan, yahoo.
19 "We've heard many things about you,
That you're a mighty warrior too
And worthy to be our good friend.
20 "And so we have appointed you
Today to be the high priest kenned
Of your nation, you are to be
Called the king's friend *by bond and free*"
(And he sent him a purple robe
And a gold crown for astralobe)
"And you are to take our side's fuss
And always keep friendship with us."

There is a string attached when rulers state
Intention to give gifts and not be late.
The seal of the king's vast approval won
Is really sign that the poet's undone.
So far no king has taken note of mine,
Which is a good thing, given that the fine
For lèse majesté's not my cup of wine.
Beloved, I set the king of self down from
The throne within my heart where You
have come
And leave the gifts and honours to Your
name
And let You step up now to make Your
claim.
My recourse to meter and rhyme is cast
Alone to catch the remnant of the bassed
And minnowed on my shore patched and
half-mast.

29 "And now I free you and exempt
All the Jews from payment's attempt
In tribute and salt tax and crown,
30 "And instead of taking with frown
The third of the grain and the half
Of the fruit of the trees in graf
That I should get, I release them
From this day and henceforth from hem.
I will not take them from the land
Of Judah or from, understand,

The three districts added to it
From Samaria and Galilee,
From this very day as I sit
And for time and eternity.

31 "And let Jerusalem and her
Suburbs, her tithes and to infer
Her revenues, be holy and
Free from tax set at the king's hand.

32 "I release also my control
Of fortress in Jerusalem
And give it to the high priest's roll,
That he may station in it's hem
Men of his own choice to guard it.

33 "And every one of the Jews fit
Taken as captive from the land
Of Judah that's still in my hand,
I set free without payment, and
Let all officials cancel too
The taxes on their cattle due.

34 "And all the feasts and Sabbaths and
The first day of the months and yet
Appointed days, and three days set
Before a feast and three days after
A feast, let them be all in laughter
Days of immunity's release
For all the Jews under my piece.

35 "No one shall have authority
To exact anything in fee
From them or annoy any of
Them about anything above.

I too could send a letter to my neighbour
Releasing him from taxes by my favour,
And telling him that I would let it go
And not take any profit from his show.
I think that he would call the men in white
To take me to a place where minds not
right

Are cared for and protected in their spite.
That only goes to show insanity
That marks the ways of kings and
councilry.

Beloved, the more official be the seal,
The heavier the wax and ribbon zeal,
The greater is the foolery that's done.
This world turns on a smack and waiting
pun.

The hand the restrains self's the one that's
won.

36 "Let Jews be enrolled in the band
Of the king's army to the stand

Of thirty thousand men, and let
The maintenance of all these get
As due to forces of the king.

37 "Let some of them be stationing
In the great strongholds of the king,
And let some of them be put in
Places of trust in royal bin.

Let their officers and their chiefs
Be of their own number's *reliefs*,
And let them live by their own laws,
Just as the king's and by his claws
In the land of Judah to *pause*.

38 "As for the three districts above
Added to Judea for love
From the land of Samaria,
Let be added to Judea

So that they are seen to be under
One ruler and obey no thunder
But the high priest *and so not wonder*.

39 "Ptolemais and the land adjoining
I've given as a gift and returning
To Jerusalem's temple trust,
To meet the expenses that must
Accrue upon the sanctuary.

40 "I also grant, *I am not chary*,
Fifteen thousand in silver shekels
Each year from the king's sums and
speckles.

41 "And all the other money that
The officers have failed in flat
To pay as they did here before,
They'll give now to the temple store.

42 "Moreover, the five thousand shekels
Of silver with which my man heckles
To get each year from the income
Of temple service is in sum
Cancelled, since it's owed to the priests
Who minister there in their feasts.

The civil servant and the president,
Prime minister and all such carping vent,
Have three things here in common with the
gross

King Alexander in letter verbose.
They're all ready to pretend friendly face,
They're all ready to take an army's place,
And all ready to drain the coffers till
The bankers machinations can fulfil.

The World Bank was invented on a day
When Alexander proclaimed formal sway
Of Judah with magnanimous a hand
And started flattery of moneyed band.

Seduction of the populace with shares
Is still the standard way to sell some wares.

43 "Whoever takes refuge at court
Of Jerusalem's temple sort,
In any of its precincts, for
Cause that he owes money in store
To the king or has any debt,
Let him be released and be met
With all his wealth in my lands set.
44 "Let the cost of rebuilding and
Restoring the structures at hand
Of the sanctuary be paid
From the funds of the king outlaid.
45 "And let the cost of rebuilding
The walls of Jerusalem's wing
And fortifying it around,
And the cost of rebuilding sound
The walls in Judea, also
Be paid out from the king's own bow."
46 When Jonathan and the folk heard
This message, they believed no word
Of it nor did they accept it,
Because they remembered the fit
Of great wrongs Demetrius did
In Israel to oppress kid.
47 They favored Alexander, since
He first spoke words that would convince
Of peaceful intent, so they stayed
Allies of him and on parade.

I mind how the good old USA took
Over religious schools in every nook
By offering the monies to the crook
For program, food, and every kind of book,
And then when with delight the children
fed
On pork from barrels of the white and red,
Inspectors came to see how they were led,
And bosses gave them rules along with
bread.
Beloved, I've taken nothing from the pool
Of common rents because I'm not a fool,
And only eat from Your blessed hand and
wait
Upon the morsels that my wife and mate
Puts on my table and my painted plate:
Give us today our daily bread and rate.

48 Now Alexander the king brought
A huge army and encamped lot
Across from Demetrius' plot.

49 The two kings met in battle, and
The army of Demetrius manned
Fled, and Alexander pursued
Him and defeated all the brood.
50 He pressed the battle hard until
The sun was setting *on the hill*,
And Demetrius fell that day.
51 Then Alexander sent in bay
Messengers to Ptolemy's way
The king of Egypt and to say:
52 "Since I've come to my kingdom's sway
And sat down on my fathers' throne,
And set up my rule as is shown,
For I defeated Demetrius,
And took our country back to free us,
53 "I faced him on the battle ground,
And he and his army were found
Defeated by us, and we took
Our seat on the throne he forsook,
54 "Now therefore let us sign a treaty
With one another to be greedy,
And give me your daughter as wife,
To be your son-in-law for life,
And I'll send you gifts grand enough
For your position and her stuff."

Folks think today has left the ancient
practice
Cementing treaties with a wife, but fact is
That sex and wealth are still the reason's
why
Men climb up thrones or podiums to vie.
The ones just interested in their potatoes
Have no desire or motive to leave Platos
And Aristotles to join with the brass
That disdain working folk, call them rag-
ass.
Back in academy one teacher told me,
"It's not what I knew of the world to hold
me
That brought success but whom I knew and
married,
And what my dad chipped in of gold that
carried
Me through to the success you see today."
I did not listen, but remained to pray.

55 Ptolemy the king answered saying,
"Blessed was the day after the slaying
On which you came back to the land
Of your ancestors, took in hand
Your kingdom and your throne to stand.

56 "So now I'll treat you as you wrote,
But meet me at Ptolemais' moat,
So we may see each other there,
I'll be your father-in-law fair,
As you've proposed *for your own share*."

57 So Ptolemy set out from Egypt,
He and Cleopatra collegiate
His daughter, came to Ptolemais
In the one hundred sixty rays
And second year *to see what plays*.

58 King Alexander met him, and
Ptolemy gave to him the hand
Of Cleopatra his own lass
In marriage, and enjoyed the pass
Of her wedding at Ptolemais
With great, ostentious, royal craze.

59 Then Alexander the king wrote
To Jonathan to spare a rote
And come to meet him and to dote.

60 He went in train to Ptolemais
And met the two kings on their dais,
He gave them and their friends great gifts
Of silver and of gold *for shrifts*
And bought their friendship *by his drifts*.

61 A group of pesky Israelites,
Lawless men gathered in their might
To accuse him, but the kings paid
Them no attention *where they stayed*.

The politics of Jews, the kind they learned
From all the uncut kings they might have
spurned
Except their livelihood and wealth and
weal

Depended on the grace of ruling heel,
Has always been to buy their freedom out,
And so escape the persecuting clout.
The ones who had the jewels and the rings
Of gold to contribute to Christian kings
Were those who survived Spain and
Portugal

To rise again in every kind of hall.
Beloved, give me the boughten friendship I
Have failed to acquire under hedon sky,
And I shall live here too, and shall not die
Like Turks and Jews baked in a German
pie.

62 The king gave orders to take off
Jonathan's garments and to proff
Him in purple, and they did so.
63 The king also put him in tow

To sit at his side in the row,
And he said to his officers,
"Go out with him into the stirs
Of the town and proclaim that none
Is to brings charges on him won
In any matter, and let none
Disturb him for any reason."

64 And when his accusers saw what
Honour they heaped upon his gut,
By the great proclamation's rut,
And saw him clothed in purple strut,
They all fled *as before a mutt*.

65 So the king honoured him and set
Him among his chief friends, and yet
Made him a general and ruler
Of the whole land, *and that was cooler*.

66 And Jonathan returned to seek
Jerusalem in peaceful peak.

67 In the year hundred sixty-five
Demetrius the son alive
Of Demetrius came back from Crete
To the ancestral land and seat.

68 When Alexander the king heard,
He was troubled and like a bird
Went back to Antioch as spurred.

The choice is to flatter the reigning king,
Not doubting it is temporary thing,
Or then eat bread and water when the sun
Smiles and die when the famine's on the
run.

The danger is the ruler now may fall
Tomorrow and increase the heavy pall
Of darkened fate that rears a shadow ring
And spoils the armies' and the mothers'
fun.

The purple robe that Jonathan now wears
May trip him up upon the golden stairs
Of pomp and power and drop him in the
lairs

Of those who feast on human bones and
flesh.

Beloved, I cry another way and fresh,
One without friends in high places to mesh.

69 Demetrius appointed one
Apollonius for the fun
Of ruling Coelesyria,
And he summoned an army's paw
And encamped against Jamnia.
Then he sent word to Jonathan
The high priest *who reigned as one can*:

70 "You are the only one to rise
 Up against us, and I've been prized
 A laughingstock because of you.
 Why do you take power not your due
 In the hill country *out of view*?
 71 "If you're so great come down to meet
 Me in the plain and on the street,
 And let us vie for power there,
 For I have cities under care.
 72 "Ask and learn who I am and who
 The others are that aid our crew.
 Folks will tell you you cannot stand
 Before us, your ancestors planned
 So twice but were put to the flight
 In their own land after the fight.
 73 "You'll not be able to withstand
 My cavalry, infantry's band
 On the plain where there is no stone
 Or ripple or hide-out alone
 Where you can run away at hand."
 74 When Jonathan heard these words of
 Apollonius writ above,
 His spirit was aroused *in glove*.
 He chose ten thousand men and set
 Out from Jerusalem, and yet
 Simon his brother came and met
 Him there to help him. 75 He encamped
 In front Joppa, but the scamped
 Men of the city closed its gates,
 Because Apollonius' hates
 Had set a fort in Joppa's rates.
 76 But they attacked it, and the men
 Of the town were afraid again
 And opened the gates, and by claw
 Jonathan took over Joppa.

Since the Assyrian kings started to make
 Wild propaganda before every stake
 To frighten and to cow the folk to set
 Themselves beneath the paw of such kings
 met,
 The rule is to insult before attack,
 Hoping the insult will produce such slack.
 It backfired in the case of Jonathan,
 Who was not such a scaredy-cat, but man.
 Beloved, I hear the chimes of heathen bells
 That ring around me in the glens and dells
 That now are overrun with men of hate
 Pretending to be good, loving and great.
 I flee to You from flattery in state
 And from sarcastic remarks of the mate.

77 When Apollonius heard it,
 He brought three thousand horsemen fit
 And a large army, and went to
 Azotus as though he went through.
 The same time he went to the plain
 Since he had horses there for gain.
 78 Jonathan pursued to Azotus,
 And there the armies fought to notice.
 79 But Apollonius had left
 A secret thousand in the cleft
 Of cavalry. 80 Jonathan learned
 There was an ambush behind spurned,
 Because they came around his band
 And shot arrows as they had planned
 From early morn till afternoon.
 81 But his men stood firm in the boon,
 As Jonathan ordered, until
 The foes' horses got tired and still.
 82 Then Simon came out with his men
 Attacking the sidelines again
 Because the horsemen were all tired,
 And they beat them back till they gyred,
 83 And the cavalry scattered on
 Azotus plain to Beth-dagon,
 The temple of their idol spent,
 Looking for safety where they went.

In times past battles could be won when
 men
 Were merely stronger than horses in glen.
 That may still seem a tale of mythic treat
 When told of soldiers standing on their
 feet.
 But now we've got to outwit and outrun
 Both tanks and bombers blackening the
 sun.
 There are ways to strike back once it's
 begun.
 The human spirit's greater than the fleet
 Of evil merchants out to hit the street.
 Beloved, among the shadows of the mind,
 I find an even greater one behind
 That spurs against Your law, and so I take
 The greater measure for the life at stake,
 And whirl upon the sands vetched and
 well-vined.

84 But Jonathan burned Azotus
 And the surrounding towns and thus
 Spoiled them and Dagon's temple too,
 And those who sought refuge in pew
 Of it he burned with fire in view.

85 The number of the ones who fell
 By the sword, with those burned alive,
 Came to eight thousand men *to tell*.
 86 Then Jonathan left there to strive
 Against Askalon, and the men
 Of the city came out again
 To meet him with great pomp *and yen*.
 87 And Jonathan and those with him
 Went to Jerusalem undim
 With much spoil. 88 And when Alexander
 The king heard of these things in slander,
 He honoured Jonathan still more,
 89 And he sent to him a golden bore
 Of buckle, such as is the sort
 To give to royal kins' resort.
 He also gave him Ekron and
 All its suburbs to keep in hand.

The Muddle East is still filled with the way
 Of people fleeing into temples' sway,
 And under the gold dome and glitter bright
 Of cut glass mirrors that astonish sight
 The wicked hand still comes to scatter
 gore.

I've seen it on the news and on the floor
 Of marbled pavings where I came to pray.
 But Jonathan came not in evil sway.
 Both righteous and the wicked wield the
 sword,
 And both do so in the name of their lord.
 The difference is not in degree of blood
 Or in the cruelty upon the stud,
 But in the law and in the God revered,
 And in obedience to what appeared.

1 Maccabees 11

1 So then the king of Egypt called
 Together a great army walled
 Like the sand of the seashore and
 Many ships, and he laid his hand
 On Alexander's kingdom by
 Tricks to add it to his own sty.
 2 He went to Syria with sweet words,
 And the town folk opened their herds
 To meet him as the orders ran
 From King Alexander by plan,
 Since he was Alexander's wife's
 Father and not set out *in strifes*.
 3 But when Ptolemy came into
 The cities he stationed a crew
 In each city as though in due.
 4 When he came near Azotus, they

Showed him Dagon's temple in grey
 And ashes, and Azotus' town
 And all its suburbs too burnt down,
 And bodies lying dead around,
 And charred flesh sitting on the ground
 Where Jonathan had burned in war,
 For they had piled them up *in store*
 Along the road he went *before*.
 5 They told the king what Jonathan
 Had done, to blame him as they can,
 But the king kept silent *by plan*.
 6 Jonathan met the king with show
 At Joppa, and they greeted slow
 And spent the night there *in the glow*.
 7 And Jonathan went with the king
 As far as the river in fling
 Called Eleutherus, then he went
 Back to Jerusalem *as spent*.

You never know what friend you might
 need when
 The tide of human hearts turns back again.
 So Egypt's king is quiet when he sees
 The bodies piled up dead and charred in
 frieze.

Expression of horror before the toll
 Of war is best saved for the plan and goal.
 Outrage for human rights is good enough
 When politics are furthered by the stuff.
 I too am silent in my hermitage
 To see the captains hand out such outrage
 Against the poor and in exchange to make
 A show of all their charities in wake.
 Beloved, in that I'm like Your own good
 self,
 Who never seem to budge You off Your
 shelf.

8 So King Ptolemy gained control
 Of the coast as far as the goal
 Of Seleucia by the sea,
 And he kept acting wickedly
 Against Alexander's degree.
 9 He sent Demetrius the king
 Some messengers who were saying,
 "Come, let us make a covenant
 With each other, and I will grant
 You in marriage my daughter who
 Was Alexander's wife, and you
 Shall rule your father's kingdom due.
 10 "I now regret I gave to him
 My daughter, because he was grim

To try to kill me, *that was dim.*"
 11 He cast blame on Alexander
 Since he wanted his kingdom's fur.
 12 So he took away his daughter
 From him and gave Demetrius.
 He and Alexander for fuss
 Became enemies by the bus.
 13 Ptolemy entered Antioch
 And put on Asia's crown and frock.
 So he put two crowns on his head,
 The crown of Egypt and he sped
 To take the Asian crown in stock.

The problem with just war is simply that
 Each war of conquest as seen from where
 sat

The instigator is one just and stated
 To be reaction to some wrong inflated.
 The Serbs reacted to the rape and murder
 Of the Croatian on the early girder.
 No matter that a generation's past,
 Revenge is sweet as long as it can last.
 Beloved, tell me just when to strike and I
 Shall quietly refrain from torch and vie
 Until the moment of justice returns
 And I play lyre while Pennsylvania burns.
 Until then let what pacifism earns
 Feed me and mine under a grizzled sky.

14 Now Alexander the king sat
 In Cilicia at that time flat,
 Because the people of that land
 Were in revolt and out of hand.
 15 And Alexander heard of it
 And attacked him in battle fit.
 Ptolemy marched out and met him
 With a large force and army grim,
 And he retreated before him.
 16 So Alexander fled into
 Arabia for safety due,
 And King Ptolemy rose in view.
 17 And Zabdiel the Arab cut
 Off Alexander's head *in rut*
 And sent it to Ptolemy's *glut*.
 18 But King Ptolemy died just three
 Days later, and his troops in fee
 In the strongholds were killed by such
 As lived in them and knew their touch.
 19 So Demetrius became king
 In hundred sixty-seventh's ring.
 20 In those days Jonathan brought back
 Men of Judea to attack

The fortress in Jerusalem,
 And he built in his stratagem
 Engines of war against its hem.

Never rejoice, I tell all men who do,
 For the prize that's today within their view,
 Because they do not know, Beloved, when
 You

Will call them up into Your judgement
 sway.

Never rejoice, never rejoice, I say
 When I see enemies fall in the way,
 Because, Beloved, Your hand may come to
 fall

Upon the wicked in their banquet hall.
 Instead I live my life reminding men
 As well as myself in the lion's den,
 That although mouths today be shut and
 teeth

Unbared, that does not mean tomorrow's
 wreath

Has not been woven for the time of sorrow.
 Dance not today, but look toward
 tomorrow.

21 But certain lawless men who hated
 Their nation went to the king slated
 And said to him that Jonathan
 Attacked the fortress in his plan.

22 Having heard this he rose in wrath
 And set out on Ptolemais' path,
 And wrote to Jonathan to stop
 The siege, but to meet him with mop
 In Ptolemais quicker than math.

23 When Jonathan heard this, he gave
 Orders to keep on the siege grave,
 And he picked out some of the elders
 Of Israel and some priest *melders*,
 And took a chance with life in slave,

24 For he went to the king as asked
 At Ptolemais, and taking tasked
 Silver and gold and clothing and
 Many other presents and grand.
 And he gained his favour *to stand*.

25 Despite complaints that some men made
 Against him in lawless parade
 From his own nation and waylaid,
 26 The king dealt with him as they did
 Who came before him in their bid,
 And he gave him honour before
 All his friends at court and in store.

27 He confirmed him as the high priest

And all his honours there increased,
And made his reputation great
As one of the chief men in state.

The priesthood is a thing granted by kings
And is not anything from Your own wings,
And yet the multitudes acclaim the song
And honour every priest that comes along.
The priesthood of Your law, Beloved, and
grace

Is solitary in a wooded place,
And only bird and beast come to give
prayer

And fill with praise the grafted, desert air.
I search me out the temple visited
By beetle and by ant, and I am led
By insect train along the forest ways
To find the earthen temples of Your praise.
The halls of majesty turn on a twig
And spread out below ripened pear and fig.

28 Jonathan asked the king to free
Judea and the districts three
Of Samaria from tribute,
And gave him three hundred to boot.

29 The king consented, and he wrote
A letter to Jonathan *quote*
About all these things, and it said:

30 "Demetrius and the king *bred*
To Jonathan his brother and
To the nation of Jews at hand,
Greeting. 31 This copy of the letter
Which we wrote about you *for better*
To Lasthenes our kinsman we
Have written so you too may see
And know what it says *in decree*.

32 'King Demetrius to Lasthenes
His father, greeting *groats and pennies*.

33 "To the nation of the Jews, who
Are our friends and fulfil their due
To us, we have determined good,
Because of the good will they should
Show toward us. 34 "We have confirmed
now

As their possession both the how
Of Judea and the three lands
Of Aphairema, Lydda's strands
And Rathamin, the latter, with
All the region bordering piff,
Were added to Judea from
Samaria from where they come.
To all those who make sacrifice

In Jerusalem, we've been nice
To grant release from royal taxes
Which the king formerly in axis
Received from them each year, and from
The crops of the land and in sum
The fruit of the trees *where our pax is*.
35 "And other payments henceforth due
To us of the tithes in review,
And the taxes due us, and salt
And the crown taxes in default,
From all these we grant them release.
36 "And not one of these grants in fleece
Shall be cancelled from this time on.
37 "So make a copy of this drawn,
And give it to Jonathan and
Put it on holy mount to stand."

Here is a witness, my Beloved, that men
As kings and presidents, servants again,
Or civil servants, as the case may be,
Are never to be trusted while at sea,
Or on the land, when they have power to
promise,

One ought always to be a doubting
Thomas.

The payments and the taxes are all due,
The right of tax-collectors in their view,
As though they'd given something for their
pay

In wheat or steel or oranges' display.
When things are written down and to be
seen

With seal and trumpet and signature green,
Then that's the time to worry for the turf,
The tide is rising in a higher surf.

38 When Demetrius the king saw
The land was quiet by his claw
And none opposed him that he saw,
He disbanded all his troops raw
And sent each once back to his place,
Except the foreign legion's face
Recruited from each tongue and race.
That's why all the soldiers that served
His ancestors from his love swerved.

39 But Trypho earlier had been
One of Alexander's in bin.
He saw that all the troops were mad
And complained of Demetrius bad.
So he went out to Imalkue
The Arab, who was raising true
Antiochus, the young son of

Alexander, 40 and urged in glove
 That he hand Antiochus over
 To him, to become *out of clover*
 King in his father's stead. He too
 Reported what to Imalkue
 Demetrius had done and told
 Of the hate which the troops still hold
 For Demetrius, and he stayed
 There many days *with a plot laid*.
 41 Now Jonathan sent Demetrius
 The king the request then to free us
 Of his troops in the citadel
 Jerusalem, and the troops fell
 In the strongholds, for they as well
 Kept on ambushing Israel.
 42 And Demetrius sent this word
 To Jonathan for what he heard,
 "Not only will I do these things
 For you and your nation on wings,
 But I will honour you and yours
 If I have a chance *on the shores*.
 43 "So now I think you'd better send
 Me men to help me in the end
 For all my troops rebel and bend."

The ones ambitious to eat power like soup
 Always need help with tank and gun and
 troop.
 But that is not the message they spell out,
 They keep that budget always in some
 doubt.
 Instead they rant and reel for friendship's
 gain
 Pretending they are among sound and sane,
 While military spending saps the soil
 And poverty of nations turns on oil.
 Beloved, I trounce the heart in me that
 springs
 After the power of glory and of things,
 And turn myself in whirling to Your face,
 And find it everywhere eye fills with grace,
 Among the pods of people on the street,
 Among the growing things I taste for treat.

44 Jonathan sent him three thousand
 Brave men to Antioch to stand
 Before the king in his joy planned.
 45 Then the men of the city came
 Together in numbers to claim
 A hundred twenty thousand strong
 Who wanted to do the king wrong.
 46 But the king fled into the palace.

Then the townsmen come *in their malice*,
 Held the main streets and fought along.
 47 So the king called the Jews to help,
 And they all gathered to the whelp
 And spread out through the city *wide*,
 And slaughtered that day *all they spied*,
 A hundred thousand men *who cried*.
 48 They set fire to the city and
 Plundered it on that day and manned
 To save the king *and help him stand*.

I doubt the hope of plunder and the promise
 Of tax-relief turned Jonathan from Thomas.
 The man was brave and knew the heathen
 score,
 And how one cannot trust a pagan sore
 With uncut penis. How could such thing be
 When even Jews made up a company
 Of traitors always at the heathen gates
 Of rulers to accuse the heavenly pates?
 Beloved, I trust no man, I turn to You,
 I trust not self at all, but Self in view,
 And when You fail, Beloved, like Gabirol,
 I turn from You to You to find the goal.
 The turning never fails to bring about
 A still small voice above the din and shout.

49 When the men of the city saw
 That the Jews had gained upper paw
 Their courage failed and they cried out
 To the king with entreaty's shout.
 50 "Give us peace, and command the Jews
 To stop fighting us in our pews."
 51 And they threw down their arms and
 made
 Peace. So the Jews there on parade
 Smelled good before the royal nose
 And all the folk his kingdom chose,
 They went back to Jerusalem
 With pounds of plunder, gold and gem.
 52 Demetrius the king sat well
 To rule his kingdom for a spell,
 The land had peace before his knell.
 53 But he broke his promises all,
 As though Jonathan were in stall
 Of strangers and did not repay
 The favours Jonathan in sway
 Had done for him but still oppressed
 Him and his country *as they'd guessed*.

Let this be a good lesson both to me
 And every man who takes Your law in fee,

That taking sides in any heathen spree
Will just result in pagan hearts that fight
Being once more knit for their wrong or
right.

Uncircumcised will turn and bite the hand
That helps him gain his wealth as well as
land.

So never help the lawless from command,
Except when spoils and plunder touch the
eye.

Let me not swerve like Levite there to spy
Or like the priest to stare and wonder why,
And heavens not like the Samaritan
To waste my pity and my pounds on man,
Lest he return to spoil my heart and plan.

54 And after this Trypho returned,
And with him the young boy unspurned
Antiochus who then began

To reign and wear the crown like man.

55 All the troops that Demetrius
Had sent home rallied to his fuss
And they attacked Demetrius,
And he fled in defeat he earned.

56 And Trypho captured elephants
And made Antioch dance his dance.

57 Then the young Antiochus wrote
To Jonathan, saying, "I note
You in the high priesthood and set
You over the four districts' net
And make you now a royal friend."

58 And he sent him gold plate and spoon,
And granted him right not to swoon
Before gold cups and dress in purple
And wear a gold buckle *and lurple*.

59 Simon his brother he made chief
From the ladder of Tyre in feoff
To the borders of Egypt's *grief*.

See now, Beloved, irrational in pate
That makes the human being stop in fate.
The boy can claim the right to set the mate
In Your priesthood because he has in hand
A golden plate, a silver spoon and stand.
I too could send a letter to a man
At any address in the worldly scan
Of New York or Washington and tell him
That he's the priest of all, both sweet and
grim.

He would believe me, too, provided I
Confirmed appointment with the golden
die,

Five hundred million in the bank account
Would be enough to buy rider and mount.
Beloved, no wonder You live in the sky.

60 So Jonathan set out and went
Beyond the river to the bent
Towns and all Syria's army came
To him as allies for his fame.

And when he came to Askalon,
The folk of the town met at dawn
And honoured him till he was gone.

61 From there he went to Gaza, but
The men of Gaza came and shut
Him out. So he besieged the town
And its suburbs and burned them down
And took the spoils for his renown.

62 The folk of Gaza came to plead
With Jonathan, and he took heed
And made peace with them, but he took
Sons of their rulers to his nook
As hostages and sent them all
Back to Jerusalem in stall.
And he went on through the land till
He came to Damascus's hill.

63 Then Jonathan heard that the chiefs
Of Demetrius brought reliefs
To Kadesh in Galilee to

Remove him from office and pew.

64 He went to meet them, but he left
His brother Simon without theft
In the land. 65 Simon camped before
Beth-zur and fought against it's door
For many days and hemmed it in.

66 Then they asked him to grant as king
Some terms of peace, and he did so.
He removed them from there in tow,
And took the city and he set
A band of soldiers in it yet.

Though Jonathan is just a robber man
And rascal set up in the office span
Of high priest, but would rather lead a force
Against any town that rises, of course
It was insult added to injury
That officers of Demetrius' spree
Come out to trim his beard. If he has turned
A hand against Demetrius and spurned
It was the fault of the king's perfidy,
The result of his machinations earned.
Beloved, I too see how my loyalty
Turns now and again to another camp

As my interests change and the lords
revamp,
No longer needing help from such a scamp.

67 Jonathan and his army stayed
By Gennesaret's waters played.
Early one morn they marched away
To Hazor's plain to join the fray,
68 And see, the foreign army met
Him in the plain, and they had set
An ambush for him on the hill,
But they themselves met him as chill
And face to face. 69 Then the men in
Ambush came out from place of sin
And joined the battle and the din.
70 All the men with Jonathan fled,
Not one of them was left instead
Except Mattathias the son
Of Absalom and Judas son
Of Chalphi, chiefs of the army.
71 Jonathan tore his clothes to see
And put dust on his head, and prayed.
72 Then he turned back to the arrayed
And routed them until they fled.
73 When his men fleeing saw the spread,
They came back to him and joined him
In the pursuit to Kadesh' rim,
To their camp, and they stayed there trim.
74 Around three thousand fell that day
Of Gentiles by Jonathan's sway,
And he went to Jerusalem
Returning on his victory's hem.

I tear my clothes proverbial but not
The literal to see the evil plot
Of my heart that has fled before the face
Of institutions without hope or grace.
Do not smile and say institutions make
No face, I can attribute to the fake
As well as to the human lack and stake.
There is no face, indeed, but One and You
Stand livid before dawn and dusk in rue.
Let me rejoice to see my heart turn back
From whirling to the smoking chimney-
stack.

The victory over the clout and mace
Is unexpected, but the golden trace
Is made perfect at last and in the lack.

1 Maccabees 12

1 When Jonathan saw that the time
Was in his favour, he chose prime

Men and sent them to Rome confirming
The treaty with them and not squirming
2 To send such letters to the Spartans
And to other places and tartans.
3 So they went to Rome and went in
The senate hall with bulletin,
"Jonathan the high priest and folk
Of the Jewish nation now spoke
To send us to renew friendship
And former treaty at your lip."
4 The Romans gave them letters to
The folk in every place and pew,
Asking them to provide for them
Safe conduct to Judah's land's hem.

Jonathan makes good to renew the plot
Of Jews with Spartans and the Roman lot
For two good reasons. Those were fighting
men,

Victorious in battle and again
A danger to each enemy they had.
It was not wise to make such people mad.
A second wise thing was the fact that they
Did not share any borders in the bay
Of Judah's shore. There was no
competition

For lands to rule and waters to partition.
Beloved, make me wise to see providence
And opportunity in the presence
Of folk at distance who are rough enough
To be of aid when closer ties get tough.

5 This is a copy of the brief
Jonathan wrote to Spartans' chief:
6 "Jonathan the high priest, the elders
Of the people, the Jewish gelders
To their brethren the Spartans, greeting.

7 "An earlier letter was meeting
Onias the high priest from place
Of Arius who was in grace
The king among you, say that
You are our brethren and all that
As the attached copy here shows.

8 "Onias welcomed us in rows
With honour, and received the letter,
Which contained a clear statement better
Of treaty and of friendship's glows.
9 "Therefore, though we need not such
things,

Since we're encouraged by the rings
Of holy books here in our hands,
10 "We have decided in our lands

To send renewal of our bands
 Of brotherhood and friendship true,
 So you will not forget our crew,
 For a long time has gone by since
 You sent your letter to our prince.
 11 "But we remember you from time
 To time on every feast-day rhyme
 And other days of consequence,
 At sacrifices of expense
 That we offer and with our prayers,
 As is right to mind brothers' shares.
 12 "And we rejoice in your success.
 13 "But as for ourselves, you may guess,
 Many afflictions, many wars
 Have surrounded us on our shores,
 And nearby kings have started wars.
 14 "We were unwilling to disturb you
 And other friend allies to curb you
 With these wars, 15 "for we have such help
 From Heaven on our side, and the whelp
 Of our foes could not gain control
 Of us, but were humbled by toll.
 16 "So we've chosen Numenius
 Who is son of Antiochus
 And Antipater Jason's son
 And have sent them to Rome when done
 To renew our long friendship there
 And treaty with them for our share.
 17 "We have commanded them to go
 Also to you, greet, bring and show
 Our letter to renew our pact.
 18 "And so please give reply in fact."

The holy books are excuse and enough
 For proudly claiming independence stuff.
 "We do not need you" can be always said
 By those who trust You for both arms and
 bread.

The holy books, perhaps read as a spell,
 A trick of magic where the soldiers dwell,
 Are just enough in psychological
 To treat the men to battle for their sal.
 Beloved, the auguries of heathen kings
 And looking at the stars and other things
 Hoping to find an answer beforehand
 Of battle's outcome on the golden sand,
 These are not mine, but I take sacred word
 And hear the truth that stands and is still
 stirred.

19 This is a copy of the brief
 Once sent to Onias' relief.

20 "Arius, king of the Spartans,
 To Onias the high priest's vans,
 Greeting. 21 "It has been found in writing
 Concerning the Spartans and fighting
 Jews that they are brothers and are
 Of Abraham's family's *star*.
 22 "And now that we have learned of this,
 Please write to us about your bliss,
 23 "We on our part write to you that
 Your cattle and your wealthy fat
 Belong to us, and ours to you.
 We therefore command that in view
 Our messengers report to you."

Is that true, my Beloved, are Spartans Jew?
 I did not know the tune that came from
 You.

But all the world holds Athens in its pride,
 The city that slew Socrates to ride
 More fully in the butchered civilized
 That European billies had devised.
 If Spartans are just Jews surrounded by
 Uncircumcised Greeks under a blue sky,
 It is no wonder that they set a pace
 Of vast defences for the holy race.
 Beloved, descent is often so contrived
 To meet expedient when it's contrived
 In politics and economic share.
 Otherwise the cupboard may be found bare.

24 Jonathan heard Demetrius' chiefs
 Had come back with larger reliefs
 Of armies to attack again.
 25 He marched away then with his men
 From Jerusalem and met them
 In the region of Hamath's hem,
 For he gave them no chance to take
 A step in his own country's wake.
 26 He sent spies to their camp, and they
 Came back bringing report to say
 The enemy prepared to fall
 Upon the Jews by night in stall.
 27 So when the sun set, Jonathan
 Commanded his men to set scan
 And keep each man his sword in hand
 To be ready all night as planned
 For battle and he stationed guards
 Around the camp to save their pards.
 28 When the foes heard that Jonathan
 And his men were prepared with plan,
 They were afraid and lost their courage,
 So they lit fires and left in hurrage.

29 But Jonathan and his men did
Not know it until morning's bid,
For they saw the fires burning. 30 Then
Jonathan took after the men,
But did not catch them, not a sliver,
For they'd crossed the Eleutherus river.

I'd be unhappy after all night long
Guarding an empty camp without a song,
While enemy had slipped away along
The river and left me with fires as strong
As any lies that were told to my wrong.
But Jonathan is not one to sink down
Beneath the weight of deceit in the town.
He runs after the fugitives a while
Till he is sure they've gained in safety's
guile
And left him in the dust of many a mile.
Beloved, I tend the watches of the night
In slumber, though when there comes beam
of light
Into my spirit for a moment I
Recite a verse of Your word on the sly.

31 So Jonathan turned from the way
And attacked the Arabs that day
Who are called Zabadeans, and
He beat them and took spoils in hand.
32 He broke camp and went to Damascus,
And marched through all that region, *ask*
us.

33 Simon also went out and tramped
Through the land until he encamped
At Askalon and neighbourhood.
He stopped at Joppa and took it
By surprise, 34 since he had the wit
That they were ready to hand over
The fortress to Demetrius' clover.
He left a band there to guard it.

Simon and Jonathan make themselves look
Like ordinary bandit and a crook,
Attacking Arabs without rhyme or reason
And smiting Joppa in surprising season.
A rumour is enough to make the man
Who has the army carry out a plan.
If men are not sent out to fight, they wail
And get bored and rebel when they go
stale.

If arms are not polished on blood and gore,
They lose their sheen for killing anymore.
Beloved, the bandit too may turn to be

An instrument in Your hand for a fee,
And when not, it is just the common fate
That innocent are plunged in alternate.

35 When Jonathan came back he called
The elders of the people maled
And planned with them to build
strongholds

In Judea, 36 to build scaffolds
Of Jerusalem's walls still higher,
And to raise up defences dire
Between the fortress and the town
To separate it from the frown
Of the city, so soldiers there
Could not buy or sell any ware.
37 They gathered to build up the town,
Part of the wall had fallen down
Above the valley on the east,
And he repaired the part at least
Called Chaphenath. 38 And then Simon
Built Adida in the Shephelah,
He fortified it and when done
Installed gates with locks *firm and fun.*

39 Then Trypho tried to take the crown
Of Asia, as well as put down
Antiochus the king. 40 He feared
That Jonathan as it appeared
Might not allow it, but make war,
So he kept trying on that score
To take him and kill him, and he
Came marching to Beh-shan *in spree.*

41 And Jonathan went out to meet
Him with forty thousand in treat,
And came to Beth-shan *on his feet.*

42 When Trypho saw so large a band,
He was afraid to raise his hand.

43 He welcomed him with honour spread,
And flattered him to his friends fed,
And gave him gifts and told his men
To obey him as chief again.

The friendship of the great is always met
With calculation of what's the best bet.
They treat each other with a smile because
They know the other's wealth and power of
paws.

Without the army of forty grand stand
Trypho would not give Jonathan his hand.
But as long as the danger hovers near
He uses gay respect to hide his fear.
Beloved, I beckon to the wayward crowd

And warn them of their leaders and the
proud,
But they rush off to spare nor arm nor coin
But they would have the pleasure out to
join.

I whirl alone upon the dergah floor,
And in my whirling see You at the door.

44 Then he said to Jonathan, "Why
Have you wearied all these folk, why,
When we are not at war nor nigh?

45 Send them off to their homes and
choose

For yourself a few men to use,
And come with me to Ptolemais.
I'll hand it over to your ways
Along with other fortress stays
And all the rest of troops and chiefs,
And then go home to my reliefs.

For that is why I'm here *as lays*."

46 Jonathan trusted him and did
As he said, he sent away bid

To all the troops, and they returned
To the land of Judah as spurned.

47 He kept himself three thousand men,
Two thousand in Galilee's fen,
A thousand went with him again.

48 But when Jonathan came into
Ptolemais, the men of that hue
Closed the gates and seized him, and all
Who had come in with him in thrall
And they killed them by sword in stall.

49 Trypho sent troops and cavalry
Into *the land of Galilee*

And the great plain to destroy all
Jonathan's soldiers *at one call*.

50 But they found out that Jonathan
Had been taken captive by plan
And died along with all his men,
And they encouraged each again
And kept in their battle array.

51 When their pursuers saw that they
Would fight for their lives, they turned
back.

52 And so they all returned in stack
To Judah's land, and there they mourned
For Jonathan and his friends scorned,
And they were in great fear and so
All Israel sorrowed long and low.

53 And all the nations round about
Them tried to destroy them with shout,
For they said, "They've no help or chief,

So let's make war on them for grief
And blot them out of memory
Among all men on earth and sea."

The great mistake that Jonathan once made,
The one for which he gave his life and
paid,

Was not his lack of courage nor of skill
In battle with a strategy and will,
But that he trusted the word of the king,
The man uncircumcised and on the wing
Of lying and deceit. So let that be,
Beloved, a clear lesson also for me.

Though every man and woman bears the
scar

Of Your reflection in the soul and star,
The twist of fate and fortune is the will
Not to in everything search out Your bill.
Trust only those I know keep each
command

Of Yours is the only way I can stand.

1 Maccabees 13

1 Simon heard Trypho'd gathered great
Battalions to invade the state

And destroy Judah's land with hate,
2 And when he saw how the folk feared
And trembled when the thing appeared,
He summoned all the folk together

3 Encouraging at end of tether:
"It's known to you what I have done

With my kin and my father won
For the laws and the temple here,
You know what battles and what fear
We have gone through with foot and gear.

4 "That's why my brothers have all died
For Israel's sake and Israel's pride
And I alone stay and abide.

5 "Then why should I think of my life
And safety now before this strife,
Since I'm not greater than my brothers.

6 Instead I shall fall on the others
In vengeance for my land and that
Holy place where your wives once sat
With their offspring, now in this day
When all the heathen take their way
In wrath to destroy come what may."

Then why should I think of my life when I
Look out upon the silent and clear sky
After the clouds of dark oppression's wave
Have scattered over every righteous grave?

Beloved, the temples of the many gods
Are filled with the din of the tempered
clods

That remain to ignore Your will and make
The wrong look like the right for their own
sake.

I bide my time by walking in the wood
And counting up my beads as all men
should

To hear Your name at least upon my lips,
To savour Your faith in delicious sips
Of birchen sap and some secret in wine
That opens at the table where You dine.

7 The people's spirit was rekindled
When they heard these words, 8 and
undwindled

They answered in a loud voice, saying
"You are our leader in place swaying
Of Judas and Jonathan brother.

9 "Fight our battles, and *not to smother*
All you command we'll do each other."

10 So he summoned the strong men all
More quickly to complete the wall
Of *fair* Jerusalem, and he
Strengthened it on every degree.

11 He sent then Jonathan the son
Of Absalom to Joppa's run,
And with him a goodly-sized band,
Who drove out its dwellers to stand.

12 Then Trypho left Ptolemais with
A large army to invade sith
Of Judah's land, and Jonathan
Was with him under the guard's span.
13 And Simon encamped in Adida,
Facing the plain *where none could hide*
her.

Brave Simon runs out to the fray to find
What things the enemy has left behind.
The fact is every man named Jonathan
Falls to the fate of the first and great one
The son of Saul, whose heart was knit and
won

In David, who survived complexities
To die of old age on Abishag's knees.
What shall become of this man, one of
choice,

Shall I come here to sorrow or rejoice?
Beloved, whatever score is written for
The Jonathan I see upon the shore,
In chains or gains, I trow his destiny

Is fraught, not of the actions or the fee
Of any king, but living faithfully.

14 Trypho learned that Simon had come
In place of Jonathan *no bum*

His brother, and he was about
To attack him in battle shout,
So he sent messengers to him,
And said 15 "It is for money trim
That Jonathan your brother owed
The royal treasury untowed,
Because of the office he held,
That we detain him, for the geld.

16 "Just send a hundred silver weights
And two of his sons for debates,
So when we let him go, we'll know
He'll not rebel, we'll let him go."

17 Simon knew they were speaking guile,
But he sent for money the while
And the sons, lest he draw complain
Among the people for the taint
Who might say 18 "Because Simon did
Not send him the money he bid,
And the sons, he perished *and hid*."

19 So he sent the sons and the money,
A hundred talents, but the *funny*
Trypho broke his word and did not
Release Jonathan from the plot.

Simon was sitting between rock and hard
Face as the saying throws and he has
starred

A movie of disdain for every pard,
And yet he was forced by diplomacy
To act as though uncircumcised degree
Was truthful. His experience of late
Showed Trypho not too honest as a mate.
Such tales become the songs of every bard.
Beloved, Simon must think of what such
men

Will say who are dishonest in their den,
Because he takes a place of power and rule.
I know not which of us two is the fool,
He or myself, who never stop to think
What other men will say when on the brink.

20 After this Trypho came into
The land to destroy it and crew,
And he went round Adora's way.
But Simon and his army'd stay
Nearby him every place he went.
21 But men in the fortress had sent

Messengers to Trypho to urge
 Him to come to them by the surge
 Of desert and bring food to splurge.
 22 So Trypho had his cavalry
 Ready to go, but that night, see,
 A heavy snowfall blocked the way,
 So because of the snow that day
 He did not go. He marched instead
 Into the land of Gilead.
 23 When he got near Baskama, he
 Killed Jonathan, and so there he
 Was buried there. 24 Then Trypho turned
 back
 And went to his own land for flack.
 25 And Simon sent and took the bones
 That Jonathan his brother owns,
 And buried him in Modein, town
 Of his ancestors *and their crown*.
 26 All Israel grieved for him with great
 Lamentation, and mourned in state
 For him for many days *and late*.

It's easy, my Beloved, to mourn the great,
 The truly great who keep Your law and
 hate
 The enemy, uncircumcised, and fell,
 Deceitful and unashamed of the spell.
 It's only difficult to find such ones
 Even in a world where the tons and tons
 Of human flesh increase incredibly
 Each moment that goes by on land and sea.
 It's easy, my Beloved, to grieve and yet
 How few there be whose grief is rightly set,
 More than the sort manipulated where
 Fair politics need public outcry spare.
 I grieve not for the loss of good and true,
 But for the fact that such men rarely grew.

27 And Simon built a monument
 Over his father's tomb and lent
 To his brothers as well, he made
 It high to be seen on parade,
 With polished stone at front and back.
 28 He also built, not being slack,
 Seven pyramids face to face,
 For father, mother and the brace
 Of four brothers. 29 And for the trace
 Of the pyramids he devised
 A jolly setting and apprised
 With high columns around about,
 And on the columns he put stout
 Suits of armour memorial,

And beside the armour in sal
 Carved ships so they could all be seen
 By those who sail the sea between.
 30 This is the tomb which he built in
 Modein, and it's still there in bin.
 31 Trypho dealt deceitfully by
 The young king Antiochus shy,
 And he killed him, 32 became instead
 The king, putting upon his head
 The crown of Asia, and he brought
 Disaster on the land for naught.
 33 But Simon built up the fortress
 Of Judah and walled their ingress,
 With high towers and great walls and gates
 And locks, and stored food in their plates.

There are men who are worse than others
 are,
 And these are those who support some such
 star
 Of king or prince or president to wait
 Their turn at carrying out common hate.
 Trypho pretended that he loved the child
 Left by the dead Antiochus and wild,
 But in fact he was summoning the day
 When he could plunder everything in sway.
 The plunderers are at the heel today,
 Sending their children to Strasbourg for
 song
 Pretending that they never do the wrong.
 The hope is not in government that's strong
 In all the world, nor in the slicing pie
 In independence, but faith in Your tie.

34 Simon also chose men and sent
 Them to King Demetrius' vent
 With a request to grant relief
 To the country, for all the feoff
 Of Trypho was to plunder grief.
 35 Demetrius the king sent him
 A favorable answer trim,
 Saying, 36 "King Demetrius to
 Simon, the high priest and friend true
 Of kings, and to the elders and
 Nation of the Jews, greetings stand.
 37 "We have received the gold crown and
 The palm branch which you sent, and we
 Are ready to make common fee
 Of it with you and to write to
 Our chiefs release from taxes due.
 38 "All the grants that we've made to you
 Remain in force, let each fortress

You've built remain in your address.
 39 "We pardon any errors and
 Offences that remain to stand
 This day, and cancel the crown tax
 Which you owe, and whatever tax
 Has been drawn from Jerusalem
 Shall no longer be brought in sum.
 40 "And if any of you are fit
 To be in our bodyguard's mit,
 Let them be inscribed, and be peace
 Between us two *and let war cease.*"

I graciously forgive all the tax owed
 To me by bow-legged and by pigeon-toed,
 And freely grant the heathen population
 And Christian too plenary dispensation.
 Though I'm the king of all the earth and
 still
 Have right to take what taxes fit my bill,
 In loving-kindness I relinquish all
 And touch no bank account or cattle stall.
 Beloved, I wonder that the populace
 Looks without guffaw on the royal face
 Of prime minister and the parliament
 For formal legislation of their lent.
 The ostentatious rights of humankind
 Prove You're the only Self that is not blind.

41 In one hundred and seventieth year
 The yoke of the Gentiles in gear
 Fell from Israel's neck and her ear,
 42 And people started then to write
 In their documents and on sight
 Of their contracts, "In the first year
 Of Simon great high priest to fear
 And commander and leader of
 The Jews *in one nation and love.*"
 43 In those days Simon camped in siege
 Of Gazara and with the liege
 Of his troop surrounded the town.
 He made a siege engine to frown
 On the city and battered and
 Captured one tower *above the land.*
 44 The men in the tanks jumped out in
 The city and cause a great din.
 45 The men in the city with spouse
 And offspring went up on the house
 Wall with their clothes torn and they cried
 Out with a loud voice bonafide
 For Simon to make peace with them,
 46 And they said "Don't in stratagem
 Deal with us according to our

Wicked deeds, but in mercy's power."

Simon the great set on Gazara stroke
 Of ram to hit the tower that finally broke
 And gave them entrance in the town's main
 street.

That's when the citizens without retreat
 Decided that the best way was to sue
 For peace and see what mercy might be
 due.

Simon was good with tanks in deathly bore,
 And that's why he was set up on the shore.
 Beloved, my last declension ran amok,
 My fired-up tower has tumbled, I am stuck
 Before invasion of Your hounding grief.
 I stand alone before the blazing feoff
 And know that You have choice for my
 relief:

Destruction of my soul or joy in tuck.

47 And Simon made a pact with them
 And stopped attack in stratagem.
 But put them outside the city,
 And cleansed the houses where the *witty*
 Idols were housed, and entered all
 With hymn of praise *from wall to wall.*
 48 He threw out every unclean thing,
 And set commandment-keepers' ring.

He also strengthened up the wall
 And then built himself there a stall.
 49 The men in the fortress that sat
 In Jerusalem were out flat
 Prevented from excursions to
 The countryside to buy and sue.
 So they were very hungry too,
 And many died from famine's due.
 50 They begged Simon to make peace then
 With them, and he rescued the men.
 But he expelled them from the place
 And cleansed the citadel for grace.
 51 On the twenty-third day in claim
 Of second month, and in the flame
 Of year one hundred seventy-first,
 The Jews came in the place once cursed
 With praise and palm and harps and sound
 Of cymbals and stringed instruments,
 And hymns and songs since a foe grand
 Had been crushed and lost his presence
 In Israel. 52 Simon each year
 Said to celebrate without fear
 This day with great rejoicing here.
 He strengthened the temple hill walls

Beside the citadel installs,
And he and his men lived there well.
53 And Simon saw his son John's spell
Had reached adulthood so he made
Him the chief of the army paid,
And he lived in Gazara's glade.

Before a place that Gentiles have polluted
Can be used by the holy convoluted,
It must be cleansed from drippings of the
fat

Of pork they ate and dribbled on the mat,
And every taint of gross idolatry
That is the mark of heathen bond and free.
Before prayer can be made where Gentiles
ate

A lot of cleaning must be done in rate.
Beloved, I find a forest purified
By sun and rain and made there to abide
The nests and dens of angels at my side,
Who bow and twitter on the spread prayer
rug
And then go out to sample seed and bug.
Beloved, I find a palace by the way
The ants trudge up my hill and come to
stay.

1 Maccabees 14

1 In year one hundred seventy-two
Demetrius the king took crew
And marched to Media for aid
To make war on *the renegade*
Trypho. 2 When Arsaces the king
Of Persia and Media heard ring
That Demetrius had invaded
His lands, he sent one of his *jaded*
Commanders to take him alive.
3 And he went out again to strive
Defeating Demetrius' band,
And seizing him to take in hand
To Arsaces and kept in guard.
4 The land had rest all Simon's days.
He sought his nation's good for praise,
His rule was pleasing to them, and
They showed him honour every hand
In all the days he came to stand.
5 To crown all his feats he took out
Joppa to be a harbour stout,
And opened a way to the isles
Of the sea all around for miles.
6 He extended his borderlands,

And gained full rule throughout their
bands.

7 He took a crowd of captives and
He ruled over Gazara and
Beth-zur and the fortress to stand,
And he removed its uncleanness
And none could oppose his address.

The great deeds of the leaders and the men
Who had ambition in those days again
Included winning battles and the taking
Of captives and not gold and wealth
forsaking.

The fame of Simon was in government
And in the church or tabernacle spent,
And in diplomacy and rhetoric.
The success of great men is always thick.
But in those days the great acts did include
A thing or two that nowadays preclude
The fanfare of the prideful. Simon gained
Glory and honour in the time he reigned
By doing cleaning jobs about the house.
That's what set him above both king and
mouse.

8 They tilled their land in peace, the ground
Gave its increase, and the trees round
The plains their fruit. 9 Old men sat in
The streets, they all talked without sin
Of good things, and the youths arrayed
Themselves in glory and parade.
10 He then provided towns with food,
And furnished with defence not rude,
Till his fame spread through the world's
brood.

11 He set up peace in the country,
And Israel rejoiced in glee.

12 Each sat under vine and fig tree,
And there was none that so made free
With fear. 13 No enemy was left around
To fight them, and the kings were found
Crushed in those days. 14 He strengthened
all

The humble of his people's call,
He sought out the law, and destroyed
Everyone wickedly employed.

In days of all it seems the only thing
Needed to make a paradise in ring
Was crushing all the kings that plundered
where

The people grew grapes and washed
underwear.

In day gone past only the kings made sport
Of populations and took them to court
In suit for all they had and more to boot.
Oh for the times with only one bad root!
Now that all kings are crushed monopoly
Of doing ill to neighbours with such glee
Is gone and every Tony, George and Tom
Is out to cash in on wicked pom-pom.
What only one could do in Simon's day
Is now the toy of all who play and pay.

15 He made the sanctuary fine,
And added to the pots of wine.
16 It was heard in Rome, and as far
Away as Sparta, that the star
Jonathan was dead and they grieved.
17 When they heard that Simon reprieved,
His brother had become high priest
In his stead, and his rule increased
Over and land and towns in it,
18 They wrote to him on bronze tablet
To renew with him the friendship
And the alliance which their lip
Had declared with Judas and to
Jonathan his brothers in crew.
19 And these were read before the crowd
In Jerusalem and aloud.

Next I'll be hearing that the Roman power
Is also Jewish in a craven hour,
And that Remus and Romulus were fed
On milk of Moses instead of wolf-bred.
If Sparta is a brother to the great
And holy, then why not also Rome's fate?
The trinity of Rome, Sparta and Zion
Is like enough to make a chart to fly on.
Let friendship ever grow upon the pate
Of senator and priest among the great,
And may oppression of those who would
 keep
Your law be celebrated now where weep
The few and far between. The rocky steep
Above my cabin almost makes a heap.

20 This is a copy of the brief
Which the Spartans sent for relief.
"The rulers and the city of
The Spartans to Simon for love
The high priest and to elders and
The priests and the rest in the land

Of Jewish folk, our brothers, greeting.
21 "The messengers that we were meeting
From you sent to our people told
Us about your glory and bold,
And we were glad that they arrived.
Rejoiced at their coming. 22 "And what
They said we have written down shut
In our public records, to wit,
'Numenius the son and fit
Of Antiochus, and the great
Antipater Jason's son mate,
Messengers of the Jews, have come
To us to renew friendship's *hum*.
23 "It has pleased our folk to receive
These men with honour and reprieve
And put a copy of their words
In the public archives *like birds*,
So that the Spartan people might
Have a record of them in sight.
And they have sent a copy of
This to Simon high priest above.'" 24 After this Simon sent the man
Numenius to Rome by plan
With a large gold shield with the weight
Of a thousand minas in state,
To confirm the treaty with Rome.
25 When the folk heard these things at
 home
They said, "How shall we thank Simon
And his sons? 26 "Because he has done
Along with his brothers and lot
Of his father to stand firm got,
They have fought and repulsed the foes
Of Israel and set *in rows*
Its freedom *as the people chose*."

If only I had a great shield and hammered
In pure gold thinly disguised from the
 whammered,
I too could be a great man in the senate,
And say a heeded word sweetly impennate.
If only I had gifts enough to make
Testosterone balls of pope's Swiss guards
 ache,
I too could flip a finger at the crass
That spreads out darkly on the White
 House grass.
Instead of walls I have the darkly sum
Of cantillations without viol or drum.
Instead of shields I have the prickly ware
Of canticles the Scriptures come to bear.
But if, Beloved, I came to You with gold,

What would You do with one so frightful,
bold?

27 So they made a record on bronze
Tablets and put it on the fronds
Of the pillars on Mount Zion.
This is a copy written done.
“On eighteenth day of Elul, in
The year one hundred and within
Seventy-two, which is the third
Year of Simon the great high herd,
28 “In Asaramel, in the great
Assembly of the priests in state,
And the folk and the rulers of
The nation and the elders of
The country, it was so proclaimed.
29 “Since wars often occurred unnamed
In the country, Simon the son
Of Mattathias, a priest son
Of the sons of Joarib, and
His brothers, exposed them in band
To danger and resisted foes
Of their nation, in order so’s
That their sanctuary and law
Might be perserved, and they in awe
Bring great glory to their folk’s paw.
30 “Jonathan rallied the folk then,
And became their high priest again,
And was gathered to his folk’s den.
31 “And when their enemies decided
To invade their country *when prided*
And lay hands on their sanctuary,
32 “Then Simon rose up and fought *merry*
For his nation. He spent great sums
Of his own money *on the bums*,
He armed his nation’s army and
Paid them their wages out of hand.
33 “He fortified the towns of Judah,
And Beth-zur on the borders cruder,
Where before were stored the foes’ arms,
And there he set Jews out of harms.
34 “He also fortified Joppa,
Beside the sea, and Gazara,
Which is on borders of Azotus,
Where the foes lived before *that smote us*.
He settled Jews there, and provided
In those towns whatever decided
Was needed for their peace *and law*.

The famous plaque of bronze says but the
truth
And glorifies the feats of men and youth,

And tells the great deed of the fine
Between their bouts of good food and good
wine.

The bronze may still lie somewhere in a
crack
To be discovered by the aching back
Of archaeologist who knows the score,
How Maccabees were heroes on the shore.
I wonder, my Beloved, despite the favour
Of fold and sundry for their honour’s
flavour,

If anything might have been set on wall
Without the instigation and the call
Of Simon himself. Truth is fickle, knows
How fame is advertised and whipped in
rows.

35 “The folk saw Simon’s faithfulness
And the glory of his address
Won for his nation, and they made
Him their leader and high priest paid,
Because he had done all these things
And because of the justice rings
And loyalty which he had shown
Toward his nation. He sought when grown
In every way to raise his folk.

36 And in his days things at a stroke
Prospered in his hands, so that all
The Gentiles were expelled in thrall
From the country, as were also
The men in David’s city’s glow
And in Jerusalem, who’d built
Themselves a citadel to tilt
From which they used to come defiling
The sanctuary’s side beguiling
And do great harm to purity.

37 He settled Jews in it *for free*,
And fortified it for safety
Of the country and the city,
And built walls of Jerusalem
Higher and higher *as a gem*.

38 “In view of all these things the King
Demetrius confirmed his ring
In the high priesthood, 39 and he made
Him one of the king’s friends and paid
Him high honors. 40 For he had heard
That the Jews were addressed in word
By the Romans as friends of worth,
And brothers, and the Romans’ earth
Had received messengers of Simon
And with auxh honour *to take time on*.

Though I am no friend of the Romans I
Also look to the town of David's sky
And see Jerusalem beneath the shine
Of golden dome and wait its sparkling
wine.

Though I am no friend of the coliseum,
Nor do I long for Romans or to see them,
I too find that the steep highway that runs
Up from Jericho seduces my buns.
I too accept the honours of the way,
I bow to take the scintillating day,
I turn toward the Beduin's poor tent
And see the children standing as though
sent

Among the goats. Beloved, my honours
rise

To none other beneath the blazing skies.

41 "And the Jews and their priests decided
That Simon should be chief unchided
And high priest for ever, until
A trustworthy prophet set bill,

42 And that he should be governor
Over them and that he should store
The sanctuary and appoint
Men over its tasks and anoint
The country and its arms and forts,
And he should take as last resorts
Charge of the sanctuary *sports*,

43 And he should be obeyed by all,
And that all contracts in the stall
Should be written in his name, and
That he should be arrayed in grand
Purple and wear gold *like the sand*.

44 "And none of the people or priests
Shall be permitted for their feasts
To nullify any of these
Decisions or oppose decrees
That he makes, or to call assembly
In the land without his word trembly,
Or to be clothed in purple or put
On a gold buckle, *hand or foot*.

45 "Whoever acts contrary to
These decisions or nullifies
Any of them shall meet as due
Punishment instead of a prize."

All the best plans of chief and king and folk
Are submitted to the impending stroke
Of possibility of coming prophet.
Simon is priest as long as there is no
Responsible seer to oil the show

And raise a tentpeg and another soffit.
Beloved, the priests of every tent and gear
That trample around sacrificial bier
Are of the same ilk as Simon the bold.
All priests are enmeshed in the royal word
And merely chosen from the shriven herd,
And taken from the king's own flock and
fold.

If only there were priest alive to see
Chosen by You and sent with equity!

46 And all the people then agreed
To grant Simon the right in deed
To act in accord with these plots.

47 So Simon accepted his lots
And agreed to be the high priest,
To be commander and increased
Prince of the Jews and priests, and to
Be protector of all their crew.

48 And they gave command to engrave
This decree upon brazen pave,
To set them up where all could see
In precincts of sanctuary,

49 And to deposit copies of
Them in the treasury for love,
So that Simon and his sons might
Always maintain these things in sight.

Simon agreed to accept the folk's will
And that of king sitting on kingly hill.
The mandate did not come from You on
high

But from the hopes and wishes not to die
On the part of the king and populace.

The mandate is a mandate without trace
Of divine providence, authority.

It is merely a substitute in fee
For silence on Your part. Beloved, I know
Why You never speak now or then to show
The right. It simply is because the crowd
Has never yet turned to what You allowed
To be heard on Sinai. So why speak more?
Another word would just fall on the shore.

1 Maccabees 15

1 Antiochus, the son of King
Demetrius, sent out a thing
From the sea islands to Simon,
The priest and prince of the Jews won,
And to all the nation, 2 which said
"King Antiochus to well-bred
Simon the high priest and the prince

And to the nation of Jews' stints,
 Greeting. 3 "Since certain lawless guys
 Have taken over the excise
 Of our ancestors' kingdom, now
 I intend to lay claim somehow
 To the kingdom so that I may
 Restore it to its former way,
 And I've hired an army of troops
 And provided worships in groups,
 4 "And I intend to make a landing
 In the country with understanding
 That I may attack those destroying
 Our country and those I'm deploring
 For the destruction of the towns
 That have been till now my own crown's.
 5 "Now I confirm to you concessions
 Of all the taxes in kings' sessions
 Before me have granted you free,
 And release you from every fee
 That they forgave you before me.
 6 "I grant the right to mint your own
 Money for your country alone,
 7 "I grant Jerusalem its freedom
 And temple too not to impede them.
 All weapons that you have prepared
 And fortresses that you've not bared
 And now hold shall remain your own.
 8 "Every debt you owe to the throne
 And any future such shall be
 Cancelled for you're from now on free.
 9 "When we gain rule of our kingdom,
 We will show you honour in sum,
 To you and your nation and more
 To your sanctuary in store,
 So your glory may well appear
 In all the earth for all to fear."

This is not the first king nor is it last
 Who defines freedom as being the blast
 Of his own power and fury when it's cast.
 The speckled resident of Casa Blanca
 Supporting military coup and wonka
 On the Algerian coast said openly
 He did his actions for democracy.
 So Antiochus speaks no new vocabulary
 But what's surely known to every
 constabulary.
 Beloved, You are the same, I trow, I find
 Submission to Your law not to be blind
 But liberating from infesting lights
 Of culture and biology in rights.
 Fortuitous freedom is just a grind.

10 In year one hundred seventy-four
 Antiochus set out on shore
 To invade his ancestral lands.
 All the troops rallied to his hands,
 So there were few with Trypho's hands.
 11 Antiochus pursued him, and
 He came in his flight to Dor's sand,
 Which is beside the sea, 12 for he
 Knew that troubles piled up freely
 On him with troops gone from the spree.
 13 So Antiochus came to camp
 Against Dor, and with him to stamp
 Were one hundred and twenty thousand
 Foot soldiers, cavalry eight thousand.
 14 He surrounded the town, and ships
 Joined battle from the sea, in grips
 He pressed the city hard from land
 And from the sea, and at a stand
 Let no one leave or go in hand.

There is simply no reason that supposed
 King Antiochus might not just have dozed
 Under his own fig tree, but power posed
 Illusion of his trumpeting to find
 Enjoyment in the wenching and the wined.
 He did not have to gather men and gun,
 He did not have to weather on the run
 The blood and gore and hopeless colours
 flying.
 He could have stayed to live instead of
 dying.
 Beloved, let me choose peace and simple
 fare
 In joy without the cry and awful flare
 Of domination on the sod a while.
 Let me in faith capture the passing mile
 And go further than Antiochus dare.

15 Then Numenius and his friends
 Arrived from Rome to make amends,
 With letters to the kings and lands,
 Saying 16 "Lucius, Roman consul
 To King Ptolemy, greeting's *tonsil*.
 17 "The Jewish messengers have come
 To us as our friends and in sum
 As allies to renew our old
 Friendship and alliance as told.
 They had been sent by Simon high
 Priest and by the Jewish folk's try,
 18 "And have brought a gold shield that
 weighs

A thousand minas *where it stays*.

19 "So we have decided to write
To the kings and countries that fight
That they should not seek harm or make
War against them and their towns sake
And their country, or make alliance
With those who fight them in defiance.
20 "And it has seemed good to us now
To accept their shield anyhow.
21 "So if any outlaws have fled
To you from their country, instead
Hand them over to Simon high
Priest, so he can punish the guy
According to their lullaby."

The law of extraditions seems to be
A Roman thought imposed on the country
That sided with them in the peace invoked
Upon the Middle Sea when others choked.
There's nothing like the intervention made
To lighten load of the oppression stayed
If power is sought to go upon crusade,
Or bring down tariffs on exports and trade.
But extradition is a wondered thing
That greatly helps to frighten underling.
Beloved, I pray that You will extradite
Me from this place of wickedness and
fright
And take me to Your courts before Your
throne
Where every robin finds justice to own.

22 The consul wrote the same thing to
Demetrius the king and to
Attalus and Ariarathes
And Arsaces, 23 and to all these
Countries, and to Sampsames, and
To the Spartans, and to the band
Of Delos, and to Myndos, and
To Sicyon, and to Caria, and
To Samos, and Pamphylia,
To Lycia, and Halicarnassus,
And to Rhodes, and to Phaselis,
And to Cos, and to Side, and
To Aradus and Gortyna
And Cnidus, Cyprus and Cyrene.
24 They also sent a copy greenie
Of these things to Simon high priest,
Who was alert to say the least.

The list of countries in relations' pact
With Rome displays in fascinating fact,

That Rome was good at far diplomacy,
And this is what gave her both land and sea
To rule after a time in infancy.
Can one control the world with letters
signed,
Justing sending them out among eyed and
blind?
If so, an e-mail sent around the world
Is like a banded flag once more unfurled.
Do not, Beloved, trust in the spoken word
Or in the writing on the wall that's heard.
Rome backed it up with arms, struck down
and whacked
All those who did not recognize the
cracked
And fatal speech and sword when they
attacked.

25 Antiochus the king set siege
Against Dor once again with liege
And cannon's force and tank to butt
And that way kept Trypho there shut.
26 And Simon sent Antiochus
Two thousand chosen men in truss
To fight for him, silver and gold
And much equipment he could hold.
27 But he refused to receive them,
And he broke all agreements' hem
That he had made with Simon, and
Became estranged from him *and band*.
28 He sent to him Athenobius,
One of his friends, *come out to try us*,
Saying, "You hold under your hand
Joppa and Gazara and stand
In fortress in Jerusalem,
They are cities of my kingdom.
29 "You've devastated their surroundings,
And done great damage in your soundings,
And you have taken as your lot
Many places of royal plot.
30 "So now hand over the towns that
You have seized and the tribute pat
Of the places which you have conquered
Outside of Judah's borders honkered,
31 "Or else give me for them five hundred
Talents of silver, and for bundred
Destruction that you've caused and more
The tribute money of the score
Of towns, five hundred talents more.
Or else we'll come and make you sore."

Greed always blinds the powerful from
 seeing
 What is the real advantage to their being,
 And is the seed that subverts every state
 That ignores human rights and human pate.
 It was true in the days of Simon then,
 It is true in these days of common men
 Who pretend to establish kingdoms where
 Their companies come in and fail to share.
 Beloved, I see the human heart laid bare,
 And every motive made of at least three
 Strands woven in the diviner decree:
 Added to greed lust and its cruelty.
 Beloved, look in grace and mercy on me
 And strike down at least two out of the
 spree.

32 So Athenobius the friend
 Of the king came on his errand
 To Jerusalem, and when he
 Saw the splendour of Simon's fee,
 And sideboard with gold, silver plate,
 And his magnificence as great,
 He was amazed. And he reported
 To him the words the king resorted,
 33 But Simon gave him this reply:
 "We have neither taken the land
 Of strangers nor seized foreign stand,
 But only the inheritance
 Of our ancestors, which one time
 Was unjustly seized by our prime
 Foes. 34 "And now that we have the
 chance,
 We firmly hold inheritance.
 35 "As for Joppa and Gazara,
 Which you demand, they were in straw
 Causing great damage to our folk,
 And to our land, so at a stroke
 For them we'll give you talents told
 One hundred *of silver, not gold.*"
 Athenobius did not say
 A word to him, 36 but went back in
 Anger to the king in his bin
 And told him these words and the glory
 Of Simon and all of the story
 Of what he saw. And the king sat
 In great anger where he was at.

Athenobius had a chance to give
 An offer in the dicker and the sieve.
 Instead in pride and greed his anger boiled
 And taught the king also in what he toiled.

The market is the place where peace is
 made
 In negotiations' heathen parade.
 Peace reigns where trade is brisk and often
 sought
 With all safety for those who could have
 fought.
 Beloved, You gave a gift to heathen man
 In giving trade to protect every can.
 Where virtue does not teach the way to go,
 At least self-interest out to make a glow.
 The greed and mall above what earth
 provides
 Is what leads to the battle choosing sides.

37 Now Trypho embarked on a ship
 And escaped to Orthosia's lip.
 38 Then the king made Cendebeus chief
 Of the coastal country in brief,
 And gave him troops of infantry
 As well as some in cavalry.
 39 He commanded him to encamp
 Against Judea, *like a scamp*,
 And ordered him to build up Kedron
 And fortify its gates, and *head-on*
 Make war on the people, while
 The king pursued Trypho *a mile*.
 40 So Cendebeus came up to
 Jamnia and began to view
 The people and invade Judea
 And take the people captive freer
 And kill them. 41 He built up Kedron
 And stationed there horsemen and drawn
 Troops, so that they might go out and
 Make raids along the highways' sand
 Of Judah, at the king's command.

Mark this, Beloved, that when the robber
 band
 Comes bravely out to make a wicked stand
 Against the innocent and passer-by,
 It's because there's a king there on the sly
 That hiddenly gives orders to relate.
 The decline of order and peace is found
 Always to be the machinations' round
 Of someone whose greed makes him think
 the sound
 Of his own voice is that of God above
 Who justifies his attack on the love
 Of every man that sits under the glove
 Of his own fig tree planted in the ground.
 Let seven paces be set out for each

Man to cultivate before coming preach.

1 Maccabees 16

1 John went up from Gazara and
Reported to Simon his grand
What Cendebeus had done there.

2 And Simon called in his two fair
Older sons Judas and John, and
Said to them "The whole family clanned
Have fought the wars of Israel
From our youth to this day and well,
So we saved Israel many times.

3 "But now I'm old after my climbs,
And you by His mercy are grown.
Stand in the stead of me and throne
Of my brother, and go and fight
For our nation, and may the light
Of Heaven's aid be in your sight."

4 John picked from the land twenty
thousand
Infantry, cavalry undrowsened.
And they marched off to the attack
Of Cendebeus and set rack
For the night in Modein *on track*.

5 Early in the morning they got
Up and marched to the plain and fought,
Indeed, a large band of footmen
And horsemen met them in the glen
And a stream lay between the men.

6 He and his army stood arrayed.
He saw the soldiers were afraid
To cross the stream, so he crossed first,
And when his men saw him uncursed,
They crossed after him *in a burst*.

7 Then he divided up the men
And put the cavalry again
Among the infantry, because
The foe had many horses' *haws*.

I praise John and his twenty grand who
came
Out to attack the Gentiles on the strand
And lay them low and destroy every hand.
This world would be a better place I trow
If all penises were without the plough
Of foreskins, I believe so anyhow.
So I praise John for coming to attack
The Gentiles and for driving Gentiles back.
Beloved, I've often wondered at the sound
That You created mankind on the ground
In Your own image. Does that mean to say
That You are uncircumcised in the fray,

Or that the law completed what in due
Creation from the first had in its view?

8 And they sounded the trumpets, and
Cendebeus with army band
Were put to flight, and many struck
And fell down dead, *that was their luck*,
And the rest fled into the fort.

9 At that time Judas *a good sport*
And brother of John felt the sword,
But John pursued them till *the gourd*
Cendebeus reached Kedron's *ford*,
Which he had built for *the implored*.

10 They also fled into the towers
In Azotus's fields of flowers,
But John burned it with fire, and fell
Around two thousand of the swell.
And he got back to Judah well.

I grieve, Beloved, so many men escaped
John's hand among the monkeyed and the
aped.

Two thousand dead among the wicked foe
Is victory indeed, but greater show
Is needed for the earth to reap the glow
Of righteousness in every sort of row.
I grieve, Beloved, so many men went free
From John, his infantry and cavalry.
Beloved, burn every tower within my heart
Where evil lurks and sins would find a part.
Beloved, send me out on the road with John
To multiply the slaying of each pawn
That comforts law of jungle and the sword
Of devastation on oppressed and gored.

11 Ptolemy son of Abubus
Had been appointed to chief *fuss*
Over the plain of Jericho,
With much silver and gold to show,
12 As son-in-law of the high priest.
13 His heart was lifted and *increased*,
And he decided to gain rule
Of the country, and *as a fool*
Made traitor's plans against Simon
To destroy him and sons each one.
14 Then Simon went out to inspect
The town of the land and reflect
On their needs, and he went down to
Jericho with Mattathias too
And Judas his sons all in crew
In year one hundred seventy-seven,
In eleventh month *under heaven*,

Which is the month of Shebat *due*.
 15 The son of Abubus received
 Them like a traitor *and deceived*
 In the little fortress that called
 Dok, which he had built up *and walled*,
 And gave them a great feast, but hid
 His men there ready *should he bid*.
 16 When Simon and his sons were drunk,
 Ptolemy and his men *who stunk*
 Got up, took their weapons, and rushed
 The feast hall where Simon was crushed
 Dead with his two sons and some slaves.
 17 That is the way a man behaves
 In treachery to render ill
 For good received on his own bill.

I don't condone the treachery proposed
 By Ptolemy ben Abubus when closed
 Within the fort of Dok, and yet I find
 That Simon and Judas acted as blind
 To trust their lives to friends whose
 friendship came
 From being offered riches, power and
 fame.
 It's trusting greatly to drink up and drink
 Again until both spirit and soul sink.
 The Torah verdict on the drunken wight
 Is to snuff out his life on the first night.
 So Simon my hero and president
 Got what he just deserved for where he
 went.
 Beloved, slay every drunken fool that
 shows
 A face on the highways the righteous
 chose.

18 Then Ptolemy wrote a report
 About these things and sent for sport
 To the king, asking him to send
 Troops to aid him and in the end
 Let him rule town and country' bend.
 19 He sent other men to Gazara
 To do away with John *like sparrow*,
 He sent letters to captains asking
 Them to come to him so *in basking*
 He might give them silver and gold
 And *other gifts to make them bold*,
 20 And he sent other men to take
 Possession of the larger stake
 Jerusalem and temple hill.
 21 But some one ran ahead to fill
 In John at Gazara his dad

And brothers had been stricken bad,
 And "he's sent men to kill you too."
 22 When he heard this, his shock was great,
 He seized the men who came irate
 To destroy him and he killed them,
 As he found out their stratagem.
 23 The rest of the acts of John and
 His wars and brave deeds of his hand,
 And building projects and achievements,
 24 Indeed, they are written receivements
 In the records of his high priesthood,
 From the time his early leasthood
 When he became the great high priest
 After his father was deceased.

I fail to comprehend You in the way
 You let so many wicked men here stay
 To live and trouble every righteous man
 When You could just as well conceive a
 plan
 To wipe them off the earth and let remain
 The whole clan of the righteous and the
 sane.
 It is a question many folk have asked
 Without an answer that's not overtasked.
 But I'll give You the benefit of doubt.
 You always leave a seed, a hope, a scout.
 If all the Maccabees there were are dead,
 You have a hidden leader and one bred
 In secret or in open in whose sight
 The world at last sometime may come to
 right.

2 Maccabees

The second book of Maccabees claims to be a summary of a larger work by Jason of Cyrene, yet deals specifically with the events between 180 and 161 B.C.E. The central figure is Judas Maccabeus. Its historical scope is thus much more limited than that of 1 Maccabees. On the other hand, it presents some later controversial aspects of religion, specifically, prayer for the dead, merit of martyrdom, intercession of saints, and resurrection, all typically Pharisaical doctrines, and with the exception of the last, much opposed by the Protestant reformation. The book thus stands at the pivotal point of theological

controversy between Rome and the Reformation.

The spiritual value of the book remains, however, as strong as the first book, in affirming the abiding importance of divine law and the Sabbath.

2 Maccabees 1

1 The Jewish brothers in the town
Jerusalem and those in crown
Of Judah, to their Jewish kin
In Egypt, greetings, peace within.
2 May Alohim do good to you,
And may He mind his pact in view
Of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob,
His faithful servants *come to shake up*.
3 May He give all of you a heart
To worship Him and do His part
With courage and a willing mind.
4 May He open your heart not blind
To His law and His commandments,
And may He bring peace *in your tents*.
5 May He hear your prayers and reply
Not leaving you in time to die.
6 We are now praying for you here.

In times past such descriptions were not found.

No one prayed for another on the ground
And none asked to be entered in the sound
Of supplication in the holy round.

But times have changed, and all men are distressed

And all are seeking something of the best,
And all are waiting that the poor, oppressed
Might be delivered and justice addressed.
So since the time of noble Maccabee
Every letter and parting in degree
Is hailed with on petition of the free:
My brother, sister, mind and pray for me.
Beloved, I pray for many when they ask
And others when they neglect that fair task.

7 In reign of Demetrius' fear,
In one hundred sixty-ninth year,
We Jews wrote to you, in the great
Distress which came upon us late
In those years after Jason and
His mates rebelled from holy land
And kingdom 8 and they burned the gate
And shed innocent blood in hate.
We prayed to YHWH and we were heard,

And we offered sacrifice stirred
And grain offering, and we lit high
The lamps and set out the loaves nigh.
9 And now see that you keep the feast
Of booths in Chislev's month at least,
In one hundred eighty-eighth year.

10 Those in Jerusalem and near
In Judah and the elders and
Judas, to Aristobulus,
Who is of the family's bus
Of priests anointed, teacher of
Ptolemy the king, and in love
To the Jews in Egypt, greeting
And good health *and good everything*.

11 Having been saved by Alohim
Out of grave dangers, *it would seem*,
We thank Him greatly that He took
Our side against the king to look.

12 He drove out those who would attack
The holy city *at our back*.

13 For when the chief reached Persia by
A band that looked beyond our try,
They were cut up in Nanea's temple
By a deception and a stemple
The priests of Nanea employed.

14 Under pretext that he enjoyed
The hope of marriage, Antiochus
Came with his mates there and to rock us
Of the treasures of the town for
A dowry of his kept in store.

Oh Antiochus is looked up to by
The populace, though every king is sly.
He struts and gluts and tells the gullible
How wonderful he is and they are full.
Oh Antiochus falls in love or not,
But wants to marry to keep up his plot,
And so he tries to steal a bit of clot
To pay his dowry in the temple lot.
The honest man is forced to pay his bills
With earnings of his own and not the swills
Of plunder taken from the other man.
But kings enjoy another kind of plan
Just like the chiefs of companies today
Skim off the cream and leave the curds and whey.

15 When the priests of the temple of
Nanea had set out above
The treasures and Antiochus
Had come with a few men in bus
Inside the sacred temple wall,

They closed the temple doors as soon
 As he came in *to seek his boon*.
 16 They opened up a secret door
 In the ceiling and threw a store
 Of stones and struck the chieftain down,
 Along with his men of renown,
 Cut off their legs and arms and head,
 And threw them to the crowd outspread.
 17 Blessed in every way be our God,
 Who has brought judgment on the sod
 Of those behaving wickedly.
 18 Since on Chislew twenty-five we
 Celebrate temple's purity,
 We thought it good to notify
 You that you might now give a try
 At keeping feast of booths and feast
 Of fire established and increased
 When Nehemiah built the wall
 Of the temple and altar's call
 To offer sacrifices all.
 19 For when our fathers were in way
 Of being led captive in sway
 To Persia, the pious of priests
 Of that time took some fire for feasts
 From the altar and secretly
 Hid it in the hollow's degree
 Of a dry cistern, where they took
 Precautions that no one would look
 There. 20 But after many years passed,
 When it pleased Alohim at last,
 Nehemiah, commissioned by
 The king of Persia, sent thereby
 Descendants of the priests who'd hidden
 The fire to take it out as bidden.
 And when they reported to us
 That they'd not found the igneous
 But a thick liquid, he told them
 To dip it out and bring the gem.
 21 And when the sacrifices came,
 Nehemiah ordered for flame
 The priests should sprinkle on the wood
 The liquid residue they could.

 I wonder, my Beloved, was secret scent
 Of fire and water in the cool air went
 To make of earth Your footstool once more
 rent
 By love and faith upon the goodly brood.
 I do not know what time and priest had
 stewed
 In secret arts forbidden to the shrewd.
 I only read with wonder all the words

That speak on behalf of the beasts and birds
 Who worshipped all the days when temple
 shreds
 Lay used and abused under light of sun.
 I only read the script when it is done
 And seek the passages where things are
 won.
 Beloved, grant me the living fire to taste
 Beside the pool of Kauthar with all haste.

 22 After some time the clouds dispersed
 And the sun in its glory versed
 Shone out and then a great fire burst
 Up so all marvelled *at the worst*.
 23 And while the sacrifice was burning,
 The priests offered the prayers concerning
 The priests and everyone *there learning*.
 Jonathan led, the rest responded,
 As had done Nehemiah *fronded*.
 24 This was the prayer: "O YHWH, Lord
 God,
 Creator of all things *in pod*,
 Who are awe-inspiring and strong
 And just and merciful along,
 Who alone are King and are kind,
 25 "Who alone are bountiful, who
 Alone are just, almighty, *true*
 And eternal, and who rescue
 Israel from every wicked way,
 Who did choose our ancestors' sway
 And consecrated them *that day*,
 26 "Accept this sacrifice for all
 Your people Israel *in this hall*
 And keep Your heritage and make
 It holy *for Your holy sake*.
 27 "Gather our scattered people, set
 Free those who are still slaves and met
 Among the Gentiles, look on those
 Who are rejected and in throes
 Despised, and let the Gentiles know
 That You are our God *on the go*.
 28 "Afflict those who oppress and are
 Insolent in their pride for star.
 29 "Plant your folk in Your holy place,
 As Moses said *before Your face*."

 Jonathan's prayer is spoken like a friend
 Who speaks to You with a kind ear to lend.
 Three camps there seem to be in time of
 prayer:
 The ones who mumble jumble on the air
 And call it moving of the Holy Ghost,

And those who say their own words
without boast,
And those who stick to the warm liturgy
Repeating what for ages has decree.
Beloved, no doubt my own prayers are a
streak

So often couched in sonnet-like bird-beak,
With couplets drawn out like ghazel to seek
Your loving heart where I need never
speak.

Beloved, let prayer be silence or the din,
But open up Your heart and let me in.

30 Then the priests sang the *ancient* hymns.

31 And when the offering seraphims
Had consumed, Nehemiah ordered
That the liquid that was left quartered
Should be poured out upon large stones.

32 When this was done, a fire atones
But when the altar light shone back,
The flame extinguished its attack.

33 The thing they saw they told the king
Of the Persians that in the wings
Where the exiled priests had secreted
The fire, came liquid undefeated

With which Nehemiah and friends
Had burned with sacrificial ends,

34 The king investigated it,
And made it as sacred as fit.

35 And with those persons whom the king
Favoured he exchanged many a thing.

36 And Nehemiah and his friends
Called this "nephthar," the which name
tends

To recall purifying ends,
But most folk call it naphtha's bends.

From Nehemiah's day it seems the Persians
Have worshipped oil without any
aversions.

Naphtha's the way we get the finest gas
To help quickly to move recumbent ass.
The sacred fire of covenant at last
Is brought to light transfigured in the
gassed.

To worship You, Beloved, it seems it's best
To pour benzene upon the logs at rest
Upon the altar of the blazing heart
And watch the flames jump in and do their
part.

Some mystics contemplate the inner mind
And relish all the things within they find,

While others know the way to beat the
brass

Is something pungent smelling, something
crass.

2 Maccabees 2

1 In records prophet Jeremiah
Told the captives to take some fire
With them on deportation's pyre,

2 And the prophet when he had given
The law instructed them to live in
Captivity and not forget

The commandments of YHWH, nor yet
Be led astray in thought when they
See gold and silver statues' way
And their adornment of *great pay*.

3 And he went on to reaffirm
How the law should in every term
Remain in their heart *and be firm*.

4 The writing also said the prophet
Heard in oracle not to scoff at
That the ark and the tent should follow
With him out on the mountain hallow
Where Moses had gone up and seen
Inheritance of Alohim.

5 And Jeremiah came and found
A cave, and he brought there tent bound
And the ark and the altar of
Incense, and he sealed up above

The entrance. 6 Some of those who went
After him came as they were sent
To mark the way, but could not find it.

7 When Jeremiah heard behind it,
He chided them and said "The place
Shall be unknown without a trace
Till Alohim gather in grace
His folk again and in His grace.

8 "And then YHWH will disclose these
things,

And the glory of YHWH and rings
Of cloud will appear, as they came
In Moses time *in shade and flame*
And as Solomon asked the place
Should be consecrated *in trace*."

The truth is hidden in each human heart,
But only the few know the mining art
That will uncover the gem and the cart.

The prophet at the orders of Your hand
Has hidden treasure in each pilgrim band
And sent them out to live in every land.

The truth is hidden, yes, but few may know

The guidance to its holy, happy glow.
Beloved, be my guide in the way I go,
And let me find within my heart the light
Of incense on the altar in my night.
I see the ringing wrong, perceive the right,
But still I beg the leading path and way
Upon the gilded finishings of day.

9 It was also made clear that being
Possessed of wisdom in his seeing
That Solomon sacrificed gear
For dedication of the gear
And finishing the temple here.
10 Just as when Moses prayed to YHWH,
And fire came down from heaven in view
Consuming every sacrifice,
So also Solomon prayed twice,
And fire came down consuming all
The burnt offerings *upon the stall*.
11 And Moses said, "They were consumed
Because the sin offering of doomed
Had not been eaten." 12 Solomon
Also kept the eight days *when done*.
13 The same things are reported in
The records and in memoirs bin
Of Nehemiah, and also
That he made a library glow
And gathered all the books in show
About the kings and prophets so,
And writings of David, and briefs
Of kings about votive reliefs.
14 In the same way Judas also
Collected all the books to go
That had been lost because of war
Which had arisen on our shore,
And we still have them all in store.

The light of inspiration that fell on
Moses and Solomon in rosy dawn
And fueled the altar and the temple drawn
Remains secreted in the sacred books
That Nehemiah placed in hidden nooks
And Judas in his day saved from the crooks
That rose to destroy Israel by their hooks.
The light of inspiration still a-pace
In a world spread before Your divine face
Is what my heart and soul thirst for in race,
Beloved, so open them to me in grace.
The writings of the Prophet David sound
Within my heart and fall upon my ground

And lead me to Your throne in wavering
trace.

15 So if you have need of them, send
People to get them for your end.
16 Since, therefore, we're about to keep
The purification *in heap*,
We write to you. Will you therefore
Please keep the days *as once before*?
17 It is Alohim who has saved
All His folk, and returned enslaved
Inheritance to all, and still
The kingship and priesthood to fill
With consecration *on the hill*,
18 As He has promised through the law.
For we have hope in Alohim
That He will soon have mercy draw
Upon us and as it may seem
Will gather us from everywhere
Under heaven into His share
Of holiness, for he has saved
Us from great evils and engraved
This place with purity *and staved*.
19 Judas Maccabeus' history
And that of his brothers' decree,
Purification of the great
Temple, and dedication late
Of the altar, 20 as well as wars
On Antiochus Epiphanes
And his son Eupator *for grannies*,
21 And the appearances which came
From heaven to those who strove in fame
For Judaism, so that though
Few in number they seized the row
Of the whole land and then pursued
The Gentile hordes *both vile and rude*,
22 And re-established house of fame
The temple throughout the world's claim
And freed the city and restored
The laws cast down, and so the Lord
With great mercy showed grace on them,
23 All this written by Jason of
Cyrene in five books of love
We hope to write here in one book
For everyone to take a look.

The central issue of this book's revealed
To be the house of God, rebuilt and sealed,
The edifice on the mountain to show
That You are God alone of all the row.
The temple is the place where sacrifice

And incense covered stench of blood with
 nice
 Odours for those who prayed a while
 before
 The curtained entrance and the brazen door.
 Beloved, the book of my heart too is done
 In golden letters on the tables won,
 And while the prayers and offerings of my
 breath
 Are counted out from birth until my death,
 I turn to You and seek Your will alone
 As I come tripping, dancing at Your throne.

24 Since many people want to know,
 And there's so much to read on row,
 25 We've aimed to please those who would
 read,
 To make it easy for the speed
 Of those who wish to memorize,
 To profit readers every size.
 26 For us who've engaged here to cut
 It is no light matter in gut,
 But calls for sweat and loss of sleep,
 27 Just as it's not easy to keep
 A banquet and seek others' joy.
 But to get others' thanks in toy
 We'll gladly endure the hard toil,
 28 Leaving responsibility
 For exact details in the fee
 To the compiler, while the coil
 Of our effort's to make outline
 Of the condensation just fine.
 29 For as the master builder of
 A new house must be concerned of
 The whole construction, while the one
 Who undertakes its painting run
 And decoration has to think
 Only what's suitable for brink
 Of its adornment, such in my
 Judgment is the case with our try.
 30 It is the duty of the first
 Historian to keep the burst
 Of discussing each side of things
 And trouble with details and rings.
 31 But he who recasts narrative
 Ought to strive for brevity's sieve
 And leave off long distractionings.
 32 At this point therefore let us start
 Our narrative, adding from heart
 Only so much to what's been said,
 For it's a foolish thing in spread
 To lengthen the preface while cutting

Short the history itself abutting.

Beloved, I add to these words introducing
 The narrative, though they are only juicing
 Excuses for the brevity and song.
 I make no such excuses for my wrong.
 My hymn to You has every right to be
 Between the writings of the minstrelsy,
 And the first human duty on the brink
 Of the soul's gross existence is to drink
 From poet's draught and lift a wayward
 voice

Sometimes to sorrow and sometimes
 rejoice.

Beloved, let editors of book long since
 Researched, expounded and left with a
 wince

Have their own glory, You and I shall come
 Into our meeting place and have a hum.

2 Maccabees 3

1 The holy city was in peace
 And lawfulness on the increase
 Because of Onias the high
 Priest, who loved righteousness thereby
 Hating what wicked people try.
 2 It happened that even the kings
 Respected the Holy Place things
 And made the temple shine with gifts
 In splendour to extent that lifts
 All the expenses that arose
 From sacrifices, the king chose
 To pay for, even Seleucus
 King of Asia without a fuss.
 3 But then Simon of Bilgah's clan,
 The treasurer of temple span,
 Made quarrel with the high priest for
 The city markets and their score.
 4 A man named Simon, of the tribe
 Of Benjamin, who *without bribe*
 Had been made chief of temple, had
 A disagreement, *and one bad*,
 With the high priest about the way
 The city market *ought to play*,
 5 When he could not get upper hand
 Over Onias in command
 He went to Apollonius
 Who was a man come from Tarsus,
 And who at that time was the chief
 Of Coelesyria and reef
 Phoenicia. 6 He told him that
 Treasure in Jerusalem's vat

Was full of untold sums of money,
So it could not be counted funny,
And that they did not then belong
To the sacrifice budget *strong*,
But could be under the control
Of the king *if a valiant soul*.
7 Apollonius met the king,
And told him of the money thing.
The king chose Heliodorus,
Who was chargé d'affaires in fuss,
And sent him with commands to take
The money that lay there in wake.

It's always rumours of great wealth seduces
The men to war who had in peace held
truces.

The hidden arms and gold at Waco's brink
Is what caused US government to stink.
Simon, the king and Apollonius
Join hands conspiring with Heliodorus
To get the gold. If not the naphtha gold
Is the next thing that's on the market sold
And makes like nothing else the blood run
cold.

Beloved, the way to riches is well paved
With the intentions of all those enslaved
By their corruption and the lust to rule
All other men, though each may be a fool.
Even Your sanctuary's such a school.

8 Heliodorus at once set out
On his journey, with all the clout
To inspect Coelesyrian towns
And those on the Phoenician downs,
But really there to carry out
The king's hopes for gold *without doubt*.

9 When he got to Jerusalem
And had been kindly given hem
By the high priest there in the city,
He told what had been said and why
He had come and asked him thereby
If it was true that on the sly
There was a treasure for the guy.

10 The high priest said that there were
sums

Collected for the widows' hums
And orphans, 11 and also some coin
Of Hyrcanus, Tobias' son,
Man of high position to join,
In all four hundred talents of
Silver and two hundred of gold.
To such lengths had gone without love

Impious Simon in lies told.
12 He said no wrong thing must be done
To those folk who trust in the gun
Of the holy place and the room
Inviolatè honoured for doom
Throughout the world by everyone.
13 But Heliodorus, because
Of the king's commands had in claws,
Said that the money anyway
Should be forfeit to the king's pay.
14 So he set a day and went in
To oversee the funds in bin.
The whole town was distressed *for sin*.

Do not frown on the heathen king that sent
To temple treasury where the folk lent
Their wealth for safety to replenish load
Of office and of kingdom by the goad.
The Christian church wherever she is found
With hand in pocket of the less renowned
Is always greedy too, and more so when
The pocket's that of widows and poor men.
The Lutherans in Finland always took
For the rich parsons the widows last nook,
The last cow and the last shirt on the back
Of the tenth son without a cent to stack.
Right to tax the inheritance is sure
When the church and the king are the best
cure.

15 The priests prostrated themselves near
The altar in their priestly gear
And called toward heaven upon him who
Had given the law about the due,
That he should keep them safe for those
Who had deposited their rows.

16 The sight of the high priest would
wound

The very heart, his face lampooned
With pallor since his soul was grieved.

17 A trembling terror unreprieved
Swept over the man for the pain
That touched his heart was not one vain.

18 Folk rushed out in crowds to appeal
Since holy place was under heel.

19 Women arranged in sackcloth bent
Their way through every street they went.
Some maidens kept indoors ran to
The gates and walls, to get a view
Some others came at windows too.

20 And holding up their hands to heaven,
They all prayed aloud *without leaven*.

21 The whole folk were in pity's wake
Prostrating themselves for the sake
Of the high priest in anguished stake.

The priest is holy and sweet when the
power
Is not within his hands a blessed hour.
Ed Elwall said a true thing when he spoke
Against the pensions and the moneyed
yoke

That clergymen bear when they're paid to
speak
Your word to those in pew who come to
seek.

So Onias by fickle fanned of fate
Is free of greed and holy in his state,
And bows and weeps with poor upon the
street
Jerusalem twists out beneath their feet.
Beloved, I'd rather sing the charming songs
Of beauty in your courts, but earthly
wrongs

Meet me in sacred text where're I turn,
And even in the city where I learn.

22 While they called on Almighty YHWH
That he would keep what had been due
Entrusted safe for those who brought
It to the safety's temple lot,
23 Heliodorus went on with
What was determined by the myth.
24 When he came to the treasury
With his soldiers in infantry,
Right then the Lord of spirits and
The Almighty made such a stand
That all who had been in command
To go boldly with him were caught
Before the power Alohim brought
And fainted for terror unsought.
25 They saw appearance of a horse
With a fierce rider and perforce
It rushed on Heliodorus
And struck him with its front hoofs' fuss.
The rider was armoured in gold
And carried golden weapons *cold*.
26 Two youths also appeared to him,
Very strong, handsome in their vim,
Arrayed in glory, and who stood
Beside him giving strokes of wood
Upon his back hard as they could.
27 Straightway he fell down on the ground
With darkness on him like a swoond,

Till his men took him up and put
Him on a stretcher *head and foot*
28 And carried him away, this man
Who'd just come in the treasure's span
With a great retinue and all
His bodyguards could only fall
Helpless, and so they recognized
The sovereign power of Alohim.

It's no surprise, Beloved, this story's found
Within the canon of Your word once bound
By church father and council on the ground
That ancient people wrote and kept it
sound.

It's no surprise to find this story here
Simply because it is a tale of fear
In which the moneyed few are cut to size
And stricken to the earth before Your eyes.
Such an event's so rare it must reside
In annals read for generations' pride.
If You performed such acts each day, then
they
Could be forgotten by the canon's sway.
But as it is justice is such rare bird
That when it shows, it stays within Your
Word.

29 While he lay prostrate and despised,
Speechless before what it would seem
Of hopeless destruction of God,
30 They praised YHWH who upon the sod
Had worked a miracle to save
His own place and house from the brave.
The temple, which a little space
Was full of fear became a place
Of joy and gladness now the Lord
Almighty had appeared *adored*.
31 Some of Heliodorus' friends
Quickly asked that Onias lends
His prayers to beg the Most High to
Grant life to the wicked one who
Was at death's door. 32 And the high
priest,
Fearing the king might have increased
Suspensions of revolt at least
On the Jews part against his sent
Heliodorus, was well bent
To offer sacrifice for him
And pray he might be well and trim.
33 While the high priest offered atonement,
The same youths appeared to the
moanment

Of Heliodorus arrayed
 In the same clothing of parade,
 And they stood saying, "Gratitude
 Is due Onias and his brood,
 The high priest, for because of him
 YHWH's granted you your life and trim.
 34 "And see that you, who've been
 scourged by
 The heaven, report to all men why
 The power of Alohim is great."
 They said that and then left the state.
 35 Heliodorus offered up
 Sacrifice to YHWH and *like tup*
 Made promises to his life's Saviour,
 And having changed his own behaviour,
 He said good-by to Onias,
 And went to tell the king his pass.

You are indeed a wiser bloke than I,
 Beloved, sitting there in the frozen sky.
 I would have left ambassador to die
 And in that act called vengeance on the
 head
 Of innocent and children in their bed.
 When representatives of power and state
 Collapse upon the cobblestones of fate
 There's always some to pay among the
 poor
 Rejoicing for the reprieve that's less sure.
 You chose wisely to let the fellow live
 And return to the king and there to give
 Report of visions that cut through his skull
 And left him spent and helpless in the dull.
 I see the gulf between wise and the sieve.

36 And he bore testimony to
 All men of the deeds of the true
 Alohim, which he'd seen himself.
 37 When the king asked his servant elf
 Heliodorus what kind of
 Man would be good to send for shove
 A second time back to the town
 Jerusalem, he said *with frown*,
 38 "If you have any enemy
 Or traitor against regency,
 Send him there, for he will return
 Well beaten if alive to learn,
 For there's surely in that awed place
 The power of the gods in their race.
 39 For he who has His dwelling place
 In heaven watches o'er that place
 Himself and gives it help, and He

Strikes and destroys for injury."
 40 This was the outcome of the time
 Heliodorus came to climb
 And the treasure was kept from spree.

I told You, my Beloved, the king would not
 Be impressed even with a divine plot,
 And searches out a way to do the same
 That You foiled once already in his game.
 It was not You who intervened in store,
 But that the messenger was weak on shore.
 If You gave tit for tat each time tat
 sounded,
 The kings and presidents when hit and
 rounded
 Would recognize the hand that held the
 whip
 And turn about both armoured tank and
 ship.
 But when You only come once in an age,
 They fail to see You on the sacred page,
 Reverting to vain hope's psychology
 To spend another life on robbery.

2 Maccabees 4

1 That Simon who had liked about
 The money and raised up a shout
 Against his own land and his folk,
 Slandered Onias, in a croak
 Saying that it was he who'd brought
 Heliodorus in the plot
 And was the real cause of all
 The misfortunes that came to fall.
 2 He called a traitor and a plotter
 The very one who in the grotto
 Was benefactor of the town,
 Protector of men from the frown
 Of king and civil servant and
 A zealot for divine command.
 3 When his hatred progressed to such
 A pitch that even murders touch
 Where in the hands of Simon's men
 Send out by him once and again,
 4 Onias knew the stakes were great
 And that Apollonius mate
 And son of Menestheus and
 Ruler of Coelesyria's strand
 And Phoenicia, was stirring up
 The hate of Simon like a tup.
 5 So he went to advise the king,
 Not in an accusation's wing,
 But in view of the common weal

Of civilized as well as heel.

6 For he saw that without the king's
Attention public things in stings
Could never be in peace as long
As Simon sang his foolish song.

It may well be that Onias' was right,
A good man and a just before the fight.
But a good man alone before the crowd
Of evil-doers in the king's court loud
Is likely to accomplish just one thing:
His own downfall before the eye of king.
But Onias was in position to
Try his best in the things he had to do.
The law of life is divine and it's true:
The just must act justly and wisely too,
Despite the certainty that is in view.
The coltsfoot pushes through the pavement
and
Comes first to bloom in spring, though it
will stand
In no leaf on the crumbled asphalt's pew.

7 When Seleucus had died and Antiochus
Called Epiphanes come to rock us
Came in the kingdom, and Jason
Onias' brother wicked won
The high priesthood by deceit done.
8 He promised the king secretly
Three hundred sixty talents free
Of silver and from other stocks
Eighty more talents *for his flocks*.
9 Besides this he promised to pay
A hundred and fifty in way
If he could found gymnasium
And a college of youth in sum
To run naked in it and scribe
Jerusalem's folk in the tribe
Of Antioch. 10 The king said yes,
And Jason took high priest's address,
At once he changed the way of life
Of his folk to the Grecian life.
11 He set aside mandates herewithal,
Giving Jews their rights wherewithal,
Granted through John the father of
Eupolemus, who hand in glove
Went to make alliance with Rome,
And he suppressed law from the home
And brought new ways contrary to
The *Torah* law *and what is true*.
12 Straight off he made gymnasium
Right under the fortress, by gum,

And got the best of youths to wear
Hellenistic kind of headgear.

In every time and place today the stress
And tension between the law I confess
And the culture and climate of the mess
Of peoples and stations the world around
Is something to note, Belovèd, I'm bound.
Does taking part in local culture make
Idolator or lawless one? Forsake
The divine law and idle ditties take?
Or is it not enough to obey just
What's in the ten commandments in the
gust
Of different time and place from Moses'
thrust?
Does wearing a Greek hat destroy the law?
If so, then having a Greek name in paw
Might also try the spirits hand and claw.

13 They went to such extremes to be
Grecian and take on customs free
Because Jason was ungodly
And no high priest at all really,
14 So the priests were no longer faithful
In serving at the altar *wraithful*.
Despising the temple, neglecting
The sacrifices and electing
To take part in the lawless way
Of wrestling in arena's sway
And following the discus' call,
15 Disdaining the prized honours all
Of their ancestors to accept
The forms of Greek prestige adept.
16 That's why disaster fell on them
And those who thought those ways a gem
That were invented by the Greeks
And wished to imitate such geeks,
They became enemies at last
And they came to punish them fast.
17 For it is no light thing to show
Irreverence to the divine go,
A fact what happened will make know.

The nakedness itself is hardly brought
To light here, but the very games they
taught,
The interest in the doing and the sight,
These are the things they did that were not
right.
You have a people prepared to Your law
In every time and place to live in awe,

Who disregard Your love and will when
they
Step on the stage to sing, the field to play.
The race-car and the rock-swing and the
way
Fashion and entertainment fill the day
Are evidence of fine idolatry.
But in the quick end friend is enemy,
The stroke of taste and interest turns to
slay,
Mammon and You cannot both serve to
pay.

18 When the Olympic games were held
At Tyre and the king there beheld,
19 The vile Jason sent messengers,
Antiochian citizens,
Jerusalem sons as occurs,
To bring three hundred silver drams
For sacrifice to Hercules.
Those who carried the money's ease,
Though thought it best not to spend it
In idol sacrifice to wit,
So turned it to another task,
20 That is for fabricating mask
Of trireme *ships for battle-ask*.

So battle ships in days of Jason had
Three tiers of rowers rowing to be sad.
That is a kind of payment made in due
To idols and so the carriers true
Were not dishonest when they made the
change.
Battle ships or sacrifices in range
Both satisfy the false gods at the gate.
The messengers made no god have to wait.
Beloved, the flashing oars pound out the
sound
Of prayers to gods of war and on the
ground
To goddesses of grand fertility
Producing cannon fodder for the free.
Let Hercules lift up an head and smile
At messengers and messenger-like guile.

21 When Apollonius the son
Of Menestheus was sent when done
To Egypt for the coronation
Of Philometor king of nation,
Antiochus learned Philometor
Had become hostile and not sweeter,
So he meant to protect himself.

After Joppa he followed elf
East to Jerusalem as meter.
22 He was welcomed graciously by
Jason and the city with cry,
Brought in with torches *and not shy*.
Then he marched to Phoenicia.
23 After three years Jason sent claw,
One Menelaus, the brother of
Simon already met above,
To take the money to the king
And finalize there everything.
24 But he presented such a face
To the king that he won the race
To be high priest then for himself,
Putting three hundred more on shelf
Of silver talents than Jason.

Beloved, the government that You support
Behind each tank and bomb and frazzled
fort
Is bought with one deceit upon another,
And every governor sells his grandmother.
Where there is power to be had there is
power
To be bought in a single, trembling hour,
And with the buying fail the just and true
To sit in judgement on the fallen rue.
Beloved, I see You hand invisible
Shrouded in care to keep the eye from pull,
And know that in the end You rule the day,
But what I fear is the night now is sway
Is too much for the widow at the sink,
Is too much for the righteous on the brink.

25 With the king's orders he went back,
No priestly quality in sack,
But temper of a tyrant's crack
And rage of a wild beast to stack.
26 So Jason, who betrayed his brother
Was so betrayed by still another,
And fled to Ammon *in the lack*.
27 And Menelaus held office then,
But he did not pay with a yen
The money promised to the king
For what he got in post and ring.
28 When Sostratus the fortress chief
Requested payment for relief,
As was his job, the two of them
Were called by the king to condemn.
29 Menelaus left his own brother
Lysimachus to be another
Interim high priest, Sostratus

Left Crates chief of Cyprian bus.

I take great courage when I see the priest
Is just another crook like any beast.
If such went on two thousand years ago
And the world stands here still to see the
show,

Then I have faith corruption here and now
Is not enough to destroy holy cow.
Fire water creases brain and eye and sound
In every judgement here upon the ground,
And justice has departed in the wind
And found now more with clawed and
furred and finned.

But still You stand above the court and kirk
And see the simpered smile as well as
smirk,

And bide the time when all shall once
return

To great reward or else to stay and burn.

30 Just then the folk of Tarsus and
Of Mallus rebelled in a band,
Because their cities in remand
Had been gifted to Antiochis,
The concubine of king and caucus.

31 The king went quickly to take care,
And left Andronicus to bear
The weight of the kingdom in share.

32 But Menelaus stole temple gold
And gave the vessels yet unsold
To Andronicus, while the best
Had been sent to Tyre and the rest.

Let this be lesson lost on every church
Reformed or deformed in the level lurch,
That property must in a generation
Be transferred by the robbers in the nation
To tyrants to buy more of their oppression
While still pretending to keep court in
session.

Though Menelaus once stole the temple
gold,

He was not last on earth both bought and
sold.

The pulpit is the place where pulp is told
And lobbies justified by divine will
To trample in the dust and on the hill.
Beloved, the weight of kingdom to all men
Is more than they can bear and yet again
Keep their integrity and write the bill.

33 When Onias found out about
These things he publicly gave out
The news from his refuge at Daphne
Near Antioch to say what graft be.

34 So Menelaus spoke in the ear
Of Andronicus to appear
And kill Onias *for his tear*.

Andronicus came to Onias,
Betrayed him with sworn pledges pious,
And shook hands on it, and persuaded
Him over his suspicions waded,
To come out from his hiding place,
With no regard for justice' face,
He slaughtered him without a trace.

35 That's why not only Jews but others
Were displeased at the unjust brothers
To murder a man without grace.

36 When the king returned from the place
Of Cilicia, the Jews within

The town appealed to him to win
About the murder of Onias,
And the Greeks too would not deny us.

37 Therefore Antiochus was grieved
At heart and he wept unreprieved
Because of the behaviour seen
So well in the dead man and keen.

38 He was mad at Andronicus,
And tore from him the purple muss
And led him through the town until
They came to where they stopped to kill
Onias, and there he dispatched
The bloodthirsty fellow unlatched.
So YHWH revenged him with desert
Where he fell down dead and inert.

The ones who think that Antiochus is
The Little Horn come to set up his biz
Upon the holy hill, should think again.
Corrupt leaders of Jews invited men
Into the sanctuary and its treasure.
Blaming the king alone is without measure.

The king's corrupt indeed, and he will live
To commit such atrocities that give
The lie to his tears now, but still I know
He was corrupted partly by the show
Of men who claimed to know Your law
and go

According to the faith ancestors taught.
Such are all men and women who are
bought

By their own will, unlike those who were
caught.

39 When many evil acts had been
 Perpetrated in way of sin
 By Lysimachus with the help
 Of Menelaus, and like brown kelp
 Rumours had spread, the populace
 Came against Lysimachus' face,
 Since many golden pots were missing,
Stolen by one or two men kissing.
 40 And since the crowds became aroused,
 Lysimachus among caroused
 Armed about three thousand and went
 In an unjust attack and sent
 Under the leadership of one
 Auranus, a man who had won
 Both years and folly under sun.
 41 But when the Jews became aware
 Of Lysimachus being there,
 Some picked up stones, some blocks of
 wood,
 And others took ashes as could,
 And threw them wildly at the men
 Of Lysimachus out again.
 42 They wounded many, and killed some,
 And put them all to flight and hum,
 The temple robber himself they
 Killed close beside the treasury's way.

The people always rise against the way
 Their rulers cloud with evil light of day,
 But when they rise they do not do enough,
 And what they do is too late in the rough.
 Assassination of the criminal
 Civil servant will only cast a pall
 Over the earth unjust down to the dust.
 It takes a greater act, a greater gust.
 Jesus and Husseyne thought another try
 Would work and so they both stepped out
 to die,
 But that backfired, since they were turned
 into
 Fertility gods for the faithful few.
 Adherence to Your law alone will do,
 And wait for Your hand to come stir the
 brew.

43 Charge was brought against Menelaus
 About this incident to douse.
 44 When the king came to Tyre, three men
 Sent by the senate brought again
 The case before him. 45 Menelaus,
 Already beaten like a mouse,

Promised a lot of money to
 Ptolemy Dorymenes' son
 To win over the king for brew.
 46 That's why Ptolemy, for a bun,
 Spoke in the king's ear and aside
 When they were eating cakes to hide,
 And got him to change his mind's ride.
 47 Menelaus, the cause of the bad
 He acquitted of charges sad,
 And killed the innocent lot that
 Would have been freed before the mat
 Of Scythians had they been tried.
 48 So those who stood up for the town,
 The villages and holy crown
 Of vessels suffered an unjust
 Penalty and they bit the dust.
 49 Therefore even the Tyrians,
 Showing their hatred of such plans,
 Held obsequies both great and grand.
 50 But Menelaus, by evil hand
 Of those who held the power in band,
 Remained in office, and he grew
 More wicked as his time withdrew,
 The chief in mischief of the crew
 Against his fellows in their pew.

Whenever populace comes out to fight
 With sticks and stones and dust against the
 might
 Of the usurper and elected right,
 The rulers end their quarrels in a jiff
 And exchange money to make top lip stiff,
 And squelch the righteous poor and sink
 their skiff.
 The rate of violence is always turned
 Against the poor oppressed who never
 earned.
 Beloved, show me a better way to go,
 Politely insubordinate in show
 Before the arguments of church and state,
 Before the sweet devotions of the mate
 Of Virgin Mary laid before the view
 Of ghostly visitants in nightly crew.

2 Maccabees 5

1 About this time Antiochus
 Made second invasion and fuss
 In Egypt. 2 And it happened that
 Over all the city and flat,
 For almost forty days, there came
 Gold-clad horsemen charging through
 flame

Of air, in companies well armed
 With lances and drawn swords unharmed,
 3 And troops of horsemen were drawn up,
 Attacking back and forth like tup,
 Waving their shields and spears and such,
 With flash of gold and armour much.
 4 So all men prayed the apparition
 Might be a good omen's position.
 5 When a false rumour arose that
 Antiochus was dead who sat,
 Jason and one thousand men made
 An attack on the city raid.
 When the soldiers upon the wall
 Were beaten for the city's fall,
 Menelaus hid in fortress stall.
 6 But Jason kept on slaughtering
 His fellow citizens in ring,
 Not thinking that success is dear
 When bought at cost of death and fear
 Of one's own kin, but thinking just
 That he was gaining victory dust
 Over his enemies and not
 Over his fellow Jews in plot.
 7 He did not gain control at all
 But only disgrace from the fall,
 And fled into Ammonite stall.

Why not call Jason little horn, since he
 Attacked the holy city in a spree?
 Attacks from within the folk chosen are
 Far deadlier than those of northern star,
 Far deeper in their cuts than can be made
 By worshipper of Hercules displayed.
 The slaughter of the populace may be
 The quickest way to wealth and infamy,
 But to despise the command of the Lord
 Is just to fall at end upon the sword.
 Beloved, let Jason take his desert way
 And sit in glory on the gory prey,
 I wait instead, I wait for judgement day
 As life turns inward and the hair turns grey.

8 He met at last a horrid end.
 Aretas Arab chief to fend
 Off rumours accusing his friend
 Made him flee then from town to town,
 Persued by all men and the crown,
 Hated as rebel against law,
 Abhorred for lifting arm and claw
 Against his own land and his state,
 He was cast ashore then of late
 In Egypt, 9 and the one who drove

Many from their own land and stove
 In exile, died himself abroad,
 Having start to go for laud
 To the Lacedaemonians' sod
 In hopes of refuge among kin.
 10 The one who had thrown others in
 The bin came to lie on the sand
 With none to mourn for him at last,
 Or any grave, but was outcast.

The judgement falls indeed on every man,
 On the usurper and the worthy can,
 And all meet death at last and in that
 meeting
 Find that the banquet has another seating
 When truth comes to the wall and shadows
 fall,
 And fail the honours and the goatly
 bleating.

Beloved, I raise my eyes to banners tall
 Raised over parapet upon the wall,
 And touch the hope of light Jerusalem
 Casts over all the blight of earthly hem.
 Beloved, I raise an arm against the trust
 That You reward the righteous in the dust,
 Demanding now the temple and the bowl,
 Knowing the planting is the harvest goal.

11 When news of what had come to stand
 Reached the king, he thought that the land
 Of Judea was in revolt.
 So in his rage he went to bolt
 From Egypt and attacked the town.
 12 He ordered soldiers to cut down
 All they met and kill those who went
 Into the houses to prevent.
 13 Then there was slaughter, young and
 old,
 Destruction of youths, women told,
 And children, babes and virgins sold.
 14 Within the total of three days
 Eighty thousand lay in the haze
 Of that destruction, in the fight
 Forty thousand, and in their sight
 As many sold as slaves and killed.
 15 Antiochus, since no one stilled,
 Dared even to go in the room
 Of the most holy to his doom,
 Led by wicked Menelaus there,
 Who was a traitor to the fair
 Laws and his country everywhere.

The beastly king is truly little horn
 Come tramping vineyard, olive tree and
 corn,
 Suspicion that a movement on the ground
 Is the revival of rebellion sound.
 It is no wonder that Josephus crowed
 That Antiochus bore unworthy load
 Of horn upon a head and iron goad.
 And yet the world is full of artifice
 And hundreds of kings hurry in to kiss
 The crown of violence, abomination.
 In all this one's hardly a new elation.
 Beloved, the fear of kings is greater than
 The fear of subjects written to a man.
 Kings quake and thrust to survive if they
 can.

16 He took the holy pots in hands
 Polluted and profaned in bands
 And brushed aside the offerings that
 The kings before him placed on mat
 To honour with glory that place.
 17 Antiochus with joyful face
 Did not realize how mad YHWH
 Was for a time at Israel's crew
 Because of the town's sins in view,
 And for that reason disregarded
 The holy place, judgement retarded.
 18 But if it had not happened that
 They were caught up in sinful vat,
 This man would have been whipped and
 turned
 Back from his rash act as he earned
 As soon as he came out to do,
 Just as Heliodorus too,
 Whom Seleucus the king sent to
 Inspect the treasury for due.
 19 But YHWH did not come choose the
 nation
 For the sake of holy place' station,
 But the place for the nation's sake.
 20 Therefore the place itself in wake
 Shared the misfortunes that partake
 Of the folk and after that too
 Benefit in benefits due,
 And what the Almighty in wrath
 Left desolate, also in path
 Of restoration was restored
 In all its glory by the Lord.

Theology's a thing to understand.

The king thought that You had been under-
 manned,
 Succumbing to the power of royal hand
 Because he had the stealth to come pollute
 The temple precincts with a heavy boot.
 The God who cannot save His own house is
 Only a shadow of His former fizz.
 This argument is finely met to hear
 The temple shared in punishment and gear
 Of those who for a moment felt the blast
 Of divine anger on their loved souls cast.
 Beloved, both thoughts seem near insane to
 me
 Despite the clear logic that sets them free.
 Amazed I wait alone eternity.

21 So Antiochus carried off
 Eighteen hundred talents to scoff
 At the temple, and hurried out
 To Antioch, thinking for clout
 That he could sail on land and walk
 On water, he was such hot stock.
 22 And he left governors to lay
 Affliction on the people's sway
 Within Jerusalem, Philip,
 By birth a Phrygian with lip
 More barbarous than he who set
 Him in his station poorly met,
 23 And at Gerizim, Andronicus,
 Besides this Menelaus, to strike us
 Worse than the others did before.
 In hate toward the Jewish score,
 24 Antiochus sent Apollonius,
 Captain of the Mysians to phony us
 With an army of twenty-two
 Thousand, and ordered him in view
 To kill all grown men and to sell
 Women and boys as slaves as well.
 25 When he got to Jerusalem,
 He pretended by stratagem
 To be at peace and cunningly
 Waited till holy Sabbath's fee,
 Then seeing Jews were not at work
 He ordered soldiers out of shirk
 To march past with their arms and dirk.
 26 He killed with the sword all those who
 Came out to see the soldiers' crew,
 Then rushed into the city too
 With his armed men and killed a lot
 Of people in his wicked plot.
 27 But Judas Maccabeus, with
 Maybe nine others, *without smith*

Fled to the desert and hid there
Alive like beasts in mountain lair
On what grew wild and so not share
In the pollution of the air.

Let this be lesson to my waiting soul.
The one who smiles and gestures at the toll,
Pretending to be benign in the seat
Of governing is waiting in deceit,
The grimace of a cruel plan to grind
The Sabbath-keeper out of sight and mind.
As Apollonius once marched in style,
Applauded by the just and good a while,
So now the ones elected by the straight
And narrow meet the gun behind the gate.
Beloved, I trust You only on the throne,
And on all other rulers cast a stone,
An accusation worried to the bone,
That You are just and good, and You alone.

2 Maccabees 6

1 Not long after this, the king sent
Athenian senator bent
To compel the Jews to forsake
The laws of their fathers in stake,
Stop living by Alohim's laws,
2 And to pollute the temenos
There in Jerusalem with dross
And call it temple of Zeus from
Olympus, and to call in sum
The one in Gerizim the house
Of Zeus the Friend of Strangers' spouse,
As did the people who lived there.

Athens is compared not brightly in weight
With Sparta thought to be a Jewish state.
The books I read as a child always spoke
Of Athens as the cultivated stroke
And Sparta too severe in government,
In education and in no dissent.
Imperial Athens is another face
Behind benign philosophy and grace.
Of course Plato himself can hardly bear
To make a homophiliacal share
Of remarks on the form and trace of youth.
So why should I be surprised by the truth
That violence goes hand in hand with sex
When civilization is without checks?

3 The evil weighed was hard to bear,
4 Because the temple was filled with
Debauchery and revelling kith

Of the Gentiles, who dallied with
Harlots and had intercourse with
Women inside the sacred place,
And sacrificed there every race
Of unclean thing and for a space.
5 The altar was filled with unclean
Offerings forbidden by laws' sheen.
6 A man could not keep Sabbath day,
Nor feasts in his ancestors' way,
Or even admit he was Jewish.

The inability to keep the day
Of Sabbath because of the heathen play
Within the temple precincts is too bad.
But they at least had temple on the gad.
My Sabbath has no stone to make
pollution,
No walls of steel and glass as a solution,
But is a temple wrought alone in time,
A democratic thing of rhythm'd rhyme,
It cannot close its door on any man,
It cannot be monopoly in span,
But graces every board no matter how
Poor and barren of flesh of fish and cow.
Beloved, I meet you in the timely breath
Of evening and the morning without death.

7 On monthly celebration of
The king's birthday, the Jews in glove
Were taken and forced to accept
The heathen sacrifices kept,
And when feast of Dionysus
Came, they were compelled by abuse
To walk in parade to give glory
To Dionysus wearing gory
Wreaths of ivy by the old story.
8 At Ptolemy's advice decrees
Were made in neighbouring degrees
Of Grecian towns, that they should force
The Jews to take part in the course
Of heathen sacrifices, 9 and
Should kill those who at their command
Did not accept Greek customs' band.
So one could see the misery
That came upon them by decree.
10 For an example, two women
Were brought in for having in den
Circumcised their children. And these
Women they publicly on knees
Paraded all about the town,
With their babes hanging at breasts down,
Then threw them headlong from the wall

To kill them, women and babes all.

Is the man Apollonius not still
At helm of church and state with iron will
To destroy every suckling child and mother
That he can set his hand upon and smother?
Did You not love Israel's folk in that day
When evil entered secretly and lay?
So why should any think that peace that
now

Reigns on the city is more than the brow
Of waiting for a chance to kill the true
And hop upon the wagon with the crew
Of wickedness and stab the mother
through?

Beloved, I draw conclusions from the fact
The sun comes up and men know how to
act

For or against You and Your commands'
pact.

11 Others who hid in caves near by,
To keep the Sabbath day or try,
Were betrayed to Philip and all
Were burned together in the stall
Because their righteousness would not
Permit them to defend their lot
On that most holy day as taught.
12 Now I urge those who read this book
Not to lose courage at the look
Of such events, but recognize
That these punishments just devise
To discipline and not destroy
Our people from their land and joy.
13 Truly not to leave wicked ones
Alone for long in benisons,
But punish them straight off is sign
Of a great kindness in their line.
14 For in the case of other folk
YHWH waits in patience for the stroke
To punish when full measure's store
Of their sins gathered at the door,
But he does not deal in this way
With us, 15 so that he does not pay
Our vengeance on us on a day
When our sins reach in height to sway.
16 So He never shall take away
His mercy from us. Though he slay
With such calamities, He will
Not forsake His own people still.
17 Let what we have said serve to mind,
We must continue tale resigned.

Philosophy of suffering is a thing
Each soul must answer that comes to make
fling

Upon the soil and stone of planet earth.
Explaining suffering after water dearth
Is the first thing that humans have in task.
When that is done they can sit out and
bask.

A temporary punishment belongs
To Israel explaining in their songs.
It turns to taunt in the Qur'an for wrongs,
They boast the fire will only touch the skin
For a brief moment to punish their sin.
Beloved, a curse and blessing's in insane
Way people refuse to shine in the rain
Until the unexplainable is plain.

18 Eleazar, one of the scribes
In high position without bribes,
A noble man and aged now
Was forced to eat the flesh of sow.
19 But he welcomed death rather than
Pollute his life in such a span,
And went up to the rack himself
And spit out the flesh on the shelf,
20 As men should do with courage met
Refusing things not right to get,
Even to save life once beset.
21 Those in charge of that sacrifice
Illicit and of pagan vice,
Took him aside because they knew
Him for a long time in review,
And privately counselled to bring
His own clean meat into the ring,
And there pretend to eat the flesh
Of pagan sacrifice in mesh
As at the king's orders and fresh,
22 And that way he could save his life
In kindness and instead of strife.
23 But in his dignity and age
He chose not to besmear his page,
But by holy God-given law,
Straight off declared by tooth and claw
That they could send him with farewell
And join him too at last in hell.

A feisty old man stands before the king
And death without a thought of anything
But to reply with a brave will and show
That what he's lived in life he makes not
slow

In death, let come whatever threatening.
 The witness of friendship and kindly eyed
 Is deepest thing the pagan can provide,
 The end of days with praise from all and
 fair,
 Applause and then forgetfulness in air.
 Beloved, I see reality and feel
 The pressure of the steely weighted heel.
 Truth is none can be untrue in the end,
 Though mouthing assent to the wicked
 bend
 Of sacrifice, so why make pretence lend?

24 "Such pretence is not worthy of
 My age and grey hairs to comply,"
 He said, "lest many of our youth
 Should think Eleazar in truth
 At ninety years old had subscribed
 To a strange faith when he was bribed,
 25 "And so by acting on the sly
 In order to live or to try
 A little moment longer here,
 They should be led astray from fear
 Because of me, and I should yet
 Defile and disgrace my age set.
 26 "For even if at this time I
 Should be saved from the evil try,
 Still whether I live or I die,
 I shall not escape from the hand
 Of the Almighty in the land.
 27 "So if with courage I die now,
 I'll show them all a worthy brow,
 28 "And leave the young a noble sign
 Of how to die a good death's tine
 By choice and nobly for the laws
 Of holiness instead of claws."
 When he had said this, he went down
 At once to the rack without frown.
 29 And those who had just shown a face
 Of friendliness lost every trace
 Of good will but changed for the ill
 Because what he said fit to kill.
 30 Just as he was about to die
 Beneath the blows of evil try
 He groaned aloud and said "It's clear
 To YHWH in His holy sight here,
 Though I might have spared life and limb,
 I endure suffering for Him
 In body, but in spirit I
 Rejoice that I may hereby try
 To show I fear and obey Him."
 31 And so he died and left behind

For all a noble memory signed
 For young and old to live the right
 Before their Lord and in His sight.

The friendship that is bought by common
 greed,
 The tie of kinship or the common need
 To meet the present foe, all such in seed
 Reveal themselves to germinate and root
 In violence against the friend with boot.
 The giver of good gifts returns to loot,
 The helper of the helpless in an hour
 Raises an arm enamelled with fell power.
 Beloved, You never change like friend and
 foe,
 Who equally mistrust the come and go.
 Your grace and judgement waver not nor
 show
 The variance of dance and greed and glow.
 Beloved, I trust Your verdict with a will
 And saturate my heart to hear You still.

2 Maccabees 7

1 It happened also seven brothers
 And their mother were with some others
 Arrested and being compelled
 By the king, with torture unquelled
 Of whips and cords, to partake of
 Unlawful swine's flesh. 2 One above
 Of them, acting as their spokesman,
 Said, "What do you intend now, man,
 To ask and learn from us? For we
 Are ready to die and freely
 Rather than disobey the laws
 Of our ancestors *to last clause.*"
 3 The king fell in a rage, and gave
 Orders that pans and caldrons grave
 Be heated. 4 These were heated soon,
 And he commanded for a boon
 Their spokesman's tongue be cut out and
 Then scalp him, sever foot and hand,
 While the rest of the brothers and
 The mother had to watch and stand.

The fire torture and the scalping way
 Of dealing with a brother on a day
 Was not invented by the savage brood
 Of Iroquois or Algonquian rude,
 But by the civilized Athenian crowd
 Who took their civilization out loud
 To pall and sundry under the blue sky
 Of Europe and the Middle East to try.

Beloved, I hereby reject every call
 Of civilized and spiritual in mall,
 And keep my foot upon the ground and
 stone
 Shaded by firs and birches and the groan
 Of mammoth pine. I keep my foot straight
 on
 The wooded, needled, leafy path of dawn.

5 When he was utterly subdued,
 The king commanded evil brood
 To take him to the fire, still breathing,
 To fry him in a pan *for teething*.
 The smoke from the pan spread about,
 But the brothers and mother stout
 Encouraged one another then
 To die nobly, saying *like men*.
 6 "YHWH Alohim is guarding us
 And truly pities all the fuss,
 As Moses stated in his song
 Bearing witness against the wrong
 When he said 'He will pity too
 His servants *who stand in His view*.'"

The incense of the temple covered all
 The stench of burning fat from those in
 stall
 That were brought out in sacrifice to bawl
 Before the altar brazen and the caul.
 The song of Moses sung in days gone by
 Was fine enough with sweet smells to rely,
 But something horrid fills my nose and eye
 To hear it when they come to crucify.
 Beloved, I smell the savour and the stench
 Of burning flesh above the call of wench
 And rock within the temple You would
 quench.
 And I too lift a Psalm when round my ears
 The cries of slaughtered people draw my
 tears
 To pity at the wonder of their fears.

7 After the first brother had died
 In this way, they brought up beside
 The second to sport and deride.
 They tore off the skin of his head
 With the hair, and asked him instead,
 "Will you eat rather than have your
 Body punished and cut in four?"
 8 He answered in ancestral tongue
 And said to them, "No, *go be hung*."
 So he was tortured as the other.

9 And when he was about to smother,
 He said "You accursed wretch, you flail
 Us from this present life, but fail
 Not will King of the universe
 To raise us up to what's not worse
 Than everlasting life renewed,
 Because we have died for His laws' feud."

That really was unchristian of the man
 To use such language to the king in span,
 Deposer and appointer of the priest
 That dips his snuff in Zion at the least.
 "You cursed wretch" how could he on
 death bed
 Use such an imprecation and a spread?
 It was a time to deal confession's row
 And settle for the cushion of the flow
 Of civilized belief and hopeful gain
 Of paradise vouchsafed by those who reign.
 Beloved, if I have ever said a word
 So ugly to a sycophant or turd
 Upon the throne of power, then punish me
 With glory and with Your eternity.

10 After him the third met his fate.
 When ordered he quickly showed tongue
 And stretched his hands to burning wrung,
 11 And said nobly, "I got these from
 Heaven, and because of His laws come
 I disdain them, and from Him I
 Hope to get them back from the sky."
 12 So the king himself and his friends
 Were wondering at his words and ends,
 For his spirit held suffering
 As nothing in the world to sing.

The morbid rush to martyrdom that knew
 The Christians before all the Roman crew
 Had precedent in Jewish state and pew
 And has still adherents among the few
 Of Muslims who plough body under too.
 It is unhealthy to seek martyrdom,
 It must increase the mental faults that hum
 In aftermath of violence, no matter
 Who's wrong or right, who's thin or getting
 fatter.
 Beloved, I turn and squirm in pan of fire,
 Refusing to believe the real and dire,
 And flip a page and hope to laugh until
 My breath stops and my heart to foot the
 bill.

I eschew martyrdom and tune my lyre.

13 When he too had died, they took up
The fourth in the same wicked cup,
14 And when he was near death, he said
“One can’t but choose to die as led
At hands of men and cherish hope
That Alohim promises scope
Of being raised again by Him.
But for you there’s a future grim
Without resurrection to life!”

The willingness to choose in calm estate
A painful death surrendered to the great
Rests on a hope yet without demonstration.
It is not certain that the fond elation
Of resurrection of the righteous will
Contrast with what is waiting on the hill
For those who perpetrate the violence.
It’s founded not on certainty but sense.
While all the universe before the eye
Shows pattern and gives answer to the why,
It does not follow justice to comply
With the ideal returns to light the way
After death in a shining, glorious day.
It is a hope, indeed. I wait for pay.

15 They brought up next the fifth for strife
And tortured him to take his life.
16 But he looked at the king, and said
“Because you have such power instead
Among men, mortal though you are,
You do what you please like a star.
But do not think that Alohim
Has turned from our folk as you seem.
17 “Keep on, and see His mighty power
Will torture you upon an hour
And your descendants roughly scour!”

The ones who wield the sword to do to dust
The other man out of greed’s cruel lust
Are not moved by the preaching of the hour
When judgement shall fall on the world
with power.
The judgement of the world of tree and
flower,
Rebelling at the hand in consequence
That steals lifeblood and tatters earthy tents
Called tapping of resources, comes apace.
But even that means nothing but a trace
Of politics to wrangle in the race.

So how can such be moved by truth and
star

That shine beyond the grave twinkling so
far?

The martyr might as well shut up his mouth
And watch the tyrant build towns in the
south.

18 After him the sixth was brought out.
And as he came to die about,
He said, “Do not deceive yourself
In vain. For we suffer on shelf
These things on our account, because
Of our sins against our own laws
From Alohim. Therefore astounding
Things have happened *with you*
empounding.

19 “But do not think that you will go
Unpunished for having tried so
To fight against Alohim’s show!”

The arguments do not carry more weight
For being once again repeated and
Doubled by dying souls upon the strand.
No argument can fly in face of state.
The only argument the president
Can understand is never to be caught
Hiding beneath the rubble of distraught.
The only way is never having meant.
Beloved, I grace my speech with justice
too,
Derision is the only hope set out
Among the watchers at the gate and throne.
Beloved, I taste my peach with musty dew,
Division is the gainly rope and stout
Among idolaters of flesh and bone.

20 The mother was especially
Worthy of honoured memory.
Though she saw her seven sons die
In one day, she bore without cry
Because her hope was still in YHWH.
21 She encouraged each of them too
In the ancestral tongue as due.
Filled with a noble spirit, she
Gave reasons out courageously,
And told them, 22 “I do not know how
You came into being for now
It was not I who gave you life
And breath, nor I who set from strife
To order the stuff for your life.
23 “Therefore Creator of the world,

Who shaped the start of man unfurled
The origin of all things here,
He will in His mercy lend ear
To give life and breath back to you,
Since you forget yourselves now too
For the sake of His laws *and true*."

The argument of resurrection's power
Seen from the first of the creation's hour
Is logical and seamless, but no doubt
Creation does not imply with a shout
That resurrection's true or even sure.
It takes a tad of faith to be so pure.
The only surety is here and now,
The reward of the blood-soaked chest and brow.

Beloved, I seek Your face behind the grim
Onslaught of the great holocaust and slim
That slides around the world, refined with care

Since it was practiced on tri-racial share
In Indiana plan and in Auschwitz.
It's up to par now in its mobile kits.

24 Antiochus felt her contempt,
Suspicious of her tone exempt.
The youngest brother still alive,
Heard Antiochus come to jive,
Appealing to him with sweet words
And promises and oaths like curds
That he would make him rich renowned,
If he'd turn from the way where frowned
His ancestors, and make him friend
Of the king and raise him in end
To heights of public stature's mend.

25 Since the young man refused to hear,
The king summoned the mother near,
And urged her to counsel the youth
To save himself from death for truth.
26 After much urging on his part,
She undertook to make a start
To persuade her son *to hold firm*.

The tyrant offers all his has to give,
A place at the gate of the court to live,
The hypocrite's smile and the feast and fun,
A dagger in the back when it is done.
The hierarchy may offer gifts and loads
Of gold and silver as enticement's goads,
But it can never offer friendship's coil
Beyond the competition and the toil.

The system's flawed itself, and promise
made

Is only a camouflage and charade
Until the one-time friend has finished
score,

And climbed up on the backs of those who
swore.

Beloved, no wonder men and women here
Speak of love unconditional in ear.

27 She spoke the native tongue in ear,
Deriding the tyrant and gear,
"My son, have pity on me now.
I carried you nine months like sow,
And nursed you three years anyhow,
And have reared you and brought you up
To this point in your life and cup.
28 "I beg of you, my child, to look
At the heaven and the earth like book
And see everything that's in them,
And recognize that Alohim
Did not make them from things existing.
Thus also mankind comes out twisting.
29 "Do not fear this butcher, but be
Worthy of your brothers and see
Death, so that I in God's mercy
May get you all back once again."

A vain faith it appears to me is found
In letting the life-blood flow on the ground
In hope that faithfulness will cause You
now

To take the conscience from the faithful
brow

And recreate the lost life in another
Come back to mother every righteous
brother.

And yet it is the only straw at hand
For mother to hold to by scopes of sand.
Beloved, let me not live to see the day
When I must apply philosophic way
To keep my mind from cracking at the
stress

Of holocaust come round to my address.
There's nothing then a soul can stop and
say

Before the hand raised up to curse and slay.

30 While she was still speaking, the youth
Said, "What's the hold-up now in truth?
I will not now obey the king,
But I obey the law in spring

That came to our ancestors through
 Moses *our great prophet*. 31 But you,
 Who have contrived all sorts of stink
 Against the Hebrews, in a wink
 Will surely not escape the hands
 Of Alohim, *God of all lands*.
 32 “For we are suffering for our sins.
 33 “And if our living Lord begins
 A little anger for a while,
 To rebuke and purge out our guile,
 He will come back to reconcile
 With his own servants *and in style*.
 34 “But you, unholy wretch, you most
 Defiled of all men, vainly boast
 When you raise your hand against those
 Who are the children heaven chose.
 35 “You have not yet escaped judgment
 Of the Almighty, who is bent
 To see all things, the Alohim.
 36 “For our brothers after a scream
 Have drunk of everflowing life
 In God’s covenant *without strife*,
 But you, by Alohim’s verdict,
 Will receive just judgement untricked,
 For your arrogance and your shame.
 37 “I, like my brothers, give to flame
 Body and life for all the laws
 Of our ancestors, giving pause
 To pray to Alohim to show
 Mercy soon to our nation’s row
 And by catastrophes to make
 You admit that in His own wake
 There is no god but He alone,
 38 “And through me and my brothers’
 groan
 To bring end to Almighty’s wrath
 Which justly falls upon the path
 Of our whole nation’s aftermath.”

There is no sense to suffering, that’s a fact,
 There’s no explaining evil in the act.
 To say I suffer in Your punishment
 Is blasphemy, I think, of a heart bent.
 And yet the friends of Job without a blink
 Brought such to him in comfort on the
 brink.
 Such punishment is followed by the fair,
 And so the thought will penetrate despair.
 Anything that can help the soul go through
 The suffering that the wicked worldly crew
 Brings out is well enough, though it’s not
 true.

Forgive the accusation of the just
 Who suffers ancestral sins in the dust,
 And raise him up to glory for his trust.

39 The king fell in a heated rage,
 And handled him worse in rampage
 Than all the others, for frustration
 At the scorn he showed *king and nation*.
 40 So he died in integrity,
 Putting his whole trust in the fee
 Of YHWH. 41 And last of all, the mother
 Died, after her sons *in the smother*.
 42 Let this suffice then for the way
 Of eating sacrifices’ pay,
 And the great tortures of that day.

See here, Beloved, the ones whose policy
 Is covered by the state beside the sea
 May seem to be a compromise of will
 To make a just society and fill
 The earth with peace and grand prosperity,
 But as soon as they meet integrity
 They fall into a hot rage for the free.
 Benign smiles met in tolerance become
 The grimace of the killer when the rum
 Of the awareness of true goodness dawns
 Before their eyes accustomed to the fawns
 Of the oppressed who do both to survive
 Or climb the social ladder to deprive.
 I click my teeth and then I start to hum.

2 Maccabees 8

1 But Judas, who was also called
 Maccabeus, and his friends called
 Clandestinely toured all around
 The villages and gave the sound
 To relatives and friends who still
 Retained the Jewish faith and till,
 And gathered near six thousand men.
 2 They begged YHWH to look down again
 On the folk then oppressed by all,
 Have pity on the temple hall
 Profaned by ungodly in stall,
 3 And have mercy upon the town
 Being destroyed and all torn down,
 And listen to the blood that cried
 Out to Him, 4 and to mind beside
 The lawless slaying of the young
 And innocent, blasphemies’ tongue
 Against His name, and come to show
 His hatred of the evil row.
 5 As soon as Maccabeus got

His army organized in plot,
 The Gentiles could not withstand him,
 For the wrath of YHWH had turned trim
 To mercy. 6 Coming without warning,
 He would set fire to towns *one morning*
 And villages *the next*. He took
 Strategic positions in nook
 And set to flight many a crook.
 7 He did his best work then by night,
 So talk of his courage took flight.

Fact is that Judas Maccabeus was,
 As beauty always is as beauty does,
 A robber and a bandit, hand raised high,
 Politically correctly speaking by
 The term used by each hypocrite of late,
 Terrorism, which is just violence
 Unregistered by bandits on the fence
 Of government. Please note the chosen
 king

Was the one most affronted by the thing.
 In theory I oppose all force of hand,
 But if the choice must be made in the land,
 I prefer force to keep the Lord's command
 Than follow in the pagan freedom slogan
 For Sunday sacrifice and liquor rogan.

8 When Philip saw the man gained ground
 Slowly, and that he would be found
 Successful, he told Ptolemy,
 Coelesyria's governor
 And of Phoenicia *and its shore*,
Asking for aid to help the king.

9 And Ptolemy promptly appointed
 Nicanor son of the *anointed*
 Patroclus, the king's best of friends,
 And sent him as a chief contends
 Over sum of twenty thousand
 Gentiles gathered from every land,
 To liquidate the Jewish race.
 He gave for council Gorgias,
 A general *and gorgeous ass*
 Of military keen to pass.

10 Nicanor thought to get the king
 The tribute due Roman taxing,
 Two thousand talents, by selling
 The captured Jews in slave trading.
 11 And he straight off sent to the towns
 On the seacoast, offering the crowns
 Of ninety Jewish slaves for one
 Talent, not thinking he's outdone
 By intervention of Almighty

About to come and make him flighty.
 12 Word came to Judas concerning
 Nicanor's invasion for king,
 And when he told his mates the band
 Of men had come, 13 cowards in hand
 Who did not trust justice of God,
 Ran off and hid safely in pod.
 14 Others sold all that they had left,
 Begging YHWH to rescue for theft
 Those sold be Nicanor before
 He even entered on their shore,
 15 If not for their own sake, yet for
 The sake of the ancestral pacts
 And because He'd called them by acts
 Of His high holy name for facts.

There's always an economic factor
 Behind each case of genocide and gore.
 This time the sale of Jewish slaves would
 kill

Two birds in the bush and two on the hill
 By cancelling out both the populace
 Of Jews as well as the imperial bill.
 There's not within sight just the smallest
 trace

Of human virtue or a touch of grace.
 The rise of Rome precipitates the kind
 Of planning so effective and consigned
 To be the policy till doom's day come,
 Along with laws protecting sale of rum.
 Beloved, just look at Roman, Grecian stall
 Today that circumnavigates the ball.

16 But Maccabeus gathered all
 His men together, to the call
 Of six thousand, and told them not
 To be afraid of the foe's plot
 In so great crowd of Gentiles got
 Together wickedly to come
 Against them, but to fight in sum
 A noble fight, 17 keeping before
 Their eyes the lawless outrage gore
 Which the Gentiles committed in
 The holy place *and to their sin*,
 And the torture of town derided,
 And destruction when they collided
 With their ancestral way of life.
 18 "They trust in arms and acts of strife,"
 He said, "but we trust in the might
 Of Alohim, who with a slight
 Nod can strike down those who come out
 Against us and the whole world rout."

The pep-talks generals all give their men
 Follow the same line again and again.
 We did a great job with a victory
 Last year, so we're invincible at sea
 And on land, everywhere we might just be.
 So Maccabeus in inventing talk
 Of God-with-us and trade of arms in stock
 Is neither new nor last to vanity,
 A fair recruit to fine humanity.
 Beloved, I hear the prophet and the priest,
 The warrior and the chief down to the least
 Prep men to fight and die, and yet I doubt
 The turning of the shrew and to find out.
 The killing and unfaithfulness increased.

19 He told them also of the times
 When help came to ancestors' mimes,
 The time of Sennacherib, when
 One hundred eighty-five thousand
 Men perished, 20 also the time when
 The Galatians came in the land
 Against Babylonian stand,
 When eight thousand in all went out,
 Four thousand Macedonians stout,
 And when the Macedonians lay
 In harsh duress, the eight thousand,
 By the help that came in their way
 From heaven, destroyed one hundred
 twenty

Thousand and took in spoils a plenty.
 21 With these words he filled them with
 high
 Courage, made them ready to die
 For their laws and for their country,
 Then he divided his army
 Into four parts *and equally*.

The lesson most oft drawn from history
 Is pride of conquest instead of to see
 The awful state that warfare brings the
 world,
 The misery of those who come uncurled.
 The reason is a simple one: who write
 The history books are those who in the
 fight
 Make money on the death and gore until
 The tax-payer comes in to pay the bill.
 Beloved, I know the Bible's full of fair
 Conquest and Islam's history is a glare
 Of battles, but Your very law relates
 How every man and woman at the gates

Has right to work and rest, to eat the pie.
 Thou shalt not kill has no reasons for why.

22 He appointed his brothers too,
 Simon, Joseph and Jonathan,
 Each to command division's crew,
 Fifteen hundred men under each.

23 He Eleazar come preach,
 Reciting holy book in span,
 And gave the watchword, "God's help",
 then,

Leading the first division's score,
 He joined battle with Nicanor.

24 With the Almighty as their friend,
 They killed off more than nine thousand
 Of the foes, wounded and disabled
 Most of Nicanor's army tabled,
 And forced them all to flee unstabled.

25 They captured the money of those
 Who'd come to buy them slaves as chose.
 After pursuing them a while,

They had to go back for the style
 Was late. 26 For it was day before
 The Sabbath, and that's why for score
 They could not chase them down the shore.

27 And when they had collected arms
 Of the foe and stripped them of spoil,
 They kept the Sabbath not to toil,
 Giving great praise *safe from alarms*
 And thanks to YHWH, who had preserved
 Them for that day *as they deserved*
 And made the start of mercy served.

28 After the Sabbath they gave some
 Of the gain to those who had been
 Tortured and to the widows sum
 And orphans, and gave out from bin
 To themselves and their child and kin.

No doubt the Robin Hood principle's fair,
 Take from the royal and the widow spare.
 Since God was with them, as they said to
 start,

There was no sin in casting the first dart,
 Nor taking from the dead what they shall
 need

No more upon the fields to drink and feed.
 Identity alone, whether of Jew
 Or Greek is enough to fill up the shoe
 With violence and such in overflow
 At last incited in a bloody glow.
 Beloved, be with the battle or do not,
 I care not for the blood and gore in plot,

But be at last with peace and let me rot
In my own bed for what I haven't sought.

29 When they had done this, they prayed to
The merciful, the dear Lord YHWH,
To be completely reconciled
With his servants and unbeguiled.

30 While fighting Timothy in force
And Bacchides they killed in course
More than twenty thousand of them
And captured some strong forts in gem
And they divided up the spoils
To the tortured and orphans' coils
And widows, and also the old
Shares equal to their own *when told*.

31 They picked up all the instruments
Of war left by their foes in tents
And stored them all away to wait
The battles of another gate,
And carried off the rest in hem
To the town of Jerusalem.

32 They killed Timothy's army chief,
Unholy man beyond belief,
Who'd greatly brought the Jews to grief.

33 They celebrated the victory
In their ancestors' own city
By burning those who had set fire
To holy gates, upon the pyre
Callisthenes along with friends
Who'd taken refuge in the ends
Of some hut, so they got desert
For all the things they'd done to hurt.

34 The thrice-accursed Nicanor, who
Had brought the thousand merchants' crew
To buy the Jews, 35 having been humbled
By aid of YHWH and so out tumbled
By those that he before despised,
Took off his fine clothes as advised
And fled like a slave through the land
Till he came back into the stand
Of Antioch having lost all.

36 So instead of getting the ball
Of tribute for the Romans by
The sale of the folk on the sly
Out of Jerusalem he turned
Into a witness the Jews had
A great Defender, and were clad
Invulnerable, because they went
According to divine law sent.

Is it true that success will be the own
Of those who obey Your laws and alone?

I lay hold of the ten commandments here
And wait for my wealth and health to
appear.

I only wonder that the victory
In old Jerusalem was celebrated
With burning of the foul inebriated
Upon the pyre of flames set by the free.
Your law is one thing to fulfil in life,
Another to hold to in oral strife.
There's not a company of well-trained men
Who do not show a decollage to mend
Between what Your law says and what they
do.
Such is the condition of human crew.

2 Maccabees 9

1 About that time, as it occurred,
Antiochus had once deferred
In disarray from Persian fray.
2 For he'd attacked Persepolis
To rob their temples and not miss
Controlling the whole town, but those
Folk rushed armed to defence in rows
Defeating Antiochus and
His men, so he fled with his band.

3 While he was in Ecbatana,
He heard what happened to the claw
Of Nicanor and Timothy.

4 In rage he decided to turn
Upon the Jews his wrath for stern
Defeat, so he drove with all speed
To heaven's judgement for his greed.
In arrogance he said, "When I
Get there I'll make Jews' graveyard sty
Of the town of Jerusalem."

Every ruler of men when met with straights
Finds a scapegoat on which to show his
hates.

So Antiochus in the Persians' claw
Shouts imprecations on the Jewish law.
It's easy to vent rage on those in peace,
Upon the poor and humble in their fleece,
And so before their impotence the chiefs
Cast on the weak more sorrows and more
griefs.

Beloved, I too meet fetid days and weeks
Frustrating for the plans I have for peaks,
And know the foul temptation to lash out
At innocent ones who are cast about.
Save me, Beloved, from Antiochus' sin,
Save me as well as neighbour and my kin.

5 But the all-seeing Lord, the God
 Of Israel, struck him a prod
 Incurable. He fell in wake
 Of awful, tortured stomach-ache.
 6 It was a just end, since he had
 Tortured the bowels of others bad.
 7 Despite the pain he carried on
 In insolent arrogance drawn
 To rage against the Jews and so
 Hastened his way and was not slow.
 He fell from the chariot as it
 Sped by and was maimed when he hit.
 8 The one who thought to rule the waves
 Of the sea and lift above graves
 The mountains, was brought down to earth
 And carried in a stretcher's berth,
 To show the power of God in dearth.
 9 That ungodly body was filled
 With squirming maggots and unstilled
 Was the torture that wracked his frame,
 While yet alive his flesh was game
 To rot and the stench of it came
 To the whole army in revulsion.
 10 Because of his stench in compulsion
 No one could carry the man far
 Who thought that he could touch a star.

The Maccabean writer thinks Your hand
 Behind catastrophe in every land
 And sees Your punishment poured out
 unspared
 Upon the Gentile ruler and his laird,
 But in the measure to awaken to
 Repentance is the chosen folk in pew.
 Truth is that human suffering for its share
 On any folk or person in Your care
 Seems more or less the same, in equal
 doses.

It's only covetous hearts' comatosis
 That thinks the wicked escape any doom,
 Or that the righteous prosper in their room.
 All humankind alike share in the pain
 And in the freshness of a summer rain.

11 At that he came to lose his pride
 Under the bolt from our God's side.
 12 And so he spoke these words "It's right
 To submit to Alohim's might,
 No mortal should think he approaches
 Alohim, *on such ground encroaches.*"
 13 This despicable one made vow

To YHWH who would not anyhow
 Have mercy on him, and he said
 14 The holy city he would spread
 Like dung, he now declared was free,
 15 And the Jews, whom he did not think
 To bury but planned on the brink
 To throw them mother with the child
 At breast to the beast in the wild
 And the birds to pick their bones clean,
 Instead he'd now makes them on scene
 All equal to the citizens
 Of Athens 16 and the holy dens
 Of sanctuary, which he'd plundered,
 He would adorn with offerings wondered,
 And the holy vessels give back,
 All many times over for lack,
 And the costs of the sacrifices
 He would provide from his own vices,
 17 And in addition to all this
 He too would Judaism kiss
 And visit every town and vale
 Proclaiming God's power over hale.

The deathbed intervention for the right
 Is famous in the after years of plight.
 How many men have carried their own
 weight

In sin about the neighbourhood and state
 And plundered every poor man in a straight
 And then called in a preacher to be late
 And cried and repented upon the bed
 And looked to heaven for joy and promised
 bread!

Beloved, my own repentance like to be
 A deathbed one among the scattered free,
 Because each day I find both case and will
 To sign the same repentance oath and bill.
 Your grace sufficient is to fill my soul
 With sorrow for the way I hit the dole.

18 But when his sufferings did not end,
 For Alohim's judgment would bend
 Him justly, he gave up all hope
 For himself and wrote then to cope
 With the Jews a letter to say,
 19 "To his worthy Jewish folk's sway,
 Antiochus their king and chief
 Sends hearty greetings for relief
 In wishing health's prosperity.
 20 "If you and yours are well and be
 Your business as you wish, I'm glad.
 As my hope is in heaven, 21 "not sad

I mind with affection the token
 Of your esteem's good will *unspoken*.
 As I returned from Persian vale
 Annoying illness would prevail,
 So I thought well to plan ahead
 For general safety instead.
 22 "I hope that I shall soon be well.
 23 "But my own father in the spell
 Of expedition did appoint
 His own successor *of the joint*,
 24 "So if the unexpected came,
 The kingdom's people would be game,
 Knowing to whom the kingdom stayed.
 25 "Besides that I know how the hounds
 Of princes gathered round the bounds
 Of my kingdom keep watch to find
 The chance to come and make me blind.
 So I've appointed my own son
 Antiochus to be king won,
 Oft trusted and commended to
 You when I went to upper crew
 Of provinces, and so I write
 Also to him these words of light.
 26 "That's why I urge and beg of you
 To mind the public good in view
 As well as private that we do,
 And keep your good will to me and
 My son when he's king of the land.
 27 "For I am sure that he will keep
 My policy to treat with deep
 Respect and moderation all
 Of you in Jerusalem's stall."
 28 The murderer and blasphemer,
 Having endured the pain the fer
 Had so inflicted on the folk,
 Came to end of his life at stroke
 On foreign mountains *under oak*.
 29 And Philip, one of his men, took
 His body home, fearing to look
 At Antiochus his son, he
 Betook himself to Ptolemy
 Philometor in Egypt's lee.

The case of every chief of state is such:
 Incredible hypocrisy for much
 Evil done on the earth, and yet excuse
 For all the mirth is just more of abuse.
 The king hopes that the Jews will mind the
 way
 He treated them so well and every day,
 When in fact hardly any time or place
 Was greater suffering for the sacred race

Than when Epiphanes had shown his face.
 Beloved, the tune is well-known to the
 great
 And pretended elected of the state
 Today wherever I look on the earth.
 Each murderer pretends sainthood in worth,
 Each president's a murderer of late.

2 Maccabees 10

1 Now Maccabeus and his friends,
 YHWH leading them on to their ends
 Of getting back temple and city,
 2 Tore down the altars *without pity*
 Which had been built in public square
 By foreigners, and also there
 Destroyed the sacred precincts. 3 They
 Cleansed the sanctuary, and they
 Made another altar to burn
 Offerings, then striking fire on flint,
 They offered sacrifices' stint,
 After a lapse of two years, and
 They burned incense and in a band
 Lighted the lamps and set out bread
 Of presence on table instead.
 4 And when they had done this, they fell
 Prostrate beseeching YHWH as well
 That they might never again fall
 Into such misfortunes in thrall,
 But that, if they should ever sin,
 They might meet of His discipline
 In measure, but not be delivered
 To blasphemers, barbarians slivered.
 5 It happened that on the same day
 On which the sanctuary's way
 Had been profaned by foreign Greeks,
 The purification it seeks
 Of the sanctuary took place,
 On the twenty-fifth day in pace
 Of the same month, Chislev by name.
 6 And they celebrated its fame
 For eight days with rejoicing, in
 The manner of Succoth in bin,
 Remembering not long before,
 How during Succoth on the shore
 And in the mountain fast and cave
 They wandered like the beast and slave.
 7 With wands and fronds and palms they
 came
 In thanksgiving to Him whose name
 Gave them back His own holy place
 In purity without a trace.
 8 They made a law by public vote

That every year the Jews should note
These days with celebration's rote.
9 Such then was Antiochus' end,
Called Epiphanes *by each friend*.

The level of accommodation to
Imperial context of Judean crew
Is seen in how Chislev is the month's name
Even when faith comes in to make a claim.
It's as though Jews today thought in
December

When they came to the same dates to
remember.

The several books of prophecy abound
In how to relate to imperial frowned,
And yet over the centuries the fate's
Inevitable to the culturates.
Beloved, the restoration of the church
To the first century's ideal and perch
Succeeds somewhat, so cannot there be too
Returning to the ten commandments due?

10 Now we will tell just what took place
Under Antiochus for face
Called Eupator, who was the son
Of that ungodly man when done,
And will give a brief summary
Of the wars' main calamity.

11 This man, when he became the king
Appointed Lysias to sting
As governor of Coelesyria
And ruler too of Phoenicia.

12 Ptolemy, who was called Macron,
Took the lead in showing a ton
Of justice to the Jews because
Of the wrong done to them in claws,
And tried to keep peace in their paws.

13 For that he was accused before
Eupator by the king's friends' score.
He was accused of treason for
Abandoning Cypriot shore,
When Philometor'd trusted him,
And gone over to that man dim,
Antiochus Epiphanes.

Since people did not bow their knees
To his office, he killed himself
With poison picked up off the shelf.

14 When Gorgias became governor
Of the land, he maintained a score
Of hired soldiers, at every turn
Warring against the Jews to spurn.

The problem with trying to do right in
The context of government is it's sin.
The mercenary fool in government
Who acts once justly without peppermint
Seducing him to one lobby or other
Will be shunned by diplomatic corps
brother.

So Macron falls beneath his own hand's
weight

While Gorgias lives to show his gorgeous
hate.

Beloved, in my retreat from power and
sting

I've learned to spurn not earn many a thing
That's lauded and applauded by the great
And those who fawn upon them in their
state.

The world I live in is the morning still
Beneath a quiet quartzite studded hill.

15 Besides this, Idumeans, who
Had good forts were harassing Jew,
Taking those who fled from the city
Jerusalem without more pity
To keep the war up on the crew.

16 But Maccabeus and his men,
Beseeching Alohim again,
Rushed the fort of Idumean.

17 By brusque attack they gained the forts,
Beat off those on the wall *like warts*,
And killed each one they found until
Twenty thousand lay dead and still.

18 When no less than nine thousand took
Refuge in two strong towers for nook,
Ready to stand a siege, 19 then left
Maccabeus Simon in cleft

And Joseph, and also Zacchaeus
And his men, a band not to flee us,
Enough to besiege them, and he
Himself set off for places free
Where he was needed urgently.

The sons of Edom never lack a tower,
And since the mess of pottage in an hour
Have rarely been the friend and brother true
That blood and water ought to make them
do.

When Maccabeus took the tower and sold
The Idumean soul into death's fold,
He merely kept tradition with the bold.
No doubt both sides thought there was just
no choice,

Whether battle's to sorrow or rejoice.
Beloved, there are ways still of dealing
with
The violence of human heart and myth.
The obvious is sale and purchase where
The market is more dear than killing's
share.

20 The men with Simon, who were greedy,
Were bribed by some of those men needy
Within the towers, and when they got
Seventy thousand drachmas in lot
Let some of the men get away.
21 Maccabeus heard with dismay
And gathered the chiefs of folk and
Accused those men of contraband,
Selling their brothers for a mite,
Setting their foes free and to fight.
22 He executed these men who
Had turned traitor, and as on cue
Captured the two towers *with their crew*.
23 Having success at arms in all
He undertook, he destroyed stall
Of more than twenty thousand men
In the two strongholds *there again*.

Just see, Beloved, the power of money-lust
Upon the hearts of those willing to sell
Destruction on their brothers in the dust
And under poverty or warfare's spell!
Some sell a brother into Egypt's might,
Many sell neighbours to a dismal plight
Against the hope of just a gleam in eye
Contrived by diamond or gold to spy.
Come what may, my Beloved, let me not
buy
Another's fate, despite the marketplace
Before my house as broad on this world's
face
Enlarged so every purchase ramified
Until the poor are pushed on every side.
Some sold their brothers and came to
deride.

24 Timothy, who had been defeated
By the Jews before and unseated,
Hired him a band of soldiers and
Horsemen from Asia out of hand.
He came intending to attack
And take Judea in the slack.
25 As he came near, Maccabeus
And his men scattered dust to fuss

Upon their heads and dressed themselves
With sackcloth not to honour elves,
In supplication to their God.
26 Falling before the altar sod,
They begged Him to look graciously
On them and be an enemy
To their foes, as the law declares.
27 And then arising from their prayers
They took up their arms and advanced
A great way from the city lanced,
And stopped near where enemies pranced.
28 Just at dawn the battle began,
One side with courage and with trust
In YHWH, the other side as must
Their leader whipped in frenzy's rage.
29 When the battle was on rampage,
The enemy saw from the sky
Come down five riders on the sly
With golden bridles, and to lead
The Jewish army from each steed.
30 Surrounding Maccabeus and
Protecting him with their own band,
They kept him safe from every hand.
They broke arrows and thunderbolts
Upon the enemy *like dolts*,
So that, confused and blind, they fell
Into disorder under spell.

Justice is found not in the prayers alone
Up to the great and white celestial throne.
Daft it would be to pray and wait the course
Along which comes the enemy with horse.
Such prayers demand the taking of the
sword,
Much courage to face round the racing
horde
Along the meadow and the rocky stream.
Crush enemy with prayer indeed in beam,
Crush him moreover with the spear and
shield.
After the rise to battle in the field,
Before the victory has been unpeeled,
Enough of heaven will be then revealed
Under five horsemen with their golden
ploy.
Such is the trinity of human joy.

31 Twenty thousand five hundred men
Were slaughtered, besides of housemen
Six hundred. 32 Timothy himself
Fled to a stronghold, hid on shelf
Called Gazara, and well defended,

Where Chaereas was chief amended.
 33 Then Maccabeus and his men
 Were glad, and they besieged again
 The fort for four days. 34 Those inside,
 Relying on the strength to bide,
 Blaphemed and hurled out wicked word.
 35 But at dawn of the fifth day stirred,
 Twenty young men in the army
 Of Maccabeus, and angry
 Because of the blasphemies heard,
 Bravely stormed the wall and with stirred
 Fury cut down every one met.
 36 Others who came up in the net
 Turned on the defenders and set
 Fire to the towers, they kindled fires
 And burned the blasphemers on pyres.
 Others broke open at the gates
 And let in the rest of their mates,
 And they occupied the city's plates.
 37 They killed Timothy, who was hidden
 In a cistern, and his unbidden
 Brother Chaereas, as well as
 Apollophanes *and that jazz*.
 38 When they had finished all these things,
 With hymns and thanksgiving in wings
 They blessed YHWH who shows great
 kindness
 To Israel and gives address
 Of victory *without a guess*.

Joy in Your grace, Beloved, is measured by
 Untrodden faithful soldiers marching nigh
 Dead thousands slain by Your help from
 the sky.
 A grace it is that ten thousand are slain.
 Such grace is multiplied and not in vain
 May come ten thousand more into the
 grave
 Across the tumult of joy of the brave.
 Cause every wicked one to die, and see
 Commandment-keepers singing songs to be
 Among the joyous works of art You find
 Beneath the cloud upon which You
 unwind.
 Eager to praise Your name, the killers
 come
 Under the banner of the hymns they hum
 So long as You raise havoc with the dumb.

2 Maccabees 11

1 Soon after this, Lysias, who
 Was the king's guardian and kin too,

Who was in charge of government,
 Being vexed at what had been sent,
 2 Summoned near eighty thousand men
 And all his cavalry again
 And came against the Jews. He thought
 To make the town a Grecian plot,
 3 And tax the temple as he did
 On other nations' sacred bid,
 And auction off each year the post
 Of high priest *for another roast*.
 4 He did not take into account
 The power of Alohim to mount,
 But trusted ten thousand footmen
 And thousands of horsemen *in den*,
 And eighty elephants *in glen*.
 5 He swept into Judea, he
 Came near Beth-zur, a fort to be
 About five leagues from the city
 Jerusalem, and pressed it hard.
 6 When Maccabeus and his pard
 Heard that Lysias was besieging
 The fortresses, they and their lieging
 With sorrow and with tears besought
 YHWH to send a good angel wrought
 To save Israel. 7 Maccabeus
 Himself was the first in the fuss,
 And he urged others to risk lives
 With him to aid their brothers' hives.
 Then they rushed off to see who strives.

In early days the problem of the Jews
 Was that they had a temple fixed with pews
 That could be dreamed of as a source of
 news
 And income to the kings out to abuse.
 Since then the populace degenerates,
 No longer needing gold to seduce fates,
 But ready to attack the ghetto twice
 And make of poverty a sacrifice.
 A low profile in days past might have won
 A respite from the flogging under sun,
 But now the heat reactor finds the crowd
 Of deer and dog and refugee allowed.
 Beloved, Lysias came to get the gold.
 Now I have only Psalms to sing of old.

8 And there, while they were still nearby
 Jerusalem, a horseman nigh
 Appeared at their head, clothed in white
 And brandishing gold weapons' sight.
 9 They praised merciful Alohim,
 Encouraged to fight to the beam,

Wild men or beasts of iron gleam.

10 They went on in battle array,
A heavenly ally out for prey,
YHWH had mercy on them that day.
11 They hurled themselves like lions
against

The enemy, and killed incensed
Eleven thousand of them and
Sixteen hundred horses in band,
And made the others flee the land.
12 Most of them got away stripped and
Wounded, and Lysias himself
Escaped in disgrace *like an elf*.
13 Since he was not stupid, he thought
About his defeat, thought a lot,
And realized the Hebrews were
Invincible because the stir
Of Alohim was on their side.
So he sent a message to them
14 To persuade them by stratagem
To settle on just terms while he
Would persuade the king to be free
With them and always act friendly.

The horseman clothed in white is figure
known
After captivity by Jewish clone.
Before that time, for the most part, they had
To meet their enemies with sword and sad
Spear and at best the iron chariot blade
That in the later days made spade and
spade.
It's only in the age of empires high
That golden swords and spears are set to
fly.

Beloved, I see the magic plumes arise
Against the splendour of the driven skies
I know Your angels flush the meadow
sweet
And dance among nasturtiums as my feet
Until I notice that their cheep and tweet
Make pale to nothing all the other lies.

15 Maccabeus, who kept his eye
On peace and common good's supply,
Agreed to all that Lysias urged.
For the king granted every purged
Request in behalf of the Jews
Which Maccabeus came to choose
In writing to Lysias made.
16 The letter written *undismayed*
To the Jews by Lysias read so:

"Lysias to Jewish folk, hello.

17 "John and Absalom, who were sent
By you, have brought your letter meant
And signed by you and they have asked
About the matters by which tasked.
18 "I've told the king of everything
That needed him to see the thing,
And he's agreed to what he could.
19 "If you'll keep your good will toward
The government, I'll be implored
In future to promote your good.
20 "As for the details I've commanded
These representatives here banded
With yourselves to negotiate.
21 "Farewell. One hundred forty-eight
Year, Dioscorinthius' rate
Twenty-fourth *neither soon nor late*."

The mission of Absalom and John keeps
On reappearing in the worldly steeps.
The lives of thousands hang upon the hopes
That civil servants somewhere know the
ropes
And will not let them down. They run the
crown.

The arrogant style of the civil vice
Is worrying, if that reveals a slice
Of character of those who feed the pumps
And empty out our garbage in the dumps.
Beloved, I hate to think the food supply
And water depend on such precious fry
As Lysias and his underlings who try.
The sword of Damocles is everywhere,
The more enhanced, the greater is its share.

22 The king's letter read in this way:
"King Antiochus in his sway
To his brother Lysias, hello.
23 "Now that our dad's gone on below
To the gods, we desire the folk
Of the kingdom be undisturbed
In caring for the work uncurbed.
24 "We've heard the Jews do not consent
To our father's change to Greek pent,
But prefer their own way of living
And beg their own customs be giving.
25 "Therefore, since we choose this folk be
Free of disturbance, our decree
Is that their temple be restored
To them and they live unabhored
By the laws of their own ancestors.
26 "You will do well among inquestors,

Therefore, to send word to them and
 Give them pledges of friendship's stand,
 So they may know our policy
 And be of cheer and happily
 Conduct their own affairs freely."

The problem is that every time there's
 change
 Of king there's danger of a further range
 Of persecution from the hand of power.
 Even this new Antiochus is dour
 To accept fait accompli in the tower.
 If Judas had not taken back the city,
 He would have carried on and without pity
 The policy of his own father, but
 He thinks it fruitful to keep his mouth shut
 And reap a greater reward with the rest.
 Who knows when he may yet grasp of the
 best
 Of temple and of harvest in the west.
 Beloved, the fair king's always just a mutt.

27 The king's letter sent to the nation
 Was this: "King Antiochus' ration
 To senate of the Jews and folk
 In common, greeting *at a stroke*.
 28 "If you are well, we are well pleased.
 We're also in good health and eased.
 29 "Menelaus has informed us that
 You wish to return and keep scat
 Of your own affairs. 30 "Therefore those
 Who go home by the thirtieth rows
 Of Xanthicus will have our pledge
 Of friendship and full promise edge,
 31 "For the Jews to enjoy their own
 Food and laws, just as early shown,
 And none of them shall be molested
 In any way for what protested
 May have been done in ignorance.
 32 "And I have also sent by chance
 Menelaus to encourage you.
 33 "Farewell. The one hundred and due
 Forty-eighth year, Xanthicus' view
 The fifteenth day *and not to stew*."

The government then as now would control
 The very morsel any mouth in troll
 Would take on lip, and when met with the
 fact,
 Knows how to pretend control of the pact.
 King Antiochus gives the Jews a share

To choose what they will ever eat and
 wear,
 Providing that they race to the right place
 Before a certain date or meet the mace.
 There has to be a show of power in king,
 For all kings are unsure of self and ring,
 And so before they're frightened come to
 sting.
 Beloved, I judge upon the fifteenth day
 As good as any to come out and play,
 Ignoring tax collectors on the way.

34 The Romans also sent a note,
 Which thus read if once more I quote:
 "Quintus Memmius and Titus
 Manius, envoys of the Russ
 Romans, to the folk of the Jews,
 Greeting. 35 "With regard to what views
 Lysias the kinsman of the king
 Has granted you, we also sing
 Our own consent. 36 "But as to things
 He thought as might refer to kings,
 As soon as you've considered them,
 Send some one quickly on the hem,
 So we may make proposals right
 For you. For we are on our way
 To Antioch. 37 "Therefore make hay,
 And send some men, so that we may
 Have your judgment. 38 "Farewell. The
 one
 Hundred and forty-eighth year done,
 Xanthicus fifteenth *and well spun*."

The Romans always hurry to make sure
 That everyone knows they have the manure
 In hand and carry of all biggest stick,
 And so benignly promise not to kick.
 The Romans always have proposals fair
 That they expect everyone everywhere
 To follow without question in the lurch:
 They have the makings of catholic church.
 Beloved, I need no missives from the great,
 Or from those who pretend to be the state,
 That element that has no nucleus
 Or any electron beside the bus.
 The letter that is dated always is.
 It's dated and fermented to a fizz.

2 Maccabees 12

1 When this agreement had been reached,
 Lysias returned unimpeached
 To the king, and the Jews kept farming.

2 But some governors were alarming,
 Timothy, Apollonius
 The prideful son of Gennaeus,
 Hieronymus and Demophon,
 Nicanor Cyprus' chief undone,
 Would not let them live quietly
 And in peace. 3 And some ungodly
 Men of Joppa too did this deed.
 They asked the Jews with them in greed
 To set sail with their wives and seed,
 On boats they provided, as though
 There had been no ill will in stow,
 4 And this was done by public vote
 Of the whole city out to gloat.
 When they agreed, because they wished
 To live in peace and not up-dished,
 The men of Joppa took them out
 To sea and drowned them with a shout,
 5 When Judas heard the cruelty
 Upon his countrymen's degree,
 He ordered up his men, 6 and they
 Called on Alohim's righteous way,
 Attacked the murderers of his brothers,
 He set fire to the harbour smothers
 By night, and burned the boats, and killed
 Those who took refuge there *unskilled*.

It's hardly any use to make the king
 Or president or head of anything
 A friend, because he always has at gate
 Ferocious dogs he sends out to take bait
 Of every passer-by in peace to rate.
 So Antiochus claimed to give the peace,
 But his own lords were criminals to fleece.
 He might have sent them all to work in
 ships
 And row his plundering around for dips,
 But any that he took instead would be
 As bad or worse upon both land and sea.
 Beloved, I know the course of hierarchy
 Is always sinful plunder of the free,
 Whether in times past or eternity.

7 Because the city gates were shut,
 He went away thinking to glut
 Joppa another time. 8 But when
 He learned that in Jamnia the men
 Planned the same trick to wipe out Jews
 Who lived among them in their mews,
 9 He attacked Jamnia's folk by night
 And set fire to the harbour site
 And to the fleet, so that the glow

Of light was seen as far in show
 As in Jerusalem, so far
 As thirty miles. 10 When they in car
 Had gone more than a mile from there,
 On their march against Timothy,
 About five thousand Arabs' share
 With five hundred horsemen in fee
 Attacked them. 11 After a hard fight
 Judas and his men won the blight,
 By help of Alohim *in sight*.
 In their defeat the Arabs begged
 Judas to grant them pledges pegged
 Of friendship, promising to give
 Him cattle and to help to live
 In every way handed and legged.
 12 Judas thought they might be of use,
 And so agreed to make a truce
 With them and so they all retired.
 13 He also attacked one town spired
 With earthworks and with walls where
 dwelt

All sorts of Gentiles *on the belt*.
 Its name was Caspin. 14 And welt
 Of those who were inside relied
 On the strength of the walls to bide
 And on what corn and wine provide,
 And they behaved with insolence
 Towards Judas and men of sense,
 Blaspheming curses on their tents.

So many men of Caspin live by me
 Or are seen on the news eternally!
 So many trust in weight of wealth and see
 With disdain those who hope in their
 degree

To worship You in peace from infantry!
 Make a man think he's safe and he will
 soon

Cry curses on the holy for a boon.
 Beloved, the insolence of my own heart
 Is often covered with the stone rampart
 Of inner chamber, where I ought to bow
 Before the lighted throne where I kowtow.
 Make me, Beloved, see that the wall of
 grief

Is not a solace against Your belief,
 Let me praise You as well as tree and leaf.

15 But Judas and his men called on
 The great Sovereign of the world drawn,
 Who without battering-rams or cars
 Of war overthrew all the stars

Of Jericho and in the days
 Of Joshua, rushed in a craze
 Upon the walls. 16 They took the town
 By will of Alohim *and crown*,
 And slaughtered such a crowd of them
 The lake nearby in breadth of hem
 Of a quarter of a mile seemed
 To run over with blood *that gleamed*.
 17 When they had gone ninety-five miles
 From there, they came to Charax guiles,
 To the Jews called Toubiani.
 18 But they did not find Timothy
 There, for he had by then gone off
 Without doing a thing but scoff,
 Though in one place he left a strong
 Fort garrisoned to keep along.
 19 Dositheus and Sosipater,
 Who were captains under the fer
 Maccabeus, marched out and slew
 Those Timothy had left in crew
 In the stronghold, and more than ten
 Thousand *of evil, wicked* men.

For shame, Beloved, that I rejoice to hear
 That Dositheus and Sosipater near
 Marched out and killed the soldiers of the
 cross

Or of the Grecian temples to their loss!
 In Your commandments You say not to kill
 And yet my gloating heart's too large to fill
 With fat reports of Maccabean skill.

Beloved, the thirst for blood in human heart
 Is not assuaged by slaughter in the cart,
 But only by the change in triumph made
 By love of You beneath the leafy shade
 Of birch and aspen, mountain ash in view
 Of rosy morning blessing lake and dew.
 So I perch on a pine-bought, humming
 glade.

20 But Maccabeus set his bands
 And appointed men in commands,
 And hurried after Timothy,
 Who had a hundred and twenty
 Thousand with him as infantry
 And two thousand five hundred more
 In cavalry *to even score*.
 21 When Timothy learned of approach
 Of Judas, he sent off in coach
 The women and the children and
 Also the baggage to a stand
 Called Carnaim, for that place was hard

To besiege and with trouble starred
 To reach because the narrow pass
 On all sides was in rocky mass.
 22 But when Judas' first band appeared,
 Terror fell on the foe who feared
 Him who sees all things, and they fled
 This way and that, till some fell dead
 By point of spear and sword of their
 Own men 23 And Judas pressed pursuit
 With energy and put the boot
 To the sinners and so destroyed
 Thirty thousand men so employed.

Lay terror, my Beloved, upon the mind
 And eye and hand and foot of the foul blind
 Who rule and trample the few who love
 You
 And keep Your commandments as is their
 due.

Lay terror, my Beloved, upon me too,
 And keep me in the narrow way to do
 Your will alone and not turn in the way
 Of idols and of rock stars in their sway
 Of providing support for status quo
 And armies of merchants and tanks that go
 About the world like riff-raff to bestow
 An advertising edge on yesterday.
 Beloved, show me today a better ray,
 Commandments ten to do, remember,
 know.

24 Timothy himself was captive
 Of Dositheus and Sosipater
 And their men, *but they let him live*.
 With great guile he begged them to let
 Him go in safety, he could get
 Most of their parents and the brothers
 Of some, and because of his smothers
 They feared to keep him in their set.
 25 When with many words he'd confirmed
 His solemn promise though unwormed
 To restore them unharmed, they let
 Him go, for the sake and regret
 Of their brothers' salvation yet.
 26 Then Judas marched against Carnaim
 And temple of Atargatis,
 And killed twenty-five thousand prime
 People. 27 After the rout and miss
 Of these, he marched against Ephron,
 A fortified city unwon
 Where Lysias lived with multitudes
 Of people of all lands and broods.

Strong young men took their stand before
The walls and made defensive score,
With many tanks and missiles there.

28 But the Jews called upon their great
Sovereign who with His power of state
Shatters the might of enemies,
And they forced the town to its knees,
And killed twenty-five thousand of
Those who were in it *to wear glove*.

29 Setting out from there, they hurried
Up to Scythopolis *and scurried*.

The place is seventy-five miles
Out from Jerusalem *with smiles*.

30 But when the Jews who lived there gave
Witness to the good will and brave
Which the folk of Scythopolis
Had shown them and their dealings' kiss
In times of trouble, 31 they thanked them,
Exhorting them to be a gem
To their race in the future too.
Then they went to Jerusalem,
Since feast of weeks was close in view.

They might as well have slaughtered all the
folk

Within Scythopolis and rid at stroke.

Just because the Jews there gave them good
name

Was no proof they would continue the
same.

It is no use to give back good for good,
Knowing that people just act as they should
When they see their advantage in the
scheme.

A better policy would be to cream
The populace of earth. The fatal truth
Is that they're out to kill the Jews from
youth

To old age, and that topic never dies.
Offensive and pre-emptive best relieves.

The Maccabees were too kind to the
Greeks,

And that's why pogroms still go on for
weeks.

32 After the feast called Pentecost,
They hurried out against all cost
To fight Gorgias, the governor
Of Idumea's *land and shore*.

33 And he came out with three thousand
Infantry and four hundred manned
In cavalry. 34 When they joined battle,

It happened that a few Jews straddle
Fell. 35 But a certain Dositheus,
One of Bacenor's men of use,
Who was on horseback and was strong,
Caught hold of Gorgias to grab thong
Of his cloak to drag him off horse,
To take the man alive of course,
But one Thracian horseman came down
And cut off his arm with a frown,
So Gorgias escaped and ran to
The town of Marisa with crew.
36 As Esdris and his men had been
Fighting for a long time for kin
And were weary, Judas called on
YHWH to show Himself ally drawn
And leader in the battle gone.
37 In the tongue of their fathers he
Raised the battle cry, with degree
Of hymns, then he charged on the men
Of Gorgias by surprise again,
And scattered them in flight in fen.

The Hebrew tongue began those days to be
The medium of magic treachery,
The casting up of spells to the degree
Of charlatans and true men of faith free.
The Hebrew tongue in hymn and psaltery
Remains my choice as I stand in the wake
Of Maccadean assault for its sake.
I sing the magic syllables and see
The falling and the flight of enemy.
I see temptations fly away from me,
Along with hopes of honour in the glee
Of government and church in agony.
The Psalms of Maccabees I shall take
And find that I have not made a mistake.

38 Then Judas gathered in his band
And went to the city well-manned
Of Adullam. As seventh day
Was coming on, they cleansed their way
According to the custom's sway,
And kept the Sabbath there as planned.

39 On the next day, Judas and men
Went out to get the lads again
That had fallen to lie with kin
In ancestral graves *without sin*.
40 But under the shirt of each man
They found the sacred idol's span
Of Jamnia, which law forbids
The Jews to wear, *both dads and kids*.
And so they understood at last

Why these men had fallen outcast.
 41 So they all blessed the ways of YHWH,
 The righteous Judge, who gives in due
 The revelation of the true,
 42 And they returned to prayer to beg
 The sin committed on a keg
 Might be completely blotted out,
 The noble Judas told the folk
 To keep themselves free of sin's pout,
 For they had seen how at a stroke
 What happened because of the sin
 Of those who had fallen of kin.
 43 He also took up a collection,
 Man by man, to amount's selection
 Of two thousand drachmas of silver,
 And sent it to Jerusalem
 To provide for sin offering's *pilver*.
 He acted by this stratagem
 For right and honour and in mind
 Of resurrection of *mankind*.
 44 For if he did not think that those
 Who had fallen would rise as chose,
 It would have been an empty thing
 And foolish for the dead praying.
 45 But if he hoped splendid reward
 Laid up for those who sleep by sword
 Of godliness, it was a thought
 Both holy and pious he wrought.
 He made atonement for the dead
 To save them from their sin and dread.

The Sadducees and Pharisees would come
 To argue about resurrection's sum
 For centuries, but truth lies in the grave,
 And only You have hand of strength to
 save.
 Beloved, You can do as You will with sin,
 With those struck down for idols that they
 win,
 For those whose hands are bloody with the
 share
 Of innocent struck down without a care.
 The prayer for the dead or the sacrifice
 Of goat before the altar will suffice
 For intercession of the righteous man.
 It is the intercession in its span
 That makes atonement for the thoughtless
 deed,
 The lost coin and the fevered search in
 greed.

2 Maccabees 13

1 Year one hundred and forty-nine
 Judas and his men hear grape-vine
 Say Antiochus Eupator
 Was on his way to a great war
 Against Judea, 2 and with him
 Lysias, his guardian dim,
 Who had charge of the government.
 Each of them had a Greek force sent
 Of one hundred and ten thousand
 Foot soldiers and five thousand three
 Hundred in men of cavalry,
 And twenty-two elephants, and
 Three hundred chariots armed with scythes.
 3 Menelaus too joined with withs
 And pure hypocrisy to urge
 On Antiochus to the dirge,
 Not for his country, but for sake
 Of the career he had in stake.
 4 But the King of kings caused the wrath
 Of Antiochus in his path
 When Lysias informed the king
 That he was to blame for the ring
 Of trouble, he ordered to take
 Him to Beroea for the sake
 Of killing him there as they do
 In that place with the crime-sunk crew.
 5 For there's a tower in that place,
 Fifty armlengths high, full of trace
 Of ashes, and it has a rim
 Running around it to make swim
 From every side down to the ashes.
 6 There they all push until he splashes
 Any man guilty of the charge
 Of sacrilege or crime at large.
 7 By such a fate it came about
 That Menelaus who was stout
 In crime, died without burial
 In earth 8 And this was just withal,
 Because he'd balleied many sins
 Against the altar whose fire wins
 And ashes were holy, he met
 His death in ashes justly set.

Good Menelaus, for causing all the weight
 Of trouble to the king at Lysias' gate,
 Must meet a horrid death and fervid fate,
 Because the worst of kings will always find
 A scape-goat on whom to vent vengeance
 blind.
 But Menelaus is no better in view
 And no worse, all chiefs sit in the same
 pew

To further their careers, not to make peace
And profits for the people on increase.
It was just that poor Menelaus should die
Smothered in ashes for his sins and cry.
What was unjust, Beloved, is that the crew
Of civil servants and the king's men too
Remained alive and well to perpetrate.

9 The king with heathen arrogance
Was coming to show the Jews a dance
Far worse than what his father did.
10 But when Judas heard of this bid,
He ordered the folk call upon
YHWH day and night from dawn to dawn,
Now if ever to help those who
Were on the point of being through
Him deprived of the law and their
Country and holy temple fair,
11 And not to let the people, who
Had just begun to revive too,
Fall in hands of uncouth Gentile.
12 When they had all joined for a while
In the petition and besought
The merciful Lord with a lot
Of weeping and fasting and lying
Prostrate for three days without vying,
Judas encouraged them and told
Them to stand ready and be bold.

The four great means of true petition lie
Exposed here for both Jew and Christian
eye:
Prayer, fasting, weeping, and prostration
met
Success divine before the heathen bet.
Beloved, I too in my time have been set
In prayer and fasting, weeping and the pale
Of earth prostration at the divine veil.
The ones who realize the immanence
Of pagan attack on the square and dance
Are ready to petition You with fire.
But blinded to the danger by desire
The populace would rather sing and dance
And drink to all the gods of goddess'
prance.
I see clear-eyed the fall of town and pyre.

13 After a secret interview
With the elders in temple pew,
He decided to march out to
Decide the matter by the aid
Of Alohim once on parade

Before the king's army waylaid
Judea and the city fade.
14 Relying on the world's Creator,
Encouraging his men like satyr
To fight to death for land and law,
Temple and town and common awe,
He pitched his tent near Modein's *draw*.
15 He gave his men the watchword well,
"God's victory," and with the spell
Of a picked force of bravest youth,
He attacked the king's band in truth
By night and killed two thousand men
In the camp. Then he stabbed again
The leading elephant with rider.
16 At last they filled the camp beside her
With terror and confusion and
Withdrew in triumph *from the stand*.
17 This happened, just as day was dawning,
Because the Lord's help in the awning
Protected him on every hand.

The BAR man was the target when
The USA attacked Japanese yen.
In every battle there is strategy
To knock out what is dangerous in spree.
So Judas touched the torch of battle cry
Beneath the black of night and darkened
sky
Not only to the infantry and horse,
But to the leading elephant of course.
He took care also to kill off the man
That knew how to guide elephants in span.
Beloved, I seek the strategy as well
As I choose foes to kill and to dispel.
I touch the tirade of temptations' haste
Before they meet the ear and eye and waist.

18 The king fired by the daring Jews
Tried strategy to post his cues.
19 He marched on Beth-zur, a strong fort
Of the Jews, was turned back, resort
Again, and was defeated there.
20 Judas sent to the fortress ware
Whatever was needed in share.
21 But Rhodocus, man from the ranks
Of the Jews, gave secret think-tanks
To the foes, and was sought and caught
And sent to prison as he ought.
22 The king negotiated then
A second time with all the men
In Beth-zur, gave them promises,
Made pacts and then withdrew with his,

Attacked Judas' army in crew
 And then was defeated anew.
 23 He heard that Philip, left in charge
 Of rule of Antiochan pew,
 Had revolted, so left at large
 He called the Jews and made his peace,
 Swore to observe their rights and lease,
 And offered sacrifice to give
 Honour to the temple and live
 To show his generous hand there
 Toward the holy place and share.
 24 He received Maccabeus, left
 Hegemonides unbereft
 As governor from Ptolemais
 To Gerar, 25 went to Ptolemais.
 The people of Ptolemais were
 Angry over the treaty's stir,
 And wanted to abrogate it.
 26 Lysias took the public mitt,
 And spoke well in defence of it,
 Convincing and appeasing them,
 Gaining their good will for a gem,
 And set out for Antioch's hem.
 So ended the king's stratagem.

Rhetoric to gain public view and thought
 In favour of the regime was not taught
 A century ago, but ancient times
 Were quite familiar with such crimes.
 When Lysias took the podium to speak
 In favour of the Jews, he was not meek,
 But spoke in favour of the royal will
 To keep the Jews glad on their kingly hill.
 The anti-Semitism of the place
 Appeals indeed, and makes one hide one's
 face
 For very shame that such a creed could
 stand
 So long upheld in every heathen land.
 Identity is what exacerbates
 The human will in genocidal traits.

2 Maccabees 14

1 After three years, word came to Judas
 And his men that *Demetriudas*,
 The son of Seleucus, had sailed
 Into Tripolis' harbour galed
 With a strong army and a fleet,
 2 Took control of the country neat,
 After killing both Antiochus
 And side-kick Lysias *to mock us*.
 3 Now one Alcimus, who had been

High priest once but defiled by sin
 In times of separation knew
 He could not be safe in his pew
 Or gain access to altar's due,
 4 And went to King Demetrius
 In year one hundred fifty-one
 And gave him a gold crown and fuss
 Of a palm and besides these won
 The temple olive branches fun.
 For that day he made no request,
Waiting later to do his best.

A new king always means a chance to take
 A new position in the new-born stake.
 So Alcimus saw opportunity
 When Demetrius sailed across the sea,
 Killed Antiochus and Lysias dead.
 The story is a well-know pattern bred.
 Alcimus was an opportunist found
 Willing to defile himself on the ground
 As priest rather than forego benefit
 Of taking bribes in bank account and mitt.
 Beloved, I am no priest nor do I seek
 A pound of pence beyond the food I peek,
 I have no golden crown to give nor yet
 A palm and olive branch for what I get.

5 But he found opportunity
 That furthered his mad purpose, see,
 Invited by Demetrius
 To council meeting and famous,
 Where they asked him about the Jew.
 He answered, 6 "Those of the Jews who
 Are called Hasideans, whose leader
 Is Judas Maccabeus, heeder,
 Are keeping up war and rebellion,
 And hindering the peace like hellion.
 7 "That's why I've laid aside my post
 Of high priesthood's ancestral boast,
 And have come here, 8 first because I
 Am truly concerned for the why
 And wherefore of the royal grant,
 And secondly because I plant
 A stake of interest in my folk.
 For through the folly of the stroke
 Of those I mentioned in our land
 The whole nation comes to a stand.
 9 "And since you know, O king, the thing,
 Have thought for our country and ring
 With that same graciousness you show
 To all other peoples in row.
 10 "For as long as this Judas lives,

No rule of peace anyway gives.”
11 When he had said this, the king’s
friends,

Who were hostile to Judas’ ends,
Quickly inflamed Demetrius
Still more and they made a great fuss.
12 He then straightway chose Nicanor,
Who commanded elephant crew,
Appointing him the governor
Of Judea, and sent him for
13 To kill Judas, scatter his band,
And set up Alcimus to stand
As high priest of the temple grand.
14 And the Gentiles throughout Judea,
Who had fled before Judas *freer*,
Flocked to join Nicanor, thinking
Misfortune for the Jews would bring
Prosperity on their crime ring.

Political intrigue is always set
As white and black before all those are met,
And one protagonist is right and fair
In all his doings, while the foe, beware,
Is evil black and to the core to get.
By this I do not think to make a point
Of skin colour at all by any joint.
Humankind set themselves in groups to
neigh
At economic passions in their sway,
And use the faith or gods or hue of skin
To justify the foraging in sin.
So when the Jews are down the others rise
To make a fortune at the Jews’ demise,
Using the Jews to undermine the guise.

15 The Jews heard of Nicanor’s coming
And gathering of the Gentiles humming,
And sprinkled dust upon their heads
And prayed to Him who set the spreads
Of His own people for all time
Always upholding His own dime
By showing Himself in the clime.
16 At the command of the chief, they
Set out from there to make essay
Of battle at a village called
Dessau. 17 Simon, the unappalled
Brother of Judas, had met there
Nicanor, but was checked a spare
By sudden surprise of the foe.
18 Still Nicanor, who heard the glow
Of courage of Judas and band
Was hesitant to make a stand.

19 Therefore he sent Posidonius,
Theodotus and Mattathias
To make a treaty in the land.
20 Considering fully the pact
The leader told the folk exact
Who all agreed upon the stacked.

The times that diplomatic concourse makes
Peace are those times when for the subtle
sakes

Of fears of boldness generals despair
Of laying with impunity the fair
Upon the bloody graves. So they beware.
It is the case of law as it’s applied
By every democratic state decreed,
That peace is bought at gunpoint of the
side.

Beloved, I have a grand alternative
To forced and controlled violence to give:
Let every child be educated at
The hand of teacher to turn every brat
To the obedience of Your commands.
They’re only ten and easy on the hands.

21 The leaders set a day on which
To meet by themselves for a pitch.
A chariot came out from each band,
With seats of honour set to stand.
22 Judas posted armed men to watch
At each strategic point to botch
The sudden treachery that might
From hand of foe come to the light,
And so the parties parleyed right.
23 Nicanor kept Jerusalem
And did nothing out of the stem,
But sent away the crowds of folk
That had gathered to see the stroke.

24 And he kept Judas in his sight,
Appreciated well the wight.
25 He urged him to marry and bear
Children, so he married the fair,
And settled down, and came to share
The common life. 26 But when Alcimus
Noticed their good will for each Remus,
He took the treaty that was made
And went where Demetrius stayed.
He told him that Nicanor was
Disloyal to the ruling buzz,
For he had set conspirator
Judas against the kingdom score,
And so to be his successor.
27 The king became excited and,

Provoked by the false words at hand
Of that depraved man, wrote Nicanor,
Saying he was displeased in manner
With the treaty and ordered him
To send out Maccabeus trim
To Antioch as a prisoner grim.

The problem with the royal rule or yet
Democracy as it is often met
Is simply not to let the well alone,
But there must be contention at the bone,
And prizes given to those who meet the
score
Of ruler or of lobby at the door.
Peace is occasion for some man to try
His hand at some dissension on the sly.
Beloved, let peace reign and not
government,
The rule of every man his own affairs,
And so be You alone the Sovereign sent
To oversee a world, one without cares.
The earthly anarchy is opportune
For divine rule, and may it enter soon.

28 When this message came to Nicanor,
He was troubled and grieved in manner
That he had to annul their pact
When the man did no wrong in act.
29 Since it was not possible to go
Against the king, he watched for show
Of chance to carry out the scheme
By stratagem in what to seem.
30 But Maccabeus noticed that
Nicanor was more frosty at
His meetings with him and more rude,
And thought there must be motives crude.
So he gathered not a few men,
And went into hiding again
From Nicanor. 31 When the man knew
He was outwitted by the crew
Of Judas, he went to the great
And holy temple there to state
While the priests offered sacrifice
And ordered them to hand in trice
The man. 32 And when they said on oath
That they knew nothing of the growth
Or where the man was whom he sought,
33 He pointed toward the temple plot
And swore, "If you do not give up
Judas to me for prison tup,
I'll tear down this temple of God
And destroy the altar on sod,

And build here a fine house to show
The worship of Dionysos."
34 He said this and then turned to go.

To have a temple made of stone and gold
Gives opportunity to royal bold
To threaten conscience and the hope of fair,
And destroy people praying everywhere.
A better temple is that of the skies,
The secret meeting of those who despise
The dome and altar, but who greatly prize
Your law and Psalms of David in their
guise.

Beloved, my temple is the sudden room
Of Sabbath as it nears me in the gloom,
And my spires are the slight songs of the
ray
Of David sung by one or two in stray.
I flee to time instead of place to be
Where no man can have a monopoly.

Then the priests stretched out their hands
toward

The heaven and called upon adored
Defender of our nation so.
35 "O Lord of all, who have no low
Need of anything in the show,
You were pleased to set temple here
For Your dwelling among sincere,
36 "Holy One, Lord of holiness,
Keep undefiled this house address
So recently made pure in fear."
37 One Razis, elder of the town
Jerusalem, came under frown
Of Nicanor as a man who
Loved his fellow citizens and
Was thought of well on every hand
For good called father of the Jews.
38 For in those times not to abuse
Mingling with Gentiles, they'd accuse
Him of Judaism and for
Judaism he'd risked his score.
39 Nicanor, wishing to show hate
He had for Jews and for their state,
Sent five hundred soldiers to take
Him, 40 thinking that for such a stake
He could do injury like rake.

Note, my Beloved, how swings the human
hand
Once ready to do righteously in band,
Albeit at the gunpoint of the grand.

Nicanor now rejoices with the king
 To do the Jews the harm of anything.
 He just obeys the orders from above,
 And that is why he puts on SS glove.
 Those who obey commands of those in
 power
 Take part in wickedness exposed an hour.
 The ten small words so easy to avail,
 No killing, lying, stealing in the pale,
 Would circumvent the hope of even chiefs
 Of state and company and come to griefs.
 No need for officers decked out in mail.

41 When the troops were about to take
 The tower and force the door in wake
 Of the courtyard, they ordered fire
 Be brought against the doors in pyre.
 Being surrounded, Razis fell
 Upon his own sword, 42 to die well
 Rather than fall in sinners' hand
 And suffer outrages to stand
 Against his noble birth and band.
 43 But in the heat of the fight he
 Did not hit himself exactly,
 And the crowd was now rushing in
 Through the doors. He bravely like kin
 Ran on the wall, and manfully
 Threw himself down into the spree.
 44 But they quickly drew back, so he
 Fell in the middle of the space.
 45 Still alive and aflame with grace
 Of anger, he rose gushing blood,
 And ran through the crowd to a rock,
 Where he stood to survey the flock,
 Blood wholly drained, he tore out his
 Entrails and took the stinking fizz
 In both hands and threw them out on
 The Gentile crowd calling upon
 YHWH of life and spirit to give
 Them back to him again to live.
 This was how he died *before dawn*.

There's hardly anything that stinks as much
 As freshly gutted entrails to the touch.
 Razis could hardly find a better way
 To show disdain for those who held the
 sway
 Than scatter them with fresh dung from his
 own
 Guts torn out to leave only flesh and bone.
 With every word I write, each sonnet bare,
 I throw my dung on Gentiles everywhere

Who fail to hear Your word upon the air
 Of Sinai and to keep the Decalogue.
 I treat them all as less than frog and hog.
 Humanity is born of one thing true,
 The hearing of Your word, Your word to
 do.
 Without it every soul's illusion's share.

2 Maccabees 15

1 When Nicanor heard that Judas
 And his men were in Samaria's
 Region, he made plans to attack
 Them with complete safety on track
 Of Sabbath day. 2 And when the Jews
 Who were compelled to take his cues
 Said, "Don't destroy so savagely,
 But show respect for the decree
 Of Sabbath which He who sees all
 Things has honoured, made sacred hall
 Above all other days in call,"
 3 The thrice-accursed wretch asked if there
 Were a sovereign in heaven to care
 About the Sabbath day in share.
 4 They witnessed, "It's the living Lord
 Himself, Sovereign in heaven adored,
 Who ordered us to keep the day
 Of Sabbath the seventh in sway,"
 5 He replied, "And I'm lord on earth,
 And I give you commands of worth
 To take up arms and do the will
 Of the king in valley and hill."
 Yet he did not succeed at all
 To carry out plans to appal.

The Sabbath is the one thing in Your law
 That points against the human held in awe
 And limits action of the chief on those
 Who are subordinate to what he chose.
 That's why all rulers on the earth oppose
 The Sabbath that relieves the hands and
 toes
 Of workers and oppressed in every field.
 That's why on every other thing they yield,
 But not on obligation out of hand
 To keep the Sabbath that reminds the band
 Their power's limited by the command
 Of You, Beloved, Creator come to stand
 A Saviour and commander of all men.
 Beloved, send out the Sabbath law again.

6 This Nicanor in arrogance
 Set up a public remembrance

Of victory of Judas and
 His men who were with him in band.
 7 But Maccabeus did not cease
 To trust YHWH for help and release.
 8 He told his men not to fear what
 The Gentiles might do in their glut,
 But to keep in mind the times past
 When help from heaven came at last,
 And now to look for victory
 Which the Almighty would decree.
 9 Encouraging them from the law
 And from the prophets held in awe,
 Reminding them also of fights
 That they had won, he made them lights.
 10 When he had roused their courage, he
 Gave his orders, and by the while
 Showing the sins of the Gentile
 And violation of their oaths.
 11 He armed each of them not with troths
 In shields and spears as with the brave
 Words of the spirit, so he gave
 Them cheer by telling them a dream,
 A sort of vision, it would seem.
 12 What he saw was this: Onias,
 Who'd been former high priest by us,
 A noble and good man, too,
 One fitting and trained from the pew
 And childhood, was praying with hands
 Outstretched for Jews in all the lands.
 13 Then likewise a man appeared, grey
 In hair and beard in noble way,
 Majestic in authority.
 14 And Onias spoke, and he said
 "This is a man who loves the bred
 Brothers and prays much for the folk
 And holy city, at a stroke
 Jeremiah, God's prophet woke."
 15 "Jeremiah stretched out his right
 Hand and gave to Judas a light
 And golden sword, and as he gave
 It he told him, 16 "Take holy sword,
 A gift from Alohim adored,
 With which you will strike down your foes
 Arrayed against you in their rows."

The problem with seeing strange sights and
 rounds
 Is simply that encouragement alone
 Is not all that comes upon such bright
 grounds.
 The dream entails responsibility,
 Not only to oneself and the degree

Of visionary light but the fold free
 For whom the vision's taught. The burden
 there
 Is greater than a hundred backs to share,
 But must be bourn by one alone to hear
 The ranting of the unjust on the ear.
 Beloved, I too have seen the strange,
 profound,
 And swooned in awe before the wondered
 sound,
 And I have lived to regret speaking of
 The vision of eternal hope and love.

17 Encouraged by the words of Judas,
 So nobly and quickly imbued us
 With courage and boldness to act
 On the behalf of souls in pact,
 To fight foes hand to hand with tact
 Because of danger to the town,
 The sanctuary and the crown
 Of temple. 18 Their concern for wives
 And children, and their kinsmen's lives,
 Lay on them with less weight as they
 Thought of the holy temple's sway.
 19 And those who had to remain in
 The city were in troubled bin,
 Anxious that the fight would begin
 There in the countryside. 20 When all
 Were looking for the coming thrall,
 And the foe was then close at hand
 With army and elephant band
 Strategically set and with horse
 And riders deployed on the course,
 21 Then Maccabeus, seeing all
 The men and elephants in call
 Stretched out his hands toward heaven and
 prayed
 To YHWH who works wonders unstayed,
 For he knew that it's not by arms,
 But as YHWH decides in alarms,
 And that he gains the victory
 For those who deserve it's decree.

It's sweet that Maccabeus thinks Your arm
 Always gives victory from every harm,
 And all things go by Your will on the day
 Of battle, and You have the upper sway.
 It takes a lot of faith to see the mill
 Of grand oppression, see and believe still
 That all things work for good when fellows
 fall

Who had been perfect in Your commands
thrall.

Beloved, though I'm a doubter at the wall,
And not like Judas who is sure that good
Is always on the throne, and as things
should

So they occur in town and field and wood,
I still believe that trust in You alone
Is where I must stand to keep up my own.

22 And he called upon him like this,

"O Lord, You did send angel kiss
In Hezekiah's time, the king
Of Judah, and he slew a ring,
A hundred eighty-five thousand
In Sennacherib's camp and band.

23 So now, O Sovereign of the sky,
Send a good angel here to fly
With terror and trembling of us.

24 By the might of Your glorious
Arm may these blasphemers who come
Against your holy folk fall dumb."
With these words he ended his prayer.

25 Nicanor and his men strode there
With trumpets and with battle song,

26 And Judas and his men along
Met the foe in battle with prayer
To Alohim and supplication.

27 So, fighting with their hands in station
And praying to Alohim well
In their hearts, they laid low in spell
Thirty-five thousand men to tell,
And they were very glad to see
God's manifestation's degree.

28 When the action was over and
They were returning joyous band,
They recognized Nicanor where
He lay dead in full armour there.

I praise You, my Beloved, that on a day
The self-serving officer in the fray
Lay dead while doing what the order taught
Him by superiors in land and lot.
I too receive the orders of my lust,
The orders of the public word in trust,
The statutes of the evil parliament,
The rations that the civil servants sent.
I too receive and I fail to appear
Faithful to all of these before my ear,
But act as one dead by Your command
here,

The ten words once caught on Mount Sinai
when

You came to speak to chiefs, women, and
men.

I praise You, my Beloved, and praise again.

29 Then there was shouting and tumult,
And they blessed the Sovereign Lord's cult
In the ancestral tongue's result.

30 And the man who was ever in
Body and soul of citizen
Defender, the man who maintained
His youthful good will and sustained
Toward his countrymen, told them
To cut off Nicanor's head's gem
And arm and carry them into
Jerusalem *for all to view*.

31 And when he got there and had called
His countrymen to stand appalled,
And set the priests before the altar,
He sent for those who came to falter
In the fortress. 32 He showed the head
Of vile Nicanor and the spread
Of his arm which in pride stretched out
Toward the temple in oath's shout
Against the holy and Almighty,
33 And he cut out the tongue unsightly
Of the ungodly Nicanor
And said he'd give it in a score
Of pieces to the birds and hang
Up these rewards his folly rang
Opposite the sanctuary.

34 And they all, looking to the free
Sky, blessed YHWH who had shown
himself,

Saying, "Blessed is He who has kept
His own place undefiled and swept."

35 And he hung Nicanor's head from
The citadel, a clear sign come
To every one of help from YHWH.

36 And they all decreed by vote true
Never to forget of this day,
But celebrate the thirteenth day
Of the twelfth month, which in its way
Is called Adar in Syrian tongue,
The day before Mordecai's sung.

37 This, then, is how matters turned out
With Nicanor. And from that rout
The city has been in the hands
Of the Hebrews. So my tale stands.

This brings us to the end of trials seen

Among the heathen for the Jewish screen,
And how the Jews made out to gain their
land,
And town and temple to keep Your
command.

It is a good place to end any book
On positive in every way You look.
Yet in the centuries since then I trow
Greater atrocities come anyhow.
There is no ever after happily,
But only more of the same in the spree.
And so I turn a Maccabean prayer
To You, Beloved, who rule earth
everywhere,
That all men might live in peace and come
to
Keep Your commandments and worship
just You.

38 If it is well told to the point,
That is what I wished to anoint,
If it is poorly done or fair,
It was the best I could prepare.
39 For just as it's harmful to drink
Grape juice alone, or, on the brink,
Water alone, while grape juice mixed
With water's sweet and good when fixed,
So also the style of the tale
Delights the ears and without fail
Of those who read the work. And here
Will be the end of *smile and tear*.

The writer of the Maccabees is not
The first to wonder at wording and plot.
I too think of the choice of word and feel
And rhythm and a rhyme in hand and heel.
I mix a bit of figure and word poised
Originally above all the noised,
As heady wine, but balance it as well
With clichés chosen from my deep inkwell.
So my Beloved, I answer to Your tune,
And bow to You at morning, night and
noon,
And pray my tinkling rhymes lead none to
sin,
Neither the stranger nor my dearest kin.
Let help and hope destroy the wayward
way
That speaks and writes and acts against
Your sway.

Job

The book of Job is traditionally thought to have been written by Moses, but scholars tend to place it at a much later date by authors unknown. There is disagreement about the integrity of the book as well, and it may be a compilation from several sources. Its canonicity is universally recognized, however.

The more burning question is the placement of the book, between the Maccabees and before the volume of poetry and wisdom literature to follow. In fact, the book of Job addresses an issue that was central to the books of Maccabees, the issue of divine punishment and reward. In the Maccabees, courage is taken from the belief that suffering is always punishment from God. When it is applied to His own people, it is limited and results in repentance and reformation. When it is applied to the Gentiles, it results in doom. Therefore, the faithful Jews in the Maccabees are able to look beyond torture and death to a coming reward in the resurrection.

This view of reality permits the appearance of another scenario, precisely that of Job. How does one relate to suffering when there is no preceeding sin to require punishment? The comforters of Job suggest that the answer lies in secret sin, and they demand that Job confess in order to end his suffering and receive the renewed approbation of God. Job stubbornly clings to his innocence defined as his action in accordance with divine law. Whilst the book does not answer the question posed by innocent suffering, and no doubt any philosophical answer would be preposterous in that it would attempt to explain the unexplainable, the book does justify Job's viewpoint. Suffering itself is not evidence of sinfulness. Knowledge of specific acts of transgression can be the only basis of judgement. That central idea is abundantly confirmed in the book of Job. The book of Job is a necessary sequel to the Maccabees. It cannot be understood outside the context of the Maccabees (as the entire history of Christian theology and exegesis so abundantly testifies).

By the same token, Job, as a descendant of Esau, is one of the few figures in the Bible whose sinlessness is maintained with absolute force. The book thus expands the narrow view of the Maccabees, which combines the faithfulness to God's law with being a part of the chosen people, to the universalist principle that God does not regard station and ancestry, but only faithfulness to His law. How much sorrow, bloodshed, and agony in this world might have been avoided had that one principle been kept clearly in mind! Instead we are faced with the domination of the religion of Job's comforters: only believe in Jesus, who bears the just punishment of God (as did Job) on behalf of all, and all sinfulness inherent in the human condition is repealed and forgiven, and humankind is free to live by the law of the jungle and pretend to call it right and just.

The epithet for God that is commonly used in this book is aleph-lamed-he pointed by the Masoretes as Eloah. Since the letters are precisely the same as those used in Arabic for Allah, I have preserved that English form. The view that Allah is an Arab moon god is fallacious. The forms in the book of Job are otherwise influenced by Arabic or Aramaic, and it is only proper to realize that Allah, Alah, and Eloah are all cognates and the same divine name.

Job 1

1 There was a man in land of Uz,
Whose name was Job, and that man was
Perfect and upright, one who feared
God, shunned evil *when it appeared*.
2 And seven sons and three daughters
Were born to him. 3 Also, his *purse*,
Possessions were seven thousand sheep,
Three thousand camels, and *to reap*
Five hundred yoke of oxen, five
Hundred female donkeys *alive*,
And a very large household, so
This man was greatest *in the show*
Of all the people of the East,
Respected by both great and least.

So few are in the book of revelation

Proclaimed both perfect and without
probation.

Upright and perfect was the good man Job
And rich as well, in livestock, tent and
robe.

With seven sons and daughters and to spare
He was a man respected everywhere.

Those shunning evil in this time and place
Are rather kicked in shin and slapped in
face,

So much the world has gone apace in doing
The evil for the good and widely wooing
The false for true. Now such a one would
be,

Instead of greatest, least upon the tree.

Ah, let me not with longing look to Uz

As though the best is always what once
was.

4 And his sons would go to their feast

In their houses, from great to least

Each on his day, and would send to

Invite their three sisters *and crew*

To eat and drink with them. 5 And so,

When the days of feasting would go,

Job sent and sanctified them, and

He rose early at dawn to *stand*

And offer holocausts for all

According to number *and call*.

For Job said, "It may be that my

Sons have sinned and cursed on the sly

Alohim." So did Job's command.

With seven sons, each on the day

appointed,

To hold a feast of memory to the Lord,

The week goes by in honour of the

Anointed.

Divine the sceptre and divine the sword

That sends and sanctifies the holy feast.

God bless them all from greatest to the
least.

Beloved, I love the vision of the man

Job who in all his wealth from Ramadhan

To Ramadhan remembered to give gifts

To You. The memory's bright scene

uplifts.

And when the holy Sabbath morning broke,

The gallows saw strewn on them things that
spoke

Of piety and low submission to

The whirling days and nights walking with
You.

6 On a day sons of Alohim [angelic beings]
Came to present themselves *in stream*
Before YHWH, and Satan also
Came among them *to make a show*.

7 And YHWH said to Satan, "From where
Do you come?" So Satan *took care*
To answer YHWH and said, "From going
To and fro on the earth, and *slowing*
From walking back and forth on it."

8 YHWH told Satan, "Have you found fit
My servant Job, that *there is* none
Like him on earth under the sun,
A blameless and upright man, one
To fear Alohim, evil shun?"

9 So Satan answered YHWH and said,
"Does Job fear Alohim for dread?"

10 "Have You not made a hedge around
Him, around his household, and bound
All that he has on every side?
You've blessed his hands' work *to abide*,
And his possessions have increased
In the land *and have never ceased*.

11 "But now, stretch out Your hand and
touch

All that he has, and *after such*
He'll surely curse You to Your face!"

12 And YHWH said to Satan, "I place
All that he has within your power,
Only don't lay hand on his *flower*."
So Satan went out from the place
Where all stood up before YHWH's face.

The angels all come at the new moon to
Report their lovely tidings there to You
Upon the throne above the universe.
Some tell the good and some tell of the
worse.

Accuser there may be among them still
Who says I whirl and cantillate to fill
The gullet with good things. He must be
wrong,

For You, Beloved, repeat creation's song
Upon the just and on the unjust too.
This life rewards no men for what they do,
But only shows both good and bad when
done

By You or by Your one rebellious son.
Bless me or not, surround me with a hedge,
I whirl in tears or joy up to the edge.

13 Now there was a day when his sons
And daughters *were* eating their buns
And drinking grape juice in their oldest
Brother's house, 14 and messenger *boldest*
Came to Job and said "Oxen were
Plowing and the donkeys *confer*
Feeding beside them, 15 "when there came
The Sabeans to raid *in blame*
And took them all away, indeed
They've killed the servants with the speed
Of sword, and I alone escaped
To tell you *all about the scraped!*"

16 While he was still speaking, another
Also came and said *like the brother*,
"A great fire fell down from the sky
And burned up the sheep, *who knows why*,
And the servants, and consumed them,
And I alone escaped the hem
To tell you!" 17 While he was still
speaking,

Another also came and *sneaking*
Said "The Chaldeans formed three bands,
Raided the camels *on the sands*
And took them away, yes, and killed
The servants with mouth of sword *filled*,
And I alone escaped to tell!"

18 While he was still speaking *the spell*,
Another also came to tell,
"Your sons and daughters *were* eating
And drinking grape juice *in a fling*
In their oldest brother's house, 19 "and
Suddenly a great wind *and sand*
Came from across the wilderness
And struck the four corners' address
Of the house, and it fell upon
The young people, and they are gone,
And only I escaped distress!"

My worldly wealth is just a shadow and
The raucous, quavering tune of passing
band.

The gathering to eat and drink in praise
Of Your name, my Beloved, on all the days
Of every week draws on the jealous eye
Of men and even angels in the sky.
I cantillate and whirl knowing full well
That death awaits the faithful at the bell.
This world is gallows, place of sacrifice,
From day of birth, let no man linger twice.
This time perhaps I too escape to say
Sabeans fell upon the good today.

Tomorrow I shall give my head in ransom,
No help that I may be both rich and
handsome.

20 Then Job arose, and tore his robe,
And shaved his head *off like a globe*,
And fell to the ground in prostration.
21 And he said "Naked in my rasion
I came from my mother's womb, and
Naked shall I return to stand.
YHWH gave, and YHWH's taken away,
Blessed be the name of YHWH, hooray!"
22 In all this Job did not sin nor
Charge Alohim wrong at the door.

Who ask what was the meaning of this act
Of God, catastrophe or plague in fact
Charge You, Beloved, with perpetrating
wrong.

A pious face will not change tune or song.
Find purpose in the evil thing is to
Charge You, Beloved, with evil. That is
true.

The role of man and me in this wide world
Is not to find out why the flag's unfurled
In violence and hopeless ravaging.
Such come not from Your heart, but from
the king.

The role of man and me is nakedness
Upon the gallows floor, except the dress
Of blessing Your name in both word and
deed.

I have no other joy nor other need.

Job 2

1 Again there was a day the sons
Of Alohim came *in their tons*
To present themselves before YHWH,
And Satan came among them too
To present himself before YHWH.
2 And YHWH said to Satan, "From where
Do you come?" So Satan *with care*
Answered YHWH and said, "From going
To and fro on the earth *to sing*,
And walking back and forth on it."
3 Then YHWH said to Satan *alit*,
"Have you noticed My servant Job,
That *there is none like him in robe*
Upon the earth, a blameless and
An upright man, who *heart and hand*
Fears Alohim and cannot stand
Evil? And still he holds fast to

His righteousness, despite when you
Incited Me against him, to
Destroy him without cause *or due*."
4 So Satan answered YHWH and said,
"Skin for skin! Yes, all a man's led
He will give for his life. 5 "But stretch
Out Your hand now, give bone a fetch
And touch his flesh, and he will curse
You surely to Your face *or worse!*"
6 And YHWH said to Satan, "Behold,
He's in your hand, but spare him cold."

Beloved, I may be in the hand of tyrant
Who fails not to oppress worthy aspirant
To Your law and Your favour. I do not
Beg You to better one poor dervish lot.
Instead I ask that tyranny not be
So prevalent that such is all I see
And thus become participant in it
For blindness to the good. The better fit
Of clothes of light I would prefer to
woollen,
And new potatoes, corn and beans to
bullion.

Let me rejoice in visions of tomato
And leave the rubies hidden in their grotto.
Then spare or not my life, but let me know
That You are present in the path I go.

7 So went Satan out from the sight
Of YHWH and struck Job with the might
Of boils from the sole of his foot
To the place where the crown is put.
8 And he took a potsherd to scrape
Himself with it, and sat *agape*
Among the ashes *in such shape*.
9 Then said his wife to him, "Do you
Still keep your integrity due?
Saying 'See I shall wait a while,
Expecting my salvation's smile?'
See, your memory is blotted out
From earth, both daughters and sons stout,
The pangs and pains my womb in vain
Bore in sorrows and without gain,
And you yourself sit down to spend
The nights under the sky to fend
Corruption of the worms you tend,
While I wander from place to place
A servant in each house disgrace,
Waiting for the sun to go down
That I may rest from labour's frown
And the pains that beset my view:

Curse God and die *there in your pew.*”

10 But he told her, “You speak as one
Of the foolish women undone.
Shall we surely take of the good
That Alohim gives, and so should
We not accept adversity?”
No sin was in Job’s lip’s decree.

I too might curse, Belovèd, if I knew
Which is the blessing and which is the true
And which the curse. The limits on my
vision

Teach me to circumspection in decision.
The pain and pleasure principle may be
A rule of thumb, experience, though, can
see

That oftentimes the twisting rope of senses
Is product of an ailing paunch or menses.
The blessing is the blessing of Your law,
In pain or pleasure, there I stand in awe.
I scrape my boils and eat my cakes of
ashes.

I dream I take from You, despite the
sashes,

Celestial windows’ goods unmixed with ill,
The honeyed cake and healing bitter pill.

11 Now when Job’s three friends heard the
tale

Of evil that came without fail
On him, they came each one from home,
Eliphaz the Temanite gnome,
And Bildad the Shuhite, Zophar
The Naamathite, they all came far
In rendez-vous to mourn with him
As well as come to comfort him.

12 And when they lifted up their eyes
Far off, they did not recognize
Him, and they raised their voice and wept,
And they each one tore his cape *kept*,
And scattered dust upon their heads
Toward the sky *that upward spreads*.

13 So they sat down with him upon
The ground for seven days from dawn
And seven nights, and not one spoke
A word to him, they saw the stroke
Of grief was very great *like oak*.

I have no friend as good as those of Job.
None weep at my disaster, tear the robe,
Nor put dust on their heads. Perhaps the
times

And mores go far to mitigate my crimes.
I doubt that I could take such friend so long
As seven days, so You do me no wrong,
Belovèd, that You have made my friends
be few

And far behind the things the wicked do,
And reticent to show me their emotion.
But my friends also have this common
notion

That losses are an opportunity
To gloat and see if anything’s for free.
As one is, so one’s friends, Belovèd, I take
You only for my friend, forget the wake.

Job 3

1 After this opened Job his mouth,
And cursed his day *from north to south*.

2 So spoke Job and also he said

3 “Let the day perish I was led
To be born, and the night when said
‘There is a man child conceived here.’

4 “Let that day be darkness *and fear*,
Let not Allah standing above
Regard it *in eternal love*,

Nor let shine on it light of day.

5 “Let darkness and death’s shadow take
It for their own, let a cloud’s wake
Stay on it, but let blackness rake.

6 “As for that night let darkness seize
It, let it not be joined to frieze
Of the year’s days, let it not come
To be numbered of the months’ sum.

7 “See, let that night be desolate,
Let no joyful voice be its mate.

8 “Let them curse it that curse the day
Ready to rise in mourning’s sway
Against leviathan *to play*.

9 “Let the obscure stars of it fail,
Let it seek light to no avail,
Nor find the morning eyelids *pale*,

10 “Because it did not shut the doors
Of my matrix, and kept the stores
Of sorrow that my eye *implores*.

The longest day of the year was the day
That Job was born, and so to curse the grey
Of that twilight that night and day are not
Counted among the years along their plot,
But every year is just the round that’s made
By the three hundred sixty-four that stayed
In Jubilees, the calendar for spite

That counts the Sabbath years and counts
them right.

For this, Beloved, there comes a fatal
spring

When for a week my spirit takes not wing
But mourns the sorrow of Job and his wife
And turns away for Scriptures' joys and
strife.

Beloved, when I sit for the troubled week,
It's still Your face I turn and turn to seek.

11 "Why did I not die at the womb?
Nor at my birth meet once my doom?

12 "Why did the lap give me a place,
Why did the breasts give me their grace?

13 "Then I should have lain at my rest
And in silence slept on earth's breast,

14 "With kings and counsellors of earth
Who built tombs for themselves of worth,

15 "Or with princes with gold in hand
Filling with silver house *and land*.

16 "Or once aborted I had been
As infants seeing light nor *sin*.

17 "In that place the wicked cease care,
And the weary make rest their share.

18 "The prisoners together rest,
They hear no voice that once oppressed.

19 "The small and great equally lie
Where servant's free from master's eye.

Beloved, if all are equal in the grave,
Both king and master and the poor and
slave,

What difference can monument then bring?

The only memory's to hear one sing
The blessing of Your name upon the wing
Of cantillation of the Scriptures' word
By which all things in sky and earth
occurred.

Beloved, if all are equal in the tomb,
I take advantage of my breath and room
To praise Your name and thank You for the
share

I have in living misery and care
As well as joy and beauty in the air
And meadow by the forest where I live.
Beloved, I praise You while You take and
give.

20 Why is light given to one who sits
In misery, and life that fits
The bitter soul 21 who longs for death

That does not come to take his breath,
And digs for it more than the one
Who seeks out hidden treasures' run,
22 Who rejoices exceeding glad
To find a grave that may be had,
23 To a man whose path's hidden night
And whom Allah binds from His sight?
24 My sighing comes before I eat,
My screaming pours like waters meet.
25 For what I feared most fell on me,
And the most frightful comes to be.
26 I was not in security,
I had no rest nor quiet place,
And yet trouble's before my face.

The human cry of grand despair comes
only
When righteous ones in righteousness feel
lonely.

They only see futility of princes'
Amassing gold before which the soul
winces.

The small and great go to the grave with
care

With or without the silver chain and hair.
The golden flesh of gods adds not a day
To human life, nor does the silver stay
The plague, the weakness of the hand and
eye.

To long for death belongs to any guy
No matter whether purse is empty or
Filled with the treasures of a great king's
store.

I'm satisfied with mornings dark and few
As long as though unseen they're spent
with You.

Job 4

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite
Answered saying what he thought right.

2 Shall we try a word to you now,
You are grievously tried *somehow*?
But who can keep from speaking up?

3 See, you have taught many and you
Have strengthened weak hands *not a few*.
4 Your words have upheld fainting ones,
And you have strengthened knees *and*
buns.

5 But now that it falls on your head,
You faint. It touches your vast spread
And you are troubled *and unfed*.

6 Your fear *became* your confidence,

Your hope your uprightness' *defence*.

7 Remember now whoever failed
When he was innocent and veiled?
Or where were righteous ones cut off?
8 Even as I have seen them scuff,
Who plough iniquity and sow
Wickedness reap the evil show.

The task in ancient times was not complaint
That evil in the world proves God is faint.
The atheistic view parochial today
Was not the song they used to sing or lay.
In those days evil was the proof exact
That God was punishing the wicked act,
And every man that suffered on the shore
Was known to be a sinner what is more.
Beloved, I doubt both atheist and fraud
Of the sweet Christian in the way she
clawed.

The evil that I see proves not that You
Do not exist, nor that the suffering's due
To punishment that You dish out with
brew.

I am agnostic of both to the core.

9 By Allah's blast they fall down dead,
Consumed by His nostrils' breath spread.

10 The lion's roar, fierce lion's voice,
Young lions' teeth are cracked *by choice*.

11 The lion though strong falls in death
For lack of prey, and at a breath
The stout lion's cups scatter wide.

12 A word was secretly brought me,
My ear received a little fee.

13 In thoughts from visions of the night,
When deep sleep falls upon men's plight,

14 Fear came upon me, trembling so
It made all my bones shake and go.

15 A spirit passed before my face,
My body hair stood up in place.

16 It stopped, but I could see no form,
An image by my eyes did swarm
Till in the silence I heard sound.

The shudder of the spirit wind where fails
The breeze and damps beyond where
human quails

Is taken as full proof that what is heard
Is prophecy more stout than omen bird.
When leaves rustle without the breath of
wind

The soul forgets the gory way she sinned

And takes the motion for a sign that truth
Is cheap enough for every dangling youth.
The image in the eye is truer thought
That what can be measured and sold and
bought,

And overcomes the scruple of good sense
And reason and morality in fence.
Beloved, I trash the vision and the groan
And trust in You, You only and alone.

17 Shall mortal man's justice aground
Be greater than that of Allah?

Shall man be more pure in his paw
Than his own maker *at the draw*?

18 See, He lay no confidence in
His servants, and His angels' *kin*
He charged with foolishness *in bin*.

19 How much less then in those who dwell
In clay houses, in dusty cell,

Crushed by the moth *in flight a spell*?

20 They are destroyed from morn till night,
They perish ever without sight.

21 Does not their very beauty fail?
They die, no wisdom to avail.

The revelation of cause and effect
Makes men arise and bow down with
respect

For such great knowledge of the universe,
That all things happen for their own true
reasons,

And all inexorably in their seasons,
Go on set course for better or for worse.

The human mind shies from catastrophe
And in its face denies what eye must see.

His reasons he supports with idle dreams
Decked out in occult revelations' beams.
To deny what each man knows in his skin
And flesh, a thousand well-shod prophets
sin.

Beloved, I know that pain may come
though all

A man has done has been Your beck and
call.

Job 5

1 Call now if any answer you,
To which holy ones turn to view?

2 Anger indeed kills foolish men,
And envy slays slight ones again.

3 I've seen the foolish taking root,
And cursed the planting of his foot.

4 Let his children be far from fare,
 Crushed in the gate when none is there
 To save them from the grinding snare,
 5 Whose harvest hungry teeth consume,
 And even spoiling the thorn's room,
 Robber to swallow their wealth's bloom.
 6 Although affliction does not come
 Out of the dust nor trouble's sum
 Out of the ground, 7 still man is born
 To trouble like vultures forlorn
 Send their young upward *in the morn*.

The human flight afflicted is secure
 Despite the rates of comfort that inure
 The mind and heart to every daunting woe.
 Death is the end of every road men go.
 The ride of life is in a hearse and all
 The laughter and the merriment in call
 Do naught but shorten that brief journey till
 The final rest is found in dale or hill.
 Beloved, I seek my rest today in You
 And with each breath that may be last in
 view
 I whisper Your name and taste on my
 tongue
 The sweetness in age of the being young.
 Beloved, I seek my final rest again
 In You alone and in no hope of men.

8 So I would flee to El God, to
 El God would I commit my due,
 9 Who does great things untraceable,
 And marvels without number full,
 10 Who grants the rain upon the earth,
 And sends water on fields from dearth,
 11 To set on high those that are low,
 So those who mourn may not be slow
 To rise and sit in safety's glow.
 12 He brings to naught the plans of men
 Cunning, so that their hands again
 Cannot perform their enterprise.
 13 He takes the wise in their own craft,
 On wicked counsel He has laughed.
 14 They find the darkness in the day,
 And grope at noon as in night's sway.

The plans of men are cut in grief just when
 The least expected, all hopes die again.
 The sunlight is a traitor with the store
 Of hope and love and laughter at the door.
 In youth I planned a life set to the full
 Of work and happiness and miracle.

I look back on three-quarters of my fate
 (If I am blessed to have the average rate)
 And see the barren just beginnings of
 The things I thought in store in gift and
 love.

A few books written, hardly any wine,
 The most of fruit now shrivelled on the
 vine,

I find the end is looming while the start
 Was never started from my hopeful heart.

15 But He saves the poor from the sword
 Of their mouth and is oft implored
 From the power of the mighty gored.
 16 The poor has hope and so the weak,
 But the unjust mouth's stopped for cheek.
 17 See, blessed is the man Allah shows
 Correction, so despise no blows
 Of the Almighty *where He chose*.
 18 As He wounds so He shall bind up,
 The hand that strikes shall heal *the cup*.
 19 He shall deliver you in time
 Of six troubles, the seventh crime
 Shall not touch you *with harm or rhyme*.
 20 In famine He'll redeem from death,
 In battle from sword's power and breath.
 21 You shall be hidden from tongue's
 whip,
 Nor shall you fear destruction's hip.

Eliphaz as proponent of the pox
 That every case of suffering in the flocks
 Is punishment and due from You above
 Presents his case as filled with divine love
 For the poor and afflicted by the host
 Of powerful and great who have a boast.
 The punishment is just correction that
 The God of justice metes out to the flat
 Who fail to live according to the rule
 That was imposed by common consent's
 school.

Beloved, I do not question punishment,
 Nor fate of any kind, but I relent
 To rejoice in the pleasure that I know
 In judgement of my enemy and foe.

22 At plague and famine you shall laugh,
 Nor be afraid of beastly gaff.
 23 The very stones of the field make
 A covenant and for your sake,
 The beasts of the field shall make peace
 With you *and give safety's release*.

24 And you shall know your tent in peace,
 And find your dwelling place release,
 And not sin *more in the increase*.
 25 You shall know also that your seed
 Will be great and your offspring's *feed*
 Shall be as the earth's grass *in speed*.
 26 You'll come in full age to the grave
 Like a grainsheaf in time to save.
 27 See this, we've searched it, so it is.
 Hear it and know for your good's fizz.

Theology that says You consecrate
 The righteous to be wealthy in Your state
 And laugh at the plagues that do not come
 near
 Their door is something I still find round
 here.
 The very stones of the field are the friends
 Of those who never need to make amends,
 And those who succeed in their
 exploitation
 Can be sure of their children's blessed
 ration.
 Beloved, I ask no fame nor power nor
 wealth
 Be given to my children for their stealth,
 But only that they live from day to day
 Within the brightness of divine law's sway.
 And for myself I ask no greater gift
 Than that I too be found in the same shrift.

Job 6

1 Then Job gave answer, and he said
 2 Oh that my grief were rightly spread,
 And my calamity laid bare
 In balances together *there!*
 3 It would be heavier than the sand
 Upon the seashore, *by the land*,
 That's why my words appear unscanned.
 4 The arrows of Shaddai in me
 Poison my dried up spirit *free*,
 The terrors of Allah are set
 Arrayed around me *and are met*.
 5 Does the wild ass bray when he's fed
 With grass, or does the ox with dread
 Low while before him fodder's spread?
 6 Can tasteless food without salt please?
 Or is there taste in egg white *cheese?*
 7 The things my soul refused to touch
 Are as my food in grief *as much*.

It is the common lot of men to bray

After the pain and sorrow of the day,
 And for the victim of deceit and fraud
 To be despised and condemned by the
 pawed.

The justice humans feel is for the one
 Who wins the day when everything is done,
 And counts the ones he tramples underfoot
 Deserving of the pain to which they're put.
 Beloved, tell me You take another view,
 Since You are just and good in Your own
 pew.

Tell me that You despise reality,
 Not that You are the owner of the fee.
 Then I like all men shall not turn my eyes
 Away to choose religion for a prize.

8 Oh that I might have my request;
 And that Allah grant *me, a pest*,
 The thing that I long for as best!
 9 Even that it would please Allah
 To destroy me; that He'd loose claw
 Against me and cut off *my straw*.
 10 Then I should still have comfort, aye,
 And harden myself at the sty
 Of sorrow. So let Him not spare,
 For I shall not deny the share
 Of the Holy One's words *laid bare*.
 11 What is my strength, that I should hope?
 And what *is* my end on the rope,
 That I should lengthen my life's *grope?*
 12 *Is* my strength as the strength of stones?
 Or *is* my flesh of brass *and bones?*
 13 Have I not trusted in His aid
 While wisdom's driven from my grade?
 14 To the afflicted let friend show
 Pity, but instead on the go
 He forsakes the fear of Shaddai.

Maybe Job suffers since he stands to pray
 To Allah in the hope of life and stay.
 The sweet Christians I know think Allah's
 breed

Is just another name for the moon's seed.
 So much for ignorance in Christian pew.
 Such people know nothing at all of You,
 Beloved, the God of Abraham and true,
 Of Jesus and the Bible in the stew.
 Beloved, I feel for Job, I've seen his cave
 And wondered at the light and smallness
 grave
 That was his lot despite his wealth and
 power.

I've sat with Job and talked about his hour,
And made suggestion that Islamic ways
Are in Your patience to seek out Your
praise.

15 My very brothers now treat me
With deceit as a stream to be
Flowing with the current away.
16 They look black because of ice sway,
Snow falls on them and melts away.
17 When they have heat they disappear,
When it is hot, they're consumed here.
18 The paths of their steps turn aside,
They go to nothing to abide.
19 The pathways of Tema look on,
The ways of Sheba wait for dawn.
20 They were confounded in their hope,
They came but then they could not cope.
21 You have no pride or strength at all
Who fear when you see that I fall.

Ha! My brothers also treat me with fleece!
There's no church I can enter and with
peace,
And synagogues are founded for the toil
Of Jewish wights who do not want my
spoil.

Samaritan will take no convert near,
And Muslims try to pull me by the ear.
I understand Job's plaint for treachery,
I've heard his comforters alive and free
Present their case before my ear and eye
To say that You are one of three nearby,
Or treasure of the few who hold the bill,
And measure out forgiveness to the nill,
Who accept baptisms by Trinity,
Or bow to Mecca trying to be free.

22 Did I request you bring me gifts,
Or ask for a reward that lifts?
23 Or that you should deliver me
From my foes and the enemy,
Rescue me from power of mighty?
24 Teach me, and I will hold my tongue,
Make me see how I've sinned and sung.
25 How right words carry lots of weight,
But what's your wrangling in rebate?
26 You make speeches just for reproof,
In desperation and in spoof.
27 You overwhelm the orphan and
You betray your own friends in band.

28 Since you've accomplished your task
see
If there is some deceit in me.
29 Reply, I pray without deceit,
Judge now in a righteous retreat.
30 Is there wickedness in my tongue?
I can taste when the evil's stung.

There's no reply from those who rule the
state
And prance about the altar with the mate
In fancy robes with crosier held in hand,
All purpled up and crimsoned in the band.
There's no reply when any man asks why
He is forlorn beneath a barren sky,
Except that You bless those who do the
right,
And those who suffer, suffer in Your sight.
Beloved, the modern man asks other things.
He wonders why evil at all in springs
Is cast on earth, since You are one born
good.
I spit on philosophy's questionings,
And scorn the atheist's doubts of Your
rings.
I think I in justice do as I should.

Job 7

1 Is there not an appointed time
For man to live in the earth's clime,
And his days also like the days
Of one hired by the hour for pays?
2 Just as a servant greatly looks
For the *sundial's* shade *in its nooks*
And as a hired man hopes to gain
His salary after the pain,
3 So I follow my months in vain
And bear the nights where I have lain.
4 I lie down saying "I wish night
Were gone and I might see the light"
And then I toss and turn until
The dawning of day *on the hill*.
5 My flesh is decked in worms and dust,
My skin once healed breaks out and
pusse,
6 My days more swiftly than the shuttle
Of a weaver fly in rebuttal,
And without hope for all the strife.
7 O remember now that my life
Is only breath, my eye shall see
No more good *in haven or lea*.

The argument that all men die on earth
And therefore suffering does not show the
death

Of man's obedience to Your law is one
That satisfies my questions when I'm done.
To suffer does not prove a man has sinned,
Since all die appointed to dust and binned.
Besides that, days of life fly quickly past,
And no joy here is entertained to last.

The righteous as well as the sinners cast
About for one more glass of wine and yet
Another laugh before the sail is set.

One tide takes all down to the grave, both
those

Who keep Your law as well as cads who
chose

To drink upon the brink and thus to doze.

8 The eye that sees me shall lose sight,
Your eyes lie on me, I'm requite.

9 The cloud is dissipated and
Who enters grave no more shall stand.

10 He shall not return to his house,
None shall know him there, no, nor spouse.

11 Therefore I'll not refrain my mouth,
I'll speak in spirit's anguish south
And north I shall complain in toll
Of bitterness upon my soul.

12 Am I a sea or whale that you
Set a guard upon me to view?

13 When I say "My bed shall ease me,
My couch comfort complaint *I see*,"

14 You frighten me with dreams and yet
In terror I see visions set.

From the creation to this very time
Your sight alone creates or weighs the
crime,

Your breath makes the soul come to life
until

You breathe it out again in nothing's till.
With all the power You give me and the
right

I make complaint about the day and night.
Wherever I turn in my prayer from sight
Of You, I find You guarding me for spite.

I sleep, yes, but I dream, and none can
know

If dreams still frighten beyond deathly
show.

I ease myself by my complaint abroad
And teach my lips to tremble on the sod.

Beloved, though I turn from Your blazing
hand,

I turn to turn to You and Your command.

15 My soul chooses strangling and death,
Rather than life *and to have breath*.

I loath life, I would never take
On me immortality's lake,
Leave me alone, for my days quake.

17 What's man, that You should honour
him?

That You should set hope on the dim?

18 That You should find him there each
morn,

And try him each moment since born?

19 How long will You not leave me now,
Let me alone till I somehow
Swallow my spittle *in the trough*?

20 I've sinned, what shall I do for You,
O You preserver of men's crew?

Why have You set me as a mark
Against You, weighed down in the dark?

21 Why don't You pardon me my sin,
And take away by wicked bin?

For now shall I sleep in the dust,
And You shall seek me in the trust
Of morning, and I'll be but rust.

The suffering of humankind is great,
It's infinite in one brief moment's state,
And in the quiver that lets the mind go
Into the darkness of oblivion's show.

You bloat, Beloved, that You can suffer
one

Without the limitations of the dawn,
In infinite time and outside of time,
In places human beings never climb.

Beloved, the human heart is greater than
Your heart, because it's given that we can
Suffer eternity in time's brief share
While You must have all years in which to
bear.

We can in just one moment take the weight
Of infinite in pain as well as hate.

Job 8

Then answered Bildad the Shuhite,
And said: How long will you incite
To speech? The words of your mouth reach
Like a strong wind *as if to preach*.

3 Does God make a wrong judgement, or
Does the Almighty fake the score?

4 If your children have come to sin
Against Him and He throws in bin
Those that transgress *by hand or shin*,
5 If you would seek El in between,
And El Shaddai for prayer on scene,
6 If you were pure and upright, now
Surely He would wake anyhow
For you, and make prosper your brow.
7 Though your beginning was small
fleece,
Your end would be greatly increased.

Bildad is wise to note that wealth and
riches
Raise the shaded soul out of strife and
ditches,
And that the man who lacks in well-set
stitches
Lacks also goodness for his gathered
fitches.
The pain is proof of unfoiled wickedness,
And God prospers every unsound address
That makes repentance and is daily pure.
If God does not reply, it's a thing sure
The man that prays today prays but in vain
Because that man deserved the punished
pain.
Today I see the tightened victim of
Crime is the guilty one to hit and shove
In every church and mosque and
synagogue,
Among the human trash, if not by dog.

8 Just take a look at former times,
See our ancestors in their crimes,
9 For we of yesterday know naught,
Our days on earth are shadow brought,
10 Shall they not teach you and reveal
The words that in their heart appeal?
11 Can water reeds grow without mire?
Can cattails prosper in the fire?
12 Whilst it is still green, not cut down,
It fades before the herb *in town*.
13 So are the paths of all forgetting
El in hypocrite's hope on-setting,
14 Whose hope shall be cut off, and whose
Trust in a spider's web accuse.

The great appeal to long statistics held
Above one's own experience that spelled
The faith and trust a soul may gain for fire
Is not an argument that fits desire.

Just because generations in the past
Both sinned and suffered consequence to
last,
Is not proof that my suffering here and now
Is punishment for secrets on my brow.
Beloved, I give the congregation met
Of Job's sweet friends and comforters the
set,
And take my way on Sabbath day to find
Retreat alone from those who blame the
blind.
Both dumb and blind I raise a Psalm in
praise
To You who bless the goings of my haze.

15 He shall lean on his house, and it
Shall not stand, he shall hold a bit,
But it shall not remain as fit.
16 He's green before the sun, his branch
Sprouts out in the fields of his ranch,
17 His roots are wrapped around the heap,
And finds the place a stony keep.
18 If He destroy him from his place,
Then He'll deny him in a trace,
Saying, I have not seen your face.
19 See this is the joy of His way,
Out of earth shall others give ray.
20 Behold, God will not cast aside
The perfect, neither will abide
The evil doer, *but deride*,
21 Till He fill your mouth with the share
Of laughter and your lips to bear
Rejoicing *for your lack of care*.
22 Those who hate you shall be ashamed,
The dwelling of wicked be blamed.

How true it is that You, Beloved, will not
Cast off the pure in heart, the righteous
plot!
But see here how fast human hearts can
take
The truth and bend it for the wicked sake.
That Your care does extend to righteous
men
Is not proof that those who suffer again
Are therefore not righteous in what they do,
Performing each command that's come
from You.
Beloved, I thank You for the providence
That fixes hope and health upon the fence
Of this world in precarious combat.

I thank You now, Beloved, for where
You're at.
But as I thank You, I hold that the pain
Of living in a dark world is not vain.

Job 9

1 Then Job replied and then Job said
2 I know the truth, but how can man
Be righteous with El *as by plan*
Set up in judgement in his stead?
3 If he will argue with Him, he
Cannot answer one in the fee
Of a thousand of inquiry.

When one man has a case to bring to fight
With neighbour be the matter wrong or
right,
The two can meet before the bench and bar
Of judgement and decide particular.
But when a man brings up a case in point
Against You, my Beloved, in joy or joint,
There is no courthouse to bring in relief,
The man just has to stand there in his grief.
So how can any other when he sees
The trouble and the sorrow without ease
Say that the first is guilty in the breeze,
Since no judge has passed verdict in assize?
Job's final argument is finely spun,
His living logic's logic when it's done.

4 He's wise in heart, mighty in strength,
Who's prospered against him at length?
5 He removes mountains, they know not,
Overturns them in wrath like pot.
6 He shakes the ear out of her place,
Her pillars tremble at His mace.
7 He commands the sun not to rise,
He seals away the stars in skies.
8 He only spreads the heavens out,
And treads upon the waterspout.
9 He makes Arcturus, Orion,
The Pleiades and stars that run
In chambers of the south begun.
10 He does great things past finding out,
Wonders indeed beyond the rout.
11 He goes past me, I see Him not,
He hovers too above my plot,
But I perceive no sight nor thought.
12 He grasps His prey with none to bar,
And who can ask Him where You are?
13 Allah does not withdraw His wrath,
The proud do not stoop to His path.

14 How much less shall I answer Him,
And choose out words both bright and dim?
15 Though I were righteous, I would not
Make a reply upon the spot,
But only supplication brought
To my Judge *and the One I sought*.

You and man are not equals at the bar
Of justice, one is higher than the star,
The other is a brother to the worm,
And there is nothing for a common term.
You fashion in Your hand the mighty
weight
Of star and sun and moon, and You relate
Narration of the quiet Universe,
While humankind lies under blast and curse
Of time and place and earthly limits too,
Beneath the seemly weight of his sins' due.
To be judged by his peers is human right,
But You are beyond the illumined light.
The distance twixt our form and humble
state
Means that the human being's always late.

16 If I had called and He replied,
I would not believe to confide.
17 For He breaks me with tempest weight
And gives me wounds in no caused rate.
18 He will not let me take a breath,
But fills with bitterness *like death*.
19 I speak of strength, and He is strong,
I speak of judgement, who takes prong
To set a time and place along?
20 Should I justify myself then
My own mouth will condemn again.
"I'm perfect" proves me but perverse.
21 I am perfect, I do not know
My own self, I despise the show.

There is no instance that can bring about
The justifying of Your storm and shout,
And before Your creating power and voice,
The human will to justify his choice
Is dumb. If ever man could raise a cry
In witness of his hue and alibi,
That fact itself would be his fair undoing,
The revelation of his misconstruing.
Beloved, though I be perfect in the way
I meet Your fair commandments' ray in
sway,
I am such only in the grace and power
Of Your sovereign hand to create an hour.

The shard has no rejoicing at the cord
And pattern devised by maker and lord.

22 One truth: and so I say the thing.
He destroys perfect on the wing
With the wicked and everything.
23 If scourge slay suddenly, He'll laugh
At the trial of innocent gaff.
24 The earth is given into the hand
Of the wicked, he covers stand
Of the judges of it, if not,
Then where and who is He in plot?

You laugh indeed, for nothing can touch
You
With any seed of destruction in view.
You have the right to return to the dust
The pot You make, and every such pot
must
In silence sits before the grinding wheel
And makes complaint beneath no step nor
heel.
And yet it seems to those whose eyes look
out

Upon the world in beauty and in rout,
That You have left the wicked line about
To cut the flesh and heart with blade of
steel.

Beloved, if this is not so, then I beg
To wonder why You do not show Your
leg?

The emptiness of Universe weighs hard
On human heart and eye, the flying card.

25 My days run now quicker that foot
Of a runner, to flight they're put
And no good enters in their wake.
26 They pass by like the ships at sea,
Like the eagle upon the wee.
27 If I say I'll forget complaint,
I'll leave of heaviness like saint,
28 I fear of all my griefs, I know
You'll not hold me unguilty row.
29 If I am wicked, why do I
Vainly clamour against the sky?
30 If I wash with water of snow,
And make my hands clean as to glow,
31 Still You will throw me in the ditch,
And my own garments will unstitch.
32 For He is not a man as I,
That I should answer in reply,
That we should confer on the bench.

33 Nor is there mediating hench
To lay his hand on both *to quench*.
34 Let Him remove His rod from me,
Let not His fear terrify me.
35 Then I would speak and not fear Him,
But it is not so with life dim.

It is an argument against the fail
Of accusation that Job's strong and hale
To rise in accusation of Your hand
Oppressing him despite his righteous stand.
If suffering is the evidence of wrong,
Then cannot protest against line and long
Be evidence in case of truth and will
To do and act out Your commandment
still?

The logic of Job's call is sweet to hear,
Despite the angry answers that appear,
Despite the arrogance of form and trace
The sweet Christian brings in instead of
grace.

Beloved, I see Your wisdom in the sound
A sound man makes upon the barren
ground.

Job 10

1 My soul is weary of my life,
I shall not leave complaint for strife,
I'll speak in my own bitterness,
As a man I can do no less.
2 I'll say to Allah, Don't condemn,
Show me wherefore Your stratagem.
3 Do You enjoy oppression's heel,
Despising Your own hand's appeal,
And favour wickedness at keel?
4 Do You have eyes of flesh, or see
As a man sees eternity?
5 Are Your days as the days of man?
Are Your years as man's life in span?
6 So You're so closely interested
In what small evil thing I did,
Minutely searching out my fault
Leaving me in the dark and fault?
7 You know I'm not a wicked man,
But none can save out of Your plan.

The welt experience of grief's despair
Implies, Beloved, that You take help in
care

To view the slightest rudeness in a man,
And find the fault as soon as e'er You can.
Job's trial seems to him beyond belief,

Beyond what's worthy of Your sight and
fief,
Who can hold up the universe in sway,
Why do You take the trouble in Your way
To punish man for what he himself finds
Not in the contemplation of his rinds?
Beloved, Your greatness would belie the
knife
That with such invective slices the life
Of Job, and if of Job, of everyone
Born on the brief sphere that Your hand has
spun.

8 Your hands have fashioned me alone
And yet You slay me *flesh and bone*.
9 Remember now You've made from clay,
And will You bring back to dust's way?
10 Have You not poured me out like milk,
And curdled me like cheese *for ilk*?
11 You've arrayed me in skin and flesh,
With bones and sinews me enmesh.
12 You've granted me both life and grace,
Preserving my spirit and place.
13 These things have You kept in Your
heart,
I know that this is in Your part.

The act of Your creation would presume
That You would take an interest in the
doom
That overtakes a being from Your hand,
So Job throws out this argument as
planned.
Why make an eye so marvellous to see,
To grate against the speck of dust to be
The medium of light and thought an hour,
Only to crush that eye within Your power
To very dust again, without excuse
Or without any inkling of its use?
I trow Job's argument is understood
By the divine mind that set forth its hood,
Or so Job says, when he claims he knows
what
Within You divine heart and spirit's shut.

14 If I sin, then You mark me out,
You'll not acquit me from my rout.
15 If I be wicked, woe is me,
If I be righteous, there's no fee
To lift my head from the world spree,
So You see my grief's great degree.
16 It just gets greater. You hunt me

Like a fierce lion, and again
You appear marvellous to men.
17 You bring new witnesses to me,
Increase Your wrath infinitely,
You bring pain on catastrophe.
18 Why did You bring me from the womb?
I wish I'd died and found the tomb.
19 I should have been as never born,
From womb to grave on the same morn.
20 Are not my days few? Give me peace
To take some comfort in release
21 Before I go and not return
To the land of darkness and *learn*
Death's shadow *there and not to spurn*.
22 A land of darkness, dark as dark,
Shadowed with death, assailed in park
Of chaos and lightning as stark.

The argument is sound by the gross hand
Of statistics and science in the land.
The fact is innocence and guilty rip
Have little effect on the mighty trip
Of humankind through suffering and
through pain.

If escape from our sorrows is the main
Reason for virtue, then our virtue's vain.
It matters little whether wrong or right,
The illness and the grief strike in one night
The wise and foolish in the divine sight.
Beloved, let Job's comforters answer such
Good arguments he brings for them to
touch,
And I will praise Your wisdom that the
sound
Of understanding once has hit the ground.

Job 11

1 Zophar the Naamathite replied,
2 Do not so many words require
And answer, should be justified
One with more talk than can abide?
3 Should your lies make men hold their
peace?
When you make mockery's increase
Shall no one make you blush for shame?
4 For you've said 'My doctrine is pure,
And I am clean in Your eyes sure.'
5 That Allah would speak up to hear,
And open His lips at your ear!
6 That He would show you wisdom's right
And multiply it in your sight!
Know that Allah lays punishment

On you less than transgression meant.
7 Can you by searching know Allah?
Can you examine to the craw
Almighty God we hold in awe?

Zophar's a sweet one like the Christian
mate
That usually comes to gloat with sugared
hate.

His first in argument is sheer insult,
The second is a misquote of the cult,
The third claims that poor Job in fact
deserves

A greater punishment for secret swerves,
The fourth claims that since God is infinite
Appeal to simple justice is not right.
Beloved, such nonsense still carries its
weight

Today among the Christian small and great.
Original sin demands death and so
What people suffer in revenge is slow.
You may be beyond thought and sight but
You

Must always be just and to Self be true.

8 As high as heaven, what can you do?
Deeper than hell, can you know true?

9 Its measure's longer than the earth,
And broader than the sea in worth.

10 If He cuts off or shuts in place,
Or gather together from trace
Who can hinder Him *from His grace?*

11 He knows vain men, He sees the heart
Of wickedness, He'll do His part.

12 Man is foolish but thinks he's wise,
Born a wild ass's colt for guise.

13 If you prepare your heart extending
Your hands toward Him not pretending,

14 If wickedness is in your hand,
Put it away from house and land,
And let no evil stay in band.

The three things Zophar tells the man to do,
Repent in heart, make supplication true,
And put away the evil deed from hand,
Are right and good, the only way to stand.
But each repentance must have focus made:
It must refer to the specific trade
In sin and the specific in transgression
Against Your law to make a right
confession.

Job simply can't confess a thing he's done

As long as he cannot remember sun
That rose upon commandment he ignored.
Today the sweet Christian and the adored
Can always find a reason to confess,
Since sin's defined by such vague terms'
address.

15 Then you'll lift face without a spot,
You'll be steadfast and not fear plot.

16 For you'll forget your misery,
Remembered like waters that flee.

17 Your life shall be clearer than day,
You'll shine out like the morning ray.

18 You will be safe, since there is hope,
You'll settle and rest in your scope.

19 You'll lie down and never have fear,
Others will come comfort to hear.

20 The eyes of sinners, they shall fail,
And they shall not escape the pale,
Their hope like giving up the ghost,
Gone down in silence from their boast.

The wicked Christian that calls to
repentance

Promises all sorts of things in the sentence
Of clear reprieve. He dotes on safety's
wheel

Because he has a company of steel
Supporting him against the man alone
That is the object of his vigil's drone.
I'd rather find a Christian with a deed
Of righteousness than always the same
speed,

Saying the crucifixion of a man
Is all a part of the great divine plan
To make all right that went wrong in the
way,

And gives the in-crowd licence for their
prey.

Beloved, I see there were such men around
Before the cross was raised above the
ground.

Job 12

1 And Job answered and came to say
2 Surely you're crown of humankind
And wisdom dies when you're aligned
In the tomb. 3 But I know a thing

As well as you, I'm no worse fling
Than you, indeed who does not know
The things that you propose to show?

4 I'm one mocked by his neighbour when

I call on Allah before men
And He gives no answer to me,
The just and upright comes to see
How he's laughed to scorn wickedly.
5 The one in trouble is a light
Despised by those resting in spite.

Job's words are highly unpolitical
When he points out he's just as good a pal
As those who come to give him their
advice

On how to act sweetly, Christlike and nice.
The fact that what he says is true just
makes

His saying so greater post for mistakes.
Though he is ridiculed in pecking order
His last sarcastic thrust on grateful hoarder
Will never be forgiven till the day
That You step in Yourself and take the
sway.

Beloved, I see the victim everywhere
Made guilty by the sacred, public stare,
While perpetrators get the laurels and
The glory of a blaring ghost bandstand.

6 The robbers' tents prevail, and those
Who provoke El are safe *in rows*,
Allah gives them all that they chose.

7 But ask the animals and they
Will teach you about the right way,
And the birds in the air will say.

8 Speak to the earth, and it will show,
The fish in the sea also know.

9 Who among all of these does not
Know that YHWH's hand all this has
wrought?

10 In His hand is each living thing,
The breath of humankind in sling.

11 Does not the ear understand words?
Does not the mouth taste meat *and curds*?

12 With the old ones is wisdom found,
Long years bring understanding's sound.

13 With him is wisdom and due strength,
Counsel and understanding's length.

14 What He breaks down is not rebuilt,
What He shuts up cannot be split.

Job says in fact that even pigs know well
That what you get is not the fair to tell.
Division of goods on the earth is not
In justice, but forever in the slot
Of law of jungle, the strong eat the weak

And people take of porkers with a squeak
And never stop to think that what you do
Does not get just reward among the few.
The argument will not sit very well
With those who think that You just cast a
spell

And every man gets by his own deserts
The grief and joy the universe asserts.
Beloved, I simply fail to find the thread
Of justice in the earthly share of bread.

15 He holds back waters, it is dry.
He sends them out, the world's thereby
Overrun with the flood. 16 With Him
Is strength and wisdom, the deceived
And deceiver are his relieved.

17 He spoils the counsellors in way,
He makes fools of judges in sway.

18 He unfastens the bands of kings,
He ties a cord about their rings.

19 He leads away captive the priests,
And overthrows the elite *feasts*.

20 He takes away the faithful speech,
And understanding from the reach
Of those grown old able to preach.

21 He pours contempt on government,
And weakens power of their chiefs bent.

I'm glad that Job, at least in time of grief,
Notes that the priest and ruler in their feoff
Are robbers and rough bandits despite glare
Of jewels and fashions and finely gelled
hair.

I'm glad that Job, when attacked to the
bone,

Sees through hypocrisy and walks alone.

I'm gladder still to know You're on his
side,

Even if You're no help against the tide
Of pain and grief he blunders round to
quell.

You are the staff and strength of Israel.
Beloved, what Job says must be true, I
throw,

As I look on the bench of justice now,
Neither thought of truth nor of justice there
Is found, merely the shop and metallad air.

22 He shows deep things from darkness'
store,
He brings light from death's shadowed
door.

23 He raises nations, turns them low,
 Enlarging them to make them slow.
 24 He removes wisdom from the chiefs
 Of earth's folk, and makes them *for griefs*
 Wander in wilderness away.
 25 They grope in darkness without light,
 He makes them stagger *in the night*
 Like drunken men *out for a fight*.

The reason presidents stumble in view
 Of kings and queens come to receive their
 due,
 Is not because You set a block before
 Their feet as soon as they come in the door.
 Job's wrong in that. At least today the
 reason
 Is simply that cheap alcohol's in season,
 And if it were not so, it would not matter,
 There's tax enough for everything to scatter
 And table lid and load with whiskey till
 The president and wife meet in the swill.
 Beloved, Job gives You credit out of turn,
 But in time even Job would come to learn
 That patience is a skill of those who fret
 For where tax euro, pound and dollar met.

Job 13

1 Indeed, my eye has seen it all,
 My ear has heard the sound and call.
 2 What you know is in my mind too,
 I'm not inferior to you.
 3 But I would speak to El-Shaddai,
 And reason with El is my cry.
 4 But you are forgers of lies, you
 Are all physicians with no clue.
 5 O shut your mouths and let that be
 Your wisdom's gauge and guarantee!
 6 Hear now my pleading argument
 And listen to what my lips sent.
 7 For El's sake you speak wickedly?
 For Him you talk deceitfully?

The lie is simply that poor Job has sinned,
 The evidence is taken from the wind.
 And yet it is a lie that's commonly
 On heart and tongue of rabble under tree.
 There is no man who does not judge his
 brother
 Of wickedness despite knowing another.
 Humankind cannot escape making such
 Judgements except by training mind to
 touch

No judgement except evidence that one
 Has transgressed the commandment under
 sun
 That's mentioned in the ten. All other
 things
 Are prejudices that work condemnings
 For deceit before God on every day.
 The commandments save the soul from
 such sway.

8 Will you accept His person fast?
 Will you contend for El at last?
 9 Is it good that He searches you,
 As one man ridicules a few
 Do you mock Him *without a clue*?
 10 He will certainly reprove you,
 If you in your heart make distinctions
 Of persons *based on your own pinctions*.
 11 Shall not His glory make you fear?
 Shall His dread not fall on you here?
 12 Your remembrances are like ashes,
 Your bodies like clay *in their sashes*.
 13 Be quiet and leave me alone
 To speak, come my way what's in stone.
 14 Why do I take my flesh in teeth,
 My life in my hand *like a wreath*?
 15 Though He kills me, still I'll trust Him,
 I'll keep to my own path not dim
 Before His face, *though it be grim*.

Job's friends are sure they know what's
 right as they
 Express the appeal of their inner way.
 So doing they judge both their God and
 men
 In wickedness always rising again.
 The duty of man is not to make clear
 Philosophy that he just might hold dear,
 But to follow the path of Decalogue
 As carefully as would a sniffing dog,
 And disregard the arguments of fate,
 The falling of the blade, grimace of hate.
 Though circumstance pile on the cruel
 weight,
 Job stubbornly refuses to let go
 Of his obedience to the ten in row.
 His argument is true, though friends are
 slow.

16 He also will save me for that,
 A hypocrite fails where He's at.
 17 Hear well my speech and what I say

And let your ears now not delay.
 18 See now, I bring myself to court,
 I know I'm right in my resort.
 19 Who brings a case against me now?
 If I am silent anyhow,
 I'll give up the ghost in *the row*.
 20 Just give me two advantages,
 And I'll not retreat from the biz.
 21 Relieve the pain a moment here,
 And hide Your glory from my fear.
 22 Then raise Your voice and I'll reply,
 Or let me speak so You can try.

The courtroom Job describes is never found
 On earth, each judge, I will be honour
 bound,

Lays fetters on the prisoner in pain,
 And keeps pretence of glory without
 shame.

The innocent and guilty, all the same,
 Are hedged in and intimidated where
 The judgement seat's established and laid
 bare.

Will You, Beloved, do less than humankind
 In Judgement, will You hide Your glory
 vined

So none shall be afraid, and will You heal
 The pain that erodes mind and what men
 feel?

I think not. My hope's not in such a bench,
 But in the fact Your justice comes to clench
 In mercy every sinful man and wench.

23 Count out transgressions I have made,
 Make me know clearly where I've strayed.

24 Why do You hide Your face from me
 And treat me like Your enemy?

25 Will You break a leaf blown about,
 And persecute stubble in rout?

26 You write against me bitter things,
 Trot out my youthful questionings.

27 You put my feet in the stocks too,
 Examine all my paths in view,
 And mark the heels of my feet too.

28 It rots and vanishes away,
 Like a moth-eaten coat *to stay*.

Instead of crowing claims without
 substance,

Guess-work and the opinions set to dance,
 Job asks for a clear catalogue in trace
 Of all the sins he's squandered in the place.

The innocence of Job is manifest,
 And few can make such claims before the
 test,

But even accusations of the guilty
 Are usually stated in form witty.

Beloved, I've been accused of many a
 crime,

But hardly ever of the things for dime
 I've truly done that miss the heavenly
 mark.

My real sins remain secrets in the dark
 From human eyes, and only You know
 truth.

Such are accusers in this world uncouth.

Job 14

1 Man born of woman's of few days,
 And full of trouble, *despite praise*.

2 He sprouts like a flower that's cut down,
 He flees a shadow *on the town*.

3 Do You have regard for such men,
 And so bring me to judgement's ken?

4 Who can bring cleanness from the soiled?
 No one *at all for having toiled*.

5 His days are set, the number of
 His months is given to You above,
 You've set the limits he'll not pass
To walk upon the earthly grass.

6 Turn from him, so that he may rest,
 Till he like workman do day's best.

Job wonders that the King of universe,
 The One who guides the stars in their
 converse,

Should so minutely take regard to man,
 That You should notice detail in his span
 For which to punish him with toil and boil.

Man is a mere breath whispering to soil.
 It is not possible in course of things
 That One so great as You in creations
 Could be so finely warped in judgement
 that

You damn a man for sins that he out flat
 Cannot perceive despite most careful coil
 Of introspection after earthly toil.
 There is no justice, if You require ends
 In things beyond human heart, sight, and
 bends.

7 For there's hope for a tree cut down,
 That it will sprout again a crown.

8 Though the root shrivel in the earth

And the stock perish with the dearth,
 9 Still at the scent of water it
 Will bud and spring out boughs and fit.
 10 But man dies and he wastes away,
 He gives up the ghost where to stay,
 11 As waters run off from the sea,
 And flood diminishes to be
 Dry *after the rain and the score*,
 12 So man lies down to rise no more,
 Till heavens fails, they shall not wake
 Nor be raised out of their sleep's *stake*.
 13 O that You'd hide me in the grave,
 And keep me under secret glaive,
 Until Your wrath be past, that You
 Would set a time *of judgement* due
 And keep my remembrance in view!
 14 When a man dies, shall he live more?
 All my appointed days in store
 I'll wait till I change at the door.
 15 When You call I will answer You,
 Desire turns to what Your hands do.

The tree sprouts up again after the axe,
 But men remain in graves flat on their
 backs.
 Job goes beyond empirical to wonder
 If there's no resurrection beyond thunder,
 And whether You remember Your hands' *deeds*
 When they are planted in the earth like
 seeds.
 Such cogitation is a human thing,
 And yet it is a crumb of hope to sing.
 Beloved, whether I rise in incarnation
 Of tree or blossom in a new-born ration,
 Or in the fatal resurrection meant
 For good and wicked on the earth's ascent,
 I too trust in the hope that future brings
 The universe another time of kings.

16 For now You've counted out my steps,
 Your eye's upon my sins' relapse.
 17 My transgression's sealed in a sack,
 You bind iniquity for lack.
 18 The falling mountain comes to naught,
 The rock is removed from its slot.
 19 The waters scour the stones, the rains
 Erode the growing earth of gains,
 And You destroy the hope of man.
 20 You always win against his plan,
 He passes out of sight and mind.
 You mar his form, send out resigned.

21 His children come paying respects,
 He does not know from their neglects,
 They too fail, but he never knows.
 22 But his flesh shall bow to its pain,
 His soul in him shall griefs complain.

Despite the crumbling of the fading earth,
 The dimming of the stars, the new star's
 birth,
 The ages upon ages beyond ken
 Of man's imagination in his den,
 I too trust that my failings are all told
 Within the sanctuary of Your hold.
 While mountains wear away beneath the
 cold,
 Your memory of my flash in the dark
 Is safe and settled in the heavenly park
 To rise again when Your mind is set free
 To new creations after burning sea.
 I trust that in the dim years of the tomb
 When ancestors' and all descendants' doom
 Lies in forgetfulness, You'll deck a room.

Job 15

Then Eliphaz the Temanite
 Replied and said *without delight*,
 2 Does a wise man speak vain conceit,
 Filling his belly *like a treat*
 With the east wind *without retreat*?
 3 Does he reason unusefully
 With speeches that can do no good?
 4 You cast off reverence when you could,
 And fail to meet El prayerfully.
 5 Your mouth gives witness to your sin,
 You choose the tongue of crafty kin.
 6 Your own mouth condemns you, not I,
 Your own lips come to testify.
 7 Are you the first man to be born?
 Did you come before the hills *sworn*?

Eliphaz argues that Job's innocence
 Is belied by the words he speaks in sense.
 He does not stop to ask what else the man
 Could do but humbly tell the truth in ban.
 Job himself knows and says that self-
 defence
 Is not a pretty picture, but the fact
 Is no one comes to help when he's
 attacked.
 He has no choice but tell the truth himself.
 For speaking truth, he's dealt with like an
 elf.

Beloved, the sweet Christian today is sure
The victim, when she cries, is not like pure
And humble Christ or Mary, so he cries
“Un-Christlike, you rant, and I shall
despise.”

Who’s he to say what’s Christlike and
what’s wise?

8 Have you heard the secret of God?
Do you hide wisdom in your pod?
9 What do you know that we do not?
What do you understand of plot
That was not also to us taught?
10 With us are both grey head and old,
More elder than your father cold.
11 Is what El gives to console you
Worth nothing at all in your view?
Do you have any secret too?
12 Why does your heart take you away?
Why roll your eyes in disdain’s sway?
13 To turn your mind against El and
Let words fly you don’t understand?
14 What is man that he should be clean,
Born of woman, a righteous bean?

Eliphaz makes an issue that the men
Who’ve grown old in their foolishness
again
Just for their age are right in what they say,
Claiming that sin original at bay
Is the fate of all humankind in sway.
The concept of intrinsic sin instead
Of defining sin by the action led
And listed in the Decalogue is not
A new one. See these fair Christians are
taught
By Eliphaz himself, with such a name
Appealing to Your strength and for such
shame!
Beloved, I do not trust the failing word
That finds sin in humanity deterred
By nothing, an inborn speck and a turd.

15 See, He relies not on His saints,
The heavens before Him have their taints.
16 So then how much filthy to stand
With abominations in hand
Is man who drinks iniquity
Like water *taken from the sea*?
17 I’ll teach you, listen to my speech,
And what I’ve seen I come to preach.
18 Gnostics told what ancestors said,

And have not hid the message *spread*,
19 To whom alone the earth was left
Without a stranger passing cleft.
20 The wicked man is bowed with pain
All his days, and the number vain
Of years is set to violence.
21 A dreaded sound falls on his sense,
In midst of his prosperity
Destroyers come upon his tee.
22 He does not have faith in return
Up from the darkness he would spurn,
He’s predestined for what swords earn.

Eliphaz is not sure whether his state
Is that of Gnostic thinker with his mate
Or if the sin original with him
Leads to complete depravity not dim.
Two doctrines join in his mind and they
swim

Out to reveal that matter is a grim
And awful thing, and evil in itself,
So even sinless angels, gnome and elf
Are filthy for the matter clouding brain.
Only the pure light and spirit can gain
Acceptance, but the man who’s trapped
below
In darkness does not feel the pull of glow,
Predestined for destruction on the go.
Such is the sweet Christian’s belief in pain.

23 He goes out begging for bread there,
He knows darkness is coming share.
24 Trouble and anguish make him fear,
They overcome him and his gear
Like a king ready for war’s tear.
25 He attacks El Himself by hand
Stretched and strengthened against the
stand
Of El Shaddai *and His command*.
27 He made his face fat, shining fat,
His haunches trembling in their fat.
28 He lives in towns made desolate,
In houses no man can locate,
About to fall in ruined state.
29 He’ll not gain wealth to keep at all,
Nor prolong days in earthly stall.

Eliphaz sees the human state itself
Between birth and the dark of death on
shelf
As proof that man is evil and cannot
Obey You in his deeds as You have taught.

His Calvinistic-gnostic word and plot
 Contrive to contradict You in the fact
 That You have told humankind how to act,
 And having told us, have the right to wait
 Obedience within the human state.
 All doctrines of devils and men are there
 To give excuse for those who would not
 share
 Obedience to Your word spoken with care
 On Sinai. My Beloved, I see the race
 Of false religions all about the place.

30 He'll not depart from darkness then,
 The flame shall dry his branch again,
 And by his mouth's breath on a day
 He'll disappear and go away.
 31 Let the deceived trust vanity,
 For vanity's his reward's fee.
 32 Fulfilled before his time, his bough
 Shall not remain green anyhow.
 33 He'll shake his green grape from the
 vine,
 And drop his olive blossom fine.
 34 The hypocrites' assembly's dark,
 Fire burns the tents of bribery's park.
 35 Pregnant with mischief they shall bear
 The passing vanity and care,
 Their wombs their broken trusts prepare.

Eliphaz' final argument is that
 Humankind is a temporary vat,
 And just because he's not eternal he
 Can never satisfy Your symmetry.
 The argument sounds spiritual but it
 Is loaded with irrational to fit.
 It simply does not take eternity
 To obey Your ten words on Sinai's lee.
 One can refrain from killing on a day,
 One does not need a timeless frame to say
 The truth about one's neighbour in the
 court.
 The Sabbath only needs seven days to
 sport.
 Beloved, save me from spirituality
 That lifts the mind to faithless ecstasy.

Job 16

1 Then Job replied and said to all,
 2 I've heard many such things in call,
 You're miserable comforters all.
 3 Shall empty words come to an end?
 What makes you so bold to defend?

4 I also could speak as you do,
 If your soul were in my soul's shoe,
 I could heap up words against you,
 And shake my head at what you do.
 5 But I would strengthen you instead,
 You'd find solace in what I said.
 6 Though I speak, my grief's not assuaged,
 I refrain, but how am I paged?
 7 He tires me with his arguments,
 You've left me desolate in tents.

Human conditions set as argument
 That Job's deserving of such punishment
 Is general, and so well could be spent
 On comforters who sit brave and content.
 The argument is valid only if
 All humankind suffers in Job's grief's skiff.
 And so the proof falls in the ditch and there
 Is only left the failure to give share
 Of human solace that each should have
 done.

Job's logic here at last shows that he's won.
 Beloved, just wait and see if logic sways
 The enemy in all his wicked ways.
 The victory of words seems empty when
 The winnings fall on the deaf ears of men.

8 You've cast me down for a witness,
 Emaciated in my dress.
 9 He tears me in his wrath and he
 Renews persecution of me,
 He gnashes on me with his teeth,
 My foe sharpens his eyes beneath.
 10 They've gaped upon me with their
 mouth,
 They've smitten me upon the south
 Cheek in reproach, they come together
 Against me, *those birds of a feather*.
 11 El's left me in ungodly hands,
 Released me into wicked bands.
 12 I lived in peace till He broke me,
 He took me by the neck, you see,
 And shook me till I rattled, then
 He made me His bull's eye again.
 13 His bowmen crowd around me while
 He splits my kidneys in His guile,
 He pours my gall out on the ground.
 14 He breaks me again round and round,
 He runs at me a pace a mile.

The foolish words of Eliphaz to Job

May well be couched in Christian kind of
robe,

But are so outrageous to hear that he
Complains that You, Beloved, have set
them free

Like hounds against him, like the pigs to
root

And dig him in the mire of their pursuit.
As soon as I hear claims to be the great
And remnant people of Your own estate,
I know the next thing is the well-aimed
boot.

The worst on earth today as then for soot
Are those who claim to represent Your
throne.

The Judenrat, cardinals' college, and
The council of marjas have hit the sand.
I'd rather be at mercy of rock band.

15 I have sewed sackcloth upon my skin,
Defiled my horn in the dustbin.

16 My face is swollen with my tears,
My eyelids shadowed with death's fears,

17 Not for injustice in my hands:

Also my prayer *is* pure as stands.

18 O earth, do not cover my blood,
Let my cry continue like flood.

19 See now, my witness *is* in heaven,
My record book *is* on high *seven*.

My friends scorn me: *but* my eye pours
My *tears* to Allah *without shores*.

21 If one could contend with Allah
As one brings neighbour to court's claw!

22 When I've gone a few years, then I
Shall go my way and I shall die.

It's not the boils so much, and not the death
Of children and of flocks in stealth of
breath,

But to be left before the righteous mate
To feel the tendrils of the good man's hate
That makes Job blame You for his perverse
fate.

He's able to stand before flood and storm,
And take the batterings of cold and warm,
The tragedies that fail not on the earth
In death, disease, in hail, locust, and dearth.
What he blames You for, My Beloved, is
just

The Christian tendency to cast in dust
Each one that is a victim of the round
Of human circumstance upon the ground.

The higher the suffering soul, the greater
sound.

Job 17

1 My breath's corrupt, my days extinct,
The graves for me *already winked*.

2 Truly mockers surround me and
My eye must see them acting grand.

3 Be the gauge of my surety,
Who'll strike hands in a pact with me?

4 For You've shut wisdom from their heart,
And so You'll not lift up their part.

5 He calls his friends to share the spoil,
But his own children's eyes see toil.

6 He's set me as a mocking word
Among the people that has stirred,
I've become the one in whose eye
They come to spit and then pass by.

7 My eye is darkened in my grief,
My members like shadow's relief.

My God, I always thought the Psalms were
made

To comfort human hearts among the
strayed,

But nothing so expresses what I've seen
In my long life upon this earthly green
As these words filtered down from Job's
ascent.

I've touched this land till I know what he
meant.

I've felt in my own flesh the nasty cut
That he declares here before Your door
shut.

This very day and week I've felt the spit
Fly in my face, seen the hand raised to hit.
It's always those who claim to live for You,
The ones whose pious words spoken as
true,

Who do the evil deed and smirk to find
Their arrows hit the mark though they're
well wined.

8 Upright men shall be amazed when
The innocent shall stir again
Against the hypocritic men.

9 The righteous shall hold to his way,
The one with clean hands *without pay*
Shall be strengthened *from day to day*.

10 But as for all of you, go back,
Return when I find without lack
Just one wise man within your stack.

11 My days are past, my goal is gone,
 The thoughts of my heart fail the dawn.
 12 They change the night into the day,
 The light is brief in darkness' sway.
 13 If I wait, I shall only meet
 The grave to live in *for my seat*,
 I've made my bed in darkness *neat*.
 14 I've said to corruption, "My father,
 To the worm, be my mother rather,
 And be my sister *or don't bother*.
 15 "And where is my hope now, my hope,
 Who shall see it *and give the hope?*
 16 "They shall go down into the pit,
 We shall together in dust sit."

How many times have I been brunt and
 sore
 Before the false accusing at the door!
 I hesitate to speak my righteousness,
 For it is just a broken thread's confess,
 And I'm amazed that any feels the need
 To trample me down before such weak
 seed.
 And yet the promise is that strength shall
 come
 To beat the proudly sounding of the drum.
 Beloved, I cling to You with patient dread
 To see the instance on enemy's head.
 We all go down to dust and feel the claw,
 And yet the rightness of the right in awe
 Rains light upon the kinship of the grave.
 I raise a head before them. I am brave.

Job 18

1 Then answered Bildad the Shuhite,
 And said 2 How long till end's in sight
 Of words? Come to your senses and
 Then we will speak *truth by command*.
 3 Why are we considered as beasts,
 Called vile in your sight *as though priests?*
 4 He tears himself in wrath. Shall earth
 Be barren for your sake with dearth?
 Shall rocks be moved from place of worth?
 5 The light of the wicked shall be
 Extinguished and the sparks fly free
 From his fire not to shine a wee.
 6 The light shall be dark in his tent,
 His candle fail as he too went.
 8 His strong steps shall find narrow path,
 His own advice cast him in wrath.
 8 For he's thrown in a net to catch
 His own feet, and he walks *a patch*

To find a snare *without a match*.
 9 The gin shall take him by the heel,
 The robber win against his weal.
 10 The snare's set for him on the ground,
 A trap for him in his way found.
 11 Terrors frighten him every way
 To drive him to his feet to stray.
 12 His strength shall turn in famine's ride,
 Destruction ready at his side.
 13 It shall consume strength of his skin,
 The firstborn of death is his kin.
 14 He's cast out from his tent's safety
 To come before fear's king to be.
 15 Strangers shall inhabit his tent,
 Sulphur shall be strewn where he went.
 16 His roots shall be dried up beneath,
 Above his branch cut off *in wreath*.
 17 His memory shall perish from earth,
 Name never mentioned as of worth
 In the street. 18 He'll be driven from
 The light to darkness and then some
 Will chase him from the world *to come*.
 19 He'll have neither a son to stay
 With nephew in the folk's array,
 None staying in his dwellings' way.
 20 Those who come after are amazed
 At his day, as those who were crazed
 Before with fright *to see unpraised*.
 21 Such is the wicked's dwelling place,
 Who does not know Allah *for grace*.

There is no rhyme but treason in the word
 That Bildad lets fall from his mouth like
 turd.

He merely swears and curses while he's
 stirred,
 But does not yield a reason since he's
 blurred.
 Job must fail and be brought to nothing
 since
 He does not know You like the party
 quince
 Here on a roll. When two or three together
 Repeat their nonsense any kind of weather,
 The repetition only is enough
 To convince human anti-mind for fluff.
 Beloved, I leave the foolish speech alone,
 Except to note that rhetoric in bone
 Can be used so effectively that stone
 Will stoop to agree with the tough and
 scruff.

Job 19

1 Then Job answered and said 2 How long
Will you vex my soul, and lift strong
Words to shatter me *with a song*?
3 These ten times you have outraged me
Without shame for cupidity.
4 If really I have sinned in full,
I only am responsible.
5 If you desire to attack me,
Then bring proof of iniquity.
6 Know now that Allah's thrown me down,
And caught me in His net *and frown*.
7 See how I cry against the blast
Without reply to me outcast.
I cry for help, no justice comes,
No matter how I count my sums.

Job points out the lack in the argument
That his friends keep saying without relent,
That suffering is the evidence in due
That sin has been committed in the pew.
Job says the evidence must be in state
Of witness of particular in fate,
The act of sin transgressing divine law,
And not deductions made and based on
straw.

The arguments seem so conclusive to
The minds of biased men come into view.
The same men would have found reason to
say
The Virgin Mary too had gone astray,
Since pregnancy is proof of semen passed
Into the womb of woman. I'm aghast.

8 He's blocked me here on every side,
There's no place where I may abide,
He's spread out darkness where I ride.
9 He's stripped me of my glory's crown,
I see it from my head fall down.
10 He's destroyed me on every hand,
And I am gone, and my hope's stand
He's removed like a tree from land.
11 He's kindled His wrath against me,
And He counts me an enemy.
12 His troops regroup and rise in way
Against my tent to take their prey.
13 He's put my brothers far from me,
And mine acquaintance verily,
All these have been estranged from me.
14 My kinsfolk have failed, and my friends
Long known forget me *for their ends*.
15 The folk of my house, even maids,

Call me a stranger, renegades.
16 I called my servant, and he gave
Me no answer, though I begged brave.
17 My breath is strange to my wife, though
I appealed to my children's show.
18 Even young children despised me;
I got up, they called mockingly.
19 My closest friends all abhorred me,
The ones I loved turned against me.

Job's argument is simply that his state
Of suffering is not proof in the stalemate,
But rather opportunity and duty
For friend and relative to enter beauty
By coming to his comfort now instead
Of coming to hammer him on the head.
He feels acutely all the pain in store
Brought on by wicked men darkening door
With accusations instead of the word
Of love to which they all should have been
stirred.

Beloved, I lay aside theology
And come to You to bind Your heart to me
In grace before the golden throne above
That stands in glory, grace, eternal love.

20 My bones stick to my skin and flesh,
I've only skin of teeth in mesh.
21 Have pity on me, pity please,
O you my friends; upon my knees
Before Allah who gives no ease.
22 Why do you persecute me like
El, unsatisfied with the strike?
23 I wish my words were written down
And printed in books of renown!
24 I wish them graven with a pen
Of iron and lead in rock and glen.
25 For I know my redeemer lives
To stand at last upon what gives
The earth *for judgement come again*.
26 After my skin is peeled away,
Still in my flesh shall come the day
When I see Allah *in His way*,
27 Whom I shall see for myself, and
My eyes shall gaze upon the grand
And on no other, though my gut
Melt in me *and my life be shut*.
28 But you should say, Why should we go
Against him, as if his roots show?
29 Be fearful of the sword, for wrath
Brings the sword's punishments in path,
Till you know judgement's aftermath.

The suffering of the man before the wind
Of his catastrophe when others sinned
Leads to a vision glorious to see,
One that opens doors on eternity.
The judgement coming and hereafter glows
In these words of faith that righteous Job
shows.

He bears prophetic word in his own teeth,
In broken skin and aching bone beneath
The shattered hopes of human comfort
gone.

And so he only sees the coming dawn.
Beloved, I join the vision of the man
Who sees You stand in judgement and I
can

Look forward to the day when every face
Will come before You beyond time and
place.

I hastily looked all about for You,
Beloved, Creator of the Universe,
Behind iconostasis, in the view
Of altar spread with golden cups diverse
And jewelled spoons. I searched the
standing crowd,

Eyes passing over necklaces and ring,
Ears at the ready to hear You speak loud,
I searched the church in vain where angels
sing.

At last I find You, my Beloved, behind
The furs and caps of vested and well-dined,
Sat stretching nervous hands from eyes to
stare

Beneath the matted, stringy, greying hair,
Above the patched dress, ruined, gaping
shoes,

Only divinely burning eyes give clues.

Job 20

1 Then answered Zophar Naamathite,
And said 2 That's why I've come in sight
So quickly to answer the wight.

3 I've had to listen to reproach,
My mind fights back against encroach.

4 Do you not know this ancient thing
Since man was set upon earth's ring,

5 The wicked's triumphing is short,
The hypocrite's joy moment's sport?

6 Though he might climb to heaven above,
And his head reach the clouds thereof,

7 Still he shall perish like his dung,

Those who saw him know where he's
flung.

8 He'll fly away just like a dream
And not be found, as it may seem
A vision in the night to fade.

9 The seeing eye on the parade
Shall see no longer where he stayed.

10 The poor shall overtake his young,
Recover what he took and stung.

11 The strength of youth filled up his
bones,

Yet they lie with him among stones.

Zophar at least has reason on his side
When he answers Job from his hurt and
pride.

He says Job's view that all men come at
last

To the same end, the dust and death when
passed,

Is partial view. The great reality
Is that the joy of the wicked to see
Is fleeting and a greater sampling's fee
Would show despite impressions of their
glee

That in fact everything on earth comes
round

And justice at last rises on the ground.
Beloved, the argument may well be strong
In the sum, yet it does not come along
As proof that Job is sinful because he
Is suffering. Justice in its time's no gauge
That innocence in grief comes not on stage.

12 Though wickedness be sweet in mouth,
Hidden under his tongue in south,

13 And he save it and not forsake,

But keep it in his mouth for stake,
14 Still it turns the meat in his paunch

Like gall of asps in him to launch.

15 He's swallowed wealth, and he'll return
To vomit what he did not earn,
El shall cast them out and to burn.

16 He shall suck the poison of asps,
The viper's tongue shall slay with gasps.

17 He shall not see the rivers, floods,
The brooks of honey, butter's buds.

18 What he laboured for he'll restore,
And shall not swallow it down more,

According to his wealth shall be
The restitution of his fee,
And he'll not joy in it's degree.

19 Because he's oppressed and forsaken
 The poor, he's violently taken
 Away the house he buildded not,
 20 He shall not feel the quiet taut
 In his belly, he shall not save
 What he desired *down to the grave*.
 21 There shall none of his meat be left;
 No man shall find his goods bereft.
 22 In his abundance he's distressed,
 All wicked hands shall rob his nest.
 23 *When* he's about to fill his bod,
 The wrath shall fall on him *from God*
 And rain upon him eating pod.
 24 He'll flee from iron weapons too,
 The bow of steel shall strike him through.
 25 It's drawn, and comes out from the
 back,
 The glittering sword without the lack
 Of gall comes out, and terrors fall.
 26 All darkness *shall be* hid in pall
 Of his secret places: a fire
 Not blown shall consume him in ire;
 It shall go ill with him that's left
 In his tabernacle bereft.
 27 The sky shall make appear his sin,
 The earth shall rise up with a din.
 28 The increase of his house shall fail,
 And dissipate before wrath's veil.
 29 This is the lot of wicked men
 From Alohim, portion again
 Appointed him by El *for yen*.

Zophar's concept of justice in the round
 Of robbing robbers' children is not sound.
 It's only to admit the jungle law
 Is sacred and esteemed for tooth and claw.
 That may or may not be reality,
 But if it is, I stand against its fee.
 Like Job I demand that the right be left
 To live in peace and never come to theft,
 And that the children suffer nothing of
 The robbing fathers' lack of faith and love.
 Beloved, if every token of the hand
 That shows rebellion against Your
 command
 Is justice come to play with toy and sand,
 Then I set down my spade and pail and take
 Myself back to my mother's house and
 stake
 And leave You and Your congregation's
 wake.

Job 21

1 But Job answered and said 2 Hear now
 With care my speech, and give somehow
 Me this comfort *upon my brow*.
 3 Let me speak and after I've spoken
 Continue with your mocking *token*.
 4 For me, *is* my complaint to man?
 Why should I not in anguish scan?
 5 Mark me, and be astonished, and
 Lay *your* hand on *your* mouth *as banned*,
 6 Even when I remember I
 Am afraid, and trembling *and sigh*
 Take hold on my flesh *as I die*.

Job remarks on the fact his friends deny
 A man the right to rattle and to die.
 The sounds made in approaching death are
 not
 A moral issue in the cosmic plot,
 But results of the way that flesh is wrought.
 The one who casts disparagement on such
 Anguish of heart and body with a touch
 Of his superiority since he
 Is still alive and well upon the tee
 Shows gross unconsciousness that all men
 must
 Once come to die and in that thing may
 trust.
 The implication is that righteous men
 Are all immortal in Auschwitz and glen
 Of Buchenwald. The argument is dust.

7 Why do the wicked live, become
 Old, and mighty in power, *and bold*?
 8 Their seed is established in sum,
 They see their offspring dear as gold.
 9 Their houses *are* safe from all fear,
 Neither does Allah touch their gear.
 10 Their bull ruts and it does not fail,
 Their cow brings forth calves sound and
 hale.
 11 They send out their sons like a flock,
 Their children dance *around and rock*.
 12 They take the timbrel and the harp,
 Rejoicing at flute's voice and carp.
 13 They spend their days in wealth, and in
 A moment go to the grave's bin.
 14 Therefore they say to El, "Depart
 From us; for we don't want to start
 In knowledge of Your ways *and art*.
 15 "What *is* Shaddai, that we should serve?
 What do we gain to pray *with verve*?"

Job disagrees with Zophar in his sampling,
And thinks his science lacks in method
amplifying.

The fact is that the life of wicked men
Is not a brief joy and destruction's den,
But often is a full life in their view
And is cut short only by death's last pew.
Their days in wealth carry the prideful
heart

From cradle to the brave rebellion's part:
Empirically they know they need no God
To carry them above or under sod.

Job may be right, I daresay that he is,
When speaking of those of his time and
bizz,

But I've an inkling that today all men
Live lives of inner anguish in their glen.

16 See, their good *is* not in their band:
The wicked counsel's not at hand.

17 How often is the wicked light
Snuffed out, and on them comes the night
Of their destruction! God hands out
In wrath their sorrows *as they pout*.

18 They are as stubble before wind,
And as the chaff that is unbinned
Before the storm. 19 God keeps in mind
His sins for his children in bind,
He passes judgement he shall know.

20 His eyes shall see destruction glow,
And he'll drink of the dregs of wrath
In the Almighty Shaddai's *path*.

21 For what joy has he in his house
After him when his months *like mouse*
Are cut off *with both sons and spouse*?

The measure of Your punishment does not
Attain the conscience of the wicked lot,
And so, according to Job's righteous
thought,

It plays no role at all in penitence
Among the wicked men in their safe tents.
Job's daring in his view that evil now
Is not Your call to righteousness somehow
As most of those who convert to the church
Give testimony from their wayward perch.
It's their reward indeed come to their end,
But is no argument for life to fend.
The righteous too may live a life with
friend,
In wealth and happiness at last snuffed out

In death before he knows what he's about.

22 Shall *any* teach El what to know,
Since He judges the high for show?
23 One dies in his full strength, in ease
And quiet, 24 his *flocks* produce *cheese*
And milk, and their bones moist with
marrow.

25 Another dies in bitter, narrow
Soul and never eats well to please.
26 They shall lie down alike in dust,
And worms shall cover them *like rust*.

Job sees his friend teach God the level of
Righteousness of each man seen from
above,

Expressed in how much wealth he's given
here.

Righteousness is gauged out in health and
gear.

Job finds the thing irrational for fear,
Implying that the action of each man
Is the only way one can judge in span
Who is the rogue and who is not by plan.
Beloved, I see Job's friends around me still,
In every judgement based on dress and frill,
And how that judgement then extents to
claim

Goodness for some who act in evil flame,
And demonize some others, who though
poor,

Act unrelentingly by Your law sure.

27 See, I know your thought and devices
You wrongfully think up in crisis.

28 For you say "Where's the prince's
house,

And where lives wicked man with spouse?
29 Have you not asked them in the street?

Do you not know of their defeat,
30 The wicked is reserved to meet
His punishment upon the day
Of his destruction? They shall be
Brought out the day of wrath's decree.

31 Who shall declare his way in face?
And who come to repay his race?

32 Yet shall he be brought to the grave,
And shall remain as the tomb's *slave*.

33 Clods of the valley shall be sweet
To him, and every man in feat
Shall follow after him, as *tread*
Innumerable before his *dread*.

34 How then do you comfort in vain,
Since your replies falsely remain?

The concept of Job's friends is that the dire
On earth that every man feels of the fire
Is evidence of wickedness and pain
Of punishment meted out not in vain.

Job answers that all men on earth receive
Both good and evil alike sans reprieve
And on the final day of judgement wake
To rewards and to pains for their acts' sake.
Beloved, I see around me for excuse
Both pains brought on by humans in abuse
And also the catastrophes of earth
That cannot be seen of a direct birth
In evil men have done. I hold with Job,
Who hopes the future will explain the robe.

Job 22

1 Then Eliphaz the Temanite
Answered and said *with all his might*,
2 Can a man be profit to El,
As wisdom profits man a spell?
3 *Is it* pleasure unto Shaddai
That you are righteous as a guy?
Does He gain anything when you
Make your ways perfect or then true?
4 Does He strike you for fear of you?
Will He bargain in judgement's view?
5 *Is not* your wickedness great too,
Your sin an infinite in due?
6 You must have taken from your brother
A pledge without reason or other,
And stripped the poor of everything
They had to cover up their wing.
7 You've failed to give water to drink
To the weary upon the brink,
And you have kept back bread to eat
The hungry needed for a treat.

Eliphaz is a theologian bare
Who postulates a God who is not there,
A God so high and spiritual the flame
Of right and wrong and justice has no
claim.

To balance off the realm of spirit high
He describes a man lower under sky
And also infinite in power of worth,
So evil he can change the cosmic earth.
These logical conclusions based on how
The human mind is structured on the bough
To reason in extremes and in abstractions

Is what divides the human race in factions.
And yet for all philosophy he falls
Back on the empty accusations' walls.

8 But *as for* the mighty man, he
Had earth where the honoured *for free*
Came to live and dwell *faithfully*.
9 You've sent out widows empty and
Broken the orphans' arms to stand.
10 Therefore snares *are* round about you,
And sudden fear troubles your view.
11 Or darkness, *that* you cannot see,
Many waters cover your *lee*.
12 *Is not* Allah in height of heaven?
And see how high the stars have striven?
13 And you say "How can El know what
I do behind the darkness shut?"
14 Thick clouds *are just* a cloak for Him,
They do not stop His eye, make dim,
He goes His rounds on heaven's rim.

Eliphaz tries to put words in Job's mouth
As he revolves from east and west and
south.

He claims Job's just trying to hide his sin,
And thinks that You, Beloved, see not
within.

He makes Job out to be a secret villain,
Pretending to be cool and right and willing,
But in fact resting on secret sins chilling.
The affirmation without facts appals
But guilty till proved innocent in halls
Is the outcome of statistical view,
And probable in cause now takes the pew
Over the justice of law and of order.
Beloved, I'm like to become just a hoarder,
A hermit in my temple and recorder.

15 Have you noticed the wicked way,
16 Which were cut down out of time's
sway,

Whose foundation was overflowed
With a flood *killing fleshly load*?

17 Such said to El, "Depart from us,
What can Shaddai do for our fuss?"
18 Yet He filled their houses with good,
But wicked counsel leaves my wood.
19 The righteous see *it*, and are glad:
The innocent laugh at their bad.
20 Since our substance is not cut down,
But what is left of them in town
The fire consumes *to black and brown*.

Eliphaz meets Job's argument for peace
Until the Day of Judgement come release
With reference to history of the flood
That punished all the wicked world with mud.

The argument might be good as it goes,
But Eliphaz takes it beyond its toes
To say that since he himself thrives and grows,

That shows that he himself's not one of those

Who suffer for their sins, so he is good,
Whereas Job is in station and in wood
Of the men that failed to go in the ark
And left their bleaching bones about the park.

All men start out with premises of truth,
But fail in bending their sorts without ruth.

21 Acquaint yourself with him, and be
At peace, and good will come to thee.

22 Receive, I beg, law from His lips,
Treasure His word in heart and ships.

23 If you'll return to the Shaddai,
You'll prosper *here under the sky*,
And if you put away your sin

Out of your household and your bin.

24 Then you'll lay up gold like the dust,
From Ophir like pebbles and rust.

25 Shaddai shall come to your defence,
And you'll have silver in your tents.

26 For then shall you have your delight
In the Shaddai *both day and night*,
Lift up your face to El aright.

27 You shall make your prayer to Him
then,

And He will hear you *in your den*,
And you shall pay your vows *like men*.

28 You shall also decree a thing
And it will have establishing,
And light shine on your ways *and wing*.

29 When *men* are cast down, then you'll
say

"There's lifting up!" So in your way
You'll save the humble *from the fray*.

30 He'll save the innocent in land,
It's saved by pureness of your hand.

Eliphaz begs Job to repent and see
How repentance will raise him in degree
And make him rich and loved eternally,

Or at least by poor neighbours in their glee.
Eliphaz would seduce the righteous man
With gold and silver and in wicked plan
Reduce the right to might and recognize
Only the wealth and power beneath the
skies.

Beloved, I here reject theology
Of power and of success beneath the tree
Of knowledge. I would better come to Thee
In all my wealth of worldly poverty
And covet only Your heart in the spree,
Your hope and faith, and Your community.

Job 23

1 Then Job answered and said *to him*,

2 Today also's my complaint grim,

3 If I only knew where to find Him,
I'd come where he sat to remind Him.

4 I'd set my case out before Him,
Fill my mouth with arguments *trim*.

5 I'd know how He would answer me
And understand what He said *free*.

6 Will He accuse me with great power?
No, he'd stand me up *in an hour*.

7 There the righteous might argue case,
I'd be saved from my judges' face.

Job's down to earth and simple in his view
That You are just in Your judgement and
true,

So that the one who's simply lived to do
By Your commandments would be
declared right

And innocent, if he stood in Your sight.

The fact that You cannot be seen among
The crowd does not mean that the poor are
hung,

But that the elders in the gate may make
A false verdict for all their righteous sake.

Beloved, I too search out the nook where
You

May be found by the accused in the pew,
And trust that what I've done of right be
known

To You, and what not You'll find to atone
As I stand here by invisible throne.

8 See, I go forward, but He's not,
I turn behind, but see not plot.

9 On the left where He performs action
I cannot see Him in a fraction,
He hides Himself upon the right,

And I cannot get Him in sight.
 10 But He knows the way that I take:
When he has tried me, for His sake
 I shall come forth as gold *in wake*.
 11 My foot has held His steps, His way
 I've kept to and not gone astray.
 12 Neither have I abandoned yet
 The commandment from His lips met,
 I've held the words of His mouth's ease
 Greater than my necessities.

Job turns to front and back, to right and left
 And whirls about the plain and mountain
 cleft,
 But cannot see You as he whirls away.
 So too am I come out to work and play.
 I turn to find you on the mountain top,
 I look for You as dizzying I drop
 Into the depths of darkness and of pain.
 I search You out in sunlight and in rain.
 But everywhere I turn, I find no trace
 At all of You, Your hand, Your foot, Your
 face.
 Beloved, I find myself to be alone
 Before the great invisible in throne
 Where You're unseen because too near in
 grace,
 Under my skin, in marrow of my bone.

13 But He's in One, and who can change
 What His soul desires in His range?
 14 For he performs what is appointed
 For me, many things He's anointed.
 15 That's why I'm troubled before Him,
 When I ponder, then I fear Him.
 16 El breaks my courage, and Shaddai
 Puts me in terror *by and by*.
 17 Since I did not fall in the dark,
 It was not darkness struck my mark.

Job's argument is valid for the man
 Who's seen the desert and the darkened
 span
 Of sky beneath the hood and knows the
 night
 Is of no greater danger than the light.
 But what about the child? Each little boy
 Knows that the darkness is feared in both
 joy
 And cunning. What about the child for
 right?
 I grasp Job's great theology to spare

Relation to Your being and be ware:
 The argument is that You, Beloved, care
 And are One and not three or four to share,
 And proof of that is that the terror of
 The darkness is illusion of a glove.
 The argument is scintillating, bare.

Job 24

1 Why has Shaddai not set the times
 Of judgement, and those in His rhymes
 Not seen His days come in their climes?
 2 *Some* take away the landmarks; they
 Steal flocks and *herds as well as hay*.
 3 They drive away the orphan's donkey,
 And confiscate widow's ox *wonkey*.
 4 They turn the needy from the way:
 The poor of the earth hide away.
 5 See them like wild donkeys that stray
 The desert, go out on their way,
 And getting up to find their prey,
 The desert gives their food *and hay*,
 For them and for their offspring's *lay*.
 6 They reap *every one* his field's grain,
 Glean grapes of wicked *not in vain*.
 7 They cause the naked to remain
 All night without clothes in the rain,
 Without a covering in the cold,
 8 Wet with the mountain showers untold,
 Pressed against the damp rock wall cold.

Job wonders that You have not set the time
 For all to see and hear the prose and rhyme
 Against those who with cunning come to
 steal

The portion of the poor and turn his wheel.
 How many more have wondered at the fate
 And been amazed to see judgement so late!
 No doubt the reason's only that You wait
 Not at all in eternity's estate.
 Beloved, You do not know how long time
 seems

To us, because You live and breathe in
 dreams
 Of Your divinity without constraint
 Of days and years that make a human faint.
 You have not shivered there against the wet
 Stone wall without a covering to get.

9 They tear the fatherless from breast,
 And confiscate the poor man's rest.
 10 They cause *him* to go naked and
 They snatch the hungry sheaf in band.

11 They press oil within secret walls,
Tread winepresses, while thirst enthralls.
From out the city comes the sound
Of groaning of men on the ground,
Cries out the wounded soul, and yet
God does not lay folly to get.

13 They're those that rebel against light;
They do not know the ways of right,
Nor stay in its paths and its sight.

14 The murderer gets up in time
To kill the poor and needy grime,
And in the night as a thief's mime.

15 Adulterous eye waits for the eve,
Saying "No one sees to believe,"
And so makes his face to deceive.

16 In dark they dig through houses' walls,
Which they'd marked in daytime for falls,
They do not know the light that calls.

17 Morning's to them shadow of death,
If someone knows them, bated breath
They are in terror *such that galls*.

How many fatherless are torn from breast
Today as slaves return from east and west
To do their tasks and send a pittance round
Back to debt-ridden houses on the ground!
There are more slaves today in this world
bound

Than ever earlier lived to the sound
Of cracking whip, more children die today
From overwork, malnutrition for pay
Than in the times of Rome and Grecian ray,
Or in the times the Sultans came to prey
On Circassian girls and Slav men to row
Their ships across the Caspian to glow.
Beloved, the height of progress and the
show

Of civilized is in the slaves to tow.

18 He *is* swift as the waters; their
Lot is cursed in the earthly share:
He goes no more by vineyards bare.

19 Drought and the heat consume the snow
Waters: *so does* the grave *make show*
Of those who've have sinned *and on the go*.

20 The womb shall forget him; the worm
Shall feed sweetly on him in term;
He shall no more come into mind,
Wickedness broken like tree vined.

20 He steals from the barren in turn,
And does not let the widows earn.

22 He draws the mighty with his power:

He rises up, none knows his hour.

23 *Though* he is set in safety's rest
His eyes are on their ways for best.

24 They're lifted for a little while,
But then thrown down upon the pile,
They're taken from the way like all,
And cut off like grain ears for the stall.

25 And if *it's* not *so* now, who will
Belie me and call my speech nil?

Poor Job, he thinks the ear is tuned to hear,
He does not know that speeches up to gear
Are only pauses for opponent's breath
And for a chance to think on pain of death
How he will answer reason spoken well.
It's easier to make a reply's spell
If one ignores the content and the meaning
Of what is said, and only take the screening
That best supports one's own view in the
net.

The comforters are hardly listening yet.
Beloved, what of the wicked in their gain,
Shall they not enter into final pain?
Is there a chance for righteous men at last
To enter rest after the slaver's blast?

Job 25

1 Then answered Bildad the Shuhite,
And said 2 Power and fear with the wight,
He makes peace in high places' site.

3 Is there a limit to his hosts?

Is there any end to his boasts?

4 How then can man be justified
With El? Or pure who's come to bide
Through a woman *and not to hide*?

5 Look even at the moon and see
That it shines not in purity,
And the stars are soiled in His sight.

6 How much less man, *who 'se just a*
worm?

And the son of man, *come* to squirm?

Bildad answers Job with the argument
Noted by Greeks later, ideal bent
Is far too pure for matter in this world:
It is a thing of pure spirit unfurled.
Job's guilty of having a body made
In womb of woman, and the act displayed
Of his obeying or his not means naught.
Do what he may, be he taught or untaught.
I grasp the idea that matter is rot,
I merely doubt the truth of what he sought.

The stars are pure unless they fail to do
According to commands given by You.
And Job is innocent if he acts by
The Decalogue no matter in what sty.

Job 26

1 But Job replied to him and said,
2 How have you helped the weak, unfed,
And saved the arm without strength led?
3 How have you counselled ignorant,
And clarified things with your cant?
4 To whom have you uttered your words?
And whose spirit came from your turds?
5 The dead shiver beneath the deep
And all the things that in it creep.
6 Naked is sheol before Him,
Nothing makes hell in His eyes dim.
7 He stretches out the north on naught,
And hangs the earth on nothing wrought.
8 He binds up waters in thick clouds,
That burst not under their weight's crowds.
9 He holds back the face of his throne,
And spreads his cloud upon its *stone*.
10 He's set around the water bounds,
Until day and night end their rounds.
11 The pillars of the heavens quake
Astonished for His menace' sake.
12 He divides the sea with His power,
And by His knowledge makes to cower
The proud. 13 By His breath He has set
The gems of heaven, His hand has met
To form the crooked serpent yet.
14 See, these *are just* parts of His ways:
How little is known to His praise!
His power's thunder, who can raise?

Job answers Bildad with two arguments:
The first is that his high-minded good sense
In raising You above all matter's glow
Obstructs the sympathetic hand to show
Good will and help to those who're poor
and slow.

The second is that such cosmology
Removes Creator from created's spree,
And thus makes You a pallid mimicry
Of Job's false comforters beside their tents.
Beloved, I too see how Your breath around
The hill, flying upon the lake and ground
Fill ear and heart with freezing, dismal
sound.

I too see the cold stars stare on the bound
Of the shy viper sliding from the mound.

Job 27

1 Moreover Job kept up his speech,
And said 2 *As* God lives, *who'd* impeach
My justice, and Shaddai hurts me,
3 While all the while my breath's in me,
And Allah's breath's in my nose free,
4 My lips shall not speak wickedness,
Nor shall my tongue deceit confess.
5 Let me never admit you're right,
Till death I'll not take from my sight
Integrity. 6 My righteousness
I hold fast, and not acquiesce,
My heart shall not reproach *me* while
I live *and exist without guile*.

Job now accuses Bildad of the sin
Of false theology not like to win.
Till now he's ranted only that the act
Of disobedience is sin in fact,
But now he speaks of sin in awful word
And of the heart by sinful thoughts once
stirred.

To hold belief about You that's contrary
To Your nature and character, though
chary,

In Job's view's also wickedness and not
Just the injustice such conceptions plot.
Beloved, let my tongue and my mind not
make

Idols of stone and brick, nor take in stake
Idols made of a spirit I've defined
As pure against all matter and confined.

7 Let my foe's fate be as the sinners',
Let my attackers be no winners.

8 For what hope has the hypocrite,
Though he wins, Allah burns his mitt.

9 In trouble will El hear his cry?

10 Will he take delight in Shaddai?

And call on Allah for a try?

11 I'll teach you by the hand of El:
What's with Shaddai I shall not quell.

12 See, all of you have seen the thing,
So why sink in vanity's ring?

13 This *is* the lot of wicked man

With El, heritage of who plan

Oppression to get from Shaddai.

14 His many sons were born to die
Without food though they multiply.

The concept of a God so spiritual

That nothing in creation satisfies
 Her longing to be shoved against the sties
 Of cornered in a lonely lane by wall
 Job calls a vanity, a common word
 Known in the Scriptures for an idol turd.
 The depredations Job calls on his foes
 Are justified and justifying goes
 By the fact that His view of You is sound
 Against the heathen harpies on the round.
 Beloved, I too call down destruction on
 The false theologies I myself spawn
 And cling to, to say nothing in degree
 Of those who hold the blessed Trinity.

15 The rest shall be buried in death,
 His widows will not waste their breath
 To weep for him. 16 Though he heap high
 Silver like the dust, though he buy
 Clothes abundantly as the clay,
 17 He may prepare *it for a day*,
 But the righteous shall wear the lent,
 And silver go to innocent.
 18 He builds his house as a moth might,
 Like the shelter a guard might cite.
 19 The rich man shall lie down, but he
 Shall not be gathered up to see,
 His open, staring eye shall be.
 20 While terrors take him like a flood,
 Night tempest steals him *for the mud*.
 21 The east wind carries him away,
 And he departs, and as a grey
 Storm hurls him from his place to stay.
 22 *God* shall shoot at him, and not spare,
 Though he would flee Him anywhere.
Men shall clap their hands at him, and
 Shall hiss him from his place to stand.

I like the vision of You shooting arrows
 At Trinitarians caught in the narrows
 Of spiritual delight to know that You
 Punish by plague and pox the righteous
 few.

I hiss at them and incur every wrath
 Political correctness in its path
 Can throw at me, and yet I chuckle while
 The heathen wilt beneath Your cynic's
 smile.

Free-thinkers are a better breed than those
 Who claim to be the very ones You chose,
 Who think three gods in one in silken
 clothes
 Refine the world by crucifixion's pose.

Beloved, send out the east wind on the
 West
 And temper it for its own sins in crest.

Job 28

1 For there's to silver a vein found,
 And place to find gold on the ground.
 2 The iron is taken from the earth,
 And brass molten from stone *of worth*.
 3 He sets a limit to the dark,
 And searches out perfection stark,
 The stones of darkness and death's shade.
 4 The mine is scored deep underneath
 The dwelling places, without wreath
 They there remain without support,
 Hanging forgotten from resort.
 5 The earth produces common bread,
 While underneath its fire is fed.

Job takes a parable for argument
 From the earth spread out like a living tent
 In peace producing grape and mellowed
 corn,
 But underneath the quiet, secret bourn
 Is molten mountain flesh and magma's fire,
 The secret treasures of divine desire,
 That may erupt and shall upon a day
 When least expected to join in the fray.
 I see, Beloved, that what seems peace on
 earth,
 And what seems catastrophic means in
 mirth,
 Are just the surface of reality,
 And all Your ways a safe hidden from me.
 The comforter who comes in Christian
 guise
 Speaks from his ignorance and is not wise.

6 Its stones *are* the place of sapphires:
 And has dust of gold *in its fires*.
 7 *There* is a path which no bird knows,
 The vulture's eye does not expose.
 8 The lion's cubs do not tread out,
 Nor comes the lion of redoubt.
 9 He puts his hand out on the rock;
 He turns up mountains by the stock.
 10 He cuts out rivers from the stone,
 His eye sees precious things alone.
 11 He hides the floods from overflowing;
 And hidden things he brings for showing.
 12 But where shall wisdom once be found?
 And where *is* understanding's ground?

13 Man does not know its price or cost,
It is not in living land tossed.

Job's arguments are fair and true no doubt,
And yet I think how much of truth is out
That once was hidden by the sea and shore.
The science of the human eye takes store
Of wonders by the storm that must awake
When curiosity takes bite of cake.
And yet the place of sapphires is still safe,
Despite the many mines the human waif
Digs for discovery of precious light
Reflected in the cold stone to the sight.
Beloved, I hold the wisdom that in gains
Gallops across the human land and plains
And still think that what is not known is
more
Than what's safe in the pockets of the gore.

14 The deep says "It is not in me,"
"Not with me either," says the sea.
15 It cannot be gotten for gold,
Neither for silver shall be sold.
16 With Ophir's gold there's no compare,
With fine onyx or sapphire's share.
17 Gold and crystal equal it not,
Nor exchange for golden jewels' lot.
18 No mention made of coral, or
Of pearls: for the price *of the store*
Of wisdom's above rubies' *core*.
19 The topaz of Cush holds no light
To it, nor even pure gold's sight.

They used to say that Ophir is a land
In the far west beyond the rushing strand
Of the Atlantic, in the mountain band
Where Incas ruled, and llamas made a
stand.

They used to say that Cush was poor of late
And bombed by the Italian head of state,
Who crushed Haile Selassie in his hate,
And disremembered topaz bright and great.
But I turn with an ear to what was said
Beyond the drought, beyond the hungry
fed,
And failed not to believe the gold was
there,
Nor that the shining stone of Cush's share
Was worthy of protection and of joy.
I have so thought since I was just a boy.

20 From where comes wisdom, where's the
place

Of understanding *in its trace*?

21 It's hidden from all living eyes,
Kept secret from the bird that flies.
22 Destruction and death say "We've heard
With ears the fame of what *occurred*.
23 God understands its way, He knows
The place it stays and place it goes.
24 For He looks to the ends of earth,
And sees the whole sky in its berth.
25 To make the weight for the winds'
treasure
He weighs the waters by their measure.
26 When he made a decree for rain,
A path for lightning by the train
Of thunder, 27 Then He saw and spoke,
He prepared it and searched its yoke.
28 And He said to man, "See, the fear
Of the Lord is wisdom's *cheer*,
Departing from the evil way
Is understanding *on display*."

Beloved, Beloved, I hear Your wisdom's
clang
Upon the very syllables I sang,
And covet to depart from evil ways
Sheltered in understanding of Your praise.
Beloved, I hear the law proclaimed in fire
And make its statutes heart of my desire,
I see the lightning, hear the thunder blast,
And make the faith of Sinai mine to last.
The words of Job compel me to the trust
Of You who knew the weight of wind from
dust
Before Copernicus could tie his shoe,
Before Galileo had come in view.
With every sight of world and sky and lake
I turn toward You and Your banner take.

Job 29

1 Job further continued his speech
And said 2 Oh, that I now could preach
As *in* months past, when Alohim
Watched over me, *as it did seem*,
3 When His lamp shone upon my head,
And when by His light I was led
Through darkness, 4 just as I was in
The days of my prime *without sin*,
When Alohim's sweet counsel was
Over my tent, 5 when the Almighty
Was yet with me, children *not flighty*

Were around me, 6 when my feet's *claws*
Were bathed with cream, and the rock
poured
Out streams of oil for me *restored*!

Job thinks back on his youth and with a
sigh
For good old days that now have passed
him by.
The divine counsel found in Decalogue
And in the Psalms and Torah pedagogue
Are sweet to young hearts that are quick to
learn
The ways of justice before they can earn
Reward for good and punishment for sin
That would come out in act and fill their
bin.
The very rocks give oil to youthful hands
That carry Your deep thoughts and your
commands
In heart and mind, in hand and foot and act,
Remembering, Beloved, Your loving pact.
No wonder Job in his affliction minds
The days of joy in youth, the day that
binds.

7 When I went out to the gate by
The city, took my seat to try
The open square, 8 young men saw me
And hid themselves, the elders free
Got up to leave. 9 The princes stopped
Their speaking with hands on mouth
propped.
10 The nobles held their peace, their tongue
Stuck to the roof of their mouth hung.
11 The ear that heard me, blessed me then,
The eye that saw, witnessed again.
12 Because I saved the poor that cried,
The fatherless with none beside
To help. 13 The blessing of him that
Was ready to perish came sat
Upon me, and I caused the heart
Of widows to sing in joy's part.
14 I put on righteousness, and it
Clothed me, and my judgement *was fit*
As a robe and a diadem.
15 I was eyes to the blind *in hem*,
And feet *was* I to the lame too.
16 I counselled the poor without due,
What I knew not I searched out too.

The young men are not slow to help the
weak,
The widow and the orphan from the sleek.
Job minds how he was quick in hand and
eye
To justice, though he'd not alert a fly.
The young are not slow to expect the crow
Of elders and of princes for the show
Of expertise they make when they run in
To combat wickedness and others' sin.
But Job has lived to earn and learn the view
That rich and the successful in the pew
May be or not deserving of the shoe.
By contrast, poverty is no gauge that
The heart is clean and pure where the weak
sat.
The wicked way's known to both bird and
bat.

17 I broke the wicked jaws and took
The spoil out that his teeth forsook.
18 Then I said, I'll die in my nest,
Days multiplied like sand *addressed*.
19 My root *was* spread out by the streams
The dew lay all night on my dreams.
20 My glory *was* fresh in me, and
My bow was renewed in my hand.
21 Men listened to me and they waited
In silence at my counsel stated.
22 After I spoke, they held their peace,
My speech dropped on them for release.
23 They waited for me as for rain;
They opened wide their mouths to gain
The spring rains. 24 *If* I laughed at them,
They were not offended by gem,
The sight of my face did not make
Them sad at all and for my sake.
25 I chose out their way, and sat chief,
A king in the army in fief,
And one who comforts those who mourn,
Protecting them from harm and scorn.

Job wonders that his comforters who claim
To be the heirs of righteousness in flame
So quickly change their views of man and
beast.
Man looks upon appearances increased.
When wealth and favour deck the brow,
they hear,
But when the body's bent with illness now,
Insinuations lead them anyhow
To outright accusations of the weak.

When gold and silver sparkle, what a man
 Says goes without the opposition's plan.
 But when mere wisdom fills his mouth, the
 train
 Rise up in opposition and disdain.
 A silk tie's worth more than the scholar's
 note,
 A pig's ear more than good deeds on the
 float.

Job 30

1 But now the youth make me their sport,
 Whose fathers would not meet report
 That I should hire them to keep sheep
 Along with my dogs in their heap.
 2 What could they do in any case
 To help the aged, perished face?
 3 For want and famine they remain,
 Fleed to already desert plain,
 4 Who cut up mallows by the reeds,
 And juniper roots *for* their needs.
 5 They were driven out from all men,
 Followed by cries as a thief's den,
 6 To live in holes upon the plain,
 In caves of the earth, in rocks' main.
 7 Among the thickets where they brayed,
 They found out nettles and were stayed.

The nettle was a thing I knew already,
 But juniper roots as a diet steady
 Was something that I hardly knew to claim.
 Between the two, I think a man in blame
 And fled from civilized society
 Could find survival in that double key.
 Myself, I'd rather take the berry too
 That graces the pine forest of my pew.
 Beloved, I bring You thanks that You have
 set
 In desert places instead of the wet
 A hidden way to succulence and sweet
 For those who miss the table and the meat.
 I find about me everywhere the treat
 In mushroom, briar and leaf, all things I
 greet.

8 Children of fools and of base men,
 Viler than the earth *of their den*.
 9 Now I'm their song and their byword.
 10 Disgusted at my sight, they're stirred
 To flee far from me, though they spit
 Upon my face and where I sit.
 11 Because He's loosed my cord and hit

Me, they think I'm a target fit.
 12 Upon *my* right *hand* rise the youth,
 They push on my feet without ruth,
 And raise up against me the ways
 Of their destruction *as for praise*.
 13 They dig holes in my path and set
 Calamity for me to get,
 Even though they've no helper yet
 When they shall have destruction met.
 14 They rushed upon me, no restraint,
 In desolation not to faint.

Job's had enough of prissy patronizing.
 He speaks up now no mincing and
 disguising
 To say what he thinks of such folk that
 come
 To celebrate his frothing at the gum.
 There's just one right response before the
 sight
 Of man's calamity before the night,
 And that is awful silence and restraint
 If not the pouring out of tears by faint.
 Most people, my Beloved, are shocked to
 hear
 And see the effects of the storm-cloud
 clear.

The few that have no sympathy or tear
 Are often the highly placed in the drear
 Of the religious. Let me find for fear
 An atheist when I've lost hope and gear.

15 Terrors are turned upon me: they
 Pursue my soul as the wind's way:
 My health passes with the cloud's sway.
 16 And now my soul's poured out in me;
 Days of affliction fell my tree.
 17 By night even my bones come through
 My flesh with no rest for sinew.
 18 My covering is changed by that
 Great stroke upon me *where I sat*,
 It chokes me *and holds me down flat*.
 19 He's thrown me out into the mire,
 I'm like dust and ashes *from fire*.
 20 I cry to You, You do not hear,
 I stand up, You do not appear.
 21 You've turned into a cruelty
 To me, with Your strong hand's decree
 You oppose and come against me.
 22 You lifted me up to the wind,
 Swept me away and disciplined
 To my destruction *who'd not sinned*.

The whirling of the soul, the dervish right,
Follows the flaming sun, the cold of night,
Until the strength of man is flung from
sight,

Dissolved in elements' refracted light.
The pain of dissolution at the drawn
Wind and the whirlwind flying, coming on,
Sounds in the howling of the dervish pawn,
Illusion of the night, image of dawn.
Beloved, like Job I listen to the wind,
And like Job contemplate where I have
sinned

And where I have not, yet the whirling fate
Of all men on the slaughter-ground is great.
Your hand molds body of the clay, Your
breath
Blows through the troubled waters of my
death.

23 For I know You'll bring me to death,
To placed appointed to all breath.
24 Yet You do not take in Your hand
Annihilation of the band,
But as they fall save *in the land*.
25 Did not I weep for the distressed?
Was not my soul grieved when addressed
By the poor *and the self-confessed*?
26 When I expected a good thing,
Then evil overtook my ring,
When I waited for light of dawn
The darkness came upon me drawn.
27 My entrails writhed and found no rest,
Days of affliction on my breast.
28 I went mourning without the sun,
I rose, cried in congregation.
29 I am a brother to dragons,
The friend of owls *come in their tons*.
30 My skin is scorched on me, my bones
Are burned beneath the heated stones.
31 My harp is tuned to mourning sound,
My flute to weeping *on the ground*.

Beloved, if You require the sound of harp
Accompanied by the voice when I carp,
You are not just to expect flute as well
Upon the wind to say a flying spell.
I do not fear the owls, in fact I wish
I heard a few more such voices to swish
Through pine and fir above my house and
dish
As I ignore the tolling of the bell.

Beloved, I pray the dragons in their gloom
Might find my paths instead of such in
doom

With human hands and hearts that speed
me on

To hopeless places shivering on the dawn.
The dragons are the better healers here
Where comforters like Job's choose to
appear.

Job 31

1 I made a promise to my eyes
I'd not so much as a maid prize.
2 What has Allah made from above?
What does Shaddai hold in His glove?
3 *Is* not destruction to the sinner
The prize allowed to such a winner?
4 Does He not see my ways, and count
All my steps *to find the amount*?
5 If I have walked with vanity,
Or if my foot's not deceit free,
6 Let me be weighed in a just scale
So Allah shall know my right tale.
7 If my step has turned from the way,
And my heart walked by my eyes' ray,
If any blot stuck to my hands,
8 *Then* let me sow, in contrabands
Let someone else eat, yes indeed,
Let my descendants go to seed.

Job recognizes that You see his ways,
He recognizes that You're due for praise,
But also notes that in this world of strife,
Both holy and unholy lose their life.
The common fate of men is not decided
Simply by tallying the sins derided
And compensating each accordingly.
That has to wait until the day set free
For judgement when all faces once appear
Before Your face and lose their charms
sincere.

Beloved, all men await that day with fear
Or with the ignorance that it is near,
Or with the hope that You in mercy stand
Before the throne of judgement in
command.

9 If my heart has been once deceived
By a woman, or unrelieved
I've been in ambush at the door
Of my own neighbour for his store,
10 *Then* let my wife lie in the bed

Of another man where he led
 To copulate with him instead.
 11 This is a crime, iniquity
 To be judged so outrageously.
 12 For it's a fire consuming all
 That I have left *in barn and stall*.
 13 If I despised the cause of my
 Manservant or maidservant by
 Their struggle with me, 14 why should I
 Then make complaint when El stands up
 And casts upon me like a tup?
 15 Did He who made me in the womb
 Not make him too before my doom,
 One to fashion us both in room?

That's pretty strong for language that Job
 uses,
 The kind that takes both long and short for
 fuses.

He says if he has done a thing that meets
 Criterion for punishment on streets
 Or market-places or before the gate
 Of any city where the elders wait,
 Then let the neighbour muck his wife and
 be

Done with the rage and with hypocrisy.
 And yet, Beloved, by end of book You
 state

As at beginning, come now soon or late,
 That Job is perfect and one that eschews
 The evil and loves good by every muse.
 If You accept such language in the pews,
 That's Your concern, for myself I refuse.

16 If I have withheld from the poor
 What they want or need of the sure,
 Or cause the eyes of widow dame
 To cloud up for lack of her claim,
 17 Or if I've eaten all alone
 And left the orphan without bone,
 18 For so my father from my youth
 Taught me not to do, it's the truth,
 19 If I've seen any languish for
 Lack of clothing, poor at my door,
 20 If his loins have not blessed me, and
If he were *not* warmed with the band
 Of my sheep's fleece so he could stand,
 21 If I have lifted up my hand
 Against the fatherless, when I
 Saw I could help or at least try,
 22 *Then* let my arm fall from its socket,
 And broken to the bone to rock it.

Job is so certain that he's done no sin
 For which he's being punished in the din
 That he says let the arm fall off and break
 If anyone can testify and shake
 His witness that he's kept as well as can
 Your law in this world under heaven's
 span.

He's not one to proclaim his righteous
 worth,

He's not out to claim salvation on earth
 By doing good works and against the will
 Of Luther and of Calvin on the hill.

He merely tells the same truth You once
 told

At the beginning of the book and bold.
 He cannot lie in his integrity
 To satisfy his comforters all three.

23 I held El's destruction in fear,
 His sovereignty kept on my gear.

24 If I have put my hope in gold,
 Saying to the fine gold when sold,
 "You are my confidence made bold,"

25 If I was happy to be rich
 By getting with my own hand's stitch,

26 If I saw the sun shine or moon
 In brightness 27 and my heart gave boon
 To worship them with idol's kiss,

28 This also *would have been to miss*,
 A sin before the judge, for I
 Should have denied El in the sky.

It seems that in days long since gone a man
 Could look up in the sky and try to scan
 The body of his gods who wandered there,
 Or rather followed their paths in the fair
 Of vanity before the eyes that can.
 No doubt the colour of the sun itself
 Gave the idea that gold was made by elf
 To be the flesh and blood of the great god,
 And the moon was the pattern for the pod
 Of silver, and so wealth was born to cast
 A shadow on the life of man and blast.
 If no one makes an idol now of those
 Dead bodies in the heavens, some men
 chose

To make an idol still of gold that shows.

29 If I rejoiced when others fell
 Who hated me, or lifted well
 Myself in gladness at his fate,

30 Or sinned by wishing on his pate
 A curse, 31 if the men of my tent
 Said they went hungry when they went,
 32 The stranger did not sleep outside,
 I opened my doors to confide
 In travellers, 33 if I tried to hide
 My sin like Adam [red earth], in my pride,
 34 If public opinion abide
 In my fear or I make my way
 According to how high the pay
 Of others was to make me stay
 And not speak justice, but to stray,
 35 Oh that one would hear what I say!
 See, I wish Shaddai'd speak to me,
 And give proof of His enmity!
 36 I'd take the load upon my back
 And wear it as a crown *for lack*.
 37 I'd tell Him every step I'd taken,
 Like a prince beside Him *unshaken*.
 38 If my land cries against my stain,
 Or its furrows likewise complain,
 39 If I have eaten without pay
 Its fruits, or caused to go astray
 The owners of the plot away,
 40 Let thistles grow instead of wheat,
 And cockle for the barley treat.
 Job's words are ended *in defeat*.

Three things Job offers up in testimony
 That his claim to justice is not one phoney:
 He says if he is sinful let the male
 That lives next door take some of his wife's
 tail,
 And let his arm drop off and broken lie,
 And let his fields bear thistles on the sly
 Instead of wheat once planted or then rye.
 That's saying quite a lot, but then I see
 How he was provoked by humanity
 In the strange figures of his bonny three.
 Beloved, I come to end of Job's words
 here,
 I've listened to the argument with fear,
 And vote for Job, that You set all things
 right
 Upon the day of judgement after night.

Job 32

1 These three men ceased to answer Job,
 Because he *wore a* righteous robe
 In his own eyes, *or so they thought*.
 2 Then the anger of Elihu
 Son of Barachel, Buzite crew,

Of the kinfolk of Ram in plot,
 Flared up against Job and enflamed,
 Because he justified and claimed
 That he was right, not Alohim.
 3 Also against his three friends' dream
 He shook with ire, because that they
 Had found no answer for their way
 Of damning Job *in their esteem*.
 4 Now Elihu had waited till
 Job had spoken and said his fill,
 Because they *were* older than he.
 5 Elihu, when he came to see
 No answer in the mouth of three,
 Then he flamed up and was angry.
 6 Elihu son of Barachel
 The Buzite answered and said well,
 I'm young, and you *are* very old,
 So I was afraid to be bold
 And speak my mind out clear and cold.
 7 I said, "Days should speak, and the pile
 Of years teach wisdom *and not guile*."

The fact is Elihu's presented as
 A teenage wonder full of all the jazz
 Obnoxious self-esteem creates in all
 Who grow up too fast like a weed on wall.
 There are some who think Elihu's speech
 wins
 The prize against his elders' wings and
 fins,
 But such who do approve theology
 From him fail to remember what we see
 Of anger in his disrespectful spree.
 Of course the whole thing's literary fancy,
 And not report of what a youth gone
 dancey
 Is like to say. It's couched in poetry.
 Somebody may have added to the book
 Thinking it was too short to take a look.

8 But *there's* a spirit in a man:
 The inspiration *and the plan*
 Of the Shaddai to understand.
 9 Great men are not wise, neither do
 The aged have judgement in view.
 10 That's why I said listen to me,
 I'll show my opinion freely.
 11 See, I have given you respect
 By waiting for your words select,
 I listened to your reasoning
 Whilst you tried to search out the thing.
 12 I listened attentively, but

Not one of you could convince shut
Mind of Job or answer his words.
13 Lest you should say "*Like soaring birds*
We've found out wisdom: El has put
Him down and not man *under foot*."
14 Now he's not said a word to me,
So I'll not reply by your scree.

The pretence of respect Elihu spews
Is so incredible, I blow my fuse.
No wonder fathers find their teenage sons
More than they know to handle on their
buns.

His greatest claim is that he will not speak
With the same arguments that Job found
weak
When expressed in the mouth of trinity
Of his abusers on their gallant spree.
Let me, Beloved, here just express a doubt.
I'll see if Elihu for all his shout
And cant comes up with something new to
hear
That Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar fear.
So far I've found that blind speakers are
blind
Whether young or old, blunt or else well-
tined.

15 They were amazed, replied no more,
They left off speaking *at the door*.
16 When I'd waited for them to stop
Their prattle and spinning *like top*,
17 I said, I'll answer my part too,
And I'll show them a thing or two.
18 Because I have a lot to say,
The spirit in me comes to sway.
19 See how my paunch is like a sack
Of wine without a vent to slack,
Ready to burst like bottles new
Of wine bubbling to come to view.
20 I'll speak, and so relieve myself,
I'll open my lips *like an elf*.
21 I'll disregard each man's estate,
And forget titles soon and late.
22 For I'm not used to flattery,
Nor does my Maker lend them free.

I think it is not rare among the young
To think it virtue to forget the rung
Of honour climbed and titled in their way
By their fathers and uncles on display.
Pretence of not giving a care at all

To who is titled or not at the ball,
Is not the virtue of equality,
But simply shows that the youth in degree
Has not yet had the time to gain trophy.
Beloved, I have been young and now am
old,
I too have been unwise and just as bold,
And while it may be late to make
correction,
At least keep me from foolish insurrection.
Titles indeed are often bought and sold.

Job 33

1 So, Job, please listen to my speeches,
And hearken to my words *like peaches*.
2 Behold, now I've opened my mouth,
My tongue has spoken in my mouth.
3 My words *shall be of* my heart's right,
My lips bring knowledge into sight.
4 The Spirit of El has made me,
And the breath of the Almighty
Has given me my life freely.
5 If you can answer me, then do,
Stand up before me in my view.
6 See, I stand at your order here
As though I were El to appear
As you wished, though I'm formed of clay.
7 Behold, my terror shall not sway
To make you fear, nor shall my hand
Be heavy on you *where you stand*.

If Job is here to justify the deeds
That You Yourself said measured up to
reeds,
The world about him, for their frozen
creeds
And hearts, disdain him for the truth he
feeds.
But one of them without a qualm or blush,
Without a hesitation in the rush,
Is bold to say that he comes in the tent
Of pain and suffering here to represent
You on Your throne, though made of clay
and breath
That hangs upon a thread over his death.
The human mind is great above all things:
None but the human can presume as kings,
None but the human quibbles at the mote,
And grasps the collar and squeezes the
throat.

8 I've certainly heard what you said,

And understood intention spread.
 9 "I'm clean without transgression, I
Am innocent, no sin in sty.
 10 "See, He finds something against me
 And counts me as an enemy.
 11 "He puts my feet in stocks and stays,
 He follows and marks all my ways."
 12 See now, in this you are not just,
 I'll answer you as well I must,
 Allah's greater than man *of dust*.
 13 Why do you so strive against Him?
 He gives no account of the dim.

Elihu focuses in his impatience
 Upon the same feature in Job's ematience.
 It's true enough that man is here to show
 His patience before pain and death come
 slow,

And in that quiet lack of questioning
 Earn the reward of Paradise in spring.
 But that is simply not the question here.
 We're faced with two concepts of You, one
 drear,

That pain is evidence of divine sword
 Dividing human flesh with sin's reward,
 And one that states You come on
 Judgement Day

To give reward, to every man his pay.
 Elihu has not picked up on the question,
 And so's irrelevant in his suggestion.

14 For God speaks once or maybe twice,
 Man's perceiving does not suffice.

15 In a dream, vision of the night,
 When deep sleep falls on man and wight,
 Asleep safe in bed *without fright*.

16 Then He opens the ears of men,
 And seals their instruction again,
 17 So He may draw man from his goal,
 And hide man's pride *against the toll*.

18 He keeps back his soul from the pit,
 And his life from the sword in fit.

19 He's chastened with pain on his bed,
 And all his bones suffer instead,
 20 So that his life abhors his bread,
 And his soul his dainty meat *fed*.

21 His flesh is consumed away, so
 It cannot be seen; and the show
 Of his bones stick out *in a row*.

22 Indeed his soul comes near the grave,
 His life to the destroyers *brave*.

The answers of the trinity of bold
 Comforters was based on the clear and cold
 Logic that pain is always a reward
 For sin, therefore wherever pain is stored
 There must be also sin. The logic's weak
 And faulty, but it's logic there to seek.
 Elihu claims that logic's not enough
 To answer the deep questions in the rough,
 But for that man's dependent on the gruff,
 The vision in the night revealing tough.
 Beloved, I question here the reason and
 The vision of both glory and the stand
 Of trouble on the shore, the golden sand.
 A doubting Thomas, I am always banned.

23 If there's a messenger with him,
 Interpreter, one who's *not dim*
 Among a thousand, to shew man
 His uprightness *and make him scan*,
 24 Then he is gracious to him, and
 Says, "Save him from the *horrid* pit,
 I've found a ransom, *and one fit*."

25 His flesh is fresher than a child,
 He'll return to his youth *unguiled*.

26 He'll pray to Allah who gives grace,
 And with joy come before His face,
 For He'll reward man's righteous case.

27 He looks on men, *if any* say,
 "I have sinned, and gone the wrong way,
 And found to profit where I stray,"

28 He will deliver his soul from
 Going into the pit to come,
 And his life shall behold the light
Of great salvation come in sight.

Elihu is the first great Christian man,
 The first to state two heresies in span.
 The first is that grace comes as soon as due
 When a man gives confession in his pew
 Acknowledging his sinfulness in view,
 Instead of in particular to set
 Transgression right and do commandments
 met.

The second is that such a man will miss
 The grave and its pains for the divine kiss.
 The false gospel is shown here in its bliss
 Of lawlessness and the great lie that man
 May avoid death to live as a man can.
 Eternal life with sins paid by another
 Is the good news that trips up every
 brother.

29 See all these things El does for man,
30 To bring back his soul from the span
Of the grave to the living light.
31 Mark well, O Job, listen to right,
Be still and I will dispel night.
32 If you have anything to say,
Answer me: speak and speak away,
For I desire to justify
You *if you only will comply*.
33 If not, listen to me and be
Quiet and I will teach freely
The wisdom *that you do not see*.

Elihu brings salvation like the church,
He does not leave Job sitting in the lurch.
The message is that grace brings life to last
And conquers the grave and its pains gone
past.
Job only needs to lie and say he's sinned,
And all will be well among fowl and
finned.
But he must first relinquish truth and
reason
Before the great Magisterium's season.
The pope goes back well beyond Peter's
day,
Alive and well in what Job's friends would
say.
Before the teaching of the revelation
Against all reason and against all ration
Of fact, the poor Christian must bow his
head
And thank the church on perch for
heavenly bread.

Job 34

1 Elihu continued his speech,
2 Listen, wise men, to what I preach,
And you with knowledge, give me ear.
3 For the ear tries words, as the tongue
Tastes food *and with its savour hung*.
4 Let us choose to us judgment: let
Us know for ourselves the good met.
5 For Job has said, "I'm in the right,
El's taken justice from my sight.
Should I lie against my own hand?
My wound's without a cure to stand
Without having done wickedness."
7 What man *is* like Job, *who* drinks up
Scorn like water *poured in a cup*?
8 He goes out with the band of sinners,
And makes the wicked men his winners.

9 For he has said, "It profits man
Nothing to delight in the plan
Of Alohims set out to scan."

The sweet Christian cannot have it both
ways.

Elihu has the same belief for praise
That pain is punishment for wickedness,
And consequently a man's bright success
Is proof that he's a winner in the dress,
A righteous man who does good
everywhere,

And has no hidden sins among the fair.
If that is so, he preaches righteousness
By works of the law, a grave offence mess
To every Protestant who answers call.
His gospel's mixed with manure from the
stall.

Beloved, the mixing up of concepts here
Is not a new thing, and also I fear
Does not end with Elihu's tongue and ear.

10 So listen to me, you who know,
El is not one for wicked show,
Nor does Shaddai an evil row.
11 He'll pay a man by what he's done,
According as he's lost or won.
12 Surely El will not do a thing
That's evil, neither shall a sting
Against justice make Shaddai's wing.
13 Who's given Him charge over earth
Disposed of the whole world in worth?
14 If he sets his heart upon man
To gather his spirit in span
And his breath to Himself by plan,
15 All flesh shall perish in the crust,
And man shall turn again to dust.

Elihu now takes up another story
To add to the two already in glory
And inconsistency in what he says.
He now takes up the atheistic fez.
He's sure that God who does an evil thing
Must not exist at all under the wing
Of universe, and since we see around
Us evil, it must be just to abound,
And is not evil. Job if pained at all
Must be pained justly pushed against the
wall.

He has not gone to that logic I find
So common here, that evil in the bind
Is evidence that no God's here to take

The throne at all beside the evil stake.

16 If now you understand, hear this:

Listen to my voice and my hiss.

17 Can any One who hates the right

Come to rule over all for spite?

Will you condemn the One who's just

Above all beings *made of dust*?

18 Do you say to the king he's wrong,

And to princes they've hit the gong?

19 *How much less to him* that accepts

Not face of princes nor adepts,

Nor regards the rich more than poor?

For they're all works of His hand sure.

20 In one moment shall they all die,

And people be troubled to fly

At midnight, and pass away: and

The mighty be taken from hand.

21 For His eyes *are* on ways of man,

And He sees all his goings' span.

Prolific is Elihu, I must say!

He finds another inconsistent ray.

He first says that he does not care a whit

For title or position in outfit,

And then he goes on to make point that
might

Makes right and every king sets up his
knight.

If might makes right, then that above all
things

Is bowing before face and fame and stings.

Beloved, this passage of Your Scripture
holds

The best lesson to humankind that scolds

The tendency to inconsistency

So prevalent in every speech I see.

I pride You on the inspiration here

That comes out shouting loud and spare
and clear.

22 *There's* no darkness, shadow of death,
Where hidden sinners hold their breath.

23 For He'll not lay on man a load

More than in justice is El's goad.

24 He'll break in pieces mighty men

Without number, and set again

Others in their place. 25 So He knows

Their works, and overturns their pose

In a night, and they are destroyed.

26 He strikes them down as those
employed

In wickedness in public sight.

27 Because they turned back from His
right,

And would not keep His ways *in light*.

28 So they cause the cry of the poor

To come to Him, and he hears sure

The cry of the afflicted poor.

After all his bright inconsistency,

Elihu comes back to the trinity

Of comforters and takes up once again

The selfsame argument of those false men.

Since God is just and all things come from
Him,

The pain of Job reveals the evil dim

That he had done in secret to the poor.

It is an evidence to make things sure.

Beloved, I see that every generation

Comes with the same old lies' perpetuation,

But only multiplies disdain for each
That came before him in the stand to
preach.

The edifice is strong and without breach,

And yet divides with each man keen to
teach.

29 When He gives quietness and peace,

Who then can make trouble's release?

And when He goes to hide His face,

Who then can see Him in His place?

Against a man, against a race,

30 So that a hypocrite reigns not,

So that the people be not caught.

31 But surely it is meet to say

To El, I've borne my punished pay,

I will offend no more *today*.

32 If I am wrong, then correct me;

If I have done iniquity,

I will do no such more *in spe*.

33 Should He act by your mind and will,

As you say the yes and the nil?

I can't speak for you, choose your *swill*.

34 Let men of understanding tell,

And let a wise man hear me well.

35 Job spoke without knowledge in spell

And without wisdom he was swell.

36 I wish Job more pain till the end

Because he answers like a fiend.

37 He adds rebellion to his sin,

He claps among us as to win,

And adds against El words in bin.

Here the sweet Christian's attitude awakes
The pinnacle of Christian love for sakes
Of sinners. How Elihu heaps the stakes
Of status quo. See how oppressed heart
shakes!

The innocently evil heart and mind
Of the majority is of a kind:
What is must be the will of God and blind,
God would not allow bad kings
unconsigned.

If a king reigns, he has to do the right,
Since right is defined by the kingly might.
From this appears the sweet Christian in
love,

He hopes that Job will burn in hell to shove
The idea that a man may do the good
And still fall beneath shower in the wood.

Job 35

1 Elihu spoke again and said
2 Do you think you come out ahead
To say that you are right instead
Of El? *To me you sound ill-bred.*
3 Because you said "What profit's here
If I *am cleansed* from sin *in fear*?
4 I'll answer you, and your friends too.
5 Look at the sky and see how high
Above the clouds *are floating by.*
6 If you sin what happens to Him,
Many transgressions make no dim.
7 If you do right, what do you give
To Him in help to make Him live?
8 Your wickedness hurts only man
As you, and your goodness in plan
Can only help the son of man.

The argument that human action wakes
No answering response in Your own breaks
Is quite irrelevant to questions posed.
But it's a part of the concept that dozed
Beneath the sleeping mind of Elihu
And his three friends in what they say and
do.

The point is proved that You care not a
whit
For what folk do on earth here where they
sit,
And actions good and bad have no effect
Because You're spirit only and select.
The spiritualization of Your throne
Opens the door to thinking matter's stone
Is in itself impure, unholy and

Justly endures pain's punishment to stand.

9 Because of the oppressing weight
Of wrong the oppressed cry in state,
Because of the hand of the great.

10 But none says "Where's Allah my
maker,

Who gives songs in the night *to shake her.*"

11 Who teaches us more than the beast
Of the earth, and makes us increased
In wisdom above birds that fly?

12 There they cry, but none gives reply,
Because of proud men on the sly.

13 Surely El will not hear the vain,
Shaddai will not regard the main.

14 Though you say you cannot see Him,
Yet judgement is come before Him,
So just be still and trust in Him.

15 Now since He does not pour down
wrath

In its extremity on path,

16 Therefore Job's speech is all in vain,
And he says words that are insane.

Elihu's argument is that since those
Who lie beneath oppression of their foes
Do not blame You for all their pain in
rows,
But submit to injustice thinking that
If You permit it, they'll accept the bat,
Then Job is wrong to choose another way.
The argument of popular in sway
Is strong for the majority whose minds
Are closed by their stupidity and blinds.
It's true that patience has its own reward,
But that is no excuse to show the sword
When one cries out in anguish in the night.
Elihu's name is too good in Your sight,
A hypocrite like others who are right.

Job 36

1 Elihu kept on talking then.
2 Be patient and I'll show again
I speak for Allah *and not men.*
3 I'll fetch my knowledge from afar,
And count my Maker a right *star.*
4 For truly my words *are* not false,
I'm perfect here *to dance the waltz.*
5 See, El is great, despises not,
Mighty in strength and wisdom's lot.
6 He does not save a wicked life,
But gives right to the poor *in strife.*

7 He keeps His eyes on righteous men,
 And kings on the throne, see, He sets
 Them up forever, *no regrets*.
 9 And if *they're* bound in fetters' chains,
 And held in afflictions' remains,
 9 Then he shows them their work for pains,
 And their transgressions for their gains.
 10 He also opens up their ear
 To discipline, and commands fear
 That they back from iniquity.
 11 If they obey in service free,
 They'll spend lives in prosperity,
 And years in pleasures *faithfully*.
 12 But if they don't obey, they shall
 Perish by the sword, and pell-mell
 Die without knowledge *in a spell*.
 13 The hypocrites heap up their wrath,
 But cry out not upon the path
 Of their captivity for pain.
 14 They die young among unclean vein.

Elihu continues to speak aloud
 On Your behalf, Beloved, to all the crowd,
 And as the vicar of the son of God,
 He lays out teaching fast upon the sod.
 He speaks of hypocrites, and by that sound
 I know that there are still upon the ground
 A faithful few who do not dance to tunes
 Baked in the Vatican or in lampoons
 Of rock and roll to jazz the place a while.
 Yes, My Beloved, the queue's of many
 mile
 Of those ready to speak for You and smile.
 Beloved, Beloved, keep me off from such
 guile.
 I speak for that self that's illusion's pile
 And leave the rest to utter hale and heal.

15 He saves the poor when he's oppressed,
 And opens their ears *when addressed*.
 16 And yet He would have taken you
 Our of your trouble to a pew
 Where there is no trouble in view,
 Before a table set with stew.
 17 But you received the wicked's plot,
 Judgement and justice fall your lot.
 18 Because *there's* wrath, *beware* lest He
 Take you with one's stroke's equity,
 Then no great ransom will set free.
 19 Will He be moved by your wealth's fee?
 No, not by gold or hand mighty.
 20 Desire not the night, when the folk

Are cut off in place *by a stroke*.
 21 Take heed, don't hide iniquity,
 That's why you have affliction's fee.
 22 See, El's exalted in His power,
 Who can teach Him even an hour?
 23 Who's determined for Him His way?
 Who can tell Him He's in the sway
 Of evil? 24 Mind you magnify
 His work in all that man may spy.
 25 Every man may see it; man may
 Behold *it* far off *on the way*.
 26 See, El *is* great, we know *Him* not,
 Nor can His years number be sought.
 27 He makes small drops of water form,
 They pour down as rain cold and warm,
 28 Which the clouds drop distilling on
 Humankind in abundance drawn.
 29 Can any understand the clouds
 Spreading out tents with noise of crowds?
 30 He spreads His lightning on it too
 As far as the sea bottom's view.
 31 For by them He judges the folk,
 He gives them nourishment for yoke.
 32 With clouds He covers up the light,
 And then commands to come the night.
 33 He shows His coming by the sound
 The very cattle know the round.

You are, Beloved, great and that's
 argument
 For everything that comes allowed and sent
 Into the human heart and brain and tent.
 You are great and that answers every vent.
 By saying You are great I mend the view
 That would be torn by what I say and do.
 By saying You are great I crush the sound
 Of the oppressed complaining on the
 ground.
 By saying You are great I raise a wind
 To hide the reproach of the world that
 sinned.
 So much can be accomplished, both the fair
 And evil by proclaiming to the air
 The truth in tones so loud that none can
 share
 Insight inspired by You, Beloved, to bare.

Job 37

1 At this also my heart is moved
 And trembles from the place it's grooved.
 2 With care hear the sound of His voice
 Gone out from His lips to rejoice.

3 He guides it under the whole sky,
 His lightning round the world and by.
 4 After the lightning comes the thunder,
 Roaring with a sound made to wonder,
 He does not stop them in the blunder.
 5 El thunders greatly with His voice,
 He does great things by His own choice.
 6 He says to the snow, "Fall on earth."
 He orders the sleet too as well
 As the downpour into a swell.
 7 He seals the hand of every man;
 That all may know His work and plan.
 8 Then the beasts go into their dens,
 And stay hidden from woods and fens.
 9 Out of the south comes the whirlwind:
 And cold out of the north where binned.
 10 By breath of El the frost is given;
 The wide streams straitened where they've
 striven.
 11 He empties the thick cloud of rain,
 Dispersing it brightly again.
 12 And it is turned around about
 By His counsels, that they in rout
 May do whatever He commands
 About the world and on its lands.
 13 He causes it to come, maybe
 For punishment, or for the fee
 Of His land or even mercy.

The artistry by which the false faith rises
 Upon the air truly, indeed surprises.
 The pinnacle of poetry that's found
 In book of Job is tattered and unwound
 By the young tongue of Elihu to show
 How beautiful poetry on the go
 Can be, and yet corrupt the truth to glow
 With full oppression on the seat and row.
 Beloved, I hear the sweetness of the loom,
 I hear the rhyme unreasoned with perfume,
 And feel the ecstasy rise up and bloom.
 I touch wood and knock for the feather
 where
 The down-to-earth may strike the preaching
 bare
 That sings like Mozart, but with evil share.

14 Listen to this, Job, and stand still,
 Consider El's great words and will.
 15 Do you know how Allah brings them
 And causes light from the cloud's hem?
 16 Do you know the weight of the clouds,
 His miracles perfect in crowds?

17 How your clothes warm when from the
 south
 The earth is quieted in mouth?
 18 Did you spread out the sky with Him,
 Strong like a molten glass not dim?
 19 Teach us what we shall say to Him,
 For we cannot in darkness grim.
 20 Shall it be told Him that I speak?
 If a man speaks, he'll fail as weak.
 21 And now *men* see not the bright light
 Which *is* in the clouds day and night:
 But the wind passes, making right.
 22 Fair weather comes from the north side,
 Allah is glorious to abide.
 23 Shaddai, we cannot find Him out,
 He's excellent in strength and stout
 In judgement and justice about,
 He will not afflict *in the rout*.
 24 That's why men fear Him, He will not
 Regard the wise of heart and plot.

Both Job and good Elihu say the same:
 You do not come to afflict those in blame.
 Job means that all eat of the bitter fruit
 That's this world in portion to the root,
 But pain of punishment shall come to boot
 Only on day of judgement for the loot.
 Elihu means that the pain here and now
 Is not unjust affliction on the brow,
 But well deserved in punishment to yield
 Repentance from the heart that should be
 healed.
 With one and the same word two men can
 make
 The truth shine brightly or a vain mistake.
 Beloved, the language of man's tongue is
 frail
 To say the truth in clarity's new mail.

Job 38

1 YHWH answered Job from the
 whirlwind,
 And said 2 Who's this that's come
 unbinned
 By speeches without knowledge *tinned*?
 3 Hoist up your pants now like a man,
 I'll question, reply as you can.
 4 Where were you when the footer for
 The earth I poured? Declare the score.
 5 And who has measured it, do you
 Know who stretched its line out in view?
 6 On what are the foundations stayed,

The corner stone set and arrayed?
 7 When morning stars sang in parade,
 And children of Alohim made
 Songs of rejoicing in charade?
 8 Or *who* shut up the sea with doors,
 When it broke out as the womb pours?
 9 When I made clothing of the cloud
 And thick darkness for it a shroud,
 10 And ploughed it a place by My plan,
 And set its bars and doors in span,
 11 And said to here you now may come,
 But no further may proud waves hum?

 You are a sneaking villain, my Beloved,
 To come with such words that seem in the
 gloved
 To gain the confidence of trinity
 Of comforters met in quadrinity.
 You speak to one possessed of pain and
 strife
 To show him that he's weak in death and
 life
 As though he had not said as much himself
 Before he was dragged down and off the
 shelf.
 Beloved, I've heard such rhetoric before,
 And in fact think it not too bad a score.
 Let light burn in the opposite to make
 The foolish rise in pride to set their stake
 Before they feel the lash in their surprise
 Open before them justice from the skies.

 12 Have you commanded morning's rays
 Since the beginning of your days;
And caused the dayspring to know praise,
 13 To take hold of the ends of earth,
 To shake the wicked from their berth?
 14 It's turned as the clay *to* the seal,
 They stand as a garment to weal.
 15 And from the wicked their light's held,
 And the high arm broken and felled.
 16 Have you entered in the sea springs?
 Have you walked searching the deep
 things?
 17 Have death's gates been opened to you?
 Or have you seen their doors in view?
 18 Have you perceived the breadth of
 earth?
 Declare if you know of its worth.
 19 Where *is* the way *where* light is found?
 And where is darkness on the ground?
 20 That you should hide them in a box,

That you should pasture them like flocks.
 21 Do you know it because by then
 You were already born with men?
 Or because you are old in den?

 Beloved, your argument holds not a whit
 Of weight, I am surprised You offer it.
 The fact that Job was not born when You
 made
 The earth has naught to do with the parade
 Of his sins or his righteous acts unstayed.
 The question is, did the man sin or not
 That You came in to punish in his plot.
 Job says he did not, his friends say he did.
 You ought to have the sense to answer bid
 Instead of bragging on Yourself that way.
 The man has suffered plenty at the hand
 Of his own trinity, why take a stand
 Against him, when You know the man is
 right?
 Move on to the confession. Leave the night.

 22 Have you entered the treasure trove
 Of the snow or where the hail hove,
 23 Which I've saved up for troubled times,
 For days of battle and of crimes?
 24 From where does the light go forth that
 That scatters the east wind on earth's flat?
 25 Who has divided watercourse
 For overflowing waters' *horse*,
 Or a way for the thunder's light,
 26 To bring rain on the earth with might,
Where no one *is*, *in* wilderness,
 Where no man comes to make address,
 27 To satisfy the desolate
 And waste *ground*, and to spring *the bait*
 Of budding tender herb *not late*?
 28 Is there a father for the rain,
 Or who begets the dew again?

 There are a few around today who know
 A good bit about the ground where they
 grow,
 And how the hail is formed and how the
 snow,
 And where the rain comes from, the
 thunder too,
 And who and how engenders morning dew.
 But with that knowledge they're no wiser
 than
 The comforters of Job in their wild plan
 That every pain on earth is punishment

From You and proves the sinner has been
bent.
If knowledge of the fact of universe
Gives naught in aid to prove You none the
worse,
Then why bring up such things to knock
Job down,
As though he were a fool upon the town?
Beloved, You're smart, but still You earn a
frown.

29 Out of whose womb has come the ice?
The hoary frost of heaven's device,
Who hath gendered it *to suffice*?
30 The waters covered as with stone,
The surface of the deep alone
Frozen fast *and under whose throne*?
31 Can you bind up the Pleiades
In their sweet fragrance like a breeze,
Or loosen Orion with ease?
32 Can you bring round the zodiac
In its time and deliver back
Arcturus with his sons *in slack*?
33 Do you know the order of heaven?
Can you set rule on earthly heaven?
34 Can you lift up your voice to clouds,
To bring the water down in shrouds?
35 Can you send lightnings, make them go,
And say to you, "We're in a row?"
36 Who's put an order in their heart
To understand and do their part?

The zodiac's a question now and then,
And still an object to interest most men,
Or at least teen-aged daughters on the wen.
If You're the one who moves the zodiac,
Does that mean that the load is on Your
back
Of the responsibility of all
The zodiac's supposed to do in thrall?
I hardly pay attention to the stars
That so determine night and day and bars.
I'll let You turn Your playthings round and
round
And not worry at all what hits the ground.
Beloved, I trust Your grace more than the
band
Of constellations that come in to stand,
And Your own mercy more than fellow-
manned.

37 Who can give precise count to clouds,

Or bottle up the heavenly crowds,
38 When the dust hardens on the ground,
And the clods cleave where they are
bound?
39 Will you in prowess give a hand
To hunting lion, fill the band
Of lion cubs with meat for sand?
40 When they couch in *their* dens, *and* stay
In secret places where they lay?
41 Who gives the raven his food's share,
When his young ones cry in the air
To El when their cupboard is bare?

Job 39

1 Can you predict when the wild goats
Upon the rock bring forth like stoats?
Can you tell when the deer give birth?
2 Can you count the months in their worth
That they fulfil, or know the day
And hour when they bring forth to stay?
3 They bow themselves, bring forth their
young,
Cast sorrows *with a lick of tongue*.
4 Their young ones are strong, fed on corn,
Go out not to return where born.
5 Who has sent out the wild ass free?
Or loosed its bands *beside the sea*?
6 Whose house I've made the wilderness,
And barren land for his address.
7 He scorns the multitudes in town,
Regards no driver's cry and frown.
The mountains *are* his pasture's range,
He finds every green thing's exchange.

Beloved, I'm reconciled to all You do,
The evil things men accuse You in pew
Of perpetrating on the pleasant earth.
I'm reconciled to flood and storm and
dearth.
I'm reconciled, Beloved, because You did
One thing that makes up for the evil bid
Of power and punishment, of soul and sin:
You made the wilderness and put therein
The wild ass to run beautiful and grin.
That one act is enough to serve the sound
Of universe for square, and cube and round.
I'm reconciled to You, Beloved, who made
The wild ass and put wild ass on parade,
The shy wild ass who never once obeyed.

9 Will the unicorn come serve you,
Abiding by your crib *and pew*?

10 Can you harness the unicorn
 To draw the furrow in his scorn,
 To plough the valleys after you?
 11 Will you trust him for his great strength,
 Leave him your tasks to do at length?
 12 Will you believe he'll bring home seed
 Gathered into your barns indeed?
 13 Did you create the peacock's wing,
 Or feathers the ostrich may fling?
 14 She leaves her eggs upon the earth,
 And warms them in the dust for birth.
 15 She forgets that the foot may crush,
 Or that the predator may rush.
 16 She is hardened against her young,
 As though *they were* not hers where flung,
 Her labour's in vain without fear,
 17 Since Allah made no sense appear
 In her nor gave her wisdom's *tear*.
 18 When she flies up, she scorns the horse
 As well as its rider in course.

The ostrich and the unicorn no doubt
 Show Your wisdom in all things You're
 about,
 Although the one is stupid and the other
 Seems mythological to every brother.
 The ostrich and the unicorn jump out
 To scare the witches in their dancing bout,
 Although the priest and harlot and the
 mother
 Have never caught a glimpse of them to
 smother.
 Beloved, the ostrich is a wondered bird
 Whose eggs are laid upon the earth and
 stirred
 For You alone to protect them unerred.
 Beloved, the unicorn is wild and free,
 And never caught by any likes of me,
 And so witnesses to Your unity.

19 Have you given the horse its strength,
 And clothed its neck with thunder's length?
 20 Can you make him afraid to be
 Like a grasshopper? The glory
 Of his nostrils *is* fine and free.
 21 He paws the valley, shakes his mane,
 Goes out to meet army on plain.
 22 He mocks at fear, and knows no fright,
 He does not turn from sword in flight.
 23 The quiver rattles at his side,
 The glittering spear and shield *deride*.

24 He swallows the ground with fierce
 rage,
 He gives the trumpet sound no gauge.
 25 He whinnies at the trumpet sound,
 He smells the battle on the ground,
 The thunder of the captains' voice,
 The shouting *to fear and rejoice*.
 26 Does the hawk fly by your esteem,
 Stretch her wings toward the southern
gleam?
 27 Do eagles mount at your command,
 To make their nests high above land?
 28 She lives and stays upon the rock,
 Upon the crag and the strong stock.
 29 From there she goes to seek the prey,
 Her eyes see it distance away.
 30 Her young ones also suck up blood,
 She's where the slain lie *in the mud*.

You seem, Beloved, enamoured of the
 horse,
 And of the hawk and eagle in their course,
 And pass over the grasshopper waylaid
 As though he had no merits to be paid.
 I protest You and all of humankind
 Who ignore the grasshopper, you the blind
 Who watch the games of men in jumping
 high
 And praise the highest jumper going by
 With gold and silver medals on the sky.
 Leave off those poor and sad men to their
 blame
 And raise the great grasshopper to his
 fame.
 How many body lengths can he jump now,
 While men are plodding underneath the
 plough!
 The best are always ignored anyhow.

Job 40

1 And so YHWH answered Job and said
 2 "Shall the one who meets the Shaddai
 Teach Him a thing? He that reproves
 Allah, answer Him as behoves?"
 3 Then Job replied to YHWH and said
 4 "See, I am vile, what's to be said?
 I'll lay my hand on my mouth *spread*.
 5 "Once I spoke, I shall not reply,
 Twice, but ask no more which or why."
 6 YHWH answered Job from the
 whirlwind,
 And said, Hitch up your pants and skinned,

I'll ask you, you will answer Me.
8 Will you annul My just decree?
Will you condemn Me and go free
To condemn those acting justly?

You try to make it sound like those who
came
With Christian arguments are not to blame,
But Job instead who speaks the sound and
sane.

Job flounders at the vision of Your form,
He knew he would, he said if it got warm
That You would frighten him beyond the
sway

Of argument out of the light of day.
How is it that Job's always right no matter
What he comes to say about the meat
platter?

He might as well have stuck here to his
guns

For all the leeway You give him in runs.
I'll keep that thing in mind if ever I
Am faced with visions of You going by.
You're not One to be trusted on the sly.

9 Have you an arm like that of El?
Can you thunder like his voice spell?

10 Dress yourself in your majesty,
Array you in glory's beauty.

11 Scatter like sparks your rage and wrath,
Find out the proud and spoil his path.

12 Look on the proud, *and* bring him low,
Tread down the wicked in their row.

13 Hide them together in the dust,
Bind their faces in secret *must*.

14 Then I'll confess that your right hand
Can save you *in a troubled land*.

Job does not need an arm of strength like
Yours

To be able to say when he's indoors
Whether he's stolen silver from the plot
Of neighbour, friend or foe as like as not.
It does not take the power of universe
Creating to call up the right or worse.
You gave us all ten words to know the
course

We ought to travel through cacti and gorse.
Job never said his own right hand could
save,

He just complained that You, though strong
and brave,

Let him fall in the hand of Saracen,
And under the vile tongue of Christian
men.

Beloved, scatter the sparks of Your own
rage,

Our business is ten words upon the page.

15 See now behemoth I have made
With you, he eats grass *unafraid*
Just like the ox *set on parade*.

16 See how his strength is in his haunch,
His force in navel of his paunch.

17 He moves his tail like cedar beam,
The sinews of his tight hips gleam.

18 He *is* the chief of El's creation,
He that made him can make the ration
Of His sword flash upon his station.

20 The mountains surely bring him food,
Where beasts of the field play in brood.

21 He lies under the shady trees,
Hidden by reed and fen *from breeze*.

22 The leafy trees give him their shade,
The willow brooks surround his glade.

23 See how he drinks a river up,
And hurries not to fill his cup,

He knows he can take on his tongue
The whole of the Jordan in rung.

24 What man can catch him by the eyes,
Or pierce his maw and take for prize?

Behemoth is a great beast that You made
To cover over continents once stayed,
And thunder on the plains and on the hills
To find his drink in rivers and not rills.
Behemoth is an image that abounds
Across the dry lands to the sea-scape
sounds,

Whose shadow is a fearsome thing to see
Above the plateaux garnished with no tree.
Beloved, the king of land's behemoth and
The king of sea the great leviathanned,
Before whom no man yet could ever stand.
And yet all men are called once before You
To stand in judgement for the things they
do,

Not for the weakness of flesh like the dew.

Job 41

1 Can you draw out leviathan
With a hook *and a line in span*?

Or pull his tongue with cord let down?
2 Can you put a ring in his nose,

Or stick a thorn through his jaws' pros?
 3 Will he beg you for mercy's sake?
 Will he please words for his mistake?
 4 Will he make a treaty with you?
 Will you take him for servant due?
 5 Will you play with him like a bird,
 Caged up for your maids *on their curd*?
 6 Shall the companions make a feast
 Of him cut in choice parts at least?
 7 Can you fill his skin with iron barbs,
 Or his head with fish spears *for garbs*?
 8 Lay your hand on him, mind the war,
Do this alone and do no more.
 9 See, trusting in him is but vain,
 His very sight makes him to reign.
 10 No one's so fierce that he will dare
 To stir him up out of his lair,
 So who can stand up before Me?

So who can stand up before You, You ask?
 Is there no basic difference in mask
 Between You and leviathan, I say?
 Leviathan is without mercy's way,
 While You are supposed to be full of grace
 And mercy in the way You act in place.
 That's why these men are arguing. They
 find

That where there is no mercy of the kind,
 And man is suffering pain, he must be fined
 For his transgressions while we were well
 wined.

A man can stand before You and not where
 Leviathan is thrashing on the air
 Because of Your grace and Your mercy
 there.

Your question, My Beloved, is just not fair.

11 Who has come before Me so I
 Should give him the price for to spy?
 Mine are all things under the sky.
 12 I'll not conceal his parts or power,
 Nor his good proportions *an hour*.
 13 Who can uncover him his shroud,
 Or come with double bit allowed?
 14 Who can open doors of his face?
 His teeth *are* terrible in place.
 15 *His scales are his pride, tight as steel,*
 Closed and shut up as with a seal.
 16 One is so closely joined to other
 That no air comes between *to smother*.
 17 They are joined each to each, they stick
 Together and are not cut quick.

18 He sneezes and turns on a light,
 His eyelids like the morning *bright*.
 19 Out of his mouth go burning lamps,
And sparks of fire leap out *like tramps*.
 20 Out of his nostrils there goes smoke,
As from a pot or caldron broke.
 21 His breath kindles coals, and a flame
 Goes out of his mouth *for a game*.
 22 In his neck there is strength, and pain
 Is turned to joy before his reign.
 23 The flakes of his flesh join in one,
 They are firm and cannot be won.
 24 His heart is as firm as a stone,
 Like the bottom of millstone's *throne*.
 25 When he gets up the mighty fear,
 In terror they fail to appear.
 26 The sword of the attacker fails,
 Spear, dart, and shield before his flails.
 27 For him the iron is like the straw,
 And brass like rotten wood in craw.
 28 The arrow cannot make him flee,
 Slingstones turn into stubble scree.
 29 Darts are counted as stubble torn,
 He laughs at the spear shaken, borne.
 30 Sharp stones *are* under him: he spreads
 Sharp pointed things about his sheds.
 31 He makes the deep boil like a pot,
 He makes the sea like oil in lot.
 32 He makes a path shine after him,
 The deep as with the frost grown dim.
 33 Upon earth there is not his like,
 Who's made without a fear *to strike*.
 34 He sees all heights, he *is* a king
 Over all the proud and foundling.

The dragon is a wonder, one decreed
 By all the tales of Orient and seed
 Of Western isles before humankind's
 greed.

The dragon is a wonder with his breath
 Of flames of fire and coals bearing the
 death

Of every green and fleshed thing in his
 path.

The dragon is a creature of great wrath.
 And yet You know the dragon in his need.
 Beloved, the hope of air and fire and sea,
 The hopelessness of earth bearing the tree,
 All tell a greater story in their way
 Than does the flying dragon in its day.
 The dragon slips at sunset under wave

And leaves the human soul to face the
grave.

Job 42

1 Then Job replied to YHWH and said,
2 "I know You can do all things spread,
And no thought's hidden from Your head.
3 "Who tries to hide his thoughts without
Realizing that You're about?
So I have uttered things that I
Understand not although I spy,
Things beyond my reach in the sky.
4 "Yet hear, I pray, and I will speak,
I'll ask of You, tell what I seek.
5 "I've heard of You by word in ear,
But now I see the thing I fear.
6 "So I take back the speech I made,
Comfort myself in ashes laid."

I ask myself why Job took back his speech,
And then I wonder why You came to
preach.

The only answer I can find is this:
You had to tell of Your power and Your
bliss
In all creation, because when Job saw
You in the whirlwind You were held in
claw
Of pain and boils like he was, You joined
in

The sorrow of Job as if both were sin.
So Job would never recognize His Lord
Scrapping His boils and weeping with the
scored.

That vision of You taking part in pain
Gave Job a better answer than the vain
In thoughts his comforters had come to tell.
And so he took back all he said in spell.

7 After YHWH spoke to Job these things,
YHWH said to Eliphaz who springs
From Teman, "My wrath is enflamed
Against you and your two friends *blamed*,
For you've not spoken the thing right
About Me, as Job did, My wight.

8 "So take you seven bullocks drawn
And seven rams *upon the lawn*,
Go to My servant Job *at dawn*
And offer up a burnt offering,
And My servant Job for the thing
Will pray for you, him I'll accept,
Lest I deal with you where you've stepped

According to your folly kept,
In that you have not said of Me,
Like My servant Job, *faithfully*."

Job never answered Elihu a word,
And now You too ignore that omen bird.
He taught better, more eloquently all
The others said in their falsehood and stall,
But no one paid the least mind to his rant.
The whole crowd must have rested in their
cant.

The sacrifice You now require is for
The three alone, Elihu at the door
Is too young to take credit for the wrong.
He only sang a warbling kind of song.
Let me, Beloved, ignore the rabbled fuss
At my words, let me mind they are not
worse

Than children, empty children whose vain
thought
Is not worth a response when they are
caught.

9 So Eliphaz the Temanite
And Bildad too who was Shuhite
And Zophar the Naamathite
Went and did as YHWH told them to,
And YHWH accepted Job in view.
10 And YHWH turned Job's captivity,
When he prayed for his friends' degree,
Also YHWH gave Job twice as much
As he had beforehand to touch.
11 His brothers came to him and all
His sisters and friends *great and small*
And ate with him in his own tent,
And sorrowed for the way things went,
And comforted him for the way
YHWH had brought evil on his day,
And every one gave him a piece
Of money and an earring's lease
Made of gold *to help without cease*.

At last we find the kind of comfort that
A Christian and a Jew with well-filled mat
Should bring to friend and brother where he
sat.

When sorrow strikes the soul, the
preacher's hand
Should be to comfort all men in the land,
And not to call down fire and brimstone
where
A man is bent beneath his load of care.

The friend and relative that came in late
 Came in best for both Job and their own
 fate.
 Their kind words and their gold and gifted
 rate
 Call down from You reward, not pain on
 pate,
 And may the reward come in this life too,
 And not just in the Judgement Day in view,
 Though truth to tell pain is in every pew.

12 So YHWH blessed Job's end and
 increase

Beyond his beginning and start,
 For he then possessed for his part
 Fourteen thousand sheep, also six
 Thousand camels *to do their tricks*,
 And a thousand yoke of oxen,
 And a thousand she asses *then*.

13 He had seven sons and three daughters.

14 And called the name, *after the
 slaughters*,

Of the first, Jemima, the name
 Of the second, Kezia's *fame*,
 And the name of the third *in book*,
He called at last Kerenhappuch.

15 In all the land there were not found
 Women so fair as daughters round
 The hearth of Job, and their dad gave
 To them inheritance *and slave*
 Among their brothers *safe and sound*.

16 After this Job lived many years,
 A hundred and forty appears, (or:
*And Job lived after his great trial
 A hundred seventy a while,
 So all his years when counted fast
 Were two hundred and forty classed*),

And saw his sons, and his sons' sons,
 Four generations *on their buns*.

17 So Job died being full of days,
 Old and object of all men's praise.
*And it is written that he'll rise
 Again with those whom in their guise
 The Lord YHWH will raise [to the skies].*

My great joy as I read these words is this:
 In every book the sons are named for bliss,
 And daughters barely given any kiss,
 And if mentioned at all are given just
 A number and a wheel upon the dust.
 But Job's sons are forgotten in the list

Of names of righteous ones we should have
 kissed.

While all the names of daughters are
 spelled out.

That thing is great and makes me want to
 shout

For joy that at last tables are reversed,
 And daughters are rewarded and not
 cursed.

Let every man and woman here take note
 That women are as great as men in boat,
 With Your commands and promises to
 gloat.

*He is described in Syriac
 Book to live in land without lack
 Of Ausis on the borders of
 Idumea and land of love
 Arabia, and his name then
 Was Jobab, and with Arab wife
 He got a son, Ennon, [for life].
 He himself was son of Zaré,
 A son of Esau in the way,
 And his mother was Bosorrha,
 He was fifth from Abraham's day.
 These were the kings who ruled Edom,
 Which land he also ruled in sum,
 First, Balac, the son of Beor,
 The name of his town was in score
 Dennaba, but after Balac,
 Jobab, who is called Job came back,
 And after him Asom, was ruled
 Out of the land of Thaman [pooled,]
 And after him Adad, the son
 Of Barad, who destroyed and won
 Madiam on plain of Moab,
 The name of his city's confab
 Was Gethaim. And his friends who
 Came to him were Eliphaz due
 Of the sons of Esau, the king
 Of the Tamanites, and the spring
 Of Bildad, king of Sauchaus,
 And Zophar king without a fuss
 Of the Mineans' [following.]*

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